
COMPILATION OF ARTICLES ON SCIENCE BUDGET CUTS AND NEW POLICIES
BY THE TRUMP ADMINISTRATION [R.W. O'Connell]

11/12/24: FYI. Subject: This Week: Seismic changes ahead for science policy post-election / UN looks to research nuclear war impacts / Trust in science survey up for review

SEISMIC CHANGES AHEAD FOR SCIENCE POLICY UNDER SECOND TRUMP PRESIDENCY

Although science policy was not a focal point of the 2024 campaign, the reelection of Donald Trump as president will have far-reaching consequences for the research enterprise. Among the most imminent changes are that diversity, equity, and inclusion initiatives will come under immediate pressure. On day one of his new administration, Trump has pledged to revoke Biden's executive order prioritizing DEI programs, which science agencies had pointed to as a basis for expanding efforts to diversify the STEM workforce. Trump has also already announced various senior personnel who have an adversarial view toward DEI initiatives, such as Stephen Miller, who will be his deputy chief of staff for policy. Miller's legal advocacy group issued FOIA requests to various science agencies last month to probe their diversity programs.

Visa policy changes affecting scientists and students could also be in store. Although Trump's campaign speeches focused on his proposals for curbing illegal immigration, he has also pledged to use visa policy as a tool of research security. In a campaign video on "stopping Chinese espionage," Trump said he will "impose whatever visa sanctions and travel restrictions are necessary to shut off Chinese access to American secrets." More broadly, research security is poised to be a topic of intense focus during his administration. Many people Trump has already picked or eyed for top roles are known for having a deep interest in the subject, including Rep. Michael Waltz (R-FL), who will be his national security advisor; Rep. Elise Stefanik (R-NY), his nominee for U.S. ambassador to the United Nations; and Sen. Marco Rubio (R-FL), reportedly his choice for secretary of state.

The outlook for science budgets is less clear. In his first term Trump prioritized spending on research tied to "industries of the future" but nevertheless proposed sweeping budget cuts to science agencies as part of a broader drive to reduce government spending. Since Trump ultimately did not insist on tight budget caps during the negotiations, Congress rejected his proposals for cuts and was even

able to significantly expand some science agencies. Yet Trump appears interested again in cutting government spending, promising to task technology executive Elon Musk with identifying ideas for cuts. Trump may also attempt to roll back some of President Joe Biden's signature spending initiatives, such as the energy technology subsidies in the Inflation Reduction Act and the semiconductor industry subsidies in the CHIPS and Science Act. However, many of the programs created by those acts have bipartisan backing in Congress.

CONGRESS RETURNS WITH NEXT YEAR FRONT OF MIND

Congress is back in session this week after a seven-week break for the election. At this point, votes are still being tallied to determine which party will take control of the House when President-elect Donald Trump takes office for a second term in January 2025. It is already clear, however, that Republicans will take control of the Senate, meaning that Trump should be able to get his top political appointees confirmed without Democratic support. Republicans may also push to delay finalizing the fiscal year 2025 budget until Trump takes office, hoping for greater influence over final appropriations. If Republicans take control of both the House and the Senate, Trump can use an expedited process known as reconciliation for certain types of legislation.

Republicans may look to strengthen the R&D tax credit available to businesses as part of a broader overhaul of the tax code. The 2017 tax reform law signed by Trump weakened the R&D tax credit, but Republican lawmakers have proposed to reverse that move.

The composition of key congressional committees could look very different next year, with several high-profile changes set to occur. On the Senate Commerce, Science, and Transportation Committee, for example, Sen. Ted Cruz (R-TX) looks likely to take over as chair. Cruz has been highly critical of the Biden administration's focus on diversity, equity, and inclusion, and recently published a report slamming the National Science Foundation for funding diversity initiatives. The Senate Energy and Natural Resources Committee will also see new leadership following the retirement of its chair, Sen. Joe Manchin (I-WV). The committee's top Republican, Sen. John Barrasso (R-WY), may also depart the panel to serve in a leadership role in his party's caucus. In the House, the ranking member of the Commerce-Justice-Science Appropriations Subcommittee, Rep. Matt Cartwright (D-PA), lost his seat, as did the chair of the Energy Subcommittee of the House Science Committee, Rep. Brandon Williams (R-NY). On the House Energy-Water Appropriations Subcommittee, ranking member Rep. Marcy Kaptur (D-OH), looks set to hang on to her seat despite a very close race, which AP has yet to officially call.

AAAS HOLDING EVENTS ON TRUST IN SCIENCE

The American Association for the Advancement of Science will host an event Thursday to discuss the release of the latest Trust In Science survey from the Pew Research Center. The past four editions of the survey have reported declines in the number of Americans who view science as having a positive effect on society and increases in the percentage who have a negative view of science. AAAS will also host a meeting of the Science and Human Rights Coalition Thursday and Friday that will focus on “building a culture of trustworthy science.” The event will review “strategies for elevating and promoting science that is civically engaged, and giving scientists the tools, resources, and support they need to carry out that work.”

ALSO ON OUR RADAR

- * The House Oversight and Accountability Committee will hold a hearing Wednesday on unidentified anomalous phenomena, an umbrella term for aerial, undersea, or transmedium objects of unknown origin. The hearing will attempt to shed light on government research programs and findings concerning UAP, according to a press release. Witnesses include Timothy Gallaudet, a naval oceanographer and former acting NOAA administrator, and Michael Gold, a former top NASA official who was a member of a recent NASA study on the topic.
- * NIH’s Scientific Management Review Board will meet Tuesday for the first time since 2015 to discuss NIH’s mission, structure, and budget. The dormancy of the board was the subject of a probe by House Republicans in 2023.
- * MIT planetary geophysicist Maria Zuber has replaced former NASA Administrator Jim Bridenstine as the chair of NASA’s Mars Sample Return review team. The team’s report recommending a new architecture for the mission is still expected by the end of this year.
- * British physicist Mark Thomson was selected last week as the next director-general of CERN, Europe’s leading particle physics lab. His term starts in 2026.

1/17/25: NYT. Kennedy Sought to Stop Covid Vaccinations 6 Months After Rollout / Robert F. Kennedy Jr. petitioned the F.D.A. to revoke authorization of the shots at a time when they were in high demand and considered life-saving.

Robert F. Kennedy Jr., President-elect Donald J. Trump’s choice to lead the nation’s health agencies, formally asked the Food and Drug Administration to revoke the authorization of all Covid vaccines during a deadly phase of the pandemic when thousands of Americans

were still dying every week.

Mr. Kennedy filed a petition with the F.D.A. in May 2021 demanding that officials rescind authorization for the shots and refrain from approving any Covid vaccine in the future.

Estimates had begun to show that the rapid rollout of Covid vaccines had already saved about 140,000 lives in the United States.

The petition was filed on behalf of the nonprofit that Mr. Kennedy founded and led, Children's Health Defense. It claimed that the risks of the vaccines outweighed the benefits and that the vaccines weren't necessary because good treatments were available, including ivermectin and hydroxychloroquine, which had already been deemed ineffective against the virus.

...John Moore, a professor of immunology at Weill Cornell Medical College, called Mr. Kennedy's request to the F.D.A. "AN APPALLING ERROR OF JUDGMENT." Gregg Gonsalves, an epidemiologist at the Yale School of Public Health, likened having Mr. Kennedy lead the federal health agencies to "putting a flat earther in charge of NASA."

,,,At the time Mr. Kennedy challenged the Covid vaccines, some of his objections touched on wider concerns about their rapid development. Emergency-use authorization – a preliminary form of approval – for immunizations was unusual. Others argued that a public health emergency dictated a speedier rollout.

Dr. Jennifer Nuzzo, director of the Pandemic Center at Brown University School of Public Health, said it would be reasonable to debate whether Covid vaccines should have been subject to additional study. But she profoundly disagreed with Mr. Kennedy's views, saying that "the idea that in early 2021 that you could be saying that people over the age of 65 don't need Covid vaccines – that's just nuts."

Vaccines have rare side effects, and there have been cases of injury from the Covid shots. Government officials weigh the harms against the potential to save lives. An estimate released in early 2024 found that the Covid VACCINES AND MITIGATION MEASURES SAVED ABOUT 800,000 LIVES IN THE UNITED STATES.

Another study found that in late 2021 and 2022, Covid DEATH RATES AMONG UNVACCINATED PEOPLE WERE 14 TIMES THE RATES OF THOSE WHO HAD RECEIVED A COVID BOOSTER SHOT. Researchers also estimated that from May 2021 through September 2022, MORE THAN 230,000 DEATHS COULD HAVE BEEN PREVENTED among people who declined initial Covid inoculations.

From the start of the Covid vaccine campaign, Mr. Kennedy's view that the Covid vaccines were dangerous put him at odds with Mr. Trump,

whose Operation Warp Speed to develop the vaccines was one of his policy triumphs. And Mr. Kennedy went on a concerted campaign against the vaccine.

Mr. Kennedy told Louisiana lawmakers in late 2021 that the Covid vaccine was the "deadliest vaccine ever made."

Comments...

I can't understand why the Congress can't listen to 75 Nobel Laureates who have written a letter saying that Kennedy shouldn't be the Health and Human Services Secretary? Doesn't science mean anything anymore? Many of these people have devoted their entire adult lives to improving the plight of mankind. Are we just going to disregard what they say like they don't know what they're talking about? What's happening is absolutely crazy.

Ask the parents of the unvaccinated Samoan children who died from measles due to RFK, Jr.'s anti vax campaign what they think of RFK, Jr. Over 80 Samoans died from measles, most of them children. See the attached article from "The Lancet" for more information. "The perils of RFK Junior's anti-vaccine leadership for public health" [https://thelancet.com/journals/lancet/article/PIIS0140-6736\(24\)02603-5/fulltext](https://thelancet.com/journals/lancet/article/PIIS0140-6736(24)02603-5/fulltext)

Republicans died during Covid at a 43% higher rate...They say 300,000 people died needlessly because of Republican anti-public health attitudes. And Covid was only 2-3 times as deadly as the flu...If bird flu comes along with its higher death rate I honestly wouldn't care if they dropped like flies; if only they did not bring their children, their grandparents, and the rest of us down with them.

How does Donald Trump identify the least qualified and most dangerous individual to fill every position? It's uncanny.

Raise your hand if you know anyone who has contracted polio in the U.S. in the last 50 years. No one? And why do you think that is?

1/20/2025: Inauguration day

1/24/25: Van Scoyoc Newsletter

Health

Trump hits NIH with 'devastating' freezes on meetings, travel, communications, and hiring

President Donald Trump's return to the White House is already having a big impact at the \$47.4 billion U.S. National Institutes of Health (NIH), with the new administration imposing a wide range of restrictions, including the abrupt cancellation of meetings including grant review panels. Officials have also ordered a communications pause, a freeze on hiring, and an indefinite ban on travel. Officials halted midstream a training workshop for junior scientists, called off a workshop on adolescent learning minutes before it was to begin, and canceled meetings of two advisory councils. Panels that were scheduled to review grant proposals also received eleventh-hour word that they wouldn't be meeting. Read more: [Science, STAT News](#)

Trump administration directs federal health agencies to pause communications

Amid a deluge of executive actions, the Trump administration has directed federal health agencies to pause external communications, such as regular scientific reports, updates to websites and health advisories, according to sources within the agencies. The initial orders were delivered Tuesday to staff at agencies inside the US Department of Health and Human Services, including to officials at the US Food and Drug Administration, the US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention and National Institutes of Health, according to the Washington Post, which first reported the story. Read more: [CNN](#)

Trump's gag order halts CDC publication

For the first time in its more than 60-year history, the CDC's Morbidity and Mortality Weekly Report (MMWR) did not go out as scheduled because of a communications pause at federal health agencies issued by the Trump administration. Past editors of MMWR and prior leaders of CDC lamented the lack of publication, and its potential impact on the distribution of vital public health information. Read more: [MedPage Today](#)

Senate sets date to vet RFK Jr.'s nomination to lead HHS

Prominent vaccine skeptic Robert F. Kennedy Jr. will testify before the Senate Finance Committee on Jan. 29 as he attempts to calm concerns from Democrats and Republicans about his nomination to be the nation's top health official. Read more: [BioPharma Dive](#)

FDA approves Johnson & Johnson's nasal spray for depression as stand-alone treatment

The Food and Drug Administration on Tuesday approved Johnson &

Johnson's nasal spray to be used alone in adults with a major depressive disorder that is difficult to treat, as sales of the drug grow. The spray, called Spravato, is now the first-ever stand-alone therapy for treatment-resistant depression, which is when trying at least two standard treatments does little to nothing to improve depression symptoms in a patient. Read more: CNBC

Defense

Pete Hegseth, Trump's Pentagon pick, clears Senate test vote Pete Hegseth, President Donald Trump's pick to lead the Pentagon, cleared a key procedural hurdle in the Senate on Thursday to advance his nomination. The vote on ending debate came down to the wire, though Hegseth ultimately secured 51 Republican votes to move forward. A final confirmation vote on Hegseth could now occur as soon as Friday or early Saturday. Two GOP senators voted against him: Sens. Lisa Murkowski (AK) and Susan Collins (ME). Read more: ABC News

DOD names officials temporarily helming key tech offices as the Pentagon awaits new leadership Several familiar faces who steered some of the Pentagon's major technology and cybersecurity efforts over the last few years are operating in senior-level executive roles in acting capacities, as officials wait to see who the Trump administration will appoint to permanently lead key offices, multiple sources told DefenseScoop. Read more: DefenseScoop

Pentagon announces slate of new officials for second Trump term The Pentagon on Tuesday released a list of new officials sworn in this week to run the Defense Department – the most comprehensive look yet at its new team of leaders under the Trump administration. The 32 positions include advisers and deputy assistant secretaries, none of which require Senate confirmation, meaning they can immediately take office. President Donald Trump's top nominees to run the department are still awaiting approval from Capitol Hill, and these officials will help steer the department in the interim. Read more: Military Times

Trump's Pentagon to begin task for crafting NORTHCOM plan to 'seal' US borders Hours after being sworn in as the 47th president, President Trump began signing a flurry of executive orders and actions, including one presidential action declaring a national emergency on the Southern border and then an executive action calling on the Pentagon to clarify the military's role "protecting the territorial integrity of the United States." In that second one, he gives the Secretary of Defense 10 days to deliver a Unified Command Plan tasking US Northern Command (USNORTHCOM) with the border mission. Read more: Breaking Defense

Trump wants a faster security clearance process Often security

clearances are considered an overhead function barely gaining the mention or attention of senior leaders. But the spotlight was back on the security clearance process Monday when President Donald Trump issued two executive orders addressing security clearances – one rescinding the security clearance eligibility of the 50 individuals who signed the Hunter Biden laptop memo, which described the controversy as a “Russian information operation,” and another offering immediate interim eligibility to presidential appointees whose background investigations have not yet been completed. Read more: [Defense One](#)

Energy

Trump signs executive order pausing wind turbine leases, could impact Midwest President Donald Trump on Monday made good his promise to create policy “where no windmills are being built.” The executive order he signed Monday temporarily halts offshore wind energy lease sales in federal waters and pauses approvals, permits and loans for both offshore and onshore wind. During the pause, officials will review the environmental impact of both onshore and offshore wind projects on wildlife and consider the “economic costs associated with intermittent generation” and the effects of subsidies on the viability of the wind energy industry, according to the executive order. Read more: [USA Today](#)

Trump signs order ‘unleashing’ Alaska’s resources On his first day back in office, President Trump signed an executive order that aims to undo most of his predecessor’s work on Alaska energy and environmental issues. The order entitled “Unleashing Alaska’s Extraordinary Resource Potential” was among dozens Trump signed. “So, we’re opening up ANWR,” Trump said at the Resolute Desk in the Oval Office. The order calls for new leases in the Arctic National Wildlife Refuge and much more. Read more: [Alaska Public Media](#)

U.S. Department of Energy reverses Biden LNG pause The U.S. Department of Energy (DOE), effective Monday, ended the Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG) pause and returning to regular order following direction given by President Donald J. Trump to “unleash American Energy Dominance.” The Office of Fossil Energy and Carbon Management (FECM) is directed to resume consideration of pending applications to export American liquefied natural gas (LNG) to countries without a free trade agreement (FTA) with the United States in accordance with the Natural Gas Act. Read more: [DOE](#) [DOE offers](#)

\$30 million for superhot rock geothermal projects The Department of Energy last week launched a research and development program into the production of superhot rock geothermal energy, a resource that is unused but has major potential – 1% of its U.S. capacity could provide 4.3 TW of firm power, according to the Clean Air Task Force. DOE’s Advanced Research Projects Agency–Energy is offering \$30

million in funding to begin its Stimulate Utilization of Plentiful Energy in Rocks through High-temperature Original Technologies, or SUPERHOT, program to provide access to reservoirs capable of producing 10 GW to 20 GW of baseload power at a competitive cost, ARPA-E said on Jan. 16. Read more: [Utility Drive](#)

Eergy committee sends Trump's Interior, Energy cabinet picks to full Senate The Senate Energy and Natural Resources Committee voted Thursday to advance President Donald Trump's nominees to lead the Interior and Energy Departments – with both nominees receiving bipartisan support. The committee backed the nomination of former North Dakota Gov. Doug Burgum to lead the Interior Department on an 18-2 vote and advanced Chris Wright to lead the Energy Department on a 15-5 vote. Read more: [Politico](#)

Space

NASA awards Artemis logistics studies NASA issued study contracts to examine logistical issues for a long-term human presence on the moon despite uncertainty that the current administration will continue to pursue the Artemis lunar exploration campaign. NASA announced Jan. 23 that it selected nine companies for contracts with a combined value of \$24 million to study logistics needed for later human missions on the moon, when the agency anticipates larger crews spending more time on the lunar surface. Read more: [Space News](#)

Trump orders interim NASA chief to end DEI initiatives Following suit alongside other United States federal agencies, NASA has been instructed to close offices associated with diversity, equity, inclusion and accessibility (DEIA) initiatives, and end any related programs. Employees of the space agency received a memo from acting NASA administrator Janet Petro on Wednesday, issuing the directive in compliance with a pair of executive orders signed by President Trump during his first days in office. Read more: [Space.com](#)

Science and Technology

Trump ends Biden AI executive order The Trump administration has fulfilled its promise of revoking the Biden-era executive order on artificial intelligence which has served as a framework for Federal agencies approach to the emerging technology for over a year now. Signed in October 2023 by former president Joe Biden, the executive order on AI set standards for AI in eight categories including: safety and security; privacy; equity and civil rights; supporting consumers and workers; innovation and competition; American leadership; and government use of AI. The 2024 Republican Party platform vowed to repeal the order after saying that the order stifled AI innovation. Read more: [MeriTalk](#)

As Trump crow about billion-dollar A.I. deal, Musk undercuts announcement President Donald Trump hosted an event Tuesday with wealthy tech CEOs to tout what he portrayed as one of the biggest accomplishments of his presidency thus far: a \$500 billion investment in artificial intelligence infrastructure. But it didn't take long for his biggest benefactor, Elon Musk, to throw dirt all over it. Read more: [MSNBC](#)

Fundamental Science and Engineering

NSF invests \$40M to strengthen STEM research capacity and workforce development across five EPSCoR jurisdictions The U.S. National Science Foundation is investing approximately \$40 million to support research and STEM workforce development in Delaware, Guam, Kentucky, Louisiana and Vermont. These grants are part of the NSF Established Program to Stimulate Competitive Research (NSF EPSCoR), which aims to bolster research competitiveness among 28 targeted states and territories, referred to as jurisdictions. "EPSCoR is a driving force in enabling STEM research for everyone, everywhere, ensuring broad access to innovation and opportunity," said NSF Director Sethuraman Panchanathan. Read more: [NSF](#)

In Case You Missed It—Important Research News From NSF This Week

Chasing sparks: Unraveling a 50-year-old X-ray mystery A Penn State University research team recently solved an enduring physics enigma, revealing new information about how X-rays form during thunderstorms. Learn more: [X-Ray Mystery](#)

A greener, cleaner way to extract critical metals from junk materials Researchers at the University of Pennsylvania, along with collaborators at Northwestern University, have developed a safer and more sustainable method for extracting cobalt and nickel from junk materials. Both elements are critical components in the lithium-ion batteries that power many technologies central to modern life. Learn more: [Critical Metals](#)

Generate electricity by attaching device to your clothes A research team at the Seoul National University has developed a three-dimensional stretchable piezoelectric energy harvester that can harvest electrical energy using body movements. The device is to be used as a wearable energy harvester as it can be attached to the skin or clothes. Learn more: [Wearable Energy Harvester](#)

Superalloys resist wear at nearly forge-level heat using new process Finding lubricants that work at exceptionally high temperatures challenges researchers and industries alike. Recently, a Virginia Tech team may have uncovered a promising candidate by happenstance:

transition metal spinel oxides formed on nickel-chromium-based superalloys. The researchers, funded by NSF, published their results in Nature Communications. Learn more: [Superalloys](#)

Brain-computer interface can enable people with paralysis to socialize with others, participate in remote work and enjoy recreational activities A research team from the University of Michigan, Stanford University, and Brown University have developed a brain-computer interface, which when surgically placed in a research participant with tetraplegia, (paralysis in all four limbs), provides an unprecedented level of control over a virtual quadcopter -- just by thinking about moving his unresponsive fingers. Learn more: [Virtual Quadcopter](#)

Oceans and Atmosphere

US lawmakers move to block NOAA Fisheries from closing red snapper fishery Federal lawmakers from the U.S. state of Florida have introduced legislation to block NOAA Fisheries from closing the recreational South Atlantic red snapper fishery for three months of the year. "Florida's fishing industry is a multi-billion-dollar economic driver in our state, supporting hundreds of thousands of jobs and attracting visitors to communities along our coast," U.S. Senator Rick Scott (R-FL) said in a statement. "I'm proud to work with [U.S. Representative John Rutherford (R-FL)] on the Red Snapper Act." "We have ample data showing that red snapper seasons help support coastal economies and the national economy overall -- especially in Florida," U.S. Representative Darren Soto (D-FL), one of the cosponsors of the bill, said in a statement. Read more: [Seafood Source](#)

Environment

Senate committees advance Trump's energy, environment nominees The Senate's Environment and Public Works Committee advanced Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) nominee Lee Zeldin in an 11-8 vote, with Sen. Mark Kelly (D-AZ) as the only Democrat voting in favor. Sen. Sheldon Whitehouse (D-RI), top Democrat on Environment and Public Works, expressed opposition to Zeldin's nomination, saying Zeldin did not condemn a reported effort to move the EPA headquarters out of Washington or fire agency employees and pointing to his "op-eds spouting Big Oil-approved talking points." Republican Shelly Moore Capito (R-WV) supported Zeldin, saying, "I was very pleased during his testimony see how he intends to run the agency in line with the laws that Congress has passed with the goal of prioritizing EPA actions on the core responsibilities of the agency that are essential to protecting health and our land, air and water." The Hill

Trump scraps Clinton-era environmental justice order The Trump administration has erased a decades-old requirement for federal agencies to consider the environmental and public health consequences of their decisions on people of color and low-income communities. As part of a newly issued executive order, Trump revoked former President Bill Clinton's 1994 directive that's often seen as a milestone in federal efforts to overcome the effects of long-standing discrimination that has left disadvantaged populations disproportionately exposed to dangerous pollution. Read more: E&E News

Bloomberg to fund UN climate body after Donald Trump's Paris exit The UN climate change body will receive funding from the foundation of billionaire Michael Bloomberg after President Donald Trump declared the United States would withdraw from the Paris Agreement for the second time. In an announcement on Thursday, Bloomberg said the intervention aims to ensure the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) remains fully funded despite the US halting its contributions. Read more: Al Jazeera

Agriculture

Trump pick to lead USDA eyes payments to farmers to cover trade losses from tariffs President Donald Trump's pick to lead the U.S. Department of Agriculture said on Thursday she would consider direct payments to farmers to offset losses from proposed tariffs, modeled after the approach taken in Trump's first term. If confirmed, Brooke Rollins would lead the \$200 billion agency and its nearly 100,000 employees whose broad remit includes nutrition and commodity programs, farm loans, forestry, and trade. Read more: Reuters

Feenstra expects changes as farm bill negotiations continue A member of the House Agriculture Committee expects changes to come from farm bill negotiations. Iowa Republican Randy Feenstra says he was frustrated a new farm bill wasn't finished last year. "Now we have majorities in the House and Senate, and we have the presidency. I do think there are going to be some things changing in the farm bill, probably some things around SNAP, work requirements, or fraud adjustments." Read more: Brownfield Ag News

USDA announces presidential appointments to senior staff The U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) has announced several key presidential appointments who will hold senior staff positions at the agency. The appointments include Kailee Tkacz Buller, USDA Chief of Staff, Preston Parry, USDA Deputy Chief of Staff, Jennifer Tiller, M.B.A., M.P.A, Chief of Staff to the Deputy Secretary and Senior Advisor to the Secretary for Food, Nutrition, and Consumer Services, Ralph Linden, J.D., USDA Principal Deputy General Counsel, Audra

Weeks, M.S., M.B.A., USDA Deputy Director of Communications, and Dominic Restuccia, USDA White House Liaison. Read more: Food Safety Magazine

Trump preparing 10% tariff on China in February Bloomberg's Josh Wingrove and Hadriana Lowenkron reported Tuesday that President Donald Trump widened his tariff threats to include China and the European Union on his second day back in office after day one saw Canada and Mexico in his sights. "We're talking about a tariff of 10% on China, based on the fact that they're sending fentanyl to Mexico and Canada," Trump said during an event at the White House on Tuesday, specifying Feb. 1 as a possible date," Wingrove and Lowenkron reported. Read more: Successful Farming

1/31/25:

xFrom rwo@virginia.edu Fri Jan 31 02:04:17 2025
Date: Fri, 31 Jan 2025 02:04:15
From: "O'Connell, Robert W (rwo)" <rwo@virginia.edu>
To: "astro-faculty@virginia.edu" <astro-faculty@virginia.edu>,
"astro-postdocs@virginia.edu" <astro-postdocs@virginia.edu>,
"astro-staff@virginia.edu" <astro-staff@virginia.edu>

Subject: Impoundment of grant funds

I've attached below the best available information on the Trump administration's attempt to impound scientific grants and contracts. This is from the American Institute of Physics' "FYI" newsletter. Dara Norman, the president of the American Astronomical Society, has also issued some comments on the situation, but those were less specific.

By the way, I think Norman's letter only went out to AAS members, and I discovered last year (to my surprise) that most Astronomy Dept faculty are not AAS members. This would be a good time to sign up, my friends.

Even with the initial policy rescinded (and probably thoroughly illegal in the first place), the confusion continues, and some agencies may adopt a defensive posture in which they implement part of the policy as a precaution.

In particular, NSF had threatened to pause "all payments of funds under open awards." This would be serious if it continues. Most agencies do not award full funding to new university grants when they begin. Rather, they transfer funds to hosting institutions on an incremental basis, and this affects approved individual grants in different ways. You would have to determine the actual cash balance

in UVa coffers for each of your grants before you continue spending. The impacts may differ between grants made directly from the agencies and those which are awarded through contractors, such as NRAO, STScI, IPAC, and Chandra. UVa had better issue clarifications about this soon.

The administration is also evidently determined to quench spending on DEI and related initiatives. I believe both NSF and NASA have required PIs to include DEI provisions in all approved grants for several years. Any spending in those categories is definitely vulnerable. It's especially dangerous for any project in which DEI is mentioned in the official abstract, since the agencies are going to be required to send that for review by adversarial parties. I doubt this is going to be resolved for some months, but you should be pressuring the UVa administration and the major institutions that represent US science for clarifications ASAP.

With due respect for the estimable attributes of Man's Best Friend, this is a supreme example of a "dog's breakfast."

Best,

Bob

1/30/25: FYI. TRUMP SPENDING FREEZES SOW CONFUSION AMONG RESEARCHERS

A White House memo directing federal agencies to pause grant payments caused widespread confusion and concern among scientists and research institutions this week. The Office of Management and Budget abruptly rescinded that memo on Wednesday, less than two days after issuing it, but the White House press secretary later insisted that other freezes tied to executive orders issued by Trump remain in effect.

On his first day in office, Trump ordered agencies to terminate all grants related to diversity, equity, and inclusion initiatives "to the maximum extent allowed by law" and to pause spending on energy and climate initiatives related to the "Green New Deal," without defining the term. The subsequent OMB memo issued on Monday was widely interpreted to apply to most federal grant programs, regardless of whether they were singled out by earlier executive orders. OMB said the pause would begin at 5 pm Tuesday, with no end date specified. OMB quickly faced legal challenges from states and non-profit organizations, and a federal judge temporarily halted the grants freeze until Feb. 3, when a court hearing is scheduled to take place. Congressional Democrats also decried Trump's actions as illegal.

IMPACT ON FEDERAL RESEARCH STILL UNCLEAR

OMB appeared to walk back the scope of the funding freeze on Tuesday, stating in a follow-up memo that the pause is “expressly limited to programs, projects, and activities implicated by the President’s Executive Orders, such as ending diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI), the green new deal, and funding nongovernmental organizations that undermine the national interest.”

OMB also issued a 52-page spreadsheet that asked federal agencies to review thousands of grant programs to evaluate whether they are subject to Trump’s executive orders, including many scientific research programs. It is unclear whether federal agencies will be expected to comply with this request in light of OMB rescinding the first memo. The spreadsheet came with instructions for federal agencies to answer 14 questions about each program by Feb. 7, including details such as whether the program is expected to disburse any funds between now and March 15 – the day after the current deadline for Congress to reach a deal on funding the federal government.

On Tuesday, the National Science Foundation announced it would be pausing “all review panels, new awards, and all payments of funds under open awards” as it works to provide the program review and analysis requested by OMB. NSF updated that message after the OMB memo was rescinded, removing the previous language and stating, “Our top priority is resuming our funding actions and services to the research community and our stakeholders.” NSF also advised, however, that its grantees must comply with the Trump administration’s executive orders and cease prohibited activities. “In particular, this may include, but is not limited to conferences, trainings, workshops, considerations for staffing and participant selection, and any other grant activity that uses or promotes the use of DEIA principles and frameworks or violates federal anti-discrimination laws.”

WIDESPREAD CONFUSION AND CRITICISM

Prior to the announcement of the memo’s rescission, House Science Committee Ranking Member Zoe Lofgren (D-CA) described [aip.us17.list-manage.com] the Trump administration’s attempt to freeze federal funding as an “unlawful impoundment” and an “attack on the American taxpayer.” “Scientists researching everything from cures to childhood cancer to severe weather prediction are wondering if their research will remain funded,” said Lofgren, adding “This is a mess.”

Jennifer Jones, director of the Center for Science and Democracy at

the Union of Concerned Scientists, said in an interview on Tuesday that OMB's plans to pause the disbursement of funds for federal research had prompted a "whole new level of anxiety" among scientists, with some questioning whether their jobs and the future of their field of research are on the line. The Trump administration's actions are "meant to really just intimidate everybody doing science and research," Jones said.

University research management offices responded in varying ways to the OMB memos, with some initially advising academics to pause spending federal grant money, and others assuring them that the memos would not impact them. Much of that guidance has now been updated, but inconsistencies remain. The Association of Public and Land-grant Universities and the Association of American Universities sharply criticized the OMB memo. "We are extremely concerned about the impact of this action on our country's ability to maintain its scientific and technological lead against competitors and potential adversaries," wrote AAU President Barbara Snyder in a statement on Tuesday. APLU President Mark Becker described OMB's memo as an "overly broad mandate that is unnecessary and damaging."

"OMB's action has unnecessarily injected an enormous amount of confusion and uncertainty across the nation," Becker said.

ENDD 1/31/25 MSSG

FEBRUARY

2/1/25: Andrew Weissman (substack). FBI firings / My take on the remarkable events today at DOJ-FBI

Here is my take on the above developments as recounted by the acting Director of the Federal Bureau of Investigation (where I served as the General Counsel under Director Mueller). The head of the FBI recounts d receiving a memo from the acting Deputy Attorney General to fire 8 senior career FBI personnel (unless they resign) and the compilation of a list of thousands of FBI personnel who worked on the J6 cases.

1. Firing career FBI agents without cause would violate civil service protections. If the firing is based on their oversight of J6 or Trump criminal investigations that would not constitute good cause. So, if the above is accurate (and I have no reason to think it is not) then Emil Bove (the Acting Deputy Attorney General and until recently one of Trump's criminal defense counsel) is taking action that violates their rights.
2. The wording of the above is interesting- it does not say whether

Bove was saying in the memo that Bove himself was firing these FBI personnel or whether Bove was directing the acting FBI Director to do so (the acting FBI Director reports to Bove). But it sounds to me like Bove sent a memo that directed the acting FBI Director to fire these 8 senior FBI personnel ("are to be terminated"), and he refused. The memo is worded in an odd passive voice, suggesting the FBI Director did NOT go along with the Bove "resign or be fired" scheme, but did pass along on what his boss, Bove, said he wanted to do to them.

3. The Bove memo's direction to compile a list of over a thousand people seven to create a targeted enemies list – what possible legitimate reason is there to hold these people to heightened scrutiny? Absolutely none that I can think of, whereas it is entirely consistent with a retribution effort.
4. All of this is not just highly unusual – ie it had NEVER happened before – but it may well be completely illegal, and certainly appears on its face to be. And this is happening at the top of what is supposed to be a Justice Department.
5. If there is a lawsuit by the affected FBI personnel, it may ironically result in a trial where the facts about the righteousness of the J6 cases and the Trump criminal prosecutions is laid out for all to see – ironically, exactly what Trump has sought to keep under wraps and whitewash. Wouldn't that be a case of just deserts!

2/6/25: WP. Trump policies sow chaos, confusion across scientific community / U.S. scientists, unaccustomed to shock-and-awe political assaults, are reeling from President Donald Trump's executive orders on DEI, gender and other subjects.

February 6, 2025 at 6:00 a.m.

By Joel Achenbach and Carolyn Y. Johnson

Scientists knew change was coming under President Donald Trump, but they were not remotely prepared for the chaos, confusion and fear incited by executive orders that have destabilized the world's largest engine for innovation and discovery.

Small-scale turbulence is manageable in the nation's laboratories and academic institutions, but researchers trying to navigate unprecedented policy changes are whispering existential doubts.

"It's feeling like this could be the beginning of the end of my career," said Benjamin Karin, a National Science Foundation

postdoctoral fellow and evolutionary biologist at the University of California at Berkeley. "It's hard to know if that really is true, but I'm starting to have those doubts. It's a pretty awful feeling."

The first weeks of the Trump administration have been dizzying for scientists in government agencies and laboratories across the country where federal dollars keep experiments running. One of Trump's first orders demanded an end to all government spending on diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI). Another said federal employees must use the word "sex" rather than "gender" and forbade federal spending on "gender ideology."

The orders and other administration memos were stunning and bewildering to many researchers because the language – such as an order to stop "Marxist equity" efforts – was ambiguous.

"Marxist equity? What is that? I don't even know what that is," said Darby Saxbe, a University of Southern California clinical psychologist who has a five-year National Institutes of Health grant to study the neurological changes in the brains of new parents.

As they await more clarity, many scientists are being told to move forward with existing projects. But the uncertainty in the nation's laboratories is pervasive, with scientists unsure whether the work they do will remain funded, free of political interference and published without censorship.

"You've got scientists who should be thinking creatively about their next experiment and the next discovery that we hope they make and instead are thinking about their car payment or their house payment because a lot of early-career scientists live paycheck to paycheck – and that is incredibly concerning to me," said Sudip Parikh, chief executive of the American Association for the Advancement of Science (AAAS), the nation's leading advocacy organization for science education and research.

The state of play has changed not daily but hourly, as administration edicts have been rescinded or halted by judicial orders. At one point, scientists at the National Institutes of Health campus in Bethesda, Maryland, were told they couldn't purchase critical lab supplies to keep their experiments running. A few days later, they could**– though scientists report it's an onerous, clunky process.

Meanwhile, postdoctoral fellows funded by the National Science Foundation scrambled to pay their bills after the funding portal that provides their stipends was ordered frozen. Then the portal reopened <<https://new.nsf.gov/executive-orders>> Sunday in response to a court order.

But for how long? At the NSF, a \$9 billion agency that funds basic

research across the nation, staffers were informed Tuesday that significant layoffs would soon hit the agency. Four employees who attended those meetings shared information on the condition of anonymity for fear of retaliation. They described an agency beset by fear and shock.

Parikh was among four witnesses who testified Wednesday before the House Science, Space and Technology Committee, which held its first hearing of this congressional session, focusing broadly on the state of American science and technology. Much of the hearing was devoted to fears that the United States is falling behind China in the global competition for supremacy in science and technology.

Several Democrats sharply criticized Trump's executive orders. "My fear is that the chaos the new administration is sowing will be enough to leave our science and technology enterprise in ruins, with Chinese Communist leaders in Beijing popping champagne corks,"**said Rep. Zoe Lofgren (D-California).

But witness Samuel Hammond, chief economist of the Foundation for American Innovation, derided DEI efforts at science agencies, saying they have "politicized research, demoralized faculty and wasted billions of taxpayer dollars."

A report released last year by Sen. Ted Cruz (R-Texas) claimed NSF had directed \$2 billion to "thousands of research projects that promoted neo-Marxist perspectives or DEI tenets." But Rep. Valerie Foushee (D-North Carolina) disputed that, saying the Cruz report was based on a search of language in NSF grants that flagged anything with words such as "disability, women, underrepresented, diversity, bias, minority, barrier, systemic, Hispanic."

Foushee said there is an effort to demonize research "that has anything to do with people who aren't White, able-bodied men."

Science is, by its nature, unpredictable. The next big step in artificial intelligence, cancer biology or geoscience may turn up somewhere entirely unexpected.

That's why science agencies sprinkle funding widely to laboratories across the United States, enterprises that are ideally run by a diverse workforce. No one can be certain who will generate the next great idea.

The government spends about \$200 billion a year on all forms of research and development. The private sector spends more. But the government is still the biggest funder of "basic" research, in which results may have no application or may wind up creating something as revolutionary as GPS, smartphones or the internet.

Researchers who depend on federal dollars are in the same position as other federal workers rattled by Trump's policy changes. But science agencies and university-based**researchers have generally enjoyed bipartisan support and have little experience with shock-and-awe political assaults.

Moreover, the scientific community, historically lacking in diversity, has embraced DEI initiatives. And diversity is the law: The 2022 Chips and Science Act passed by Congress requires the NSF to broaden the demographics of science research. The act "bolsters opportunities for minority-serving institutions, emerging research institutions and rural communities" and "establishes a chief diversity officer at NSF to advance diversity, equity and inclusion," according to the NSF's website.

Dannagal Young, a professor of communication, political science and international relations at the University of Delaware, expressed consternation that NSF-funded researchers looking into racial, gender and ethnic differences in political and health outcomes feel constrained in how they perform their work.

"That's like if you went to a climate scientist and said, you can still apply for funds, but you are prohibited from making any reference to warming ocean temperatures," Young said in an email. "Or if you said to a neuroscientist, make sure your grant proposal doesn't make any reference to the human brain."

But trust in science edged downward during the pandemic. Leaders in public health fields were demonized for pandemic-era restrictions. Conspiracy theories have flourished as the information ecosystem has fragmented, and doubts about the credibility of government experts have increased.

And then Trump returned to power, issuing a blizzard of orders and memos that confounded scientific and medical researchers and their institutions.

The usual process for reviewing grant proposals was paused. The NSF has scrambled to identify projects with language that would violate the Trump administration's orders to halt efforts related to DEI or "gender ideology."

Diana Macias, an NSF postdoctoral fellow and forest ecologist at the University of California at Berkeley who is Latina, described the shock of learning that at the National Science Foundation, certain keywords – including "women" and "Hispanic minority" – were being used to flag scientific grants for review.

"My identity is being targeted in so many different ways," Macias said. "It is very terrifying."

After an initially slow response, some professional associations representing researchers have become more vocal in recent days.

Janice R. Lachance, interim executive director of the American Geophysical Union posted a statement Monday night on the organization's website saying "much of what is coming from the Executive branch of the U.S. government runs counter to AGU's mission and values and harms our members." She specified the administration's actions concerning diversity and inclusion efforts and research on climate change.

The Infectious Diseases Society of America and the Association of Schools and Programs of Public Health also have expressed alarm at the removal of information from websites,**including those of the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, and withdrawal of research manuscripts under consideration by scientific journals.

Some of the nation's largest professional scientific and medical associations are still trying to decide how best to respond to the Trump administration's aggressive intervention. Major research universities have been similarly cautious in their responses. The generally muted reaction, according to leaders in the research community, is partly due to the rapid pace of the executive orders, the vague nature of their wording and the judicial interventions.

"The hardest thing is just trying to keep up with what each thing means," said Parikh, the AAAS chief executive. "We have a set of principles about what we think is important, and we're sticking with those as opposed to trying to respond to everything that comes out – it's too hard and too fast to do that."

Marcia McNutt, president of the National Academy of Sciences, said the organization's board of directors will meet next week to decide how to proceed.

"We're concerned about saying anything that would be instantly out of date," McNutt said.

Within science agencies, career employees described an atmosphere of fear and anxiety.

"People are scared. They don't know what's coming," said physicist Michael Lubell, a professor at the City College of the City University of New York and former longtime chief lobbyist for the American Physical Society. "Could there be retribution if they speak out?"

/Lena H. Sun contributed to this report./

349 Comments...

I have two daughters that are scientists and they and so many other scientists and researchers are scared and heartbroken. It takes years of hard work to get where they have gotten and they do their work for humanity. I truly believe that this mayhem is going to hurt us and we as a country won't have any friends to help bail us out. We've pissed them off.

Forbidden words? FORBIDDEN WORDS???
Orwell is doing 2500 rpms.

Well, I am a member of the scientific community with a long history of service in public natural resource agencies. I am not overcome by chaos or confusion. What I am feeling comes a lot closer to anger and a sense of betrayal.

Trump likes to think of himself as smart, in spite of all evidence to the contrary. So he really hates people who actually are smart, because they show how stupid Trump really is

I'm a scientist and I know what it is like to live pay check to pay check as a post-doc and to also know that in another year or so I'll have to find another job. But having survived those years and having had a long, wonderful productive career in science, I'm glad I'm now retired and don't have to put up with Trump's idiocy.

The GOP is a death cult, with evangelicals salivating for the Second Coming in the Middle East, so pouring fuel on that fire is fine with them. Plagues, famine, wars – they welcome them because they believe in fairy tales, and Trump & Musk are using that ignorance to further their greed for power.

Texans should be deeply ashamed of their state for the representation by a person like Sen. Ted Cruz. Ted is nothing but a butt-smooching sycophant who has moved Texas to a level below Alabama, Mississippi, Louisiana, Florida, and Georgia. Texas is now officially the epicenter of stupidity and bigotry in America! Thanks Ted! We're Number 1!

Even a court order doesn't restore NSF funding that ends with no notice. Payroll ending NOW. Please check and see how many NSF labs who supposedly have funds restored by court order are actually receiving money. Impounding of funds is happening right now.

The Trump Regime is about showmanship, drama, faux outrage, conspiracy theories and self righteous indignation.

They cancelled grants into biodiversity. They are insane.

Don't be cowed by all the anti-DEI howling from Trump and his ilk. They clearly have their own DEI as they search for people who are Delusional, Egomaniacal, and Ignorant (hence anti-scientific, allergic to facts)

2/7/25: NYT. Trump Administration Cuts Put Medical Progress at Risk, Researchers Say / Grants from the National Institutes of Health come with additional money for overhead. A planned \$4 billion cut would leave colleges with large budget gaps.

Published Feb. 7, 2025 Updated Feb. 8, 2025, 4:34 p.m. ET

[The proposed policy appears to be based on a deliberate misunderstanding of indirect cost charges, and it fails to acknowledge that the charges are based on legally binding agreements negotiated with the universities by the federal government.]

The nation's universities and academic medical centers were reeling on Saturday from a directive by the Trump administration to slash funding for medical research, a decision that doctors and scientists said would have a devastating effect on studies aimed at finding treatments for diseases such as cancer, diabetes and heart disease.

The change is aimed at reducing the amount of tax dollars that universities spend on overhead costs. The National Institutes of Health, which announced the move Friday evening, said \$9 billion of \$35 billion <<https://x.com/NIH/status/1888004759396958263>> – or about 26 percent – of grant dollars distributed last year had gone to overhead.

The new policy, which takes effect on Monday, will cap “indirect funds” for costs like buildings, utilities and support staff at 15 percent and is aimed at saving \$4 billion.

Dr. David J. Skorton, president of the Association of American Medical Colleges, said the policy would sharply cut funds to universities and medical centers that do N.I.H.-funded research, likely limiting the number of studies that could go forward.

“These are real consequences, longer waits for cures and for diagnosis, slower scientific progress, losing out to competitors around the world, and fewer jobs,” he said, adding: “Those who are facing any health challenges will suffer from less biomedical research.”

Dr. Robert Lefkowitz, a Duke University professor of medicine who won the Nobel Prize in Chemistry in 2012, said that indirect funds pay for the purchase and maintenance of highly sophisticated microscopes that enable him to examine the structure of molecules.

That fundamental research, he said, has made it possible to develop lifesaving medicines for cancer and other diseases. No single researcher, or even a group of researchers, could afford the upkeep on the equipment without the federal dollars tacked onto their grants to support it, he said.

"I think the American people need to understand how devastating it would be if this goes through," Dr. Lefkowitz said. "A lot of research would just have to stop; I can't imagine that the shortfall could be met from other sources."

The N.I.H. funding also supports
<<https://www.unitedformedicalresearch.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/03/UMR-NIHs-Role-in-Sustaining-the-US-Economy-2024-Update.pdf>>
about 412,000 jobs, from research assistants to grant managers to people who dispose of toxic chemicals, according to United for Medical Research, an organization of universities and health advocates.

The leading category of study at the National Institutes of Health is cancer research, an area that has produced breakthrough drugs that have significantly extended survival for people with certain blood cancers and skin cancers. Close behind is infectious disease research, an area that produced the mRNA technology that rapidly produced vaccines against Covid in 2020.

Advances in sequencing the human genome supported in part by the institutes also led to therapies for people with cystic fibrosis who expected to die in their 30s, but are now living into their 60s.

Still, the Trump administration has been sharply critical of what it derides as "woke" policies and cultures at universities, which have been bracing for a hit to their budgets. Project 2025, the Heritage Foundation's policy blueprint for a Republican presidency, called for capping research funds, saying they were sometimes used to fund diversity, equity and inclusion initiatives. Cutting such costs would "reduce federal taxpayer subsidization of leftist agendas," Project 2025's authors said.

Elon Musk, who is running President Trump's government efficiency program, hailed the announcement of the cuts on social media. He suggested that some elite universities devote much more than 30 percent of their grant dollars to administrative costs.

"Can you believe that universities with tens of billions in

endowments were siphoning off 60% of research award money for 'overhead'?" Mr. Musk wrote on X, his social media platform. "What a ripoff!"

While some elite universities do have large endowments, Lawrence O. Gostin, an expert in public health law at Georgetown University, said indirect costs are a lifeline for smaller academic institutions, including historically Black colleges, that depend on federal dollars and conduct medical research on tight margins, often losing money.

"This would be catastrophic," Professor Gostin said. "It would mean that, at the most extreme, universities wouldn't be able to even take N.I.H. money, and would have to stop doing essential research, including research on pediatric cancer and heart disease and dementia and a whole range of other things. At the very best, they would be hemorrhaging money."

He called the policy "literally the opposite of the mission of the N.I.H., which is to advance research, not to make it difficult or even unaffordable."

The administration has said the changes taking effect Monday will apply to existing grants. That will be jarring, said David A. Baltrus, a University of Arizona associate professor whose lab is developing antibiotics for crops.

"I think it's going to destroy research universities in the short term, and I don't know after that," he said. "They rely on the money. They budget for the money. The universities were making decisions expecting the money to be there."

Dr. Baltrus said that his research is focused on efforts such as keeping E. coli bacteria out of crops like sprouts and lettuce. He said the policy change would force his university to make cuts to support staff and other overhead costs.

An N.I.H. social media post said the change could save the federal government as much as \$4 billion and sharply cut payments to Harvard, Yale and Johns Hopkins, which have overhead rates above 60 percent of their grant sums.

The institutes are currently supporting about 11,000 research projects in cancer research. Infectious disease research is a close second, with nearly 9,000 projects underway. Much of the research the institutes fund is meant to discover how diseases work – in the interest of finding cures.

Dr. Skorton, a cardiologist and the president of the medical school association, said the N.I.H. has helped drastically change the fate of people with congenital heart disease, the most common birth

defect. He said when he was born in 1949, 80 percent of people with the condition died before adulthood. Now, 90 percent of them survive.

The N.I.H. funds also support medical equipment suppliers and janitorial services nationwide, with \$6.8 billion going to California, \$5 billion to New York, \$4.5 billion to Massachusetts and \$3.8 billion to North Carolina.

The proposal may tee up a potent test for Republican lawmakers who have largely avoided direct challenges to the Trump administration.

Republican-leaning states reap millions from the institutes, including about \$1 billion each to Florida, Missouri and Tennessee, according to N.I.H. data <<https://reporter.nih.gov/>>. North Carolina researchers were awarded \$3.7 billion in grants last year.

Senator Patty Murray, Democrat of Washington, said in a statement late Friday that the move could “dismantle the biomedical research system, stifle the development of new cures for disease and rip treatments away from patients in need.”

“Just because Elon Musk doesn’t understand indirect costs doesn’t mean Americans should have to pay the price with their lives,” Ms. Murray said in a statement. Her state gets about \$1.5 billion in N.I.H. funds.

The institutes spent about \$35 billion in 2023 on about 50,000 competitive grants to about 300,000 researchers at 2,500 universities, medical schools and other research institutions nationwide, according to the Trump administration. Of that, about \$26 billion directly funded research and \$9 billion covered indirect costs.

The indirect costs pay for buildings, utilities, lab equipment, cleaning costs and “research administration,” which includes the work of safety and regulatory committees that are mandated by the federal government, as well as animal caretakers and other support staff.

One study found
<<https://www.unitedformedicalresearch.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/03/UMR-NIHs-Role-in-Sustaining-the-US-Economy-2024-Update.pdf>>
that every dollar the institutes spend generates \$2.50 in additional spending economic activity.

Dr. Norman Sharpless, a former director of the N.I.H.’s National Cancer Institute, said he expected a forceful response from universities.

“I think it’ll be a very swift legal response from the university counsels across the country,” Dr. Sharpless said. “I do think it will

get enjoined, but hopefully it will lead to a discussion of what indirect costs ought to be. And that's a healthy discussion to be having."

He said 15 percent in indirect costs would be too low in high-cost cities with key research centers such as New York City, San Diego and Boston. "Because you're effectively saying you can't do science in Manhattan," he said.

2/7/25: FYI: Science Policy News. SCIENCE AGENCIES BRACE FOR MASS LAYOFFS / Reports suggest NSF, NOAA, and NIH are among the agencies in line for major cuts.

A flurry of news reports this week suggests that the Trump administration's plans to aggressively downsize the federal workforce will extend to science agencies.

The National Science Foundation has been asked to prepare to lay off between a quarter and half of its staff in the next two months, according to reporting by Politico on remarks made by a senior NSF employee at an internal meeting. The administration may also propose cutting NSF's \$9 billion budget to as low as \$3 billion, an anonymous source told Ars Technica. (FYI has not been able to independently corroborate these accounts.)

[A comment on a different ArsTechnica article repeats the amount of the dollar cut but also says the intention is to move research dollars to the private sector from the university sector.]

Cuts of that magnitude have been proposed in the past by Russell Vought, whom the Senate confirmed yesterday as director of the White House Office of Management and Budget on a party-line vote. In 2022, Vought's Center for Renewing America proposed cutting NSF's annual budget to just under \$4 billion to "force a reprioritization of the core mission of NSF and eliminate the leftward march of the agency and its funding choices."

Congressional Democrats expressed alarm about the Politico report at a Wednesday hearing on the state of the U.S. research enterprise held by the House Science Committee. Ranking Member Zoe Lofgren (D-CA) said she has heard corroborating reports from individual agency employees but is unsure if they are accurate.

The National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration may also be in line for major cuts. Former NOAA officials told CBS News that current employees "have been told to expect a 50% reduction in staff and budget cuts of 30%." Vought's 2022 budget blueprint proposed a 20% cut to NOAA, citing a desire to eliminate its focus on "climate

extremism.”

Although Congress uniformly rejected the steep budget cuts that President Donald Trump proposed for science agencies in his first term in office, Trump is now aggressively challenging congressional spending prerogatives. Trump’s rapid dismantling of the U.S. Agency for International Development has raised fears that other agencies could be next. (Unions representing USAID workers have filed lawsuits attempting to reverse the dismantling.)

The National Institutes of Health is also bracing for upheaval along with the rest of the Department of Health and Human Services. Trump is considering an order that would direct HHS to fire thousands of employees, according to the Wall Street Journal.

Trump’s nominee to lead HHS, Robert F. Kennedy Jr., said last year he wants to immediately fire around 600 employees at NIH. Sen. Angela Alsobrooks (D-MD) raised the subject in his Senate confirmation hearing, expressing concern that Kennedy indicated to her in a private meeting that he intends to “clean house” at NIH. Kennedy responded in the hearing by saying he wants to remove “corrupt” scientists, citing recent reporting about how a NIH researcher manipulated images used in research papers.

The administration is exploring a variety of mechanisms to downsize the federal workforce. The Office of Personnel Management has asked agencies to produce lists of employees who joined recently and are still on their probationary periods, which makes them easier to remove. OPM has also made offers of deferred resignations to hundreds of thousands of federal employees. (The initial deadline to respond was yesterday but a judge extended it to permit further court proceedings on whether the offers are legal.)

In addition, Trump is in the process of reclassifying swaths of federal workers into roles that have fewer civil service protections, arguing that policymaking positions should be subject to greater political control. An executive order issued his first day in office creates a new “Policy/Career” category in the schedule of civil service positions, a renaming of the “Schedule F” order he issued toward the end of his first term.

Agencies could also undergo a reduction in force (RIF), a legal mechanism to lay off federal workers. Federal regulations permit RIFs due to reasons such as agency reorganizations, lack of work, and shortage of funds.

The administration is already attempting to merge USAID into the State Department, and it is rumored to be considering moving at least part of NOAA into the Interior Department. There will likely be lawsuits challenging the authority of the president to take such

moves absent congressional authorization.

Another action that could lead to major staffing changes is Trump's pledge to move up to 100,000 federal employees out of the DC area. For instance, policymakers have begun to talk about the prospect of moving NASA's headquarters out of DC to states such as Florida or Texas.

Related:

[2/4/25]: Politico. Science funding agency threatened with mass layoffs / National Science Foundation staff heard the plans at a meeting Tuesday.

One of the United States' leading funders of science and engineering research is planning to lay off between a quarter and a half of its staff in the next two months, a top National Science Foundation official said Tuesday.

The comments by Assistant Director Susan Margulies came at an all-hands meeting of the NSF's Engineering Directorate, according to two program managers who attended.

Margulies, NSF and the White House didn't respond to detailed questions about the layoffs and their potential implications.

"A large-scale reduction, in response to the President's workforce executive orders, is already happening," a spokesperson for the Office of Personnel Management said in an email. "The government is restructuring, and unfortunately, many employees will later realize they missed a valuable, once-in-a-lifetime opportunity in the deferred resignation offer."

The NSF announcement comes amid reports of planned layoffs at the General Services Administration and with a Thursday deadline looming for federal workers to accept buyouts from the Trump administration that some former government officials have warned are legally dubious.

The Trump administration is trying to "scare the shit out of people so they take advantage of the resignation offers out of fear," said one NSF program manager who asked not to be identified to avoid retribution.

But if the White House and its so-called Department of Government Efficiency are serious about slashing NSF, the result would be catastrophic, the same program manager warned. Cutting the \$10 billion grantmaking agency in half would "gut the intellectual center

of U.S. leadership in science and technology," the official said.

It's unclear how the threatened reduction in force at NSF would comply with union agreements the agency has with the American Federation of Government Employees. AFGE didn't respond to requests for comment.

Related:

[2/6/25]: ArsTechnica. White House budget proposal could shatter the National Science Foundation / "This kind of cut would kill American science and boost China."

Sometime during the next several weeks, the directors of federal agencies will receive a draft version of President Trump's budget request for the coming fiscal year, which begins on October 1. This "passback review" is a standard part of the federal budgeting process which ends in Congress writing a budget and the president signing it into law.

The budget request will be the first of President Trump's second term, and it will offer a clear window into the priorities of his new administration. Although widespread cuts are expected for much of the government's discretionary spending, the outlook for the National Science Foundation appears to be especially grim.

During an emotional all-hands meeting on Tuesday, the agency's assistant director for engineering, Susan Margulies, told agency employees to EXPECT BETWEEN A QUARTER AND A HALF OF ITS STAFF TO BE LAID OFF within the coming months, E&E News reported.

On Thursday, two sources told Ars that the science agency should expect to see steep cuts in Trump's forthcoming budget request. In recent years, the National Science Foundation has received an annual budget of approximately \$9 billion, the vast majority of which is spent on research and research-related activities. The CUTS COULD BE AS DEEP AS 66 PERCENT, with one person indicating the top-line budget number for the National Science Foundation could start at \$3 billion.

Such a massive cut is not out of line with a proposal made by Russ Vought for the fiscal year 2023 budget as part of his Center for Renewing America. Vought is expected to become the White House budget director in the coming days. Three years ago, Vought proposed cutting the National Science Foundation budget to \$3.9 billion. The cuts, he wrote, would require NSF "to make better decisions and target grants to actual research that will benefit the whole country, not just propagandize for woke ideology."

...such cuts could prove disastrous for the US science community. "This kind of cut would kill American science and boost China and other nations into global science leadership positions," Neal Lane, who led the National Science Foundation in the 1990s during Bill Clinton's presidency, told Ars. "The National Science Foundation budget is not large, of the order 0.1 percent of federal spending, and several other agencies support excellence research. But NSF is the only agency charged to promote progress in science."

...Some fields, including astronomy, non-health-related biology, and Antarctic research, are all almost entirely underwritten by the National Science Foundation. The primary areas of its funding can be found here.

Comments...

It used to be that saboteurs worked in the shadows. Today they're being celebrated.

When I see republicans asking for help when they are struck down and struggling from the consequences of their votes in the future, I will have some internal debate because I want to help people, and set a good example, because a good person will help someone when he has the ability to do so. But I'll also want to just say "no, fuck you, you voted for this and now you can reap the whirlwind"

Related:

[2/7/25]: Tampa Bay News. Push to move NASA HQ to Florida still abuzz among space community / NASA headquarters currently employs nearly 2,500 people among its total workforce of nearly 18,000 civil employees.

The idea floated earlier this month by Gov. Ron DeSantis that NASA might consider moving its headquarters from Washington to Florida remains a topic of interest in space circles.

During a panel discussion about public-private partnerships during the commercial space convention SpaceCom's final day at the Orange County Convention Center on Thursday, the top-voted question during a Q&A portion asked for panel members to weigh in on the idea of bringing the headquarters to Kennedy Space Center. While there was laughter among the crowd, it still prompted an evenhanded answer from Jonathan Baker, chief of spaceport development at KSC.

"We're focused on exploration and innovation, and so we want to enable that in whatever way possible, right? So however the agency deems best to accomplish that here at KSC, we're ready and on board

to support that," Baker said. "Whether that means a move for headquarters or not. We are ready to support whatever the agency needs to move forward."

Rob Long, CEO of Space Florida, the state's aerospace finance and development authority, smiled and chimed in as well. "I mean, it would make a lot of sense to move NASA headquarters to Kennedy Space Center," Long said. "Just saying."

While the back-and-forth was made with some levity the idea isn't completely unrealistic, especially in an era under President Trump's second administration married with SpaceX founder and CEO Elon Musk's push to cut government spending as head of the Department of Government Efficiency, Trump's cost-cutting initiative known as DOGE.

2/8/25: WP. NIH cuts billions of dollars in biomedical funding, effective immediately / Researchers say it would hurt facilities that work on medical issues such as cancer research and heart disease. Elon Musk contends the old policy was "a ripoff."

The Trump administration is cutting billions of dollars in biomedical research funding, alarming academic leaders who said it would imperil their universities and medical centers and drawing swift rebukes from Democrats who predicted dire consequences for scientific research.

The move, announced Friday night by the National Institutes of Health, drastically cuts its funding for "indirect" costs related to research. These are the administrative requirements, facilities and other operations that many scientists say are essential but that some Republicans have claimed are superfluous.

"The United States should have the best medical research in the world," NIH said in its announcement. "It is accordingly vital to ensure that as many funds as possible go towards direct scientific research costs rather than administrative overhead."

In a social media post, NIH said the change would save more than \$4 billion a year, EFFECTIVE IMMEDIATELY. The note highlighted the multibillion-dollar endowments of Harvard University, Yale University and Johns Hopkins University, implying that many universities do not need the added federal funding.

Last year, \$9B of the \$35B that the National Institutes of Health (NIH) granted for research was used for administrative overhead, what is known as "indirect costs." Today, NIH lowered the maximum indirect cost rate research institutions can charge the government to 15%, above...

The NIH policy, essentially a massive budget cut to science and medical centers across the country, was quickly denounced as devastating by universities and research organizations.

Some scientists said the move could threaten research already underway and noted that their universities have a fraction of the endowments of schools such as Harvard and Yale. Industry leaders also questioned whether the move was legal, pointing to existing law governing NIH funding.

...The funding is "part and parcel of the total costs of conducting world class research," Owens added. "We are carefully reviewing this policy change as it contradicts current law and policy. America's competitors will relish this self-inflicted wound."

Ted Mitchell, the president of the American Council on Education, a nonprofit that works with university leaders, said some labs were in the process of shutting down over the weekend.

Mitchell warned [that unless the policy is blocked] that there will be "less biomedical innovation, and that is going to contribute to higher degrees of disease and death in the country."

Trump allies hailed NIH's move. The U.S. DOGE Service, the office led by billionaire Elon Musk that has focused on slashing government spending, said NIH's new policy would save billions of dollars in "excessive grant administrative costs" and praised the "amazing job by NIH team" in a post on social media.

"Can you believe that universities with tens of billions in endowments were siphoning off 60% of research award money for 'overhead'?" Musk wrote in his own post, contending that the old policy was "a ripoff."

Republicans in recent years had weighed cutting federal funds for overhead costs at universities, with the first Trump administration abandoning a plan to do so amid pressure from biomedical leaders.

Democrats immediately castigated the Trump administration, saying NIH's move would imperil clinical research, patient care and laboratory operations, among other health-care priorities.

"Just because Elon Musk doesn't understand indirect costs doesn't mean Americans should have to pay the price with their lives," Sen. Patty Murray (D-Washington) said in a statement.

Murray, the top Democrat on the Senate's appropriations panel, also pointed to bipartisan legislation that she oversaw last year and has been enacted into law, which she noted banned changes to how NIH funds overhead costs. The new policy is "illegal and arbitrary,"

Murray said.

...[Indirect costs] amount is a percentage of the direct research costs in the grant and varies by institution. But it can be more than half of the direct costs. A research award for \$100,000 in direct costs, for example, could come with \$50,000 in indirect costs, making the total grant \$150,000.

In fiscal 2023, out of \$35 billion in awarded grants, \$9 billion went to overhead, NIH said.

In its announcement, NIH said that on average, the overhead rate has been about 27 to 28 percent of the direct research funding in the grant but that "many organizations" charge indirect rates of over 50 percent and in some cases more than 60 percent. The agency's new policy will cap the rate at 15 percent and TAKE EFFECT ON MONDAY, cutting tens of millions of dollars or more in funding for many universities – VIRTUALLY OVERNIGHT.

..."I expect it will cause some universities to not be able to afford to accept federal life science grants. I am at a loss to understand how this is beneficial to Americans," Zuber added.

..."This abrupt change in the way grants are funded will have devastating consequences on medical science," said Rathmell..."Many people will lose jobs, clinical trials will halt, and this will slow down progress toward cures for cancer and effective prevention of illness."

..."A sane government would never do this," [Jeffrey] Flier wrote on social media.

Several researchers said that NIH's high rate of funding for indirect costs helped subsidize the infrastructure necessary for their work – everything from a building's heating and electricity to personnel. They also said that the government's willingness to fund indirect costs at more than 50 percent balanced out the lower rate that researchers tend to receive from private foundations, which were more likely to fund 15 percent of the indirect costs.

NIH said it was cutting its rate of funding indirect costs to be more in line with private foundations that fund research, noting that many foundations do not fund indirect costs at all.

Researchers also said it was misleading for NIH to selectively highlight some university endowments in its social media post announcing the new policy. The schools' endowments, a collection of tax-exempt donations and investments, have limitations that make it difficult for schools to radically draw them down, and portions of the endowments can be restricted to uses that donors stipulate.

Republicans had weighed similar measures in the past. President Donald Trump in 2017 proposed capping indirect costs at 10 percent, but the effort did not succeed.

...But some Trump officials said they were wary of the sudden policy change, noting the immediate blowback across academia, and predicted that the move would be opposed by GOP lawmakers worried about the effect on their constituents. "Red states have universities too," one Trump official, speaking on the condition of anonymity**because they were not authorized to speak to the press, wrote in a message.

Correction: A previous version of this article misstated the percentage of overhead funding that NIH said is in research. In its announcement, NIH said on average, the overhead rate has been about 27 to 28 percent, not 27 to 38 percent. The article has been corrected.

4056 Comments...

What we've learned very quickly is that any statement coming out of the White House or its allies in Congress regarding any agency or department should be assumed to be a lie. The Post rarely gets up the nerve to say so, but The NY Times is giving lots of evidence of that on pretty much a daily basis. The administration's accusations about spending by the USAID, for example, are pretty much all made up hogwash.

Let's be very clear: TRUMP'S ACTIONS WILL RESULT IN PEOPLE DYING!
It's that simple.

Indirect costs on government contracts to defense companies (Lockheed, Northrop Grumman, etc) are routinely over 100%. When can we expect those to be capped at 15% as well? Indirect costs on SpaceX contracts are over 50%. When will that be cut to 15%? This is utter madness.

"A sane government would never do this" But a government run by a revengeful lying psychopath and one a self confessed Asperger personality would. Between Trump and Musk they have no conscience, decency, empathy, integrity, knowledge or wisdom.

How do you do research without the buildings to do it in and the equipment with which to do it? We're going to wind up, in four years, as a very large third world country, run into the ground by a demented despot.

I am a physician scientist at Johns Hopkins. This move by Fuehrer Trump will devastate my university as it immediately cuts the budget by 30%. We will need to close cancer trials and fire a good part of

our work force. Research labs will close. We all lose.

all this so rich people can avoid paying their taxes.

This is insane. Without workspace and assistants, what research can be conducted? Researchers will quit without funding...And the cruelty. Those people who lose their jobs immediately still have house payments to make.

President Musk's doge-bag stormtroopers strike again.

While the U.S. government weakens its scientific leadership, Canada stands ready to welcome top researchers with open arms. Our robust research infrastructure, public healthcare system, and strong federal and provincial support for life sciences make Canada an ideal destination for those whose work is now imperiled. The loss for the U.S. could be Canada's gain—talented scientists should look north, where their research will be valued and sustained.

I am a medical oncologist who runs clinical trials evaluating new cancer fighting medications. I cannot emphasize enough: We are so totally screwed.

Egg prices were high, and you didn't like the way she laughed.
You fooking morons.

[Hey! Another Trump campaign promise fulfilled! Nobody's paying high prices for eggs anymore because, as NBC reported tonight, in many areas THERE ARE NO EGGS AVAILABLE AT ANY PRICE. Just forget about them.]

At one time, I was a federal contracting officer, handling both contracts and grants. I understand overhead charges, all cost based contracts and grants include a line item for overhead, or administrative costs. These overhead rates are audited and approved by government audit agencies. What I would like to see is a copy of Eli Musk's government contracts, pretty sure we will find he is being paid overhead costs.

I am not sure how to explain how devastating this is to our global scientific standing. NIH is the golden standard for human research from diabetes to cardiovascular disease, cancer, pediatric diseases, addiction and public health etc. They are gutting our research institutions, they are destroying our scientific progress and higher education communities. Also the indirect cost covers the salaries and livelihood of millions of employees not just scientists. I do agree reforming is needed, but this is NOT reform. This is destruction by a fascist movement. By the way we got the notice Friday night around 9 pm EST.

I never realized that cancer research, which requires state-of-the-art facilities, was part of a "leftist agenda."

Ah yes...Shock and Awe...at 77 years old I'm watching the destruction of my beloved America by the most vile and evil traitors in our history. I've watched it creep since Reagan; I studied it at Yale and saw it in all its Gory with the election of trump in 2016.

Yes indeed, Red States have huge medical centers funded by the NIH. MD Anderson in Texas is a massive operation. Well done, Texas, you played yourselves.

Trump to ill Americans: Just die already!

We're now dependent on foreign countries for new medicine. The Republican Party is the dumbest political party on the planet. The developing world is going to move past us in most industries now. Only a republican would hand world hegemony to communist china

If you are outside research/academia this might be hard to fully grasp so let me try to clarify. To do our work, we need safe, secure, and clean buildings. We need running water, the lights on, the exhaust systems intact. We need chemical fume hoods, biosafety cabinets, incubators filled with CO₂ to do our experiments safely, and without contamination. We need an animal facility and caretakers to ensure our animals are being used humanely. We need to dispose of our chemicals and sharps safely. These are just some of the indirect costs. The direct costs include salary support (often NIH grants do not cover 100% of a PIs salary and we need to do multiple things to have a decent salary), the reagents we use, gloves we wear, pipette tips we need, kits we use are all direct costs. These are prohibitively expensive- a single antibody may cost hundreds or dollars and different media for cell culture is also hundreds of dollars for a 500mL bottle. Housing animals (which unfortunately are the best way we have to mimic human physiology) is costly. It adds up quickly. If you want to cut the rates, renegotiate with the universities. But maybe you can see how a lab in NYC costs more to run than maybe Kansas and why IDCs vary. It's pretty scary to be at a university doing research right now.

Indirect costs are supporting administrators who ensure we spend funds according to federal rules, building maintenance, energy costs and safety monitoring. Standard NIH grants have not been inflation-corrected for 20 years. We are already operating on a shoestring budget, needing ingenuity and support from our universities to remain productive, and we are. Building a career and being productive in such a system has been very tough, but also very rewarding. Everyone who is still in it is among the smartest and most productive in the world, a true blessing for this country. This move by the Musk/Trump administration will kneecap US biomedical research,

exactly at a time where China's biotech industry is becoming a serious competitor. I am also a cancer survivor. I am cancer free because of a robotic surgical technique my brilliant colleagues developed at my medical school, validated in a NIH-funded clinical trial. The infrastructure supporting them will be gone soon when indirect rate cuts become permanent, and this will cause huge damage and make our state's population less healthy. But I think this is the intention. They must be stopped for all of our sakes.

And what does the Republican Congress, who approved those funds say? Oh, yeah. "Thank you sir, Trump, may I have another."

Note that Big Pharma spends more on advertising than it does on R&D, but of course the US will never free up some of that money by banning ads for prescription drugs ("ask your doctor if a little black capsule that solves all your problems is right for you").

It's really important to understand how these numbers work. If the overhead is 55%, it means that for \$1M of planned research, the government sends \$1.55M, which is closer to 35%. This 35% is used for things hazardous waste disposal and other things that scientists are not allowed to manage individually (for darn good reasons), but also jobs for accountants, janitors, IT, and all the things that need to exist in order for the scientists to work. Capping this rate at 15% when a rate was previously 55% means basically 73% cut in critical infrastructure that enables research. Researchers will not be able to continue their work without these things. This is not a "rip off"

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[2/8-9/2025]: DFT --- ***NOT SENT***

At first I thought these moves were the reflexive random thrashing of mindless zealots...but now it looks like they are part of a cold-blooded, deliberate and malicious attack on the underpinnings of the US scientific enterprise. I can't judge the extent to which these people understand the consequences of what they're doing, but I suspect they don't care. They seem eager to produce a Gaza-like wasteland for American science.

This is a fundamental assault on university finances. Again, it's undoubtedly illegal as it stands because indirect costs are actually negotiated contractually between the federal government and individual universities.

The negotiated rates cover all parts of university operations that cannot be specifically assigned to an individual research project: utilities; building space; infrastructure maintenance; centralized computer and internet services; libraries and data management; health

and safety operations; emergency services; insurance; and general administrative functions like grant administration, payroll, personnel, purchasing, government compliance offices, audit services, etc. Universities are subject to the same level of scrutiny as any other government contractor in the private sector.

There is no peacetime precedent for wholesale termination of already-approved research allocations. Scientific research programs normally take years to develop and mature. Serious damage will be done by interruptions in support even if funds are restored later. In particular, key personnel may have to find other jobs; and in the life/health sciences long-running experiments, clinical studies and other time-critical projects can suffer catastrophic damage.

The attack on ID costs is based on ignorance or a deliberate misunderstanding of federal grants and contracts. If they were serious about it, this would apply to all the contracting the federal government does, including with defense contractors and the companies that Elon Musk runs.

Unfortunately, because it's claimed to address "wasteful overhead," it may well find more sympathy in Congress. and the imposition of some kind of cap is not unlikely. There's a parallel movement to tax the annual income from university endowments.

And you'd think these fools would care about the overall economic impact. Cuts across the government will have negative consequences. Watch the unemployment rate soar (especially in Virginia). Watch unemployment insurance run dry. Watch the GDP take a hit, because every dollar of federal spending generates multiple dollars of economic activity. Watch the GOP take a bad hit in the 2025 elections in Virginia.

[Based on FY 22 ann report, annual federal grant revenue to UVa is about \$400M.

F&A rate is 61.5%

Direct costs are therefore $\$400M / 1.61 = \$250M$

while F&A earnings are $0.61 \times \$250M = \$150M$

Under a 15% F&A cap, the total revenue would be $1.15 \times \$250 = \$288M$, and F&A earnings would be $0.15 \times \$250 = \$38M$.

There would be NET LOSS of \$112M/year in F&A revenues.]

Related, from the 5/13/25 faculty meeting:

SRM claims the impact of a 15% ID cap would be a \$10M hit to CAS. Mostly in startup packages. CAS budget is \$452M overall this year. BoV increased tuition 3% for next year, but policy after that unclear.

[The "\$10M hit" underestimates the ultimate impact. That's the loss of discretionary funds allocated to A&S. But UVa as a whole will be on the hook to replace the loss of something like \$100M in indirect cost allocations to run its infrastructure and support functions. It's going to be next to impossible to squeeze that out of current operating funds without serious effects on academic operations. \$100M is on the order of 800 staff members' full-time compensation. Are we going to fire them all? If the new ID cap becomes policy, almost certainly this means a faculty and staff hiring freeze for some years, reduction of grad student support, freeze on capital projects and new initiatives, poorer academic support services (e.g. computing, internet), no access to discretionary endowment income, etc.]

Effects of announced restructuring of NSF are unclear but could be deleterious to astronomy. The Astronomy Division will disappear, leaving us subject to less knowledgeable and sympathetic overseers.

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2/12/25: SPACEREF via NASA Watch <<https://nasawatch.com/>>

Planetary Science Institute
February 12, 2025

Opinion: Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Accessibility Are
Important for the Workplace and Science

by Mark V. Sykes, Ph.D., J.D. – CEO and Director, Planetary
Science Institute

To the American Public and Government Officials:

I would like to share a positive perspective of diversity, equity, inclusion and accessibility from the context of a science institute. At a time when these principles are being purged by our government from a large swath of federal programs, you should know they actually advance science, thereby advancing the interests of our country, and are important for the workplace. In the course of this, I would also like to take this opportunity to show you that scientists

share much of your experiences and backgrounds as people, and something about the process of science itself.

The Planetary Science Institute takes pride in the accomplishments and discoveries of our scientists as they pursue our mission of exploring the Solar System and solar systems around other stars, pursuing questions of origins, life, and how everything works.

Our scientists are highly trained, highly skilled, and are supported by dedicated administrative and support staff that are likewise deeply experienced and remarkable. We open our doors widely to all those who are passionate about pursuing this work and sharing it with the scientific community and general public.

This work is not for the faint of heart, as it is supported through openly competed and limited sources of funding primarily from NASA and other agencies. To maximize our success as an institute in this context, we seek to attract people from all walks of life.

Our institute and its mission are apolitical. Our scientists range from strong supporters of the current administration to those who deeply oppose it to those who don't particularly care or have other political interests. We have scientists of a broad range of national origins, race, and gender identities. Our scientists are Evangelical Christians, Jews, Mormons, Catholics, Muslims, Buddhists, Atheists, and other religious and non-religious persuasions. Some are veterans. Our scientists have diverse personalities and a wide range of interpersonal skills. Some have physical challenges, some are neurodiverse, and everyone comes from a wide range of economic and cultural backgrounds. This is diversity. We value it. We encourage it. We want it.

Diversity is a strength of our Institute and a strength to our science. How can that be? Science depends not just on technical skill and knowledge, but more importantly on imagination. We use our imagination when identifying questions raised by our observations of the universe around us, then gaining new understanding in answering those questions, and then to determine how we can challenge our newfound understanding. Scientific insights can spring from a recent research paper, a conversation with a friend, a religious experience, a dream, or watching a basketball game. As we work together, we share our ideas from our different perspectives and experiences. The vast range of insights facilitated by increasing diversity maximizes the quality and range of the science that we produce. This is true for all science.

We want to retain our talented employees and enable them to engage in meaningful work, so it is important to provide a positive, engaging and supportive work environment. To realize this, we commit to being a community dedicated to excellence in our work and helping each other

to be successful in our professional and even personal endeavors. We value each other and our families. We value everyone's opinions – even when we do not agree with them. We listen to each other. We are honest with each other. We always treat each other fairly with dignity and respect. We acknowledge when a person has been wronged and work to rectify it justly. This is equity.

Science is a naturally inclusive human endeavor unconfined to a single institution or profession. It is largely a cooperative, even global enterprise, inclusive of many communities. Inclusion supports our desire for growing diversity to add to what we have. We also want to create more diversity by reaching out to the general public, including communities of people that have little participation in our field or even science in general. We want to inspire them, teach them, and hopefully motivate them, sometimes by giving them some participatory experience in our science. We actually do this as a regular matter for all the communities in which we live.

We are committed to enabling all staff members to reach their full potential. Therefore, we are committed to providing accessibility. When employees need help with accessibility to do their jobs, we do whatever we can to help. This goes beyond just providing a special chair or a large computer screen. Accessibility by PSI is sometimes provided by time. Time to deal with intrusions of life, recognizing this can be significantly constrained in some businesses. Accessibility promotes productivity and a positive work environment.

Always striving to promote diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility enhances our ability to advance our mission objectives and promotes the betterment of our science. Denouncing these principles and degrading their use is harmful to our science and to American competitiveness in the world. It worries me that such rhetoric has often presaged violence against those who are perceived to benefit from the denounced activity. Many of our scientists are concerned for their future and even physical safety. There are legitimate complaints regarding some activities undertaken under the rubric of these principles. However, I would like to see those specific objections considered and addressed in a fashion that is narrowly tailored to relieve any wrong being committed while maintaining and building on all the good we have achieved.

Mark V. Sykes, Ph.D., J.D.
CEO and Director
Planetary Science Institute

5 responses

1. billinpasadena says:

February 12, 2025 at 10:11 pm

It's not quite clear how these values of any good workplace require an expensive addition to the administration to be accomplished. Was PSI failing before they added a DEI office? And why did some universities with complex DEI bureaucracies fail so badly in free speech and welcoming outside speakers with heterodox views?

Keith Cowing says:
February 13, 2025 at 6:36 pm

I'm sorry -- is there a cogent point in your word salad? Just wondering.

2.

Steven Parnell says:
February 13, 2025 at 10:44 am

Really Keith? Noting else going on at NASA? The amount of attention given to this is ridiculous. I've been at NASA for almost 40 years and I can tell you that over the last 4+ years of dealing with these DEI "directives" has caused more harm to the collective than any good to the outcomes of the mission of the agency. I know that among many I talk to, there was a sigh of relief with the recent EO's to end this. China is about to beat us with a crewed mission to Mars (probably by the end of this decade) and we need a force of "unity" within NASA to accomplishing the necessary advancements to getting there first! The only "flag" at NASA that matters is the American flag planted by a crew on the surface of Mars.

I've followed Nasawatch for decades and for the most part it was very informative, however, lately the echo chamber of an ideology has infected it to the point of being irrelevant. Per Audacia Ad Astra!

*

Keith Cowing says:
February 13, 2025 at 6:35 pm

Well I guess I won't be missing you either. I am leaving your comments up given that they are a classic example of the ignorance and intolerance that pervades the space community these days. Oh yes -- you say you have been at NASA for almost 40 years yet Google and the NASA.gov search engine seem to find no evidence of that. But your IP says that you are online via the University of Colorado in Boulder. No NASA centers there. Google shows no connections. So -- I guess you do not actually exist. Have a nice day.

3.

DP Huntsman says:

February 13, 2025 at 12:54 pm

Well said, Dr Sykes! I'll all but guarantee you that those who take issue with your position, though, will NOT say anything fact-or-data based in rejoinder, but just cast aspersions (or words that sound like aspersions). Thank you very much for speaking up.

As far as Steven Parnell's take -- spent 46 years at the agency before retiring, and it's like he hasn't even read what Dr Sykes has written. ANYTHING-- including those efforts lumped under the term DEI -- can be run more efficiently. But in aerospace, we have historically Not done an excellent -- automatic -- job at outreach to ensure NASA et al heard from ALL walks of people in this hugely diverse country, unless we were forced to make sure we were doing it. It Never just happened naturally -- still, to this day. Centuries and in the case of women, millennia-- of habits don't get changed on a dime; and DEI's sole purpose is to first recognize that-- and then pro-actively do something about it, no excuses.

Thanks again, Dr Sykes.

Dave Huntsman

2/12/25:

xFrom rwo@virginia.edu Wed Feb 12 18:02:26 2025

Date: Wed, 12 Feb 2025 18:02:24

From: "O'Connell, Robert W (rwo)" <rwo@virginia.edu>

To: "David.Leckrone@nasa.gov" <David.Leckrone@nasa.gov>

Subject: Bad old days are back

Hi Dave:

When I was reading about the Trump-Musk administration trying to fire essential agency personnel for no reason, your name naturally popped into my head.

Trump is the best argument to be retired and watching it all from the sidelines (at least I hope that's where we are).

Hope all is well with you.

Cheers,

Bob

Robert W. O'Connell
J. D. Hamilton Professor of Astronomy, Emeritus
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P.O. Box 400325
Charlottesville, VA 22904-4325 [https://rwoconne.github.io/
profile](https://rwoconne.github.io/profile)
USA

2/21/25: <<https://www.chronicle.com/>> THE RISE (AND FALL?) OF THE
NATIONAL SCIENCE FOUNDATION / In the '50s, America declared
science an 'endless frontier.' We may be reaching the end of it.

URL: [https://www.chronicle.com/article/the-rise-and-fall-of-the-
national-science-foundation](https://www.chronicle.com/article/the-rise-and-fall-of-the-national-science-foundation)

The Review | Essay
By Carly Anne York

For most of the past century, the United States has been the global leader in scientific discovery. In just the last five years, American scientists have won more Nobel Prizes than the rest of the world combined. But we weren't always leaders in scientific advancement. It wasn't until the 1950 establishment of the National Science Foundation (NSF), the largest funding source for basic research in the country, that America became a powerhouse of modernization.

Under the Trump administration, the same system that boosted the United States to scientific dominance is being recklessly dismantled. In the past few weeks, the newly created Department of Government Efficiency has ordered the NSF to reduce its staff by 25-50 percent to meet strict new budget targets. They have already fired 168 workers. Even more alarming, the administration is considering slashing the NSF's \$9-billion budget to just \$3-4 billion, jeopardizing funding for thousands of scientists and their research. Beyond budget cuts, political interference is reshaping the NSF's priorities. A recent executive order from President Trump mandates a review of all funded projects for flagged terms associated with DEI initiatives such as "gender," "ethnicity" and "systemic." Any projects containing these words must be modified to comply with the order or risk losing funding. Not only does this policy effectively roll back critical diversity initiatives, it will make research into important topics like health care much more difficult to fund.

Because many scientists conduct their work at universities, these

policies are a profound threat to higher education. Many of the technologies and medical breakthroughs we rely on today**– from computers to Viagra – were first developed within university research labs. American universities' renowned science programs attract the brightest minds from around the world. In fact, 43 percent of America's STEM work force was born in other countries. This is due both to the quality of education in our university system and the groundbreaking scientific advancements made within these institutions – made possible in large part by the National Science Foundation.

It is important to understand how funds from an NSF grant are distributed to universities. In 2024 the NSF had a total budget of about \$9 billion to support scientists around the country across all disciplines, including biology, geology, chemistry, mathematics, physics, psychology, sociology, and even some parts of engineering and computer science. Compared to the \$841-billion budget for the Department of Defense, this is a drop in the bucket of the total national budget. With that \$9 billion, around 11,000 projects were awarded funds. Of those 11,000 projects, the average NSF research grant in 2024 was approximately \$150,000. That money covers the salaries plus benefits of graduate students in the lab. Often this salary is somewhere around \$25,000 and for the length of the grant (typically 3 years). And then there is the university's overhead, or "indirect costs," a certain percentage of the total grant that goes to the university for keeping the lights on. This portion varies by institution and typically ranges anywhere from 20–80 percent of the requested costs, though this also might soon change under the Trump administration. Slashing the budget of the NSF even further will devastate the engines of discovery and innovation without making a dent in the overall national budget.

In recent decades, the National Science Foundation has paid for billions of dollars of basic research each year, but this was not always the case. Traditionally, American science was supported by philanthropists and other powerful people. In fact, before World War II, government funding was incredibly rare in the United States, mostly granted to aeronautics and agriculture studies. This meant that to fund their research, scientists needed to be able to convince someone rich that their research was valuable. For example, Alexander Graham Bell, the famous inventor of the telephone, got most of the money for his invention from the wealthy father of one of his students. He eventually married that student, securing his line of funding.

Although funding throughout the 19th and the early 20th century was limited, faculty members were still expected to engage in research in addition to teaching. Herbert Hoover, the U.S. secretary of commerce from 1921–28, was concerned by the lack of financial support for basic research. Up to this point, the United States largely let the

rest of the world lead the way in scientific discovery. Hoover saw this as a national weakness and campaigned to establish a national research endowment to support university research with funds provided by industry. Though Hoover was adamant that the future of the nation depended on our scientific prowess, industry failed to see how they would benefit from research that might not lead to an immediate application. They declined to provide funds, and Hoover's endowment never came to fruition. It wasn't until 1940 that President Franklin D. Roosevelt approved the National Defense Research Committee, the forerunner to today's National Science Foundation.

Slashing the budget of the NSF even further will devastate the engines of discovery and innovation without making a dent in the overall national budget.

The pivotal figure in the shift to government funding of science was Vannevar Bush, the former vice president of the Massachusetts Institute of Technology. At the time of his tenure, MIT relied on corporate sponsors to fund their labs. This was unusual; most institutions depended on student tuition, private philanthropy, and grants from local industries for funding. After the stock market crash of 1929, however, the university found itself struggling to stay afloat. Most administrators of private universities felt that the government had no business in higher education, and their peers at public universities largely agreed. But with the Depression looming, Bush decided to reconsider federal funding for his university. He had the idea of creating contracts with the federal government to support basic research across all scientific disciplines. In 1938, Bush was elected president of the Carnegie Institution, which afforded him the platform to influence federal scientific policy. He oversaw the creation of the National Defense Research Committee in June 1940, which awarded thousands of research contracts to universities across the country under his watch. By 1945, 90 percent of MIT's annual operating budget came from federal research contracts.

The National Defense Research Committee was created with the goal of advancing technological development for World War II. Before the war, university scientists and the military stayed largely in their own lanes. In fact, there had been a lack of cooperation between civilian scientists and the U.S. military during WWI, and the feelings of contempt ran both ways. Scientists at the time considered the enlistment of their skills for the military as a "deseccration upon the temple of science," as the historian Daniel Kevles put it. At the same time, any scientists who did try to work with the military ran into a wall of prejudice: Military officers didn't believe scientists to be as qualified as service members. In fact, in the 1930s some scientists had tried to collaborate with the armed services but were told that no civilian could match a service member's judgement about the practicality of new weapons. These attitudes were of great

concern for Bush, who wanted to use the power of science to enhance the U.S. military. By helping channel federal funding directly to scientists, he was able to mend this fissure, and both parties came to see the benefit of this relationship. Scientists had the financial means to perform high-quality research, and the military had access to the brightest minds in the country. With Bush's guidance, the National Defense Research Committee supported the development of radar, sonar, the mass production of penicillin, and (most controversially) the Manhattan Project. Without a doubt, this new funding system greatly increased the power of the U.S. military.

The collaboration between scientists and the military was thriving under the National Defense Research Committee, and Roosevelt asked Bush to consider how the organization could be extended into peacetime. In response, Bush penned a report entitled "Science, the Endless Frontier," proposing what would eventually become the National Science Foundation. The report highlighted the boundless potential of basic science. Despite Bush's intimate involvement with military operations, his report emphasized that "the most important ways in which the Government can promote industrial research are to increase the flow of new scientific knowledge through support of basic research and to aid in the development of scientific talent."

Bush's grand vision finally materialized in 1950, when President Harry S. Truman signed a bill creating the National Science Foundation to support fundamental research and education across all fields of science and engineering within universities. There were several reasons Bush felt that universities were the best place for scientific discovery. The success of science depended on an atmosphere that was "relatively free from the adverse pressure of convention, prejudice, or commercial necessity," while providing security and intellectual freedom to its researchers. Bush understood that new knowledge can create opposition, since it often challenges current beliefs. That could be a barrier to true discovery within government and industry.

Although the partnership between academe and the government had been largely successful, Bush recognized the risks of relying on federal funding for research. Anticipating potential conflicts, he established fundamental principles to safeguard the integrity of federally funded science. These principles emphasized stable support for university research while ensuring complete autonomy in methodology, personnel, and the scope of inquiry. Bush was not alone in his apprehensions; others have echoed concerns over the decades. During the 1960s, as the Vietnam War escalated, students across the country protested military funding of universities, highlighting the tension between government influence and academic independence. The Trump administration's assault on the NSF represents precisely the kind of political interference Bush sought to prevent – one that threatens not only scientific progress but also

the very foundation of academic freedom.

Undermining the NSF is not just a threat to universities and researchers – it is a threat to the well-being of every American.

Thanks to Bush's vision, American universities have not only been powerhouses for discovery – they have also been the training ground for new scientific talent. Bush was concerned about the cost of higher education, which might force the country into “neglecting great talent among those who fail to attend college for economic reasons.” His solution was the mosaic of grants and fellowships that the National Science Foundation now supports. He proposed that these grants include undergraduate scholarships, graduate fellowships, and support for advanced training. Since the initiation of the NSF Graduate Research Fellowship in 1952, an estimated 70,000 graduate students have been supported while earning their advanced degrees in various scientific disciplines. According the 2024 NSF Financial Report <<https://www.nsf.gov/pubs/2025/nsf25002/index.jsp>>, 357,600 people were directly supported this past year, including researchers, postdoctoral fellows, trainees, teachers, and students. Outside these figures, NSF programs indirectly impact millions of people, from pre-K to college students, through educational curricula such as museums and outreach programs.

Since its inception, the NSF has played a pivotal role in establishing the United States as a global leader in scientific discovery. But this is not the first time its funding has faced serious threats. In recent years, Congress slashed the 2024 NSF budget by 8 percent as part of a bill to avert a partial government shutdown. The latest proposals from the Trump administration are just another chapter in a recurring pattern of underinvestment in science. This weakening of scientific focus is already taking a toll on the United States' global standing. By several key metrics, we are losing ground to China, which has already surpassed the United States in the number of science and engineering Ph.D.s awarded and the volume of research published in top-tier scientific journals. If we continue to fall behind, the consequences will extend far beyond a diminished global reputation. Scientific research drives innovation, fuels new industries, creates high-tech jobs, and strengthens the economy. It enhances public health, secures our food supply, and advances climate science. Undermining the NSF is not just a threat to universities and researchers – it is a threat to the well-being of every American.

If the Trump administration truly seeks to make America great, it must recognize that sustained investment in the NSF is essential for scientific progress and national prosperity. Ensuring this future, however, requires action – not just from scientists, but from the public as well. Across the country, researchers and advocates are mobilizing against the dismantling of our nation's scientific

infrastructure. Graduate students nationwide have organized Stand Up for Science, an initiative calling on scientists and citizens to rally in Washington, D.C., on March 7 in defense of research and innovation. As budgets continue to shrink, more protests are sure to follow. This is a critical moment for American science and the future it shapes. We cannot afford to be silent.

Read other items in this What Will Trump's Presidency Mean for Higher Ed? <<https://www.chronicle.com/package/donald-trump-and-higher-ed/>> package.

2/14/25: Nature. NASA embraced diversity. Trump's DEI purge is hitting space scientists hard / Some researchers at NASA and outside it feel betrayed by the changes at the agency, which was known for promoting inclusion in science.

In the corridors of NASA buildings across the United States, Pride flags and pictures celebrating women in science are being taken down. Scientists are adding space-mission stickers to their laptops to cover ones that displayed rainbows and other symbols of LGBT+ support. Employees are stripping pronouns from their e-mail signatures and holding darkly humorous conversations in which they try to avoid saying any pronouns at all.

These and other changes are rippling through NASA, which is purging programmes involving diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI) throughout the agency. The directive to do so came from US President Donald Trump, who on 20 January issued an order to eliminate DEI initiatives across the federal government...

Nature spoke with scientists inside and outside NASA about the impacts of its DEI changes -- and heard anger, fear and confusion. Although the orders affect all federal agencies, they are keenly felt at NASA, which has a long history of working towards inclusivity. In 2020, Trump appointee Jim Bridenstine, then head of NASA, ADDED INCLUSION TO THE AGENCY'S LIST OF CORE VALUES, joining safety, integrity, teamwork and excellence. That fifth value has now been removed from many NASA websites.

"How do you go from something being so important that it's a pillar [of the agency], to being so reviled that it's off of everything?" asks Julie Rathbun, a planetary scientist at Cornell University in Ithaca, New York.

...In a statement, NASA said the agency "is committed to engaging the best talent to drive innovation and achieve our mission for the benefit of all. As new guidance comes in, we're working to adhere to new requirements in a timely manner."
A changed agency

NASA's push towards inclusivity is one of the most visible in the US government. In the 1950s and 1960s, all of the agency's astronauts were white men. By 1978, it had bowed to internal and external pressure and had chosen several women and people of colour to fly to space. Today, NASA's astronauts, as well as its world-renowned scientific and engineering teams, are measurably diverse.

But signs of NASA's efforts to make space for everyone are disappearing. These removals have been triggered both by official edicts -- such as the requirement to remove pronouns from employees' email signatures -- and by unofficial notices, such as verbal suggestions to remove flags or other displays from workspaces.

Trump's changes have also halted projects by employee affinity organizations -- groups ranging from military veterans, to Asian Americans and Pacific Islanders, to Black employees. Before 20 January, NASA celebrated these groups' efforts with many glowing, now-deleted web articles.

...Other cancellations include a programme that paired undergraduates from underrepresented groups with active planetary missions, giving the students a chance to observe scientists at work.

Many NASA employees are angry about the changes to DEI, but are buckling down to work nevertheless. "We believe in the mission, and we know that our work is important," says the senior scientist. "We know that it matters for the nation."

As federal workers, NASA employees can't push back against the changes, no matter how much they personally support DEI efforts, says Knicely, who co-chairs a community working group on best practices for DEI at NASA. But space scientists outside NASA are voicing their frustration with the agency's rejection of years of progress towards a more diverse community. Several of them wrote an open letter to NASA leadership on 6 February protesting the changes, which has garnered more than 1,000 signatures.

Many of those scientists have been working with NASA for years on DEI issues. For example, researchers have been studying the DEI practices that improve science, and have been working with NASA to integrate those approaches into its funding programmes. These include a system for ANONYMOUS REVIEW OF PROPOSALS to use facilities such as the Hubble Space Telescope -- a change that reduces gender and other biases -- and REQUIRING INCLUSION PLANS IN AGENCY-FUNDED RESEARCH GRANTS, which raises awareness of barriers to participation.

[Yes, see 7/25/24 article in CHED by Robert George and Anna Krylov and comments in Jerry Coyne's blog. A clear sense that the agency has gone too far and is undertaking an exercise in political

theater rather than introducing pragmatic ways of improving demographic balance.]

Viewed broadly, the cuts "basically say that Indigenous peoples, underrepresented peoples, even women don't really belong there at NASA," says Hilding Neilson, an astronomer at the Memorial University of Newfoundland in St John's, Canada and a Mi'kmaw person. "That's a horrible and shameful thing that is going to set NASA back decades, if not longer."

Some researchers inside and outside the agency are doubling down on their scientific and technical projects while living according to their values as best they can. "You can take down the websites and you can tell people not to put their pronouns in their emails, but that doesn't mean they're not going to use the right pronouns for their colleagues," says Sarah Horst, a planetary scientist at Johns Hopkins University in Baltimore, Maryland. Others are feeling alienated by the agency's actions. For the early-career scientist, the uproar is a huge distraction from their work: "Can I be allowed to focus on my science, please?"

[My friend, early career scientists have much more to worry about under the Trump administration than distractions caused by changes in DEI policies.]

MARCH

3/5/25:

xFrom smd@listsrv2.nasaprs.com Wed Mar 5 11:06:25 2025
Date: Wed, 5 Mar 2025 11:05:13
From: smd@listsrv2.nasaprs.com
To: "'smd@listsrv2.nasaprs.com'" <smd@listsrv2.nasaprs.com>
Subject: [Smd] SMD Research Programs Update

SMD Research Programs Update

Esteemed Colleagues,

As you may be aware, the new Administration has issued Executive Orders (EOs) and implemented policy and guidance that may affect grants, cooperative agreements, and contracts. SMD, consistent with agency direction, is working diligently to comply with the requirements of the new policy and guidance, as well as court orders resulting from litigation related to EOs and guidance. SMD currently oversees approximately 6,000 grants, cooperative agreements, contracts, interagency transfers, and internal NASA transfers; thus,

as you can imagine, the process of implementing the new policy and guidance is taking some time and the turnaround time on actions will be longer than normal. We ask for your patience. Please also realize that we are in a highly dynamic environment with multiple lawsuits being adjudicated each with the potential to impact policy and guidance affecting grants, cooperative agreements, and contracts.

SMD would like to provide the following brief updates:

1. Unfortunately, Research Opportunities in Space and Earth Science (ROSES) 2025 was not released on Valentine's Day as it has been in past years. There are multiple reasons for this related to the increased workload on the SMD R&A Lead as well as everyone who works with Notices of Funding Opportunities. SMD is working diligently on ROSES-2025 and hope to release it soon.
2. The Grants and Cooperative Agreement Manual (GCAM) is being revised to ensure compliance with new Executive Orders, policy, and guidance. We hope to have the revised GCAM released soon.
3. The proposal creation function for the Topical Workshops, Symposiums, and Conferences (TWSC-2024) in Space and Earth Sciences and Technology solicitation, NNH24ZDA002N, is disabled on the NASA Solicitation and Proposal Integrated Review and Evaluation System (NSPIRES). Previously submitted proposals will still be reviewed and selection decisions will be made. This pause in accepting new proposals is needed to update the TWSC solicitation to be compliant with Executive Orders as well as to adapt it to the recent revision of the "Uniform Guidance" (2 CFR 200) that governs all grants and cooperative agreements. The timeframe for when TWSC will be revised/replaced and open for new proposals cannot be predicted at this time. For more about TWSC visit: <https://science.nasa.gov/researchers/funding-for-events/>.
4. Some websites that NASA hosts and supports may have been taken offline so that NASA can ensure the sites meet the policy and guidance of the new Administration. We hope to have the websites, with any appropriate modifications, back online as soon as possible.
5. In late January, NASA senior leadership decided to postpone the upcoming meeting of the NASA Advisory Committee (NAC), which had been scheduled for early February. As the Science Committee reports to the NAC, SMD chose to mirror the direction to the NAC and pause the work of the Science Committee. For consistency and given that the chairs of the six independent division-level advisory committees (DACs) serve on the Science Committee, this pause applies to the DACs as well.

3/7/25: Ars Technica.Taking the Science out of NASA / White House may

seek to slash NASA's science budget by 50 percent "It would be nothing short of an extinction-level event for space science."

Eric Berger

Although the Trump administration will not publicly release its budget request for at least a few more weeks, senior agency officials are starting to be briefed on the president's priorities.

This includes NASA. As expected, the president's plan for the space agency includes some significant shakeups, including a desire to move elements of NASA headquarters to field centers around the country. However, in perhaps the most drastic change, the White House seeks to massively cut funding for science programs at the space agency.

Multiple people familiar with the White House proposal said cuts to NASA's "Science Mission Directorate" could be as high as 50 percent. These sources emphasized that no decisions are final, and there are some scenarios in which the cuts to NASA's science programs would be less. BUT THE INTENT IS TO SLASH SCIENCE.

The associate administrator who runs NASA's Science Mission Directorate, Nicola Fox, appeared in Houston on Thursday for a news conference about a lunar landing. Afterward, Ars asked her about the implications of cutting science funding in half.

"We haven't had any information yet about the budget, and I hate planning something on rumors and speculation," Fox said. "You know, we will continue to do great science. We'll continue to have a balanced science portfolio, for sure. And you know, we'll be grateful for what we get, and we'll do great stuff with it."

An "extinction-level" event

However, as word of these potential cuts spread through the scientific community this week, they have set off alarm bells and generated a response that indicated otherwise.

"If this is implemented, it would be nothing short of an extinction-level event for space science and exploration in the United States," said Casey Dreier, chief of space policy for The Planetary Society. "Losing this much money, this fast, has no precedence in NASA's history. It would force terrible decisions, including turning off scores of active, productive, irreplaceable missions, halting nearly all new mission development, and decimating the country's space science workforce."

In many ways, NASA's science directorate is the crown jewel of the space agency. Nearly all of the most significant achievements over the

last 25 years have been delivered by the science programs: /Ingenuity/ flying on Mars, New Horizons swooping by Pluto, images from the James Webb Space Telescope, the discovery of thousands of exoplanets, the return of samples from asteroids and comets, Cassini's discovery of water plumes on Enceladus, a continuous robotic presence on Mars, and so much more. Even the recent lunar landings by Firefly and Intuitive Machines were funded by NASA's science directorate.

Of NASA's roughly \$25 billion budget, however, only about 30 percent is allocated to science. For fiscal year 2024, this amounted to \$7.4 billion. This spending was broken down into approximately \$2.7 billion for planetary science, \$2.2 billion for Earth science, \$1.5 billion for astrophysics, and \$800 million for heliophysics.

<<https://cdn.arstechnica.net/wp-content/uploads/2025/03/nasa-science-funding-since-1980-1.png>>

NASA science funding since 1980. Credit: Casey Dreier/The Planetary Society
NASA science funding since 1980. Credit: Casey Dreier/The Planetary Society

The proposed cuts are being driven by Russell Vought, the recently confirmed director of the White House Office of Management and Budget, which sets budget and policy priorities for a presidential administration. In some sense, the budgetary decisions should not come as a surprise, as they are consistent with what Vought proposed in a "shadow" budget for fiscal-year 2023 as part of his Center for Renewing America.

"The budget also proposes a 50 percent reduction in NASA Science programs and spending, reducing their misguided Carbon Reduction System spending and Global Climate Change programs," Vought's organization wrote in its report published in December 2022.

Zeroing out Earth science?

Despite Vought's desire, however, NASA is expressly charged with studying our planet.

The congressional act that created NASA in 1958 calls for the space agency to expand human knowledge about Earth's atmosphere and space, and the agency's Earth observation satellites have substantially increased our understanding of this planet's weather, changing climate, and land use.

Even if NASA's Earth science budget were taken to zero, cutting the overall science budget in half would still dramatically reduce funding in planetary science as well as other research areas. Scientists told Ars that NASA would be forced to make difficult decisions, likely including shutting off extended missions such as the Voyager and Curiosity probes on Mars, and possibly even the Hubble Space

Telescope. It might be possible to save missions in later stages of development, such as the Dragonfly probe to Saturn's moon Titan, and the NEO Surveyor mission to search for hazardous asteroids. But it would be impossible to start meaningful new missions to explore the Solar System, potentially setting back planetary exploration a decade.

The cuts also seem at odds with the administration's stated goal of commercializing space, that is, allowing the agency to buy more services where they are available from the private sector. Instead, the heaviest cuts—sources said that NASA may face an approximately 25 percent budget cut, overall—would fall on the agency directorate, Science, least able to buy commercial services.

"There are no commercial or private options for exploratory space science," Dreier said. "No private individuals or companies are currently able or willing to independently pursue boundary-pushing, breakthrough science missions like Europa Clipper, James Webb Space Telescope, or the Parker Solar Probe. This is a unique capability and responsibility of our public space agency. There is no private space science sector of our economy waiting to fill the gap."

Such a budget, scientists fear, would cede the future of exploration in our Solar System to China, which last year revealed a long-term exploration plan to compete with and potentially surpass its competitors, including NASA and the United States.

The president's proposal for NASA's budget is just a starting point for negotiations with Congress, of course. The president establishes budget priorities, but Congress actually sets funding levels and authorizes spending. However, to date, the US Congress has shown little appetite to oppose President Trump's policy priorities. Moreover, a lot of NASA's key science centers are located in Democratic-leaning states such as California, Maryland, and New York, which do not have a lot of power in the current Congress.

Comments...

I know we're not supposed to be hopeful for harm to impact others in this comment section, but damned if I don't wake up each morning, flip open the news feed, hoping upon hope, for a successful assassination or a highly negative medical outcome to have occurred. And I curse how that jackass managed to MISS last summer :(Its a real shame that there aren't people in the USSS who are thinking "wonder if we could 'accidentally' miss something going on" But of course, the probability that the staff of the US Secret Service are anything other than 'full MAGA' is vanishingly small :(So: lets see; with the budget cuts we lose:

ongoing monitoring of the Voyager data stream
probably lose New Horizons monitoring

the upcoming Venus mission
Dragonfly's trip to Saturn and what should have been amazing
science FLYING AROUND A MOON
will there even be enough money left to listen to the hardware
already on Mars?
oh yeah, and good bye to Mars Sample return.

NASA's Earth Science I think often gets overlooked in the public eye, but it's really worth noting what's at practical stake here. In many ways (not to diminish the space / planetary side of their work), the Earth Science is how most people are helped by and interact with NASA's work, even if they don't realize it. To note just a few things they do in the climate space:

- o develop one of only three latest-generation "reanalysis" products, that give a best guess of the weather and state of the atmosphere at every point on and above earth (MERRA2), which apart from being priceless for climate research is used to drive weather (incl fire weather) forecasts and is crucial for training future AI-driven models

- o develop one of the world's top global climate models (GISS Model E)

- o do a lot of crucial applied climate science work on projecting climate impacts, both at home and abroad, with some of the world's leading experts on humid heat, agricultural modeling, sea level rise, etc.. This stuff directly informs US climate adaptation policy (such as through the New York City Panel on Climate Change, which has many NASA GISS staff among its authors).

- o Run one of the country's most prestigious Earth Sciences postdoc fellowship programs, helping train the next generation of scientists.

(In addition to the Greenbelt campus, a lot of this happens in their New York GISS office, hidden above the diner from Seinfeld, and is done at NASA because of the synergy between their Earth observation networks, computing resources, and scientific prowess)

Make America great again by ceding leadership in everything except wealth inequality

My dad worked as a Nasa contractor for decades, we lived on the space coast and got to see many launches from about as close as you could safely and legally be. From what he said, by and large most of the men working out there (and back then at least, it was mostly men) were quite right wing. He said he caught all kinds of shit constantly as he

was quite moderate politically. It would be ironic if this puts a bunch of Trump-voting engineer types out of work. Not to worry, they'd find a way to blame illegals and woke liberals with a little logic-bending.

Remember, this is all in service of eventually getting enormous tax breaks passed to benefit the billionaires. There is a little bit of trump's unbridled hatred for all things government thrown in as seasoning, but it's all about dismantling our system of self-governance and passing all (ALL) of the leftovers up the economic ladder. A wholesale, blatant, brazen, in-your-face looting.

If this disruption is pulled through unmitigated, NASAs lead in space will be lost to China. It has been decades of tenacious work on probes, rovers, technologies, infrastructure that forged countless well oiled teams with experienced seniors and established the right culture. Fire them and ALL that is lost! It will be way more than a decade imho to rebuild competence doing this stuff. Ask Boeing!

3/12/25: NASA SMD. Subject: [Smd] Update to NASA Science Advisory Committees

Update to NASA Science Advisory Committees

On February 19, 2025, the President issued Executive Order 14217, Commencing the Reduction of the Federal Bureaucracy, which sets forth the Administration's policy of reducing the size of the Federal government in order to minimize waste and abuse, reduce inflation and promote American freedom and innovation. This Executive Order directed the termination of several Federal advisory committees across the government and ordered the identification of additional unnecessary Federal advisory committees for termination.

NASA maintains an advisory committee for each of the five science divisions within the Science Mission Directorate: Astrophysics, Biological and Physical Sciences, Earth Science, Heliophysics, and Planetary Science. These committees, which are discretionary and not required by statute, have supported NASA's achievement of its science goals.

In response to Executive Order 14217, NASA's acting administrator, Janet Petro, has directed NASA to merge these five committees into a single advisory committee with broad representation from across the NASA science community. This restructuring will provide the opportunity to retain one non-statutory science committee and ensure continued support of NASA science goals -- improving efficiency, while ensuring NASA maintains the important process of engaging with the

science community.

NASA's Science Mission Directorate is in the process of determining the best structure, scale, and scope for the merged committee. The directorate is committed to ensuring representation from all areas of expertise relevant to the Science Mission Directorate's objectives.

The Science Mission Directorate is committed to continuing to engage with the science community in a variety of ways -- both formal and informal.

3/13/25: NASA Watch: The New NASA Is Emerging

Keith's note: According to sources there is a "plan" under formulation to remove nearly all NASA Headquarters functions and move them to various NASA field centers. There will be little left in Washington, DC. Oversight will now be distributed -- not centralized. Human Spaceflight (SOMD) will reside at NASA JSC (where it already is for the most part). ESDMD (exploration) stuff will be split between JSC, KSC, and MSFC (again, not much change). Science Mission Directorate (SMD) responsibilities will eventually go to GSFC. Armstrong would get Aeronautics programs and Technology development would be sent to LaRC. NASA Ames and Glenn will see some shrinkage and a possible effort to be closed (their real estate is valuable). Meanwhile JPL is a big TBD. Stay tuned. Things keep changing.

Comments...

Neil.Verea

March 13, 2025 at 12:43 pm

The distribution sounds reasonable on paper, question is will the HQs people occupying the various positions in the MDs be willing to leave DC? SMD to GSFC seems the least disruptive as many already live in Maryland (not so good for those living in VA and DC). SOMD, moving to Houston may not be all that appealing from a quality of life perspective (think oppressive summer heat April-October) although many came from Houston, have tasted the Good Life of DC and may not want to trade down. STMD move to LaRC is a natural move to its roots from a previous era, but again giving up the DC lifestyle, taking a paycut to move to Newport News -- really? Aeronautics move to Armstrong is the least reasonable, Aero seems more aligned with LaRC and GRC than Armstrong in sheer numbers, not to mention 50+ year olds and their spouses taking a pay cut, moving from the DMV to Palmdale, Lancaster, Mojave or Tehachapi -- Yikes not that Newport News or Cleveland would be any better. So a lot of slots would be open and filled by local unqualified, but eager warm bodies, so how would that be more efficient?

Implementing any of these moves (exception SMD to GSFC) would be disruptive beyond measure and would be years (certainly beyond this Administrations 4 years) before stability is restored if ever. But on paper it looks like a reasonable plan. Here is an idea, in the tradition of consistency move the administrative offices to Stennis, which already has several Agency administrative functions, including the head administrator, the NASA Administrator.

Ever been to Lancaster? Cleveland (GRC is technically in Brook Park) has 3 major league sports franchises (yes the Browns still qualify as a pro franchise), arguably the best orchestra in the world, a major art museum, one of the largest theater complexes in the nation, within driving distance of a national park, and sits on one of the worlds largest bodies of fresh water. Hardly a desert.

Laughed at the Newport News comment -- that's why many of us live in the Historic Triangle (Yorktown, Jamestown, Williamsburg) -- very pleasant living. If you are OK not having the need for big city life.

I'd disagree with the AFRC vs LaRC statement. LaRC has many things it does. AFRC is all aero with the exception of one small program out of STMD. The entire valley is built on aerospace, and there is significantly more opportunity for actually flying things year round, not to mention the flight ops experience. You can do all Aero at AFRC, while being significantly more limited with flight testing out of LaRC. The real argument imo is that you are 100% correct that no one wants to live in the Antelope Valley, especially if their used to things like water, or the color green<A6>

Hearing reports that the Issacman people want to move the shriveled remains of HQ to S. Arlington.

I'm sure Ames' real estate is valuable, but not sure how valuable a couple hundred acres containing lots of hazardous materials next to the airport in Cleveland is.

Ames has a big underground plume too.

That real estate sits across the airport from the proposed new indoor stadium for the Browns. I would not be surprised if local politicians are being dazzled with all sorts of development if only they let GRC be shutdown. Reminds me of how GRC<F9>s largest rocket engine test facility was shutdown to extend a runway at Hopkins for international flights. The result? GRC missed out on all the commercial rocket engine development of the past two decades and unless you are going to Dublin you are not getting an international flight out of Hopkins. I wonder with the gutting of the EPA whether environmental concerns will still be such an impediment to development.

Google will probably buy up the rest of Ames. Probably other tech companies as well.

They just sold a long-empty lot right next to GRC for about \$65k/acre. The GRC main campus is something like 350 acres, so at the same price, that's \$23M max, if you sold off the whole thing. It'd probably go for less if you factor in the cost of any remediation & demolition of old buildings. To put that in perspective, ONE SEAT on one Crew Dragon flight is something like \$55M <F3> \$88M. Selling off ALL of GRC wouldn't buy half of one astronaut's seat on the world's cheapest ride to space. Glenn's ATF has a lot more empty real estate, though so maybe they're thinking about selling that. 6000+ acres, but the price per acre would be less.

3/16/25: substack.com. Amiko Kelly. The Only Thing Abandoned is the Truth / Preserving NASA's Legacy Amidst a Vortex of Misinformation

As a little girl in rural Texas, I used to slip out of my house before bed, lying on the still-warm driveway in my thrifted hand-me-down silky blue nightgown, staring up at the stars. I chased them—not with rockets or telescopes, but with dreams, curiosity, and the quiet hope that someday I'd break free from my small world and reach for something greater.

I know what it means to dream beyond your circumstances. We were seven kids, poor, and poorer after my parents' divorce. Stability was never a given. At 15, I was alone—my first home wasn't an apartment or shelter but a treehouse. Really, just a wooden platform in an old oak, no roof, just sky, hidden in the woods where we once played. Railings like a top bunk with only the earth below.

But even in those moments when survival was my biggest concern, I never stopped thinking about the stars. I never stopped dreaming of space, of finding my way into a future beyond the life I'd been handed. That dream carried me through, driving me to carve out a path to NASA, to a future that once felt impossible.

That's why it's so painful to see people tearing NASA down now, dismissing it, mocking it, and twisting reality to fit a narrative that serves only those who created the lies. I've seen friends and even family members call NASA "shameful," using clown emojis to describe decisions they've been misinformed about and claiming that NASA employees are only now being "held accountable" for long-standing practices, like providing weekly activity reports. These comments overlook the reality of what NASA represents.

I know what it stands for. I see what it inspires.

Working for NASA wasn't just a dream—it was a calling. I worked hard

to get my foot in the door and even harder once there. Like many who have devoted their lives to space exploration, I've watched with heartbreak as misinformation chips away at the trust and admiration NASA earned.

NASA was once among the most respected government agencies, symbolizing human achievement and possibility. But today, conspiracy theories, climate denial, and political distortions diminish decades of groundbreaking work.

And now, it's not just bad faith attacks—budget cuts wielded like Elon Musk's chainsaw, hacking away at vital offices such as Technology, Policy and Strategy, even the Chief Scientist, which helps monitor the climate*—at a time when science is more crucial than ever. A fact made even more apparent when politicians like Marjorie Taylor Greene absurdly claim Democrats control the weather.

These cuts aren't about efficiency.

NASA operates on a fraction of a penny per tax dollar, yet Musk and his DOGE team, with Trump's backing, are driving this destruction. Trump has granted him near free rein, thanks to the hundreds of millions he poured into buying the presidency. This detriment is the price we pay for letting the wealthy dictate our future.

Ironically, many of Musk's supporters—people far from wealthy—ignorantly support his agenda, serving his interests while he disregards their struggles. In addition to the irony, they disregard that Musk received \$35 billion in government aid to fund Tesla and SpaceX.

Meanwhile, Musk's expanding influence in space exploration and oversight of employees raises serious concerns about conflicts of interest as his private companies profit from the programs he has slashed.

Trump and Musk also chopped NASA's Office of Diversity and Equal Opportunity, undermining fairness in hiring and fostering discrimination. America needs employees from all walks of life and diversity of thought. Diversity makes us stronger.

Despite their supposed championing of free speech, this destructive duo is also policing language and personal pronouns, requiring NASA to scrub mentions of 'environmental justice,' 'Indigenous people,' and 'women in leadership.' Even NASA's tagline—"Through Artemis, NASA aims to land the first woman and first person of color on the Moon"—has been erased. They've also removed profiles from the website that shared inspiring stories of employees connected to diversity, further eroding representation.

The Astronauts Weren't Abandoned. The Truth Was.

Recently, I've been following and correcting misinformation spreading like wildfire about NASA supposedly abandoning astronauts in space. The story went viral—fueled by people eager to believe the worst. Reality check: the astronauts—our friends—weren't stranded. NASA never forgot them. As always, the agency prioritized their safety and well-being.

For example, Astronaut Frank Rubio's mission was originally planned for under six months but was extended to 371 days due to mission requirements, breaking the record for the longest single spaceflight by an American. But this extension followed standard NASA protocol, focused solely on mission needs and crew safety, without fanfare or controversy.

Where were the MAGA salty tears then?

And it's not just this one story—misinformation distorts even the most routine NASA operations. Take the recent launch of the Crew-10 mission on Friday. I've seen people, including the media, falsely call it a "rescue mission" by SpaceX for the astronauts already on the space station when it was a standard crew rotation, just like NASA has done for decades. The astronauts on the station are not stranded. They have a fully functional spacecraft—which has been there since September—to bring them home, just as every crew before them has had.

Yet, just two days before the launch, when NASA decided to scrub the Crew-10 mission due to an issue with the rocket's ground support equipment—prioritizing safety as it always has—people called it "shameful." It's as if ensuring the safety of astronauts is seen as a failure—that delaying a launch for a technical issue is a sign of weakness rather than part of the process that has made spaceflight safer.

This mindset didn't emerge out of nowhere. In a political climate where bravado is mistaken for strength and where Trump has fueled the belief that leadership means never backing down—even when caution is necessary—people are now applying that mentality to spaceflight.

But here's the truth: real strength isn't reckless. It's knowing when to wait, when to reassess, and when to prioritize human lives over optics.

Yet repeatedly, we see the same pattern—a refusal to engage in critical thinking, a rush to mock and tear down rather than take the time to learn. This behavior isn't just misinformation; it's an active effort to sabotage exploration, scientific progress, and trust.

The People Who Once Admired NASA Now Tear It Down

What's even more disappointing is seeing people I once considered friends – people who used to be inspired by space exploration–buy into these lies and spread them without a second thought.

One of these former friends and his wife—a teacher—who once admired my husband's mission, joined in. His wife had even asked if her elementary students could send letters to my husband after his nearly yearlong mission in space. Those kids looked at him with admiration, inspired by the idea of someone living among the stars.

Yet, they have both fallen into this mindset, fueling the narrative and dismissing what he, and so many others, worked hard to achieve.

What happened? When did curiosity and respect turn into cynicism and contempt?

Without NASA, Private Space Wouldn't Exist

People say, "We don't need NASA anymore. SpaceX is the real space program," followed by a rocket and strong-arm emoji. However, SpaceX and other private space companies wouldn't even be part of the conversation without NASA.

NASA laid the foundation, building the technology, infrastructure, and expertise that private companies now rely on. The commercial space industry exists because NASA invested in it, partnering with companies to develop new spacecraft, train astronauts, and provide launch facilities. SpaceX didn't send astronauts to the International Space Station alone—it did so through a NASA contract, using NASA-trained astronauts under its oversight.

This endeavor isn't a competition. NASA and private space companies work together, pushing the boundaries of exploration in ways that neither could do alone. However, to act as if NASA is now obsolete means to erase the decades of work that made private spaceflight possible in the first place.

And let's be honest: Sustainable space exploration—not just the Apollo days of several necessary test flights to and around the moon—needs funding and is now a global endeavor where we share expertise and, yes, financing with our international partners. Trump and Musk's 'American first, go-alone' isolation can undercut our long-term space exploration goals for humanity's benefit.

SpaceX alone is not going to fulfill that complex and costly role—Musk needs NASA more than NASA needs Musk. Is that why he's trying to

decimate it? A deflated NASA will make it vulnerable for exploitation. Next, Trump and Musk will be on the SpaceX launch pad doing another advertisement to prop up Musk's oligarchy.

NASA's Legacy is Everywhere—Even If You Don't See It

To claim NASA has given us “nothing” is to betray the reality of how much this agency has shaped our world. The technology that fuels our daily lives—GPS, medical advancements, earth observation, weather forecasting, and even improvements in water purification—exists because of NASA's innovation. The research conducted for spaceflight has led to better heart monitors, safer aircraft, and life-saving medical treatments. Even the phone in your pocket has components developed thanks to space technology.

I know this personally. While in NASA's Technology Transfer & Commercialization Office, I witnessed firsthand how the agency's work translated into real-world benefits. The cutting-edge research and technological advancements didn't just stay in space—they directly improved lives here on Earth. These innovations weren't abstract ideas; they brought tangible changes to everything from health care to consumer technology.

NASA belongs to all of us. Its discoveries through telescopes and robotic probes**expand our understanding of the universe, drive technological innovation, and inspire the next generation to chase the stars, just like I once did.

With Trump and Musk planning to slash NASA's budget further and implement a second wave of mass layoffs, they and their MAGA brethren used dehumanizing language to describe civil servants, words like “traumatize them,” “they're grifters,” and as Marjorie Taylor Green said, “they don't deserve their paychecks.”

Dictators use this tactic to get the public to accept the atrocities they're about to commit.

But low-information citizens, as Trump once called as he professed his love for “the poorly educated,” are ignorant of what federal employees do.

“That's why he's willing to take a chainsaw to people's jobs, Medicare, social security, and Medicaid,” a union president said in response to a now-deleted X repost by Musk: “Stalin, Mao, and Hitler didn't murder millions of people. Public sector employees did.” With Musk openly defending murderous, genocidal thugs and blaming civil servants of all people, it's safe to say we've resolved the question about Musk's infamous ‘salute.’

And for what? Musk has no proof and is unclear about how much he's truly saving the government from 'waste, fraud, and abuse.' When government employees leave—voluntarily or not—they'll still rely on unemployment or Social Security if they can't find private sector jobs. The so-called 'savings' will fund defense spending and tax cuts for the rich while regular people lose access to essential services. That's not a trade-off any taxpayer should accept. Trump's lying about this, and MAGA either isn't listening or is completely brainwashed—they keep voting against their own best interests.

Before the bill passed on Friday, which would give Trump and Musk even more power to dismantle the government, agencies were already being forced to submit plans to slash their budgets in preparation for a second wave of mass layoffs.

Soon, the NASA we knew—the agency that received bipartisan support, was consistently voted the best place to work in the federal government, and was recognized and revered by the public—will be a gutted memory of a glorious time of achievement which existed to “focus on peaceful applications of space science and technology.”

But suppose we allow misinformation and politically motivated destruction to take root. In that case, we're not just jeopardizing NASA's future—we're eroding the spirit of exploration, innovation, and hope that makes us human.

When we lose faith in NASA, we lose belief in what we can achieve together, in the boundless possibilities that come from daring to dream, reaching for the unknown, or even Mars—not as a corporate cash grab or a personal monument, but as a shared human endeavor.

Unlike Trump and Musk, whose dreams are only as big as their self-importance and the size of their bank accounts, NASA's vision is about us striving together toward something more significant.

Hint: it's not ego.

3/15/25: NYT. Editorial. THE AUTHORITARIAN ENDGAME ON HIGHER EDUCATION

[full article captured in another file]

When a political leader wants to move a democracy toward a more authoritarian form of government, he often sets out to undermine independent sources of information and accountability. The leader tries to delegitimize judges, sideline autonomous government agencies and muzzle the media. President Vladimir Putin of Russia has done so over the past quarter-century. To lesser degrees, Prime Minister

Viktor Orban of Hungary, Prime Minister Narendra Modi of India and President Recep Tayyip Erdogan of Turkey recently have as well.

The weakening of higher education tends to be an important part of this strategy. Academic researchers are supposed to pursue the truth, and budding autocrats recognize that empirical truth can present a threat to their authority. "Wars are won by teachers," Mr. Putin has said. He and Mr. Erdogan have closed universities. Mr. Modi's government has arrested dissident scholars, and Mr. Orban has appointed loyal foundations to run universities.

President Trump has not yet gone as far to impede democracy as these other leaders, but it would be naïve to ignore his early moves to mimic their approach. He has fired government watchdogs, military leaders, prosecutors and national security experts. He has sued media organizations, and his administration has threatened to regulate others. He has suggested that judges are powerless to check his authority, writing on social media, "He who saves his Country does not violate any Law."

Mr. Trump's multifaceted campaign against higher education is core to this effort to weaken institutions that do not parrot his version of reality. Above all, he is enacting or considering major cuts to universities' resources. The Trump administration has announced sharp reductions in the federal payments that cover the overhead costs of scientific research, such as laboratory rent, electricity and hazardous waste disposal. (A federal judge has issued a temporary restraining order against those cuts.) Vice President JD Vance and other Republicans have urged a steep increase of a university endowment tax that Mr. Trump signed during his first term. Together, these two policies could reduce the annual budgets at some research universities by more than 10 percent.

Mr. Trump is squeezing higher education in other ways too. The Education Department let go of about half its work force, potentially making it harder for students to receive financial aid. The virtual elimination of the U.S. Agency for International Development led to the cancellation of \$800 million in grants to Johns Hopkins alone. On March 7, the administration targeted a single university, announcing that it would end \$400 million in grants to Columbia as punishment for its insufficient response to campus antisemitism.

We understand why many Americans don't trust higher education and feel they have little stake in it. Elite universities can come off as privileged playgrounds for young people seeking advantages only for themselves. Less elite schools, including community colleges, often have high dropout rates leaving their students with the onerous combination of debt and no degree. Throughout higher education, faculty members can seem out of touch, with political views that skew far to the left.

Mr. Trump and his advisers are tapping into public dissatisfaction with real problems at universities. But as is the case with their approach to trade, government waste, immigration policy and European military spending, many of their would-be solutions will not solve the underlying problems or will create new ones. The American higher education system, for all its flaws, is the envy of the world, and it now faces a financial squeeze that threatens its many strengths – strengths that benefit all Americans.

Chief among them is its global leadership in medical care and scientific research. American professors still dominate the Nobel Prizes. When wealthy and powerful people in other countries face a medical crisis, they often use their connections to get an appointment at an American academic hospital. For that matter, some of the same Republicans targeting universities with budget cuts seek out its top medical specialists when they or their relatives are ill.

American leadership in medical and scientific research depends on federal money. Private companies, even large ones, typically do not conduct much of the basic research that leads to breakthroughs because it is too uncertain; even successful experiments may not lead to profitable products for decades. Mr. Trump's planned funding cuts are large enough to force universities to do less of this research. The list of potential forgone progress is long, including against cancer, heart disease, viruses, obesity, dementia and drug overdoses. And there will be costs beyond the medical sector. There is a reason that Silicon Valley sprang up next to a research university.

The nonfinancial parts of the administration's campaign against higher education are also alarming. Last weekend, immigration officers arrested Mahmoud Khalil, a leader of pro-Palestinian demonstrations at Columbia who holds a green card and is married to an American citizen. The government has offered no evidence that he broke the law. Even many legal scholars who reject his views on Israel and Hamas consider his arrest to be a dangerous violation of free speech principles, and we share this concern. Mr. Trump described Mr. Khalil's detention as "the first arrest of many to come," a sign that the president wants to chill speech among the many immigrants on university campuses.

What is the most effective response to Mr. Trump's campaign against universities? For people outside higher education, this is a moment to speak publicly about why universities matter. They promote public health, economic growth and national security. They are the largest employers in some regions. They are an unmatched, if imperfect, engine of upward mobility that can alter the trajectory of entire families.

For people in higher education, this is a moment both to be bolder about trumpeting its strengths and to be more reflective about

addressing its weaknesses. About those shortcomings: Too many professors and university administrators acted in recent years as liberal ideologues rather than seekers of empirical truth. Academics have tried to silence debate on legitimate questions, including about Covid lockdowns, gender transition treatments, and diversity, equity and inclusion. A Harvard University survey last year found that only 33 percent of graduating seniors felt comfortable expressing their opinions about controversial topics, with moderate and conservative students being the most worried about ostracization.

"The insularity of American academia is appalling," said Michael Roth, the president of Wesleyan University. "It has led to massive resentment against intellectual elites." This insularity does not justify Mr. Trump's policies, but it does help explain the dearth of conservatives defending universities today. Universities will be in a stronger long-term position if they recommit themselves to open debate.

As for trumpeting the sector's strengths, the leaders of American higher education have been largely timid and quiet in the face of the Trump onslaught. "The people who are attacking higher education are talking nonstop," said Holden Thorp, a chemist and former university administrator who runs the Science family of journals. "And the people leading higher education are not saying very much." (Mr. Roth, a frequent critic of the administration, is an exception.) University presidents seem to be hoping that if they keep their heads down, the threat will pass – or at least pass by their campus. They are unlikely to be so fortunate.

In Mr. Trump's first term, administrators and professors sometimes made the opposite mistake and commented on political issues about which they had little expertise. College presidents do not need to become pundits. But they do need to defend the core mission of their institutions when it is under attack. University leaders would help themselves, and the country, by emerging from their defensive crouches and making a forthright case for inquiry, research, science and knowledge.

Comments 1466...

Authoritarians do not want an educated population. trump is on his way to being one, with the blessings of his party and the courts. Restricting education and thought is one of the first steps.

Intellectuals were a targeted sector in "purges" by Stalin's USSR and Communist China. Anti-intellectualism is a hallmark of authoritarian governments and the Trump Administration following suit. Case in point, US Attorney for D.C. Ed Martin told (private/Jesuit) Georgetown University if it doesn't eliminate D.E.I. initiatives then he won't hire any graduates. Imagine conservative uproar if the US Attorney

for Virginia told (private/Christian) Liberty University it would not hire graduates until it stopped teaching Young Creationism. How ironic that Republicans used to champion state's rights and individual freedoms while condemning federalism but now that they hold the reins of power, they're fine with federal tyranny.

"Restricting education and thought is one of the first steps" in authoritarian rule? Then why are the Democrats so opposed to school choice when so many children are being poorly served by the public education system? Btw, Columbia University annually receives \$2 billion from the US government, being us taxpayers. I think Columbia, and their ability to educate their students, can get by on only \$1.6 billion that they are now going to receive.

@mjbarr DEI is under attack because it has essentially all of the problems of its fraternal twin, Affirmative Action:

- AA/DEI led to reverse discrimination against majority and some minority groups, creating unequal treatment and perpetuating discrimination.
- AA/DEI reinforced negative stereotypes and created resentment among those who did not receive favored treatment.
- AA/DEI created doubts about qualifications of those selected on racial or ethnic criteria rather than merit, leading to stigmatization.
- AA/DEI's lowered admission standards often meant admitting students who were unqualified and unable to meet academic and work performance standards, thus setting them up for failure.
- AA/DEI's focus on broad categories like race/ethnicity ignored diversity within groups, so privileged minority individuals often received preference while the truly disadvantaged were overlooked.
- AA/DEI addressed symptoms of inequality, not root causes; tackling underlying problems like inadequate education, economic disparities and social barriers is crucial.
- AA/DEI undermined meritocracy, with racial/ethnic characteristics outweighing individual achievements and qualifications. A society based on equal opportunities should prioritize merit to ensure fair competition.
- As Chief Justice Roberts said in the Supreme Court decision against AA, "Eliminating racial discrimination means eliminating all of it." This of course means eliminating racial preference in DEI, too.

As a university professor, now in Canada, I agree with many of the

points in this article. The attack on education is shocking and concerning for the future of the country. One reason I believe is not discussed often enough that Americans are turning against the higher education system is the cost. Tuition is skyrocketing and students are entering weak job markets, leaving them saddled with debt well into middle age. If we want to win back public support, we need to start lowering tuition costs. Everyone should have access to education without it burdening them. Of course, none of the Trump policies give universities enough room in their budgets to also lower tuition, so perhaps it's a moot point.

@Holly the reason that American universities, especially state universities, cost so much now is because of Ronald Reagan. When he was governor of California he decided that by making public higher education affordable, states were creating a dangerous "educated proletariat." His education adviser Roger A. Freeman spoke to this at a press conference in 1970:

[cont] "We are in danger of producing an educated proletariat. ... That's dynamite! We have to be selective on who we allow [to go to college]. If not, we will have a large number of highly trained and unemployed people." Reagan began to cut back spending on state higher education in California. Other states over the years also cut back. Now only about 15% of state university budgets come from the state. In the 1960s and most of the 1970s state universities were very affordable. Not any more. Once again, the blame falls on Republicans, who often ironically rail against how expensive higher education is.

Discussions of higher education overlook the fact that the bulk of our higher education institutions are not elite Ivy League research universities, but regional public universities. Those students are often balancing school with commuting to campus, multiple jobs, and family responsibilities. Regional universities enable hard-working students to become teachers, nurses, med techs, social worker, physical therapists, and many other careers that are essential to our society—and that provide a path to the middle class. The Trump attacks will damage these schools that are already underfunded and strained to the limit, and the damage will impact us all—especially the opportunities available to children of working families.

Universities need the humanities and social sciences as much as the STEM fields. Otherwise, how are we to understand society's workings and the organization of power? How else can we ever solve vast social problems? Professors with liberal views come by them honestly, because their own research proves the existence and the source of social inequalities and injustices. It is good for researchers to teach their students methods of inquiry, standards of proof for research findings, and to present their

students with their findings. If those findings lead to conclusions about injustice, then instructors must go where the evidence leads. This is not indoctrination, it's the essence of teaching. Researchers and students with conservative views should be free to express them. But after they express them, they must be prepared to cite evidence to back them up. All too often, when they try to do so, the evidence they cite is rife with bias and shows their own indoctrination.

As one of those supposedly "woke profs" blamed for triggering authoritarian attacks on higher education, let me set the record straight. After twenty years teaching at a public university, I've observed two consistent truths: students genuinely value exposure to diverse viewpoints, and conservatives often struggle academically not because they're silenced, but because their arguments lack substance and evidence. The fields I teach – Africana studies, gender studies, anthropology – weren't included in my first twelve years of education. These disciplines exist because people fought for their inclusion in academia. They are legitimate areas of inquiry that have expanded our understanding of history, economics, and society.

[cont] This fantasy of liberal professors "silencing debate" is a convenient fiction. Ask yourself: what exactly is conservatism today, beyond the MAGA death cult? It seeks to preserve comfortable ways of life and roots these desires in religious doctrine rather than historical evidence or factual analysis. They're making faith-based arguments in academic settings that demand empirical evidence or at least careful argumentation. The Editorial Board and a fair number of commenters seem reluctant to confront an uncomfortable reality: sometimes one political position is simply better supported by evidence than another. That's not ideological bias -- it's good scholarship.

@Andrew there are many generalizations here. It's hard to know where to start. I'll just pick two. One, faculty really do not simply live lives of thought and research. We teach, we support both our universities organizations and our fields. And even when we are doing what you call thought and research, it's not like there are not objective goals we have to reach. It is rewarding work to be sure, but not quite the pastoral fantasy you've set out here. Two, it's been said that it's expensive to be poor, and that's true for universities as well. Some years ago my state did a study of the drivers of expenses at its state universities. One of them was the reduction of state funding, which in turn created a whole apparatus of marketing and philanthropic efforts to make up for the shortfalls. Squeezing universities has not made them cheaper.

@Andrew I teach engineering in one of the universities. Nearly every faculty in an university setting has a moderate income. That is not

what had been cut. Federal funding does not go to salary for faculty. The cut is on financial support for high tech research and that will affect the chances of making new breakthroughs. Reducing research funding will affect American high tech industrial competitiveness and healthcare in the long term. In anticipation of these cuts, universities are already reducing the number of graduate students and postdoctoral researchers that will be hired in laboratories by as much as 30-50% this year. Chocking off the next generation of engineers, researchers, and doctors will very effectively knock off American from the top spot as a high tech powerhouse. Where are we going to find engineers to staff industrial positions building new products of the future? Within a few years, I can guarantee you that our global competitors will surpass us as they redouble their support in higher education. Science, technology, and medicine together form a close-knitted ecosystem. Destroying university level research will have harm far beyond our campuses. As I get close to retirement age, I have never imagine that America will cease to be THE global technology leader in my lifetime, until now. Self-inflicted wound is so sad.

Intellectuals were a targeted sector in "purges" by Stalin's USSR and Communist China. Anti-intellectualism is a hallmark of authoritarian governments and the Trump Adminstration following suit. Case in point, US Attorney for D.C. Ed Martin told (private/Jesuit) Georgetown University if it doesn't elininate D.E.I. initiatives then he won't hire any graduates. Imagine conservative uproar if the US Attorney for Virigina told (private/Christian) Liberty University it would not hire graduates until it stopped teaching Young Creationism. How ironic that Republicans used to champion state's rights and individual freedoms while condemning federalism but now that they hold the reins of power, they're fine with federal tyranny.

As a professor at a large public university in Ohio, I think daily about looking for a job in another sector. Why? Because Trump and DeWine – with the passage of SB 1 – have effectively deputized every student who enters my classroom to decide that some word in my syllabus is somehow diminishing their civil rights. In the age of cell phones and social media, professors are vulnerable, every day, to the whims of one disgruntled student – it is McCarthyism on steroids. I didn't become a professor so I could receive death threats for saying the word gay.

[cont] By encouraging private citizens to monitor faculty curriculum and create a culture of policing, Trump and DeWine are effectively at the bully pulpit, intimidating everyone. And of course, the not-so-cloaked white supremacy of it all is staggering. Trump's "End DEI portal" encouraging parents to provide "details of concerning practices" for teaching concepts or using materials they find objectionable is not intended for Black or female or LGBTQ students to cite what they reject, but rather

is directly targeted at being a McCarthy-esque catch-all for white grievance. Encouraging private citizens to inform on others is a hallmark of all authoritarian regimes. And professors – our safety, our families – are in the direct line of fire. I'd like to think that, like my grandfather who was blacklisted, I am prepared to take the hit. But if I'm being honest, I'm not sure I am.

So the New York Times' editorial solution to ending the attacks on higher education is for those of us in higher education to endorse attacks on diversity, equity, and inclusion, public health measures, and the rights of trans youth to obtain health care? That will make the loudest, most powerful reactionary voices in America right now feel that their opinions are supported enough? No thank you, we'll pass.

What the commenters who are bashing the Ivies and similar universities seem to forget is that for every "elitist left-wing " institution of higher learning they find so objectionable, there is a Grand Canyon, Liberty, High Point, California Baptist, etc. university dedicated to indoctrinating their students in the far-right "conservative" values they hold so dear.

Let's stop over analyzing this. Trump is not normal. This is all about payback. Save the criticisms for another time. It is like saying that the murderer had a point – the victim could be annoying at times. It doesn't matter right now. Oppose Trump policy and actions at every turn.

Of course the Trump administration wants to silence knowledge, accusing universities of pushing agendas as he himself pushes his own agenda. A well informed citizenry--if we had one at this point--would never have elected him, and he knows it. Knowledge, inquiry, research skills, and critical thinking are all serious threats to authoritarian takeovers. This man is throwing the baby out with the bathwater as he seeks to accrue unlimited and permanent power by controlling viewpoints, research and knowledge. Great discoveries with benefits to mankind do not occur in a vacuum, they need to be carefully nurtured and given the freedom to produce great fruits.

I am a tenured professor in the humanities. People need to realize that the recent cuts have decimated humanities programs at top universities. We receive no funding from the NIH, but we have been forced to cut our admissions in half. On top of this, the humanities has been an enormous punching bag for at least a decade by now. We are constantly told we are utterly useless and a complete waste of time. We are caricatured as being a bunch of whining extremists by people who don't read books. Meanwhile, we see politicians and young people utterly ignorant of history, geography, critical thinking, reading and writing. We are not perfect but please stop beating us up and insulting us. When everyone is a bunch of mindless automatons

existing on TikTok and AI with no memory of anything over five months old you will realize we have become utterly soulless as a country. We're almost there already. I do not know if the humanities will survive this era.

Ever since the GOP started allying with the forces of Biblical ignorance in the 1970's and 80's, the challenge for them has been how to eliminate other educational avenues. In Florida this past decade, Ron DeSantis has gamely attempted to seize control in the name of "fairness" of formerly independent venues of higher education. One of his acolytes, Pam Bondi, will show resentful right-wingers everywhere how to attack perceived enemies while claiming to do so in the name of justice.

Thanks ny times. But please also discuss and cover the vast majority of institutions that don't fit the caricature that you raise and affirm with little evidence. For example, start by reporting on the vast majority of faculty who pour their life and soul into the success of their students (and generally not pushing a political agenda), often foregoing more lucrative and less punishing careers outside of academia.

I have been an academic researcher and administrator for more than 50 years. I'm still teaching part time and mentoring undergraduate research at age 81. I've advanced degrees from both public and private institutions and have worked at both. I'm increasingly tired and frustrated at being categorized as "elite." My personal middle class upbringing engendered an aspiration to become educated, which I actualized by spending almost a decade learning beyond high school. I, and my wife who helped support me in the endeavor, voluntarily sacrificed both time and money to pull that off. The result? A solid middle class life style for us both, and a life and occupation for me pursuing truth and ideas, while passing those opportunities forward to the next generations. There are literally thousands of others who have taken similar paths through and to non-exclusive institutions of higher education. To call us "elite" is pejorative. We simply worked to identify and achieve long-term goals, which also demanded commensurate responsibility.

This is a very balanced take. Like many people, I am ambivalent – on the one hand, what Trump is doing is dangerous for all the obvious reasons. Gutting medical research funding is obviously incredibly destructive and attacking universities is in fact something that comes from an authoritarian playbook. On the other hand, there is much that is profoundly wrong with the universities, especially in the humanities where the boundary between research and scholarship has been blurred for a long time. So when I hear Trump giving a list of demands to Columbia University, it is very unsettling. At the same time, when he attacks their Middle Eastern Studies Department, I can't help but admitting that he has a point because much of what is done in

certain corners of the humanities is a little more than political activism disguised by a thin layer of pseudointellectual jargon. So, on the one hand you have politicians who want to remake higher education in their own image; on the other hand, you have at least parts of the universities that are themselves little more than gathering places of activists with PhDs. A very difficult situation to overcome.

I find it interesting that those Republicans tossing the most stones at higher education all went to elite universities. It's time they walk-the-walk. If higher education is so horrible, then let's hire ...high school dropouts to be judges and generals. Let's close the military academies. Let's have the current leaders denounce their education and schools. Go for it!

I find it hard to forgive my colleagues in academia who pushed DEI too far, with the anonymous micro-aggression reporting hotlines, unconscious bias workshops, trigger warnings and safe spaces etc. Many of us warned that this would blow back in our faces politically, and now it has happened. But as with everything, it's just an excuse for Trump, a pretext to destroy American civilization and turn us into a monarchical oligarchy, like Russia.

** I work in academia and find the characterization of the faculty especially to be so off-base. My guess is that few (but certainly not zero) vote for Trump. But any fair assessment would judge that most are in fact extremely centrist and eager to appear that way. Many are dispositionally and culturally deeply conservative. They are not, by and large, people with notably left-leaning politics. Far from it.

That

is a caricature and a stereotype nurtured over years, not least in these pages, where unfortunate and silly episodes involving loudmouths became symbols of supposed dysfunction. Reporting and commentary on campuses would be horribly dull if they actually covered the day-to-day operations, which hew toward a stifling status quo and institutionalism, and most certainly not a radical activism.

I agree that ideological conformity is a serious problem in both the social sciences and humanities. I have also read about scholars and even scientists being attacked and, yes, some have been forced out. As an actual liberal, I think intellectual discourse is impoverished if it does not involve civil discussion and debate with those of differing or opposing views, provided that this discourse is grounded in substantiated facts, vetted by rules of evidence. However, good faith is utterly absent in the attacks of Trump on universities, just like it was in the attack of his hero, Putin. Instead, in terms of national security and prosperity, Trump's attack on scientific research is the second most stupid thing he has done, next to his alienation of our allies, which has weakened the U.S. against the "no limits" alliance of Russia and the PRC.

--- ENDD NYT "AUTHORITARIAN ENDGAME" ---

3/17/25: FYI

SENATE INTRODUCES NASA AUTHORIZATION BILL

A bipartisan <E0>100-page bill [aip.us17.list-manage.com] to reauthorize NASA was introduced in the Senate on March 11. The bill is co-sponsored by Senate Commerce, Science, and Transportation Committee Chair Ted Cruz (R-TX) and Ranking Member Maria Cantwell (D-WA) in addition to two Republican and three Democrat members of the committee. In a <E0>statement, [aip.us17.list-manage.com] Cruz said the bill <FC>allows commercial space ventures to flourish, builds up a U.S.-led low-Earth orbit economy, and takes the first step towards returning America to the Moon and ensuring we will be first on Mars.<FD>

The senators recommended funding NASA at \$25.5 billion in FY25, a slight increase over the agency<F9>s FY24 budget of \$24.9 billion, but the passage of the continuing resolution on Friday will keep NASA funding at FY24 levels this year. A <E0>similar authorization bill [aip.us17.list-manage.com] was introduced in December but did not progress before the end of the last Congress.

The bill explicitly reaffirms congressional support for the Space Launch System, which has faced criticism [aip.us17.list-manage.com] for cost overruns and delays. The bill similarly expresses support for the Mars Sample Return mission but includes thinly veiled criticism of that mission<F9>s cost and timing, instructing the administrator to establish a <FC>realistic<FD> cost estimate within 90 days and sign a fixed-price contract for the mission with industry partners within a year of the bill<F9>s passage. It also calls for the U.S. to continue supporting the International Space Station until a commercial alternative is operational. The ISS is currently set to be deorbited [aip.us17.list-manage.com] after its operations end in 2030.

v3/18/25:

From: "Kurczynski, Peter (GSFC-6600)" <peter.kurczynski@nasa.gov>
Subject: NASA Advisory Committees and the COPAG
Date: March 18, 2025 at 17:29:10 EDT
To: "copag-ec@bigbang.gsfc.nasa.gov" <copag-ec@bigbang.gsfc.nasa.gov>

External Email - Use Caution

Dear COPAG Executive Committee,

On Wednesday, March 12, the NASA Science Mission Directorate announced that the advisory committees for each of the five science divisions within the Science Mission Directorate (Astrophysics, Biological and Physical Sciences, Earth Science, Heliophysics, and Planetary Science) will be merged into a single advisory committee with broad representation from across the NASA science community.<A0> The Astrophysics Division has three Program Analysis Groups (PAGs): Cosmic Origins, Exoplanets, and Physics of the Cosmos. These PAGs were reporting out through the Astrophysics Advisory Committee (APAC).<A0> The Astrophysics Division intends to continue the activities of those three PAGs, and their affiliated Science Analysis Groups (SAGs), Science Interest Groups (SIGs), and Science and Technology Interest Groups (STIGs).<A0> The Division is working on developing a new reporting structure for the PAGs so that they can continue to provide findings of analyses to the NASA Astrophysics Division Director.<A0>This will be finalized in the coming weeks and an update will be issued.<A0> In the meantime, the Astrophysics Division would like to thank all those who serve, or have served, on the PAGs or their affiliated groups, providing key input into the division<F9>s activities.

Warm regards,
Peter

3/19/25: NASA Watch: Internal NASA Memo: NSSC Active Contracts Review

Keith<F9>s note: this went out to a vast portion of the NASA workforce today. I guess we know what people will be working on over the weekend spreadsheets, not brackets. From what I am told by NASA sources anyone can see virtually anything they want <F3> even if it is not their own stuff. No, I do not have <F3> or ever want <F3> access to this sort of proprietary/confidential stuff. Full memo below (spreadsheet and link do not work).

PLEASE READ THIS EMAIL IN ITS ENTIRETY

In accordance with Executive Order 14222 a complete review of NSSC contracts and grants are required. You have been identified as a technical monitor or contracting officer Representative (COR) with grants requiring a review. Please access the Power App Link OP-DataCallResponseTool-PowerApps and select E014222 Review <F3> NSSC to complete the following data field:

Center

Mission Directorate

Description of contract/grant requirement

Planned contract/grant action

Impact if contract/grant is terminated <F3> Be very specific on the impact to programs, projects, and mission. Don<F9>t just provide generic information.

Rationale for not terminating or descoping contract/grant <F3> Justify the impact on the agency if this is terminated.

POC providing justification and impact

COR (first name and last name) if blank

This review of contracts and grants must be completed by NLT COB 3/26

If you are receiving this email you have been identified as a person who can provide the required information. Most of you will have more than one purchase order to enter. The attached spreadsheet has already been sorted by the EMAIL ADDRESS 1 COLUMN but can be sorted how you see fit. It is not linked to a sharepoint. Please take this request very seriously and respond before the deadline. Provide as much essential detail regarding the impact to the agency if the requirement(s) are terminated.

Comment from Dave:

Oh no. I haven't checked my email since 2pm yesterday, but believe I might receive this. However, most my contracts, if not executed, could result in entire center shutdowns.

3/21/25: NASA Watch

Keith's note: WRT Janet Petro's update today -- she included a comment about her standard update closing "Embrace the Challenge". IMHO when the entire NASA workforce is uncertain about whether they will even have a job, if their projects will be cancelled, or NASA's future as the world's leader in space exploration, "Embrace the Challenge" tends to fall a little short and sound a dull thud as to what NASA's extended family really needs to hear right now. I went through the RIF-like effort at Space Station Freedom Level II. I know exactly what people are going through. So Janet, maybe you should use that new 5 Question App to ask people how they are doing as this chaos grinds them down -- and what you can do to help them through. Just asking them may be enough -- better than a hollow slogan. Just sayin'.

3/22/25: NASA Watch. NASA's Ever-Changing Artemis Crew Tagline

Keith's note: there has been a swarm of stories of late about NASA abandoning the whole "first woman and first person of color" tag line that the Biden Administration used with regard to Artemis lunar missions -- which evolved further to "NASA will land the first woman, first person of color, and first international partner astronaut on the Moon". That tagline evolved out of the Trump 1.0 Administration's original "first woman" preface as to who'd be landing on the Moon. Now that's all gone as part of the DEI purge and shunning of international partners that has been inflicted upon all of the Federal Government by Trump 2.0.

I saw this coming. A lot of us did. On 23 January 2025 I posted "NASA's First Woman, First Person Of Color" Artemis Tagline: "Let's see how the Diversity purge affects this popular opening line for NASA Artemis postings." BTW while the graphic NASA used to symbolize the Biden Administration's stance on Artemis crews has been taken down, like everything else, it can be found on the Internet Archive here.

3/26/25:

xFrom uvstig@lists.nasa.gov Wed Mar 26 14:08:47 2025
Date: Wed, 26 Mar 2025 14:07:12
From: Stephan McCandliss via UV STIG <uvstig@lists.nasa.gov>
Reply-To: Stephan McCandliss <stephan.mccandliss@jhu.edu>
To: "pha-cas@lists.johnshopkins.edu" <pha-cas@lists.johnshopkins.edu>
Cc: "copag-ec@bigbang.gsfc.nasa.gov" <copag-ec@bigbang.gsfc.nasa.gov>, "uvstig@lists.nasa.gov" <uvstig@lists.nasa.gov>

Subject: [UV STIG] Fwd: USRA Legislative Update from Washington

A particularly interesting FYI...

Begin forwarded message:

From: "Hammond, Eric S." <ehammond@usra.edu>
Subject: USRA Legislative Update from Washington
Date: March 26, 2025 at 13:27:11 EDT
To: stephan.mccandliss <stephan.mccandliss@jhu.edu>

A close up of a sign Description automatically generated

Dear Professor McCandliss:

USRA provides periodic updates to the Council of Institutions (COI) on legislative activities of interest to the university community engaged

in
space and aeronautics-related research and education. The information
contained herein is non-proprietary and may be shared with
colleagues.<U+200B>

The point of contact for these legislative updates is Eric Hammond,
Director of Corporate and Government
Affairs (email: ehammond@usra.edu).<U+200B>

In this update, the following topics are discussed:<U+200B>

1. Continuing Resolution Enacted; NASA Funding Remains at FY24 Levels
An overview of the recently passed continuing resolution that
maintains NASA's funding at Fiscal Year 2024 levels through
September 30, 2025, and its implications for the agency's
operations and initiatives.
2. NASA's Budget Outlook Under the Current Administration and
Congressional Leadership An analysis of the current
administration's fiscal policies and Congressional leadership's
NASA priorities.
3. Senate's NASA Authorization Bill A review of the bipartisan NASA
Transition Authorization Act of 2025, which outlines funding
authorizations and strategic directives for the agency.
4. Upcoming and Recent Congressional Hearings Pertinent to NASA A
summary of recent and forthcoming congressional hearings related
to NASA, highlighting discussions that are particularly relevant
to universities and research institutions.
5. Recent Legislation Pertinent to NASA An update on newly introduced
bills and legislative actions affecting NASA.
6. Organizational Reviews and DOGE Implications at NASA

A summary of DOGE's ongoing activities and their potential
implications
for NASA's workforce, mission planning, and research collaborations.

1. Continuing Resolution Enacted; NASA Funding Remains at FY24 Levels

Congress passed, and the President has signed into law, a continuing
resolution (CR) that maintains government funding at FY 2024 levels
through September 30, 2025. As a result, NASA will see no immediate
funding increases, and any previously planned new initiatives for
fiscal year 2025 remain on hold. Under the CR framework, federal

agencies are prohibited from initiating new programs or significantly increasing existing funding allocations, obligating NASA to operate within the constraints of the prior year's budget.

Consequently, NASA will continue to delay or slow projects initially slated for additional funding or launch in FY 2025. Historically, during CR periods, agency officials manage budgets conservatively due to financial uncertainty and constraints on strategic planning. Extended flat funding scenarios often compel NASA to defer essential maintenance, infrastructure upgrades, and mission development, leading to increased long-term costs and disruptions to mission timelines.

Legislators across party lines have previously highlighted that relying repeatedly on continuing resolutions compromises the ability of agencies to undertake strategic, long-term planning. While this CR has effectively prevented a government shutdown, it continues to place NASA in an operational holding pattern, raising ongoing concerns about the agency's future budgetary health, mission stability, and overall capability to support research and exploration initiatives, including those led by university partners.

In response, USRA, working closely with the Issues and Program Committee (IPC) and its Council of Institutions, continues to advocate for:

- Robust top-line funding for NASA and sustained research support across federal science agencies
- Recognition that science and exploration are inextricably linked in advancing U.S. leadership in space
- Strong backing for USRA's member universities, which span 39 states and the District of Columbia

2. NASA's Budget Outlook Under the Current Administration and Congressional Leadership

With the new administration and Republican majorities in Congress, NASA's budget and strategic direction may see notable changes. The potential appointment of Jared Isaacman—an entrepreneur known for privately funded space missions and support for commercial space initiatives—as NASA Administrator signals possible increased emphasis on private-sector partnerships and cost-effective exploration strategies, involving companies such as SpaceX, Rocket Lab, and Firefly Aerospace.

Under Isaacman's anticipated leadership, the administration may review

NASA's current portfolio of exploration programs, including the Artemis program. Particular attention could be given to large, cost-plus contracts, such as the Space Launch System (SLS) rocket developed by traditional aerospace firms like Boeing. These programs could be reevaluated in favor of commercially developed alternatives, such as SpaceX's Starship, potentially aimed at reducing costs and accelerating human exploration of the Moon and Mars.

Alongside this emphasis on commercial innovation, early budget discussions suggest the administration may propose substantial reductions in NASA's science budget, particularly targeting certain Earth science research areas. Historically, similar proposed reductions have faced significant scrutiny and bipartisan debate in Congress.

It remains important to note that, regardless of administration proposals, NASA budgets require congressional approval. Congress has previously restored funding to many NASA science and education programs that administrations have sought to reduce, notably including the Office of STEM Engagement. USRA will continue monitoring these developments, advocating for sustained support of university-led research and education initiatives.

3. Senate's NASA Authorization Bill

The Senate recently introduced the NASA Transition Authorization Act of 2025, a bipartisan bill that seeks to define the agency's strategic direction and authorize funding levels. It reaffirms support for the Artemis program, promotes public-private partnerships, and strengthens STEM education initiatives. While it reflects some administration-aligned policy shifts, such as potential reductions in Earth science missions, the bill overall suggests Congress's continued commitment to sustaining NASA as a multi-mission agency.

Read the bill here: [The NASA Transition Authorization Act of 2025](#)

The authorization bill contains several provisions with direct relevance to universities:

A. Funding for Science and STEM Programs

- * Authorizes \$7.58 billion for the Science Mission Directorate and \$143.5 million for the Office of STEM Engagement [Sec. 101, pp. 5–6].
- * Reaffirms the value of a balanced portfolio (large, medium, and small missions) as recommended by decadal surveys [Sec. 601, p. 47].

B. STEM Education and Academic Partnerships

- * Title VII explicitly supports the National Space Grant College and Fellowship Program and efforts to build a skilled technical workforce [Sec. 701–702].
- * The bill emphasizes NASA’s collaboration with universities across multiple domains: aeronautics, hypersonics, advanced air mobility, and hydrogen aviation [Sec. 502–508, pp. 39–47].

C. Opportunities Through Public–Private and Research Initiatives

- * Encourages academic involvement in advanced materials research, unmanned aircraft systems, and technology development through SBIR [Sec. 402–403, Sec. 503–504].
- * Supports university access to suborbital crew missions and low–Earth orbit science platforms [Sec. 305, p. 32].

D. Commercial Low–Earth Orbit Development Program (CLDP)

- * Directs NASA to maintain a continuous human presence in Low Earth Orbit (LEO) and plan a transition from the International Space Station (ISS) to commercial space stations, enabling universities to partner with industry in conducting research in LEO [Sec. 301–304, pp. 17–27].

E. Cost Cap Oversight for PI–Led Science Missions

- * Calls for increased accountability in science mission cost estimates and adherence to cost caps, which could influence future university–led mission proposals [Sec. 602, pp. 48–51].

F. Workforce and Talent Development Initiatives

- * Establishes a NASA public–private talent program and expands mentoring activities to strengthen the early–career pipeline and STEM engagement [Sec. 808–809].

G. Earth Observation and Data Access

- * Directs NASA to evaluate private sector data procurement (e.g., for Landsat) and assess implications for scientific continuity and academic access [Sec. 604–605, pp. 52–54].

Outlook for Universities

The fact that this bill is bipartisan and resembles House efforts from last year demonstrates a strong consensus: NASA should remain a

multi-mission agency, advancing exploration, supporting Earth science, and driving innovation through partnerships. For universities, the legislation offers a reassuring blueprint. Despite expected pressure from the administration, Congress appears determined to maintain a broad suite of programs, many of which directly benefit academic researchers, students, and university-led missions.

One initiative not currently included in the bill—but still a priority for the USRA Issues and Program Committee (IPC)—is the long-standing proposal for a university-led small satellite program. The initiative aims to provide more structured, mission-driven opportunities for students and researchers to contribute to NASA science through CubeSat and small satellite development. While it continues to represent a compelling opportunity to expand hands-on training pipelines and enable broader access to space-based research, it has yet to gain traction in legislation. Given the current funding environment, there is even less appetite for establishing new programs that would require dedicated authorizations or appropriations. Still, USRA and the IPC remain committed to advancing the concept.

Turning authorization into funded programs will be the next step, and USRA will continue to engage with appropriators and authorizers to ensure that university priorities remain at the forefront.

4. Upcoming and Recent Congressional Hearings Pertinent to NASA

This section provides an overview of recent and upcoming congressional hearings related to NASA, with a focus on matters of interest to universities and institutions. The hearings involve the House Committee on Science, Space, and Technology; the Senate Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation; and the House and Senate Appropriations Committees.<U+200B>

Upcoming Hearings

* April 1, 2025, 10:00 AM EDT

Space & Aeronautics Subcommittee Hearing – Leveraging Commercial Innovation for Lunar Exploration: A Review of NASA’s CLPS Initiative This hearing will review NASA's Commercial Lunar Payload Services (CLPS) initiative, focusing on how commercial innovations are being leveraged for lunar exploration and potential opportunities for university partnerships. You may view the hearing [here](#).

Recent Hearings

- * March 26, 2025, 10:00 AM EDT
Environment Subcommittee Hearing – To the Depths, and Beyond:
Examining Blue Economy Technologies

This hearing explored advancements in oceanic technologies and their implications for environmental research and the economy. While not exclusively focused on NASA, the discussion included topics relevant to Earth observation and climate studies. You may view the hearing [here](#).

- * February 26, 2025, 10:00 AM EST Space and Aeronautics Subcommittee
Hearing – Step by Step: The Artemis Program and NASA's Path to
Human Exploration of the Moon, Mars, and Beyond

The hearing examined the progress and plans of NASA's Artemis program, with a focus on human exploration initiatives and potential opportunities for university partnerships. You may view the hearing [here](#).

- * February 25, 2025, 10:00 AM EST Nominations Hearing for Michael
Kratsios to Lead the Office of Science and Technology Policy and
Mark Meador to Serve as a Federal Trade Commissioner

This hearing evaluated the nominations of Michael Kratsios for Director of the Office of Science and Technology Policy and Mark Meador for Federal Trade Commissioner, positions influencing science and technology policy relevant to NASA and academic institutions. You may view the hearing [here](#).

- * February 12, 2025, 10:00 AM EST
Energy Subcommittee Hearing – From Transformative Science to
Technological Breakthroughs: DOE's National Laboratories

While centered on the Department of Energy's national laboratories, discussions included collaborative efforts with NASA, highlighting interdisciplinary research opportunities for universities. You may view the hearing [here](#).

5. Recent Legislation Pertinent to NASA:

1. H.R.1368 – DOE and NASA Interagency Research Coordination Act
Sponsor: Rep. Nicholas Begich [R-AK-At Large]
Committees: House – Science, Space, and Technology
Date of Introduction: February 14, 2025
Latest Action: Referred to the House Committee on Science, Space, and Technology on February 14, 2025.
Summary: Establishes interagency coordination between the Department of Energy (DOE) and NASA for research activities.

2. H.R.390 – ACERO Act

Sponsor: Rep. Vince Fong [R-CA-20]

Committees: House – Science, Space, and Technology

Date of Introduction: January 14, 2025

Latest Action: Referred to the House Committee on Science, Space, and Technology on January 14, 2025.

Summary: Promotes advanced computing and engineering research opportunities.

3. H.R.477 – MACH Act

Sponsor: Rep. Vince Fong [R-CA-20]

Committees: House – Science, Space, and Technology

Date of Introduction: January 16, 2025

Latest Action: Referred to the House Committee on Science, Space, and Technology on January 16, 2025.

Summary: Supports hypersonic research and development initiatives.

4. H.R.1626 – Edward J. Dwight, Jr., Congressional Gold Medal Act of 2025

Sponsor: Rep. Joe Neguse [D-CO-2]

Committees: House – Financial Services

Date of Introduction: February 26, 2025

Latest Action: Referred to the House Committee on Financial Services on February 26, 2025.

Summary: Awards the Congressional Gold Medal to Edward J. Dwight, Jr. for his achievements.

5. H.R.108 – Space Research Innovation Act

Sponsor: Rep. Andy Biggs [R-AZ-5]

Committees: House – Science, Space, and Technology

Date of Introduction: January 3, 2025

Latest Action: Referred to the House Committee on Science, Space, and Technology on January 3, 2025.

Summary: Encourages innovation in space research through expanded grant opportunities.

6. Bill to Institute RIF Moratorium at the National Aeronautics and Space

Administration

Sponsor: TBD

Committees: House – Science, Space, and Technology

Date of Introduction: TBD

Latest Action:

Summary: Prohibits any reduction in force (RIF) at NASA until Congress enacts FY26 appropriations

7. The NASA Transition Authorization Act of 2025

Sponsor: Sen. Ted Cruz [R-TX], Sen. Maria Cantwell [D-WA]

Committees: Senate Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation

Date of Introduction: TBD

Latest Action: NA

Summary: Reauthorizes NASA's programs and activities through fiscal year

2025, establishing and revising initiatives related to space exploration, research, and technology.

6. Organizational Reviews and DOGE Implications at NASA

The Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE) is currently undertaking assessments across federal agencies to identify possible opportunities for increased efficiency and organizational alignment. In response, NASA has begun preliminary internal planning exercises to align with this process, including reviews of mission support functions and organizational structures.

NASA's Acting Administrator has communicated regularly with agency staff about these assessments, emphasizing that discussions remain exploratory, and no formal decisions or directives have been issued at this stage. The ongoing budget constraints associated with the current continuing resolution add complexity to NASA's long-term strategic planning processes.

USRA continues to closely monitor these assessments, recognizing their potential implications for NASA's workforce stability, university partnerships, and multi-year research initiatives. Throughout this

process, USRA remains committed to highlighting and protecting the importance of university-led science, research, and innovation.

3/25/25: Spacenews. NASA terminating \$420 million in contracts

NASA is terminating \$420 million in contracts the agency says are redundant or <FC>misaligned<FD> with its core priorities, but has provided few details about what is being cut.

In a statement to SpaceNews late March 24, NASA press secretary Bethany Stevens confirmed a post by the Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE) that NASA had terminated about \$420 million in unneeded<FD> contracts.

<FC>NASA is committed to optimizing its workforce and resources in alignment with the Department of Government Efficiency<F9>s initiatives. As part of this effort, NASA has identified and phased out \$420 million in contracts that were determined to be redundant or misaligned with our core mission priorities,<FD> Stevens said in the statement.

<FC>This streamlining effort ensures that taxpayer dollars are directed toward the highest-impact projects while maintaining NASA<F9>s essential functions at the highest level of execution,<FD> she continued. <FC>In total, we are aiming for these measures to result in considerably more savings for the American people, reinforcing our commitment to efficiency, innovation, and continued leadership in space exploration.<FD>

NASA did not answer questions about specific contracts selected for termination or details about how it determined those contracts were redundant or misaligned. The DOGE post, published just before midnight March 21, said only that it included three contracts worth \$15 million each to consultancies for <FC>Change Management Support Services.<FD>

APRIL

4/1/25: FYI. NSF CONSTRUCTION BUDGET DEFUNDED AS TRUMP CHALLENGES 'EMERGENCY' SPENDING / The president eliminated the agency's budget for major construction by disputing "emergency" appropriations made by Congress.

The National Science Foundation's budget for major construction projects is set to be eliminated for fiscal year 2025 after President Donald Trump canceled some of the "emergency" funds appropriated by

Congress last month. Top Senate appropriators argue the action is illegal and puts at risk all \$12.4 billion of the emergency funding allocated across agencies including NASA.

If Trump's decision stands, it is unclear if NSF would be able to transfer money from other accounts to cover the \$234 million shortfall in its Major Research Equipment and Facilities Construction (MREFC) account. This hole in the agency's budget represents a 2.6% cut to its fiscal year 2024 topline of \$9 billion. Congress funded the MREFC account using emergency funding that was agreed to in a 2023 bipartisan side deal that allowed legislators to exceed spending caps set in law. Appropriators used the same funding method for MREFC in the final spending legislation for fiscal year 2025, enacted last month, which largely carries forward spending levels from the prior year.

Trump wrote to Congress last week declaring that the MREFC funding and 10 other accounts were "improperly designated by Congress as emergency" in the 2023 side deal. "I do not concur that the added spending is truly for emergency needs," he added.

Appropriators on both sides of the aisle objected to Trump's move as an encroachment on their spending power. Sens. Susan Collins (R-ME) and Patty Murray (D-WA), who lead the Senate Appropriations Committee, sent a letter to the Office of Management and Budget stating that the language of the appropriations legislation "has always been interpreted to give the president a binary choice: He must concur with all or none of Congress's emergency designations."

Murray highlighted in a press release how the decision jeopardizes the MREFC funding as well as \$100 million for procurement and construction projects at the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration. Both Collins and Murray said the availability of all the emergency funding could now be at risk, including the \$9 billion that Trump approved, which includes \$250 million of NASA's construction and environ

Current MREFC Projects

The MREFC account funds major projects that cost over \$100 million to construct as well as "mid-scale" research infrastructure that costs between \$20 million and \$100 million to construct. The \$234 million appropriated by Congress for the account in fiscal year 2025 already falls short of NSF's requested amount of \$300 million.

The agency requested \$60 million for Antarctic infrastructure upgrades, such as building a new pier at the McMurdo research station to replace the ice pier where resupply vessels offload, which has failed three times in the last 12 years. "If the infrastructure that enables Antarctic science is not kept robust and efficient, [the U.S. Antarctic Program] is at risk of losing science capabilities year

over year as facilities, utilities, equipment, and the vehicle fleet degrade,” the agency wrote in its budget request.

NSF also requested \$154 million for the Leadership-Class Computing Facility in Texas, which will host an academic research supercomputer that will provide a hundredfold improvement for AI applications compared to NSF’s current leading computing system, according to the agency. NSF previously said that it expected the facility to begin operations in 2026.

NSF further requested \$85 million to fund mid-scale infrastructure projects across all research disciplines funded by the agency. Projects recently funded in this category include a new weather radar system, Cosmic Microwave Background astronomy instrumentation, and a compact X-ray free electron laser facility. Many other major projects have been waiting in the wings for MREFC funding. These include the Giant Magellan Telescope and the Thirty Meter Telescope, either of which would require a significant and sustained MREFC budget increase in order to move forward with NSF support – a possibility that now appears even more distant.

NSF declined to comment on how Trump’s decision might affect its infrastructure projects.

4/10/25:

FYI: Science Policy News from AIP

BULLETIN

April 10, 2025

NASA Administrator Nominee Wants More Flagship Science Missions

Clare Zhang

Jared Isaacman expressed confidence that NASA could stand up additional missions in basic science and space exploration despite committee Democrats’ budget concerns.

Jared Isaacman

Jared Isaacman, President Trump’s nominee for NASA administrator, at his Senate confirmation hearing on April 9. Senate Commerce, Science, and Transportation Committee

Jared Isaacman, President Donald Trump’s pick to lead NASA, told senators it would be feasible to have “multiple flagship scientific missions at once” on top of space exploration efforts and expressed enthusiasm for basic science at the agency. Isaacman said Trump is “looking to usher in a golden age of science and discovery,” while committee Democrats pointed to recent layoffs, contract terminations, and proposed budget cuts at the agency.

At his nomination hearing Wednesday before the Senate Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation, Isaacman introduced himself as “not a typical nominee” for the NASA administrator position.

“I’ve been relatively apolitical. I am not a scientist. I never worked at NASA,” he said. “I do not think these are weaknesses. In fact, I believe President Trump found them to be strengths.”

Isaacman is a billionaire tech CEO who has commanded two private orbital missions led by SpaceX. His nomination has been praised by various space industry stakeholders while drawing criticism from some conservative groups and activists due to his past donations to Democratic campaigns and the diversity initiatives of companies he has been involved with.

In his opening remarks, Isaacman said one of his primary objectives would be to make NASA “a force multiplier for science.” He told senators NASA should concentrate its resources on science with no obvious economic return and “undertake the near impossible” so that industry and academic institutions can build upon the agency’s discoveries.

He also pointed to NASA’s challenges, saying that most of its programs are over budget and behind schedule. Isaacman has criticized aspects of NASA’s human space exploration programs in recent years, calling the Space Launch System rocket “outrageously expensive” while petitioning the agency to fully fund the Chandra X-ray telescope. NASA had planned to decommission Chandra last year due to budget shortfalls in fiscal year 2025 but delayed that decision following pushback from scientists and Congress.

At the same time, Isaacman told Committee Chair Ted Cruz (R-TX) that NASA could “absolutely” stand up full missions to the Moon and to Mars, as well as run more scientific missions.

Sen. Gary Peters (D-MI) asked Isaacman if this would still be possible with budget cuts to NASA, adding that he believes “it’s pretty clear we’re likely to see constrained budgets.”

“If I’m confirmed, I absolutely am going to roll up my sleeves and get in the trenches with the best and brightest and figure out where we have our program challenges, what’s impeding progress, clear those obstacles and get back to delivering on the mission,” Isaacman answered. “If we can do that, then we’re going to get the inspirational side of NASA going, we’re going to get the STEM side growing, and the next generation is going to grow up and want to reach even farther.”

TIES TO MUSK

Cruz asked Isaacman whether he would commit to maintaining the International Space Station at least through 2030 if it is safe and scientifically feasible to do so. The CHIPS and Science Act authorizes funds for the ISS to 2030 and NASA currently plans to deorbit the station after that.

"There were those in the [first Trump] administration pushing to deorbit the International Space Station prematurely," Cruz added. Democratic senators also noted that Elon Musk has suggested that the ISS should be deorbited as soon as possible to focus on a mission to Mars and that his company SpaceX has been awarded the contract to deorbit the ISS.

"Given that we've invested over \$100 billion in the station, I think that would be profoundly foolish to give up on that investment, as long as it is safe to continue using it," Cruz added.

Isaacman told senators he did not know of any reason why the ISS should be brought down before 2030 and he would like to understand Musk's reasoning. "What

I do think we need to do is maximize its remaining life, get as much of the high potential science and research to the station, figure out what that space economy is, so when the day does come to hand it off to the commercial LEO [low-Earth orbit] destinations they are in a financially self-sustaining type of way," he added.

Sen. Ed Markey (D-MA) questioned Isaacman's "deep personal and financial ties" to Musk, including paying millions of dollars to SpaceX for two private space flights and investing tens of millions in SpaceX, as well as his company maintaining a partnership with Starlink worth millions each year. Markey also referenced reporting that Musk personally asked Isaacman to lead NASA and asked whether this was true.

"You can understand why the public would be concerned about conflicts of interest here," Markey added.

Isaacman did not answer whether Musk was present when Trump offered him the administrator position but told senators that he has not had any communication with Musk regarding his plan to manage NASA since the nomination.

Peters asked Isaacman how he would make sure Musk is not allowed undue influence over awarding or implementation of contracts, saying that Musk serves as both the CEO of SpaceX and a White House employee as the head of the Department of Government Efficiency that has slashed federal spending and contracts. "My loyalty is to this nation, the space agency, and their world-changing mission," Isaacman answered. "They're the contractors. NASA is the customer. They work

for us, not the other way around.”

AGENCY CHANGES UNDER TRUMP

In her opening statement, Ranking Member Maria Cantwell (D-WA) referenced reporting that NASA has laid off workers including its chief scientist, economist, and technologist; canceled research grants and \$420 million in contracts; and may slash its science budget by 50%. She asked Isaacman whether he would reorganize NASA by closing any of its ten centers without congressional authorization and whether there should be personnel or budget cuts.

Isaacman did not specify whether he would close any of the centers or cut agency resources, saying he is “eager to understand” the considerations and current discussions around reorganization.

“I think NASA is going to require the best and brightest from across the nation and all of our critical infrastructure in order to achieve its mission,” he said.

Markey asked Isaacman whether he would commit to fully restoring and maintaining access to NASA’s data and to resisting any political pressure to sideline climate research at the agency. Markey pointed to reporting that previously publicly accessible climate datasets and visualizations have been altered or taken down since Trump took office.

Isaacman said he had not been made aware of any such changes to NASA datasets.

Trump White House budget proposal eviscerates science funding at NASA

“This would decimate American leadership in space.”

Eric Berger <<https://arstechnica.com/author/ericberger/>> – Apr 11, 2025
9:15 AM | 292

This week, as part of the process to develop a budget for fiscal-year 2026, the Trump White House shared the draft version of its budget request for NASA with the space agency.

This initial version of the administration's budget request calls for an approximately 20 percent overall cut to the agency's budget across the board, effectively \$5 billion from an overall topline of about \$25 billion. However, the majority of the cuts are concentrated within the

agency's Science Mission Directorate, which oversees all planetary science, Earth science, astrophysics research, and more.

According to the "passback" documents given to NASA officials on Thursday, the space agency's science programs would receive nearly a 50 percent cut in funding. After the agency received \$7.5 billion for science in fiscal-year 2025, the Trump administration has proposed a science topline budget of just \$3.9 billion for the coming fiscal year.

Detailing the cuts

Among the proposals were: A two-thirds cut to astrophysics, down to \$487 million; a greater than two-thirds cut to heliophysics, down to \$455 million; a greater than 50 percent cut to Earth science, down to \$1.033 billion; and a 30 percent cut to Planetary science, down to \$1.929 billion.

Although the budget would continue support for ongoing missions such as the Hubble Space Telescope and the James Webb Space Telescope, it would kill the much-anticipated Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope, an observatory seen as on par with those two world-class instruments that is already fully assembled and on budget for a launch in two years.

"Passback supports continued operation of the Hubble and James Webb Space Telescopes and assumes no funding is provided for other telescopes," the document states.

Other significant cuts include ending funding for Mars Sample Return as well as the DAVINCI mission to Venus. The budget cuts also appear intended to force the closure of Goddard Space Flight Center in Maryland, where the agency has 10,000 civil servants and contractors.

The passback process

The cuts are in line with what Ars Technica exclusively reported last month

<https://arstechnica.com/space/2025/03/white-house-may-seek-to-slash-nasas-science-budget-by-50-percent/>, that the Trump administration was considering a massive 50-percent cut to NASA's science programs. Publicly, some officials downplayed these concerns. As recently as this week, NASA's acting administrator, Janet Petro, characterized this reporting <https://spacenews.com/nasa-developing-options-for-agency-restructuring-in-unsettling-environment/> as "rumors from really not credible sources."

However, science policy experts have been more alarmed, characterizing

such cuts as an "extinction level" event for what is seen as the crown jewel of the space agency. Nearly all of NASA's most significant achievements over the last 25 years have been delivered by the science programs, including feats such as *Ingenuity* flying on Mars, New Horizons swooping by Pluto, and Cassini's discovery of water plumes on Enceladus.

This passback document represents just the opening salvo of the process to establish a federal budget for fiscal-year 2026, which begins on October 1 of this year. The budget is produced by the White House Office of Management and Budget, which is overseen by Russell Vought, who has long made his anti-science budgeting priorities clear <<https://americarenewing.com/issue/budget/>> through his Center for Renewing America.

The Trump administration nominee to lead NASA, private astronaut Jared Isaacman, said during a confirmation hearing this week <<https://arstechnica.com/space/2025/04/isaacman-sls-and-orion-are-not-a-long-term-solution-for-nasa/>> that he strongly supported NASA's science programs. It is unlikely that Isaacman was involved in drafting this document, as he has not yet been confirmed by the US Senate. Nominees, typically, are excluded from policy prior to confirmation.

After receiving passback documents, NASA usually has 72 hours to review the materials and then submit appeals and justification for changes. Any modifications are then incorporated into a final document that becomes the "President's Budget Request" for the next fiscal year. It is unclear when the Trump administration plans to release this budget request, a public document. It could happen within the next four to six weeks.

Congress will likely fight back

Following this, the White House will work with Congress to actually set the budget. The US House and Senate each have separate appropriations committees that consider (or not) the White House priorities in establishing a final budget that the president must then sign into law. Fierce opposition to some of these NASA cuts is likely in Congress.

"This massive cut to NASA Science will not stand," US Rep. George Whitesides, D-California, told Ars. "For weeks we have been raising the alarm about a rumored 50 percent cut to NASA's world-leading science efforts. Now we know it is true. I will work alongside my colleagues on the Science Committee to make clear how this would decimate American leadership in space and inflict great damage to NASA centers across the country."

One concern, however, is that should the budgeting process be delayed—as is often the case with the federal budget—the White House could force agencies to make operational plans based on the president's budget request once the new fiscal year begins on October 1. Again, this will depend on negotiations with Congress, but, using a process called impoundment, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Impoundment_of_appropriated_funds some Trump officials believe it may be possible to turn the budget request into an actual budget for all intents and purposes.

292 Comments

<https://arstechnica.com/space/2025/04/trump-white-house-budget-proposal-eviscerates-science-funding-at-nasa/#comments>

4/11/25:

xFrom rwo@virginia.edu Fri Apr 11 13:40:39 2025
Date: Fri, 11 Apr 2025 13:40:26
From: "O'Connell, Robert W (rwo)" <rwo@virginia.edu>
To: "astro-alldept@virginia.edu" <astro-alldept@virginia.edu>
Cc: "O'Connell, Robert W (rwo)" <rwo@virginia.edu>
Subject: Huge budget cuts proposed for NASA Astrophysics

I hesitate to draw your attention to the following article. It will not make your day.

<https://arstechnica.com/space/2025/04/trump-white-house-budget-proposal-eviscerates-science-funding-at-nasa/>

This would be a good time for everyone to go to the AAS public advocacy page at

<https://aas.org/advocacy/get-involved>

and see how you might be able to help.

-- RWO

xFrom awootten@nrao.edu Sat Apr 12 09:44:22 2025
Date: Sat, 12 Apr 2025 09:44:10
From: Al Wootten <awootten@nrao.edu>
To: "O'Connell, Robert W (rwo)" <rwo@virginia.edu>
Subject: Re: [astro-nraoadjunct] Huge budget cuts proposed for NASA Astrophysics {External}

Congressmen written, so all will be well... One disaster after another! Thanks for the heads up! Al

Sent from my Verizon, Samsung Galaxy smartphone
Get Outlook for Android

4/13/25: :at 12:00

THIS LETTER SENT to my Congressman John McGuire, using McGuire's online site for sending mail:

<https://mcguire.house.gov/contact/email-me>

Was a little glitchy and had to start over again to get on the right track.

=====

Dear Representative McGuire:

I strongly urge you to sign the bipartisan Congressional letter in support of full funding for NASA's science programs. These have supported three generations of space scientists and guaranteed that the US is the undisputed world leader in space science.

NASA's Science Mission Directorate has delivered some of the most spectacular scientific discoveries of the last fifty years -- discoveries that have inspired hundreds of thousands of young people to become scientists and engineers. There are few, if any, federal investments that have produced a better return for education and building the STEM workforce in this country.

Since Virginia hosts one of the few NASA launch sites at Wallops Island and also the large NASA Langley Research Center, space science is also an important contributor to its economy.

Sincerely yours,

Robert W. O'Connell

=====

The final address tag was omitted, since name, address, email and phone were entered separately.

Note that there was no way to arrange for a CC to myself, so there

is no record of the message in either of my email accounts. Just this file version.

Separately, had logged into my (infrequently used) Gmail account and cleaned out a lot of trash. Note that I will be getting McGuire's newsletters at the gmail address(!)

4/14/25: From: FYI <fyi@aipcomm.org>

Subject: This Week: DOE caps indirect costs / Trump poised to seek massive science cuts in 2026 budget / More university research frozen

FYI: Science Policy News from AIP
THE WEEK OF APRIL 14, 2025

DOE SHARPLY CUTS FUNDS FOR INDIRECT COSTS OF UNIVERSITY RESEARCH

The Department of Energy announced last week it will immediately cap indirect cost rates at 15% to "halt inefficient spending" by universities, mirroring a move by NIH in February that has been blocked by a federal judge. DOE stated the uniform cap will save over \$405 million annually and "help improve efficiency, reduce costs and ensure proper stewardship of American taxpayer dollars." The DOE and NIH moves signal a sea change in the federal government's attitude toward financing indirect costs, which support activities such as equipment and facilities maintenance, IT services, and administrative support. "The purpose of Department of Energy funding to colleges and universities is to support scientific research – not foot the bill for administrative costs and facility upgrades," Energy Secretary Chris Wright said in a statement.

University groups quickly moved to contest DOE's move. "This is a ruinous policy. Our nation's economic competitors are laughing at another self-inflicted policy wound that will slow the pace of American research and innovation," said Matt Owens, president of the Council on Government Relations, an association of research institutions. "We stand ready to work with the Trump administration to improve research indirect costs policy and to reduce the red tape encumbering federally sponsored research." COGR recently issued a document of recommendations to improve government efficiency in research management and joined other research associations in announcing an effort to develop a new funding model for indirect costs. DOE's press release says that the average rate of indirect costs incurred by the department's grant recipients at colleges and universities is more than 30%.

TRUMP'S BUDGET LIKELY TO PROPOSE MAJOR SCIENCE CUTS

Leaked drafts of President Donald Trump's upcoming budget request to Congress suggest he plans to seek massive cuts to science programs. A preliminary version of the budget revealed last week proposes cutting NASA's Science Mission Directorate by about 50% to \$3.9 billion for fiscal year 2026. A similar document for the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration calls for cutting the agency's budget by 27% to \$4.5 billion and eliminating its Office of Oceanic and Atmospheric Research. Some of that office's research would be transferred to other parts of NOAA, according to press accounts of the proposal. Research groups have reacted with alarm to the prospect of such cuts. The American Astronomical Society stated last week that a 50% cut to NASA's science directorate would be "catastrophic to our nation's leadership in the space sciences, damaging a broad range of research areas that are unlikely to be supported by the private sector." In anticipation of proposed budget cuts, the American Meteorological Society issued an open letter to Americans last month highlighting the economic benefits of federal science funding, and the American Physical Society is collecting stories of the positive impacts of research funded by federal agencies. (These three groups are AIP Member Societies.) Meanwhile, the House and Senate have begun preparing to draft their own budget proposals for the upcoming fiscal year. The chairs of the Senate Appropriations Committee put out their initial instructions for the appropriations process last week, including how to submit requests for earmarks, and said hearings will commence later this month. House appropriators put out similar instructions earlier this month and have already begun their budget hearings.

MORE UNIVERSITY RESEARCH FROZEN BY TRUMP ADMINISTRATION

The Trump administration apparently has ordered the National Institutes of Health to stop paying investigators on all existing agency-funded projects at Columbia University and block new funding as it pressures the university to take certain actions in response to an antisemitism probe, according to Science. The administration is also seeking formal oversight of the university through a legal agreement called a consent decree, according to The Wall Street Journal. The agreement would likely require negotiation between the administration and the university under the oversight of a judge. The administration already froze \$400 million in research funding last month to pressure the university to take various actions, such as hiring security officers who can remove people from campus or arrest them and placing departments focused on Middle Eastern, South Asian, and African Studies under the oversight of a new official rather than faculty.

Meanwhile, the administration has increasingly used research funding as a lever to pressure additional universities to implement its policy priorities. For instance, last week Cornell and Northwestern received stop-work orders and funding-freeze notices spanning grants from several agencies. Among the affected projects is a collaboration

between the Cornell High Energy Synchrotron Source and the Air Force Research Lab, Scientific American reported. Harvard University, which is under threat of a sweeping freeze on federal research funding, announced today it would not comply with the administration's demands, arguing they exceed federal authorities and violate First Amendment protections.

NOAA REFIRE PROBATIONARY EMPLOYEES

The National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration has reportedly refired hundreds of probationary employees who were first fired in February and then reinstated and put on administrative leave in March. Former NOAA employees impacted by the decision expressed dismay on social media, describing the experience as a "roller coaster" and a "wild and silly process," for instance. NOAA's actions followed the news last Wednesday that an appeals court stayed a Maryland judge's ruling preventing 18 federal agencies from firing probationary employees in certain states. The day before, the Supreme Court paused a similar but separate ruling by a San Francisco judge, effectively halting the reinstatement of fired probationary workers nationwide at six government departments: Defense, Energy, Interior, Treasury, Agriculture, and Veterans Affairs.

ALSO ON OUR RADAR

- * NSF halved the number of awards from its flagship Graduate Research Fellowship program to 1,000 while leaving open the possibility of making more awards depending on "future resourcing considerations."
- * The Trump administration has canceled a major contract supporting the U.S. Global Change Research Program and fired several of its staff, according to Politico. The administration also canceled \$4 million in climate research grants at Princeton University, including for the Cooperative Institute for Modeling the Earth System, stating it "promotes exaggerated and implausible climate threats." It is unclear if CIMES has been fully defunded, as it was last renewed in 2023 for \$85 million over the following five years.
- * NIH has barred scientists working in China, Cuba, Iran, North Korea, Russia, and Venezuela from accessing various biomedical databases, citing a Biden-era executive order that directed actions to better protect Americans' data from adversarial countries. Separately, the Justice Department issued an FAQ last week about the executive order implementation.
- * In response to Trump's tariffs, China reportedly halted most exports of rare earth magnets and six rare earth metals pending implementation of a new export licensing process.

- * Last week, Trump ordered investigations into state laws “burdening” energy generation, with an emphasis on those that mention climate change, environmental justice, or greenhouse gas emissions. Trump also ordered DOE to “accelerate the development, deployment, and commercialization of coal technologies” and to study using coal to power AI data centers.
- * Data-focused organizations have formed a coalition to support efforts to “rescue” public federal datasets that are at risk of becoming inaccessible.

4/16/25: FYI: Science Policy News from AIP
BULLETIN
April 16, 2025

Judge Blocks DOE Move to Cut Indirect Cost Rate
Clare Zhang

Universities sued the Department of Energy for abruptly cutting its facilities and administrative cost rates for research grants.

A federal judge issued a temporary restraining order today after the Department of Energy announced Friday that it would place a 15% cap on indirect cost rates for university research grants and terminate current grants that do not adhere to the cap. Universities and higher education associations sued the department on Monday, arguing that the change was “arbitrary and capricious” and does not follow the government’s own indirect cost regulations.

DOE stated that the average rate of indirect costs incurred by the department’s grant recipients at colleges and universities is more than 30% and that the cap would save over \$405 million annually. DOE currently awards more than \$2.5 billion annually to more than 300 universities.

[Yes, it would save money by NOT DOING RESEARCH.]

“The purpose of Department of Energy funding to colleges and universities is to support scientific research – not foot the bill for administrative costs and facility upgrades,” Energy Secretary Chris Wright said in the announcement. The plaintiffs asked the court to prohibit DOE from putting the rate cap policy into effect and from terminating any grants where a grantee refuses to accept an indirect cost rate below their institution’s negotiated rate.

The plaintiffs include nine universities that are expected to lose millions of dollars in indirect cost recovery annually under the DOE cap. These range from MIT, which would lose more than \$15 million in

indirect cost recovery over the next year, to Michigan State University, which would lose \$32 million in indirect cost recovery annually, according to the lawsuit. Brown, Cornell, and Princeton are also plaintiffs and have separately had hundreds of millions of dollars in research grants frozen by the Trump administration earlier this month.

Indirect costs, also known as facilities and administrative (F&A) costs, are used to cover research-related expenses such as equipment and facilities maintenance, IT services, and administrative support. Indirect costs are paid in addition to direct research costs and are often expressed as a percentage. For example, an indirect cost rate of 50% means that for every dollar awarded as part of a research grant for eligible direct costs, the institution would receive an additional 50 cents to cover indirect costs. In that case, indirect costs would represent one-third of the total award.

Brown's Vice President for Research Greg Hirth wrote in a filing with the court that the new policy would force the university to eliminate research-related administrative and facilities maintenance positions, stop graduate students' work and thereby hinder their degree completion, and reduce or close experimental and computational facilities.

For universities, indirect cost rates are typically negotiated by either the Department of Health and Human Services or the Department of Defense's Office of Naval Research, normally depending on which agency provided more funds directly to the university in the last three years. All other agencies must use this negotiated rate for their grants to that university, the lawsuit states. Rates are negotiated based on the university's documented costs and can be adjusted if an audit establishes that the university has recovered excess costs. "DOE denigrates 'indirect cost payments' as 'not for the department's direct research funding,'" the lawsuit states. "But DOE ignores that indirect costs are often necessary for DOE's own research to continue: Cutting-edge research, for example, requires physical infrastructure and equipment, ethics review boards, and many other costs that are not traceable to specific grants but are nonetheless essential for the work."

The lawsuit argues that the policy change does not follow required procedures or provide appropriate justification to deviate from negotiated indirect cost rates. The new policy also fails to consider "reliance interests," including institutions' long-term budget planning around established indirect cost rates and the early career scientists who will lose their jobs as a result of grant cuts, the lawsuit adds.

Regarding current grants, the lawsuit further argues that terminating these grants based on a new cap would be illegal. Agencies can only

legally terminate grants if the grantee gives consent or fails to comply with the terms of the grant, or the award "no longer effectuates the program goals or agency priorities." The new policy also makes retroactive changes to current grants, which is only permissible with congressional authorization, the lawsuit adds. DOE is the first agency after the National Institutes of Health to announce a policy change on indirect costs. The first Trump administration attempted to cap indirect cost rates on NIH grants at 10%, but the proposal faced bipartisan opposition in Congress, which enacted legislation that prevents deviations from negotiated rates.

The lawsuit states that NIH's attempted 15% cap, announced in February, was illegal for many of the same reasons. A federal judge in Massachusetts blocked NIH's cap earlier this month and the agency subsequently appealed the decision. The plaintiffs in the DOE case filed their lawsuit in the same court.

4/15/25: WP. What Harvard could lose in its battle with the Trump administration / Trump on Tuesday threatened the school's tax exempt status, and a \$2.2 billion freeze on grants kicked in. Harvard borrowed money in anticipation of cuts.

Harvard University appeared to be bracing for federal funding cuts before it publicly pronounced on Monday that it will not submit to the Trump administration's demands that it cede unprecedented control to the government.

Last week, the school borrowed \$750 million from Wall Street to shore up its coffers. Then on Monday, just as it announced it was not capitulating to President Donald Trump, it posted a sweeping summary of the kinds of research innovations that are at risk if federal officials cut grants that fund research on illnesses from cancer to diabetes.

The Trump administration's \$2.2 billion freeze on funds to Harvard began Monday night as a trickle of stop-work orders on major contracts that support projects ranging from research on a deadly infection to the effects of spaceflight on the human body. The damage assessment on which research had been stopped was occurring throughout the day Tuesday, with more cancellations expected.

..."All the President is asking, don't break federal law, and then you can have your federal funding," White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt said Tuesday. "I think the President is also begging a good question ... why are the American taxpayers subsidizing a university that has billions of dollars in the bank already?"

...Harvard is the wealthiest college in the nation with a \$53 billion

endowment, a collection of tax-exempt donations and investments that pays for salaries, research, financial aid and other expenses in perpetuity. A lot of that money, however, is restricted by donors and cannot be easily accessed.

...The president does not have unilateral authority to revoke the school's tax exemption, but the IRS can eliminate it if Harvard is found to be participating in political campaigning or lobbying.

..."It's pure punitive lunacy. They're just trying to bring the golden goose of American science, technology and education pipeline to a halt," said Donald E. Ingber, founding director of the Wyss Institute for Biologically Inspired Engineering at Harvard. Late Monday night, he received a stop-work order on two parts of a larger contract that support about 20 employees and are collectively worth nearly \$20 million. "It goes against everything this administration talks about with international competitiveness," Ingber said. "We are turning away the future workforce. The brain drain has started already."

Comments...

If they revoke colleges' tax except statuses for what they consider political speech or policies, they'd better revoke the tax exempt status of every church that preaches politics from the pulpit.

Stop pretending this has anything to do with anti-Semitism. The idea that the administration that sent an innocent Slavadoran man off to a foreign death camp and refuses to return him cares about the rights of a racial minority is simply preposterous. This is about the far right in this country finding money anywhere it can to fund ridiculous, budget busting tax cust for the rich.

But think what they would have lost had they complied with the edicts from the Trumpists, their honour, their reputation, their integrity and their self-respect. Just ask the partners at Paul Weiss.

Another day, another attempt to smash some of the best things about America. Another front in this interminable war on nothings. Another windmill to joust. His misapplication of power truly exposes what a weak man he really is. This fool may be President, but he'll always be a loser.

Harvard is one of the greatest research universities in the world. Trump is nothing but blip in history. Harvard has been around a long time, and will continue to thrive and long outlive Trump. The sooner he departs this earth the better. As an American living abroad, I am absolutely ashamed of this moronic US president and his foul administration. It's obscene what is going on over there.

And why are the American taxpayers subsidizing companies owned by Elon

Musk, when he is the world's richest person?

Bezos is worth \$200B and Harvard's endowment only worth \$50B. Why doesn't the owner of this paper stand up to Trump??

Trump was ordered to pay \$25M as a fraud settlement brought by 25 students at Trump U who paid for classes that didn't exist. TU was shuttered in light of scandal and rampant abuse. And now president Bevis Butthead is telling Harvard what is ethical? Screw that.

4/17/25: WP. Trump's freeze on \$2.2 billion to Harvard provided no proof of wrongdoing / The Trump administration skipped over requirements, including offering to hold a hearing, when applying financial penalties related to civil rights violations.

Harvard University stands to lose billions in federal funding, but the government's actions against one of the world's top research institutions were applied with vague accusations and no proof of specific legal violations, documents show.

...Trump administration officials have publicly said that Harvard has violated students' civil rights and mentioned Title VI, which is the federal law that says any school found to violate civil rights is not eligible for federal funding. Harvard, according to the letter the administration sent the school on April 11, was not keeping Jewish and pro-Israel students safe and allowed antisemitism on campus. The letter also said the university had diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI) programs that could not stand.

But the government's notice did not list or explain the specific violations that occurred at Harvard. The administration's action skipped over requirements that say the government must identify and list violations, offer a hearing, notify Congress and then wait 30 days before applying penalties.

...The Trump administration's alleged disregard for federal procedure is part of the basis for separate lawsuits filed by the faculty unions at Harvard and Columbia University. "These procedures exist because Congress recognized that allowing federal agencies to hold funding hostage, or to cancel it cavalierly, would give them dangerously broad power in a system in which institutions depend so heavily upon federal funding," attorneys for the American Association of University Professors wrote in the Harvard faculty union lawsuit.

...Trump has shown his willingness to punish, without detailed explanation, institutions for their embrace of social policies with which he disagrees.

...Universities use federal funds to, among other things, produce

cutting-edge medical research and technological advancements that make the United States a leader in many lucrative fields.

The five-page letter to Harvard did not specify which DEI initiatives the administration wanted eliminated, only that it must shutter all such programs and "demonstrate that it has done so to the satisfaction of the federal government." The demands, written by officials at the Education Department, the Department of Health and Human Services, and the General Services Administration, were relatively vague. The administration wants the school to hire an external auditor to evaluate the "viewpoint diversity" of the university's students and faculty, make "meaningful governance reform and restructuring," and allow for "reducing the power held by students and untenured faculty," the letter said.

The letter also demanded admission changes to "prevent admitting students hostile to the American values and institutions inscribed in the U.S. Constitution and Declaration of Independence, including students supportive of terrorism or anti-Semitism."

Comments...

This is where we find out if the other two branches of government will save America from a domestic fascist dictator.

I keep forgetting, how is going after higher education institutions going to lower my grocery prices?

Classic Trump , no sense, no process, only blind, rabid, revenge for perceived slights. The USA is in the grip of a single person's clinically insane ego and greed!

Take away Harvard's tax exemption? Fine. Just make sure you follow up and remove the tax exemption for all churches and synagogues.

[Yes, talk about institutions that discriminate against Jews.]

In 1933 Peter Drucker, an Austrian economist at Frankfurt University, Germany fearful of Hitler's plans for the country was prepared to leave but hoped that it would not be necessary to do so. The first Nazi-led faculty meeting at his university convinced him otherwise. Drucker wrote down his thoughts about that meeting,

"Frankfurt was the first university the Nazis tackled, precisely because it was the most self-confidently liberal of major German universities, with a faculty that prided itself on its allegiance to scholarship, freedom of conscience, and democracy. The Nazis knew that control of Frankfurt University would mean control of German academia. And so did everyone at the university.

"Above all, Frankfurt had a science faculty distinguished both by its scholarship and by its liberal convictions; and outstanding among the Frankfurt scientists was a biochemist-physiologist of Nobel-Prize caliber and impeccable liberal credentials. When the appointment of a Nazi commissar was announced . . . and every teacher and graduate assistant at the university was summoned to a faculty meeting to hear this new master, everybody knew that a trial of strength was at hand. I had never before attended a faculty meeting, but I did attend this one.

"The new Nazi commissar wasted no time on the amenities. He immediately announced that Jews would be forbidden to enter university premises and would be dismissed without salary on March 15; this was something that no one had thought possible despite the Nazis' loud antisemitism. Then he launched into a tirade of abuse, filth, and four-letter words such as had been heard rarely even in the barracks and never before in academia. . . . [He] pointed his finger at one department chairman after another and said, 'You either do what I tell you or we'll put you into a concentration camp.'"

Harvard was founded in 1636. This makes it older than the United Kingdom, 1707. Italy, 1861, and Germany, 1871. It trained many of the leaders of the American revolution. It was old when Napoleon was born. It was 200 years old when many of its graduates fought and died for the Union in the Civil War. If Harvard cannot withstand the onslaughts of this stupid little man it will be because he is ultimately successful in destroying the entire American Democracy. And if this happens, we will deserve it for not pushing back against the sycophants who support him. Every student and graduate of every university and college in the country needs to be on the phone and e-mailing to their representatives telling them to grow spines or resign. Remind them that they were elected to represent their constituents in a functioning Congress, and to uphold the authority of that Congress.

"Harvard hasn't done anything to violate its tax-exempt status." Brunson added: "there's not a single competent attorney left in the Administration." -- One of the quotes in Heather Cox Richardson's newsletter this morning

Are you saying the presidential administration needs MORE that juvenile petty petulance to remove federal funding from a university?!!

Has everyone read the conditions trump wants on Harvard? Literally, trump wants to control every aspect of the University from the President, curriculum, hiring to maintenance workers. This from the party of small government, free speech, now wants to dictate every

aspect of your life from corporations to educational institutes. smh

Related: [4/22/25] interview on "Fresh Air" with Steven Levitsky.

Q: The letter that the administration sent to Harvard a week ago Friday – that's April 11 – is a pretty remarkable letter...This is a part of the letter that deals with Harvard's apparent imbalance in viewpoint diversity – according to the administration, obviously – underrepresenting conservatives. But here's what the text of the letter says.

"By August 25, the university shall commission an external party which shall satisfy the federal government as to its competence and good faith to audit the student body, faculty, staff and leadership for viewpoint diversity, such that each department, field or teaching unit must be individually viewpoint diverse. This review shall begin no later than this summer and shall be submitted to the university and the federal government by the end of the year. Harvard must abolish all criteria preferences and practices, whether mandatory or optional, throughout its admissions and hiring practices that function as ideological litmus tests. Every department or field found to lack viewpoint diversity must be reformed by hiring a critical mass of new faculty within that department or field who will provide viewpoint diversity."

That's a pretty remarkable thing for a government to demand of a university, isn't it?

A: What that passage is saying is that the government is demanding the right to dictate to a private university who it can hire and not hire and effectively what it can teach and cannot teach. That's the end of academic freedom. That is completely incompatible with a democratic society. And I know of no democracy that's ever permitted that sort of intervention. I know of many authoritarian regimes that didn't permit that level of federal intervention into the internal life of a university.

...Autocrats to the left, like Hugo Chavez, autocrats to the right, like Erdogan and Orban, invariably go after universities. And that is precisely what the Trump administration is doing. So there were a number of reasons why the university ultimately said no to the Trump administration's demand. But faculty are really concerned, particularly those of us who not only teach here, but who study authoritarianism and have seen these kinds of assaults elsewhere.

Q: You know, there was some reporting over the weekend – this is pretty wild – that suggested that the government's letter... may

have been sent by mistake. What do you make of this?

A: I think that the administration blinked. I think it realized that this was not going well. Harvard's resistance gave a real burst of energy and encouragement not just to other universities, but to civil society across the country that's been waiting for the more powerful actors, the more prominent actors in our society, to get off the sidelines and begin to fight back. I know that Harvard's leadership was concerned that Harvard's public image is not great right now. It's viewed as very elitist and that there was a concern that the public would rally behind Trump against Harvard if there was such a conflict. That did not happen. To the extent that anybody rallied, the public rallied and was beginning to rally behind Harvard. And I think the administration realized that this fight was not going well and wanted to reset the negotiations. And I think they realized that they asked too much, and the danger now is that they'll come back and offer – or demand 60% of what they demanded before. And I don't know what the university's response will be.

4/18/25: IHE. What to Know About Trump's Strategy Targeting Colleges' Grants and Contracts / The novel approach is targeting billions of dollars for research and could reshape higher education for years to come.

Several agencies, including the White House and a joint task force, are involved in freezing funds for grants and contracts to universities.

Photo illustration by Justin Morrison/Inside Higher Ed | Michael M. Santiago/Getty Images | patrykstanisz/iStock/Getty Images

Over the course of just 13 weeks, President Donald Trump has made it clear that he'll use billions of dollars in federal grants and contracts, primarily for research, as a lever to force colleges and universities to bow to his agenda and increase the representation of conservative ideology on their campuses.

The cuts don't follow any typical investigative process and sometimes lack clear explanations or legal justifications. And such an aggressive ad hoc strategy is one that that many higher education lawyers, policy analysts and administrators say could reshape postsecondary education for years to come.

"It's certainly unprecedented and deeply disturbing," said John King Jr., former secretary of education under President Obama and current chancellor of the State University of New York system. Trump's actions "really threaten the long-standing partnership between the federal

government and higher education in the pursuit of both innovation and economic mobility.”

Trump and his advisers have signaled their intent to crack down on “woke” higher education but haven’t said how they will do so. Instead, a cadre of conservative policy analysts plotted how to leverage other agencies and sources of funding, beyond access to the \$130 billion distributed annually in federal student loans and Pell Grants.

“At the beginning it felt like I was the only one fighting,” Chris Rufo, an influential anti-DEI advocate and a member of the Board of Trustees at New College of Florida, said on /The Daily/, a/New York Times /podcast last week. “Now, fast-forward five years, [and] some of the ideas that I had cobbled together have suddenly become reality, they’ve become policy, they affect billions of dollars in the flow of funds.”

But efforts to send colleges and universities into “an existential terror,” as Rufo put it, have required the Trump administration to move at a dizzying pace and leverage multiple mechanisms that most higher education lawyers, policy analysts and officials say are incredibly novel.

To catch up, here are four things you should know about Trump’s funding threats to colleges and universities.

Broad Scope of Attack

A large part of what makes the Trump administration’s current push to crack down on colleges and align their actions with his agenda so unprecedented, experts say, is its sheer magnitude, from the amount of money at risk to the number of investigations involving various agencies.

The Education Department has historically taken the lead on holding colleges accountable, leveraging institutions’ eligibility for student aid programs to force compliance. Bu this time around, it’s an all-hands-on-deck effort with a magazine of federal programs used as ammunition.

At least four departments beyond Education—Justice, Defense, Energy and Health and Human Services—have also been involved, cutting off scientific research grants, which are typically considered immune from political attacks.

The group launched reviews of Columbia and Harvard Universities, demanded sweeping changes and froze \$400 million and \$2.2 billion in

grants and contracts, respectively. The funds at risk support a wide range of research at the universities, including on cancer, tuberculosis and the effects of environmental pollution on health. Faculty have warned of dire consequences if the freezes continue.

In addition to Columbia and Harvard, Northwestern, Cornell, Brown and Princeton Universities have had some of their federal funds frozen, though it's not clear why or who made that decision and under what legal authority. (/The Wall Street Journal/ reported that White House staff were behind the Cornell funding freeze.)

The Trump administration also froze \$175 million at the University of Pennsylvania to penalize administrators for allowing a transgender athlete to swim on the women's team three years ago.

What the Trump administration is doing enters a "whole new territory," Princeton president Christopher Eisgruber said in a recent interview with /The New York Times/.

Starting with the freeze at Columbia, "the government was using its tremendous power over research dollars to try to control what a private university was doing in terms of matters that are generally considered part of academic freedom," Eisgruber added. "There's a very fundamental threat here right now ... to America's research universities that anybody who cares about the strength of this country, our economy, our prosperity, our security, our health should be worried about."

Colleges also face other threats from the federal government. The Department of Education has launched or actively pursued at least 97 investigations concerning alleged antisemitism and DEI programs which could imperil those institutions' access to federal financial aid. And the National Institutes of Health and the Department of Energy moved to cap reimbursements for costs indirectly related to research, which, if enacted, could cost colleges billions.

Bypassing Standard Processes

Adding to the difficulty for colleges, the Trump administration is largely ignoring regulatory standards and procedures when it cuts funding.

For instance, cabinet members have broadly used the term "investigation" to describe the ways they are cracking down on colleges. But in most cases, the review process has lasted only a few days and resulted in little to no evidence of the alleged violation. Often, universities have been presented with a list of ultimatums or policy changes they must make in order to avoid a funding freeze or restore their funds.

The stop-work orders that have been issued so far have been “arbitrary” and “often unsupported,” said King of SUNY. If there is rationale, it often “seems disingenuous.”

And some universities have yet to receive a formal notification about a funding freeze. For example, Brown officials have not received any official word of a rumored \$510 million cut.

“We have nothing to actually substantiate what’s being reported,” Brian Clark, Brown’s vice president for news, told /Inside Higher Ed /in an email.

For civil rights investigations, investigations typically begin when the Education Department notifies an institution of the allegations made in thorough detail, experts explained. Then, the Office for Civil Rights conducts an in-depth investigation that includes talking to students, faculty and staff and gathering documents or data regarding the allegations. That process allows colleges to voluntarily resolve the investigation and negotiate a settlement with the department. The resulting agreement usually outlines various changes that colleges must make to comply with federal law. Some conservative critics have said those settlements or resolution agreements were “toothless.”

If the parties cannot agree or a college refuses to comply with the federal law, the department could sue a college. But that’s rare, and the Education Department has never pulled a college’s federal funding over civil rights violations—a move that’s considered a nuclear option.

Brendan Cantwell, a higher education professor at Michigan State University, noted that despite the quick turnaround, the administration’s investigations do, at times, parallel the motivations of traditional reviews. But what makes this approach so unprecedented and unlawful, in his mind, Cantwell said, is its “unmeasured” and “blanketed” nature.

“So while there are precedents and similar examples in the past, beyond very superficial similarities, the similarities fall apart,” he said.

Breaking Contract Law

The means by which Trump is terminating grants and contracts is also novel, a lawyer who specializes in government contracts told /Inside Higher Ed/.

Generally, the only people who have authority to take contract-based actions on behalf of the United States are contracting officers or agreements officers, said Jayna Marie Rust, a partner at Thompson

Coburn LLP. But under the Trump administration, it's often unclear if this is the case, especially with the Department of Government Efficiency reviewing contracts and grants and touting decisions to cancel millions in agreements.

Rust said she has not seen any of the direct communications between government agencies and universities regarding contract/grant termination that are due to the identity of the institution and therefore can't say if the notifications come from contracting or agreements officers. But notifications coming from others is something she has seen in other terminations that schools are receiving.

"But to the extent these communications are not coming from the agreements officers or contracting officers, that is unusual," Rust said.

And much like the procedure for investigating and addressing policy violations, the government is supposed to ensure due process before excluding schools from receiving federal funds, which is effectively what the terminations have done. The Trump administration has seemingly bypassed those steps. (Several faculty groups and associations have sued to restore the canceled funding.)

Even when the administration has completed a process to determine whether an entity can be excluded from receiving federal funds, contracting and agreements officers also often conduct a risk analysis to see if the benefit of letting that entity complete a contract or grant outweighs the benefit of cutting ties (which could result in losing the benefit of work that's already completed), Rust said. It appears that the Trump administration also hasn't gone through that review.

More Than Money at Stake

As a result of the sweeping scope of Trump's attacks and the lack of precedent, the risks for colleges and universities are more than financial, higher ed experts say.

Yes, losing billions of dollars in federal funding is a problem, and not one that elite institutions' endowments can solve. But more than that, what's at risk is the core mission and ethos of American higher education, King said.

"From the technology inside of your phone to the treatment you may receive at your doctor—all of that can be traced back to research conducted at America's higher ed institutions. And it's under threat," he said.

And though the dollar amounts of funding pulled from smaller private liberal arts institutions and state universities may be "more modest,"

they're still significant, he added. "For those researchers, it's heartbreaking, and it will ultimately harm economic development and national security."

The full impact of these funding freezes is not yet clear. But until the courts weigh in, colleges are stuck between a rock and a hard place, said Nussbaum, of Church Church Hittle + Antrim.

"Schools are trying to make that decision of how can we make decisions consistent with our mission and values in a way that's not going to get us called out?" Nussbaum said. "I think we'll have a little bit more certainty on where the means and bounds of the discretion of the executive agency is in the funding. But I think in the meantime, a lot of schools are trying to wait out that clock."

4/21/25: From: FYI <fyi@aipcomm.org>

Subject: This Week: NSF ends DEI and misinformation grants + 12 advisory panels / Kratsios sketches S&T priorities / Trump escalates fight with Harvard

THE WEEK OF APRIL 21, 2025

NSF ENDS DEI AND MISINFORMATION RESEARCH GRANTS

The National Science Foundation announced last week that it is terminating grants related to diversity, equity, and inclusion or combating misinformation. The decision applies to grants that involve engaging with people based on characteristics that are protected from discrimination under various laws, such as race, color, religion, sex, and national origin. It also applies to research that "could be used to infringe on the constitutionally protected speech rights of American citizens across the United States in a manner that advances a preferred narrative about significant matters of public debate." NSF stated that such grants no longer "effectuate" agency priorities, language that has been used by the Trump administration as a legal mechanism to terminate active awards.

NSF acknowledged in the announcement that one of the statutory goals of its "broader impacts" grant review criteria is to increase the participation of women and underrepresented groups in STEM, but it nevertheless stated that NSF-funded projects may only conduct activities to reach these groups "as part of broad engagement activities" that are "open and available to all Americans." NSF also stated it will continue to operate programs that broaden participation based on protected characteristics if they are explicitly established in law and "prioritized" in NSF appropriations language. Grantees may expand STEM participation based on non-protected characteristics, such

as institutional type, geography, socioeconomic status, and career stage, but NSF cautioned that such characteristics “cannot indirectly preference or exclude individuals or groups based on protected characteristics.” Furthermore, NSF stated that research with a focus on protected characteristics is permissible when such characteristics are “intrinsic to the research question” and the research is aligned with agency priorities.

Reacting to the move, House Science Committee Ranking Member Zoe Lofgren (D-CA) called on NSF to “reverse course immediately” to protect the agency’s integrity. “The American people deserve a scientific enterprise free from political interference, where expert scientists and engineers participate in a merit-based review process to recommend the most innovative and promising research proposals,” she stated. Lofgren also noted that Democratic staff on the committee had just published a rebuttal to a report by Senate Commerce, Science, and Transportation Committee Chair Ted Cruz (R-TX) that stated that over \$2 billion in NSF grants “went to questionable projects that promoted DEI tenets or pushed onto science neo-Marxist perspectives.”

NEW OSTP DIRECTOR SKETCHES OUT S&T PRIORITIES

In a major speech last week, White House Office of Science and Technology Policy Director Michael Kratsios said the Trump administration will pursue novel funding methods, deregulation, and heightened research security measures to achieve U.S. technological preeminence. Kratsios said the U.S. should strive to be “more creative in our use of public research and development money,” specifically calling for greater use of “prizes, advance market commitments, and other novel funding mechanisms, like fast and flexible grants.” He also said deregulation is necessary to enable the construction of more nuclear power plants and to advance transportation technologies such as “supersonic aircraft or high-speed rail and flying cars.”

Kratsios criticized as inadequate the Biden administration’s “small-yard, high-fence” approach to technology security, which emphasized placing strict controls on a relatively small number of cutting-edge technologies. He went on to call for the U.S. to implement “strict and simple export controls and know-your-customer rules, with an unapologetic America-first attitude about enforcing them.” He also expressed support for tightening restrictions on foreign scientists, saying, “To safeguard our intellectual capital, we must restrict foreign access to sensitive data and strengthen oversight of international collaborators.” In the portion of his speech focused on securing research and supply chains, Kratsios emphasized risks posed by China, referring to the country as “both a geopolitical rival and technological competitor.”

ADVISORY PANEL TERMINATIONS REACH NSF

The National Science Foundation terminated 12 advisory committees last week, joining a growing list of science agencies that have culled committees in response to a February executive order from President Donald Trump aiming to reduce the size of the federal government. NSF dissolved the advisory committees for its Directorates of Mathematical and Physical Sciences, Geosciences, and STEM Education, among others. Five NSF advisory committees will continue to meet as they are required in statute, including one for the new Technology, Innovation, and Partnerships Directorate, which will hold its inaugural meeting on April 28. The other four surviving panels are the Astronomy and Astrophysics Advisory Committee, the Committee on Equal Opportunities in Science and Engineering, and the panels involved in reviewing nominations for the National Medal of Science and NSF's Alan T. Waterman Award.

TRUMP ADMINISTRATION ESCALATES FIGHT WITH HARVARD

The Trump administration put \$2.2 billion of Harvard University's research funding on hold last week after the institution rejected a series of demands laid out in an April 11 letter signed by three federal officials on the administration's Joint Task Force to Combat Anti-Semitism. Those demands extend well beyond anti-semitism measures, such as a requirement that Harvard audit its students, faculty, and staff for "viewpoint diversity." In announcing the funding freeze, the task force stated that Harvard's refusal to comply with the demands "reinforces the troubling entitlement mindset that is endemic in our nation's most prestigious universities and colleges – that federal investment does not come with the responsibility to uphold civil rights laws." Harvard has accused the government of overreaching, stating it will "not surrender its independence or relinquish its constitutional rights." Meanwhile, President Donald Trump has also threatened to revoke Harvard's tax-exempt status, and the Department of Homeland Security has threatened to limit its ability to enroll foreign students. In addition, foreign donations to the university are being scrutinized by the Department of Education, building on probes begun during the first Trump administration.

EVENT TO EXPLORE TRAJECTORY OF SCIENCE POLICY UNDER TRUMP

The upheaval in science policy to date under the new Trump administration will be explored in a webinar this Wednesday afternoon hosted by the magazine Issues in Science and Technology. The panelists are Caroline Wagner of Ohio State University, Carrie Wolinetz of Lewis-Burke Associates, Divyansh Kaushik of Beacon Global Strategies, and Jason Rittenberg of Excel Regional Solutions. FYI Director Mitch Ambrose will moderate the conversation.

4/24/25: From: FYI <fyi@aipcomm.org>

Subject: US Physics Departments Expect to Shrink Graduate Programs

FYI: Science Policy News from AIP
BULLETIN

US Physics Departments Expect to Shrink Graduate Programs
Clare Zhang

Student enrollment and guaranteed financial support are expected to fall amid anticipation of federal budget cuts, a new report finds.

Many U.S. graduate programs in physics and astronomy are expecting lower enrollment in the next two classes of first-year students, according to a report published yesterday by the American Institute of Physics that assesses the impacts of uncertainty about the future of federal science funding and policy under the Trump administration.

AIP contacted all 292 department chairs at schools offering graduate degrees in physics and astronomy in the U.S. and received 115 replies during the response window between April 3 and 16.

The report anticipates that first-year enrollment in physics and astronomy graduate programs could decline by about 13% this fall. This includes a 25% decline at private institutions and a 7% decline at public institutions. Those values are derived from respondents' estimates of how many more or fewer first-year students they expect at their own institutions in 2025 compared to 2024. Many department chairs said they believe the decline in first-year students will be even larger in the fall of 2026.

"It is almost certain we will have to shrink the size of our graduate program in future years due to the anticipated reduction in federal funding," one respondent wrote. "Faculty will have to get more adept at pursuing non-federal sources, but that is unlikely to cover the gap. Faculty and students alike are all very concerned, and I suspect some students will start to leave the program prematurely if they perceive academia/national labs as an increasingly nonviable path for the future."

Although only three respondents said they have rescinded at least one offer of enrollment, several said their university administration did not allow them to make follow-up offers when an offer was declined. Others reported that their departments have limited their funding offers to only cover the first year of study or have removed language that commits to providing funding.

In addition, 18% of departments reported that at least one of their faculty members had federal funding terminated or reduced, and another 28% expected such news in the next six months.

EMOTIONAL TOLL

Several department chairs described a climate of intense stress and decreased morale among faculty and students. One respondent characterized the effects so far as “mostly psychological,” as researchers anticipate cuts to grants and indirect cost rates that they believe will eliminate staff, leave scientific infrastructure to deteriorate, and set back young scientists’ careers. “One cannot work like this – all energy goes in thinking how to survive and not think in physics – it is like being in the war,” another department chair wrote. “No one can be productive in climate like this – It is the end of the US scientific and technical dominance in the world – we will not recover from this in a decade,” they added.

The funding uncertainty has also led to faculty and staff hiring freezes. One respondent expressed concern that their institution would be unable to replace retiring faculty in the long term.

Many department chairs also expressed concern regarding the Trump administration’s border policies and their impacts on foreign researchers and international travel. One respondent said undergraduate students at their university have had their visas revoked, and another said they have witnessed a “chilling effect” on foreign postdocs and students. News outlets have reported cases of student arrests or deportations following revoked visas. One respondent wrote that graduate students are now more interested in searching for positions abroad, while another said some scientists are leaving the country because of the unpredictable and hostile environment.

Traveling researchers often discuss what to delete from their phones and consider using burners, another respondent said, adding that British and Canadian researchers avoided their most recent meeting. A French scientist garnered attention in March after being denied U.S. entry on his way to a conference, and last week the Canadian Association of University Teachers issued travel guidance warning its members against non-essential travel to the U.S.

4/25/25: From: Van Scoyoc Associates <kmorrison@vsadc.com>
Subject: Washington Week in Science – April 25, 2025

A Weekly Update of Science Policy News and Select Funding Opportunities

NIH grants plummeted \$2.3 billion in Trump’s first months, as federal-academia partnership crumbles

The National Institutes of Health has scaled back its awards of

new grants by at least \$2.3 billion since the beginning of the year, with the biggest shortfalls hitting the study of infectious diseases, heart and lung ailments, and basic research into fundamental biological systems, a new STAT analysis has found. This roughly 28% contraction in funding comes on top of threats to freeze billions of dollars of NIH funding to specific universities as well as abrupt terminations to hundreds of research projects on Covid-19, HIV/AIDS, health disparities, vaccine hesitancy, and other areas targeted by President Trump's political agenda. Read more: [STAT News](#)

No NIH grants for colleges with DEI programs or Israel boycotts

If colleges and universities want to receive funding from NIH, they'll have to certify they don't operate any diversity, equity, and inclusion or accessibility programs that violate federal antidiscrimination laws, under a new NIH policy announced Monday. The new policy also bars colleges from boycotting Israel or Israeli businesses if they want to receive NIH grants. Read more: [Inside Higher Ed](#)

NIH guts its first and largest study centered on women

President Donald Trump's administration appears to be killing much, if not all, of a historic initiative that was the first, and is still the largest, National Institutes of Health (NIH) effort centered on the health needs of women. The Women's Health Initiative (WHI) has enrolled tens of thousands of participants in clinical trials of hormones and other medications and tracked the health of many thousands more over more than 3 decades. Its findings have had a major influence on health care. WHI leaders announced yesterday that contracts supporting its regional centers are being terminated in September and that the study's clinical coordinating center, based at the Fred Hutchinson Cancer Center, "will continue operations until January 2026, after which time its funding remains uncertain." Read more: [Science](#)

RFK Jr. eyes reversing CDC's Covid-19 vaccine recommendation for children

HHS Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. is weighing pulling the Covid-19 vaccine from the government's list of recommended immunizations for children, two people familiar with the discussions told POLITICO. The directive under consideration would remove the Covid shot from the childhood vaccine schedule maintained by the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention and widely used by physicians to guide vaccine distribution, marking

Kennedy's most significant move yet to shake up the nation's vaccination practices. Read more: Politico

House oversight Democrat demands answers on gutting of CDC public records office

The top Democrat on the House Committee on Oversight and Accountability wants answers from the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention about why its public records staff was gutted on April 1, when thousands of federal health agency workers were fired. Rep. Gerry Connolly, a Democrat from Virginia, sent a letter to CDC's acting director Dr. Susan Monarez on Thursday, expressing "concern" about the 22 staffers who handled and fulfilled public records requests being placed on administrative leave until their jobs are eliminated on June 2. Read more: NPR

FDA milk quality program suspended after job cuts

The Food and Drug Administration is suspending a quality control program for testing milk and other dairy products due to a size reduction in its food safety and nutrition division. According to Reuters, an internal email from the FDA's Division of Dairy Safety stated the agency was suspending its proficiency testing program for Grade "A" raw milk and finished products effective Monday. Read more: NewsNation

Trump administration cancels top NASA climate lab's lease at Columbia University

The Trump administration canceled the lease for its top climate monitoring lab, located in New York City, as of May 31, according to an email seen by CNN. In the email, the director of the NASA Goddard Spaceflight Center in Maryland informed employees of the impending closure of the NASA Goddard Institute for Space Studies and transitioning to remote work. Read more: CNN

Bipartisan caucus criticizes proposed NASA science budget cuts

The bipartisan co-chairs of the Congressional Planetary Science Caucus have criticized the proposed cuts in NASA's science programs, marking the first Republican opposition in Congress to the plans. In an April 15 statement, Reps. Judy Chu (D-CA) and Don Bacon (R-NE) said they were "extremely alarmed" by reports that the draft budget proposal for fiscal year 2026 would cut NASA's science budget in half. Read more: Space News

Trump-appointed National Science Foundation leader resigns

National Science Foundation Director Sethuraman Panchanathan abruptly resigned Thursday afternoon, more than a year before the end of his term. "I believe that I have done all I can to advance the mission of the agency and feel that it is time for me to pass the baton to new leadership," Panchanathan said in an all-staff memo obtained by POLITICO's E&E News. Read more: Politico

NSF ends DEI and misinformation research grants

The National Science Foundation announced last week it is terminating grants related to diversity, equity, and inclusion or combating misinformation. The decision applies to grants that involve engaging with people based on characteristics that are protected from discrimination under various laws, such as race, color, religion, sex, and national origin. It also applies to research that "could be used to infringe on the constitutionally protected speech rights of American citizens across the United States in a manner that advances a preferred narrative about significant matters of public debate." NSF stated that such grants no longer "effectuate" agency priorities, language that has been used by the Trump administration as a legal mechanism to terminate active awards. Read more: AIP

4/25/25: From FYI:

...DOGE stated that NSF canceled 402 "wasteful DEI grants" in a post on X last Friday, the day of NSF's announcement. The New York Times reported that the list of terminated grants totaled over 400 and a crowdsourced list includes hundreds. Based on the crowdsourced list, the divisions with the most grant cuts currently include Research on Learning in Formal and Informal Settings, Behavioral and Cognitive Sciences, Computer and Network Systems, Engineering Education and Centers, and Equity for Excellence in STEM.

...The announcement also notes that the grant terminations are not limited to, DEI and misinformation. The administration has targeted climate research grants at other agencies based on a January executive order.

...NSF has been particularly involved in funding diversity, equity, and inclusion efforts through its "broader impacts" grant review criterion, which assesses a project's potential to benefit society based on seven goals, including expanding participation of women and individuals from underrepresented groups in STEM. Those goals are defined by a legal statute that cannot be removed or altered without action by Congress.

The agency acknowledged this goal in its announcement but

indicated that it will no longer fund activities to only engage with these groups. Rather, these activities may only be conducted “as part of broad engagement activities” that are “open and available to all Americans,” the announcement states. Furthermore, grantees may expand STEM participation based on non-protected characteristics, such as institutional type, geography, socioeconomic status, and career stage, but NSF cautioned that such activities “cannot indirectly preference or exclude individuals or groups based on protected characteristics.”

“Projects that aim to create more opportunities for more people in every region of the country to participate in science and technology remain an important part of NSF’s mission,” the agency stated.

4/25/25: IHE. NSF Director Resigns

By Kathryn Palmer

<<https://www.insidehighered.com/author/kathryn-palmer>>

Sethuraman Panchanathan, director of the National Science Foundation, resigned Thursday after nearly five years at the helm. His resignation comes less than one week after he issued sweeping priority changes—including terminating funding for projects that focus on diversity, equity and inclusion or combating misinformation—at the independent agency that funds billions of dollars to nonmedical university research each year.

“I believe that I have done all I can to advance the mission of the agency and feel that it is time to pass the baton to new leadership,” Panchanathan wrote in a resignation letter, first reported by /Science/. “I am deeply grateful to the presidents for the opportunity to serve our nation.”

Although it’s not immediately clear what prompted his resignation, Panchanathan is among the latest top federal officials who have resigned since President Trump started his second term in January. The administration has also fired thousands of other federal employees, including dozens at the NSF, and terminated many grants that don’t align with the agency’s new anti-DEI priorities. Additionally, Republican senator Ted Cruz of Texas has been targeting the agency for months calling it a bastion of “a far-left ideology.”

According to /Science/, even more changes are coming to the NSF. The Department of Government Efficiency reportedly told Panchanathan earlier this month to plan to fire half the NSF’s 1,700-person staff; the Office of Management and Budget reportedly told him that Trump only plans to request 55 percent of the agency’s \$9 billion budget for

fiscal year 2026.

"While NSF has always been an efficient agency," he wrote in his resignation letter, "we still took [on] the challenge of identifying other possible efficiencies and reducing our commitments to serve the scientific community even better."

Trump picked Panchanathan, a computer scientist from India who previously worked as a top research administrator at Arizona State University, to run the agency during his first term in office. But soon after Panchanathan started his six-year term in 2020, voters rejected Trump's bid for re-election, and most of Panchanathan's work at the NSF happened under former president Joe Biden's administration.

Under Panchanathan's leadership, the NSF's stated priorities have included increasing diversity in the STEM workforce, forming industry partnerships, job creation and broadening research opportunities for smaller universities and community colleges. In 2022, Panchanathan oversaw the creation of the NSF's Directorate for Technology, Innovation and Partnerships, which is focused on "accelerating breakthrough technologies, transitioning these technologies to the market, and preparing Americans for better-quality, higher-wage jobs," according to the NSF's website <<https://www.nsf.gov/tip/latest>>.

Despite the second Trump administration's quick and radical changes to some of those Biden-era policies, Panchanathan was seemingly adapting-up until his resignation Thursday-while many other scientists sound the alarm that Trump's policies will hurt research and innovation.

In his statement on the NSF's reoriented priorities last Friday, he said that any NSF-funded activities in support of "broadening participation" in STEM "must aim to create opportunities for all Americans everywhere" and "not preference some groups at the expense of others, or directly/indirectly exclude individuals or groups."

4/25/25: From: "Patterson, Ricky (rjp0i)" <ricky@virginia.edu>
To: "Majewski, Steven R (srm4n)" <srm4n@virginia.edu>,
"astro-faculty@virginia.edu" <astro-faculty@virginia.edu>
Subject: Re: [astro-faculty] NSF hoax?

With the chaos surrounding other agencies, and the abrupt resignation of the NSF Director yesterday just ahead of a promised/threatened 50% staff cuts and 55% funding cuts for NSF, I think that it would be prudent to be sure that you have copies of all of your grant related documentation downloaded from Research.gov.

However, some of the first people that raised the alarm yesterday about Research.gov going down with loss of data expected have now

updated their messaging to say that they now believe these fears to be not well-founded.

<https://bsky.app/profile/jeremymberg.bsky.social/post/3lnnlwivq4227>
[bsky.app]

(here is the original post from yesterday at 5pm:
<https://bsky.app/profile/jeremymberg.bsky.social/post/3lnlmlvf23s23>
[bsky.app])

Hope this is helpful (as we've all been reduced to a reliance on rumors to stay ahead of potential purges)

4/25/25: From: Astronomy Department Chairs <Astro-Chairs@virginia.edu>

To: Faculty Department <astro-faculty@virginia.edu>,
"astro-staff@virginia.edu" <astro-staff@virginia.edu>
Subject: [astro-faculty] American Institute of Physics Survey

Earlier this month the AIP's Research Team conducted a brief survey to help them better understand the impact of recent federal funding decisions on physics and astronomy departments.

They have just published a report highlighting our findings. Here is a link to thereport: <http://n-physics-and-astronomy-graduate-programs.wv2.aip.org>

They found that:

- More than a third of the responding departments expect to enroll fewer first-year graduate students for the Fall 2025 semester. Many told them that the situation was still fluid when they contacted them.
- The expected total decline is around 13%, or about 600 first-year students. Many believe the decline will be even larger for the Fall 2026 semester.
- Almost half of the departments responding had experienced either lost or reduced federal funding (18%) or anticipated losing funding within the next six months (28%).
- Departments at private institutions are more likely to have experienced or anticipate a loss or reduction of funding.
- When the AIP asked, very few departments had rescinded offers of graduate school acceptance. Many described making offers for only one year of funding or writing the offers so that rescission would be easier.

I'm very glad that we were among the Astronomy Department to have maintained our traditional graduate class size, and that we did not alter our standard admissions offers or protocols. We were able to do this in confidence in part because of the support we had been assured by the Graduate School of Arts and Sciences.

Unfortunately, the overall situation does impact the prospects for our undergraduate majors, and this means we must redouble our efforts to be straightforward in our discussions about the realities of the field and to provide viable counsel and mentorship in the countless rewarding and remunerative career pathways that our degree programs afford.

Steve

4/28/25: FYI

MORE GRANT TERMINATIONS, DEFERRED RESIGNATION OFFERS AT NSF

The National Science Foundation announced a second round of grant terminations last Friday, stating [aip.us17.list-manage.com] the decision reflected the agency's "commitment to funding research opportunities for all Americans everywhere." The first round [aip.us17.list-manage.com] came a week earlier, eliminating over 400 active grants, according to the Department of Government Efficiency. A crowdsourced database [aip.us17.list-manage.com] of NSF grant terminations over the last two weeks currently includes over 500 grants, the largest share of which falls under the STEM Education directorate. Members of the union representing NSF issued an open letter [aip.us17.list-manage.com] to scientific societies asking them to mobilize their members to reach out to local media outlets, contact their members of Congress, post on social media, and more "to mitigate the unfolding crisis and the threat to the long-term viability of NSF."

NSF also re-offered deferred resignation plans to its employees following the resignation of agency director Sethuraman Panchanathan last Thursday. Employees must apply by the end of the day on May 8, and those who do will be placed on administrative leave by May 23. The memo, reviewed by FYI, "encourages" all NSF employees to consider accepting the deferred resignation agreement "in light of future restructuring, staffing reductions, and constrained budget environments." It adds that reduced leadership positions, "standardization across directorates and increased centralization," and the possibility of "significant workforce reductions" are expected in the coming months.

4/30/25: Watched several presentations at an open session of the

NAS Board on Physics and Astronomy. From the DOE, NSF, and NASA Astrophysics.

They were strictly on the accomplishments of the agencies over the last year or so. There was no reference to the incredible cuts the Trump administration has already made or those it intends to make. And none of the questioners (in the room or online) raised the issue either.

The NASA presenter started with about 5 minutes on the Roman mission.

The DOE presenter went out of her way to praise the new Trump appointee to the leadership of DOE.

Of course, the unprecedented attack of science by Trump may have been a hot topic in the executive sessions.

DOE made a big pitch for its active development of AI in high-end computer simulations. 3 of the 6 topics illustrated were astronomical(!)

4/30/25: ArsTechnica. RFK Jr. rejects cornerstone of health science: Germ theory / In his 2021 book vilifying Anthony Fauci, RFK Jr. lays out support for an alternate theory.

[Jesus Christ!]

...The trouble is that now that Kennedy is the country's top health official, his warped ideas are contributing to the rise of a dystopian reality. Federal health agencies are spiraling into chaos, and critical public health services for Americans have been brutally slashed, dismantled, or knee-capped—from infectious disease responses, the lead poisoning team, and Meals on Wheels to maternal health programs and anti-smoking initiatives, just to name a few. The health of the nation is at stake; the struggle to understand what goes on in Kennedy's head is vital.

While we may never have definitive answers on his cognitive situation, one thing is plain: Kennedy's thoughts and actions make a lot more sense when you realize he doesn't believe in a foundational scientific principle: germ theory.

Germ theory is, of course, the 19th-century proven idea that microscopic germs—pathogenic viruses, bacteria, parasites, and fungi—cause disease. It supplanted the leading explanation of disease at the time, the miasma theory, which suggests that diseases are caused by miasma, that is, noxious mists and vapors, or simply bad air arising from decaying matter, such as corpses, sewage, or rotting

vegetables.

Germ theory also knocks back a lesser-known idea called the terrain theory, which we've covered before. This is a somewhat ill-defined theory that generally suggests diseases stem from imbalances in the internal "terrain" of the body, such as malnutrition or the presence of toxic substances. The theory is linked to ideas by French scientist Antoine Béchamp and French physiologist Claude Bernard. Béchamp, considered a bitter crank and rival to famed French microbiologist Louis Pasteur, is perhaps best known for wrongly suggesting the basic unit of organisms is not the cell, but nonexistent microanatomical elements he called "microzyma."

...It's important to note here that our understanding of Kennedy's disbelief in germ theory isn't based on speculation or deduction; it's based on Kennedy's own words. He wrote an entire section on it in his 2021 book vilifying Fauci, titled *The Real Anthony Fauci*. The section is titled "Miasma vs. Germ Theory," in the chapter "The White Man's Burden."

In the chapter, Kennedy promotes the "miasma theory" but gets the definition completely wrong. Instead of actual miasma theory, he describes something more like terrain theory. He writes: "'Miasma theory' emphasizes preventing disease by fortifying the immune system through nutrition and by reducing exposures to environmental toxins and stresses." Kennedy contrasts his erroneous take on miasma theory with germ theory, which he derides as a tool of the pharmaceutical industry and pushy scientists to justify selling modern medicines. The abandonment of miasma theory, Kennedy bemoans, realigned health and medical institutions to "the pharmaceutical paradigm that emphasized targeting particular germs with specific drugs rather than fortifying the immune system through healthy living, clean water, and good nutrition."

According to Kennedy, germ theory gained popularity, not because of the undisputed evidence supporting it, but by "mimicking the traditional explanation for disease—demon possession—giving it a leg up over miasma." To this day, Kennedy writes, a "\$1 trillion pharmaceutical industry pushing patented pills, powders, pricks, potions, and poisons, and the powerful professions of virology and vaccinology led by 'Little Napoleon' himself, Anthony Fauci, fortify the century-old predominance of germ theory."

In all, the chapter provides a clear explanation of why Kennedy relentlessly attacks evidence-based medicines; vilifies the pharmaceutical industry; suggests HIV doesn't cause AIDS and antidepressants are behind mass shootings; believes that vaccines are harmful, not protective; claims 5G wireless networks cause cancer; suggests chemicals in water are changing children's gender identities; and is quick to promote supplements to prevent and treat diseases,

such as recently recommending vitamin A for measles and falsely claiming children who die from the viral infection are malnourished.

..."It's so unbelievable, because you can't imagine that someone who's the head of Health and Human Services doesn't believe that specific viruses or bacteria cause specific diseases, and that the prevention or treatment of them is lifesaving." [Paul Offit]

..."He holds these beliefs like a religious conviction," Offit said. "There is no shaking him from that," regardless of how much evidence there is to prove him wrong. "If you're trying to talk him out of something that he holds with a religious conviction—that's never going to happen. And so any time anybody disagrees with him, he goes, 'Well, of course, they're just in the pocket of industry; that's why they say that.'"

Comments...

The whole foundation of the religious fools and ignorant zealots powering the conservative machine is a denial of fundamental reality. They firmly and adamantly believe that their superstition and ignorance are not simply equivalent to knowledge but superior to it. They're a blight on humanity and have been all along.

I would once again like to thank Senate Republicans for inflicting this known moron on the rest of us. I hope you're happy.

OK, fine. Here's a small (really small) sample of *Pseudomonas aeruginosa*. Let's just rub that into that little abrasion on your leg and wait a couple of days. Stay away from bad air or whatever else you like. We'll watch.

Sometimes it is not the political populism that angers me, but the celebration of sheer incompetence that comes with this government. I understand that the political pendulum swings back and forth between traditional and more forward-looking ideologies. But the thing we have here is just incompetence and stupidity. And it does a lot of damage to real people.

It's so freaking rich that a huge part of the Trump 2.0/MAGA2025 grift was "restoring meritocracy to government", only for them to fill the bureaucracy to the brim with meritless brain worm infected clowns like RFK Jr.

4/30/25: virginiabusiness.com. DOJ demands University of Virginia prove it's dismantling DEI

Leaked April letter came one day before U.Va. board vote

Kate Andrews <<https://viriniabusiness.com/author/kandrews/>>
//April 30, 2025//**

SUMMARY:

- * U.S. Department of Justice
<<https://viriniabusiness.com/blog/tag/department-of-justice/>>
sent letter to U.Va. <<https://viriniabusiness.com/blog/tag/u-va/>>
administration calling for university to produce report it has
dismantled and dissolved DEI
<<https://viriniabusiness.com/blog/tag/dei/>> initiatives
- * DOJ's Civil Rights Division gives school a May 2 deadline
- * U.Va. Board of Visitors
<<https://viriniabusiness.com/blog/tag/board-of-visitors/>> voted
to
dissolve DEI office March 7
- * DOJ letter says it has received complaints that U.Va. has not made
30-day report public and possibly has not taken action on board's
mandate

The University of Virginia's president, rector and university legal counsel received a letter Monday from the U.S. Department of Justice's Civil Rights Division calling for the university to produce audio and video from a closed session of its board of visitors last month, as well as show evidence that every division of the university and its health system has dissolved and dismantled its diversity, equity and inclusion initiatives, following a board vote in March.

The DOJ's letter, dated April 28, says its civil rights office has received complaints that U.Va.'s administration has not made public a required 30-day report on its progress in ending DEI operations throughout the university, and alleges that U.Va. "may have failed to implement these directives." The letter gives U.Va. President Jim Ryan, the university's rector and legal counsel a May 2 deadline to update the Justice Department's civil rights office on its progress.

Arriving one day before a Tuesday special meeting of the BOV, during which members voted on a second DEI-related resolution, the letter was signed by Harmeet K. Dhillon, the newly appointed assistant attorney general for the DOJ's civil rights division and a U.Va. law school alum, as well as Deputy Assistant Attorney General Gregory W. Brown and senior counsel Jeffrey Morrison.

According to the letter, the DOJ issued letters to U.Va.'s undergraduate institution and its law school on April 11 and April 18 regarding admissions practices, "particularly regarding racial preferences" after the U.S. Supreme Court's 2023 ruling to strike down affirmative action policies in college admissions, as well as executive orders issued by President Donald Trump to dismantle DEI "apparatuses and instruments of discrimination based on race, skin

color, ethnicity, national origin and other impermissible, immutable characteristics.”

The letter issues a May 2 deadline for the university to produce the official BOV resolution from March 7, “along with all written or electronic records (including audio or video recording) of the ... public and closed session meeting and deliberations,” as well as certification that the resolution’s dictates are being enacted at every part of the university, including the UVA Health system and all of U.Va.’s undergraduate, graduate and professional programs and schools.

The letter also calls for “all reports submitted by you or members of your administration” to the board and the rector from around April 7 regarding the execution of DEI dissolution at U.Va.

“Per the directives of the Board of Visitors and that unanimous [March 7] resolution, your office and you were required to report to the Board of Visitors within thirty days, confirming the total elimination of DEI at the University of Virginia,” the letter says, adding that the civil rights department has “received complaints that your office and the university may have failed to implement these directives and further that you have refused to produce the report on the matter.”

The DOJ letter was made public on the C’ville Bubble account <<https://x.com/CvilleBubble/status/1917059868197872013>> on X Monday, the day before U.Va.’s board met in a special session in part to discuss progress on the dissolution of U.Va.’s DEI office and other DEI initiatives.

Also on Monday, The Jefferson Council, a group of conservative U.Va. alumni who have been critical of the university’s leadership particularly over pro-Palestine student protests, claims of antisemitism and free speech issues, posted Ryan speaking in an undated video about the board’s then-upcoming March 7 vote. According to the Jefferson Council’s post, Ryan was addressing the U.Va. Faculty Senate about the DEI resolution.

“The board would like to talk to us about that update,” Ryan says in the one-minute video. “I will say I’m optimistic we’re going to end up in a good place.”

However, the council alleges that “multiple Jefferson Council researchers and allies have had their FOIA requests for the 30-day DEI report denied – a stonewalling that The Cavalier Daily independently encountered as well.”

On Tuesday, board members met at the Boar’s Head Resort off campus and voted for a resolution that says in part that “the University of Virginia has made progress on implementing the directives of the Board

of Visitors' March 7 resolution on diversity, equity and inclusion, and additional work remains to be done to ensure and advance open inquiry at the university and to best prepare students to become citizen-leaders ready to serve our community."

The resolution also rescinds a September 2020 resolution that "endorsed pursuit of numerical goals for the composition of students and faculty," a policy that called for U.Va. to hire more faculty from underrepresented racial and ethnic groups, as well as more women in certain fields, and to aim to diversify its student body as well.

Moreover, the April 29 resolution calls for the president, interim provost and an appointee of the U.Va. Faculty Senate to report to the board at its next meeting in June on "work being done to ensure an intellectual climate and campus culture where all students, faculty and staff are able to express politically diverse views, engage in constructive discussion across differences, and respond to competing perspectives in good faith."

Ryan was among more than 550 university and college presidents and other higher education leaders who signed an American Association of Colleges and Universities letter issued April 22 that condemned what they call the Trump White House's "unprecedented government overreach and political interference," including threatening to pull approved federal funding for university research and revoking international students' visas or terminating their legal statuses.

Of the six Virginia presidents who signed the letter, Ryan was the only head of a public university to do so.

U.Va. and the DOJ's Civil Rights Division did not immediately respond to requests for comment Wednesday.

4/30/25: Nature. Trump team's science cuts threaten tenure hopes for early-career academics / As funding dries up, US universities will need to reconsider traditional tenure requirements.

...Johnson's not alone. For other early-career researchers who spoke to Nature, the path to meeting standard tenure expectations now seems blocked, and they are looking to their universities for guidance on how to proceed. Since Trump began his presidency, US agencies such as the National Science Foundation (NSF) and the National Institutes of Health (NIH) that fund science have been slashing research awards that don't align with the administration's political ideology. They've also been freezing grants to universities with DEI programmes, or that the administration says have failed to protect their students from antisemitism. (Harvard University in Cambridge, Massachusetts, yesterday released reports initiated in 2024 by internal task forces that found evidence of this type of discrimination – as well as

discrimination against Muslim and Arab students – and has pledged reform.)

These and other actions by the Trump team have left many researchers in limbo, waiting for funding that might never arrive, or scrambling to find other sources of financial support, to keep their teams intact.

Annika Barber, a molecular biologist at Rutgers University in New Brunswick, New Jersey, says that for many laboratories, including hers, even a three- to six-month gap in funding means that people have to be fired.

...Possibilities under consideration include bridge funding – whereby a university provides temporary financing until a long-term solution is found – and modifying the requirements of tenure. The group hasn't yet made any specific requests of Rutgers, but Barber says its members think that tenure extensions – giving researchers more time to meet requirements – won't work in this situation, because there's no guarantee that funding will ever be restored.

Johnson agrees that a tenure-clock extension probably won't solve the problem. "I don't know how we could still meet the tenure requirements" if US science budgets continue to be targeted, she says. Media outlets have reported that Trump will be requesting a reduction of about 40% in the NIH's spending for fiscal year 2026, for example.

...Even with university support, researchers are getting creative about funding their work. Quinnehtukqut McLamore, a social psychologist in their first year as a faculty member at the University of Missouri in Columbia, sees no way to secure federal funding in time for a tenure review. They spent months developing a study in response to an August call for proposals from the NSF for research that supports LGBT+ people in science. But McLamore abandoned the effort after Trump took office in January and signed anti-LGBT+ policies, including one that recognizes only two sexes, male and female.

...They warn that tenure itself is under threat – and therefore might not be a goal to work towards any more. Members of Trump's Republican Party have been trying to weaken tenure for years, suggesting that it protects poorly performing academic workers from dismissal. Two Republican-controlled states, Kentucky and Ohio, passed legislation in March making it easier to fire tenured professors at public universities; other Republican-led states, including Nebraska and North Dakota, are considering similar bills.

5/1/25: Nature. Exclusive: NSF stops awarding new grants and funding existing ones / US science funder also plans to screen grant applications for compliance with 'agency priorities'.

Staff members at the US National Science Foundation (NSF) were told on 30 April to "stop awarding all funding actions until further notice," according to an email seen by Nature. The policy prevents the NSF, one of the world's biggest supporters of basic research, from awarding new research grants and from supplying allotted funds for existing grants, such as those that receive yearly increments of money. The email does not provide a reason for the freeze and says that it will last "until further notice"

Earlier this week, NSF leadership also introduced a new policy directing staff members to screen grant proposals for "topics or activities that may not be in alignment with agency priorities". Proposals judged not "in alignment" must be returned to the applicants by NSF employees. The policy has not been made public but was described in documents seen by Nature.

An NSF staff member says that although good science can still be funded, the policy has the potential to be "Orwellian overreach". Another staff member says, "They are butchering the gold standard merit review process that was established at NSF over decades". One program officer says they are resigning because of the policy. Nature spoke with five NSF staffers for this story, all on the condition of anonymity because they are not authorized to speak to the media.

The changes are hitting an agency already in crisis. In the past two weeks, the NSF has terminated roughly 1,040 grants that would have awarded US\$739 million to researchers and their institutions. The agency's director, Sethuraman Panchanathan, resigned last month.

...Funding for the NSF, as for all other federal agencies, is set by the US Congress. To date, the agency has received only about one-quarter of the funding that Congress appropriated to it for the current fiscal year, which ends on 30 September.

It is not clear whether a funding shortfall is driving the latest grant freeze. But Matthew Lawrence, a specialist in administrative law at Emory University in Atlanta, Georgia, says that under a 1974 law called the Impoundment Control Act, the NSF must give Congress special notice of the grant halt, which would otherwise be unlawful.

Cuts to NSF spending this year could be a prelude to a dramatically reduced budget next year. Science previously reported that US President Donald Trump will request a \$4 billion budget for the agency in fiscal year 2026, a 55% reduction from what Congress appropriated

for 2025. Similarly, the proposed 2026 budget for the National Institutes of Health calls for a 44% cut to the agency's \$47 billion budget in 2025, according to documents leaked to the media. During Trump's first term, Republicans in Congress rejected many of the president's requested cuts to science funding, but it is not clear that they will do so again.

In the long term, severe reductions to science funding could damage the economy, according to new research. A report by economists at American University in Washington DC estimates that a 50% reduction in federal science funding would reduce the US gross domestic product by approximately 7.6%¹. "This country's status as the global leader in science and innovation is seemingly hanging by a thread at this point," one NSF staffer says.

5/2/25: From: "Majewski, Steven R (srm4n)" <srm4n@virginia.edu>
To: "astro-faculty@virginia.edu" <astro-faculty@virginia.edu>,
"Johnson, Barbara Kay (bkn9x)" <bkn9x@virginia.edu>

Subject: [astro-faculty] Fwd: Adoption of Standard 15% Indirect Cost Rate for NSF Grants and Cooperative Agreements awarded to Institutions of Higher Education

Hello –

I haven't received this notice from NSF, even though a colleague of mine at another institution did.

–sm

Begin forwarded message:

Subject: Fw: Adoption of Standard 15% Indirect Cost Rate for NSF Grants
and Cooperative Agreements awarded to Institutions of Higher Education
Date: May 2, 2025 at 2:54:36 PM EDT
To: "srm4n@virginia.edu" <srm4n@virginia.edu>

From: NSF eBusiness Outreach <EBUSINESS@LISTSERV.NSF.GOV> on behalf of NSF Business Applications <NSF_Business_Applications@NSF.GOV>

Sent: Friday, May 2, 2025 12:39 PM
To: Nidever, David <david.nidever@montana.edu>
Subject: Adoption of Standard 15% Indirect Cost Rate for NSF Grants and Cooperative Agreements awarded to Institutions of Higher Education

The U.S. National Science Foundation (NSF) is updating its policy regarding the reimbursement of indirect costs in federally funded financial assistance. The Foundation is adopting a standard 15% indirect cost rate for NSF grants and cooperative agreements awarded to Institutions of Higher Education (IHEs). The policy will apply to all new NSF financial assistance awards to IHEs made on or after May 5, 2025. This change is intended to streamline funding practices, increase transparency, and ensure that more resources are directed toward direct scientific and engineering research activities.

5/2/25: From: American Astronomical Society <aas@aas.org>
Subject: The President's Budget Request and a Call to Action

The President's Fiscal Year 2026 Budget Request proposes slashing \$163 billion in federal spending. Please engage with us at the AAS to make our voices heard!

Dear Colleague,

As you may have seen, the President's Fiscal Year 2026 Budget Request* was released today. This budget request provides suggestions for the level of funding that Congress should appropriate for federal programs. The plan proposes slashing \$163 billion in federal spending for the next fiscal year, which includes a 56% cut to the National Science Foundation, a 47% cut to NASA's Science Mission Directorate, and a 14% cut to the Department of Energy's Office of Science. These proposed cuts are certainly alarming, and the AAS Board of Trustees has released a statement highlighting the potential impacts if such cuts were to be enacted. If you are interested in reading more, Colin Hamill has written a blog post explaining today's budget request in more detail.

While the proposed cuts to our science agencies are deeply concerning, it is important to remember that the President's Budget Request is not law, it is only a proposal. Congress holds the power of the purse and will ultimately pass bills that set the funding levels for FY26. During the first Trump administration, we saw large cuts to science funding in the budget request, but Congress largely ignored those cuts and chose to increase federal funding for the sciences. However, for a multitude of reasons, we cannot assume the current Congress will do the same this time. The President's Budget Request should serve as a call to action for our community – we are facing an existential threat, and we must actively engage with Congress to show why the work that we do is meaningful for the nation.

Next week, AAS will be hosting a week of action, calling on all of us to take a few minutes each day to engage in advocacy, whether that be calling and emailing your members of Congress, or educating yourself

on federal science funding through a journal club. You can find details for the week of action here, and keep an eye out on AAS social media channels for daily guidance. I also encourage you to request a Zoom or local meeting with your congressional offices and consider inviting a congressional staffer to your institution/department. I met with my own congressional office in Tucson a week ago, and earlier this week, the faculty at Michigan State University invited a staffer from their Representative's office to visit the department. We need more voices to do the same. Please reach out to the AAS public policy team (public.policy@aas.org) and they would be thrilled to assist you with setting up such meetings. If you would like to opt-in to regular communications from the AAS policy team about advocacy actions you can take, please fill out this short form.

We are in unprecedented times of risk for scientific research. These times call for extraordinary action if we want our elected representatives and the public to continue to support this critical work. Please engage with us at the AAS to make our voices heard!

– Dara Norman, AAS President

* Note that the request released today is a “skinny” budget, which generally does not include proposed budgets at the division or program level for these agencies. We expect more detailed information to be released later this month.

5/2/25: WP. Amid DOGE-induced turmoil, National Science Foundation in crisis / The \$9 billion agency exists entirely to fund science researchers, projects and facilities outside its Alexandria, Virginia, headquarters. It's had to hit reverse on its main mission.

From Antarctic research stations to telescopes high in the Andes to research submarines miles below the waves – and in laboratories and classrooms across the United States – the fingerprint of the National Science Foundation is vast and consequential. The 75-year-old government agency has one function: keep the U.S. science enterprise at the leading edge.

In the last two weeks, however, the \$9 billion agency, which exists entirely to fund science researchers, projects and facilities outside its Alexandria, Virginia, headquarters, hit reverse on its main mission. NSF has been forced to cancel more than a thousand active research grants. Funding for new research has slowed to a crawl, as the agency has awarded half the number of grants since President Donald Trump's inauguration compared to the same period in 2024, according to a Washington Post analysis of the NSF grants database. On top of that, officials are running budget scenarios of drastic cuts for next year.

Now there's a leadership vacuum. Last week, NSF director Sethuraman Panchanathan abruptly resigned, writing in an email to staff: "I have done all I can."

NSF funds basic science research, the kinds of questions sparked by curiosity that may have no clear application and little interest from corporations or philanthropies, but can deepen our understanding of nature, spawn new industries and change the world. An NSF-funded observatory was the first to detect ripples in space-time predicted by Albert Einstein. NSF's basic research into circuits and transistors helped advance the chips that power modern technology. Some 268 Nobel laureates have received funding from the agency.

The first months of Trump's second presidency have been marked by the unraveling of a historic relationship between research institutions and federal government. That partnership, forged in the wake of World War II, has powered American science preeminence.

...The journal Science reported that Trump's draft budget proposal, which has not yet been submitted to Congress, would cut 55 percent of the NSF budget.

..."The US science machine that is the envy of the world is about to be wrecked," Michael Turner, a cosmologist at the University of California at Los Angeles, said in an email. "If we go down the route of dismantling the great American science machine we will suffer the consequences in all aspects of life."

...While serving under President Joe Biden, Panchanathan oversaw new initiatives, mandated in congressional legislation, to broaden the impact of, and participation in, science. Researchers seeking grants have been required to describe how their work would advance those goals. Such efforts, which seek to diversify the demographics of the scientific community – historically dominated by White males – also are designed to expand funding for research in institutions in rural America and far from the coasts.

But the return of Trump put much of this in reverse. One of his first actions was banning the use of federal money for DEI research. NSF officials immediately complied, launching keyword-triggered reviews of grants, mining the agency's vast research portfolio for topics the administration no longer wanted to support, including DEI and "gender ideology." The immediate compliance with Trump's executive orders was viewed as a betrayal by many of his own employees, but Panchanathan continued. He went on to fire 10 percent of NSF's employees, despite internal anger – a blow that was later partly reversed.

...Then, in two tranches of cancellations, more than a thousand grants were terminated, most of them focused on DEI. Also targeted are

“misinformation” and “disinformation” research programs.

NSF has been the focus of Republican ire in recent years. Last year, Sen. Ted Cruz (R-Texas) released a staff report that claimed to have identified 3,483 NSF grants, totaling more than \$2 billion, that promoted DEI tenets or “pushed onto science neo-Marxist perspectives about enduring class struggle.” The Democratic staff of the House Science, Space and Technology Committee responded this year with its own report, saying the Cruz report contained “embarrassing mistakes” such as flagging grants focused on biodiversity. “At best, the Cruz Report is a sloppy mess that should be viewed as nothing more than the political hit job it is,” the report said.

...The grant terminations at NSF may not be legal, said Rep. Zoe Lofgren (California), the leading Democrat of the Science Committee. And if the Trump administration does, as has been speculated, push through drastic cuts to the budgets of NSF and other science agencies it will be a “disaster,” she said. “The vast majority of GDP growth in the United States is related to science and technology investments, and now we’re crushing it,” Lofgren said. “There’s plenty of things that could be made better at NSF. That’s different from gutting the agency.”

And the larger, flagship research infrastructure NSF runs – its telescopes, its observatories, its South Pole operations – will also be on the chopping block if extreme budget cuts are enacted, according to multiple people familiar with planning scenarios. “If the agency is operating at 50 percent capacity, how should the agency approach hard strategic decisions? Do you start shutting down astronomical observatories? Do you turn off all of Antarctic operations?” said a person familiar with the agency’s governance. “You have to look at the biggest ticket items.”

Comments...

**[Guy Montag] Trump’s butchering of the National Science Foundation isn’t fiscal conservatism—it’s the gleeful execution of American genius by a scientifically illiterate strongman and his army of know-nothing sycophants. Each canceled grant isn’t just a line item—it’s a murder weapon, snuffing out potential cures, technological revolutions, and the careers of young scientists who dared believe their country valued knowledge. His administration isn’t merely defunding DEI initiatives—it’s systematically erasing the voices and perspectives that actually drive innovation, replacing peer review with political purges led by the same troglodytes who think telescopes promote “neo-Marxism.”

[cont] The Antarctic researchers left stranded, the observatories going dark, the graduate students whose life’s work now ends with

a form email—these aren't collateral damage. They're casualties in Trump's jihad against intellect itself, waged to satisfy his base of science-denying zealots who cheer as America burns its own laboratories to own the libs. When China's labs lap ours, when our children inherit a wasteland of abandoned research and withered opportunity, when the last flicker of American scientific dominance gutters out—remember these cuts weren't necessary. They were spite, distilled into policy by a man who can't bear the thought of minds brighter than his own flourishing without his permission. History won't record this as budgeting — it'll stand as the moment America committed national suicide by stupidity.

They don't understand how fast scientific and tech leadership can move to other countries. A lot of the research is on things that are not immediately lucrative so companies won't do it, but will lead to things that may be transformative in 10 years or more. I have been involved in AI research for years. For a long time, it seemed to go nowhere but the NSF kept funding things that looked like they might be promising. And at some point around the 2000's, some of the approaches started to work well. And it got better, and now we have Gemini and ChatGPT and other tools, none of which would have ever been built without the years of NSF funded basic research. Other countries understand this and will grab our best researchers.

Three grants I work on are cancelled. They are completely gutting STEM education grants. More reporting on this please. I want people to understand it is even less likely that their child will have a competent physics teacher because of these incompetent criminals.

I'm a scientist. Twenty-five or thirty years ago, you rarely saw papers written by Chinese scientists in high quality scientific journals. Since then the fraction of papers written by Chinese authors has exploded. I have also visited China and seen their labs – they are filled with state-of-the-art equipment. I came away jealous. My point is that the Chinese are investing heavily in fundamental scientific research. And Europe is increasing their investment as well. It is completely idiotic for the US to be pulling back on fundamental scientific research at this time.

They are indeed investing in their country's future, and don't give a flying F&zk about billionaires.

The NSF funds the future for our grand children and their children. Cutting off funding may put money in our current billionaire's wallets, through tax reductions, but it will surely cost our country dearly by the end of the century.

Nothing screams "America First" like systematically torching the very scientific engine that made America first in the first place. After all, who needs basic research, Nobel Prizes, new industries, or GDP

growth when you can have a bloated, self-congratulating bureaucracy dedicated to witch hunts for scary words like "diversity" and "climate"? Truly inspiring work, canceling a thousand research grants is such a brilliant strategy to inspire the next generation of scientists... to move to Europe. And what a leadership masterstroke – NSF gutted, world-class telescopes shuttered, kids with dreams crushed before graduation – all so we can finally protect America from the terrifying menace of anole lizard genetics and "misinformation studies."

[cont] Meanwhile, DOGE's idea of efficiency seems to involve swapping out world-class scientists for political hacks whose qualifications include owning at least three MyPillow products and never having read a book without pictures. Congratulations – in record time, DOGE has managed to transform the National Science Foundation into the National Science Fiction Foundation, because at this rate, the only research left will be fanfiction written by Ted Cruz about Marxist salamanders. Truly, America is winning again.

If Trump really wants to keep America great (it doesn't really need to be made great, again) he would double NSF's budget (actually ask Congress to do so . . .). Just another example of how little he knows about what makes America great.

I have been involved in AI research for years. For a long time, it seemed to go nowhere but the NSF kept funding things that looked like they might be promising. And at some point around the 2000's, some of the approaches started to work well. And it got better, and now we have Gemini and ChatGPT and other tools, none of which would have ever been built without the years of NSF funded basic research. Other countries understand this and will grab our best researchers

We are rapidly destroying an entire generation of American scientific prowess. Of all Trumps multitude of self-inflicted wounds and disasters, this ranks near the top.

What will it take to get Republican legislators to speak up? There is nothing conservative or patriotic about destroying much that has made America great. Truly heartbreaking.

The NSF is a little known and relatively small agency that nevertheless has had a major impact on innovation and our economic success. The bulk of our graduate population (i.e PhDs) which populate our tech companies is due to NSF funding. The sums involved are tiny in comparison to other programs and the attack on NSF is purely ideological.

European universities are knocking on the door of my colleagues inviting them to leave the US. The brain drain begins.

There is nothing that Musk does that he doesn't owe to the federal funding of science. Period full stop.

DOGE has stupidity down to a science.

Trump is not making America great, he is literally destroying what makes it great, impressive, envied, and admired by other countries that could only dream of the ability to bankroll billions to keep their country at the cutting edge of technology and innovation. Those grants are what keeps this country making money and creating jobs that will last for decades. Trump is cutting "waste" because he doesn't understand what it takes to actually build or create anything. He's lives his whole life play-acting a businessman with Daddy's money.

they cancelled grants that had as a goal studying 'magma inclusions' .. something that happens under volcanos. Guess why

All NSF proposals were required to show how the proposed research is benefiting the community. Proposals without a clearly-labeled "statement of impact" were rejected. It is there where some DEI-like language was gratuitously copy-and-pasted by lazy proposers, something which back-fired under Trump.

[Successful proposals did tend to use the trendy DEI catchwords...but not because of laziness. That was EXPECTED under the revised grant protocols of the last five years. But yes, that backfired spectacularly. Scientists are now being punished for doing what the government required them to do.]

The idea of putting a hold on grants because the synopsis contains keywords like inclusive or bias is terrifying; can't these people read whole paragraphs?

I am a professor at a small public STEM university. Our grad program will absolutely be gutted if the current NSF "pause" on new awards and refusal to commit yearly increments of funding for existing awards continues.

These programs are EXACTLY what makes this country Great. In conjunction with our great universities, these are the incubators for the future of medicine, materials, energy and more.

Corporations are not interested in funding anything that will not be in a product in the next 5 years.

We're witnessing the revolt of the dummies. Stupid people don't understand science or its applications, and they resent people who do.

Science is involved with every aspect of our material lives.

They are smashing the machinery that built American supremacy. The nation elected vandals and looters to strip its own wealth.

The indisputable fact at the core of this issue is that for every dollar spent on research in the US we get something like \$4-5 of economic benefit.

It was foreign Scientists (Albert Einstein, Enrico Fermi, Neils Bohr, et al) that made valuable contributions to the USA. Even today, with 340 million or 4.1 % of the Globe's people, Science is one of the main factors that enables us to "punch above our weight". With Trump's "War on Science" at the EPA, NWS, NOAA, and now, at the NSF, we are falling into a Dark Age that will be hard to get out of. And all this to give \$4 Trillion in tax breaks to Millionaires and Billionaires who would never have become that rich, if they had been born in Bolivia or Bangladesh.

This is absolutely bonkers. The Trump administration is steering a course away from an economy based on innovation, and back to kids in factories screwing widgets. It's just stone age bonkers thinking.

We salute you Comrade Trump! Historians will credit your dismantling of NSF as a key milestone in the making of the Chinese Century!

The current Administration is truly a ship of fools. Through short-sightedness, greed, avarice, and sheer incompetence this Administration is killing the goose that has been laying gigantic golden eggs. Science fuels industry, and the US has been second-to-none and the envy of the world. No longer.

Back in the 1980s, the Nation at Risk report warned that if a foreign enemy had caused our schools to fail like they were, we'd see it as an act of war. Well, today the same thing is happening to the National Science Foundation. Only this time, it's not a foreign enemy—it's our own leaders cutting funding, ignoring science, and tearing down the very system that keeps us competitive. We're doing to ourselves what our enemies could only dream of. The question is---WHY?

The portion of Panchanathan's letter quoted in the article has apparently been cut from his letter as published on the NSF website: <https://www.nsf.gov/news/statement-director-sethuraman-panchanathan-his-departure>

The research cuts this administration is making across government is devastating, stupid, and totally at cross purposes with making America great.

Trump is in a tariff tizzy while at the same time while sabotaging the research engines that power American's leadership in science and medicine. How is this not a threat to national security?! Congress

needs to wake up and impeach this deluded fool who is overwhelmed by stale yet vile grievances.

5/2/25: FYI: Science Policy News from AIP
BULLETIN
May 2, 2025

Funding Cuts Hit STEM Career Pipelines Clare Zhang

NSF has already terminated hundreds of STEM education-related grants, and Trump's 2026 budget proposes even deeper cuts across the federal government.

Federal funding cuts are hitting STEM engagement programs across the career pipeline, from K-12 to postdocs and early-career faculty. Almost half of NSF's mass grant cancellations in April were in the Directorate for STEM Education and dozens of the agency's most prestigious early-career faculty grants were terminated, according to an agency list reviewed by FYI. Meanwhile, the president's budget request for fiscal year 2026 proposes cutting STEM engagement programs at a variety of agencies, including a \$4.7 billion reduction in funding for general research and education and broadening participation efforts at NSF.

According to a list provided by NSF's union representative, between April 18 and April 25, NSF canceled more than 1,000 active research grants; this number includes collaborative grants awarded to multiple institutions. Many of these were related to diversity, equity, and inclusion or misinformation, and the agency's announcement stated that the grants no longer "effectuate" agency priorities. NSF has since stopped disbursing grant funds, including for new grants and yearly allotments for current grants, and begun screening proposals for "topics or activities that may not be in alignment with agency priorities," Nature reported.

The president's budget request released today proposes further cuts to "climate; clean energy; woke social, behavioral, and economic sciences; and programs in low priority areas of science" as well as NSF's "broadening participation" efforts.

The elimination of grants deemed to be related to DEI has disproportionately affected grants for STEM education, with 213 cancellations in the Division of Research on Learning, which supports research on STEM learning and teaching in K-12 schools and other centers for STEM education, such as museums. The canceled grants pursued a range of strategies to engage with new audiences in STEM, such as implementing "inclusive" curricula, developing after-school programs, and shaping students' professional identity formation. Many

focus on women and Black and Latinx learners; NSF's recent announcement states that it will only fund activities to reach individuals from underrepresented groups in STEM "as part of broad engagement activities" that are "open and available to all Americans."

The Division of Undergraduate Education had 63 grants canceled, many of which similarly focus on researching or developing racially equitable learning environments. Other grant terminations are less clearly connected to the agency's new approach to DEI, such as a grant for an experiential learning program to expose undergraduates to the semiconductor industry, which references "systematically embedding diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility" into its activities "from student recruitment, educational program design, to course design."

NSF also funds summer research experiences for undergraduates through the REU program, which provides students with stipends and, in some cases, assistance with housing, meals, and travel. Each REU site is located at a university and supports eight to ten students per year from other institutions. Science reported in February that many REU sites seeking renewals for their expiring three-year grants were told that this summer's program had been canceled due to a lack of funding. On social media, researchers reported that NSF awarded 52 REU grants in 2025, compared to around 200 every year since 2015.

NSF additionally terminated 15 active grants for REU sites in April. Andrew Rice, the principal investigator for the REU site at Portland State University's Center for Climate and Aerosol Research, received a termination notice on April 25 informing him that the program would not receive the three-year, \$500,000 grant that the agency originally agreed to fund. The termination has put an end, at least for this year, to the university's 10-year-old program. Rice has notified this year's accepted students that the program has been canceled, as they no longer have the money to support students' stipends and housing, he said. "My experience is, if you want to really be very inclusive and allow everybody to do it, you do need to pay students to do that work," he added.

Rice noted that all REUs are open to all U.S. undergraduate students. Most of Portland State's REU participants come from two-year community colleges or four-year institutions that have fewer resources to support undergraduate research, and many of the participants have never conducted research before, he said.

The program gives these students exposure to the one-on-one mentorship of graduate programs, Rice said. "It really starts them on the right path," he added. "And for me, that's how I got started... I knocked on a bunch of doors until someone took me in, and... that's where I got hooked. That first research experience, I was like, 'This is really cool. Do they pay people to do this?'" The grant terminations also had

a significant effect on researchers at the graduate level and beyond, with 51 grant cancellations in the Division of Graduate Education, including 12 postdoctoral fellowships. One Bluesky user shared that his postdoctoral offer was rescinded following the termination of its underlying grant, while another said his wife is no longer receiving a salary after her grant was terminated. NSF also awarded 1,000 graduate research fellowships this year, compared to more than 2,000 every year since 2021. Additionally, 65 CAREER grants, NSF's most prestigious grants for early-career researchers, have been canceled.

STEM EDUCATION CUTS AT OTHER AGENCIES

The president's budget request proposes eliminating NASA's Office of STEM Engagement, stating that "NASA will inspire the next generation of explorers through exciting, ambitious space missions, not through subsidizing woke STEM programming and research that prioritizes some groups of students over others and have had minimal impact on the aerospace workforce."

So far, it is unclear how many STEM engagement grants have been canceled. NASA said in March that it canceled \$420 million in "unneeded contracts." The Department of Government Efficiency database and the NASA Grants database include canceled grants worth over \$600,000 total for workshops, conferences, and recruitment for professional societies, including the National Association of Black Physicists and the Society of Women Engineers.

The agency has also canceled two grants under its Science Activation program for community engagement, including the Native Earth | Native Sky project, a five-year grant in its final year that worked to develop and implement culturally relevant STEM curricula for Native American middle school students. "It's unclear to me why something like this would be cut. Because what we're really trying to do from a grand, 40,000-foot view is to get more young students, particularly middle schoolers, interested in all STEM fields," said Kat Gardner-Vandy, the principal investigator for Native Earth | Native Sky. "So to me, it means the result is fewer students who see themselves as scientists and who see themselves as wanting to grow up and perhaps go into these fields. And if we don't have that workforce, the United States is really going to fall pretty far behind the rest of the world in terms of STEM."

Furthermore, NASA appears poised to cancel the Here to Observe program that paired undergraduates from underrepresented groups and at smaller research universities with scientists running NASA missions, Science reported.

At the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, the president's 2026 budget request calls for more than a billion dollars in cuts to NOAA, specifically calling out "educational grant programs

[that] have consistently funded efforts to radicalize students against markets and spread environmental alarm.” This may refer to the agency’s Sea Grant program, which allocates millions of dollars a year for education and research at 34 colleges and universities. The agency already moved to cancel Maine’s Sea Grant program, possibly at Trump’s behest after he and the governor of Maine had a public argument, but agreed to “renegotiate” the \$4.5 million grant less than a week later.

5/2/25: WP. George Will. The Trump GOP’s attacks on universities advance the left’s agenda / The political attacks on Harvard and other educational institutions aren’t conservative at all.

Even academics are educable, so universities might emerge from their current travails improved – more willing to include intellectual diversity on campuses, or at least be more circumspect about impeding it. This is the good news.

The bad news: Republicans rejoicing about breaking academia to the saddle and bridle of federal government supervision demonstrate that we have two parties barely distinguishable in their shared enthusiasm for muscular statism. As “conservatives” mount sustained attacks on left-dominated educational institutions, they advance the left’s perennial agenda: the permeation of /everything/ with politics.

Such statism will extinguish THE core conservative aspiration: a civil society in constant creative ferment because intermediary institutions – schools, businesses, religious and civic organizations – are given breathing room, and are free to flourish or fail without supervision from above by a minatory central authority.

The president says he wants to “reclaim” the universities. His verb implies restoration: that the universities once were what he wants them to be, APPENDAGES OF THE FEDERAL GOVERNMENT, subject to its agendas, which shift with gusts from the electorate. Even if the administration were not FLAGRANTLY VIOLATING THE LAW (THE ADMINISTRATIVE PROCEDURE ACT) CONCERNING DUE PROCESS when freezing or withdrawing federal funds from universities, it would then be doing lawfully what should not be done at all.

The administration is right about protecting Jewish students from campus antisemitism. But this CONCERN LOOKS INCREASINGLY PRETEXTUAL as the administration broadens government’s reach to encompass universities’ admissions, hiring, administrative and curriculum decisions, and to punish plagiarism, and more.

The political class is to be trusted to define proper “viewpoint

diversity" in "each department, field, or teaching unit." (This language is from the administration's letter commanding Harvard University.) And to measure the government-enforced diversity that conservatives favor – a "critical mass" of appropriately diverse faculty hires – by its intellectual micrometer. And to police deviations from propriety.

A German concept used to validate the society-saturating politics infecting Europe 90 years ago was /Gleichschaltung/. It denoted totalistic government: the "coordinating" or "harmonizing" of all important social institutions. A foreign word, but no longer a foreign practice.

As a candidate in 2023, Donald Trump vowed to "choke off the money" to schools assaulting "Western civilization itself." As he defines this, and as he defines "assaulting" it. What could go wrong?

**America's research universities are sources of U.S. economic dynamism and vital to technology-dependent national security. It is folly (and unlawful) to punish entire institutions for the foolishness of a few departments. When English departments are "decolonized" – dead White men purged from the curriculum – the only victims are students deprived of Shakespeare. Ideological indoctrination is rarer in engineering departments, where knowing the right facts rather than having the right feelings matters, otherwise bridges crumble and skyscrapers tumble. Leave all departments alone, some because their silliness does not matter much, others because their excellence matters greatly.

Some Republicans want to further tax universities' endowments. There is a 1.4 percent tax on a few of the largest, which include thousands of individual funds dedicated to particular uses, and money for student aid. The crux of the conservative case against taxation of endowments is: Such taxation is partly /intended/ to further the homogenization of society – to enlarge government's sway by enfeebling a rival source of independent judgment and action.

More devastating than taxing endowments would be stripping institutions of what enables them to build endowments: their tax-exempt status and their donors' right to tax deductions. The president says the universities' exemptions are "totally contingent on acting in the public interest!" He seems to define this as CONFORMITY to his administration's agenda and preferences. As the next Democratic administration surely will do regarding its agenda. The IRS can be a hammer for pounding various institutions into obedience to the presidency of the moment.

...Today, each party pretends to be dramatically different from the other regarding philosophical fundamentals. Actually, they offer no

clear choice to voters who are wary of /any/ American Gleichschaltung. Both parties seem equally oblivious to the deep disharmony that inevitably accompanies attempts to harmonize all important sectors of civil society by melding political and cultural power.

What could go wrong? Look around.

Comments...

[AI summary] The comments overwhelmingly criticize George Will's attempt to equate the actions of both political parties regarding universities, with many arguing that the Trump administration's efforts to control universities are authoritarian and unprecedented. Commenters emphasize that the left's agenda is more aligned with education and democracy, while the right's actions are seen as destructive to academic freedom and democratic values. There is a strong sentiment that the false equivalency presented by Will distracts from the real threat posed by the current administration's policies

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I greatly appreciate George Will's robust defence of the value of research universities and academic freedom. On the other hand, I agree with almost everyone else here that the GOP now is, by far, a greater threat to the American system than any faction of the Democrats. What is most revealing about the column, however, is Will's assertion that the "foolish" wokeism of some humanities departments is hardly of serious consequence in the context of the importance of universities. Hasn't he devoted something like ten columns every year for the last couple decades to hammering universities about their progressive and post-modern tilt? That was not entirely undeserved -- but Will did more than his share to spread suspicion about the integrity of universities, and his former GOP colleagues were thrilled to pick that up and fashion it into a political battering ram against universities that not only drew MAGA glee but now threatens their independent existence.

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As an outsider (Canadian), that has voted for both conservatives and liberals in my over 40 years of adult life, what I see in Will's latest piece is an irresponsible false equivalency. Yes, the Democrats can, and sometimes do, overreach. But on the whole, they "get" the value of western liberal democracy - the broad brushstrokes - even if they sometimes go off course in the fog of ideological battle (woke, and all that). But MAGA is an entirely different creature - a monster, in fact. It is not open to any dissent, and

aggressively imperil dissent everywhere and every way. They operate based on: Might makes right. We are right. Lay the others to rubble. There is simply no equivalency.

Academia's Quasi Communism curriculum is a threat and has done damage to the party of Kennedy. Half the nation wishing to be European isn't a good trend and is a direct result of higher Ed. indoctrination. Much more damaging than the MAGA monster

I'm simply baffled by this reply. Does Bi-Polar-Violations really think that some obscure professors, speaking to a small segment of a student body, which is a portion of a minority segment of the USA (i.e., those attending degree granting institutions) is a bigger threat than a President that pardons January 6 insurrectionists, and empowers thug like squads to grab off the street, imprison, and deport human beings without a shred of due process, etc. etc. to infinity? The vast majority of Americans can ignore the pronoun police. But what happens when you turn law enforcement into unaccountable gangsters, or turn violent anti democratic militia into heroes for the sole reason that they are loyal to the Don?

Indeed, great point. We should make sure the children are indoctrinated to fear the countries ranking highest on the world happiness index, and go back to putting fear of the specter of communism into them. Surely that will help the country go back to the cherished ages that were a direct result of the New Deal.

Nonsense. Nonsense. And more Nonsense. Reading your responses to A Canadian Bob I'm reminded of what physicist Wolfgang Pauls said: "What you said, was so confused that one could not tell whether it was nonsense or not"

You can try to say this is a both sides issue. But at the moment there is only one party that is dismantling our constitutional rights. Only one party that is attempting to subdue the free press. Only one party that is using fear and intimidation to keep its own members in line.

George Will has been returning to the "both sides" well a lot lately ... which I guess is what you do when you're afraid to say, "the party I'm still bound to are becoming fascists." We're told universities are "woke" and discriminate against conservative opinions. There's no evidence, we're just told to believe it. On the other hand, the damage Trump is doing to the universities is measurable and very real. There's no "both sides" here, George.

Do try to get out of your epistemic bubble; reluctant though I am to use the Disparate Impact fallacy, the non-hiring (and sometimes firing) of conservative professors is striking. The president of Princeton (Mr Will's alma mater) for instance, was recently asked

to name a conservative professor other than its token conservative, and was unable to. (Partly because the other one was fired a couple of years ago, via double jeopardy after blaspheming one of the tribal gods, even though he had tenure.) Being Jewish didn't used to count as conservative, but the evidence for campus anti-semitism is overwhelming. I don't see how it could have escaped the notice of even a WaPo commenter, even if there has also been overreach on broadening the definition of anti-semitism to include constitutionally-protected hate speech, or even lack of support for Zionism. Mr Will, by the way, is uncharacteristically ahistorical here: "It is folly (and unlawful) to punish entire institutions for the foolishness of a few departments." I agree with President Reagan's unsuccessful veto of the relevant law, but it does mandate exactly that: All of Bob Jones University lost its tax exemption because of discrimination mandated by its strange God; all of Harvard is likewise unambiguously required to lose its tax exemption because of its strange gods.

Banning books, defunding support of Universities, elimination of the Department of Education, defunding science and research while installing unqualified anti-science loyalists in charge healthcare and the FDA, blatant lawlessness, etc. When exactly will you call it out for what it is? This is all authoritarian in nature, and fascism will rise from said authoritarian. Look at history to predict the future.

Statism in pursuit of repression and inequality and more wealth disparity is not equivalent to statism that attempts to promote equality and an equal distribution of wealth. The Republicans have gotten away with the "government is the problem" lie since Reagan.

The President is kidnapping people and sending them to life in prison, while grifting a crypto scam. That's reality George.

Anyone who thinks ANYTHING the Dems do is equal to or worse than what Trump et al are doing needs to have their head examined.

Wrong. Trump is trying to bend Universities to his will with government fiat. But the Democratic party has imposed no such fiat. If schools and faculty lean liberal it is because over generations there has been a free market place of ideas that drift to the left. The very substance of the subjects in humanities and social sciences force a liberal viewpoint: one cannot read *Les Misérables* and be Republican, at least not this current flavor of cruelty in the party. One cannot study America's history of slavery and be a white supremacist, one cannot study the economics of famine and not advocate for sharing wealth, one cannot study biology and ever advocate for creationism. A good education is truly a liberal education. Republicans just cannot accept that the free market place of ideas bypasses cynicism, greed, and cruelty.

Hiring policies for faculty in Ivy League schools in last 20 years suggest an otherwise a "not free marketplace of ideas." Or maybe just a coincidence that overwhelming majority of Ivy League faculty hired in last 20 years were already left leaning democrats?

The faculty hired are selected by the school and not under government fiat. There are Christian right wing universities in America that are not threatened by Trump, so he is being selective in his self righteous campaign against the woke DEI loving elites. The Republicans have been eager to bring down universities long before Trump.

Just a note, but those blue States comprise the worlds 5th largest economy. Red States not so much.

Actually, California alone is the world's 4th largest economy. All the blue states together might be the 3rd largest.

The 'left's agenda' is economic growth, social progress, national security and scientific discovery.

Maybe Harvard and other "elite" universities are liberal because an education helps one to see the world through a lens of acceptance and not one of domination. These institutions, for the most part, welcome diversity and accept that the world and society is changing. Unlike conservatives, who are always looking in the review mirror and talking about traditional values and trying to make the world a static place. All institutions have problems and need to make changes, but to think that a want-to-be dictator who brags about not reading and who cannot speak in complete thoughts knows what to do is ridiculous.

I never understand why Will always wants to say "Democrats do it, too" when they clearly don't.

Will fails to distinguish what Trump is doing (statist control of universities to promote a fascist agenda) from what universities have done on their own to ensure diversity.

Speaking from experience as a retired university professor, sadly, the academic "leftists" that Will fantasizes about hardly exist. "They" are a false stereotype fabricated through the rhetoric of right wing ideologues for decades based in some kind of if-you-don't-believe-in-my-God-you-must-believe-in-my-devil presupposition. Adding conservative ideologues to the faculty doesn't advance critical thinking, discovery, or even a useful diversity of thought because today's right wing sees words and numbers as weapons to deploy in service of ideological culture war battles, leaving the so-called "left" disarmed by our nearly universal assumption that words and numbers exist for the purpose of optimally discovering and

representing the truth about reality.

[cont.] Reality is a vast mystery for all human beings of whatever political bias, but it seems that only the so-called "leftists" who populate rigorous, truth-seeking disciplines have the humility and curiosity to explore it. The political right primarily cares about power, domination and pretending to always BE 100% right by nature. Evidence is self-evidently being respected on the political right only if it confirms preexisting right wing biases (see for instance Fox News or the rhetoric generated by Republican politicians). The intellectual diversity of universities is not benefited by hiring faculty with this kind of right-wing mindset.

George got it mostly right, up until he wrote that both Dems and Reps are the same on this issue. That is ludicrous. Dems have never tried to impose anything on universities that the universities didn't seem to have wanted anyway, e.g. DEI. But, he deserves credit for calling out the danger for what it is. The US higher education system is the envy of the world and a huge producer of wealth for our nation. Trump endangers the whole thing.

Nobody goes into education or public service to make money. Liberals are the ones who care.

I struggle to see the Democrat Party and mainstream media the way George Will and other conservatives portray them. Will accurately describes this Trump Administration's bullying and unconstitutional and unlawful attempt to take over the administrations of private universities. I am unaware of any time in history when a Democrat President or Administration attempted to do the same, or anything even close. And yet Will asserts that somehow the Democrat party has attempted to coerce speech and orchestrate a government take over of private universities too. Huh? Never happened.

[cont.] Conservatives claim that mainstream media is biased completely against them, they whine about it constantly. And yet, many conservatives write for this paper and others across the country, many of them own these papers. Show me one right wing media outlet that employs liberals and progressives and allows them to write or speak from their perspective. This false equivalency on regular display in mainstream media by conservatives is a big, big reason we are in the throes of an actual authoritarian takeover. Conservatives seem determined to convince themselves that a liberal scold with a higher education is worse than a wannabe dictator determined to overthrow our constitutional republic and they can't seem to spot the authoritarian takeover in progress by their own party right now.

For all the years you have been a columnist you have infused everything with politics, George. As I keep saying, the academy has

been left since ancient Greece because liberals are more intellectually curious than the right wing and less focused on making tons of money. But when they teach they don't teach politically. In political philosophy they still teach Plato, the theorist for fascism, and still teach Machiavelli who I think was writing a satire with the Prince (contrast with the Discourses) but is considered quite right wing. They still teach Hegel, the theorist of the nation state and the duty of all citizens to do whatever the gov't tells them to do. I have no idea where you get the notion that because most professors are left and most conservatives want to make more money than colleges pay so they don't do professor stuff as much what is taught in the assigned reading is just left. It isn't. It never was. It would only be that way if the right takes over the academy and lies like it does, like you do. You really need to stop this nonsense, George. You could have taught at university; you chased the money instead. Right?

Why not just clearly say that what the administration is doing is taking a page out of the authoritarian playbook? The Trump administration is trying to enfeeble all independent sources of judgment and action, whether it be the media (see Paramount and CPB news just this week), law firms, or universities.

5/6/25: IHE. Documenting Trump's 'Arbitrary' Cuts to Science / The Trump administration has canceled close to \$3 billion in NIH and NSF research grants, often without much explanation. Now researchers are crowdsourcing databases of suspended grants to shed light on what's being lost.

...Although the Trump administration and its allies have spotlighted National Institutes of Health and the National Science Foundation-funded projects on politically charged topics—including transgender people's health, HIV prevention, vaccine hesitancy, misinformation and diversity, equity and inclusion—as examples of canceled projects, those are far from the only research areas that have lost funding since January.

The agencies have also axed funding for research on cancer, maternal mortality and internet freedom without much explanation. And lacking comprehensive data from the government, the scholarly community has been tracking the cuts on their own terms in an attempt to understand the scope and scale of the losses.

...Delaney and his colleagues were aware of terminated NIH grants that weren't on the HHS spreadsheet. So, they put out a call for submissions on social media and created their own publicly accessible spreadsheet documenting the canceled research projects they could verify through those submissions as well as from news reports, social media posts and available government data.

The culmination of those efforts is available on Grant Watch, a website Delaney helped launch last week. It tracks and lists grant terminations at the NIH and the National Science Foundation—which has also canceled more than 1,000 grants over the past month as it undergoes ideologically driven priority shifts similar to those reshaping the NIH. The goal, he said, is to give academic researchers and their advocates another tool to resist policy decisions that many argue will hamper university budgets and local economies, slow scientific innovation, and weaken the United States' global competitiveness.

...According to Grant Watch's tally, as of late last week the NIH had canceled some 789 research grants—totaling roughly \$2 billion—and the NSF had canceled 1,042, worth more than \$780 million. Inside Higher Ed reached out to both the NIH and NSF last week, but both agencies declined to specify the total amount of federal funding they've canceled so far this year. An NSF spokesperson declined to produce a detailed list of the grants the agency recently terminated, and HHS sent Inside Higher Ed a link to the HHS spreadsheet that partly inspired Delaney and his colleagues to create Grant Watch.

...Grant Watch isn't the only project academics have undertaken in an attempt to create a robust record of the scope, scale and consequences of gutting federal support for research. Abby Andre, a graduate student at Ohio State University who previously worked as an attorney for the U.S. Department of Justice, recently launched the Impact Project after finding it difficult to keep track of the deluge of reports about mass federal worker firings, funding freezes and grant terminations. The need for the Impact Project—which is far broader in scope than the database Delaney and his team at Harvard created to document NIH and NSF cuts—stems from the unprecedented “pace of change in the federal government,” she said.

...While she has used some available government data, she also cross-references it with news reports and crowdsourced information to build out and update the Impact Map, which categorizes funding cuts by location, sector—including education, housing and academic research—and type of cut, such as funding cancellations or federal worker firings. It offers a visualization of the “severe” cuts to federal research funding and the implications they have for hundreds of higher education institutions and the communities they serve, she said. Indeed, not one state in the country has been spared.

Academic institutions are one of our primary sources of research and drive knowledge across sectors,” Andre said. “The concern is not only that we're losing knowledge, resources and future answers to complex problems, but that we're also going to be diminishing the value of higher education as funding is diminished.”

5/7/25: From: FYI <fyi@aipcomm.org>
Subject: State Department Poised to Close S&T Cooperation Office

FYI: Science Policy News from AIP
BULLETIN

State Department Poised to Close S&T Cooperation Office /
International scientific collaboration agreements could face
significant disruption or delay if plans to eliminate the office go
forward.

The State Department plans to eliminate its Office of Science and
Technology Cooperation as part of a sweeping reorganization at the
agency, current and former staff members at the department told FYI.

Thousands of scientific collaboration agreements between the
U.S. and foreign countries are negotiated and overseen by the
office, including agreements that allow U.S. researchers to access
international science facilities such as CERN and ITER. While some
of these agreements automatically renew, others will lapse without
intervention, potentially disrupting international research
collaborations and data sharing agreements as well as research
facility access abroad.

Staff at the office were told in late April that their unit would
most likely be closed and their positions terminated as part of the
department-wide reorganization effort announced by Secretary of
State Marco Rubio on April 22. A final decision is expected later
this month and would take effect July 1. Unlike some other science
offices at the department that are rumored to be facing
consolidation, such as the Office of the Science and Technology
Advisor and the Office of the Special Envoy for Critical and
Emerging Technology, there are no apparent plans to merge or
reorganize the cooperation office into another unit.

"There are grave concerns about how the work will proceed," said a
State Department employee who requested anonymity to speak freely
about internal discussions. "It is completely unclear which office
will take on this work and how they would have the bandwidth and
authority to do so."

When senior department officials told staff the cooperation office
was earmarked for elimination, the news came as a surprise, multiple
sources told FYI. The employee quoted above described the decision
as "baffling," given how much the Trump administration claims to
support American leadership in the technology space.

"The president himself has stressed the importance of emerging
technology, and some of the foremost government experts in fields

like quantum and biotech are part of the Office of Science and Technology Cooperation,” the employee said. They added that the office is the only part of the State Department that works with all federal science agencies to “make sure that our approach to international work is thorough and covers the broad scope of American science and tech priorities.”

“To say that another office – which is probably already operating on a shoestring budget – can simply take on the work is laughable,” the employee said.

The office has around 20 staff members who are a mixture of foreign service and civil service officers, contractors, and fellows, some with more than a decade of experience. While the foreign service officers may be reassigned to new roles if their positions are eliminated, the rest of the staff are set to lose their jobs.

Some staff members told FYI they are already looking for new employment but are hopeful that the department might reverse course. No staff contacted by FYI have yet received written notice of their termination. A State Department spokesperson did not confirm whether the office is in line for elimination, stating simply that the secretary of state has asked the under secretaries to draw up reorganization and workforce optimization plans to be reviewed this month.

Science and technology agreements set to expire over the next 12–18 months include ones with countries such as Japan, Egypt, Oman, Indonesia, Singapore, Pakistan, Tunisia, and the UAE. Though some of these will renew automatically, the employee said the absence of the office means the U.S. will lose its ability to negotiate changes and “ensure we have the right protections for research security, the best access to data, and the best way forward for advancing emerging technology.” Some of the most high-profile agreements that the office oversees do not auto-renew, including those with China and the European Union. The office is also involved in managing joint science and technology funds with countries such as Israel, India, and Egypt, as well as the U.S. Science Envoy Program and the Embassy Science Fellows Program, among others. It is unclear what will happen to these programs if the office is eliminated.

The cooperation office is “one of those tiny supports upon which the majority of major international science projects rest,” said Cole Donovan, a former long-time employee of the office, in a social media post last week. In addition to U.S. researchers potentially losing access to international facilities, Donovan warned that the closure of the office could potentially pause progress on major science facilities under construction in the U.S. if agreements covering international financial contributions are not completed. Speaking to FYI, Donovan noted that the Case-Zablocki Act requires

that federal agencies consult with the State Department before entering into any international agreements representing the United States. All of the agreements that touch on science, with the exception of those related to space, come through the cooperation office for review. Science agreements represent one of the largest categories of international agreements that the department reviews, Donovan said, as so many involve information sharing or have to be checked to ensure they protect American intellectual property rights.

Asked about the potential fallout of eliminating the office, Donovan said he was concerned that the loss of rapid and routine approval for international scientific relationships could have widespread implications that may not be immediately obvious. The U.S. has agreements with international forecasting and emergency management organizations, for example, which "if not maintained, could damage the ability of scientists to share timely emergency information in response to natural disasters," he said.

"I think the impact is probably going to be much larger than people expect, and not necessarily in ways that people might think about," Donovan added.

5/7/25: From: FYI <fyi@aipcomm.org>

Subject: Republican-led States Angle for NASA Headquarters

FYI: Science Policy News from AIP
BULLETIN

Republican-led States Angle for NASA Headquarters / Politicians from Texas, Florida, and Ohio are pushing to move NASA headquarters out of Washington, DC.

Legislators and governors from Texas, Florida, and Ohio are working to draw NASA's headquarters to their home states.

Led by Sen. Ted Cruz (R-TX) and Rep. Brian Babin (R-TX), all 27 Republicans on Texas's congressional delegation sent a letter in April to President Donald Trump urging him to relocate NASA's headquarters to the Lyndon B. Johnson Space Center in Houston, Texas. "NASA is disconnected from the day-to-day work of its centers and hindered by bureaucratic micromanagement in Washington," the letter states. It goes on to argue that the agency would be better served in Houston because Johnson Space Center "maintains the largest NASA workforce, accommodates extensive research and development partnerships, and houses Mission Control." Meanwhile, Sens. Rick Scott (R-FL) and Ashley Moody (R-FL) introduced the

Consolidating Aerospace Programs Efficiently at Canaveral (CAPE Canaveral) Act to relocate NASA's headquarters from Washington to Florida's Space Coast in Brevard County. A companion bill was introduced in the House by 11 Republicans and three Democrats.

Cape Canaveral is home to NASA's Kennedy Space Center and the Cape Canaveral Space Force Station. The Florida Council of 100, a nonprofit organization comprised of business leaders, wrote a letter to Florida's congressional delegation in support of relocating NASA's headquarters to Florida's Space Coast.

The same day that the CAPE Canaveral Act was introduced, Ohio Gov. Mike DeWine (R) sent a letter to Trump asking him to move NASA's headquarters to Cleveland, the home of NASA's Glenn Research Center. Rep. Max Miller (R-OH) and Sen. Jon Husted (R-OH) followed suit by sending similar letters to Vice President JD Vance and NASA administrator nominee Jared Isaacman. NASA published an update in November on its efforts to find a new headquarters building ahead of its lease expiration in 2028. The agency indicated it is seeking a 375,000 to 525,000 square-foot facility "in Washington or the immediate surrounding area." However, Politico has reported that there have been internal discussions at NASA about possibly doing away with a centralized headquarters altogether and instead dispersing those responsibilities across states.

Discussions about relocating NASA's headquarters come in the wake of the Trump administration's February executive order directing agency heads to identify leases eligible for termination. A subsequent memo from the Office of Personnel Management instructed agency heads to develop reorganization and workforce downsizing plans that include "any proposed relocations of agency bureaus and offices from Washington, DC, and the National Capital Region to less-costly parts of the country." Those plans were due in April and have not been made public.

During his presidential campaign, Trump promised to move up to 100,000 federal workers out of DC. During his first term, he moved branches of the U.S. Department of Agriculture to Missouri and the Bureau of Land Management headquarters to Colorado. The decision was reversed in 2021 under the Biden administration and the BLM moved back to DC.

Lawmakers in support of relocation across Texas, Florida, and Ohio all say that moving NASA's headquarters out of DC would lower agency operating costs, save taxpayers money, improve efficiency, and provide a boost to their local economies. Florida Gov. Ron DeSantis (R) claims that relocation would save the agency "about a billion dollars."

In Ohio, the Cleveland City Council passed a resolution aimed at

persuading the federal government to relocate NASA's headquarters there. "Moving NASA headquarters to Cleveland, Ohio would: provide significantly lower cost of living and operational costs than Washington, DC, resulting in substantial taxpayer savings; strategically align efforts to decentralize federal agencies; reinvigorate Ohio as the birthplace of aviation and the heart of America's aerospace industry; and optimize workforce and facility use by consolidating operations near an existing NASA field center," the resolution reads. Meanwhile, some lawmakers have contested the notion that moving agency headquarters will result in new efficiencies. Rep. Eleanor Holmes Norton (D-DC) introduced a bill in March that would prohibit the relocation of agencies' headquarters outside Washington without Congressional approval, arguing that "Congress cannot write laws or conduct oversight without the critical information provided by agencies" in the National Capital Region.

"Moving federal agencies is not about saving taxpayer money and will degrade the vital services provided to all Americans across the country," Holmes Norton said in a March press release. "In the 1990s, the Bureau of Land Management moved its wildfire staff out West, only to move them back when Congress demanded briefings on new wildfires," she added.

5/8/25: NASA Watch. The Cost of Breaking The GISS Lease

Several sources report that the NASA GISS lease of the Armstrong Hall building in New York City can't be broken by GSA without incurring a large financial penalty. So, if NASA leaves anyway with a DOGE claim of a cost savings NASA will still be paying ~\$3 million a year until 2031 for a building they can't/won't use -- plus the rent for wherever the GISS folks are moved to.

5/9/25: NASA Watch. USRA's Non-Deletion Deletion of LPI Website Material

Keith's note: a week ago I posted Erasing NASA Diversity Abstracts Is Not That Easy saying "The NASA DEI Erasure Squad has been busy. If you search for past LPSC abstracts on DEI, DEIA, diversity etc. you'll see that they have disappeared and prior meeting agendas have been altered." Well they have been busy and huge amounts of material are simply vanishing. USRA did this stealthily until too many people started to notice -- only then did they have the notion that they should say something using some classic Orwellian Double Speak. (More below)

According to Nature: 'Orwellian': planetary scientists outraged over deletion of research records: "Over the past several weeks, hundreds

of meeting abstracts have quietly vanished from the websites of research conferences organized by the Lunar and Planetary Institute (LPI) in Houston, Texas – a NASA-funded research institution that maintains key archives and information about US planetary science. The abstracts have a common theme: diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI). These topics were banned from receiving government funding by a 20 January executive order from US President Donald Trump, who called them “illegal and immoral discrimination programs”. The LPI did not seek permission from the abstract authors to remove the material.”

I got this from USRA last night “Statement Regarding the Removal of DEI Content from LPI Websites” which said “After consulting with our counsel and in a good faith effort to comply with these Administration directives to the best of our understanding of their terms, USRA/LPI removed (not deleted) all DEI-related content from the public-facing websites, which are maintained under USRA’s cooperative agreement with and grant from NASA.”

Wait a minute: “USRA/LPI removed (not deleted) all DEI-related content” Huh? USRA took it offline. It has been deleted from the website. It is gone. Vanished. Absent. Disappeared. What kind of Orwellian Double Speak is this? Where is it? But they say “If and when USRA is advised by an authoritative federal body that we can restore that content, with or without a disclaimer, USRA will promptly do so.”

USRA still took this material offline with no mention whatsoever in advance that this was going to happen – or why. Only when everyone started to notice did they finally decide to admit what they were doing with a press thing sent out after hours.

5/12/25: IHE. Can Scientific Research Survive Without Federal Funding? / Universities are offering temporary relief to researchers whose projects have been disrupted by federal funding cuts. But it won't help in the long term, and experts say industry and philanthropy are in no position to make up for the losses.

By Kathryn Palmer <<https://www.insidehighered.com/author/kathryn-palmer>>

Colleges and universities are digging into their own pockets to temporarily support graduate students and faculty in limbo after the Trump administration’s sudden cancellation—and stalled review—of billions of dollars in federal research grants.

In February, the Yale School of Medicine began offering temporary funding to researchers with terminated grants—many related to topics the Trump administration has deemed unworthy of scientific inquiry, such as transgender health—to give them time to reorient their

research. Yale's Graduate School of Arts and Sciences is also investing \$4 million to support graduate students who have lost training and research grants. Similarly, last month Johns Hopkins University announced that it is tapping earnings from its \$13.2 billion endowment to give researchers \$100,000 each for delayed grants, or \$150,000 for terminated grants, during a 12-month period. And Northwestern University—which hasn't received any grant payments from the National Institutes of Health since March—is offering faculty up to \$50,000 to maintain projects for up to one year.

While institutional funding will help some researchers continue their work in the short term, experts and research advocates say it's far from a long-term solution. And neither is counting on private industry or philanthropists to step in to sustain the U.S. research enterprise at the same scale federal grants have done over the past 80 years, experts say.

Over the past several decades, universities have already substantially increased the amount of money they spend on their own research and development—from 10 percent of the total in 1970 to 25 percent in 2023, according to federal data. Meanwhile, federal support for academic research has been on the decline, falling from 71 percent to 55 percent during that same timeframe. And support from industry, charities and other sources have always been marginal, collectively making up about 15 percent of contributions to research funding at colleges and universities in 2023.

[It may be that much of the universities' own funds come from ID charges on federal grants -- meaning that they are not independent of federal support.]

"When it comes to supporting curiosity-driven scientific research, there is simply no replacement for the federal government," said Toby Smith, senior vice president for government relations and public policy at the Association of American Universities. "While private industry is critically dependent on the broad-based knowledge and training produced by university-based research, industry tends to focus their own R&D efforts on applied research where they can better guarantee a direct return to the company on their shareholders' investment."

Although the Trump administration's long-range vision for supporting scientific research remains far from clear, colleges are under immediate pressure to fill in some of the federal funding craters that have already upended research—including some clinical trials—on cancer, diabetes and HIV prevention.

And it's not just the nation's wealthiest institutions that are

launching bridge funding efforts.

The Universities of Hawaii, Massachusetts and Arizona have all announced programs designed to bridge funding gaps and help graduate students stay on track and finish their dissertations, or faculty whose research projects are at risk of disruption.

'Fuel' for the Economic Engine

Soon after faculty at the University of Arizona raised concerns about cuts to research funding, officials established a Bridge Funding Investment Program to aid faculty with an established track record of extramural funding, with a particular focus on preserving Ph.D. student support. According to Tomás Díaz de la Rubia, senior vice president for research and innovation, UA—which is still recovering from a budget crisis, has allocated \$1 million in bridge funding.

While that won't cover all of the terminated grants, "the bridge has to go somewhere," he said, explaining that the program isn't supporting projects that don't have viable alternative long-term funding options. Instead, "we're providing funding for projects where the faculty member has other sources of funding and other proposals with the same or different federal agencies," Díaz de la Rubia said. "So far, we've been able to support every request that we've received through this process."

The bridge programs at Arizona and other universities aren't intended to indefinitely sustain the academic research enterprise, which is facing the possibility of even deeper funding cuts. Earlier this month, President Trump unveiled his budget proposal for Fiscal Year 2026, which includes gutting the budgets for both the NIH and the National Science Foundation—two of the biggest funders of university research.

Díaz de la Rubia said UA and other universities are already working with local, state and federal lawmakers, as well as companies that rely on university research, to make a case for preserving research funding and the economic benefit it affords taxpayers.

For every \$1 the NIH spent on research funding in 2024, it generated \$2.56 of economic activity, according to a report by United for Medical Research
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"Congress needs to hear a lot of voices, not just academic voices," he

said. "Without the fuel for the economic engine, there is no engine. And universities are that fuel. We are the ones that create those early-stage discoveries and technologies that get translated into private sector innovations that drive the economy and provide for national security."

Industry Support 'Not Realistic'

While big-name technology and pharmaceutical companies bring fully formed inventions to market, those products are typically derived from university-led discoveries. For instance, NIH funded-research contributed to 99 percent [of drugs approved between 2010 and 2019](https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10148199/), according to the Center for American Progress. And many of the components of smartphones, including touch screens and multi-core processors, have origins in federally funded university research <https://www.aau.edu/university-research-made-your-smartphone-smart>.

In 2023, only 6.8 percent of research expenditures in the United States came from industry, according to data from the Association of University Technology Managers (AUTM).

"A decline in research funding will result in fewer inventions, which means fewer innovations will get to market. The pipeline for innovations is being constrained right now," said Stephen Susalka, CEO of AUTM, which supports the development of academic research. And since the cuts to research funding come on top of broader budget cuts to higher education institutions, scientists may receive less financial support for their patent applications, preventing private companies from using their inventions. "I imagine that in 10 years, there will be fewer drugs approved than there are today because of these constraints on the front end," Susalka said.

Ruth Johnston, vice president of the National Association of College and University Business Officers, said that expecting the private sector to support such research in lieu of the federal government may be "idealistic, but it's not realistic." Similarly, philanthropic organizations likely can't replace once-stable federal research support—especially given the market volatility President Trump's tariff-driven economic agenda has introduced.

"Because the market is so uncertain right now, philanthropic organizations are trying to think of their own financial sustainability," Johnston said. "They have to be given money from somebody—are people going to want to give at the same levels as they were before?"

And while some philanthropic organizations are stepping in to support

research on specific topics — the Bill Gates Foundation said Thursday that it plans to spend \$200 billion on researching poverty, infectious diseases and child deaths before it closes in 2045 — relying on private donors even when the economy is strong has its drawbacks.

That's in part because both industry leaders and wealthy do-gooders are driven by their own financial or personal goals, said Christopher Newfield, director of research at the Independent Social Research Foundation in London and professor emeritus of English at the University of California at Santa Barbara.

"The strength of U.S. research has always been that it is researcher-driven, by the people who know best, not by moguls with special interests or axes to grind," Newfield said in an email. "Firms take fundamental concepts, materials, discoveries mostly uncovered in universities and apply them in product lines that they think have high future value in the marketplace. Usually this needs to be a near-term future—a couple of years. Fundamental research takes place not over years but decades."

But the research enterprise will take much less time to collapse, Newfield suggested, if Trump's plans to destabilize the higher education sector—and especially its research production—come to fruition.

"If the impounding and cuts survive the courts and Congress, then the U.S. will fall behind Europe and East Asia fairly quickly, within around five years. Research moves very quickly, even outside of STEM," he wrote, adding that cash-strapped universities won't be able to train as many future scientists, leaving businesses with a shrunken pool of workers with advanced skills.

"Since the system's parts are all interconnected, the general intellectual level of U.S. higher education will deteriorate on a number of fronts at the same time."

Tough Choices Ahead

Jeffrey Miron, a senior lecturer of economics at Harvard University and vice president of research at the right-leaning Cato Institute, said that while some universities are mitigating the short-term impact of cuts to federal research funding, "there's almost certainly going to be a negative impact" if universities lose as much federal support as Trump has proposed.

And though it will be nearly impossible to replicate federal funding from another source, the government's policy shifts will force universities to reevaluate where sustaining research falls on their list of priorities.

"They may have various programs, schools, departments, majors or athletic teams that they will come to decide are not essential," he said. "They might be able to partially offset some of the government funding cuts if they repurpose the money they were spending to maintain those programs and use that to fund the sciences that are not going to be easily supported by industry or philanthropic organizations."

Making such decisions won't be easy; Columbia University last week announced 180 layoffs as a result of federal funding cuts, and other institutions have frozen hiring. But Miron said it could also give universities more control over their research dollars.

"Accepting federal funding comes with its own costs, where the government feels it can tell institutions what to do on a whole range of things, including admissions, hiring, university leadership and how they deal with campus protests," he said. "Maybe they would prefer to be a somewhat smaller enterprise and do fewer things if it means they get full choice about which things they do and the political positions they take."

5/12/25: FYI. HUGE SHAKE-UP OF NSF BEGINS AS AGENCY MARKS 75TH ANNIVERSARY

The National Science Foundation turned 75 on Saturday, but celebrations planned for this week have been marred by a turbulent few months at the agency and breaking news of a major organizational shake-up. On Friday, NSF announced it had initiated a Reduction in Force (RIF) of executive positions across the agency and the elimination of its Division of Equity for Excellence in STEM. In an internal memo, viewed by FYI, NSF's Chief Management Officer Micah Cheatham stated that the agency currently has space for 143 Senior Executive Service (SES) positions but has determined that just 59 are required going forward. The agency plans to reassign SES staff who do not retain their titles to new roles within NSF by June 30 and lay off those without "fallback rights." All staff within the STEM equity division are subject to the RIF order, with around 15 to 30 employees thought to have been affected.

The memo also revealed major changes to hundreds of staff known as rotators – scientists who are temporarily employed by NSF for a few years at a time under the Intergovernmental Personnel Act in order to help the agency stay on the cutting edge of research. Over the next 30 days, NSF plans to move IPA rotators out of SES positions "into new, executive-level positions where they will retain program responsibility and authority but will no longer supervise federal employees." NSF also plans to reduce its temporary workforce from 368

employees to a target of 70 employees. These positions will focus on “presidential priorities in artificial Intelligence, biotechnology, nuclear energy, quantum science, and translational science,” according to the memo.

These actions appear to be connected to broader plans to DISBAND DISCIPLINE-SPECIFIC DIVISIONS AT THE AGENCY AND DOWNSIZE THE EIGHT DIRECTORATES, according to reporting by Science. On social media, current and former NSF staff reacted with dismay at the restructuring of the agency and the elimination of the STEM equity division. NSF’s workers union, AFGE Local 3403, also issued a letter calling for the immediate resignation of Cheatham, arguing that his actions violate federal law because many functions of the equity division are required by statute and that he is “clearly more interested in appeasing the administration than in doing the work directed and funded by Congress.” In a statement on the division termination, NSF said it “is mindful of its statutory program obligations and plans to take steps to ensure those continue.”

From the mentioned 5/8/25 article in Science:

...“These actions are necessary ... to reduce the size of government and reduce federal spending,” according to a memo from Micah Cheatham, NSF’s chief management officer. The move is part of a plan to radically restructure and downsize the agency, as reported yesterday by Science.

...That restructuring would abolish NSF’s current 37 divisions spread across the agency’s eight directorates. Science has now learned that the new structure will retain the existing directorates but replace divisions with “clusters” that fund research in the president’s five priority areas. Unlike the current divisions, which are led by an SES director and an SES deputy director, the new clusters will be headed by non-SES supervisors.

In advance of adopting its new structure, Cheatham announced NSF is eliminating the Division of Equity for Excellence in STEM (EES) and firing its entire staff, believed to number between 15 and 20. The reduction in force, in effect immediately, will be completed by 12 July. EES is one of four divisions within NSF’s \$1 billion education directorate, and last week NSF foreshadowed its demise by terminating 331 of its grants. They were seen to be out of step with a presidential directive on diversity, equity, and inclusion that bans any research that preferentially favors one demographic group or excludes participation of other group

From the original 5/8/25 article in Science:

Exclusive: NSF faces radical shake-up as officials abolish its 37 divisions / Changes seen as a response to presidential directives on what research to fund

The National Science Foundation (NSF), already battered by White House directives and staff reductions, is plunging into deeper turmoil. According to sources who requested anonymity for fear of retribution, staff were told today that the agency's 37 divisions—across all eight NSF directorates—are being abolished and the number of programs within those divisions will be drastically reduced. The current directors and deputy directors will lose their titles and might be reassigned to other positions at the agency or elsewhere in the federal government.

The consolidation appears to be driven in part by President Donald Trump's proposal to cut the agency's \$4 billion budget by 55% for the 2026 fiscal year that begins on 1 October. NSF's decision to abolish its divisions could also be part of a larger restructuring of the agency's grantmaking process that involves adding a new layer of review. NSF watchers fear that a smaller, restructured agency could be more vulnerable to pressure from the White House to fund research that suits its ideological bent.

As soon as this evening, NSF is also expected to send layoff notices to an unspecified number of its 1700-member staff. The remaining staff and programs will be assigned to one of the eight, smaller directorates. Staff will receive a memo on Friday "with details to be finalized by the end of the fiscal year," sources tell Science. The agency is also expected to issue another round of notices tomorrow terminating grants that have already been awarded, sources say. In the past 3 weeks, the agency has pulled the plug on almost 1400 grants worth more than \$1 billion.

A spokesperson for NSF says the rationale for abolishing the divisions and removing their leaders is "to reduce the number of SES [senior executive service] positions in the agency and create new nonexecutive positions to better align with the needs of the agency."

NSF receives more than 40,000 proposals a year, roughly one-quarter of which are funded. And division directors wield great authority over the outcome. "Although division directors do many things, their main job is to concur on grant recommendations," says one former NSF staffer.

The initial vetting is handled by hundreds of program officers, all experts in their field and some of whom are on temporary leave from academic positions. After collecting input from outside reviewers, program managers pick the strongest proposals and ask their division director to concur with their recommendation for

funding. For all but the biggest grants, the division director's endorsement is the final approval step. That system is unlike the one used by the National Institutes of Health, where advisory councils for each institute have the final say and rely on ratings from a panel of outside experts.

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Hate to finally have to say it -- but if anything like this plan prevails, it looks like the end of good NSF support for astronomy. Will NRAO survive? NoirLab? LSST? Simon? No guarantees whatsoever.

Almost certainly the US ELT projects are toast. Likely also the ngVLA.

How can anyone justify such drastic irresponsible and irrational changes???

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5/13/25: NYT, The World Is Wooing U.S. Researchers Shunned by Trump .
As President Trump guts American research institutions, world leaders see a "once-in-a-century brain gain opportunity."

As President Trump cuts billions of federal dollars from science institutes and universities, restricts what can be studied and pushes out immigrants, rival nations are hoping to pick up talent that has been cast aside or become disenchanted.

For decades, trying to compete with American institutions and companies has been difficult. The United States was a magnet for top researchers, scientists and academics. In general, budgets were bigger, pay was bigger, labs and equipment were bigger. So were ambitions.

In 2024, the United States spent nearly \$1 trillion – roughly 3.5 percent of total economic output – on research and development. When it came to the kind of long-term basic research that underpins American technological and scientific advancements, the government accounted for about 40 percent of the spending.

[Sorry -- garbled. Does that mean that the gov. only contributed 40% of the national funds spent on basic research OR that 40% of government research expenditures were for basic research?]

"This is a once-in-a-century brain gain opportunity," the Australian Strategic Policy Institute declared, as it encouraged its government to act. Last week, at the urging of more than a dozen members, the

European Union announced it would spend an additional 500 million euros, or \$556 million, over the next two years to “make Europe a magnet for researchers.”

Such a sum is paltry when compared with U.S. budgets. So it’s understandable if their appeals are met with a request to “show me the money.” After all, salaries tend to be much lower in Europe. In France, for example, a 35-year-old researcher can expect to earn around €3,600 (about \$4,000) a month before taxes, according to the French Education and Research ministry. A postdoctoral fellow at Stanford would stand to earn the equivalent of around €6,000 (about \$6,685) a month in the United States.

Still, there is interest. Of 1,600 people who responded to a March poll in the journal *Nature* – many of them Ph.D. or postdoctoral students in the United States – three out of four said they were considering leaving the country because of the Trump administration’s policies.

And Europe’s more generous social safety net can make up for a large part of the salary differential, said Patrick Lemaire, the president of the *College de Sociétés Savantes Académiques de France*, an arm of an international council that represents about 50,000 academics in France. “There is much less money in Europe, and the salaries are much lower,” he said. “But you also have very good social security and health care, which is free; school and university tuition are free.”

5/15/25: CHED. Harvard’s Battle With Trump Escalates as Research Money Is Suddenly Canceled

The battle between Harvard University and the Trump administration escalated sharply this week, when the administration acted to terminate billions in federal grants to the university. The roughly \$2.2 billion, which the administration had previously frozen, was being clawed back grant by grant, in addition to another \$450 million announced this week. In response, the university filed an amended complaint as part of its legal challenge against the White House.

Unlike other cancellations in recent months targeting research focused on topics like LGBTQ health, race, or Covid-19, these sweeping terminations seem unrelated to research content and instead zero in on the institution at large and its response to campus antisemitism. Michael Baym, who runs a Harvard Medical School lab researching antibiotic resistance and bacteriology, was shocked to receive a notice on Monday evening saying an NIH grant supporting his lab was terminated.

“I think the reasoning behind this termination had more to do with the Harvard name as a symbol of elite academia than the content of our

research," Baym said. "I think this is entirely for symbolic value. It's hard to see who in the United States benefits from cutting medical research."

The additional terminations exacted a damaging blow to the medical school. "Nearly all of HMS's active, direct federal grants have been terminated" after the university received letters from a slew of federal agencies this week, Kristin Bittinger, dean for faculty and research integrity, wrote in an internal HMS memo.

"It is with great regret and sadness that we deliver this deeply unsettling news," said the memo, which was also signed by Rachel Cahoon, chief research administration officer. "These actions by the federal government are difficult to fully comprehend for all of us that care deeply about the work of our researchers and the positive impact their discoveries make on humankind."

A similar grim message came from the dean of the faculty at Harvard's T.H. Chan School of Public Health, Andrea Baccarelli. The government has canceled nearly all of the school's grants, he wrote in an email to affiliates, and he said he expects any remaining awards to be terminated within weeks. Baccarelli added that he and his team would be restructuring the school's financial model, a move he described as a "necessary transition to a more sustainable research enterprise."

...The additional cuts came a day after Garber issued a letter to Secretary of Education Linda McMahon refuting the administration's claims that Harvard is a partisan institution that has allowed antisemitism, liberal indoctrination, and race-based discrimination to fester on its campus. A week prior to that letter, the administration moved to freeze all future grants to Harvard. McMahon wrote at the time that "Harvard should no longer seek GRANTS from the federal government, since none will be provided."

...Baym, the bacteria researcher who received a grant-termination notice Monday evening, posted on the social-media platform Bluesky that not only was his primary NIH grant terminated, but also his other major grants, through the National Science Foundation. Those NSF grants, he learned Wednesday, were on a list of terminated grants sent to the university, he said.

In a notice sent from NSF's division of grants and agreements to Garber on Monday, Jamie H. French, the division director, wrote that "The agency has determined that termination of certain awards is necessary because they are not in alignment with current NSF priorities and/or programmatic goals. NSF understands that Harvard continues to engage in race discrimination including in its admissions process, and in other areas of student life, as well as failing to promote a research environment free of antisemitism and bias."

Baym also shared a screenshot of the NIH termination notice. His grant was canceled "due to unsafe antisemitic actions that suggest the institution lacks concern for the safety and well-being of Jewish students," the notice said.

5/19/25: Reader comments from the New York Times obituary for Richard Garwin.

Dr. Garwin is just one small example of the priceless wisdom and knowledge the nation has stored in its community of experts. Imagine how that wisdom and knowledge has been silenced or worse by the Trump administration and replaced with the lies and scams of grifters and crackpots.

Unfortunately, the personal qualities that made Dr. Garwin stand out aren't universally shared by his fellow scientists – in significant ways, they're probably the exception to the rule – and today the Executive Branch is waging an all-out, reckless assault on the scientific community while our leaders cheerfully hollow out and dumb down the government agencies that rely on science to protect us. To most Americans focused on the stress of daily life and the deliberate chaos that is being sown from above to envelop us, the dangers presented by these trends are remote and abstract, if they're paying any attention at all. But the fires are being lit, and it's only a matter of time before we all get burned.

5/21/25: WP As Trump cuts science budgets, some researchers look abroad / It's not clear how many scientists will find work in another country, where salaries are generally lower.

Image: Kartik Sheth, a recently laid-off NASA scientist, arrives Friday in France to attend a scientific conference and check out the environment for research in the country.

[Kartik is a former NRAO scientist.]

By Joel Achenbach, Carolyn Y. Johnson, Karla Adam and Kate Brady

Kartik Sheth, 53, is an astrophysicist and, until a few weeks ago, was the associate chief scientist at NASA. On March 10, he got an unexpected email: "I regret to inform you that you are being affected by a [reduction-in-force] action. ... Therefore, you will be separated from NASA at the close of business on April 10, 2025."

One of 23 NASA employees laid off that day, including everyone in the Office of the Chief Scientist, Sheth is now looking for a job –

anywhere. On Friday, he arrived in Paris to attend a conference and check out the environment for scientific research.

"I don't know if I'll find a job in America given the cuts to science," he said. "I think we could have a pretty major brain drain in the country. ... I think people are going to start to wonder if this is the place for me to continue to do science."

With billions of dollars in research grants eliminated or frozen by the Trump administration, scientists across America in a broad array of fields face an uncertain future and the possibility of layoffs. An untold number like Sheth are looking abroad, thinking of continuing their careers far from the turmoil here.

While it's unclear how many will actually make the move, American scientists are being actively recruited by countries including France, Spain, Germany and China that are hoping to reverse the flow of expertise into the United States that has been the norm for decades.

"People who were certain that they were going to spend their careers in the U.S., and stay in the U.S. for the next phase, are now totally reconsidering," said David Baker, a biochemist at the University of Washington who shared the Nobel Prize in chemistry in 2024.

The United States now faces a "wholesale change in mentality" across the science community as a result of President Donald Trump's actions, he said.

At an event at Paris's prestigious Sorbonne University this month, European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen unveiled a fund of 500 million euros (\$560 million) aimed at making the European Union a "magnet for researchers." French President Emmanuel Macron – who has been making a hard push for global talent to "choose France" – pledged an additional 100 million euros (\$112 million) to help researchers settle in France.

Macron has done this before: In 2017, on the same day the first Trump administration said it was pulling out of the Paris climate accord, Macron launched a "Make Our Planet Great Again" initiative, inviting foreign researchers to live and work in France. This year's cohort of 60 fellows, who receive monthly stipends and relocation support, will begin their program in September.

In Germany, Cornelia Woll, president of the Hertie School, a private social sciences university, was one of eight scholars behind a recent open letter urging the country's leaders – through a proposed program aimed at international academics – to "give America's top researchers a new home!"

Woll said she has asked American colleagues, "What can we do for you?"

"The only answer I've gotten is: 'Keep a job open for us in case we lose our fight,'" she said.

Britain's Labour Party government is expected to soon announce plans to spend 50 million pounds (\$66 million) to attract and relocate about 10 teams of international researchers, according to an official who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak publicly.

Martin McKee, a professor of European public health at the London School of Hygiene & Tropical Medicine, said he was "hearing from colleagues that even quite senior professors at American universities are now applying for more junior posts."

The interest isn't only from scientists. The head of a humanities department at a British university said a recent job posting drew "more than usual" interest from American academics – including those already on the tenure track.

In addition to his layoffs and budget cuts, Trump's immigration policies have generated consternation in the scientific community because many researchers – including early-career postdoctoral workers**who will fuel the next era of innovation – are foreign-born.

According to the National Postdoctoral Association, an advocacy organization, there are about 72,000 postdocs in the U.S., nearly 60 percent of them from outside the country. Many – both U.S. and foreign-born – are looking abroad as research funding is hit, said Thomas Kimbis, chief executive of the association.

Foreign-born postdocs will face uncertainty when their visas end, he said, making them more likely to start searching immediately for jobs abroad.

"We want them to be able to stay in the U.S. ... We need them, and they're giving us a strategic advantage," Kimbis said.

Working in European countries offers some advantages, such as long holidays, a year's maternity leave and free health care. Language is not an obstacle for Americans, as English has become the working language in many European laboratories.

There is no comprehensive data on the number of departing scientists.**But to date, there has been no mass exodus of researchers and there are plenty of reasons to believe it may not happen. U.S. laboratories and universities pay more than their European counterparts, offer more administrative support and arguably convey more professional prestige.

The facilities in the U.S. are typically impressive. Anand Menon, a politics professor at King's College London, said that when he went on a year-long sabbatical in New York, he felt "like a prince."

Meanwhile,**many British universities are undergoing funding cuts themselves.

"American institutions pay very large salaries, which are significantly higher than those in Europe, in Germany, in France – and here we must also find flexible solutions," said Patrick Cramer, president of the Max Planck Society, one of Germany's most prominent research organizations.

Almost lost in the concerns about a potential U.S. brain drain is the fact that science has become globally collaborative. Directives from the White House can reverberate across the world. Cramer said he fears that the Trump policies will damage research in Europe.

The U.S. is currently the Max Planck Society's most significant international partner, with about 1,000 active collaborations. Climate science projects are among those most vulnerable to disruption, Cramer said.

"Since the Second World War, American research has been a motor for science worldwide," he**said. "And the transatlantic axis in particular was also important in keeping this engine running. ... All of that is now endangered."

'Do more..with less'

The U.S. scientific enterprise has traditionally enjoyed bipartisan political support, with taxpayer dollars flowing generously from federal agencies to universities and institutions that, in turn, have attracted brilliant minds from across the planet. In opinion surveys, the scientific community enjoys higher public trust than many other sectors of U.S. society.

But Trump is determined to shrink and re-prioritize the functions of the federal government. The administration's actions have roiled agencies across the executive branch – and science and health agencies haven't gotten a pass.

Trump's budget request to Congress proposes large cuts in their funding, including a 56 percent cut to the National Science Foundation, a nearly 50 percent cut to NASA's science directorate and a roughly 40 percent cut to the National Institutes of Health.

The administration has already frozen or cut billions of dollars in research grants to universities. Some of the cuts are driven by administration priorities, including terminations of research

involving climate change, covid, vaccines, health disparities and anything deemed to touch on diversity, equity and inclusion efforts.

In a less obvious but consequential set of bureaucratic maneuvers, the normal pace of grant reviews and disbursements has slowed to a crawl. Funding agencies may not be able to get their money out the door by the end of the fiscal year on Sept. 30.

The administration also stunned the academic world by announcing**a 15 percent cap on overhead costs for research, a move held up in court battles. Many universities count on a 50 percent or higher formula for these “indirect costs.” The specter of a major drop in federal funding is already rippling through universities as they pare back opportunities for postdoctoral positions, cut internships and, in some cases, lay off researchers.

“We intend to do more, a lot more, with less,” Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. said in testimony May 14**before a House committee.

The long-term effects of these moves remain unclear. Although the Republican-controlled Congress has put up minimal resistance to Trump’s policies, some lawmakers may try to preserve targeted programs that bring money to their states and districts.

Rep. Rosa DeLauro (Connecticut), the ranking Democrat on the House Appropriations Committee, spared no words as she addressed Kennedy. She suggested he has been “promoting quackery” and “endangering the health of the American people with pseudoscience, fearmongering and misinformation.”

She added, “China and Europe are taking advantage of this disaster by recruiting American scientists away from the United States.”

Sheth, the former NASA astrophysicist, grew up in India and came with his family to the U.S. when he was 14. As a child, he loved “Star Trek” and dreamed of being a scientist, or even an astronaut. His dream came true, taking him all the way to NASA, where he worked for nine years, eight months and 27 days.

He lives in the Navy Yard area of D.C. and has family in New Jersey and Virginia. He is not eager to leave the country. What he would like most is to find a job in Washington.

For younger scientists who have yet to build out their networks or put down as many roots, taking a big leap to a distant land can be easier.

Kevin Bird, 31, is in a pivotal part of his scientific career, studying plant genomes at the University of California at Davis, supported by a National Science Foundation postdoctoral fellowship. He

long assumed his next step would be building a laboratory at a university in the U.S.

Then January came.

Without explanation, the Trump administration froze a National Science Foundation payment system that Bird**and others rely on for their salaries – a temporary but consequential pause. The growing uncertainty around science funding meant that the already competitive job market for a faculty job was tightening as universities slowed hiring.

“I was staring down what I imagine**the next year in the U.S. would look like,” Bird said. “I was really worried that the tracks were being ripped up in front of me and there was no short-term future.”

Fortuitously, a postdoctoral position in Bird’s field opened at the Kew Royal Botanic Gardens in Richmond, England. He applied in February and will start in July. Bird is searching for an apartment in London for himself, his wife and two cats.

In a season of despair, particularly for early-career scientists who are seeing job opportunities freeze or disappear, Bird feels lucky. The job lasts four years, long enough to build connections in Europe and determine from afar if American science weathers the storm.

“This is a really good length of time to basically see if the U.S. settles down and recovers from what happens,” Bird said.

Comments...

Salaries are lower, but housing costs, food costs, costs of living in general are lower. And the benefits (think health care) are much lower cost and very high quality. I'm old and retired now, but if I were one of these young researchers, I'd jump at a chance to be in a place where science is respected.

I know of three scientists who have already accepted positions in the EU and the UK. They are quite brilliant and will move the world forward with their research and work, but could not continue their work here in the US in this political environment. Other countries and the world will continue to benefit from their efforts, but the US will continue to experience a brain drain under the current administration. Trump is doing lasting damage to the USA, that will be felt for decades to come.

Great, we're going to lose all of our brilliant minds. And we're left with Cabinet Members who don't know what Habeus corpus is.

The dismantling, without public plan or thought, of the nation's scientific and engineering enterprise is the most profoundly damaging and incomprehensible thing that this administration is doing. It's mindless...it's not getting rid of DEI, it's trying to get government out of the future business, placing it in private hands.

The future of science is predicated on having PhD students working hard to earn their PhDs by doing hard science. If the funding goes away, the best of our young research professors are likely to be enticed away by either industry jobs or positions at foreign science institutes. Older, tenured faculty would be left; but without research funding, graduate students are likely to be shown the door, as their education has always been supported by the US because it has always been seen to be in our best interest until the Trump administration. Who in their right mind is going to apply to go to grad school in the future under these circumstances?

Science is what made America great after WW2...this move to kill this is beyond stupid.

Do more with less" Does the American public understand just how much scientists were already doing with less? American scientists could give the pentagon a master class in "doing more with less". The NIH is the best deal Americans got for their tax dollars while it was still fully funded. Now it's simply not possible to make the magic anymore. RIP American innovation!

As usual, the Post ignores Canada. On average, Canadian tech recruiting companies report a 70%--80% increase in US-based inquiries about jobs in Canada since January. A recent survey by the science journal Nature found that more than 1,200 of 1,608 (75%) of scientists polled were considering leaving the US. And it's not just the tech sector. Experts in law, engineering and health care are leaving. Hundreds of US doctors, double the amount year over year, have made inquiries about moving to Canada. And it's not just workers; it's also US and international STEM students and more fundamentally, the university professors who teach them, who are looking to move to Canada, given Trump's attacks on US sources and repositories of fact-based knowledge and real-world expertise. The University of British Columbia is reporting a 27% increase in graduate applications from the US over last year.

"We intend to do more, a lot more, with less," Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. said..." This from a guy who isn't a medical doctor, not a scientist or researcher and has no idea what he is talking about. Fing moron!

"The long-term effects of these moves remain unclear."
-- But are eminently predictable.

You cannot even put a price tag on the loss of key talent like these. I am not even sure this President has the mental capacity to fully comprehend these monumental losses, which takes decades and decades to develop. Our loss is their gain. We are in effect a nation that is dumbing down from the lofty heights we reached in the 20th Century. Many don't believe in vaccines, don't believe in basic science, our kids stay away from math and science because it's too hard, all they want to be are rappers, singers, movie stars and professional basketball players. These are troubling signs we are heading in the wrong direction and becoming a Third World country.

Science is about doing the science. A place to work, a community of colleagues, a sufficient social support system, a living wage, respect, rationality in the public sphere—these are the necessary conditions. Lacking in the US? Just as the cream of the German science community left that nation in the 30s, the cream in this nation will go to those places which provide the fertile soil, the necessary conditions. Au revoir, US!

The simple reason for the cuts is revenge. Scientists, researchers, meteorologists, made Trump look like the moron he is. Now he wants to get even and punish them destroying the future of the country. In case you haven't noticed, Trump is trying to recreate a 50's economy that has been dead since the early 50's when the graduates of all the GI financed programs hit the economy.

We are preparing the ground for being unable to produce anything but cheap socks and coal-powered monster trucks, but at least the MAGAs owned the educated elites.

Republicans are adding \$4.5 trillion to the national debt for tax cuts for the wealthy. But are cutting scientific research budgets in half in order to "save money." Republicans are mentally ill.

It's not a surprise when Nuttall (the Commerce secretary) glories in a future where American fingers put screws in iPhones. The Trump circus sees no value in intellectual or scientific pursuits. Our future generations are doomed.

Look no further than Russell Vought, the Christian Nationalist now running the Office of Management and Budget for the origin of these cuts. Evangelical Christians hate science.

** This is such a fiasco. I'm not a scientist or a public servant, just a citizen who depends on these folks for basically all of modern life?!? I cannot believe a society as innovation rich, as well defended, as prosperous, and as tech-bedazzled as ours, that has been coasting on public investments in science for 80 years, would throw away this inheritance. And for what?!? Some memes making fun of smart people?

The smart people are leaving. See ya, Trump-scum, wouldn't want ta be ya.

Trump's war on science isn't just policy—it's national self-sabotage, a deliberate dismantling of America's intellectual infrastructure that's already driving our brightest minds into exile. The firing of NASA's chief scientists, the gutting of NSF and NIH budgets by 50-60%, and the freeze on critical research grants aren't fiscal prudence—they're ideological arson, burning decades of global scientific leadership to appease anti-intellectual zealots.

5/22/25: NYT. Trump Has Cut Science Funding to Its Lowest Level in Decades / The reporters analyzed 35 years of grants funded by the National Science Foundation. [Article captured as PDF file]

The National Science Foundation, which funds much of the fundamental scientific research at American universities, is awarding new grants at the slowest pace in at least 35 years. The funding decreases touch virtually every area of science – extending far beyond the diversity programs and other “woke” targets that the Trump administration says it wants to cut.

That means less support for early-stage research that underpins future technological advancements – and American competitiveness – in areas like computer science and engineering; physics and chemistry; climate science and weather forecasting; and materials and manufacturing innovations.

It also means less money for undergraduate and graduate students, postdoctoral researchers and early-career professors – potentially disrupting the nation's future scientific work force.

Economists have warned that cutting federal funding for scientific research could, in the long run, damage the U.S. economy by an amount equivalent to a major recession.

“These cuts are the height of self-inflicted harm,” said Robert Atkinson, the president of the Information Technology and Innovation Foundation, a nonpartisan science and technology policy research institute. The foundation has argued that China probably already conducts more research and development than the United States.

...The lag in this year's funding, more than \$1 billion below the 10-year average, is for new research grants, but the Trump administration has gone further. It has also terminated more than 1,600 active grants for existing research projects, together worth roughly \$1.5 billion (of which at least 40 percent has already been spent).

And it wants to eliminate nearly \$5 billion of the agency's \$9 billion budget for next year, cutting spending on "climate; clean energy; woke social, behavioral and economic sciences," and diversity, equity and inclusion programs. Among the in-progress grants that have been terminated, those focused on education in science, technology, engineering and mathematics, or STEM, accounted for the vast majority of the canceled funding. Many of these grants focused on broadening participation in science and engineering among underrepresented student groups.

...The N.S.F. said in a statement that while it will focus on the Trump administration's priorities – like artificial intelligence, quantum information science, biotechnology and nuclear energy – it remains "committed to awarding grants and funding all areas of science and engineering."

...Yet the data shows the agency's funding of new grants at its lowest level since at least 1990, around when the N.S.F. expanded into its modern structure. The funding has slowed even further since April 30, when agency employees were told to stop awarding funds entirely, according to an email reviewed by The New York Times.

[Tables on awards made so far in 2025 show...

Physics	-85%
Math	-72%
Chem	-57%
Astron	-53%
Educ	-80%
Engr	-57%
Biol	-52%
Geosci	-33%
CompSci	-31%
Socsci	-29%
Tech	-20%

with respect to the 10year average 2015–2024.]

...“There's total confusion,” said one employee who has worked at the N.S.F. for more than a decade and is involved in determining which grants are recommended for funding. The employee, who did not want to be named out of fear of retaliation for speaking to the news media, said that the N.S.F.'s rigorous review process had been disassembled, and that political mandates had taken precedence over scientific merits when assessing grant proposals. “There's confusion on how much money we can spend,” the employee said. “And then there's confusion because the processes are basically paralyzed.”

Comments...

Thank you for publishing this article -- the impact on the sciences has been an extinction-level event, and it will take years, possibly decades, to reverse the damage that has already happened. In my field, astrophysics, there were about 600 fewer PhD positions offered nationally this year because of cuts to NSF. The NSF offered half as many fellowships supporting PhD students this year as last, across all fields of science. Summer research training programs for undergraduates were cut by about 1/3. Those students aren't going to come back to continue their studies in four years (or more) when the administration changes. Our graduating students who are serious about scientific careers are moving abroad at a pace I've never seen before. They can read the writing on the wall, and the dismal job market anticipated for this fall. These cuts are disproportionately hitting our future -- our students and postdoctoral researchers. The hits to facilities are also coming. We have world-leading facilities, but if they can't pay the folks to keep them running, they will be mothballed -- we've seen it before, but the public has a short memory. We are rapidly losing our status as world leaders in science, and nobody seems to have noticed. Or worse, they have noticed and are cheering about it. It's self-destructive madness.

A country never has enough intellectual horsepower. Importing American scientists is like money in the bank.

Having been involved in biomedical scientific research for more than 40 years, my only comment is that termination of grants and cuts to the budgets of the NIH and NSF will have catastrophic consequences for our country. Besides the acute effects, these actions signal to students and trainees considering scientific research as a career they should consider alternatives. The resulting gaps in the pipeline of trained personnel have irreversible downstream effects. Fundamental discoveries will not be made, and biotechnology and pharmaceutical companies will have fewer leads to pursue for new therapies. Besides the negative impact on health of this country, the economic consequences will be substantial. None of the current actions make sense if the goal of the current administration is to improve health of our population and remain globally competitive. We cannot rely on the courts to resolve the current crisis. Congress must stand up and do its job for the American people.

The problem is the Republican party isn't just using anti-expert populism to win votes. We now are being run by people who do not seem to understand how our scientific dominance has made us the most wealthy and powerful nation in the world. I can't help but wonder if the right wing obsession with seeing woke politics in scientific research has been a deliberate disinformation campaign by our friends in China and Russia designed to get us to dismantle the engine of our own prosperity.

Thanks for this. Most Americans have never heard of NSF, but the research it funds plays a monumental role in every aspect of our lives. One of my dear friends, a brilliant scientist and tenured professor at an R1, is leaving a program officer role at NSF after the chaos of being required to relocate to DC and then fired, rehired, and harassed over the last few months...This all trickles down to universities as a whole, medical centers, surrounding communities, state governments and infrastructure, and a wide range of private industries. It's not hyperbolic to say that the cuts to science funding will have catastrophic effects on the American way of life and the future of humanity.

Not mentioned in this article is how graduate programs in STEM are rescinding offers of admission. Students are being offered many thousands of dollars to leave. Principal investigators, whose funding was already extraordinarily difficult to secure, are finding themselves unable to continue and uncertain about their futures. Their institutions' indirect cost revenues are shriveling overnight, making just keeping the lights on a challenge. This is happening nationwide right now at the most elite programs and institutions. The Trump administration is taking what ACTUALLY made America great (the world's marvel of innovation, creativity, education) and purposefully throwing it all away. For nothing.

I am a research scientist at a leading university and I can confirm the outlook is even bleaker than described in this article. The most immediate impact of cutting new grants, beyond the science, will be a dramatic reduction in graduate student and post-doc hiring (this is happening already). This will mean a catastrophic disruption in the training of next generation scientists.

Any sector that is dependent upon innovation is going to be impacted by these cuts. And the idea that an administration can just wash away previously legislated spending is simply astonishing. There is no way that a modern society can function with this level of incoherence, even more so for what's left of the "natural" world.

China is thrilled. America just conceded the 21st century.

Because of the decades to millennial long lag between a climate forcing and our feeling the full effect, due to the thermal inertia of the ocean and response time of the ice sheets, the effects we are feeling now are largely just the beginning of the result of emissions from the 20th century. And emissions have been increasing steadily for decades. We are also seeing numerous amplifying feedbacks: loss of albedo (heat reflectivity) from ice melt, permafrost melt, methane release and massive wildfires; the Earth is starting to wrest any possible further human control of the climate away. We're about out of time on this, if not already, and leaders are still acting as if

this is not a planetary emergency.

I've been a Biochemistry Faculty member at the University of Washington since 1967 and have served on multiple NSF and NIH scientific review panels. Something the Public, Congress, and DOGE budget cutters don't realize is that...80-90 percent of applications for student fellowships and research grants -- despite their general high quality -- are never funded due to chronically insufficient funding for these agencies. The current financial and personnel decapitation of NSF & NIH are thus depriving the USA of the very best scientific talent it has now and for the future. This is an intellectual and cultural disaster in the making.

Trump slashing science funding is not just neglect, it's a deliberate step in a long, dangerous tradition of silencing truth to consolidate power. History is repeating itself louder, and more shamelessly.

"Trump administration's priorities -- like artificial intelligence, quantum information science, biotechnology and nuclear energy." -- These are all based in math, physics, and chemistry, which is being cut the most. The only conclusion that seems reasonable is that the GOP has been paid off by Putin and Xi to purposefully destroy our ability to compete. Without graduates there will be no one to continue our competitive advantage and the US becomes hollowed out from within.

I am a retired physician who has witnessed, sometimes with amazement, the massive advances in medical science since I graduated from med school in 1978. I have my father's medical school notes (1945) also, so I can compare what was known then. In 1945 there was substantially knowledge about anatomy, neuroanatomy, basic biochemistry, physiology and pathology, but almost no effective treatments. Penicillin was first used in the US in 1942.

[cont] What has changed, in living memory, is massive new understanding of immunology and disease pathology, along with miraculous new treatments, especially in oncology and heart disease. Patients with large heart attacks were doomed when I was a medical student. Now they go home the next day. Most diabetics lost at least one limb before they went blind and then died of renal failure. I have not had a patient lose a limb or go blind in decades. Metastatic melanoma was a death sentence as recently as 1995. Now with immunotherapy, many patients are cured. I can go on and on and on!

[cont] All of this was only made possible by federal biomedical research funding. The budget cuts (40% at NIH and 50% at NSF) and program elimination (for example closing the CDC Cancer Prevention Office) are irrational and psychotic. People like Cruz and other GOP politicians who vote for this insanity should have to revert back to

1945 medical therapy when they get sick.

As someone who has spent his entire 50+ year career working in technology industries, I can state categorically that this is the single worst decision in that entire period. Research funding has waxed and waned over that time but always with some understandable rationale. This decision was made without any consideration of the consequences, which will be felt for generations to come. Add this to the list of things that will wipe out the Republican majorities in Congress in 2026.

Congratulations President Trump. In 100+ days you have ransacked scientific research in the US, reducing it from the international powerhouse and leader we have been since WWII, to just another country struggling to get funding for projects. You may call it "America First," but having laid waste to STEM research, we are now "America Last."

NSF and NIH supported the most successful scientific ecosystem by peer-reviewed grant funding. The saddest quote in this article for me: "N.S.F.'s rigorous review process had been disassembled, and that political mandates had taken precedence over scientific merits when assessing grant proposals." We will feel this loss for decades.

If the country is aiming to be uncompetitive, focusing on a Soviet-style aging, isolated, and destructive economy, this is a good start.

5/22/25: From: FYI <fyi@aipcomm.org>
Subject: NSF Adds DEI and Israel Boycott Restrictions to Grant Terms

FYI: Science Policy News from AIP
BULLETIN
May 22, 2025

NSF Adds DEI and Israel Boycott Restrictions to Grant Terms

The restrictions apply to all new grants and amendments to existing ones. A composite image of pages from NSF's new grant policy overlaid atop an image of the Foundation's HQ.

Pages from the National Science Foundation's new grant policy. NSF / AIP The National Science Foundation updated its grant conditions on Monday to bar recipients from operating certain diversity, equity, and inclusion programs or participating in boycotts of Israel. The move follows a similar policy issued by the National Institutes of Health last month.

The new conditions state that accepting an award from NSF means the

recipient is certifying that it does not operate any programs that “advance or promote DEI, or discriminatory equity ideology in violation of federal anti-discriminatory laws,” nor will it boycott organizations with Israeli ties. NSF reserves the right to terminate funding to recipients it deems to be in violation of the policy.

The policy applies to all new NSF grants and funding amendments to existing grants, agency spokesperson Michael England said in a statement. England did not comment on what types of programs would violate the policy.

The new conditions reference an executive order from President Donald Trump in January that defines “discriminatory equity ideology” as “an ideology that treats individuals as members of preferred or disfavored groups, rather than as individuals, and minimizes agency, merit, and capability in favor of immoral generalizations.” This includes the belief that “an individual, by virtue of the individual’s race, color, sex, or national origin, should be discriminated against or receive adverse treatment to achieve diversity, equity, or inclusion,” the order adds.

No definition is provided for programs that “advance or promote DEI” in a way that would violate anti-discrimination laws.

“The unfortunate thing here is that the administration hasn’t done much to specifically define what they believe would be an unlawful DEI program,” said Posi Oshinowo, a labor and employment attorney at Wiley Rein. Another executive order directed the attorney general and secretary of education to issue guidance by May 21 regarding compliance with the Students for Fair Admissions v. Harvard ruling by the Supreme Court that race-conscious admissions are unlawful, but that guidance has not been issued yet, Oshinowo added.

“There are limited glimpses available as to what the administration views as unlawful,” Oshinowo said. A letter from the Department of Education in February asserts that the ruling in SFFA v. Harvard “should actually extend to virtually all aspects of how educational institutions operate. So not just admissions, but hiring, compensation, financial aid, scholarships, prizes, administrative support, discipline, housing, graduation ceremonies, and all other aspects of student, academic and campus life,” Oshinowo said.

“It takes the position as well that even race-neutral programs could be unlawful discrimination if they are motivated by racial considerations. One of the things they specifically call out is using essays or writing samples or extracurricular activities to try to predict, or solicit without soliciting, a student’s race,” Oshinowo added.

Additionally, the Equal Employment Opportunity Commission and the

Department of Justice issued guidance in March that identifies unlawful DEI practices, including programs that use race, gender, or sexual orientation as an eligibility factor; quotas, including aspirational goals tethered to compensation for hiring managers or leadership; affinity groups, except where groups are open to all and can be created by anyone; mandatory minimum slate requirements, such as a requirement to consider 30% “diverse” candidates in a candidate pool; and “discriminatory training.”

DEI restrictions implemented by other grantmaking agencies have been challenged in court. For instance, a grant condition restricting DEI activities for Department of Housing and Urban Development grantees is currently subject to a temporary restraining order. The judge wrote that the conditions likely exceed the department’s constitutional authority, are not closely related to the purposes of the grants, and are likely void due to vagueness.

The ban on boycotts of Israel is more clear because the conditions document provides a definition, Oshinowo said. “It also seems to be a pretty clear response to the demands of student protesters during the recent protests related to university support of Israel,” he added. “So it’s sort of an anti-capitulation obligation imposed there by the administration on universities and institutions that receive grants.”

The Trump administration has demonstrated a willingness to terminate individual grants and cut off funding to entire institutions by invoking conduct relating to DEI or Israel.

NSF has already terminated more than a thousand grants it deemed related to DEI or other topics, such as misinformation and environmental justice, that do not “effectuate” agency priorities. NSF and several other science agencies also cut off funding to Harvard University on May 12, with NSF’s termination letter asserting that Harvard “continues to engage in race discrimination including in its admissions process, and in other areas of student life, as well as failing to promote a research environment free of antisemitism and bias.”

Harvard filed a lawsuit alleging that the funding freezes and terminations go beyond the scope of agencies’ anti-discrimination procedures by targeting research programs that are not connected to the alleged discrimination.

In total, NSF has terminated more than 1,750 grants since the beginning of the administration, according to a new spreadsheet published by the agency.

5/22/25: From: FYI <fyi@aipcomm.org>

Subject: What's in Store for Science in Republicans' Reconciliation Bill

FYI: Science Policy News from AIP
BULLETIN

May 22, 2025

What's in Store for Science in Republicans' Reconciliation Bill
Lindsay McKenzie

The bill could have major implications for defense, energy, and industrial R&D.

House Republicans are advancing tax breaks for private R&D, large cuts to clean energy programs, and higher taxes on college endowments as part of their budget reconciliation bill for fiscal year 2025. A major spending boost for defense is also included in the bill, as well as plans to restart federal auctions of electromagnetic spectrum bands.

The House passed the "One Big Beautiful Bill" early Thursday in a 215–214 vote after a 42-page manager's amendment helped to win over several Republican holdouts. Under the reconciliation process, the bill will now proceed to the Senate where it may be passed with a simple majority vote, circumventing the need for Democratic support. Senate Republicans are expected to produce their own version of the legislation.

Any budget changes in the bill will be separate from the annual discretionary budget process.

Tax changes

The House's bill would reintroduce tax rules allowing companies to fully deduct domestic research costs in the year they occurred, a move that has been endorsed by many companies and universities that partner with them. This provision would reverse a rule introduced in the 2017 Tax Cuts and Jobs Act that requires companies to spread the deduction of R&D costs over five years. (That rule took effect in 2022.)

The bill also would modify the current 1.4% endowment tax on some private colleges and universities' net investment income to introduce a tiered system of rates, with a top rate of 21% for institutions with endowments exceeding \$2 million per student. In addition, the bill would eliminate several tax breaks for non-profit organizations, including an exemption on taxes for non-publicly funded research income. Higher education advocacy groups such as the Association of American Universities have opposed these changes.

Increased military spending

The bill would provide a \$150 billion boost to defense spending, of which \$24.7 billion is for construction of the "Golden Dome" missile defense shield that President Trump proposed back in January. To support this endeavor, the bill contains \$18.8 billion for "next-generation missile defense technologies," including \$7.2 billion for the development and procurement of military space-based sensors, \$5.6 billion to develop space-based and phase intercept capabilities, and \$250 million for development of directed energy capabilities. Supporting innovation and enhancing commercial technology for military use are mentioned multiple times throughout the bill. Under a section on enhancing DOD resources for scaling low-cost weapons into production, the bill includes \$2 billion for expanding the Defense Innovation Unit, a \$1 billion boost for "programs to accelerate the procurement and fielding of innovative technologies," \$250 million for the Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency's Quantum Benchmarking Initiative, and \$120 million for development of small modular nuclear reactors for military use...

Big cuts to clean energy

The bill would significantly restrict or eliminate many of the clean energy incentives introduced by President Joe Biden as part of the Inflation Reduction Act, including clean energy tax credits, advanced manufacturing tax credits, Environmental Justice Block Grants, and the Greenhouse Gas Reduction Fund. Multiple Department of Energy offices would see unobligated funding rescinded if the bill passes unaltered, including the Loan Programs Office, the Office of Energy Efficiency and Renewable Energy, and the Office of Policy, among others.

Authorizing spectrum auctions

The bill would restore the Federal Communications Commission's spectrum auction authority, with the hope of raising \$88 billion by 2034 through sales of 600 megahertz of spectrum. At present, the funds would be used to offset the costs of other provisions of the legislation. Democrats' suggestions to spend the funds on specific federal programs were voted down during committee amendments. Sen. Maria Cantwell (D-WA) has in the past proposed using auction funds to support science programs authorized by the CHIPS and Science Act, but this option no longer appears to be on the table.

5/23/25: From: Van Scoyoc Associates <kmorrison@vsadc.com>
Subject: Washington Week in Science – May 23, 2025

A Weekly Update of Science Policy News and Select Funding Opportunities

FDA significantly limits COVID-19 vaccine recommendations The US

Food and Drug Administration (FDA) announced this week it will only recommend COVID-19 vaccines for adults 65 and older and people at risk for severe illness. In a marked departure from the current recommendations of seasonal vaccination for anyone 6 months and older, the FDA will require manufacturers to conduct clinical trials demonstrating the efficacy of COVID-19 vaccines for healthy children and adults under age 65. Writing in the New England Journal of Medicine, FDA Commissioner Martin Makary, MD, MPH, and Vinay Prasad, MD, MPH, director of the FDA's Center for Biologics Evaluation and Research, said the move aligns the United States with other high-income nations that have limited vaccine access to older and vulnerable populations. Read more: CIDRAP Young adults see alarming spike in 14 types of cancer, NIH report reveals Researchers at the National Institutes of Health (NIH) have uncovered some important trends in cancer cases across the United States. Between 2010 and 2019, they found that 14 types of cancer became more common among people under the age of 50. Among these were several well-known types, including breast cancer and colorectal cancer. Interestingly, nine of the rising cancer types also showed increases in some people over 50. Read more: SciTechDaily

CDC accepts recommendations for chikungunya vaccines The U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention has accepted its advisory panel's recommendations on vaccines for chikungunya, a virus transmitted by mosquitoes. Read more: Reuters

Defense

Defense Department caps indirect research cost rates for universities The Department of Defense is planning to cap indirect cost reimbursement rates for higher education institutions at 15 percent, according to a May 14 memo signed by Secretary of Defense Pete Hegseth. The memo directs the DOD to develop the new policy within 21 days, marking the fourth federal agency—including the National Institutes of Health, the Department of Energy and the National Science Foundation—that has enacted a plan to cap indirect cost rates at 15 percent. Read more: Inside Higher Ed

DOD's tech agency braces for 10% workforce cut The Pentagon's IT agency will lose nearly 10 percent of its total staff as part of the Trump administration's push to slash the federal workforce, the agency's director told senators Wednesday. But the workforce reduction may have its upsides. "It's giving us an opportunity to ruthlessly realign and optimize how we are addressing what is an evolving mission," Lt. Gen. Paul Stanton, director of the Defense Information Systems Agency, said during a Senate Armed Services Committee hearing on May 21. Read more: Defense One

Trump unveils plans for \$175B 'Golden Dome' missile defense shield President Donald Trump on Tuesday unveiled plans to begin building a

sophisticated new missile defense shield that could intercept threats from space, estimating the endeavor would cost some \$175 billion and become operational in three years. The project "Golden Dome," which will be led by Space Force Gen. Michael Guetlein, echoes President Ronald Reagan's failed "Star Wars" program, which was criticized for being overly ambitious and siphoning money away from other national priorities. The White House cited advancements in technology as a reason why some of Reagan's vision was now possible. Read more: [ABC News](#)

Energy

Federal judge blocks Energy Department's 15% cap on indirect research costs A federal judge granted a preliminary injunction blocking the U.S. Department of Energy from instituting a 15% cap on reimbursement for colleges' indirect research costs. A group of universities and higher education associations sued the department in April, alleging it had overstepped its authority in implementing the policy and applying the change retroactively by terminating grants with reimbursement rates above the cap. In her ruling last week, U.S. District Judge Allison Burroughs agreed with the plaintiffs' arguments and said they are likely to succeed in proving the Energy Department's funding cap is "arbitrary and capricious" and violates federal law. Read more: [Higher Ed Dive](#)

Space

NASA says long-running budget shortfalls may lead to ISS crew and research reductions NASA says a "multi-year" budget shortfall even before the proposed cuts in the fiscal year 2026 budget request have led the agency to consider reductions in crew size and research on the International Space Station. At a May 20 press conference about the upcoming Ax-4 private astronaut mission to the station, Dana Weigel, NASA ISS program manager, was asked about language in the top-level fiscal year 2026 budget proposal that seeks to reduce spending on the ISS by half a billion dollars, part of \$6 billion in overall cuts to the agency. Read more: [Space News](#)

NASA's Jet Propulsion Lab ending telework policy for over 1,000 employees NASA's Jet Propulsion Laboratory (JPL) has told more than 1,000 telework employees they must return to on-site work. The move effectively ends remote work at JPL, which had been a fixture at the Pasadena, California lab since the pandemic. Employees were notified via email Thursday that an end to telework would take effect on Aug. 25 for general employees within California, and Oct. 27 for teleworkers living outside the state. Read more: [Space.com](#)

Space Force, NGA reach agreement on purchasing power for commercial ISR Top officials from the Space Force and the National

Geospatial-Intelligence Agency signed a memorandum of agreement Wednesday that delineates how the organizations will share duties for buying space-based intelligence from commercial providers. Read more: [DefenseScoop](#)

Fundamental Science and Engineering

Trump has cut science funding to its lowest level in decades. The National Science Foundation, which funds much of the fundamental scientific research at American universities, is awarding new grants at the slowest pace in at least 35 years. Among the in-progress grants that have been terminated, those focused on education in science, technology, engineering and mathematics, or STEM, accounted for the vast majority of the canceled funding. Many of these grants focused on broadening participation in science and engineering among underrepresented student groups. The N.S.F. said in a statement that while it will focus on the Trump administration's priorities – like artificial intelligence, quantum information science, biotechnology and nuclear energy – it remains “committed to awarding grants and funding all areas of science and engineering.” Yet the data shows the agency's funding of new grants at its lowest level since at least 1990, around when the N.S.F. expanded into its modern structure. The funding has slowed even further since April 30, when agency employees were told to stop awarding funds entirely, according to an email reviewed by The New York Times. Read more: [New York Times](#)

Trump's science adviser defends funding cuts as a chance to 'revitalize' U.S. science. Michael Kratsios, science adviser to President Trump, sent a blunt message to the U.S. research community, saying the community needs to learn how to thrive with less money from the federal government. Speaking to a gathering at the National Academy of Sciences building, the former tech executive said the Trump administration's termination of billions of dollars in federal grants and its proposal to slash agency budgets next year should prompt the science community to rethink its priorities. Read more: [Science](#)

As it awaits a court ruling, NSF pauses attempt to cap indirect-cost payments on research grants. The US National Science Foundation (NSF) has paused a policy that threatened to cost universities hundreds of millions of dollars a year in 'research overhead' payments. The suspension, announced last Friday, follows freezes of similar policies at the US National Institutes of Health (NIH) and the US Department of Energy (DoE). The NSF announced on 2 May that it would cap overhead payments on new research grants at 15% and was swiftly sued by a coalition of 13 US universities and 3 academic associations seeking to stop the policy. The newly announced pause will last until 13 June, when a judge will hear the case. Read more: [Nature](#)

5/23/25: To: The Caltech Community

From: Thomas F. Rosenbaum, President
David A. Tirrell, Provost

Date: May 23, 2025

Re: Your Support of Caltech Research and Education

The U.S. House of Representatives this week passed legislation that proposes to dramatically expand a tax on university endowments. If enacted, it would jeopardize funding that is invested directly in our mission to advance world-leading research and to educate tomorrow's STEM leaders for the benefit of society.

The House proposal implements a tiered tax structure, ranging from 1.4 percent to 21 percent, on the annual investment income that Caltech and other universities across the country generate from long-term, permanent investments from donors. At Caltech, a tax of this proportion would result in an annual loss of tens of millions of dollars in funding, endangering one of the Institute's primary revenue sources. Endowment revenue supports student financial aid and is invested in the Caltech faculty, facilities, and research and education programs that help make the U.S. a global leader in science, engineering, and innovation. Furthermore, the House bill undermines our ability to maintain the current level of private funding that is necessary to continue to deliver on the high level of excellence in research and education that our community experiences today.

We write to bring to your attention that this bill will be discussed next in the Senate, and to ask you to make the case for Caltech's research and teaching mission to your networks and your elected representatives. Now, more than ever, it is important that we all make clear to the Senate and to our representatives that if this provision remains in the final tax bill it will have a fundamentally damaging impact on private colleges and universities – and their students – across the country.

Our endowment, which has been nurtured over decades through the collection and strategic management of individual donations, is allocated to support Caltech's research and education every day.

- * Over the past five years, Caltech's endowment has made possible \$200 million in cumulative investment in student financial aid—an investment that is critical to our ability to practice 100% need-blind admissions, which means that domestic students are admitted to Caltech without consideration of their financial need, and ensures that more than 75% of our students graduate from Caltech debt-free.

- * Furthermore, this past year, with confidence in the long-term stability of the endowment as a foundation for planning, the Institute expanded its financial commitment to undergraduate students and their families. Beginning with the fall 2025 incoming class, students with family incomes of \$200,000 or less receive offers of financial aid packages that cover the full cost of tuition, while students with family incomes of less than \$100,000 receive offers of grant aid packages that cover the full cost of tuition, fees, housing, and food.
- * Simultaneously, Caltech has used annual allocations from the endowment to attract and retain leading faculty across fields of study and to support them in the launch of new and continuing research endeavors, such as projects that demonstrate the viability of seismic technology as a tool for measuring ground water, that pioneer novel autonomous systems and technologies, and that have led to an interdisciplinary effort to harvest solar power in space and transmit it back to a receiver on Earth.

We are grateful to our donors who over decades have generously invested in Caltech, in our research, and importantly in our people because of a shared commitment and belief in our mission. The financial resources generated from their investments, which we have been fortunate to grow over time, are essential to our ability to advance research and education that enhances well-being, drives innovation, and supports U.S. leadership in science and engineering. We take seriously our responsibility to deliver a public good and allocate the private resources we have been gifted and stewarded to that end.

As Caltech's president and provost, we advocate continually for the value of Caltech's contributions to society and join with other Caltech senior leaders and alumni and friends to communicate how we realize our mission and the importance of this work to economic development, job creation, public health, and national security, impacting the success of communities across the country. The next few weeks are a critical period in which you can add your voice to the conversation. The House bill will go before the Senate to be discussed, debated, and potentially amended. If the Senate approves the bill with modifications from its current version, the Senate and House will need to reconcile any difference and agree on one final proposal before the bill becomes law. This means that we have a concentrated window to advocate for the importance of science and discovery, of research and the value of the investment in students' education, and of the contributions that we make every day at Caltech to tackle the world's most complex challenges. I encourage you to contact your senators [caltech.us11.list-manage.com] and to urge them to reject the endowment tax increase and any such provision that would cripple our ability to deliver world-class education and research.

Please share the following important information with your elected representatives:

- * The endowment tax places more financial burden on students by making universities less affordable and less equipped to contribute to our economic prosperity, public health, and national security. Taxing schools reduces the revenue available for financial aid, a primary use of the endowment.
- * Colleges and universities manage endowments responsibly. Caltech relies heavily on its endowment to support its integrated research and education mission. Of the \$211 million drawn from the endowment in FY 2024, 90 percent of the funds were invested in financial aid and fellowships or research and teaching endeavors.
- * The endowment tax will undermine the country's global leadership in technology and innovation.
- * America's universities lead the curiosity-driven research that has led to transformative new technologies and innovations that define our lives, from artificial intelligence to the ability to sequence the human genome, to pioneering chip design that has allowed for smartphones, personal computers, and other electronic devices. The work from laboratories at Caltech and America's other universities has profoundly changed our world and has the potential to continue to drive future innovations and advancements.

5/28/25: WP. RFK Jr. says he may bar scientists from publishing in top medical journals / Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. took aim at reputed journals such as the Lancet and said his agency will create "in-house" publications instead.

Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. said Tuesday that he may bar government scientists from publishing in the world's leading medical journals, instead proposing the creation of "in-house" publications by his agency – the latest in the Trump administration's attacks on scientific institutions.

"We're probably going to stop publishing in the Lancet, New England Journal of Medicine, JAMA and those other journals because they're all corrupt," Kennedy said during an appearance on the "Ultimate Human" podcast. He also described the journals as being under the control of pharmaceutical companies.

The three journals he named, all established in the 1800s, publish original, peer-reviewed research and play a central role in disseminating medical findings worldwide. JAMA, published by the American Medical Association, and the Lancet each say they receive more than 30 million annual visits to their sites, while the New

England Journal of Medicine says it is read in print and online by more than 1 million people each week.

...Kennedy also accused several agencies under the Department of Health and Human Services – including the National Institutes of Health, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, the Food and Drug Administration, and the Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services – of being “sock puppets” for the pharmaceutical industry.

On his plans for the department to create its own journals, Kennedy said they would “become the preeminent journals, because if you get [NIH] funding, it is anointing you as a good, legitimate scientist.”

Adam Gaffney, a public health researcher and an assistant professor at Harvard Medical School, wrote in an email that “banning NIH-funded researchers from publishing in leading medical journals and requiring them to publish only in journals that carry the RFK Jr. seal of approval would delegitimize taxpayer-funded research.”

Comments...

Hold on a second... I just noticed this... does the blurb below this article's headline really read "reputed" rather than "reputable?!?!"

Where is the voice of the AMA in protest? Why are they not pointing out that for all intents and purposes RFK, Jr is practicing medicine without a license to the detriment of the entire country? The AMA and all professional medical organizations should demand that RFK, Jr resign.

Kennedy knows that no reputable scientific journal will publish his hand picked hacks' pseudo-scientific "studies" linking autism and vaccines, so he is going to set up a scientific vanity press to do so on his behalf. U.S. science is becoming an arm of government policy and ideology, not honest scientific inquiry. This is how we end up looking like the old Soviet Union in its absurd embrace of Lamarckian evolution.

George Orwell is beginning to look like a prophet, not just a brilliant novelist. The whole idea of science is independent, unbiased observation and experimentation, uninfluenced by ideology or preconception. RFK Jr. is right that private industry has too much self-interested influence over what research gets done and (occasionally) on how ambiguous results are interpreted. But the solution is *more* government spending on research suggested by independent, non commercial scientists and published in independent, well-established scientific journals. Setting up a government party line for determining what research to fund and for vetting research results is the wrong approach entirely.

...if he can actually prevent federally funded researchers from submitting articles to respected journals (can he?), that will undermine their careers.

This just continues to get more appalling by the day; as a healthcare provider/educator I don't even know what to say anymore except the Nazis are not at the door: they are IN THE HOUSE.

It's almost like putting a junkie in charge of HHS was a bad idea.

Journals like the Lancet are world renowned and respected. I wish I could say the same about RFK

5/30/25: Science. Final NSF budget proposal jettisons one giant telescope amid savage agencywide cuts / Trump's 57% proposed cut to agency would drop grant success rates to 7% and gut education and training

...Following up on the "skinny budget" unveiled on 2 May, the White House's full NSF budget request to Congress for the 2026 fiscal year would all but doom one of two proposed giant telescopes, eliminate funding for the U.S. global change research program and research on clean energy technologies, and close half of a pioneering gravitational wave observatory whose data on black hole mergers produced a Nobel Prize. The NSF budget proposal would also reduce by two-thirds the agency's investment in training the next generation of U.S. scientists and engineers and eviscerate its \$1.4 billion portfolio to increase the diversity of that workforce.

"The \$3.9 billion request reflects a strategic alignment of resources in a constrained fiscal environment in which NSF prioritizes investments that can have the greatest national impact," according to a statement from an agency spokesperson. (Computer scientist Sethuraman Panchanathan abruptly resigned as NSF director last month; he's been replaced on an acting basis by his former chief of staff, Brian Stone.)

The president's budget, which requires congressional approval, would deliver a crushing blow to the many thousands of academic researchers who depend on NSF funding. Their recent one-in-four chance of winning a grant would plunge to a minuscule 7%, turning the already competitive review process into a near-lottery. The number of scientists supported by an NSF grant would contract by three-quarters, as would the number of elementary and secondary school students and their teachers. NSF's prestigious CAREER program, which gives 5-year grants to hundreds of young investigators, would disappear.

Trump's budget would even slash many of the areas his administration has identified as national priorities. NSF's investment in research on advanced manufacturing, for example, would dip by 65%, microelectronics research would fall by 54%, and NSF's support for biotechnology would drop by 30%. Research on artificial intelligence (AI) and quantum information science (QIS) are the only priority areas that would be protected, with AI getting a 3% boost and QIS holding steady.

Although those cuts were foreshadowed in Trump's partial budget, today's 225-page proposal contains some surprises. It doesn't call for the massive layoffs that many scientists had feared. Instead, NSF's 1550-person workforce would shrink by 15%, the document says. At the same time, the number of academic scientists on leave from their institutions for assignments of 2 to 4 years at NSF would drop from 300 to 70. Those people, known as rotators, have traditionally been the sources for the dozens of new initiatives that NSF launches each year to address pressing research questions.

Trump has also unexpectedly preserved the agency's account for building new facilities, after removing funding for it from the 2025 NSF budget that Congress finalized in March. The 2026 request would provide \$251 million for major facilities, some \$201 million of which would be used to complete work on a \$500 million supercomputer at the University of Texas at Austin. NSF's long-delayed renovation of its main Antarctic research stations would continue to move at a crawl, getting \$25 million in 2026 rather than the \$60 million NSF had previously planned on spending for each of the next several years.

And the astronomical community will be stunned that the agency intends to wind down one of the sites for the celebrated Laser Interferometer Gravitational-Wave Observatory (LIGO), now operating from twin locations in Louisiana and Washington state. The observatory rely on both sites working together to confirm detections of waves and data from each, combined with information from international counterparts, are used to localize the waves' celestial sources.

In the budget request, NSF also says it will back only one of the two \$3 billion optical telescopes that the astrophysics community wants to build. That honor goes to the Giant Magellan Telescope already under construction in Chile. Its competitor, the Thirty Meter Telescope (TMT), "will not advance to the Final Design Phase and will not receive additional commitment of funds from NSF," according to the budget request.

NSF's oversight body, the National Science Board, had recommended the agency spend \$1.6 billion on one of the telescopes. But the budget warns GMT's backers, a consortium of 15 institutions, that "moving into the final design phase does not guarantee a project will be approved for construction, and doing so does not obligate the agency

to provide any further funding."

[Doesn't mention LSST]

5/30/25: On Facebook: From Fred Rasio

"Given the unaffordability of continuing funding two different multi-billion dollar telescopes, NSF will advance the Giant Magellan Telescope (GMT) into the Major Facility Final Design Phase, but the Thirty Meter Telescope (TMT) will not advance to the Final Design Phase and will not receive additional commitment of funds from NSF. NSF has received assurances from the GMT project that it can complete the final design phase without further investments. Moving into the final design phase does not guarantee that a project will be approved for construction, and doing so does not obligate the agency to provide any further funding. The FY 2026 Request supports continued design of a single telescope within the U.S. Extremely Large Telescope (ELT) program."

[Finally! ... a decision has been forced. Only a decade too late. It's only happening now because Trump intends to decimate NSF. Even with a sensible decision, the likelihood of a US ELT is probably below 30%. We'll be lucky if NRAO and NOIRlab survive.]

Comments...

Brian Siana: TMT US partners are primarily in California. Hard not to wonder if that played a role. Also, they want to shut down one of the two LIGO sites, because why would you need two sites? Efficiency!!

[Siana is at UC Riverside. But, no, the main reason NSF would choose GMT is that it is years ahead of TMT in terms of site infrastructure. It's regrettable that GMT isn't in the northern hemisphere, but that's a secondary consideration.]

Chien-Hsiu Lee: NSF said the same thing in FY25, and the congress came back and said they want two:
<https://aas.org/.../fy25-senate-funding-bill-nasa-and-nsf...>

5/30/25: AAS. Scientific Societies Issue Letter to Congress Regarding National Science Foundation Reorganizations and Cuts

A coalition of professional societies and organizations whose members conduct research in fields supported by the National Science Foundation (NSF) today issued a letter to the United States

Congress. The letter expresses support for the NSF and concern about recent organizational and financial developments at the agency.

The NSF has a 75-year successful record of driving groundbreaking innovations and landmark achievements through its support of basic research and education in the non-medical sciences and engineering. Recently, the agency has experienced abrupt reorganizations and reductions in force, plans to reduce its scope, abrupt cancellation of existing grants, and devastating proposed cuts to its future budget.

The letter, which is initially endorsed by more than 50 signatories, calls on the leaders of the US Senate Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation and the US House Committee on Science, Space, and Technology to exercise their oversight authority to investigate those developments.

The full text of the letter and the initial signatories can be found here:

Letter addressed to the leadership of the authorizing committees with oversight over NSF (PDF)

<https://aas.org/sites/default/files/2025-05/Letter%20Regarding%20NSF%20from%20Scientific%20Organizations.pdf>

Organizations interested in joining the letter are invited to contact the American Astronomical Society's Deputy Director of Public Policy, Roohi Dalal, at roohi.dalal@aas.org.

5/30/25: NasaWatch. Here's That Wonderful NASA Budget News

Janet Petro's latest Embrace the Challenge update: ..."The supplement includes the Congressional Justifications for our programs and mission areas, as well as my letter to Congress highlighting key points of the budget request. We are currently assessing the priorities and impacts to our teams and programs, and I have asked our leadership team to move forward with discussing their specific areas with you soon. Please take time to review the additional information on the budget documents online..."

Comments...

Not much different than what leaked out earlier. And is really just a wishlist from the Administration. As before in the first Administration, hopefully Congress (and Issacman) will restore some some funding and projects.

Jared has publicly supported MSR, hopefully he'll have some sway

with the WH and Congress.

MSR is 11 billion. A Ford class aircraft carrier is 10 billion. MSR is toast. JPL costed the mission out of existence.

I work on MSR so it saddens me to say this, but it was seriously mis-managed. NASA blew it on this one. Would have been such a cool and important mission for Mars science. I hate to see any cuts but I am not surprised about this one.

They go in-depth with the CS FTE and how many folks are going to get laid off. Some centers get a slight decrease while others get cut nearly half.

This budget calls for eliminating 5,000 civil servant positions from the agency relative to FY25. What an absolute nightmare for NASA.

1/3 of the agency -- and then there's the contractor work force on top of that...

Between now and when congress passes the appropriation (which is quite possibly never, like FY25), NASA is required to use the president's budget as actual planning numbers, and operate accordingly. If and when congress passes something it could be too late to reverse.

The FY26 budget doesn't retroactively cut the FY25 budget, and NASA is staffed to accommodate the FY25 budget, and the FY25 budget is law. That money has to be spent to do what it was appropriated for. For example RST was on the chopping block in the president's budget every year in his last term. Obviously NASA didn't lay off the RST staff and cancel the contracts then rehire and redo them a few months later four times. That's not to say the administration won't try to do something unlawful, they already have. But HHS and NIH were specific ideological targets of the administration, and even then their efforts haven't been as clean and straightforward as they'd hope so NASA may not seem worth the same trouble.

OK so WTF? What's the news? What level of funding are they eyeballing at the moment? I know Prez at 18B and House and Senate \$24B, what's the final deal? Or do we wait? Probies need to thank the can kickers.

From the Senate "NASA Transition Authorization Act" a few months back, it shows there is major support for NASA at \$25,507,540,000 (MCC25339 Y9G) And the House similar support late last year with \$25,224,640,000 (H. R. 8958) Reading through them ó I'm not all that worried now

I think this request is definitely the low-ball, and Congress will push back some. This request cuts 700 NASA jobs from Texas, 526 from Alabama, 510 from Florida, 554 from Ohio, 100 from Mississippi. That's 10 Republican senators. What concerns me is if they haggle over the top-line budget numbers and the administration still just RIFs a third of the workforce because they want to.

48% of Civil Servants at GSFC are gone. A once thriving center with 3k+ CS folks now down to 1.5k! It's not looking like a good summer for these folks. Depressing actually.

A proposed cut of 48% to GSFC FTEs, and even JSC/MSFC/KSC, which fared the best, are looking at cutting 20-25%.

39-40% FTE cuts at Langley, Ames, and Glenn Research centers. That is going to be a massive long term hit to NASA's research, which unfortunately is where most of NASA's long term economic impact is generated. Talk about shooting ourselves in the foot. It's a great way to initiate a death spiral for NASA R&D, and 40% cuts make it a pretty steep descent. For those talking about congress coming in and rescuing us, be aware that NASA has to plan to the proposed budget and that includes staffing and procurement. Even if congress comes through with some gravy later on, it could be too late.

STEM outreach is cut to zero. That's a very long term negative impact to the US aerospace industry. We will pay for that in ways we cannot even imagine.

5/30/25: Science. Dozens of active and planned NASA spacecraft killed in Trump budget request / Proposal would end nearly all new major science missions

President Donald Trump's administration is seeking to throttle the scientific ambitions of NASA, prematurely ending a host of active missions in orbit studying Earth and other planets, while also ending the agency's work to develop their successors. The plans, released today, call for a "leaner" agency that will land "the first human ever, an American, on Mars." But they would effectively end NASA's long-standing role as the world leader in space science, researchers say—if the U.S. Congress follows through on them.

Earlier this month, with its "skinny" budget request, the Trump administration made clear its desire to drastically slash NASA's science spending, with a proposal to cut it in half, down to \$3.9 billion. But beyond the possible cancellation of several major in-development missions—including the troubled \$7 billion Mars Sample

Return (MSR), which will collect rock samples from Mars and return them to Earth—the proposal had few details. That changed today, with the late Friday afternoon release of the president's full 2026 budget request. It would end some 40 “lower priority” missions, the budget said, “for a leaner, more focused Science program.”

The long list of cuts, which would still need to be approved by Congress, “will really damage our ability to monitor critical processes from space,” says Anne Nolin, a remote-sensing scientist at the University of Nevada, Reno. The losses aren't limited to climate change, she adds—they would also undermine U.S. capacity to scout for critical minerals and forecast the weather.

“This is a tragic mistake for the new administration,” says Alan Stern, a planetary scientist at the Southwest Research Institute and former NASA science chief. The proposal undercuts the country's science pipeline and wastes billions of dollars, he adds.

The request would kill off missions that are active in space right now, including two Orbiting Carbon Observatories (OCOs): OCO-2, a standalone spacecraft launched in 2014, and OCO-3, which is mounted on the International Space Station. Both missions carry a spectrometer that spies on wavelengths of light absorbed by carbon dioxide molecules, providing an ability to map atmospheric carbon abundance around the planet. The missions enabled investigations into the variations of the natural carbon cycle and also proved capable of detecting human carbon emissions.

The budget proposal would also end the Earth-facing instruments on the Deep Space Climate Observatory, which monitors space weather and records snapshots of the planet's surface. It would kill the space station's Sage III instrument, which makes long-term measurements of ozone, water vapor, and other gases in the atmosphere. And it would terminate the Terra, Aqua, and Aura satellites, each of which has operated for more than 2 decades, providing unprecedented insight into climate change with steady, well-calibrated instruments. And although Terra and Aqua are both near the end of their lives, Aura, which measures the stratosphere in a way no other satellite can imitate, could operate until late this decade.

The losses would not stop at Earth. The proposal would end the Juno mission orbiting Jupiter, which has revealed the gas giant's interior structure and provided close-up views of its large moons. It would end New Horizons, which famously imaged Pluto and is now pushing into a Kuiper belt of cold, icy objects that is deeper than scientists once thought. It would terminate the OSIRIS-APEX mission, which is reusing the healthy spacecraft that returned asteroid samples to Earth to

visit the asteroid Apophis right after it makes a close pass of Earth in 2029. And it would kill off several spacecraft orbiting Mars, including Mars Odyssey and Maven, while pulling the agency's funds supporting Mars Express, another orbiter operated by the European Space Agency.

The plans would also kill off nearly every major science mission the agency has not yet begun to build. It would end development of the Atmosphere Observing System (AOS), a multibillion-dollar series of satellites meant to study the complex formation of clouds and storms and their alteration by pollution—one of the main sources of uncertainty for future climate change, seen most recently in the debate on how much ship pollution reductions influence recent record high temperatures.

It would also terminate the Surface Biology and Geology (SBG) mission, which would loft an instrument into space capable of dividing reflected light into more than 400 wavelength channels across the visible and into the infrared. While these measurements can be used to study methane and carbon dioxide emissions, such imaging spectrometers—which serve, in effect, as molecular mapping tools—can also be used to prospect for critical minerals and track forest and farm health. The proposal to end SBG is particularly disappointing, Nolin says. “It’s deeply unfortunate they don’t understand the greater value of an instrument like that,” she says.

In the planetary science division, the administration would cancel two much-delayed missions NASA has planned for Venus. One, called DAVINCI, would send an armored sphere plunging through the venusian atmosphere, measuring noble gases to sort out the planet's origins and sniffing for sulfur and carbon near the surface for more evidence of recent volcanic activity. The other, Veritas, would use a radar to peer through the planet's thick clouds and re-create its topography, revealing whether volcanoes or variants of tectonic plates are active on its surface. The MSR mission is still canceled, the budget said, as it is “anticipated that future missions to Mars will return samples for study on Earth.”

The budget would not seek to end the Roman Space Telescope, a survey telescope as big as Hubble, as some had suspected—but it would strip its development funding down from \$400 million to \$156 million, potentially undermining its finishing steps. For heliophysics, it would also end the agency's attempts to revive the Geospace Dynamics Constellation, a swarm of six satellites that would measure interactions between the Sun and Earth's magnetosphere. Also surviving in the request are Dragonfly, an ambitious rotorcraft that will explore Saturn's large moon, Titan; and NISAR, a joint radar mission with India, launching next month, that will measure minute changes on Earth's surface.

By killing off so many projects, the proposal would devastate the budget of the agency's two lead science centers, the Jet Propulsion Laboratory and Goddard Space Flight Center. Further pain would come as the budget seeks to rework space missions NASA is developing for other agencies, including the next generation of Landsat for the U.S. Geological Survey and new geostationary satellites for the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration.

The proposed cuts would provide an immediate challenge for Trump's nominee for NASA administrator, Jared Isaacman, who could be up for a confirmation vote next week in the Senate. Isaacman has told lawmakers a 50% cut in NASA's science budget is not "an optimal outcome," promising that he would "advocate for strong investment in space science — across astrophysics, planetary science, Earth science, lunar science, and heliophysics." That would include continuing with the Roman Space Telescope, he said, though he was also open to the idea of fully outsourcing MSR to private industry.

Although the agency would continue to operate missions it has just launched, if it continues down the track laid out by the budget, its capacity would be much diminished. If the agency also ends its Artemis Moon program after landing astronauts back on the lunar surface, there's a real risk that the agency devolves into nothing more than a glorified launch services provider.

But Stern, for one, is ready to take the fight for NASA's future to Congress. "I believe these cuts will not stand," he says. "I'm ready to take up that battle. And I know I'm in good company."

5/31/25: ArsTechnica. Trump pulls Isaacman nomination for space. / Source: "NASA is f***ed." "NASA's budget request is just a going-out-of-business mode" without Isaacman.

The Trump administration has confirmed that it is pulling the nomination of private astronaut Jared Isaacman to lead NASA. First reported by Semafor, the decision appears to have been made because Isaacman was not politically loyal enough to the Trump administration.

"The Administrator of NASA will help lead humanity into space and execute President Trump's bold mission of planting the American flag on the planet Mars," Liz Huston, a White House Spokesperson, said in a statement released Saturday. "It's essential that the next leader of NASA is in complete alignment with President Trump's

America First agenda and a replacement will be announced directly by President Trump soon."

The US Senate Commerce Committee approved Isaacman's nomination by a vote of 19 to 9 one month ago, advancing his candidacy to the floor of the US Senate, with unanimous support from Republicans in that April vote. Approval was anticipated after the Memorial Day holiday. But the tide started to turn against Isaacman late this past week, with the first rumblings of problems coming on Friday, May 30.

On Saturday, far-right political activist Laura Loomer said on X, "Deep State operatives are trying to derail President Trump's NASA Administrator pick Jared Isaacman before his Senate confirmation vote this week." This was the first public sign that Isaacman's candidacy was imperiled.

So what happened? The waters of MAGA run murky, and the political machinations of the Trump administration are abstruse. However, the timing of Isaacman's derailment coincides with the recent departure of SpaceX founder Elon Musk from Washington. Musk had a central role in the Trump administration during its first four months. In an interview on Tuesday, Musk told Ars that he has now "significantly" reduced his involvement in politics.

Musk was a key factor behind Isaacman's nomination as NASA administrator, and with his backing, Isaacman was able to skip some of the party purity tests that have been applied to other Trump administration nominees. One mark against Isaacman is that he had recently donated money to Democrats. He also indicated opposition to some of the White House's proposed cuts to NASA's science budget. Musk's role in the government was highly controversial, winning him enemies both among opponents of Trump's "Make America Great Again" agenda as well as inside the administration. One source told Ars that, with Musk's exit, his opponents within the administration sought to punish him by killing Isaacman's nomination.

The loss of Isaacman is almost certainly a blow to NASA, which faces substantial budget cuts. The Trump administration's budget request for fiscal year 2026, released Friday, seeks \$18.8 billion for the agency next year -- a 24 percent cut from the agency's budget of \$24.8 billion for FY 2025.

Now? "NASA is f---ed," one current leader in the agency told Ars on Saturday. "NASA's budget request is just a going-out-of-business mode without Jared there to innovate," a former senior NASA leader said.

The Trump administration did not immediately name a new nominee, but two people told Ars that former US Air Force Lieutenant General Steven L. Kwast may be near the top of the list. Now retired, Kwast

has a distinguished record in the Air Force and is politically loyal to Trump and MAGA.

However, his background seems to be far less oriented toward NASA's civil space mission and far more focused on seeing space as a battlefield—decidedly not an arena for cooperation and peaceful exploration.

Comments...

We are witnessing the dismantling of the American state. These losses will be generational in their impact and frankly we may never get them back. Utterly devastating and incredibly sad.

trump discovers he almost had someone who was qualified in the job

I wonder how much longer they'll continue to blame the supposed Deep State for everything?

Texas has been a Republican uniparty state for ~30 years. They still blame Democrats for literally everything.

He'll probably be replaced by someone who thinks the moon landing was a hoax.

I'm glad Isaacman has helped prove that good people are not part of the Trump regime in any capacity.

Bye bye US preeminence in space.

"...but hey, at least Starship isn't being held back by the FAA anymore." -- To be seen. Trump is massively vindictive, so if he becomes sufficiently pissed at Musk, all bets are off, especially if he's told that there's no way for a lunar landing, let alone a Mars landing, before his term ends. (Assuming his term ever ends.)

It's gonna be way, way worse than [3 years and 7 months]. For example, just in research, NSF grants are down over 51% this year and that is across the board. In my field it's 67%. This means that positions, both faculty and graduate, and undergrad student slots are going to have to be reduced. And there is no reason to think that this isn't going to be ongoing throughout the next 4 years. This means that when it's hopefully over it could take a very, very long time to recover just to get back to where we were 6 months ago. US Government funding of science is now below where it was 35 years ago. This is happening across the entire government in pretty much every area not benefiting a very small group of very wealthy people. The rest of us are well and truly fucked.

When he was put forward, I was not a fan of his ties to Musk, but at least his interest in space was genuine. Maybe he would work out despite that. It was like üphewý we could have done a lot worse. I guess we are about to find out just how much worse. Fucking sigh!!

Trump is gutting this country from the inside, and I just don't understand how 40% of this country doesn't see that.

'Poor Elon Musk', really? Are readers expected to forget that he spent \$275m to buy the US presidential election for Trump, and was wearing a stupid MAGA hat for months? And that the DOGEboys are his?

The fact that Isaacman's nomination has been withdrawn seems indicative to me that maybe his agenda would not have been utterly corrupt and awful. I do agree 100% with that last sentence, though: "NASA being f*cked is a function of the elected leadership, not its appointees."

Yeah we can thank all those people who thought it was a good idea to have a reality TV host and rapist as president, and the rest of the fuckers in this country who wasted votes on no-chance third party candidates or simply sat on their hands.

I was a bit leery of Isaacman to lead NASA, because of his proximity to Musk, but he was obviously passionate about space, and human spaceflight, so I thought, "well, he's probably the best nominee I can in a Trump regime". Seems like even he was too good to be true. It's deeply sad to see America being so gleefully corrupted and destroyed from within, with the gloating support of nearly half the population. A country where fealty to a cult leader is the only qualification to lead entire agencies is not to going to thrive for long. Not that it's really thriving for most people now.

5 years ago Elon Musk was a pro-Obama eco-friendly Democrat. 20 years ago Donald Trump was a pro-abortion Democratic donor. Their current political incarnation is no more real than those were. It's all grifting, all the way down.

Guess exploring the final frontier is easy compared to navigating the MAGA minefield – boldly going nowhere, fast!

Musk invested \$250m (+44b for Twitter, people forget that for some reason) to install a fascist government to run American. He got it. Everything else is crocodile tears.

JUNE

6/2/25: From: "Zhou, Yifan (uyr2ce)" <uyr2ce@virginia.edu>
To: "astro-alldept@virginia.edu" <astro-alldept@virginia.edu>
Subject: [astro-faculty] Fwd: AURA Member Rep Telecon – Fri 6/6

Hi Everyone,

AURA is holding a teleconference to provide an update on FY26 budget situation. I plan to attend as our department AURA representative. If you have questions, please send them to me and I will submit them to the organizer.

Meanwhile, white house's FY26 budget requests can be viewed below:

NASA: <https://www.nasa.gov/fy-2026-budget-request/>
NSF: <https://nsf-gov-resources.nsf.gov/files/00-NSF-FY26-CJ-Entire-Rollup.pdf>

Thanks,
Yifan

Begin forwarded message:

From: Samantha Asbury <sasbury@aura-astronomy.org>
Subject: AURA Member Rep Telecon – Fri 6/6
Date: June 2, 2025 at 4:34:15 PM EDT
To: Member Representatives <MR@aura-astronomy.org>, "Member Representatives – Alternates" <AlternateMR@aura-astronomy.org>, "ALT (AURA Leadership Team)" <alt@aura-astronomy.org>
Cc: Daria Bollinger <dbollinger@stsci.edu>, Tracy Lamb <lamb@stsci.edu>, "Lori Stuckey" <lori.stuckey@noirlab.edu>, Jen Ditsler <jditsler@nso.edu>

Hello Member Reps and Staff,

I trust you all have been well. Please join AURA for a telecon to provide an update on the current FY26 budget situation, this Friday 6/6 1–2pm ET. A calendar invite with Zoom information will be sent shortly.

If you'd like to submit a question ahead of time, please use the link below.

<https://tinyurl.com/MbrRepTelecon>

Thank you,
Samantha Asbury
Senior Projects and Events/Meeting Coordinator
sasbury@aura-astronomy.org

6/2/25: From: FYI <fyi@aipcomm.org>

Subject: This Week: NSF and NASA detail proposed budget cuts / DOE begins axing major projects / State Department dissolving multiple S&T offices

FYI: Science Policy News from AIP

THE WEEK OF JUNE 2, 2025

A rendering of the proposed Thirty Meter Telescope, which NSF has declined to advance to the agency's final design phase. Courtesy of the TMT International Observatory

PROPOSED SCIENCE CUTS COMING INTO FOCUS

The Trump administration has begun elaborating on its proposed budget for fiscal year 2026, publishing some agency-specific documents and a government-wide summary last Friday that expand on the "skinny budget" released in early May. The National Science Foundation's full budget request to Congress details how the proposed 57% topline cut would be distributed across the agency's research programs and facilities. For instance, NSF proposes to operate only one of the two existing Laser Interferometer Gravitational-Wave Observatory (LIGO) sites and to cut support for the Large Hadron Collider to about 60% of the current level, reducing U.S. researchers' participation in LHC research accordingly. NSF also indicates it will not advance the Thirty Meter Telescope project to the final design phase or supply any further funding. The agency does pledge to advance the Giant Magellan Telescope to the final design phase but does not commit to seek construction funding for the project. (The agency has been debating whether to support either project to completion.)

Despite suggested cuts to high-profile science facilities, the administration does propose to increase NSF's major facility construction budget to \$251 million, up from \$234 million in fiscal year 2024. The lion's share of this budget (\$201 million) would go to the planned Leadership-Class Computing Facility led by the University of Texas at Austin.

AI and quantum information science are the only crosscutting research areas that are protected from major cuts in the budget proposal. NSF estimates the total number of competitive grant awards would plummet from around 9,600 to 2,300, and the proposal acceptance rate would drop from 26% to 7%.

NASA's request proposes a 47% cut to science programs compared to fiscal year 2024 operating plan levels, including a 71% cut to biological and physical sciences and a 66% cut to astrophysics. The

budget provides for a “leaner, more focused science program, eliminating over 40 lower-priority missions,” the document states. Among the proposed cancellations are the Mars Sample Return mission, Chandra X-ray telescope, various Earth observation satellites, and the HelioSwarm solar observation satellites. The administration also proposes to eliminate the STEM Engagement directorate.

Presidential budgets have historically served more as an indication of policy priorities than an exact blueprint for spending decisions, and Congress will advance its own spending proposals this summer. Any final discretionary spending legislation will need bipartisan support in the Senate to overcome the 60-vote threshold needed to advance bills in that chamber.

DOE BEGINS TERMINATING MAJOR CLEAN ENERGY PROJECTS

The Department of Energy terminated over \$3.7 billion in clean energy grants last week that were awarded during the Biden administration. DOE did not release a list of the affected projects but said they primarily work on decarbonization or carbon capture and sequestration. The agency’s press release emphasized that 16 of the 24 awards were approved between Donald Trump’s election and his inauguration. DOE said the projects “failed to advance the energy needs of the American people, were not economically viable, and would not generate a positive return on investment of taxpayer dollars.” The terminations resulted from a DOE review of 179 awards that were “rushed out the door, particularly in the final days of the Biden administration,” Energy Secretary Chris Wright said earlier in May. At an appropriations hearing for DOE, Wright said the Biden administration awarded \$93 billion in the period after Trump’s election. Democratic appropriators have sharply criticized the decision to terminate projects already selected for funding.

STATE DEPARTMENT FORGES AHEAD WITH PLANS TO DISSOLVE SCIENCE OFFICES

A major reorganization of the State Department that would eliminate multiple science offices is moving forward, with Secretary of State Marco Rubio submitting a plan to Congress last week. Internal documents reviewed by FYI suggest affected units include the Office of Science and Technology Cooperation, the Office of Global Change, the Office of the Science and Technology Advisor to the Secretary, and the Office of the Special Envoy for Critical and Emerging Technology. Statutory functions of these units will be reassigned to other offices. Current and former State Department staff warned FYI last month that disruption to the work of the Office of Science and Technology Cooperation could have a significant negative impact on scientists, as the office oversees major scientific international collaboration agreements for research facilities such as CERN and ITER, among other functions.

The organizational chart proposed by Rubio retains the position of assistant secretary of oceans, environmental, and international scientific affairs. The chart also includes a new assistant secretary for “emerging threats.”

ALSO ON OUR RADAR

- * President Donald Trump has withdrawn his nomination of Jared Isaacman to lead NASA, reportedly because of donations he made to Democrats. The Senate planned to take a final vote on Isaacman’s nomination this month.
- * A group of 16 states sued the National Science Foundation last week over its indirect costs cap and the termination of DEI-related grants.
- * Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick will testify before Senate and House appropriators on Wednesday and Thursday, respectively. His department’s budget request includes steep cuts to NIST and NOAA.
- * The Senate Foreign Relations Committee will meet Thursday to consider advancing the International Quantum Research Exchange Act and a bill that would extend the International Organizations Immunities Act to CERN.

In Case You Missed It

Rubio May 2025 Senate Foreign Relations Committee.png

US to ‘Aggressively Revoke’ Visas Held by Chinese Students

MAY 30, 2025

The action is among a series of recent and anticipated clampdowns on academic exchanges with China. A conference session with attendees sitting at tables, facing towards two speakers and two projector screens displaying presentation slides.

Researchers Scramble Following NSF Grant Cuts

MAY 28, 2025

Former grantees are navigating how to close out or continue their work without funding from the agency.

6/4/25: From: President Thomas F. Rosenbaum <president@caltech.edu>
Subject: 2024–25 Academic Year–End Letter

To: The Caltech Community
From: Thomas F. Rosenbaum
Sonja and William Davidow Presidential Chair
and Professor of Physics

Re: 2024–25 Academic Year–End Letter

When I last wrote you in December 2024, wishing you constancy and courage in the new year, I don't believe that any of us could have anticipated the tempest that ensued with the turn of the calendar. The Eaton fire swept through Altadena and surrounding neighborhoods in January 2025, uprooting Caltech staff, faculty, and students. Between campus and JPL, more than 300 lost their homes and thousands were displaced. The harsh reality is that it will take years to recover. At the same time, the support of a tightly knit, caring community became evident immediately. We found temporary housing for scores of victims and raised an astonishing \$5 million plus for an emergency relief fund that was dispersed in short order and with little bureaucracy. Classes resumed within days and the research enterprise has continued to hum. Our shared mission of forefront research and education in service of society inspires all of us and makes manifest the need to buoy those in need.

The Santa Anas were followed in quick order by ill winds blowing from Washington, DC. A spate of executive orders and Congressional actions have assaulted higher education from every direction: attachment of funds, unilateral lowering of overhead reimbursements well below negotiated rates for actual costs, proposed slashing of the science budget by 50%, decimation of science agencies, many fold increases in the endowment tax, restrictions on international scholars. As we attempt to navigate this treacherous landscape, it is helpful to step back and ask, what is our role and what are our responsibilities as a research university in a democratic society?

For generations, the relationship between universities and the federal government has been governed by a mutually beneficial social compact. In return for tax exempt status, universities support our democracy by educating informed and involved citizens, and by translating fundamental discoveries into technologies that drive our economy, strengthen our national defense, and improve people's lives and health. Since World War II, the research mission of the university has been amplified by substantial government investment, leading to a rise in standards of living, longer and more productive life spans for our citizens, and protection from external threats.

The American higher education system is arguably the most successful industry in the country in terms of demand, output, and longevity. With only 4.5% of the world's population, the United States has competed successfully against all comers by becoming the

destination of choice for many of the world's most talented, creative, and ambitious individuals, many of whom are drawn to our shores by our preeminent college and university system. Historically, a high proportion of these immigrants (fully 75% according to government data) have stayed and applied their skills for the betterment of society as American citizens. Caltech is no exception. Roughly half of our graduate students are international; approximately 45% of our faculty were born abroad; and close to 40% of American Nobel Prizes in the sciences were awarded to researchers who emigrated to the United States.

At a time when the social compact between universities and the government is fraying, what can we do? I believe that it is incumbent upon us to distill the essential components that permit universities to fulfill their missions as creators of knowledge and bulwarks of democracy. We can only meet the challenges of the day by sharply articulating our principles and staying true to them. Prominent among these principles are:

1. Intellectual freedom. Knowledge emerges from the clash of ideas, honed by testing arguments with those who disagree in an environment where an insight does not have to be popular to be correct. It requires an environment where the members of the community feel free to express their thoughts without fear of censorship (external or internal), to engage with contrary views, and to be willing to change their minds. This includes the ability of faculty to teach what they wish and universities to hire whom they wish, always consistent with an academically rigorous vetting process.
2. Institutional neutrality. Freedom of individual expression bears as well on the issue of formal institutional pronouncements. Universities should aim to create an environment where all members of the community are empowered to speak out about issues that matter to them and support that freedom and ability. All members of the community should feel free to take stances that may be unpopular, but reflect who they are and what they believe, without an official university position quenching that ability. Hence, it is prudent to confine official university statements to issues that bear directly on the core missions of research and education. This does not preclude an institutional response to worldly challenges through tangible intercessions that directly support at-risk members of the community, consonant with the university's mission.
3. Inclusive excellence. Knowledge is most effectively created by bringing together exceptional people of diverse perspectives, of different backgrounds, of distinct sensibilities, and letting them hone their conceptions of the world by expressing their views freely and, in colloquy, shaping each other's ideas. It requires

fashioning a robust, civic space, welcoming to individuals from all backgrounds, prizing excellence, committed to rigorous inquiry, devoted to understanding the natural world and improving the human world. The most talented individuals have the most choices, and both the local environment (university ethos and policies) and the global environment (e.g., funding, immigration policy, freedom of expression) must be attractive for them to pursue their futures in the United States.

4. Free movement of people and ideas. Resources are an essential component of discovery and innovation, but the structure in which those resources are applied determines the level of success. The United States traditionally has valued and encouraged collaborations across disciplines, across university communities, and across national boundaries, all of which have been key to accelerating progress and vaulting American universities (and industries) into world-leading status.

What we do every day and what we do together matters. We believe in facts, we believe in truth, and we believe in science. We believe in challenging the accepted wisdom if the evidence drives us to that conclusion. We believe in learning from those who are different from us and those with whom we disagree, seeking to sharpen our own understanding. We believe in the transformative capacity of discovery, as a way to realize our human potential and as a means to improve the human condition. There is great power in this clarity and there is no more important time than now to demonstrate the constancy of our aspirations through our courage to defend our communal mission.

6/4/25: ArsTechnica.

Missing the big picture

US science is being wrecked, and its leadership is fighting the last war

Facing an extreme budget, the National Academies hosted an event that ignored it.

John Timmer

WASHINGTON, DC – The general outline of the Trump administration's proposed 2026 budget was released a few weeks back, and it included massive cuts for most agencies, including every one that funds scientific research. Late last week, those agencies began releasing details of what the cuts would mean for the actual projects and people they support. And the results are as bad as the initial budget had suggested: one-of-a-kind scientific experiment facilities and hardware retired, massive cuts in supported scientists, and entire areas of

research halted.

And this comes in an environment where previously funded grants are being terminated, funding is being held up for ideological screening, and universities have been subjected to arbitrary funding freezes. Collectively, things are heading for damage to US science that will take decades to recover from. It's a radical break from the trajectory science had been on.

That's the environment that the US's National Academies of Science found itself in yesterday while hosting the State of the Science event in Washington, DC. It was an obvious opportunity for the nation's leading scientific organization to warn the nation of the consequences of the path that the current administration has been traveling. Instead, the event largely ignored the present to worry about a future that may never exist.

The proposed cuts

The top-line budget numbers proposed earlier indicated things would be bad: nearly 40 percent taken off the National Institutes of Health's budget, the National Science Foundation down by over half. But now, many of the details of what those cuts mean are becoming apparent.

NASA's budget includes sharp cuts for planetary science, which would be cut in half and then stay flat for the rest of the decade, with the Mars Sample Return mission canceled. All other science budgets, including Earth Science and Astrophysics, take similar hits; one astronomer posted a graphic showing how many present and future missions that would mean. Active missions that have returned unprecedented data, like Juno and New Horizons, would go, as would two Mars orbiters. As described by Science magazine's news team "The plans would also kill off nearly every major science mission the agency has not yet begun to build."

A NASA graphic showing different missions focused on astrophysics. Red Xs have been superimposed on most of them.

A chart prepared by astronomer Laura Lopez showing just how many astrophysics missions will be cancelled. Credit: Laura Lopez
<<https://bsky.app/profile/ohdearz.bsky.social/post/3lqi5ueblrs2t>>

The National Science Foundation, which funds much of the US's fundamental research, is also set for brutal cuts. Biology, engineering, and education will all be slashed by over 70 percent; computer science, math and physical science, and social and behavioral science will all see cuts of over 60 percent. International programs will take an 80 percent cut. The funding rate of grant proposals is expected to drop from 26 percent to just 7 percent, meaning the vast

majority of grants submitted to the NSF will be a waste of time. The number of people involved in NSF-funded activities will drop from over 300,000 to just 90,000. Almost every program to broaden participation in science will be eliminated.

As for specifics, they're equally grim. The fleet of research ships will essentially become someone else's problem: "The FY 2026 Budget Request will enable partial support of some ships." We've been able to better pin down the nature and location of gravitational wave events as detectors in Japan and Italy joined the original two LIGO detectors; the NSF will reverse that progress by shutting one of the LIGOs. The NSF's contributions to detectors at the Large Hadron Collider will be cut by over half, and one of the two very large telescopes it was helping fund will be cancelled (say goodbye to the Thirty Meter Telescope). "Access to the telescopes at Kitt Peak and Cerro Tololo will be phased out," and the NSF will transfer the facilities to other organizations.

The Department of Health and Human Services has been less detailed about the specific cuts its divisions will see, largely focusing on the overall numbers, which are down considerably. The NIH, which is facing a cut of over 40 percent, will be reorganized, with its 19 institutes pared down to just eight. This will result in some odd pairings, such as the dental and eye institutes ending up in the same place; genomics and biomedical imaging will likewise end up under the same roof. Other groups like the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention and the Food and Drug Administration will also face major cuts.

Issues go well beyond the core science agencies, as well. In the Department of Energy, funding for wind, solar, and renewable grid integration has been zeroed out, essentially ending all programs in this area. Hydrogen and fuel cells face a similar fate. Collectively, these had gotten over \$600 billion dollars in 2024's budget. Other areas of science at the DOE, such as high-energy physics, fusion, and biology, receive relatively minor cuts that are largely in line with the ones faced by administration priorities like fossil and nuclear energy.

Will this happen?

It goes without saying that this would amount to an abandonment of US scientific leadership at a time when most estimates of China's research spending show it approaching US-like levels of support. Not only would it eliminate many key facilities, instruments, and institutions that have helped make the US a scientific powerhouse, but

it would also block the development of newer and additional ones. The harms are so widespread that even topics that the administration claims are priorities would see severe cuts.

And the damage is likely to last for generations, as support is cut at every stage of the educational pipeline that prepares people for STEM careers. This includes careers in high-tech industries, which may require relocation overseas due to a combination of staffing concerns and heightened immigration controls.

That said, we've been here before in the first Trump administration, when budgets were proposed with potentially catastrophic implications for US science. But Congress limited the damage and maintained reasonably consistent budgets for most agencies.

Can we expect that to happen again? So far, the signs are not especially promising. The House has largely adopted the Trump administration's budget priorities, despite the fact that the budget they pass turns its back on decades of supposed concerns about deficit spending. While the Senate has yet to take up the budget, it has also been very pliant during the second Trump administration, approving grossly unqualified cabinet picks such as Robert F. Kennedy Jr.

All of which would seem to call for the leadership of US science organizations to press the case for the importance of science funding to the US and highlight the damage that these cuts would cause. But, if yesterday's National Academies event is anything to judge by, the leadership is not especially interested.

Altered states

As the nation's premier science organization, and one that performs lots of analyses for the government, the National Academies would seem to be in a position to have its concerns taken seriously by members of Congress. And, given that the present and future of science in the US is being set by policy choices, a meeting entitled the State of the Science would seem like the obvious place to address those concerns.

If so, it was not obvious to Marcia McNutt, the president of the NAS, who gave the presentation. She made some oblique references to current problems, saying, "We are embarking on a radical new experiment in what

conditions promote science leadership, with the US being the treatment group, and China as the control," and acknowledged that "uncertainties over the science budgets for next year, coupled with cancellations of billions of dollars of already hard-won research grants, is causing an exodus of researchers."

But her primary focus was on the trends that have been operative in

science funding and policy leading up to /but excluding/ the second Trump administration. McNutt suggested this was needed to look beyond the next four years. However, that ignores the obvious fact that US science will be fundamentally different if the Trump administration can follow through on its plans and policies; the trends that have been present for the last two decades will be irrelevant.

She was also remarkably selective about her avoidance of discussing Trump administration priorities. After noting that faculty surveys have suggested they spend roughly 40 percent of their time handling regulatory requirements, she twice mentioned that the administration's anti-regulatory stance could be a net positive here (once calling it "an opportunity to help"). Yet she neglected to note that many of the abandoned regulations represent a retreat from science-driven policy.

McNutt also acknowledged the problem of science losing the bipartisan support it has enjoyed, as trust in scientists among US conservatives has been on a downward trend. But she suggested it was scientists' responsibility to fix the problem, even though it's largely the product of one party deciding it can gain partisan advantage by raising doubts about scientific findings in fields like climate change and vaccine safety.

The panel discussion that came after largely followed McNutt's lead in avoiding any mention of the current threats to science. The lone exception was Heather Wilson, president of the University of Texas at El Paso and a former Republican member of the House of Representatives and secretary of the Air Force during the first Trump administration. Wilson took direct aim at Trump's cuts to funding for underrepresented groups, arguing, "Talent is evenly distributed, but opportunity is not." After arguing that "the moral authority of science depends on the pursuit of truth," she highlighted the cancellation of grants that had been used to study diseases that are more prevalent in some ethnic groups, saying "that's not woke science—that's genetics."

Wilson was clearly the exception, however, as the rest of the panel largely avoided direct mention of either the damage already done to US science funding or the impending catastrophe on the horizon. We've asked the National Academies' leadership a number of questions about how it perceives its role at a time when US science is clearly under threat. As of this article's publication, however, we have not received a response.

At yesterday's event, however, only one person showed a clear sense of what they thought that role should be—Wilson again, whose strongest words were directed at the National Academies themselves, which she

said should "do what you've done since Lincoln was president," and stand up for the truth.

Comments...

It's a classic catch-22. If you resist and speak up you may lose everything. If you ignore, cower & bow you may lose everything. The only certainty is, if you do the latter you lose your dignity & soul as well. Oh the irony: Every book written in the western world teaches us to be brave and stand up for what we believe in, yet in reality we are a bunch of cowards that believe in nothing.

It will also kill or gut a lot of suppliers, vendors, and contractors who provide the tools, supplies, and expertise to keep science working. Those will likewise be very difficult to replace.

There's so much the Trump administration is doing that harms people, but I feel like what they're doing to science and education will have the largest detrimental to the US as a country. I don't think we'll ever recover from this. Even if funding is restored, many of our professors and researchers will have left the country or moved on to other jobs, and we'll no longer attract many of the best and the brightest international students because of the very real threat that they're just one bad US election away from being locked up and face deportation for no real reason.

America is the only country strong enough to bring down the United States.

True! It's up there with and even beyond Brexit, where the UK declared a trade war on itself!

I see an image of a drunken country, with nukes in its back pocket, performing a self-lobotomy.

[This has] been the explicit conservative project for the last ~70 years. They want a clean slate do-over of the New Deal, all at the behest of our billionaire aristocracy.

Say goodbye to radio astronomy. Our billion-dollar investment in unprecedented telescope arrays is being rendered useless by SpaceX Starlink anyway. And one more thing: In case it isn't obvious, defunding ground-based astronomy hits particularly hard in remote, generally economically depressed communities. People work hard at a fraction of commercial tech sector wages, because it means a salary and health insurance and lifting families out of poverty. Inspiring generations of rural kids to pursue careers in STEM fields. Often the first people in their families to leave home to attend university. Paving the way for cousins and siblings. Remote astronomy

is a massively fertile investment in our people. Not only scientists: those massive sculptures of steel are maintained and operated by highly-qualified crew. You could fund a village in West Virginia or Kentucky or New Mexico for what this administration has spent on Mar-a-Lago weekends.

The Jurassic Park school of political engagement: its vision is based on movement! Don't move a muscle.

McNutt is a 73 year old who is worth millions and has a list of professional honors and awards a mile long. Unless we're at the Khmer Orange point (we are not) she has nothing to lose by speaking up: if it accomplishes anything, she gets remembered in history as a savior of American science. If it costs her the job riding the Titanic down, she can retire to the country of her choice with the respect of her colleagues around the world. I appreciate that everyone wants to be able to avoid attention and just focus on research, but this kind of thing is part of why professional organizations exist. Someone is being given an enormous amount of social capital to help look out for their field, not just to go to expensive dinners several times per year. The National Academies need to speak up for all of the researchers, assistants, and students because they're far better equipped to do so than a grad student or postdoc being paid peanuts and dependent on grants for anything other than a complete career switch.

Reagan was already fighting science, on a much smaller scale but with the same ideology. Most things Trump has been doing have been done and thought of 40 years ago, if more cautiously. The United States will not recover until the Republican Party – the party of Reagan – is no longer a effective political force, even if in the next election we have a 55% "landslide" Democratic victory.

It's hard to be brave when they are going to take your income, then your house goes and then you live on the street.

A friend of mine who works for a fluorescence microscope company just got laid off, along with half the company. It's very bad.

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RWO draft:

[The Senate should be working as hard as possible to restore US funding for basic scientific research that the Trump administration has proposed to cut.]

The proposed budget cuts threaten the entire scientific ecosystem in the country. For a moment, set aside the inevitable long-term

crippling of America's scientific and technological prowess and look at the short-term economic impact.

Implementing this budget would lead to a financial depression for the scientific workforce -- not just for the scientists themselves but for hundreds of thousands of support staff and the tens of thousands of businesses that supply them. People can easily visualize the sophisticated equipment needed by modern science in the case of the space program...but biology and clinical research laboratories depend just as much on high-tech infrastructure in the form of advanced electronics, information technology, precision devices, special materials, and other indispensable elements.

How many people would lose their jobs? Since all the money allocated by the federal government is ultimately spent on people's salaries, it's easy to make a rough estimate. The proposed cuts to the major science agencies amount to about \$35 billion. Since each federal dollar spent directly on science generates something like an additional two dollars of related economic activity in the country, the total loss to the economy would be about \$100 billion. Taking a round figure for the salary of an average worker in the US scientific system of \$80,000, that implies an equivalent loss of over one million jobs.

[Original text was "salary plus benefits...of \$100,000" -- but in this simple model, the "benefits" are also mostly spent on people's salaries. So, removing the benefits from the per-person computation, the model predicts 1,250,000 job losses.]

This will arrive as a sudden calamity, not a gradual transition that might allow the system to readjust with time. The US deliberately adopted a special structure 75 years ago in which basic research is mainly supported by the government but applied research is mainly supported by the private sector. As a result, alternative employment will not be available for many of the affected people, perhaps for years. Many will lose their livelihoods, their financial security, their homes. Collateral damage to local housing markets and essential services like health care will be serious. The effects will be centered on communities hosting research universities or other major research centers all over the country, in red and blue states alike. Phoenix, Houston, Cleveland, Nashville, Miami, and the "Research Triangle" in North Carolina are good examples of places often overlooked by those who imagine research is concentrated in blue states.

How can anyone think this is good for America?

Budget cuts: cf. IHE for 6/3/2025; Science for 5/2/25.

NASA	6 B
NSF	5 B
NIH	18 B
DOE	1 B (Office of Science)
NOAA	1.5 B
USGS	0.5 B
CDC	3 B

TOT: 35 B

EDUC 12 B

Unilateral (intellectual) disarmament.

By 7/1/25 I find myself often thinking, "Well, at least astronomy will continue to thrive in Europe and the rest of the world."
This is incredibly sad...

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6/6/25: Van Scoyoc newsletter

Space

Isaacman: people with 'axes to grind' about Musk caused withdrawn NASA nomination Jared Isaacman made clear he believes his nomination to be administrator of NASA was pulled by the White House because of his ties to Elon Musk. Appearing on an episode of the All-In Podcast published June 4, Isaacman said he was informed by the White House May 30 that President Trump was withdrawing his nomination to lead the space agency, a move that became public the next day. The podcast appearance provided his first public comments about the withdrawn nomination other than social media posts. "There were some people that had some axes to grind, I guess, and I was a good, visible target," Isaacman added.

Dozens of NASA space missions could be axed under Trump's budget: Here's a look at 6 Dozens of NASA's missions to explore the cosmos could be in jeopardy under a budget proposal from the White House. President Donald Trump's administration, which released an initial budget proposal May 2 for the U.S. space agency, dropped more details Friday, May 30 about just which NASA programs it looks to

cancel. All told, the budget request for the next fiscal year proposes slashing NASA funding by nearly 25% – from \$24.8 billion to \$18.8 billion – mostly by eliminating a significant portion of the agency's science portfolio. Read more: USA Today [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

Musk–Trump rupture poses a serious threat to NASA and Pentagon programs
Elon Musk's threat, which he later retracted, to cut off NASA's use of SpaceX's Dragon spacecraft would be a huge blow to NASA, depriving the space agency of the only American vehicle capable of transporting astronauts to the International Space Station and dramatically changing how NASA would access the \$100 billion orbiting laboratory. The threat, posted on X, came during an escalating fight between President Donald Trump and the wealthiest man in the world, after Trump had threatened to cancel all of Musk's company's federal contracts. Given SpaceX's importance to multiple federal programs, severing those relationships could leave NASA as well as the Pentagon and intelligence agencies in a lurch. Read more: Washington Post [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

Fundamental Science & Engineering

NSF chemistry funding faces 75% cut under Trump budget request
The Trump administration has released more details of its FY2026 budget request and the picture for research is EVEN WORSE THAN THE 'SKINNY' BUDGET released last month [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]. Funding for chemistry from the National Science Foundation (NSF) in the math and physical sciences program is projected to plummet by 75%, from more than \$244 million last year to just over \$61 million. Materials research would be cut by 71% to \$92 million. The NSF has calculated that its grant funding success rate will fall from an average of 26% to just 7%. Overall, it is estimated that the agency's budget would face a cut of almost 57% from over \$9 billion to about \$4 billion. Read more: Chemistry World [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

6/6/25: NRAO Newsletter

NRAO Budget Outlook

Tony Beasley (NRAO Director)

The NRAO is continuing to operate using NSF funding received as part of the Federal FY2025 Continuing Resolution. On May 30th, the NSF FY2026 budget (responding to the President's Budget Request for FY2026) was released. The NSF document proposes deep cuts (30–40%) to the annual funding of most NSF Major Facilities, including a 34% cut to NRAO (ranging from 19% for ALMA, to 68% for the Green Bank Telescope). These figures represent the start of a several-month dialog between NSF, NRAO, AUI and the community about the importance and future of scientific user facilities in the United States, and we

are hopeful that the cuts seen in the NSF FY2026 Budget proposal will be mitigated or dismissed.

Over the past several months we have changed our range of services offered to the community in response to flat funding profiles: limiting student programs, publication support, travel support, etc. Members of the community anticipating relying on NRAO financial support should check the relevant Observatory webpages to ensure they understand any changes.

We are passing through a difficult time, and communications are rarely perfect. Please don't hesitate to contact your NRAO collaborators or program points-of-contact if you have questions about Observatory status and programs.

6/09/25: FYI

SENATE PITCHING \$10 BILLION BOOST FOR NASA, CLAWBACKS FROM NOAA

Senate Commerce Committee Republicans have included nearly \$10 billion for NASA in their draft contribution [aip.us17.list-manage.com] to the reconciliation legislation [aip.us17.list-manage.com] now awaiting Senate action. Some of the additions for NASA are at odds with the president's budget request [aip.us17.list-manage.com] released May 30, including additional funds for the Gateway lunar space station, Space Launch System rockets, and a telecommunications orbiter for use in a Mars Sample Return mission, all of which would be terminated under the president's request. The Senate bill would also increase funding for International Space Station operations, while the presidential request proposes maintaining minimal safe operations and very limited research on ISS.

Aside from the NASA provisions, the Senate bill would rescind certain unobligated funds for the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration that were appropriated by the Inflation Reduction Act. The original appropriated amounts included \$2.6 billion for climate resilience, \$150 million for facilities, \$150 million for forecasts, and \$50 million for climate research, though it is unclear what proportion of the funds is unobligated. A summary [aip.us17.list-manage.com] of the bill calls these projects unneeded.

ASTRONOMERS GATHER IN ALASKA

The 246th meeting [aip.us17.list-manage.com] of the American Astronomical Society is taking place in Anchorage, Alaska, this week. The event includes many sessions focused on the Vera C. Rubin Observatory, which is due to release its first imagery to the public

on June 23. [aip.us17.list-manage.com] Three NASA town halls that were planned as part of the event have been canceled, including one featuring staff from the Astrophysics Division and one on the planned Habitable Worlds Observatory, according to the online conference program. [aip.us17.list-manage.com] A plenary session [aip.us17.list-manage.com] on Thursday will address the current science policy landscape and advocacy opportunities for astronomers.

6/16/25: FYI

NSF BUDGET TARGETED FOR CLAWBACKS

The White House has set in motion an effort to freeze more than \$30 billion in spending across several agencies, including the National Science Foundation and NASA, E&E News reported [aip.us17.list-manage.com] last week. The move affects research and education programs at NSF that use funding left over from 2024 as well as more than \$100 million of science spending at NASA, according to the report. The move is a precursor to the White House submitting a spending "deferral" request to Congress, a legal mechanism to temporarily delay the use of funds. The delayed funding could later be included in a rescissions request like the one Congress is currently considering, [aip.us17.list-manage.com] which would claw back \$9.4 billion for foreign aid, NPR, and PBS.

NIH DOES 540° TURN ON ANTI-DEI AND BOYCOTT POLICY

Last week, the National Institutes of Health rescinded a policy [aip.us17.list-manage.com] from April that restricts grantees from operating diversity, equity, and inclusion programs and bars them from boycotting Israeli entities. Unusually, NIH briefly reinstated the policy before again rescinding [aip.us17.list-manage.com] it without explanation. The National Science Foundation implemented a similar restriction [aip.us17.list-manage.com] in May that is still in effect. The DEI restrictions respond to executive orders issued by President Donald Trump in January.

6/17/25: From: "Modjaz, Maryam (vru7qe)" <vru7qe@virginia.edu>
To: Faculty Department <astro-faculty@virginia.edu>
Subject: [astro-faculty] AAS PPT on Congress & Federal funding process

Dear colleagues,

I hope y'all having a nice summer!

I thought you'd be interested in the attached presentation by the AAS' Roohi Dalal on "Advocacy for the Astronomical Sciences" in the context of the Congress & Federal funding process that was given at the

LSST-Discovery Alliance membership meeting that UVA Astro is part of . The PPT was given on June 11.

It also includes routes of advocacy that we can take.

Cheers,
Maryam

[Part 2, "LSST DA 6-11-2025 R00HI DALAL-AAS.PDF" Application/
PDF]
[(Name: "LSST DA 6-11-2025 Roohi Dalal-AAS.pdf") 1.4 MB.]
[Unable to print this part.]

6/23/25: From: "Modjaz, Maryam (vru7qe)" <vru7qe@virginia.edu>
To: Faculty Department <astro-faculty@virginia.edu>
Subject: [astro-faculty] FW: Update – Court Decision Issued – Indirect
Cost Policy for Institutes of Higher Education (IHEs)

FYI – we're back to the normal indirect cost percentage with NSF>

From: NSF eBusiness Outreach <EBUSINESS@LISTSERV.NSF.GOV> on behalf of
NSF Business Applications <NSF_Business_Applications@NSF.GOV>

Date: Monday, June 23, 2025 at 3:17 PM

Subject: Update – Court Decision Issued – Indirect Cost Policy for
Institutes of Higher Education (IHEs)

Issuance Date: June 23, 2025
Effective Date: June 23, 2025

On June 20, 2025, the U.S. District Court for the District of
Massachusetts, in No. 1:25-cv-11231-IT, vacated NSF's 15% Indirect
Cost Rate policy (NSF 25-034). In compliance with the court's
decision, NSF will not implement the policy at this time.

6/23/25: FYI

A federal judge ruled last week that the National Institutes of
Health's termination of hundreds of grants earlier this year was
illegal and ordered the agency to resume funding for the
plaintiffs. The ruling applies to parties involved in the lawsuits,
including individual researchers named in the suit, members of the
American Public Health Association, the United Auto Workers union, and
researchers at public institutions in the 22 states that sued NIH. The
plaintiffs' lists of grants are included in court
[aip.us17.list-manage.com] orders [aip.us17.list-manage.com] released
today.

Judge William Young in Massachusetts found the terminations to be arbitrary and capricious, adding, [aip.us17.list-manage.com] "This represents racial discrimination and discrimination against America's LGBTQ community. I would be blind not to call it out." In response, a White House spokesperson told Fox News, [aip.us17.list-manage.com] "Justice ceases to be administered when a judge clearly rules on the basis of his political ideologies," while a Department of Health and Human Services spokesperson said the department "is exploring all legal options, including filing an appeal and moving to stay the order." The National Science Foundation is also facing lawsuits for its grant terminations, including one filed in late May [aip.us17.list-manage.com] by 16 states and another filed last week [aip.us17.list-manage.com] by several groups representing teachers, researchers, and educators. (The American Association of Physics Teachers, one of the plaintiffs, is an AIP Member Society.) Meanwhile, NSF's implementation of a 15% cap on indirect costs was blocked [aip.us17.list-manage.com] in court last Friday.

SENATE REPUBLICANS BACK HIGHER TAXES ON UNIVERSITIES, LOWER ON BUSINESS R&D

The Senate Finance Committee's section [aip.us17.list-manage.com] of the Republican reconciliation bill, released last week, seeks to significantly increase excise taxes on university endowments, though by far less than the House bill. The draft legislation would keep the current 1.4% tax on schools with endowments worth less than \$750,000 per enrolled student but would raise that rate to 4% for schools with \$750,000 to \$2 million per student and 8% for schools with more than \$2 million per student. The House has proposed tax rates as high as 21% for the wealthiest schools. Both proposals would exempt religious institutions, colleges with fewer than 500 students, and certain state colleges.

Separately, the legislation would end the requirement that domestic research tax deductions be amortized over several years and instead allow those costs to be deducted in the same year in which they occurred. Foreign-based research would still be subject to the amortization requirement. A similar provision is included in the House bill. The legislation would also increase the semiconductor manufacturing investment credit [aip.us17.list-manage.com] and roll back energy efficiency and renewable energy tax incentives. The effects of these changes on tax revenue over ten years have been estimated [aip.us17.list-manage.com] by the Joint Committee on Taxation. For instance, it projects that the higher endowment taxes would result in around \$3.8 billion in revenue, while the R&D expensing change would decrease revenue by \$141 billion.

6/24/25: From: American Astronomical Society <aas@aas.org>
Subject: The Reason to Continue to Advocate for Science

A message from AAS President Dara Norman, urging our diverse and inclusive membership to take action to support science!

[on.jsp?ca=74c59e45-baf4-4b15-b1fc-71afc8318507&a=1118606474481&c=9b0fce40-5880

Dear Colleague,

Two weeks ago, we successfully hosted the 246th meeting of the American Astronomical Society (AAS), held jointly with the AAS's Solar Physics and Laboratory Astrophysics Divisions in Anchorage, Alaska.

...But reflecting on (the Hubble era) also brings into stark view the prospects for the road ahead in our field. Whereas the issues with the Hubble mirror immediately gave me pause about my future in the field, I was able to turn that into a reason to go back to graduate school to pursue the opportunities that other newly completed telescope projects, like the Sloan Digital Sky Survey, would bring. I am keenly aware that currently – given the questions about the funding futures of some of our most anticipated opportunities to explore new worlds, old theories, and ever-expanding questions – the future is uncertain for those in their early careers as well as those of us farther along.

Now is the time to remain steadfast and to do everything we can to convince those who hold the purse strings that this work, our work, is important. It is essential for our economy, for expanding opportunities for innovation, and for our society to maintain its curiosity and optimism by looking up into the heavens and wondering what lies beyond.

However, we must also understand that having the ability, capacity, and opportunity to do what we do – the time and space to think about big questions, to explore the universe in all its complexity, and to be curious about what we could learn next – is a privilege. It is not owed to us; it is a privilege we must fight to keep. This means that we must be humble enough to explain to others WHY it is worth keeping. We must convince the public, who will ultimately bear the cost of this work, that it is worth the investment. We must convince them of the value of what it brings back to our society as a species trying to understand our place in the cosmos, and what it brings to us as a global community on one tiny, but – so far as we currently know – uniquely special planet in the vastness of space. A community that includes as many people from as many places and backgrounds as possible AND includes those in Congress elected to represent our interests.

This is what we are up against...this is why we must continue to write

letters to our congressional delegations. Whether or not your representative is interested in science, there are people on Capitol Hill who will be talking to each other about what is and isn't possible in a funding bill. The more communications we persistently make, the more likely it is that our voices are heard, and the more justification for courage we hand to our members of Congress. Even if it seems like our letters are not read by some offices, do not give up: it is critical to make your concerns known. Even if it is unclear whether the staffer on the other end of the phone understands the details of your request, do not give up: it is critical to call and make your voice heard. Because you are not one voice: collectively, we are many. If we do not make them aware of our voices in favor of science and astronomy funding, it will be assumed that we are fine, that we are good, that we don't care. If you DO care, take action!

The advocacy work that the AAS is most suited to is supporting and enabling its diverse and inclusive membership to take action! We are ready and willing to help members present a collective front of support for science; to work with other societies and organizations to push back on proposals that will be detrimental to research, workforce, and science education; to support appeals to the broader public by elevating the discoveries of members and the benefits of this work. We're notifying members of opportunities to make their voices heard, and we're standing by to provide assistance and guidance in advance of conversations that members schedule with their representatives or with the media. Please don't hesitate to contact public.policy@aas.org and/or press@aas.org if you'd like help or wish to discuss any upcoming meetings or interviews with us. And review the slides from the Policy Plenary at AAS 246 to obtain more detailed information on the work we're doing.

We also need to be realistic: this work is hard and requires a sustained effort. We are not only trying to save our own career opportunities, but also the character of science in the US now and into the future. Even in the best-case scenario, funding levels are unlikely to return to what they were before January, and we must be prepared for that too. The threat is real, but we must use it as an opportunity to do more for maintaining science in the US. We must use this as a way to bring more people into an understanding of what science is and why it is important for a society – for our country – to make discoveries, to be curious, and to wonder collectively.

I urge you to stay in the fight... keep writing, keep calling, and keep asking to meet! Be persistent, be relentless! The President's Budget is a proposal, and WE know that not all proposals get time. Congress will soon decide what the final science allocation looks like, and we need you to continue letting them know why this proposal for cuts to science is as concerning as other non-science cuts. If WE don't make the case, no one is going to do it for us. It is up to us, so make it count!

Go to <https://aas.org/advocacy/suggested-advocacy-actions> to take action now!

— Dara Norman, AAS President

6/26/25: IHE. Scholars Continue Lambasting Higher Ed While Trump Upends It / This year's Heterodox Academy conference—the first since Republicans retook the White House—featured similar complaints about academe as in years past. But the federal government's sweeping interventions raised questions about what's really warranted.

A university president took the platform he was given at the annual convening of Heterodox Academy, a viewpoint-diversity group, to tell attendees that their long-standing gripes had found "resonance" with those trying to destroy higher education.

"Your complaints at the Heterodox conferences for almost 10 years now — about being too woke, about not having enough jobs for white people, about too many women in the academy — have found resonance with an authoritarian push to control our spaces," Wesleyan University president Michael Roth said Tuesday during a plenary panel at the event.

"We can make nice and not say that and we won't get investigated," he said. "Or we can do our job, which is to call the indecent attack on our sector indecent, wrongheaded, lawless, authoritarian, fascistic — choose your words. But if you sit there and worry about the sociology department and whether Near East studies is really antisemitic, I think you're doing their work of authoritarianism."

Many in the room applauded.

At Wesleyan, Roth said, he's tried to increase intellectual diversity and raise awareness "about the political biases that undermine faculty hiring, that undermine classroom discussions, that undermine the education we want to offer." But he said that "RIGHT NOW THAT WOULD BE LIKE TALKING ABOUT NEEDING A BETTER MILKSHAKE WHEN THE HOUSE IS ON FIRE," or like complaining about corruption in Ukraine's mining industry or the University of Kiev's anthropology department talking too much about settler-colonialism.

"The federal government is trying to destroy civil society by undermining the legitimacy of colleges and universities, of law firms — entertainment is on deck, and journalism," Roth said. "And so while we twiddle our thumbs and talk about reforming the university, PEOPLE WHO WANT TO DESTROY THE UNIVERSITY ARE DOING SO NOT BECAUSE WE DON'T

HAVE ENOUGH REPUBLICANS AT THE TOP BUSINESS SCHOOL OR WESLEYAN'S DEPARTMENT OF MATHEMATICS. THEY WANT TO DESTROY THE UNIVERSITY BECAUSE THAT'S HOW YOU CLAIM MORE EXECUTIVE POWER."

President Donald Trump has ushered in a new era for those who have long denounced academe as being intolerant of conservative views, or antisemitic, or discriminatory against white and male applicants for faculty jobs. While Republicans have for years passed laws in red states curtailing teaching, tenure, shared governance and diversity, equity and inclusion, the federal government has gone further since Trump retook office. For five months, the Trump administration has pursued an overhaul of higher ed using heavy-handed tactics such as cutting off billions of dollars in research funding and attempting to deport and bar the entry of international students and scholars for speech the administration disagrees with.

Proponents of ideas such as viewpoint diversity, intellectual diversity, open inquiry and civil discourse often argue that true academic freedom supports these concepts. But what do some of them say about what's happening now — significant governmental interference in higher ed, under the premise of providing what they've long called for? And when specifically is government intervention justified? This week's conference attempted to answer some of those questions.

...Fabio Rojas (Indiana University)...said, "Sociology is a bait-and-switch discipline. We say we're a universal discipline of social science, we say that we're a big tent where anybody can get any opinion published or have a good hearing," Rojas said, but the field instead has "an extreme emphasis on social problems. What if we actually tried to be better?" Rojas asked.

Rosemary Hopcroft...said that "in sociology, the received wisdom is that sex is a social construct. So this has helped lead to some of the worst excesses of woke ideology. I just don't think activism should be in sociology, period," Hopcroft said, beyond people's personal lives. She said, "It's too tempting for it to hijack everything else, which is what's happened."

Rojas, when asked during the panel when he thinks it's appropriate for the government to intervene in higher ed curricula, said at "a private institution, hands off, period."... But, Rojas said, "if you're in a state-chartered institution, expect political interference, because that is the definition of the institution."

Hopcroft added that legislators "have a right to say whether they think something is useful as part of a student's general education or not, given that they're largely paying for this."

On the presidential panel Roth sat on, moderator Nadine Strossen (New

York Law School) said universities the Trump administration has targeted “had THEMSELVES VIOLATED ACADEMIC FREEDOM AND FREE SPEECH PRINCIPLES. But that problem is hardly solved by government-imposed measures that violate those very same principles.”

...At one point, Roth referenced booths outside the grand ballroom operated by other organizations that are pushing universities to adopt “institutional neutrality” policies, under which institutions won’t comment on contemporary political controversies. “I worry that this is a new form of conformism,” Roth said. He said he’s suspicious of how the policies have proliferated since the Oct. 7, 2023, Hamas attack on Israelis.

“As a heterodox person, and as a Jew, I’m very suspicious when my compatriots find a new religion, be it viewpoint diversity or be it institutional neutrality,” Roth said.

...On Wednesday, during the final panel of the conference, an audience question crystallized the past days’ debate.

“Authoritarianism is bad,” said Matthew Burgess, an assistant professor in the University of Wyoming’s economics department. “So, what should be done to us if not what’s currently being done to us, and what should we do to ourselves?”

Some laughed.

6/30/25: FYI. NSF TO BE BOOTED FROM HEADQUARTERS, AIMS TO STAY IN VA

The Department of Housing and Urban Development plans to take over the National Science Foundation’s headquarters building in Alexandria, Virginia, officials announced at a surprise press conference [aip.us17.list-manage.com] last week. Virginia Gov. Glenn Youngkin (R) said at the event that some of the potential sites in Virginia originally offered to HUD would be suggested to NSF, which currently has more than 1,800 employees and moved to Alexandria from nearby Arlington in 2017. Many NSF staff gathered at the press conference to protest the decision, [aip.us17.list-manage.com] and the agency’s union blasted [aip.us17.list-manage.com] the takeover. “NSF employees are being displaced with no plan, no communication, and no respect,” the union stated. The union also said it was told HUD Secretary Scott Turner’s plans include construction of a new executive dining room, reserved parking spaces for his five cars, and a potential gym for him and his family. Turner denied these claims at the press conference and defended the move as necessary given that HUD’s current home in Washington, DC, has long been in a state of disrepair.

Democrats in Congress were quick to criticize the move, with Rep. Zoe Lofgren (D-CA) [aip.us17.list-manage.com] and Sen. Maria Cantwell

(D-WA) [aip.us17.list-manage.com] condemning the “luxury upgrades” for the HUD secretary. Democrats from Virginia’s congressional delegation are seeking details [aip.us17.list-manage.com] about NSF’s displacement from the General Services Administration, which manages federal real estate. GSA official Michael Peters said at the press conference that the relocation will save taxpayers \$500 million in deferred maintenance and an additional \$56 million in annual operating and maintenance expenses, while Sen. Mark Warner (D-VA) reacted [aip.us17.list-manage.com] by noting GSA has not offered an estimate of how much it will cost to relocate NSF. NSF is aiming to remain in northern Virginia and a move outside the DMV area is not under consideration, according to an internal memo sent last week by the agency’s acting director.

DOD, NOAA, AND NIST DETAIL MAJOR PROPOSED SCIENCE CUTS

The Trump administration is asking Congress to cut the Department of Defense’s basic research programs by 9% to \$2.26 billion and its applied research programs by 8% to \$5.7 billion for fiscal year 2025, according to new budget request documentation [aip.us17.list-manage.com] released last week. (These figures exclude funds the administration presumes will be provided through the reconciliation process.) The budget document also indicates that DOD used the wide discretion provided by Congress in its fiscal year 2025 appropriations to reduce the department’s applied research budget by 17% from fiscal year 2024 to 2025. The Commerce Department has also just finished posting its budget request documents, [aip.us17.list-manage.com] including those for the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration [aip.us17.list-manage.com] and the National Institute of Standards and Technology. [aip.us17.list-manage.com] The administration proposes eliminating NOAA’s Office of Oceanic and Atmospheric Research and transferring some of its programs to the National Ocean Service and the National Weather Service. In total, the document calls for cutting more than 2,200 positions from NOAA, roughly 18% of the agency. At NIST, the request details how the administration’s proposed cut of around 30% to the agency would require slashing hundreds of staff positions from the agency’s laboratory programs.

Meanwhile, House appropriators are gearing up to advance their own science spending proposals. They have scheduled [aip.us17.list-manage.com] markups for next week that will cover the Department of Energy, National Science Foundation, NOAA, NIST, and NASA.

The Trump administration has cut subscriptions [aip.us17.list-manage.com] to Springer Nature journals held by NIH, DOE, and USDA, according to reporting by Science.

JULY

7/1/25: ArsTechnica. RFK Jr.'s health department calls Nature "junk science," cancels subscriptions / The move comes after RFK Jr. called top medical journals "corrupt."

Scientists at several federal agencies are losing access to scientific literature published by Springer Nature, which produces the prestigious journal Nature among many other high-profile titles.

...According to the news outlet, spokespeople for NASA and the US Department of Agriculture (USDA) confirmed that agency scientists would no longer have access to Springer Nature journals. A USDA spokesperson said that it "has cancelled all contracts and subscriptions to Springer Nature. The journal [sic] is exorbitantly expensive and is not a good use of taxpayer funds." A government spending database also shows the Department of Energy (DOE) has dropped contracts with the publisher.

When Nature news first reached out to the National Institutes of Health (NIH)—which is the top funding agency for biomedical research in the world—it appeared that its access to Nature journals was not on the chopping block. But, hours later, Andrew Nixon, the top spokesperson for the US Department of Health and Human Services (HHS), which oversees the NIH, said: "All contracts with Springer Nature are terminated or no longer active. Precious taxpayer dollars should be [sic] not be used on unused subscriptions to junk science."

The move comes after HHS Secretary and anti-vaccine activist Robert F. Kennedy Jr. said on a May 27 podcast that prestigious medical journals are "corrupt." "We're probably going to stop publishing in the Lancet, New England Journal of Medicine, JAMA, and those other journals because they're all corrupt," he said. He accused the journals collectively of being a "vessel for pharmaceutical propaganda." He went on to say that "unless these journals change dramatically," the federal government would "stop NIH scientists from publishing there" and create "in-house" journals instead.

Comments...

People knew all about Project 2025 before the election. They ignored it. People knew JFKjr was a monster, his own family said so. They still voted for Trump.

He is going to cause so many additional deaths.

And by "corrupt" he means "refuses to publish false anti-vax narrative". We are being governed by the least competent, most vindictive gang of jackasses ever put into office. And things are only

going to get worse.

And this is how a dark age begins. Does he also think BMJ and JAMA are "junk science"? EDIT just finished the article.... he thinks they are "corrupt". lol. Good luck America.

They're not going for anything, Lysenkoism or otherwise. They want void. Absence. Nothing. A whole bunch of scientists have already left Federal institutions like NIH. A megacraption more are out looking for an exit ramp. We're losing people who contribute enormously to the health and well-being of the US.

"Republicans are busily committing political suicide. We just need to keep feeding them the rope that they so stupidly accept." -- I wish that were true, but as Texas shows, they can continue to blame Democrats for their own failures for decades. What they are effectively committing is genocide of their own supporters. And they are attempting to take everyone else down with them.

If it's also NASA and Agriculture and Energy, it's not just Kennedy's particular crackpottery, but instead has to be viewed as part of the administrations overall war on science. I assume they're aiming for a modern version of Lysenkoism, where whatever semblance science is allowed to exist does so in explicit service of the regime's ideology.

FFS the head of the FDA doesn't believe in germs and effectively is pushing global genocide. The fourth estate in general has simply failed.

From the 9th through the 12th centuries, Islamic society was among the world's most advanced and liberal. Science, scholarship, diversity were all encouraged. Scholars attribute multiple causes for why it ended, but for me the most important causes were a shift towards more conservative religious interpretations and resistance to scientific and philosophical inquiry. When I learned decades ago about the Islamic Golden Age and its end, I wondered how a society could allow its people to ruin it and was grateful I didn't live in such a foolish society. That was decades ago, and, hooboy, I was naive! So here I am in a society that at one time was the most advanced in the world doing the exact same thing as what happened with Islam almost 1000 years ago; only because this is Amurika, we have domestic terrorists like Kennedy wrecking everything faster and with greater stupidity. Well I'm sure this country will get everything back on track real soon, just like what happened with Islamic societies. Oh, wait....

What's really crazy to think is, the thing that immediately precipitated this turn, probably more than anything else, is that a bunch of selfish a-holes just couldn't bring themselves to wear masks for a couple years so they wouldn't get their friends and neighbors sick with a deadly disease. Rather than take a completely

inconsequential action to keep everyone safe, people chose instead to politicize it and are now dismantling the entire medical establishment just so there's no one left to tell them that they're wrong.

They quite literally and quite seriously want to bring modern America down in ruins, so they can establish an oligarchic, techno-feudal theocratic ("Christian Nationalist", "Dominionist", "Gilead". whatever) state in its place. I would not be surprised if many of the behind-scenes actors (not just Steve Bannon) are deliberately and consciously following a Leninist strategy of deliberately making conditions worse, so that the masses will consequently look to them for "relief" from their problems.

7/1/25: ArsTechnica. Eric Berger, White House works to ground NASA science missions before Congress can act / "We would be turning off some fabulous missions that are doing extremely well."

In another sign that the Trump White House is aggressively moving to slash NASA's science programs, dozens of mission leaders have been asked to prepare "closeout" plans by the end of next week.

The new directive came from NASA's senior leadership on Monday, which is acting on behalf of the White House Office of Management and Budget. Copies of these memos, which appear to vary a little by department, were reviewed by Ars. The detailed closeout plans called for must be prepared by as soon as July 9 for some missions, which has left principal investigators scrambling due to the tight deadline and the July 4 holiday weekend.

Projects should prepare their plans assuming closeout direction is given on October 1, 2025, one of the NASA memos states. Missions in operations—that is to say, spacecraft whizzing around the Solar System conducting science right now—should "assume closeout is complete within 3 months."

The memos are careful to state that the preparation of these closeout plans is for the purposes of a "planning exercise only." However, multiple scientists familiar with the new directive from NASA's leadership do not believe these closeout plans are merely for planning purposes.

Instead, based on the budget process to date and statements from the White House, they view the memos as an effort by the Trump administration to move forward with canceling as many NASA science missions as possible before Congress passes a budget for the upcoming fiscal year, 2026. This fiscal year begins on October 1, three months from today.

Science at risk

The Trump White House released its proposed budget for NASA a little more than a month ago, seeking to reduce NASA's budget by about 24 percent, from \$24.8 billion this year to \$18.8 billion in fiscal year 2026. Some areas within the budget were hit harder than others, particularly the Science Mission Directorate, which sustained nearly 50 percent in proposed cuts.

The space agency has 124 science missions in development, prime operations, or extended operations. Effectively, the proposed cuts would cancel 41 of these missions, and another 17 would see their funding zeroed out in the near future. Nearly half of NASA's science missions would therefore end, and dozens more would receive budget cuts of 20–40 percent.

This includes some high-profile casualties, including NASA's only mission at Jupiter, an effort to explore an asteroid that will fly extremely close to Earth in 2029, two promising missions to Venus, and an effort to return samples from Mars.

"We would be turning off some fabulous missions that are doing extremely well," said Jim Green, a physicist who led NASA's Planetary Science Program for 12 years before his retirement in 2022.

Normally, after the White House proposes a budget for the upcoming fiscal year, it is considered by appropriators in Congress responsible for setting funding levels and publishing a budget. However, in recent years, Congress has been unable to agree upon a budget and pass it before the beginning of the next fiscal year. This has led to a "continuing resolution" in which, generally, NASA missions continue to receive funding consistent with budget levels set during the previous fiscal year.

However, multiple sources indicated to Ars that may not happen this year, and the new memos offer an important clue in this regard.

Making missions go dark

The memos were sent to the principal investigators of the missions that the White House budget seeks to cancel. On one hand, it is prudent to have a plan of action in place should these missions actually be canceled due to a new budget, assuming one is in place by October 1. It is NASA's job to execute the budget it is given.

But there very likely is a more cynical plan at play here. The Office

of Management and Budget, led by Russ Vought, has been seeking to cut the US government's science portfolio across the board, and it fully expects a continuing resolution to be adopted as Congress almost certainly won't have a budget signed.

The congressional committees have been paralyzed, to some degree, by the Trump administration's full-court press to pass the "One Big Beautiful Bill," which exists outside of the traditional budget process. Congressional work to set the budget for fiscal year 2026 remains in its early stages, and with summer recesses looming, passage of any bill will almost certainly require many months.

Amid this uncertainty, Vought appears to be moving to shut down as many of these missions as possible.

The PBR is the plan

How will Vought and his office accomplish this? Effectively, they seek to turn the president's budget request into the operating plan for NASA—instead of a continuing resolution—in the absence of a fiscal year 2026 budget.

This has already been communicated to NASA's field center directors. Recently, according to multiple sources, NASA's chief of staff, Brian Hughes, told these center leaders that the president's budget request would soon become their operating plans. Hughes, who worked on Trump's 2024 campaign, is one of the senior political leaders running NASA in the absence of a confirmed administrator.

(*Update*: After publication of this article, NASA press secretary Bethany Stevens denied Hughes had said this. "This is either a misinterpretation or mischaracterization of Brian's words," she said. "Brian has issued no guidance stating that the PBR will become the operating plan for NASA prior to Congressional authorization of a budget.")

During a typical budget year, NASA officials submit an operating plan to Congress so authorizers and appropriators know what is happening at the agency as part of the budget-making process. During this give-and-take, appropriators provide feedback; i.e., "continue working on such and such" because it is the intent of Congress to continue funding that activity regardless of the White House's proposed budget. For example, this process saved NASA's Chandra X-ray Observatory from having its operations rapidly curtailed last year.

NASA typically complies with guidance from Congress since it receives its budget from Congress. (Really, you do not want to bite the hand that feeds.) However, this year's process is not expected to be normal, and there is no legal requirement for NASA (or other federal

agencies) to consider congressional feedback on their operating plans.

This year, in fact, the Office of Management and Budget has even stopped NASA from submitting operational plans to Congress.

"This is yet another bad faith move by the administration, which seems hell-bent on attacking science and the future of American innovation," said Rep. George Whitesides (D-Calif.), who previously served as NASA's chief of staff. "To go around Congress, and the committee of jurisdiction that I sit on, to enact their radical agenda that will make us less safe, less competitive, and less able to respond to threats is not only dangerous, it will cede all ground to our adversaries like China."

Will the last planetary scientist please turn out the lights?

How will this play out?

There are multiple strategies, and some of them are likely to end up in court fights. Philosophically, Vought believes strongly that the president should have more authority to direct federal spending. And he appears likely to try to force the issue this year. Using tactics such as rescission — essentially ordering federal agencies to freeze spending—and impoundment, Vought will seek to implement the priorities in the president's budget request, which his office wrote.

Beginning October 1, without a fiscal year 2026 budget in place, NASA may be directed to start following the closeout plans submitted this month by principal investigators and turning missions off. That means the lights go out at Jupiter, telescopes stop gathering data across the Solar System, and so on for dozens of missions.

And once those missions are gone, they're almost impossible to bring back—even if Congress were inclined to restore funding months later with a new budget.

"If there's not much hope to restart a mission, the people who are managing Juno, New Horizons, and other missions are going to be looking for their next job," Green said. "They're going to be gone. Within a few months, you won't be able to get the expertise back. And without the expertise, you don't have the ability to run the mission safely."

108 Comments

making smart and good people angry by destroying the things they care about plays well with rural, white, evangelical voters

Science is inherently anti-heirarchical. Knowledge is actually power.

Many of these freaks in government have resentments they literally pin as starting with the French Revolution, European Enlightenment and the subsequent decline of the power of nobility across Europe. The deepest ideologues driving this stuff – the Voughts, the Millers, the Vances, and outside of gov't the Thiels, the Yarvins – literally want to roll back the entirety of the 21st and 20th centuries, and reset to an era of clean, clear heirarchies, strictly enforced religious ideology, etc etc. Everything they do is in service of that. They do not like that American by-and-large work in knowledge jobs, and that those workers do things like tell their bosses to be less racist or stop sexually harrassing people. They don't like it one bit. They want us – as Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick literally said screwing in tiny screws to iPhones for companies that have to put suicide cages on the windows. They want us uneducated, poor, and subservient to them. They don't think we are worthy of anything better. They do not believe that rising tides lift all boats. They don't care that they are richer than God today because the equalification of American has lead to wider and broader and deeper prosperity overall. They see Russia as an ideal state. Mostly poor, but ruled with an iron fist by very obscenely rich men. They will destroy anything that doesn't serve that goal.

As an European i just watch in total disbelief. Since i as a kid in the seventies got interested in space and astronomy, Nasa has stood out as a light house for science, technology and knowledge about space. Something that in my eyes makes America great. I find it hard to belive that all this is crushed under the complete chaotic ignorance and stupidity of this government. Madness just Madness.

There is a Republican state representative that literally just had complications during pregnancy that arose because of Florida's anti-abortion laws. She nearly died, and promptly blamed "the left" for it all. That is to say no, ideological trolls do not admit anything, ever.

Christo-Fascism is not interested in space exploration, folks. Not even interested in knowing about the weather or even if anyone is keeping science alive. They have a lot of big plans for you, though.

What's the difference between the Religious Right and the Taliban?
About 6000 miles.

This administration is pretty focused on "flag planting" missions to the moon and Mars, and they're sucking the science budget dry to get there while also DOGEing NASA's budget. There is also a widespread belief that new private space is moving faster and is more capable than old space, as well as having access to capital markets for funding. This may or may not be true, but I'm sure that's the advice Trump is getting.

At least when Carter suggested closing NASA, he was willing to listen when the militipointed out that it was essential for national security. Trump? Not so much. We are going to be decades recovering from these cuts. We will lose some craft entirely and others will only return a small fraction of what we had hoped to get. Just as bad as the damage this does to our science is what it does to our international relations. No country will want to partner with us simply because the project might get canceled just because Trump got mad one day. And then there is the brain-drain that this has already started to happen. Our best and brightest are going to go to other countries to work. Friendly ones if we are lucky, unfriendly if we aren't. 2026 and the Democrats getting a majority in both the House and the Senate cannot come soon enough.

As someone right-leaning myself I don't really get it either. I honestly feel like its a personal vendetta by someone in Trump's cabinet or close advisors that's pushing for all this. Maybe Sergio Gor, maybe someone else. It doesn't really save that much money and doesn't really do much. Trump doesn't seem to particularly care because he's probably just ignorant about the whole thing. So it's someone else that really has their eye set on vengeance for something. Doesn't make any sense.

What's there to make sense of? Republican policy, since at least 1984, has been to shred the federal government and all that it does. This is the inevitable conclusion of that goal.

Nah, you won't be able to maintain a big military with this administration. Your military will degrade over time as skilled technicians retire, and home-schooled morons (because College is woke!) take their place. And it wouldn't surprise me if people in charge of warehouses take a leaf from their Russian comrades and start to sell things unofficially, because that's how things roll now. The fish rots from the head, and the head is - even now - insanely corrupt.

It's hard to post anything that both accurately represents what I'd like to scream out, and would stay up longer than 30 seconds. May eventually the sulfuric acidic fires from hell be unleashed on these subhuman troglodytes. But this is pretty much exactly what I anticipated and predicted through some post that I'll not be able to retrieve, about 6 months ago or so. People should understand that this is all-out-war, and gloves will have to go.

7/2/25: USRA newsletter

From: "Hammond, Eric S." <ehammond@usra.edu>
Date: July 2, 2025 at 16:12:12 EDT
To: Stephan McCandliss <stephan.mccandliss@jhu.edu>

Subject: USRA Legislative Update from Washington

1. Call to Action: Contacting Your Member of Congress

Now is a critical time for researchers and university representatives to contact their Members of Congress and advocate for strong federal support for science. Congress will soon debate the FY 2026 funding levels for NASA, the National Science Foundation (NSF), and the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA), all of which face proposed severe reductions.

A brief phone call or short personalized email can make a difference. The sample message below may be adapted as needed:

Dear Representative [Name],

I am a [title] at [University] in [City], urging you to support full funding for NASA's Science Mission Directorate, NSF, and NOAA in the FY 2026 appropriations process. The Administration's proposed cuts would significantly harm scientific research, student training, and America's innovation base. [Optional: Our institution has [X] projects and [Y] employees, [Z] students supported by these programs.] I appreciate your support of science and education. Sincerely, [Your Name]

To identify your Representative, visit house.gov and enter your ZIP code in the "Find Your Representative" tool located in the upper right corner of the homepage. You may also call the U.S. Capitol Switchboard at (202) 224-3121 to be connected directly to your Representative's office. Many professional societies are issuing similar calls to action—coordinated engagement from the academic community is both timely and critical.

If you require additional assistance in contacting your senator or representative, please do not hesitate to reply directly to this email, and I will be happy to help.

2. Deep Cuts Proposed for NASA, NSF, and NOAA

The Administration's FY 2026 budget request proposes historic cuts to federal science agencies. NASA faces an overall cut of nearly 25%, including almost a 50% reduction to the Science Mission Directorate (SMD)—the steepest decline since the early days of the space era. High-profile missions, such as the Mars Sample Return, the Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope, and upcoming Venus missions, are all at risk. Each of NASA's four science divisions—Astrophysics, Planetary Science, Earth Science, and Heliophysics—would be cut to historic lows. In

addition, NASA's STEM education programs, including Space Grant and EPSCoR, are slated for elimination.

NSF would see its budget halved—from roughly \$9 billion to under \$4 billion—under this proposal. Internal agency planning indicates all 37 disciplinary divisions would be eliminated, with widespread restructuring and funding freezes. New grantmaking has slowed, and core programs, such as the Graduate Research Fellowship Program, have already undergone significant reductions.

NOAA's proposal is similarly stark. The budget eliminates the Office of Oceanic and Atmospheric Research (OAR), effectively dismantling NOAA's primary arm for climate and weather science. University-based Sea Grant programs and coastal resilience initiatives would be terminated. Other NOAA offices, including the National Ocean Service, face potential reductions of up to 50%. Weather satellite programs developed jointly with NASA would be scaled back or canceled.

Implications for Universities: These cuts would have a profound impact on university-led research, training, and facilities. Canceled missions and frozen grants threaten research continuity, graduate and postdoctoral support, and hands-on STEM education. While the Administration sets the proposal, Congress controls the outcome. Growing bipartisan concern suggests lawmakers may push back, but action from the academic community is vital.

NASA's FY2026 Request:

image002.png

3. House Appropriations Markup Looms: Science Funding at Stake

Congress has begun work on the Fiscal Year (FY) 2026 appropriations process, which will set funding levels for NASA, the National Science Foundation (NSF), the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA), and other key science agencies. The House Appropriations Subcommittee on Commerce, Justice, Science, and Related Agencies (CJS) is scheduled to mark up its FY 2026 bill on Monday, July 7, 2025. [See more [here](#).] This markup begins the first formal step in Congress's response to the Administration's budget request, which proposes significant reductions to multiple science programs.

As of this writing, the draft text of the House bill has not been made public, and there are indications that the full language may not be released by the time of the July 7

markup. Instead, it may become available later in the week, when the full committee markup is expected to take place on Thursday, July 10. [See more here.] As a result, any current reporting on specific funding levels for NASA's Science Mission Directorate, STEM engagement programs (such as Space Grant), NSF, or NOAA remains speculative.

What we do know is that Congress is working under strict budget limits set by the Fiscal Responsibility Act, a law that caps how much the government can spend on non-defense programs—like NASA, NSF, and NOAA—for Fiscal Year 2026. These caps leave very little room for increases and will force lawmakers to make tough choices. Without strong public input, there's a real risk that science programs will be scaled back or underfunded.

Because final funding levels have not been released—and rumors suggest the full bill text may not be available until later this week—the next few days are a critical time for advocacy. Engagement from universities and researchers is essential. Speaking up now can help shape how Congress prioritizes science, both as the House begins its process and as the Senate develops its version and negotiations between the two chambers begin later this summer.

4. Senate Budget Action: NASA Gets Boost via Reconciliation | Golden Dome Initiative Funded

On July 1, the Senate passed its budget reconciliation bill—dubbed the “One Big Beautiful Bill”—which provides nearly \$10 billion in supplemental funding for NASA's human spaceflight program and establishes a new “Golden Dome” national missile defense initiative. The NASA funding targets activities such as Artemis, the lunar Gateway, Mars exploration, and key infrastructure upgrades—many of which faced sharp reductions or elimination in the Administration's FY 2026 budget request.

This reconciliation package operates outside the regular appropriations process and provides one-time mandatory funding for exploration efforts; however, it does not include support for discretionary science programs, such as NASA's Science Mission Directorate, NSF, or NOAA. The Administration's FY2026 proposed cuts to these programs, released months earlier, remain unaddressed by the reconciliation bill. The two tracks—appropriations and reconciliation—are procedurally distinct, but the resulting funding landscape has raised questions about how they may interact.

While the reconciliation funds are not meant to replace base appropriations, some concern remains that their existence could

create political cover for appropriators to limit NASA's discretionary topline. However, Senate appropriators, in particular, have expressed strong interest in restoring science funding and protecting against what they see as disproportionate cuts. There is no procedural requirement to offset the reconciliation funding with reductions elsewhere, and many in Congress emphasize that exploration supplements should not come at the expense of research, education, and technology development.

Ultimately, the reconciliation bill provides a critical boost to human spaceflight, but leaves the fate of core NASA science programs to the regular Commerce–Justice–Science appropriations process. Whether appropriators choose to reinvest in those areas will depend heavily on congressional negotiations and continued advocacy from the scientific and academic communities.

At the time of this writing, the bill's fate in the House remains far from certain. Despite Senate approval, reports highlight growing GOP resistance, casting doubt on final passage before the July 4 deadline.

5. NASA Administrator Nomination Withdrawn

At the end of May, the President unexpectedly withdrew his nomination of Jared Isaacman for NASA Administrator, citing a “thorough review of prior associations.” Isaacman—a private astronaut and entrepreneur—had already passed the Senate Commerce Committee and was awaiting confirmation. His withdrawal leaves NASA without a permanent leader.

A new nominee has not been announced, though the White House has promised a replacement “soon” who will be “mission aligned.” Until then, NASA is led by an acting administrator—typically the most senior career official—who may delay major decisions, reorganizations, or long-term strategy.

This leadership gap arises as NASA faces significant budgetary pressures and a potential reorganization amid ongoing federal reviews. In response, NASA has initiated several voluntary workforce-shaping measures, including the Deferred Resignation Program (DRP), the Voluntary Early Retirement Authority (VERA), and the Voluntary Separation Incentive Payment (VSIP). Eligible civil service employees may apply for these programs through July 25, 2025. They will continue to receive pay and benefits—often extending into January 2026—as NASA streamlines its workforce without resorting to involuntary layoffs.

Engagement with new leadership, once appointed, will be

essential to reinforcing the value of academic partnerships and science programs.

Conclusion

Federal science programs face a defining moment. The proposed FY 2026 budget would severely undermine research, education, and long-term innovation—but nothing is final. Time remains for advocacy to shape the outcome. Meanwhile, NASA's leadership uncertainty adds another dimension to the policy environment.

USRA, in coordination with its Issues and Program Committee (IPC), will continue to monitor developments and advocate for our community. We urge COI members to share this information with their colleagues and utilize the provided tools to contact their Congressional Representatives.

Thank you for your continued efforts and commitment.

7/3/25: From: "O'Connell, Robert W (rwo)" <rwo@virginia.edu>
To: "astro-alldept@virginia.edu" <astro-alldept@virginia.edu>
Cc: "O'Connell, Robert W (rwo)" <rwo@virginia.edu>
Subject: Federal science budget reaching critical phase

Federal budgeting for science in FY2026 is reaching a critical phase over the next month (regardless of how quickly the "Big Beautiful Bill" passes Congress).

I'm forwarding information on where things stand for NASA, NSF, and NOAA from the latest USRA newsletter.

Cheers (sort-of),

RWO

=====

USRA newsletter

From: "Hammond, Eric S." <ehammond@usra.edu>
Date: July 2, 2025 at 16:12:12 EDT
To: Stephan McCandliss <stephan.mccandliss@jhu.edu>
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To identify your Representative, visit [house.gov](https://www.house.gov) and enter your ZIP code in the "Find Your Representative" tool located in the upper right corner of the homepage. You may also call the U.S. Capitol Switchboard at (202) 224-3121 to be connected directly to your Representative's office. Many professional societies are issuing similar calls to action—coordinated engagement from the academic community is both timely and critical.

If you require additional assistance in contacting your senator or representative, please do not hesitate to reply directly to this email, and I will be happy to help.

2. Deep Cuts Proposed for NASA, NSF, and NOAA

The Administration's FY 2026 budget request proposes historic cuts to federal science agencies. NASA faces an overall cut of nearly 25%, including almost a 50% reduction to the Science Mission Directorate (SMD)—the steepest decline since the early days of the space era. High-profile missions, such as the Mars Sample Return, the Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope, and upcoming Venus missions, are all at risk. Each of NASA's four science divisions—Astrophysics, Planetary Science, Earth Science, and Heliophysics—would be cut to historic lows. In addition, NASA's STEM education programs, including Space Grant and EPSCoR, are slated for elimination.

NSF would see its budget halved—from roughly \$9 billion to under \$4 billion—under this proposal. Internal agency planning indicates all 37 disciplinary divisions would be eliminated, with widespread restructuring and funding freezes. New grantmaking has slowed, and core programs, such as the Graduate Research Fellowship Program, have already undergone significant reductions.

NOAA's proposal is similarly stark. The budget eliminates the Office of Oceanic and Atmospheric Research (OAR), effectively dismantling NOAA's primary arm for climate and weather science. University-based Sea Grant programs and coastal resilience initiatives would be terminated. Other NOAA offices, including the National Ocean Service, face potential reductions of up to 50%. Weather satellite programs developed jointly with NASA would be scaled back or canceled.

Implications for Universities: These cuts would have a profound impact on university-led research, training, and facilities. Canceled missions and frozen grants threaten research continuity, graduate and postdoctoral support, and hands-on STEM education. While the Administration sets the proposal, Congress controls the outcome. Growing bipartisan concern suggests lawmakers may push back, but action from the academic community is vital.

NASA's FY2026 Request:
image002.png

3. House Appropriations Markup Looms: Science Funding at Stake

Congress has begun work on the Fiscal Year (FY) 2026 appropriations process, which will set funding levels for NASA, the National Science Foundation (NSF), the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA), and other key science agencies. The House Appropriations Subcommittee on Commerce, Justice, Science, and Related Agencies (CJS) is scheduled to mark up its FY 2026 bill on Monday, July 7, 2025. [See more here.] This markup begins the first formal step in Congress's response to the Administration's budget request, which proposes significant reductions to multiple science programs.

As of this writing, the draft text of the House bill has not been made public, and there are indications that the full language may not be released by the time of the July 7 markup. Instead, it may become available later in the week, when the full committee markup is expected to take place on Thursday, July 10. [See more here.] As a result, any current reporting on specific funding levels for NASA's Science Mission

Directorate, STEM engagement programs (such as Space Grant), NSF, or NOAA remains speculative.

What we do know is that Congress is working under strict budget limits set by the Fiscal Responsibility Act, a law that caps how much the government can spend on non-defense programs—like NASA, NSF, and NOAA—for Fiscal Year 2026. These caps leave very little room for increases and will force lawmakers to make tough choices. Without strong public input, there's a real risk that science programs will be scaled back or underfunded.

Because final funding levels have not been released—and rumors suggest the full bill text may not be available until later this week—the next few days are a critical time for advocacy. Engagement from universities and researchers is essential. Speaking up now can help shape how Congress prioritizes science, both as the House begins its process and as the Senate develops its version and negotiations between the two chambers begin later this summer.

4. Senate Budget Action: NASA Gets Boost via Reconciliation | Golden Dome Initiative Funded

On July 1, the Senate passed its budget reconciliation bill—dubbed the “One Big Beautiful Bill”—which provides nearly \$10 billion in supplemental funding for NASA’s human spaceflight program and establishes a new “Golden Dome” national missile defense initiative. The NASA funding targets activities such as Artemis, the lunar Gateway, Mars exploration, and key infrastructure upgrades—many of which faced sharp reductions or elimination in the Administration’s FY 2026 budget request.

This reconciliation package operates outside the regular appropriations process and provides one-time mandatory funding for exploration efforts; however, it does not include support for discretionary science programs, such as NASA’s Science Mission Directorate, NSF, or NOAA. The Administration’s FY2026 proposed cuts to these programs, released months earlier, remain unaddressed by the reconciliation bill. The two tracks—appropriations and reconciliation—are procedurally distinct, but the resulting funding landscape has raised questions about how they may interact.

While the reconciliation funds are not meant to replace base appropriations, some concern remains that their existence could create political cover for appropriators to limit NASA’s discretionary topline. However, Senate appropriators, in particular, have expressed strong interest in restoring science

funding and protecting against what they see as disproportionate cuts. There is no procedural requirement to offset the reconciliation funding with reductions elsewhere, and many in Congress emphasize that exploration supplements should not come at the expense of research, education, and technology development.

Ultimately, the reconciliation bill provides a critical boost to human spaceflight, but leaves the fate of core NASA science programs to the regular Commerce–Justice–Science appropriations process. Whether appropriators choose to reinvest in those areas will depend heavily on congressional negotiations and continued advocacy from the scientific and academic communities.

At the time of this writing, the bill’s fate in the House remains far from certain. Despite Senate approval, reports highlight growing GOP resistance, casting doubt on final passage before the July 4 deadline.

5. NASA Administrator Nomination Withdrawn

At the end of May, the President unexpectedly withdrew his nomination of Jared Isaacman for NASA Administrator, citing a “thorough review of prior associations.” Isaacman—a private astronaut and entrepreneur—had already passed the Senate Commerce Committee and was awaiting confirmation. His withdrawal leaves NASA without a permanent leader.

A new nominee has not been announced, though the White House has promised a replacement “soon” who will be “mission aligned.” Until then, NASA is led by an acting administrator—typically the most senior career official—who may delay major decisions, reorganizations, or long-term strategy.

This leadership gap arises as NASA faces significant budgetary pressures and a potential reorganization amid ongoing federal reviews. In response, NASA has initiated several voluntary workforce-shaping measures, including the Deferred Resignation Program (DRP), the Voluntary Early Retirement Authority (VERA), and the Voluntary Separation Incentive Payment (VSIP). Eligible civil service employees may apply for these programs through July 25, 2025. They will continue to receive pay and benefits—often extending into January 2026—as NASA streamlines its workforce without resorting to involuntary layoffs.

Engagement with new leadership, once appointed, will be essential to reinforcing the value of academic partnerships and science programs.

Conclusion

Federal science programs face a defining moment. The proposed FY 2026 budget would severely undermine research, education, and long-term innovation—but nothing is final. Time remains for advocacy to shape the outcome. Meanwhile, NASA's leadership uncertainty adds another dimension to the policy environment.

USRA, in coordination with its Issues and Program Committee (IPC), will continue to monitor developments and advocate for our community. We urge COI members to share this information with their colleagues and utilize the provided tools to contact their Congressional Representatives.

Thank you for your continued efforts and commitment.

6 Pending Legislation for NASA in Congress [Details omitted]

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7/3/25: ArsTechnica. Judge: You can't ban DEI grants without bothering to define DEI / A written ruling details why a judge restored funding for many NIH grants.

In mid-June, a federal judge issued a stinging rebuke to the Trump administration, declaring that its decision to cancel the funding for many grants issued by the National Institutes of Health was illegal, and suggesting that the policy was likely animated by racism. But the detailed reasoning behind his decision wasn't released at the time. The written portion of the decision was finally issued on Wednesday, and it has a number of notable features.

... the court continues to find that the government's actions were arbitrary and capricious, in part because the government never bothered to define the problems that would get a grant canceled. As a result, officials within the NIH simply canceled lists of grants they received from DOGE without bothering to examine their scientific merit, and then struggled to retroactively describe a policy that justified the actions afterward—a process that led several of them to resign.

...The grant cancellations, Young concludes, "Arise from the NIH's

newly minted war against undefined concepts of diversity, equity, and inclusion and gender identity, that has expanded to include vaccine hesitancy, COVID, influencing public opinion and climate change." The "undefined" aspect plays a key part in his reasoning. Referring to DEI, he writes, "No one has ever defined it to this Court—and this Court has asked multiple times." It's not defined in Trump's executive order that launched the "newly minted war," and Young found that administrators within the NIH issued multiple documents that attempted to define it, not all of which were consistent with each other, and in some cases seemed to use circular reasoning.

He also noted that the officials who sent these memos had a tendency to resign shortly afterward, writing, "it is not lost on the Court that oftentimes people vote with their feet."

As a result, the NIH staff had no solid guidance for determining whether a given grant violated the new anti-DEI policy, or how that might be weighed against the scientific merit of the grant. So, how were they to identify which grants needed to be terminated? The evidence revealed at trial indicates that they didn't need to make those decisions; DOGE made them for the NIH. In one case, an NIH official approved a list of grants to terminate received from DOGE ONLY TWO MINUTES AFTER IT SHOWED UP IN HIS INBOX.

"There is no reasoned decision-making at all with respect to the NIH's 'abruptness' in the 'robotic rollout' of this grant-termination action," Young concludes. "Based upon a fair preponderance of the evidence and on the sparse administrative record, the Court finds and rules that HHS and, in turn, NIH, are being force-fed unworkable 'policy' supported with sparse pseudo-reasoning, and wholly unsupported statements."

Young also noted that the termination of grants to Columbia University was equally arbitrary. "How the scientific and research activities had any connection with unrest issues on Columbia's campus is conspicuously never explained," Young noted. "The record evidence certainly reveals none."

...Young also appears to lament the fact that he had to intervene here, writing:

"The American people have enjoyed a historical norm of a largely apolitical scientific research agency supporting research in an elegant, merit-based approach that benefits everyone. That historical norm changed on January 20, 2025. The new Administration began weaponizing what should not be weaponized—the health of all Americans through its abuse of HHS and the NIH systems, creating chaos and promoting an unreasonable and unreasoned agenda of blacklisting certain topics, that on this Administrative Record, has absolutely nothing to do with the

promotion of science or research."

7/6/25: WP. Bruce Partridge. These scientific advances were 'Made in the U.S.A.' Will they continue? / America has long led in research. Budget cuts could jeopardize that dominance.

Bruce Partridge is emeritus professor of astronomy at Haverford College.

I've spent much of my long life studying – and trying to understand – the history of the universe. Along the way, I have been constantly reminded that science is essentially international: Science knows no borders. The next great discovery could be made in Kansas or Kosovo or Kyoto.

And yet, as an American patriot, I take pride that so much scientific research bears the imprint**"Made in the U.S.A." By so many measures, this country – my country – has dominated all branches of the scientific enterprise since World War II: the number of Nobel Prizes in the sciences (nearly 300, with second-place Britain having about one-third of that amount), the number of patents in the sciences (with China rapidly catching up), the sheer number of Big Discoveries. We Americans have walked on the moon and brought back chunks of it for further study. We've whipped polio and fenced in HIV.

Consider just my small branch of science. I'm an astronomer, so here are some of the things we've learned about our solar system and the cosmos during the six decades of my scientific career:

- * We know the universe started years ago hot and dense, and we know its age – 13.8 billion years

/ A photo of the galaxy JADES-GS-z14-0, the farthest discovered yet.

Most of the colored smudges in this infrared photo taken by the James Webb Space Telescope are galaxies, not stars. Each can contain billions of stars and planets./

This is the most distant galaxy ever confirmed, as it looked 13.5 billion years ago – just about 290 million years after the Big Bang.

Galaxy JADES-GS-z14-0

Sources: NASA, ESA, CSA, Brant Robertson (UC Santa Cruz), Ben Johnson (CfA), Sandro Tacchella (Cambridge), Phill Cargile (CfA), Joris Witstok (Cambridge, University of Copenhagen), P. Jakobsen (University of Copenhagen), Alyssa Pagan (STScI), Mahdi Zamani (ESA/Webb), JADES Collaboration /

- * We know the Earth has been around for only one-third of that time – and how long it will be before the dying Sun engulfs the Earth. (Reassuringly, 4 billion to 5 billion years from now.)
- * We know ordinary matter – the stuff that makes up people and planets and stars – is only about 5 percent of the total mass in the universe.
- * We know what powers the stars, and that some stars end their lives in the blink of an eye by exploding spectacularly. Here's one example: the Crab Nebula what remains of a star that exploded 1,000 years ago, in an infrared photo taken by the James Webb Space Telescope.

/ The Crab Nebula, a supernova remnant located 6,500 light-years away in the constellation Taurus. (NASA/ESA/CSA/Tea Temim/Princeton University) /

- * We know black holes are real; some are dead stars and some, 1 million or more times more massive, squat at the centers of galaxies, including our own Milky Way. The magenta spots in the image below show two black holes in the Topsy Turvy galaxy <<https://www.nasa.gov/image-article/topsy-turvy-black-holes/>>, about 13 million light-years away from us.

/ The magenta spots in this image show two black holes. (NASA/JPL-Caltech/IRAP) /

- * We know neutron stars – stars so dense that a speck the size of a sesame seed would weigh more than a few thousand elephants – are common. The X-ray image below was made by NASA's Chandra mission. The numerous colorful dots are possible neutron stars or black holes located in a distant galaxy like our own. [M83, Soria & Wu, 2003]
- * We know some of these neutron stars spin as fast as a car engine, with a regularity better than the best clocks we can manufacture.
- * We know how all the chemical elements are made: helium in the first few minutes of the long history of the universe; carbon in stars such as the Sun; and gold in stellar explosions or collisions of neutron stars.
- * Our robot ambassadors have trundled across the rust-red surface of Mars, and we've mapped its deep canyons and monstrous volcanoes. The image below shows a canyon in Mars that's longer than the continental United States, known as Valles Marineris.

/ A mosaic of 102 images from the Viking

Orbiter. (NASA/JPL-Caltech) /

- * Our American robots have visited every one of the planets of our solar system and many of its myriad moons.

/ An image of a volcano eruption in Io. An ice volcano eruption on Io, a moon of Jupiter. The volcanic plume is this photo from 1997 is mostly ice and extended about 60 miles into space. (NASA-JPL, DLR) /

- * And we've discovered thousands of planets revolving around other stars.

All this knowledge can be labeled "Made in the U.S.A." All this is /our/ legacy, enabled by federal funding.

In just a few months, the Trump administration has undermined U.S. dominance in science, built up over many decades. The federal funding that made America the world's science leader is threatened with crippling reductions, not just for astronomy and space science but also for fundamental research in energy, chemistry, computer science and preventive medicine.

Consider, for example, the proposed budget for the National Science Foundation, the federal agency that has funded many U.S. contributions to astronomy (including mine), as well as research in physics, chemistry and computer science. Last year, NSF supported more than 330,000 scientists, students and teachers; next year, the budget allows for only 90,000. The funding rug will be pulled out from under nearly a quarter of a million American scientists, engineers and future scientists.

[Doesn't mention that ~80% of grant proposals to NSF are REJECTED each year as it stands.]

Why?

Does science cost too much? I've been involved in some of the discoveries listed above. The total cost to the average American taxpayer for all of my research, from my first article in 1961 to now, is less than a penny. The entire National Science Foundation budget for all research in astronomy costs each American about \$1 a year.

Is the scientific enterprise riddled with waste and fraud, as some in Washington insistently allege? Some experiments don't work – I've had some duds. But we learn from our mistakes; failure is not always a waste. And allegations of widespread fraud in the scientific enterprise are not just entirely unproven; they make no sense. If I receive funds from NASA, I have to account for them, and officials at both my college and NASA review my accounts. Carefully.

If, instead, the gutting of science and so much else the federal government does for us is just a whim, it is a costly one. Investments in basic research have been one of the most cost-effective expenditures of government money in my lifetime. It is not just the faster computer chips, the better weather forecasts, the cheaper batteries and the more potent vaccines American science has pioneered. Scientists at colleges and universities across the country have trained the scientists and engineers who go on to found companies that now employ millions.

In the last letter he wrote, Thomas Jefferson pointed to the value of "the light of science." Whatever the reasons are – real or proffered – for dimming this light, we risk surrendering leadership in an enterprise of proven value to our health, prosperity and sense of wonder at the marvels of the natural world.

Comments...

US technology and research also invented solar cells and solar energy, then Republicans kowtowed to oil industry executives and their lobbying money and handed a profitable manufacturing industry to China. With Trump's cuts to all scientific and medical research, fully supported by the Republican Party, the US will no longer be in the forefront of innovation or advanced medical treatments. China and Europe will benefit as the economic advantages move with the scientists whose work will be funded by other countries instead of the US. Even with full funding eventually under a Democratic president, it could take decades to regain the preeminence the US has long maintained.

I'm afraid that it is most likely that US dominance will be lost forever. Even under pre-Trump funding levels, other countries, mainly China were outperforming us. China is on the way to being the leader in renewable energy. and BEVs, and thanks to the shortsightedness of the current administration, the lead in these fields has been ceded to China. Once lost, it will be nearly impossible to regain it. Worse, many of our top scientists and engineers are reading the writing on the wall, and are looking to leave the US for other countries where their research has a better chance of being funded. Once gone, it is unlikely they will come back.

You really do have to wonder how MAGA defines "Great". They are making America less of a leader in many areas including science, which certainly does not align with my definition of great nation.

- 'Great' in the percentage of obese people
- 'Great' in stupidity and ignorance
- 'Great' in idol worshipping a certain orange person

'Great' in Dunning – Kruger

And all to provide the ultra rich with a tax benefit that most won't even notice. Most Americans are ignorant regarding the reason government funds scientific research. Most initial research is high risk. No private enterprise or even foundation is willing to invest in research that is more likely to be a "dud." This is where government steps in. Fund that initial research and then when an idea actually shows some promise, private enterprise and foundations can step in to further develop and scale the idea. This is how and why the US is number one in technology. This is why we are so successful globally. Failure to fund creates a vacuum for other countries like China, countries in Europe to fill. Just look at how many tech unicorns the US has produced versus the rest of the world. And look at how many of those companies have an immigrant entrepreneur (or more) at its core. This anti-science, no government funding philosophy will set the US back for generations.

[Don't forget we're also investing in building a police state with an all-American Gulag.]

The loss of funding will result in more than lost research. We are losing our researchers. Other countries are recruiting our scientists. When we get the funding back (go Democrats!!), we'll still have lost a large part of a generation

You forgot something: "We elect dangerous idiots twice"

Twice recently. G.W. Bush wasn't exactly an intellectual giant either.

"Will they continue?" The question is answered; NO – our leadership in science -- is over. Already, crucial funding for healthcare research – including cancer and alzheimer's research, space science, climate research – has been collapsed. NASA is being forced to abandon planetary science programs even – that have recently been initiated. Because science relies on evidence, critical thinking and proof – it's the seething enemy of a Rightist politics which relies on populations steeped in lies, hate and superstition.

[cont] This also accounts for Rightist antipathy towards education and the educated; something that in the modern era began with the vile Ronald Reagan who, as governor of CA, eviscerated that state's proud university system. He continued that "work" as president – collapsing the national education budget by 50% – dealing a blow to education at all levels while sparking the explosion in university tuitions that continues to this day.

[cont] To understand the effects of Reagan's vandalism, consider – in 1980, America's students rank #1 in math and science – globally.

But the war against science and education is also why Trump is stealing healthcare from 20 million Americans; a heartless act that will lead annually to around 120,000 deaths every year; deaths that, with health care, would have been prevented. it's all for the enrichment of Oligarchy. If this is hard to understand, think of it this way; When Alaric's Visigoth horde, on August 24, 410 AD, breached the Roman gates for the final time, it flooded the streets of that city raping and pillaging and murdering without a care. Its mission was simple; to carry away anything and everything of value. That people died in the process was meaningless. THIS is the historical context which sheds the most light on the barbarian horde to which we ceded our society on November 5.

Don't be ridiculous. We are spending at record levels on research and development, approaching a trillion per year.

Total proposed funding for basic research in 2024 (BEFORE Trump) including NIH, DOE, NSF, NASA, USGS, NOAA, NIST, USDA, EPA was \$56 billion which is about 20 times SMALLER than your ridiculous claim! See:

<https://www.science.org/content/article/final-u-s-spending-bills-offer-gloomy-outlook-science>

The existing and proposed cuts will destroy NIH, NSF, DOE, NASA, EPA, and University scientific research, leading to a complete loss of scientists, jobs, the pipeline for training scientists, to other countries and a total loss of American pre-eminence in science and technology.

"We sneer at experts," observed David DeWitt. "We spit epithets like 'academic elites' at professors dedicating their lives to pursuing discovery that benefits humankind. And we worship flashy internet hucksters selling lifestyle scams. "We mock intelligence and glorify egomania and materialism. We worship spectacle and are voyeurs for anger, confrontation, and violence. We live in fantasy worlds where what we want to believe is true regardless of whether it is true, because what we want comes first no matter what, certainly no matter any facts, this decadence of mind and body only afforded to us by modernity's remarkable luxury and technology." "It is in these ways that I regard a very great many adults as simply overgrown children."

Spot-on. I grew up in the late 60s and early 70s. There was no "bro-culture" back then. We are overrun by a verminous generation of "men-children." They have lead America into the gauzy valley of stupidity and knownothingism.

Who needs scientific knowledge and facts when all the knowledge needed can be found in the Bible, ignoramuses "doing their own research" and the genius of the 47th President and first dictator of the United States. The Earth is flat and 5000 year-old, horse dewormer cures COVID, and one can change the course of a tropical storm using a magic

sharpie.

Six thousand years old. Get your facts straight. Construction started on a Sunday, and was completed the following Friday.

Trump has basically surrendered the 21st century to China. He didn't even put up a fight. Just a small whimper.

[Lamont_Cranston] If you ask a MAGA cult member when was the USA 'great', they would likely come up with some period in the middle of the last century, say 1940 - 1970. And why was that? The USA won the Second World War, built the interstate highway system, and landed a man on the moon. Every single one was a government program. Every single one of those programs were funded by income tax rates as high as 90%.

Don't forget the GI Bill which paid for the higher education of returning WWII military. Between about 1945 and 1965 every university and college had Married Students' Housing where older ex-military students eked out a limited budget while earning advanced degrees. I read somewhere that GI Bill changed US culture and economy, built entire suburbs and highway systems, schools, shopping malls.

I knew a wealthy Santa Barbara lawyer who credits the GI bill for taking him from the working class in the North East to a multimillion dollar house, a 50 foot yacht, etc.

Trump is costing us everything that has made us great.

Greetings to Professor Partridge, who taught me physics many years ago when I was a student at Bryn Mawr college. I still remember his passion for the subject, of which this beautifully written article is a good example. I went on to a career in medicine, and have recently taken up astronomy as a hobby (in part to get my mind off politics). Like Dr. Partridge, I am devastated by the deliberate and extremely short sighted destruction of American science. I am truly puzzled as to why politicians would be against advances in science and medicine. Perhaps it is contempt for people who are smarter than they are. In any case enormous harm is being done to future generations.,

I've read about the downfall of civilizations and wondered how it happened and why they didn't do something to prevent it. Am now looking at it from the inside.

The Trump administration isn't dimming the light of science; they're extinguishing it.

The damage to America's scientific research enterprise has already been done. DOGE has crippled science and the new Republican budget

will finish it off. This isn't something that could happen. It has already happened.

Trump is running on Stalin's timeline—controlling what we see, what we know, what we remember. This is not metaphor. This is a warning. And it's not just democracy and truth that are at stake. If the U.S. surrenders its scientific and technological edge, it will forfeit a massive economic advantage—one that has driven American exports and global influence for decades. Instead of investing in next-generation industries, Trump seems fixated on reviving outdated steel mills and obsolete gas-guzzling cars. It's not just backwards—it's delusional. In a world racing toward the future, he's slamming the brakes and throwing the map out the window. A small reminder from a Swede

It is now rapidly dominating in ignorance. America was once a proud crucible of knowledge, leading the world in so many areas and highly respected for it. Now the world is shaking its head at the decline and sheer incompetence. Stunning!

I got my PhD in physics with Pell Grants and NSF grants. Under Trump those will vanish. I'm now retired, but I know many faculty at universities who are wondering how long education will last. I know they'll try as hard as they can to help students.

The magazine Nature ranked universities worldwide: Harvard is number one, MIT number 10. All universities in between, 2 to 9 are Chinese. The number of scientific papers published used to come in majority from US universities. It now comes from Chinese universities. The number of patents must show the same trend. It is predicted to accelerate in the future. And what is the Whitehouse doing to science? Destroying our scientific dominance. "US Uber alles!" Ah! Ah! Ah! Tragic. It does not have to be that way.

[henrystar] You talk science, but you show men on the Moon, which is NOT science. Here's what science actually IS:
<https://henry.pha.jhu.edu/rch.html> [Dick Henry's elaborate webpage]

[BigBill4] The National Science Foundation plays an outsized roll in funding the education of graduate students in science and engineering. At this moment, the NSF supports about 0.8 million graduate students to learn and do research. Some of these students go on to do great basic research, as described in this article. More apply their graduate education in industry where they start companies or invent the next cutting edge devices. Some graduate students go directly to work in the national labs, where they do top secret work to defend our nation.

[cont] The U.S. is in a race with China to produce the scientists and engineers that make this progress and China has ramped up its Universities so that it is currently producing twice as many

Ph.D. and masters level engineers and scientists as does the U.S. Now the Trump administration will be cutting the numbers of supported graduate students by a factor of two. After these new cuts, China will be producing 3-4 times as many Ph.D. and masters level scientists and engineers per year as does the U.S. The Trump administration has stated that the cuts are a refocusing of research on national needs and suggest that these cuts do no harm. That statement is incorrect because most graduate students work in different areas after graduating than they pursue in graduate school. The total number of graduate engineers and scientists is the important number to focus upon and the Trump administration cuts will reduce the total number of NSF supported grads by about a factor of two. If this is not corrected, China could be producing 3 - 4 times the numbers of Ph.D. and Masters level scientists and engineers as will the U.S.. Since about 3 percent of current Ph.D. level scientists and engineers in the U.S. workforce retire every year, the failure to educate will have an immediate effect on the nation. Axing NSF support hurts the U.S. in both the short and long term in ways that will be very hard, if not impossible, to correct.

So the UK had only a third the number of Nobel prize winners as the US? Population UK: 69.55 million. Population USA: 347,275 million. Might explain a bit? The US is always right at the top for boasting anyway.

The problem with de-funding the sciences is that scientists have to put food on the table for their families. When you take away their funding, you can't expect them to do brilliant things for free, while they and their families starve and live on the streets. It very quickly becomes necessary to find work outside of the sciences in order to survive. Teaching salaries only go so far, especially when your university is being de-funded. Once those scientists land stable, well-paying jobs outside of the sciences, they are lost to the sciences forever. That is because the half-life of the sciences, at least in my field, is about 5 years. Beyond that time frame, it's extremely difficult to catch up with developments in the field and be competitive with younger PhDs hunting for their first appointments. You're essentially washed up. Moreover, when the US loses its scientists, it loses the human infrastructure that trains and grooms future scientists. This is why even when MAGA is but a fading memory, we will struggle ever to lead again in the sciences. It will take a generation or two just to repair the damage this administration is inflicting on us.

How exactly does this liberal astronomy stuff relate to building golf resorts? Enquiring minds want to know. /s

I am a microbiologist and am currently at a conference. There have been multiple talks so far by researchers who work on ways to combat

antibiotic resistance who have ended by saying that their projects have the potential to save untold numbers of lives, but that the grants supporting them have been terminated. Trump is killing people while cutting America's throat.

Under DJT, we will lead the world in cryptocurrency, memes, and energy consumption. Think of the benefits to mankind.

So this is how we Make America Great Again? We do so by shutting down the only business that has kept us leading the world. Brilliant, my behind!!!

The worst part of the Trump administration is that the damage they do won't be felt immediately, but long after he's left office. Then the current president will get the blame. Just as Trump is getting the credit for the Biden economy today. Biden's major pieces of legislation have fully kicked in and jobs are being created because of it. Some of the worst of Trump's policies are set to start after the 2026 election, so voters don't know what they've done to them.

The MAGA movement represents the willful dumbing down of America. Anti-science, anti-vaccine, etc. Close-minded, frightened conservatives are trying to turn back the hands of time. They fear change. They fear progress. They are unsophisticated and under-educated. And their numbers are growing. The U.S. has indeed accomplished many great things, as this article points out, but we're collectively getting dumber by the day. I'm embarrassed by it all. Most of the western world now see us a wealthy and powerful country that's rapidly becoming a backwater, not to be trusted.

This is what happens when you elect people who have no knowledge or understanding of how the modern world developed. The fruits of basic scientific research have utterly transformed our lives from our grandparents' times and the US has been the leading nation in this, showing how crass these cuts are. Britain, who with a quarter of your population has a higher proportion of Nobel science laureates per head of population than the US, has always been less successful than the US in converting those scientific advances into commercial enterprises. Your combination of scientific excellence and commercial expertise is a world beater and if you lose the former, you are just cutting off your nose to spite your face.

...read this outlining all the current research and development status due to TACO cuts and dismantling of agencies:
<https://heathercoxrichardson.substack.com/p/july-6-2025>
A succinct, truthful summary of just where we are today and the trouble we are in.

This is not a whim. It is the Republican War On Science being fed steroids, backed by the unaccountable power of our Unitary Executive

and his Congressional psychopants. Remember that Morons Are Governing America, and they can't stand any truths that contradict the lies and panders they offer to the Deplorables who keep them in office. Science relies on empirical facts and deductive rigor, neither of which can be made to go away by simply lying more and yelling louder, the only rhetorical skills these cretins possess. I fear we're going to have to witness a lot more Natural Selection like we're seeing this week in Texas before we have a ghost of a chance of getting a solid majority of Americans to once again believe in objective reality and truth.

I have long known that my taxpayer contributions to science are next to nothing; less than a milkshake at a roadside diner. I have always supported our government's spending in this area. I too am very proud of what the U.S. has contributed to human knowledge – in all areas. I traveled the world with the Navy and continued to do so as a travel agent. I was always a little surprised, and gratified, at the respect and admiration for our country in almost every country I visited. I don't know what course to take to reverse this idiocy. We have a dunce for president evidenced by his personal ire toward higher education. I know he went to business school, but very little about how well he did or if he finished. At least one professor said he was the stupidest student he ever had. It's the Dunning-Kruger effect on steroids as he believes he's a genius. His brand of genius will destroy us. We need to get out the vote at mid-term. If the GOP suffers greatly perhaps he will lose most of his support. I have no other hope.

xFrom rwo@virginia.edu Thu Jul 10 12:09:50 2025
xDate: Thu, 10 Jul 2025 12:09:47
xFrom: "O'Connell, Robert W (rwo)" <rwo@virginia.edu>
xTo: "bpartrid@haverford.edu" <bpartrid@haverford.edu>
xCc: "O'Connell, Robert W (rwo)" <rwo@virginia.edu>
xSubject: Terrific!

Hi Bruce: Terrific article! I hope the right people read it and take it to heart.

Lately I catch myself thinking, "Well, at least astronomy will thrive in Europe and Asia." Incredibly sad.

Best,
Bob

xFrom bpartrid@haverford.edu Thu Jul 10 12:45:28 2025
xDate: Thu, 10 Jul 2025 12:45:12
xFrom: Bruce Partridge <bpartrid@haverford.edu>
xTo: "O'Connell, Robert W (rwo)" <rwo@virginia.edu>
xSubject: Re: Terrific!

Thanks, Bob. I'm certain the op-ed is high on Trump's reading

list.... Bruce

=====

7/8/25: From RW0...

SENT 7/8/25 TO:

Sen Kaine, VA
Sen Warner, VA
Sen Tillis, NC
Sen Budd, NC

email: rwo.conne@gmail.com

Subject: Restore support for basic scientific research

The Senate should be working as hard as possible to restore federal funding for basic scientific research that the Trump administration has proposed to cut. The proposed cuts threaten the entire scientific ecosystem in the country.

For a moment, set aside the inevitable long-term crippling of America's scientific and technological prowess and look at the short-term economic impact.

Implementing this budget would lead to a financial depression for the scientific workforce -- not just for the scientists themselves but for hundreds of thousands of support staff and contractors and the tens of thousands of businesses that supply them. People can easily visualize the sophisticated equipment needed by modern science in the case of the space program. But biology and clinical research laboratories depend just as much on high-tech infrastructure in the form of advanced electronics, computational power, precision devices, special materials, and other indispensable elements.

How many people would lose their jobs? Since all the money allocated by the federal government is ultimately spent on people's salaries, it's easy to make a rough estimate. The proposed cuts to the major science agencies amount to about \$35 billion. Since each federal dollar spent directly on science generates something like an additional two dollars of related economic activity in the country, the total loss to the economy would be about \$100 billion. Taking a round figure for the salary of an average worker in the US scientific ecosystem of \$80,000, that implies an equivalent loss of over one million jobs.

This will arrive as a sudden calamity, not a gradual transition that might allow the system to readjust over time. The US deliberately adopted a special structure 75 years ago in which basic research is mainly supported by the government but applied research is mainly supported by the private sector. As a result, alternative employment in the private sector will not be available for many of the affected people, perhaps for years. Many will lose their livelihoods, their financial security, their homes. Collateral damage to local housing markets and essential services like health care will be serious. The effects will be centered on communities hosting research universities or other major research centers all over the country, in red and blue states alike. Phoenix, Houston, Cleveland, Nashville, Miami, and the Research Triangle in North Carolina are good examples of places often overlooked by those who imagine scientific research is concentrated in blue states.

How can anyone think this is good for America?

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7/8/25: Facebook/Astronomers. From Elizabeth Mills.

In case folks have missed this: the state of Indiana is about to discontinue more than 400 "low enrollment" university degrees at their campuses. The IU Astrophysics PhD is among them (to be "merged/consolidated", presumably with Physics, by AY 26-27).

Among other discontinuations ("voluntarily" submitted by the universities in response to state legislation) are physics and math/science degrees at the smaller satellite campuses. These moves should also be seen in context with program reviews and cuts that have been happening for several years now in multiple states (West Virginia, North Carolina, and Kansas, all of which involved work with consulting firm rpk group).

These are having increasing impacts on science degrees and departments (though of course arts and humanities remain major targets). You can find the full list of Indiana program discontinuations here:

<https://www.in.gov/.../Info-Item-Voluntary-Early-Actions...> West Virginia cuts from 2023 (including math PhD):

https://mountainstatespotlight.org/.../wvu-board-cuts... UNC Greensboro cuts from 2024 (including physics BA/BS):

<https://www.wunc.org/.../unc-greensboro-announces-program...> Kansas programs still under review as "underperforming" (including physics degrees at almost all Kansas universities and KU's Astro BA/BS)

https://lawrencekstimes.com/.../kbor-evaluating-action...

FYI- the Astrophysics PhD is a small part of the graduate program (the main degree is still the Astronomy PhD, which should remain). But the

overall effect on IU as a whole and the availability of physics undergrad degrees to a wide population of students across Indiana campuses will be devastating. The loss of education degrees (particularly the wonderful Physics B.S. Ed at IU which helped train future teachers) is also extremely disheartening.

Comments...

You can sadly add Ohio to that list, the cuts haven't yet gotten through the system.

7/9/25; ArsTechnica. What the Duffy? Here's why Trump appointed the secretary of transportation to lead NASA "Honored to accept this mission. Time to take over space. Let's launch."

Six weeks after he terminated the nomination of Jared Isaacman to become NASA administrator, President Trump moved on Wednesday evening to install a new temporary leader for the space agency.

The newly named interim administrator, Sean Duffy, already has a full portfolio: He is serving as the secretary of transportation, a Cabinet-level position that oversees 55,000 employees across 13 agencies, including the Federal Aviation Administration.

"Sean is doing a TREMENDOUS job in handling our Country's Transportation Affairs, including creating a state-of-the-art Air Traffic Control systems, while at the same time rebuilding our roads and bridges, making them efficient, and beautiful, again," Trump wrote on his social media network Wednesday evening. "He will be a fantastic leader of the ever more important Space Agency, even if only for a short period of time."

In response to this post, Duffy wrote on X , "Honored to accept this mission. Time to take over space. Let's launch."

The idea of the secretary of transportation also running NASA may seem like an odd choice, but in some ways, the appointment of Duffy makes sense for the president. Whether it is beneficial to the space agency remains to be seen, but two industry sources speaking confidentially said they would not immediately dismiss the prospect.

Who is Sean Duffy?

Duffy has a colorful background, starring in the /Real World: Boston/ reality television show in 1997 and serving as a commentator on ESPN. A Republican, he served in the US House of Representatives from 2011 to 2019. He is married and has nine children.

Although he does not have a space background, Duffy has shown an

interest in spaceflight since becoming FAA administrator. He watched from NASA Headquarters the Crew 9 mission's splashdown on March 18, which brought Butch Wilmore and Suni Williams back to Earth after a prolonged stay in space. He also had expressed an interest in attending the forthcoming Crew 11 launch at the end of this month.

Officials at NASA were CAUGHT UNAWARE by the announcement on Wednesday evening. They had been expecting the existing acting administrator, Janet Petro, to remain in place at least through the end of the year while a new nominee was put forth to lead NASA and confirmed by Congress.

Sources indicated that although Petro did not have a particularly high standing within the Trump administration, she did nothing to be removed from her position. Rather, it seems that Trump wanted someone he liked and trusted running NASA. This is probably a benefit for the agency, as it will give NASA a direct line to the president. For example, Duffy can text Trump if NASA needs something or is being treated unfairly during the budgeting process.

Petro did not have that kind of political sway, and this is a White House in which access to the president matters a great deal. The agency was in great peril, as there was no one in headquarters who could push back on harmful things being done to NASA or get things done. Duffy will have that kind of pull. But he will also be incredibly busy already with the Department of Transportation.

Duffy will push for the president's budget

There are also some reasons to be concerned about NASA under Duffy. Because he does not come from a space background, but rather a political one, Duffy likely views his mission at NASA as carrying out the vision of the space agency established by the president's budget request, which slashes funding for science and makes significant changes to NASA's deep space exploration plans.

His appointment comes on the eve of the US Senate revealing its response to the president's budget request, a markup of the federal budget for fiscal year 2026. The Senate is likely to restore many of the cuts proposed by the White House Office of Management and Budget, which is led by Russ Vought. In terms of alignment, Duffy is likely to side with Vought and push for the president's budget to be implemented at the start of the fiscal year on October 1.

Philosophically, Vought believes strongly that the president should have more authority to direct federal spending. And he probably will force the issue this year. Using tactics such as rescission --essentially ordering federal agencies to freeze spending -- and impoundment, Vought could seek to implement the priorities in the president's budget request, which his office wrote. In this, Duffy

will offer a more capable political ally at NASA.

So buckle up. NASA finally has some clarity on who will lead the agency over the next several months, and it is a person trusted by the president. Duffy is also viewed as a capable leader and experienced politician who understands how Washington, DC, works. It's possible that Duffy will listen to the concerns of leaders at NASA in the coming weeks and seek to offset some of the more Draconian (and difficult to understand) cuts by Vought's office.

However, it is also possible that he takes his mandate to slash NASA's budget and workforce seriously, and in doing so would be vastly more effective than Petro.

260 Comments...

Is Ars joined those bending the knee to the first felon? For shame.

[Berger]: Just reporting what I hear from my space policy sources, who are across the board in terms of their politics.

I very much enjoyed The Guardian's take on his appointment, which ended with the wonderful paragraph: "Duffy has no scientific background, but does have experience with transportation, as a former contestant on the MTV reality TV game show Road Rules, a Winnnebago driving contest."

Eric roughly what percentage of insiders think the the next 20 years of space look like 1975 to 1995 and not the dawn of a new space age? Because in my darkest moments I definitely think space exploration may have peaked for at least a generation or more. I'm 41 and I worry I'm more likely to be dead and buried before we get boots on Mars or that the last Apollo astronaut will be dead before we get back to the Moon. I don't know what you're seeing out there but I see space as being at the absolute bottom of the priority barrel with almost all of the real life people I know, in the news and on social media, with the left and the right – there just doesn't seem to be any real constituency for space anymore. Elon has the entire left hoping for starships to blow up on launch pads and the right thinks science in general is inherently out to get them – I really have trouble seeing the light in the space tunnel these days.

...to keep things in perspective, defunding NASA is bad. Crippling the NSF and NIH is doubleplusgood.

The Senate Subcommittee on CJS released the audio of their meeting today: \$33.9 billion for science agencies, which means NASA and NSF. That's roughly flat funding levels for both agencies. Full appropriations committee meets tomorrow so there will likely be more information, but for now it doesn't look like the Senate wants to cut

NASA.

Duffy is there to be a hatchet man for the over 2,000 job cuts at NASA. There is no deeper purpose. With Isaacman gone, there is no one within the admin to actually fight for NASA. It'll be up to the Senate. I don't have much hope.

<https://www.politico.com/news/2025/07/09/nasa-staff-departures-00444674>

In normal times it would definitely be seen as a bad thing. Under Trump, we feel relieved if the acting head of NASA isn't a Flat Earther or Moon Landing Denier.

Well, Duffy is a climate change denier. Quoting him: " If you say the climate's changing, is it coming from CO2 or is it coming from the sun? Where is why is the climate changing? And then you would say, let's have a rigorous debate about what is causing it, or what are all the factors that bring us to climate change? And when you have the left that says "we're gonna shut down alternative science or science that challenges our narrative," I think it makes people go "maybe there is a different set of priorities here as opposed to climate change, maybe it actually is an agenda of control." -- So he supports "alternative science", whatever that is. Perhaps not a flat earther, but not necessarily much better.

Duffy has enough to deal with at DOT. Let's give him another job and hope he doesn't do both of them poorly because...Trump feels comfortable with him? NASA's about to lose 2,145 senior people. And now it has a temporary administrator who has no space expertise and is moonlighting from his main job overseeing a budget of \$106 billion?

[Congressman] John Culberson, a fierce advocate for space above any parochial considerations who lost his job in 2018, I think in no small part due to redistricting. He funneled money for Europa Clipper and campaigned hard for JPL to add even a lander to the mission. A true loss for space as far as I'm concerned.

I grew up in Boston. Sean Duffy is just about as dumbfuck-batshit as you could get, in Boston. His existence offends me.

- 1) How long is "interim"?
- 2) Who will be picked for the permanent position?

[Berger] Yeah, great questions. Interim could be six months or 18 months. I'm not sure. As for who will be picked, they were still doing preliminary discussions with people as of last week, so I think it may be awhile before they select and name a permanent nominee.

I'm not expecting a guy who couldn't correctly assess the risks of taking public transportation to the office to be able to correctly assess the risks of space travel.

destroying NASA won't be easy to undo. These programs can't be stopped and started on a whim; it takes time and steady support. Once the satellites and probes are turned off, many of them will be done, dead, and gone forever.

The man too afraid to ride the NYC subway during rush hour is gonna lead us to the moon and beyond? God help us all.

7/10/25: Guardian. Trump names Sean Duffy as interim Nasa head after rejecting Elon Musk ally / Transportation secretary named as interim administrator of space agency as it faces crisis amid Trump's budget cuts

...Isaacman, who has flown multiple missions with Musk's SpaceX, was widely viewed as Musk's pick to lead Nasa. But Trump withdrew that nomination in May, posting earlier this week that he was "surprised to learn" Isaacman was a blue blooded Democrat, who had never contributed to a Republican before.

The reversal follows an escalating beef between Trump and Musk and their respective camps, including a reportedly heated dust-up between Musk and Duffy at a White House meeting over cuts to FAA programs that support commercial spaceflight.

The appointment comes as Nasa faces an existential crisis. The agency is hemorrhaging scientific talent amid Trump's proposed budget cuts that would slash the space science program from \$7.33bn to \$3.9bn annually. Under that proposal, Nasa's total budget would fall from \$24.8bn to \$18.8bn. About 900 Nasa employees departed in February, with another 1,500 signing up for voluntary separation programs through July, according to documents obtained by Politico. The exodus has prompted protests outside Nasa headquarters, with contractors and staff holding signs reading "Save Nasa" last week.

The Arizona senator and former astronaut Mark Kelly rhetorically asked what would have happened if this sort of mass departure happened during the cold war in the mid-20th century. "We would've lost the space race to the Soviets," he answered himself. "And now we risk losing the next space race to China."

Seven former Nasa science chiefs have also written to Congress, agreeing that the cuts would hand China an advantage in space exploration. "If the administration is committed to countering the growing Chinese capability in space, the US needs to continue its investment in US space science, not cede it unilaterally," they wrote.

Duffy, a former Republican congressman from Wisconsin who starred on MTV's The Real World in 1997, brings no space background to the role. His appointment is seen as a signal that Trump intends to push through his controversial budget cuts, which would terminate dozens of science missions including the Mars Odyssey spacecraft that has been studying the red planet since 2001.

"While Nasa's science missions have greatly expanded humanity's understanding of the Earth, solar system, and universe, the current expenditure of over \$7bn per year on over 100 missions is unsustainable," the administration's May budget request reads.

Since taking office as transportation secretary in January, Duffy has focused on rolling back what he calls "woke DEI policies" and Biden-era environmental regulations. His dual role overseeing both transportation and Nasa -- agencies with combined budgets exceeding \$30bn -- tracks with Trump's thinking on mixing assignments, notably Marco Rubio as secretary of state and acting national security adviser.

Janet Petro, director of Kennedy Space Center, had been serving as acting administrator since Trump's inauguration in January.

7/11/25: Van Scoyoc newsletter

Over 2,000 senior staff set to leave NASA under agency push.

At least 2,145 senior-ranking NASA employees are set to leave under a push to shed staff, according to documents obtained by POLITICO \364 potentially spelling trouble for White House space policy and depriving the agency of decades of experience. The 2,145 employees are those in GS-13 to GS-15 positions \364 senior-level government ranks that are typically reserved for those with specialized skills or management responsibilities. The losses are spread across each of NASA\371s 10 regional centers. Read more:\240 Politico [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

Congress passes budget reconciliation bill with \$10 billion for NASA

Congress approved a budget reconciliation bill that includes nearly \$10 billion for NASA human spaceflight programs and could also lead to the transfer of a space shuttle to Houston. Of that funding, \$4.1 billion would go to procure two additional Space Launch System rockets for Artemis 4 and 5, after the administration\371s fiscal year 2026 budget request for NASA proposed canceling SLS after Artemis 3. An additional \$2.6 billion would go to complete the lunar Gateway, which had also been slated for cancellation in the budget proposal. Read more:\240 Space News [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

Senators push back on Trump's proposal to cut NASA science funding by 47%

On Thursday, the U.S. Senate appropriations committee voted on a bill that provides NASA's science programs with \$7.3 billion for the upcoming fiscal year. The bill would reject the Trump administration's budget proposal for the agency, which slashes such funding by 47%. The bipartisan Senate bill \364 worked on by Jerry Moran (R-KS) and Chris Van Hollen (D-MD) \364 initially won by a vote of 15-14. However, primarily due to contention surrounding the location of the FBI headquarters, the bill was ultimately withdrawn, and another vote will be conducted during a future meeting. "The bill funds NASA at \$24.9 billion, slightly above [fiscal year 2025 levels] to explore the solar system, to advance our understanding of climate change, promote innovation and sustainability in aeronautics," Sen. Van Hollen said during Thursday's committee meeting. "We rejected cuts that would have devastated NASA's science by 47% and would have terminated 55 operating and planned missions." Read more:\240 Space.com [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

7/11/25: World Socialist Web Site (<<https://www.wsws.org/en>>)
Dan Weedman on Trump Cuts to Science Budget

The passage of President Donald Trump's "One Big Beautiful Bill Act" on July 4, 2025 was the death knell for basic scientific research in the United States. As part of the largest redistribution of wealth from the working class to the rich in the country's history, through a permanent \$3.8 trillion tax cut, the bill has also zeroed out critical funding for ongoing research at NASA and the National Science Foundation (NSF).

A recent article by the American Astronomical Society warned, "this budget poses an existential threat to our disciplines," including planetary science, astrophysics, heliophysics (the study of the Sun), particle physics and mathematics, as well as a slew of educational outreach programs run by both agencies.

The cuts to every aspect of scientific research are also mirrored in the complete dismantling of public health programs during the ongoing COVID-19 pandemic, as well as the dismantling of the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention and the National Institutes of Health as agencies of public health and medical research. Among the sharpest expressions of this process is the inability of doctors and researchers to get adequate funding for studies into Long COVID, an array of often debilitating symptoms suffered by hundreds of millions worldwide as the result of contracting one or more coronavirus infections.

The /World Socialist Web Site/ recently spoke to former NASA administrator Dan Weedman, 82, about the far-reaching and devastating impacts the cuts in the budget will have on science in the United States.

WSWS: How long have you been involved in astronomical research?

Dan Weedman: My career has spanned 60 years. I worked at either NASA or NSF from 1992 until 2002, serving as the head of NASA Astrophysics from 1993 to 1995 and as NSF program director for the National Optical Astronomy Observatories and the National Solar Observatory from August 1999 until September 2002.

That time includes a lot of critical moments in astronomy, including the first servicing mission for the Hubble Space Telescope in 1993 and the planning, development and launch of several missions, including the Advanced X-ray Astrophysics Facility, now known as Chandra, and the Space Infrared Telescope Facility, which got renamed to Spitzer.

I retired from NSF to join the research team on Spitzer, which launched in August 2003. I worked there for a decade and a half before the funds for research were zeroed out, and then ultimately the spacecraft was decommissioned in 2020.

Over that time period, you can compare the budgets quantitatively. My annual budget in 1995 was about \$750 million. The budget for astrophysics for 2026 was cut by 66 percent/, to only \$520 million. That's not adjusted for inflation.

At the time we had real money and all sorts of plans. Now the only things that are going to be funded enough to function are the JWST [James Webb Space Telescope] and Hubble. It's going to be devastating.

An image of Pluto captured by New Horizons during its flyby of the distant dwarf planet. Among the most striking feature on Pluto is the bright expanse of Pluto's icy, nitrogen-and-methane rich "heart," Sputnik Planitia. [Photo: NASA/Johns Hopkins University Applied Physics Laboratory/Southwest Research Institute/Alex Parker]

WSWS: The budget for NASA as a whole is being gutted from \$24.9 billion to \$18.8 billion, a reduction of 24 percent. The Science Mission Directorate is getting slashed by 47 percent, nearly half, planetary science by 32 percent and heliophysics by 46 percent. An article from the Planetary Society wrote that 19 missions are being axed. Can any science be done under these conditions?

DW: The only time such a reduction has happened was at the end of the Apollo program, which was five percent of the federal budget at its height. Now you have a situation in which NASA was getting maybe a

tenth of that level of funding, and some areas are being cut to a quarter, half or two-thirds that already tiny amount.

That's why virtually every astrophysics and planetary science mission is getting canceled. The report from the AAS lays it all out, from Earth observatories like Chandra and Fermi, as well as missions across the Solar System like Juno at Jupiter and New Horizons, which took the first closeup imagery of Pluto and is now exploring the Kuiper Belt.

All of these are fully functioning spacecraft, some of which have been operating for decades. Chandra has enough fuel to last another decade and New Horizons has enough fuel for a possible second rendezvous with a body beyond Pluto. There are no other missions being planned to study X-rays or explore the outer Solar System, so they are shut down, that's it.

And there's a more fundamentally insidious part of this bill. Hubble is losing \$8 million while JWST is losing \$47 million. None of that can come from the engineers and the communications facilities, because you have to keep them both flying. So what happens is that cuts are from the research money that's going to astronomers that actually use and study the data collected.

It's explicitly zeroing out what is known as the Astrophysics Data Analysis Program, which is money that goes to people to analyze data that's already been collected. We have this incredible archive of data from all these missions going back for decades, and most of it is just sitting there unexplored. It was hard to get funding to use that data before, and now it will essentially be impossible. At least for US researchers; there's an irony that these data are being very heavily used internationally, especially in China.

There's also an extremely anti-intellectual component. Outside the US, a lot of the basic science is done by institutions. Among of the most famous are the Max Planck Institutes in Germany. In China as well, as the research is done at government-funded facilities. But in the US, all research is tied to universities.

And Trump has been very aggressive in going after anybody and anything that's even peripherally involved with universities. So cutting research funding at NASA and NSF is also a general attack on academic studies.

WSWS: And that attack on culture has been a part of the US establishment for decades. It is also reflected in the only part of NASA's budget that got increased, which is manned spaceflight.

DW: First, we should be clear that any increase there does not mean there will be any money for science. Earlier in the administration, that would have meant money going to Elon Musk and his proposed NASA

head Jared Isaacman, another billionaire. Now that Trump and Musk had their falling out, it's not clear who will take over. [Author's note: Trump has named Transportation Secretary Sean Duffy as interim NASA administrator.]

There's also the question of whether the whole Mars initiative will even happen. Really, the money is for Trump's political cronies. It's to send to home states of political allies. Billions of dollars are just going to disappear for political reasons as opposed to anything related to science. The entire motivation is just personal profit.

WSWS: Could you speak to the impact this will have on a mission that hasn't been launched, the Nancy Grace Roman telescope?

DW: There's some interesting backstory there. We were discussing Roman in the 1990s, back when it was known as the Wide-Field Infrared Survey Telescope (WFIRST), alongside a similar project funded by NSF, the new Vera Rubin Observatory in Chile. From a scientific perspective, they are both designed to do similar things, take all-sky surveys. The Rubin will do so in optical wavelengths while Roman is designed to do the same in the infrared.

The initial idea was to find as many supernovae as possible and try and pin down dark energy. And of course as the design progressed, their missions expanded, but that's essentially the goal of each instrument.

The problem that Roman has is that it is now very vulnerable because an argument can be made that both do the same thing, and Rubin is going to have an enormous amount of data well before Roman launches, which is slated for 2026 or 2027. And the fact that it's budget got cut from \$407 million to \$156 million, it may very well also get completely cut next year. That's more likely if the launch date slips, which it probably will with so much less money.

WSWS: To segue now into the NSF, could you explain what's happening there? The AAS article paints an even more dire picture.

DW: There, you can see the budget is even more about taking money from basic science and directly benefiting industry and commercial interests. The request focused on only three specific areas, artificial intelligence, quantum computing and biotechnology. And it explicitly said that any research must be in collaboration with "other federal agencies, industry and private foundations."

The budget request also stated, "NSF is prioritizing investments that complement private-sector R&D and offer strong potential to drive economic growth and strengthen US technological leadership."

There's so much in those few words. First, the budget is getting cut

from \$9 billion to just \$3.9 billion. And that's happening across the agency and is expected to reduce the people getting funded from 330,100 to just 90,000. That's going to hit students especially hard, a 70 percent decrease in graduate students and a 79 percent decrease in undergraduate students. The number of personnel are going to be decimated.

Second, this is completely against the history of NSF. From the very start it was created to be independent and do basic research. There was not a commercial connection. At the time, there were plenty of companies doing research, like Bell Labs, and they did some great work. But NSF was set up to do the stuff the commercial labs wouldn't do because they didn't see any immediate profit in it.

That phrasing indicates there's a plan to basically turn NSF into a commercial research lab, to focus only on what has an immediate profit objective and then just abandon basic research.

This is going to destroy whole careers, as well as stop them before they get started. I'm especially concerned at the devastation this is going to have on graduate students, because so many rely on NSF grants for their funding. Now essentially no one is going to get anything unless they're in those three fields.

They're killing off the new generation of scientists, the seed corn, the people who will have ideas for the future. This applies to all the sciences, because the same thing is happening at NIH. Young people are bearing the brunt of this and it's the young people that represent the future. It's throwing away our scientific future in the US, it's as simple as that.

WSWS: In addition to the truly staggering workforce reduction, one cut that blew my mind was to LIGO, which is getting cut from \$48 million to \$29 million, and shutting down one site. That project started in 1992 and the data collected was responsible for a Nobel Prize in Physics.

DW: It's a perfect example of the ignorance of all this. LIGO is trying to detect gravitational waves, and you simply can't do it with only one facility. You need at least two to confirm any detection and to have any idea of the signal's source. There are other facilities internationally that are being brought online, but they don't yet have the sensitivity of LIGO.

What gives me hope is that young people like yourself are paying attention to what's happening and are trying to help. You can't let the attempts at demoralization work.

WSWS: Agreed, there's a fight to be had, for science and for society as a whole.

1 Comment...

The WSWS is taking the right approach, interviewing Dan Weedman, a former NASA administrator. This man has the high level experience and knowledge to nail what the Trump administration has in store for US Science, be it NSF, NASA or any other of the numerous funding bodies that have since the cold war provided the resources for basic science in the US, and were a necessary component of their societal and technological progress. Fascists are not just brutish nationalists, they are also incredibly ignorant. They assume that only science that "helps private industry" is necessary. But fundamental science is just that: fundamental. It often has no obvious immediate technological application.

[cont] Would it have been OK to quash Einstein's work on special and general relativity prior to WW1, using the money to build chemical weapons or prisons? This science is so fundamental that decades elapsed before any industry had any need of it. Today, however, it is unthinkable that any space-based system could be built without, at least, special relativity. And general relativity has broadened the understanding of many mysteries in the observable universe, not to mention being the theoretical basis for gravity waves.

7/14/25: FYI

APPROPRIATORS MOVING AWAY FROM TRUMP-LEVEL CUTS TO SCIENCE AGENCIES

The House Commerce-Justice-Science appropriations bill [aip.us17.list-manage.com] released today proposes an 18.2% cut to NASA science and a 20.7% cut to the National Science Foundation. The cuts are not as deep as those proposed in the president's budget request. On Tuesday, the House Appropriations Committee will hold a subcommittee markup [aip.us17.list-manage.com] for the bill, which also covers the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration and the National Institute of Standards and Technology.

The committee also plans [aip.us17.list-manage.com] to hold a subcommittee markup [aip.us17.list-manage.com] today for the Energy-Water funding bill for fiscal year 2026 and a full committee markup [aip.us17.list-manage.com] of the bill on Thursday. The bill [aip.us17.list-manage.com] proposes \$8.4 billion for the Department of Energy's Office of Science, a 2% increase from the fiscal year 2025-enacted level. In comparison, the president's budget request [aip.us17.list-manage.com] proposed a 14% cut to the Office of Science. Budget numbers for these agencies and more will be added to FYI's Budget Tracker [aip.us17.list-manage.com] as they are released.

The Senate Appropriations Committee may revisit its own CJS bill this week after last week's full committee markup, [aip.us17.list-manage.com] during which subcommittee Chair Jerry Moran (R-KS) said the bill would maintain science agency budgets near current levels, including a \$9 billion budget for NSF and \$24.9 billion for NASA that "protects key science missions." It also would have made employees of NOAA's National Weather Service "incapable of being furloughed and removed," Moran said. The committee has not yet released the bill text. Chair Susan Collins (R-ME) postponed the vote [aip.us17.list-manage.com] on the bill after Democrats, along with Sen. Lisa Murkowski (R-AK), inserted an amendment that would prevent the Trump administration from interfering with plans to move the FBI headquarters to Greenbelt, Maryland.

The committee rejected an amendment from Sen. Tammy Baldwin (D-WI) to restore grants at NSF that were terminated for reasons other than financial mismanagement. Moran said he "shares the desire to see the NSF have a bright future," but worried the amendment was "overly broad" by requiring the reinstatement of grants terminated due to research fraud, malfeasance, or lack of scientific merit.

NIH TO CAP OPEN-ACCESS FEES

The National Institutes of Health announced [aip.us17.list-manage.com] last week that it will cap the amount it pays in open-access fees for NIH-funded research, starting in fiscal year 2026. Under the agency's open access policy, [aip.us17.list-manage.com] established under the Biden administration and put into effect by the Trump administration on July 1, NIH-funded research must be made freely available immediately after publication. Some publishers have responded by charging fees to researchers for each open-access article, which the agency then covers, NIH Director Jay Bhattacharya said in an interview [aip.us17.list-manage.com] with conservative podcast host Charlie Kirk. Bhattacharya said charging for immediate open access while also collecting subscription fees from government agencies is "double-dipping."

The agency did not specify the cap amount. The Department of Health and Human Services seemed to allude to the policy in a statement to Nature [aip.us17.list-manage.com] early this month, saying, "Science journals are ripping the American people off with exorbitant access fees and extra charges to publish research openly. HHS is working to develop policies that conserve taxpayer dollars and get Americans a better deal." In the same statement, HHS retracted its earlier announcement that it would cancel its subscriptions to Springer Nature journals.

7/15/26: AAS. Subject: Policy Updates from AAS

We continue to be concerned by reports that NASA, NSF, and other science agencies are being directed to prepare to operate at the deep cut levels in the President's Budget Request for FY2026.

The past few months have been a time of rapid change in the science policy landscape. In addition to the advocacy carried out by the AAS public policy team, many AAS members are also taking initiative to address these concerns, share our science highlights and advocate. Multiple AAS members participated in an event titled "The Things We'll Never Know: A Science Fair of Canceled Grants", held in the foyer of a Congressional office building last week. Adam Riess, who gave a speech at the event, has shared his experience in a post for the AAS policy blog:

Adam Riess: My Recent Experience Advocating for Science

We are also writing to share additional information and actions you can take, based on developments since mid-last week, and upcoming events this week.

We continue to be concerned by reports that NASA, NSF, and other science agencies are being directed to prepare to operate at the deep cut levels in the President's Budget Request for FY2026. We have released a new action alert for you to easily write to and call your members of Congress regarding this issue:

Take Action Now

On Thursday, July 10, the Senate Appropriations Committee met to discuss the Commerce, Justice, and Science (CJS) Appropriations bill, which determines funding for NASA, NSF, and NIST. While the bill text has not yet been released, statements from the CJS Subcommittee members indicated that the bill kept funding relatively flat for our science agencies, with \$9 billion in funding for NSF (a \$60 million cut from Fiscal Year 2025), and \$7.3 billion for the NASA Science Mission Directorate (the same as FY2025). However, the bill has not yet been favorably reported to the full Senate, due to disagreements related to the FBI headquarters, which is also covered under the same bill.

The House has been discussing, in their respective subcommittees, the Energy and Water bill, which covers the DOE Office of Science, at 6:00 pm ET on 14 July, and their version of the CJS bill at 12:00 pm ET on 15 July. The Energy and Water draft bill provides \$8.4 billion for the DOE Office of Science, while the CJS bill provides \$7 billion for NSF, \$6 billion for the NASA Science Mission Directorate, and \$980 million for NIST. We expect details to be released in the subcommittee reports later this week.

To learn more about the latest updates from DC, and how you can make a difference, register for this webinar on Friday, 18 July at noon ET.

7/17/25: FYI. Higher Ed Groups Bring Indirect Cost Proposal to White House

The new model would rename facilities and administrative costs and change how they are calculated.

Slides from a presentation on the current reimbursement model and agency notices announcing rate caps. COGR / NIH / NSF

A group of higher education associations is pitching the White House and lawmakers on a new model for the federal government to reimburse indirect research costs. The proposal comes amid the Trump administration's push to significantly reduce the amount that the federal government spends on those costs.

Indirect costs, as the term implies, pay for expenses that support research indirectly, such as facilities and administrative costs. The new model would split indirect costs into two categories and change the way those costs are calculated. It would also enable reimbursement for compliance and grant management costs and eliminate the rate negotiation process.

Proponents of the model presented it at a webinar on Tuesday.

"The policy and the political environment have significantly shifted," said Matt Owens, president of COGR. He noted that four agencies have already moved to cap indirect cost rates at 15% this year and said policymakers of both parties and in both chambers of Congress have "expressed concerns" about indirect costs. "This is the new policy, though it's not in effect because of legal action," Owens added. "Frankly, the status quo is no longer an option."

The proposed Financial Accountability in Research (FAIR) model would split indirect costs into two categories: essential research performance support (ERPS) and general research operations (GRO). ERPS covers costs that can be calculated as part of specific projects, such as expenses related to regulatory compliance, award oversight, information services, and facilities, while GRO covers institution-wide costs such as human resources and procurement. These terms would replace "indirect costs" and "facilities and administrative costs." The proposal would also rename "direct costs" as "research performance costs." The proposed funding structure is more aligned with those of private foundations, according to an Association of American Universities FAQ on the proposal.

The FAIR model emerged from feedback on two proposals the group

presented in June, former White House Office of Science and Technology Policy Director Kelvin Droegemeier said. Droegemeier chaired the team of experts who designed the model.

Using line items to tie funding for research support activities to specific projects through ERPS ensures the accuracy of research costs, AAU's FAQ states. Droegemeier highlighted in Tuesday's webinar that the new model would enable reimbursement of compliance and grant management costs under ERPS, which he said federal agencies have not funded for more than 30 years.

The FAIR model calculates most ERPS costs in raw dollars, though facilities costs would be calculated as a percentage of the total award budget. It also includes a simpler "base" option for calculating ERPS that sets information services and facilities costs at 10% of the budget, which an executive summary of the model says "may especially be attractive to those not having the administrative resources to benefit" from calculating project-specific costs of research-supporting facilities. GRO costs would be limited to 15% of the total award for all institutions, based on the group's analysis of costs not covered by the other categories, Droegemeier said.

Under the current model, indirect cost rates are often expressed as a percentage of direct costs. For example, an indirect cost rate of 50% means that for every dollar awarded as part of a research grant for eligible direct costs, the institution would receive an additional 50 cents to cover indirect costs. This means the 50% rate would be equivalent to one-third of the total award. Toby Smith, head of government relations and public policy at AAU, said that expressing indirect rates as percentages of direct rates causes significant confusion. "One great thing about this new model: it doesn't talk about rate. It talks about the percentage of \$1 that goes towards research," Smith said. "I heard a member of Congress on one of the talk shows talking about...indirect costs...and they used that rate as the percentage of the dollar. They're totally wrong, but that's what has gotten out there," Smith added.

The new model would eliminate the rate negotiation process that allows institutions to use indirect cost rates much higher than the 15% de minimis rate. For example, Droegemeier's institution, the University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, has a rate of 58.6%. It also adds a two-year timeline for institutions to prepare for the transition from the current indirect cost model to the FAIR model.

Presenters said OMB is working to update the federal regulations that govern indirect cost reimbursement, and the group met with OMB last week to introduce the final proposal. The group has also presented the model to OSTP and members of Congress.

Owens said, depending on how OMB intends to proceed, "there is a

pathway" toward instating a 15% cap. "We are working in good faith, we believe they are working in good faith," he later added. "There are going to still be disagreements. We're hoping that our process will take us further down that road, that we can reach agreement on what we believe is the best option going forward, and knowing that there will be adjustments as we go."

So far, some lawmakers have shown support for developing a new policy and pausing the Trump administration's caps. The House Appropriations subcommittee responsible for the Department of Energy stated in its funding bill report that it "supports the Administration's efforts to increase the accountability of taxpayer resources and provide further transparency of facilities and administrative costs." However, it adds, "A blanket indirect cost rates policy, while well-intentioned, does not fully address the unique nature of the department's research and development work" and directs DOE to pause its implementation of a 15% cap while working with the research community to develop new indirect cost rate policies.

Smith said in the webinar that members of Congress who blocked a 2017 attempt to implement indirect cost caps have now told researchers to "come up, as a community, with an alternative model, or we can't defend you in Congress this time."

"If we don't have something, we have nothing to negotiate with, and you will end up with that 15% flat rate, which I don't think anybody thinks is a good idea," Smith added.

Droegemeier asked meeting attendees to give further feedback on the model and show support for it. "We as a community really need to be together on this," Droegemeier added. "And I think the thing that would cause the biggest problem would be if we start arguing among ourselves about the model, because the alternatives, as we've seen... they're not very attractive for the future of America."

7/21/25: Science. Hundreds of NASA Employees, Past and Present, Sign Letter of Formal Dissent

The signatories of the "Voyager Declaration" warned the space agency's leadership about the consequences of major budget cuts that would halt many science missions.

A public letter from NASA employees <<https://www.standupforscience.net/nasa-voyager-declaration>> on Monday urges leaders of the space agency not to carry out deep cuts sought by the Trump administration.

"We are compelled to speak up when our leadership prioritizes political momentum over human safety, scientific advancement and

efficient use of public resources," the employees wrote in the letter. It is addressed to Sean Duffy, the secretary of transportation, whom President Trump appointed this month as acting NASA administrator.

Cuts to NASA programs have been arbitrary and in defiance of priorities set by Congress, the NASA employees said. "The consequences for the agency and the country alike are dire," they wrote.

In an email statement, Bethany Stevens, the NASA press secretary, said NASA would never compromise on safety. "Any reductions -- including our current voluntary reduction -- will be designed to protect safety-critical roles," she said.

"To ensure NASA delivers for the American people, we are continually evaluating mission lifecycles, not on sustaining outdated or lower-priority missions," Ms. Stevens said.

Upheaval within NASA continued on Monday, when Makenzie Lystrup, director of NASA's Goddard Space Flight Center in Greenbelt, Md., announced she was "stepping aside" on Aug. 1. In an email sent to center employees at 12:45 p.m. and shared with The Times, she did not give a reason for her departure. Cynthia Simmons, the center's deputy director, will take over as acting director.

"I am honored to have been part of this incredible journey with you," Dr. Lystrup wrote.

The NASA letter follows similar letters of criticism by federal employees at the National Institutes of Health and the Environmental Protection Agency. Dr. Jay Bhattacharya, the N.I.H. director, said he welcomed respectful dissent, but the E.P.A. placed 144 employees who signed that agency's letter on leave.

"We're scared of retaliation," said Monica Gorman, an operations research analyst at the Goddard. She said that staff "go to the bathroom to talk to each other, and look under the stalls to make sure that no one else is there before we talk."

Ms. Gorman is one of 287 current and former NASA employees who signed the letter, although more than half did so anonymously. More than 15,000 people work at the space agency. Prominent scientists outside of NASA, including 20 Nobel Prize winners, also offered their names in support.

The N.I.H. letter inspired some people at NASA to put together a similar effort. The N.I.H. letter writers had called their dissent the "Bethesda Declaration" -- the agency is in Bethesda, Md. -- and the NASA letter writers called theirs the "Voyager Declaration," in honor of Voyager 1 and Voyager 2, the two NASA space probes launched in the

1970s that continue to function as they fly through interstellar space.

"One of the messages that NASA management has been passing down to every employee is that no one is coming to save us, including Congress," said one of the organizers of the letter, who spoke on the condition of anonymity out of fear for retaliation. "So the Voyager Declaration is one effort to raise our voices and speak out to save ourselves," the person added.

The letter is framed as a "formal dissent" an official process at NASA for registering disagreements that managers may not want to hear. It was part of changes instituted at NASA after the losses of the Columbia and Challenger space shuttles when concerns of some engineers were brushed aside.

7/21/25: CNN. In scathing letter, NASA workers rebuke "rapid and wasteful changes" at agency

By Jackie Wattles <<https://www.cnn.com/profiles/jackie-wattles>>, CNN
Updated 5:02 PM EDT, Mon July 21, 2025

A group of 287 scientists and current and former NASA employees has issued a declaration lambasting budget cuts, grant cancellations and a "culture of organizational silence" that they say could pose a risk to astronauts' safety.

The document – titled "The Voyager Declaration" and dedicated to astronauts who lost their lives in tragic spaceflight incidents of the past – is addressed to acting NASA Administrator Sean Duffy a staunch Trump loyalist who abruptly replaced Janet Petro, a longtime NASA employee, in the agency's top role on July 9. The letter has 156 anonymous signatories and 131 public signatures – including at least 55 current employees.

Hours after the letter published, Goddard Space Flight Center Director Makenzie Lystrup, who has led the NASA campus since 2023, abruptly resigned. Lystrup did not give a reason for her departure.

"Major programmatic shifts at NASA must be implemented strategically so that risks are managed carefully," states the letter to Duffy, a former member of Congress, prosecutor**and reality TV personality who also currently serves as Transportation secretary. "Instead, the last six months have seen rapid and wasteful changes which have undermined our mission and caused catastrophic impacts on NASA's workforce."

The letter raises concerns about suggested changes to NASA's Technical Authority, a system of safety checks and balances at the agency.

Established in the wake of the 2003 Columbia shuttle disaster that killed seven astronauts, the Technical Authority aims to ensure mission safety by allowing NASA employees at all levels of the agency to voice safety concerns to leaders outside their direct chain of command.

"If you have a significant disagreement with a technical decision that's being made, (the system) gives someone an alternate avenue that's not their project manager or program manager" to express that concern, a source at Goddard Space Flight Center in Greenbelt, Maryland who asked to remain anonymous for fear of retribution, told CNN.

Changes to that system "should be made only in the interests of improving safety, not in anticipation of future budget cuts," the declaration reads.

The source said that they considered looming changes "a really scary prospect, especially for my colleagues who work directly on the human spaceflight side of things."

The letter comes as the agency is grappling with the impending loss of thousands of employees and broader restructuring.

In a statement, current NASA press secretary Bethany Stevens responded to the Voyager Declaration. "NASA will never compromise on safety. Any reduction – including our current voluntary reduction – will be designed to protect safety-critical roles," she said.

"Despite the claims posted on a website that advances radical, discriminatory DEI principles, the reality is that President Trump has proposed billions of dollars for NASA science, demonstrating an ongoing commitment to communicating our scientific achievements,"**Stevens added in the statement.**"To ensure NASA delivers for the American people, we are continually evaluating mission lifecycles, not on sustaining outdated or lower-priority missions."

In her resignation email to staff, Lystrup said she was leaving her post at Goddard with confidence in Cynthia Simmons, the current deputy center director who will take over on an interim basis, and "the center leadership team, and all of you who will help shape the next chapter of this center."**Lystrup did not mention agency leadership. Her last day will be August 1.

Spokespeople at NASA headquarters and Goddard Space Flight Center did not immediately respond to a request for comment on Lystrup's resignation.

A risky resistance

The signed letter is the most recent in a string of declarations rebuking proposed cuts and changes at other federal agencies.

Some National Institutes of Health employees led the way in June, publishing a declaration opposing what they called the politicization of research.

Another letter, signed by federal workers at the Environmental Protection Agency earlier this month, resulted in about 140 people being placed on administrative leave. At least some of those workers will remain on leave until at least August 1, "pending the Agency's inquiry," according to internal email correspondence obtained by CNN.

One signatory of the NASA letter who spoke to CNN said they felt that expressing dissent against the Trump administration may pose a risk to their livelihoods, but they believed the stakes were too high to remain silent.

Ella Kaplan, a contractor employed by Global Science and Technology Inc. and the website administrator for the NASA Scientific Visualization Studio, said she decided to publicly attach her name to the Voyager Declaration because "the overall culture at NASA has very much shifted – and it feels a lot less safe for me."

"That's been felt kind of universally by most minority employees at NASA," Kaplan said.

While Kaplan said her job has not yet been directly threatened, in her view, "I'm a member of the LGBT community...and I'm probably going to be fired for this at some point, so I might as well do as much community organizing as possible before that point."

A changing culture

The letter and its signatories implore Duffy to evaluate recent policies they say "have or threaten to waste public resources, compromise human safety, weaken national security, and undermine the core NASA mission."

The declaration's criticism of changes to NASA's Technical Authority stem from statements made at an agency town hall in June. During that meeting, NASA executives said they planned to attempt to make the Technical Authority more "efficient."

"We're looking at: 'How do we do programs and projects more efficiently? And how much should we be spending on oversight?'" said Vanessa Wyche, NASA's acting associate administrator.

Garrett Reisman – a former NASA astronaut and engineer who later served as a SpaceX advisor – told CNN that he believes implementing some changes to the Technical Authority may be welcome. He noted that NASA may have become too risk averse in the wake of the Columbia tragedy, and the current structure may be hampering innovation.

But, Reisman said, any changes to the space agency's safety backstops need to be made with extreme care. And currently, he said, he does not trust that will happen.

"I have very little confidence that it will be done the right way," Reisman, who signed the declaration, said. "So far, this administration has used a very heavy hand with their attempts to remove bureaucracy – and what they've ended up doing is not making things more efficient, but just eliminating things."

Trump's anti-DEIA efforts

The signatories who spoke to CNN each expressed opposition to President Donald Trump's directives to shutter Diversity, Equity, Inclusion and Accessibility – or DEIA – initiatives.

At NASA, leadership complied with Trump's executive order by shuttering a DEIA-focused branch, scrubbing pronouns from email signatures, and removing references to a pledge made during the president's previous term to land a woman and person of color on the moon for the first time. The space agency also shuttered employee groups that lent support to minority workers.

The source who spoke with CNN anonymously said that DEIA policies not only ensure a welcoming work environment – they're also essential to practicing sound science.

"The concept of inclusivity being a pathway to better science is something that has become really entrenched in the overall academic and scientific community in the last decade or so," the source said, adding that the changes "set an immediate tone for the destruction that was going to come."

'Indiscriminate cuts'

Among the other policies that the letter decries is the Trump administration's call for NASA to shutter some projects that have Congressional backing – a move the signatories say is wasteful and "represents a permanent loss of capability to the United States both in space and on Earth."

The NASA employee told CNN that leadership has already begun shutting down some facilities that the Trump administration put on the chopping block in its budget proposal, despite the fact that Congress appears poised to continue funding some of them.

"We've also been hearing repeatedly passed down from every level of management: No one is coming to save you; Congress is not coming to save you," the source said. "But it seems like Congress is moving towards an appropriations that's going to continue to fund our projects at approximately the same level."

The source noted that they have first-hand knowledge of leadership beginning to decommission a clean room – a facility free of dust and debris where sensitive hardware and science instruments must be prepared for spaceflight – despite the fact that there are ongoing tests happening at the facility.

The Voyager Declaration also criticizes what it refers to as "indiscriminate cuts" planned for the agency.

The White House's proposal to slash NASA's science budget by as much as half has been met with widespread condemnation from stakeholders who say such cuts threaten to cripple US leadership in the field.

Recent agency communication to staff has also noted that at least 3,000 staff members are taking deferred resignation offers, according to an internal memo, the authenticity of which was confirmed to CNN by two sources who had seen the communication.

Broader workforce cuts could also be on the horizon. NASA leadership under Petro also worked on an agency restructuring plan, though the details of that initiative have not yet been made public.

Other Trump-era changes denounced in the Voyager Declaration include directives to cancel contracts and grants that affect private-sector workers across the country and plans to pull the space agency out of some projects with international partners. The White House budget proposal calls for defunding dozens of projects, including the Lunar Gateway space station that the US would have worked on with space agencies in Canada, Europe, Japan and the United Arab Emirates.

The letter and its signatories argue these policies are wasteful, squandering investments that have been years or decades in the making.

"American taxpayers have invested a lot of money in my education and training directly," the Goddard source said. "I'm in it for the public service – and I want to return that investment to them."

Comments...

I can't say I'm surprised. NASA is one of the premier scientific agency in the government and has a lot to do with measuring atmospheric conditions that prove the climate is getting hotter. Can't have that! However, it does not matter if you measure it or not, it is still happening. You will still get swept away by the next unexpected flood. It's kind of like congress repealing the law of gravity. Things will still fall at 9.8 meters per second squared, no matter what they do.

I think one day when someone makes first contact with us, we'll look back on these days as the straw that broke the camel's back on international cooperation. NASA is the one organization that is TRULY bipartisan and international. I sure hope we don't live and die to regret the cuts to NASA. Example – cooperation with the Russians on lifting astronauts to the ISS – everything is wrong with our relationship w/Russia except this.

I get what you're saying about the agency's overall mandate. But, for what it's worth, I think highly-educated scientists by nature are generally NOT going to be aligned with the conservative and religious right, while science and research overall don't tend to be a Republican focus. The friction that exists may be more fundamental than the purpose of NASA.

The current administration sees only waste when it comes to advancing research. It appears those in charge must feel we have gleaned enough knowledge and so why throw more money to the wind? Our scientists and researchers are amazing. They are the very best in the world, and we will lose them to more enlightened countries who understand the importance of moving forward.

We once had a President that chose for America to commit it's resources to go to the Moon, not because it was easy, but because it was hard. Now we have one that chooses to dissemble NASA because he needs the money to give tax relief for the wealthy.

NASA is pure magic. It has been the habitat of scientists and engineers from the world over who came together to build something beyond earthly dreams. I was privileged to work at Goddard as a contractor for 20 years. To see it fall into the hands of ignorant yahoos is unbearable. Who will in future come from far away to pour their energy and expertise into science here after seeing the fate of their colleagues?

When the Challenger and Columbia disasters happened, America learned what happens when you move fast and break things. But the DOGE muskrats weren't even alive to learn those lessons. They are the fake it until you make generation.

[Reply to complaint about bloat] If you have kidney disease you don't

remove the brain to fix it. Surgery must be done with precision and a sense of direction. I'm sure the complacent said the same thing when Hitler was coming to power – don't worry – it will run its course and we'll be back to normal.

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7/21/25: RWO signed the letter of support for the NASA employees who sent the letter to Duffy.

To my Gmail account...

[7/21/25]: Thanks for adding your name in support of the NASA heroes!
11:53 PM (8 minutes ago)

Stand Up for Science

Robert,

Thank you for adding your name in support of the NASA heroes and their public Declaration of Dissent. Read it [here](#).

Your solidarity in joining with us all in support of our colleagues at the NASA is immensely important. It creates the pressure on the Interim NASA Administrator Sean Duffy to "change course" from his policies of dismantling and his defunding of the three key levers of the NASA mission -- the science, the staff and the funding programs. It

also increases the political pressure on every member of Congress to stand up to Trump's anti-science agenda.

If you have the means, consider a gift of \$25 or more to help fuel our powerful grassroots movement now.

Thanks again for standing up for science in America!
Colette

A gift to Stand Up for Science helps us end censorship and political interference in science, secure and expand scientific funding, and defend and support programs that offer equal opportunity for ALL people to participate in science.

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7/21/25: FYI. Subject: This Week: Science budgets advancing in Congress / Top appropriators look to block indirect cost caps / NSF

board to meet

CONGRESS ADVANCING BUDGETS FOR NSF, NASA, COMMERCE

House appropriators will hold a full committee markup for their version of the Commerce-Justice-Science bill on Thursday, following Senate appropriators who approved their version of the bill last week. The Senate bill proposes the National Science Foundation receive \$9 billion, a slight cut from the \$9.06 billion budget that Congress enacted for fiscal year 2025 but a slight increase over the final budget when accounting for the \$234 million that President Donald Trump eliminated from NSF's construction budget in March. By contrast, the House bill would cut NSF's budget by about 20% while the Trump administration is seeking a more than 50% cut. Notably, the Senate bill passed through committee with bipartisan support, while Democrats are opposing the House version.

The report accompanying the Senate bill details proposed allocations and policy direction across programs at NASA, NSF, and the Commerce Department. For instance, it specifies amounts for several of NSF's STEM diversity programs, indicating lawmakers' interest in continuing them. NSF said in April that it would continue to operate broadening participation programs that make use of protected characteristics such as race and gender if they are "prioritized" in appropriations language, amid mass cuts to grants deemed related to diversity, equity, and inclusion. The report also says the committee "rejects" the administration's proposal to close one of the two existing Laser Interferometer Gravitational-Wave Observatory (LIGO) sites and directs NSF to advance both the Extremely Large Telescope projects to the final design stage, despite the administration's intent to only advance one telescope. The House CJS report will be made public sometime this week.

For NASA's Science Mission Directorate, Senate appropriators propose near-level funding, compared to an 18% cut in the House proposal and a nearly 50% cut in the president's budget request. The Senate report states that the committee rejects the president's proposed termination of 55 missions across the science directorate and NASA's STEM engagement office. The Senate bill also maintains funding for the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration's Office of Oceanic and Atmospheric Research after the president's request proposed moving a small portion of its programs to other departments and eliminating the rest.

"While the committee could be open to realigning some programs to enhance operational outcomes, the absence of detailed plans hinders informed decision-making," the report states. For details on program-level funding proposals, consult FYI's Federal Science Budget Tracker.

TOP APPROPRIATORS LOOK TO BLOCK INDIRECT COST CAPS

The top Republican and Democrat on the Senate Appropriations Committee successfully amended the Commerce-Justice-Science appropriation bill last week to continue use of the current indirect cost rates negotiated with higher education institutions rather than implementing caps, as several agencies have attempted to do this year. They also added text to the bill report that "notes the academic research community's efforts to develop a consensus proposal" on indirect costs. Similarly, the House appropriations bill report for the Department of Energy released last week directs the agency to pause the implementation of a 15% cap while it works to develop a new indirect cost policy with stakeholders. "A blanket indirect cost rates policy, while well-intentioned, does not fully address the unique nature of the department's research and development work," the report states.

NSF GOVERNING BOARD TO MEET

The National Science Board will meet on Wednesday in an open session that will feature a panel discussion on basic research with industry representatives followed by a presentation of awards for leadership in and increasing public understanding of science and technology. The board will also hear updates on the implementation of President Donald Trump's "gold standard science" executive order and on the Graduate Research Fellowship Program. The board presented an initiative to seek outside funding for the fellowship program at its last meeting. The program initially selected 1,000 recipients in April, compared to around 2,000 in previous years. The National Science Foundation has since awarded 500 more fellowships, overwhelmingly to students in computer science, physical sciences, and engineering. During a closed session on Thursday, the board will discuss NSF's staffing, the planned relocation of its headquarters, and the search for a new agency director following Sethuraman Panchanathan's resignation in April.

7/22/25: NasaWatch: NASA Chief of Staff Action Items

Keith's note: according to this Reuters article: "NASA Chief of Staff Brian Hughes speaking at the same town hall, agreed, saying it would 'probably be considered irresponsible' to wait for the congressional budget process. The letter added that Hughes recently ordered NASA science programs targeted for cancellation in Trump's budget request to stop issuing press releases celebrating new scientific results and achievements."

In addition, senior staff at recent meetings at NASA with Hughes have been told not to expect any help from Congress in pushing back against the plan embodied in the President's FY 2026 Budget Request

i.e. multiple mission cancellations and large personnel layoffs. This is in direct contrast to an offer made last week to senior NASA staff by Acting Interim Administrator Duffy to listen to -- and then consider -- pushing for budget increases (restoration) for items planned for deletion -- if a solid case can be made.

And today the "Voyager Declaration", signed by many NASA employees complaining about a variety of unpopular actions, certainly made national news. Word has it that Hughes and his staff were not at all pleased by this or the news coverage -- especially CNN's article. Meanwhile, consolidation of and deletion of various NASA social media accounts continues. Of course this has a side benefit of allowing those missions now scheduled to go away to not have any mention made of whatever scientific results they are still quite capable of providing. This of course hastens the ability for them to just fade away.

Comments...

Feels more and more like naming Duffy was just a cover to oust Petro and put Brian Hughes in charge.

7/23/25: From: American Astronomical Society <public.policy@aas.org>

Subject: We Are Having an Impact! Keep Up the Fight!

Thank you for all your hard work in support of science funding and maintaining science integrity.

[on.jsp?ca=c275c462-f4fd-4173-b04d-fa9aa53d5c3f&a=1118606474481&c=9b0fce40-5880-11e4-92db-d4ae52712b64&ch=9c303260-5880-11e4-93e0-d4ae52712b64]
[0eeddd83-7ead-41e9-bde3-40862d011d43.jpg?rdr=true] [S.gif]

Dear Colleagues,

Well, it has been a long six and a half months since the start of the year! The AAS policy team and I have been hounding you for much of this time with policy alerts and requests for action. Not only have many of you heeded the call, but we are starting to see the impact of your efforts! This week you surpassed 2,500 unique advocates, resulting in nearly 6,000 messages to members of Congress. Thank you so much for all your hard work in support of science funding and maintaining science integrity. These efforts have been recognized and we are starting to see the results of this good work.

In the Senate committee markup of the Commerce, Justice, and Science Appropriations bill for FY2026, the committee has rejected the cuts in the President's proposed budget and essentially kept funding for NASA and the National Science Foundation at FY2024 levels! In addition to

providing robust levels of funding for our science agencies, the Senate committee also stated their support for workforce development, education, and broadening participation programs in STEM. The details are outlined in this summary from the AAS policy team. We must continue to keep up the pressure as this preferred budget goes to the Senate floor for passage and the House considers its own spending bill. There is still work to do, but we are making good progress.

There are also members of the House who are pushing back against the administration's attempt to prematurely implement the cuts proposed in their budget request. These members are even reaching out to the AAS directly for support, asking us to help bring bipartisan support for action. Your efforts as AAS members helped to secure the 64 signatures of congressional members – in just one day! – on a bipartisan letter to Sean Duffy, the new acting head of NASA, requesting that he “refrain from taking actions to implement a drastic 47% cut proposed in the President's FY2026 budget request for NASA's Science Mission Directorate.”

Our efforts are making an impact! However, as the saying goes, this is a marathon and not a sprint. We need to continue to stay in the fight! Those AAS members who have not yet participated in advocacy with your congressional delegation, please call and write to let them know that science funding is an essential part of maintaining US scientific leadership, innovation, and education. Please use our Action Alert to call or send your email now! Your members of Congress will be back in their home districts for the month of August, so please consider setting up a meeting with them to share personal impact stories. Please refer to our guidelines for setting up meetings here, and feel free to email public.policy@aas.org if you need assistance.

Let's keep up the good work!

Thank you,
Dara Norman, AAS President

7/25/25: IHE. Columbia Deal a 'Threat' to Higher Ed, Experts Warn / The \$221 million settlement extends beyond tackling antisemitism. Some experts said it's an example of “coercion,” while others say Columbia had it coming.

By Jessica Blake <<https://www.insidehighered.com/author/jessica-blake>>

The Trump administration's landmark settlement with Columbia University threatens the institution's independence and academic freedom, higher education experts say. Many warn that the agreement marks a threat not only to higher education, but also to democracy at large.

The agreement, announced Wednesday comes after Columbia faced months of intense pressure from the White House to address alleged antisemitism on campus and agree to a number of demands. It's the latest example of how this administration is pushing the boundaries of its authority to secure changes that conservatives have long sought in higher ed.

In the end, Columbia agreed to comply with the government's extensive demands while forking over more than \$200 million to unlock \$400 million in federal grants.

Education Secretary Linda McMahon celebrated the long-anticipated deal as an example of "commonsense reform," saying in a statement that Americans have "watched in horror" for decades as the most esteemed campuses were occupied by "anti-western teachings and a leftist groupthink."

"Columbia's reforms are a roadmap for elite universities that wish to regain the confidence of the American public by renewing their commitment to truth-seeking, merit and civil debate," she added. "I believe they will ripple across the higher education sector and change the course of campus culture for years to come."

But some higher education faculty, legal experts and free speech advocates say the settlement is unlawful, pointing to the quick investigation, vague allegations and unprecedented way federal funds were retracted before Columbia had a chance to appeal. Some went as far as to compare the executive actions to past power grabs by authoritarian leaders in countries like Hungary, Turkey and Brazil.

The very real danger is that if elite institutions choose to submit to the authority of the Trump administration, the whole rest of the industry will follow." -- Kevin Carey, vice president of education and work at New America

Columbia's capitulation "represents the upending of a decades-long partnership between the government and higher education in which colleges and universities nevertheless retained academic freedom, institutional autonomy and shared governance," said Lynn Pasquerella, president of the American Association of Colleges and Universities. "It signals a rise in authoritarian populism in which higher education is positioned as the enemy in a fight against corrupt, inefficient and elite institutions that are out of touch with the needs of the working class."

A federal taskforce convened to combat antisemitism first presented the university with the sweeping list of demands in March. The decision was simple: comply or permanently lose the federal funds that were frozen a week prior. The Ivy League institution agreed a week

later to nearly all of the president's demands. But the funds remained frozen.

Though Columbia was on the "right track," McMahon and other task force members said the university had a long way to go. While talks with Columbia continued, the task force turned its focus to Harvard University and made similar demands. The Crimson, however, rejected the task force's mandates and sued after it froze more than \$2.7 billion in federal funds.

Many higher education leaders say that Columbia had a choice and chickened out. But regardless, they add, Trump's ultimatum amounted to extortion.

"Whether you applaud or despise the terms of the deal, the way in which the government is operating, and getting universities like Columbia to make these deals is fundamentally coercive," said David Pozen, a constitutional law professor at Columbia. "Therefore, it poses a significant threat to the future of higher education as well as the rule of law."

Pozen and others fear that this will only further embolden Trump to take similar strikes at more institutions.

"The very real danger is that if elite institutions choose to submit to the authority of the Trump administration, the whole rest of the industry will follow," said Kevin Carey, vice president of education and work at New America, a left-leaning think tank. "It will be like a stack of dominoes one falling after the other."

Chilling First Amendment Rights

The Trump administration has said the measures taken against Columbia were necessary to address antisemitism on the campus as officials accused the university of failing to protect Jewish students and later said Columbia violated federal civil rights law.

As part of the settlement, Columbia is paying \$21 million to address allegations that Jewish employees faced discrimination. The agreement also requires the university to hire a student liaison to support Jewish students.

But the settlement goes beyond antisemitism and focuses on unrelated campus policies. For example, starting in paragraph 16, the administration says that Columbia students cannot reference race in admissions essays and mandates that the university must provide annual data showing both rejected and admitted students broken down by racial demographics, grade point averages and test scores.

The settlement also requires similar data concerning the admission of international students, bans the participation of transgender women in female sports and calls for Columbia to establish a process to ensure that all students “are committed to the longstanding traditions of American universities, including civil discourse, free inquiry, open debate, and the fundamental values of equality and respect.”

In Carey’s view, by buckling to the Trump administration, Columbia surrendered its identity as a private institution—and so would any other university that follows suit.

“The essence of an independent university is deciding who is part of your academic community, and Columbia University has surrendered that,” he said, referring to the admissions provisions.

Will Creeley, legal director of the Foundation for Individual Rights and Expression, said that, in addition to admission practices, this settlement and its “blatant disregard for federal law” will upend academia’s core commitment to fostering First Amendment rights.

“The reforms themselves require Columbia students to commit to laudable values like free inquiry and open debate,” Creeley wrote in an email to /Inside Higher Ed. /“But demanding students commit to vague goals like ‘equality and respect’ leaves far too much room for abuse, just like the civility oaths, DEI statements, and other types of compelled speech FIRE has long opposed.”

Michael Thaddeus, a Columbia math professor and president of the faculty union chapter, said though administrators insist they won’t allow the government to interfere, that assurance doesn’t mean such acts won’t occur.

“Students and scholars at American universities must be free to think and speak their minds,” he wrote in a statement to /Inside Higher Ed/. “The settlement ... risks imperiling this freedom.”

Ditching Due Process

Beyond the terms of the settlement itself, education advocates are primarily concerned with the process used to reach the agreement, which they said didn’t follow procedural norms.

Pozen, the Columbia law professor, outlined in a blog post <https://balkin.blogspot.com/2025/07/regulation-by-deal-comes-to-higher-ed.html>

Wednesday night how the task force bypassed nearly all statutory requirements of such an investigation.

Past administrations, Pozen explained, have pushed the boundaries of regulation, utilizing more guidance letters and fewer formal rule-making sessions with public comment. But even those enforcement strategies consisted of policies that applied to all institutions and were based on thorough investigations, not rushed accusations, he added.

"The means being used to push through these reforms are as unprincipled as they are unprecedented," Pozen wrote. "Higher education policy in the United States is now being developed through ad hoc deals, a mode of regulation that is not only inimical to the ideal of the university as a site of critical thinking but also corrosive to the democratic order and to law itself."

Conservative higher education experts who support the administration's approach acknowledged that it lacked due process, but also argued that Columbia deserved the stipulations and financial penalty it faced.

"When campuses like Columbia and Harvard allowed antisemitism to run amok, the consequences were going to follow," said Frederick Hess, director of education policy studies at the American Enterprise Institute, a right-leaning think tank. "The chickens had come home to roost."

Hess added that the Trump administration was not the first to "short circuit" regulatory processes, citing the Biden administration's loan forgiveness campaign and Obama's use of the gender equity law, Title IX, to combat sexual assault as examples.

[Yes, regrettably, Dem administrations had also pushed the envelope...though not anywhere near as egregiously as Trump.]

"We live in a time when concern for legal requirements and norms is increasingly dismissed across the political spectrum," so to chastise one administration for skipping steps and not the other is problematic, he said. "I continue to be deeply troubled every time [the procedural statutes] are broken. But you cannot have asymmetrical expectations for the parties in these kinds of debates."

Shifting the Political Paradigm

While a few figures, including former Harvard president and treasury secretary Lawrence Summers, applauded the resolution, many faculty members and higher education leaders expressed fear that their institutions could be next.

Kirsten Weld, a history professor and president of the Harvard faculty union chapter, said she is "very concerned" and rejects any suggestion that Columbia's settlement should be a "blueprint" for her own

institution's negotiations.

"This is about deploying the coercive power of the federal government to dictate to universities, faculty, and students what they should teach, research, and learn, on ideological grounds," she wrote in an email to /Inside Higher Ed./ "It is a dangerous abuse of federal regulatory and civil rights enforcement authority to obtain ... what it would otherwise be unable to mandate through proper legislative channels."

Ted Mitchell, president of the American Council on Education, also suggested via email that "this cannot be a template for the government's approach to American higher education."

This administration "reached a conclusion before an investigation and levied a penalty without affording Columbia due process—that is chilling," he wrote. "This administration must return to following the rule of law."

But many policy experts are doubtful that will happen any time soon.

When looking beyond just Harvard and Columbia, one thing becomes clear, said Dominique Baker, an associate professor of education and public policy at the University of Delaware, the president is inciting an "outright attack" on higher education, and he has no plans of slowing down.

From the political ousting of University of Virginia president James Ryan to the legislative termination of countless academic programs in Indiana with little to no faculty input, Baker identified one defining thread: curtailing the power of democratic institutions.

"We are in a very dangerous time, both for U.S. higher education, but more importantly for our country," she explained. "These types of outright attacks on colleges and universities are typically the moves of autocrats and dictators, often seen as signs of authoritarian takeovers."

She later added, "if one wanted to overthrow our constitutional republic, these are the types of moves you would make."

[7/24/25]: WP. White House touts deal with Columbia as critics decry 'chilling' precedent / Education lawyers and advocates said Columbia's deal with the White House was a potentially dangerous government intrusion into higher education.

...Under the terms of the deal, announced late Wednesday, Columbia WILL PAY MORE THAN \$200 MILLION TO SETTLE CLAIMS over antisemitism and discriminatory hiring. In return, the government will unfreeze more

than \$1 billion in federal grants and funding to the university.

...In agreeing to the deal, the elite Ivy League institution in New York City is entering uncharted territory: It is making an enormous payment to the federal government despite not admitting any wrongdoing while relinquishing a certain measure of oversight to an independent monitor.

Columbia's deal follows one between the University of Pennsylvania and the Trump administration this month. The administration had announced this spring that it was freezing \$175 million to Penn over its policies on transgender athletes – which were in alignment with the NCAA's rules at the time. Penn agreed to no longer allow transgender women to compete on its female teams and said it would send apology letters to swimmers who were affected by its policy.

The Columbia agreement, months in the making, came as the school had grown increasingly concerned about its ability to maintain some of its research operations in the face of the funding freezes. It stipulates that the government will not have authority to dictate Columbia's admissions decisions, hiring or the content of academic speech – a key provision for the school, which had sought to retain academic freedom amid intense federal pressure.

...“Columbia was put in an untenable position by the outrageous actions of the executive branch of the government,” said Ted Mitchell, president of the American Council on Education. The Trump administration, he added, “reached a conclusion before an investigation and levied a penalty without affording Columbia due process.”

...Among the institutions negotiating with the Trump administration are the University of Michigan and Duke, Northwestern, Cornell and Brown universities. Those schools are in talks with the White House about its concerns and at least some are in “early mutual agreement to find middle ground,” said one person familiar with the negotiations, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe sensitive matters.

...“What we're witnessing here is the emergence of a new model for regulating universities by the government,” said David Pozen, a professor at Columbia Law School. It's “regulation by deal,” Pozen said, in which the Trump administration attempts to set higher education policy through one-off, bilateral agreements with universities that it specifically targets. He called it “an extraordinarily coercive and arbitrary way to set policy. ... Everyone in higher education should be worried about the manner in which this deal was constructed.”

...The agreement goes far beyond the administration's original focus on alleged discrimination against Jewish students and faculty, Hartley

said, setting a potential precedent on issues such as international student enrollment, requirements for single-sex housing and women's sports participation.

...The largest chunk of the settlement money – \$200 million – will go directly to the U.S. Treasury, senior administration officials told reporters Thursday, speaking on the condition of anonymity in accordance with the ground rules for the call. Columbia WILL PAY A FURTHER \$21 MILLION to Jewish faculty and staff members to settle investigations brought by the U.S. Equal Employment Opportunity Commission. Administration officials called it the largest such settlement ever for victims of antisemitism, and the largest in almost 20 years for any form of discrimination or harassment. Those funds will be distributed to Jewish professors and other staff, administration officials said, including janitors who were trapped in a university building when it was taken over by pro-Palestinian protesters in the spring of 2024.

In addition to the financial settlement, the 22-page agreement requires Columbia to ensure that its programs “do not promote unlawful DEI goals.” The university must provide data on admitted and rejected students broken down by race, grade-point average and standardized test scores.

The agreement also requires Columbia to review its international-student admissions policy and directs the school to reduce its “financial dependence” on such enrollment. Columbia has more foreign students than nearly any other university in the country, with more than 20,000 enrolled in the 2023–2024 school year, according to the Institute of International Education.

While many observers were shocked by the large financial hit, some experts said that Columbia had walked away with a good agreement, given the extraordinarily difficult circumstances.

...Pozen, the law professor, said it's difficult to evaluate an agreement that was the product of a corrupt process. “If someone mugs you on the street and takes some of your cash but not all of it, did you get a good deal?” he said.

But Adam Lehman, president and CEO of Hillel International, a network of campus Jewish groups, was pleased that the agreement recognized “egregious violations” of civil rights of Jewish students at Columbia and Barnard College, its sister school, as well as steps Columbia has taken to address them.

...Under the terms of the agreement, a mutually agreed-to outside monitor will have authority to oversee the university's compliance and have access to extensive data about university admissions and hiring to assure that racial preferences are not being used.

Comments...

This is nothing more than a shakedown by Trump's criminal regime.

Only a totally blind reader of the WP could claim that enforcing the 1964 Civil Rights Act is a shakedown. Got it?

So true. Everyone knows the GOP loves the spirit and intent of the Civil Rights Act and it's so wonderful to see this administration on its righteous crusade for freedom and justice for all. I heard everyone in ICE detention is getting dessert with their dinner tonight.

Can we stop with the lies that this has ANYTHING to do with "cracking down on anti-Jewish bias"?!

Damage is done. Columbia's reputation as a leading research university is finished. The best and the brightest will go elsewhere, like outside the USA.

Hurling slogans like "From the river to the sea Palestine will be free" in the face of Jewish students, faculty or alumni makes everybody know that the speaker is calling for the destruction of the state of Israel. Anti-Zionism in this form is antisemitism, as stated on the site of the American Jewish Community, which hosts an interesting analysis of the concept of "anti-Zionism" as another form of antisemitism

There goes democracy! They folded like a cheap suitcase. Extortion, indeed! And now it will never stop.

7/25/25: NYT, Columbia Walked a Tightrope on Its Way to a \$200 Million Settlement With Trump / Talks in Washington. An expert on negotiation. A balancing act. The university chose cooperation over litigation, a strategy both pilloried and praised.

Just after Memorial Day, Claire Shipman, the acting president of Columbia University, went to see Linda E. McMahon, President Trump's education secretary... It was a tough meeting, but there were some surprisingly collaborative moments. Ms. McMahon said she wasn't interested in destroying the university. She empathized with how hard it was to run a large organization. She wanted to talk about issues beyond antisemitism, like the need to tolerate a spectrum of voices on campuses. Rather than dismiss those concerns out of hand, Ms. Shipman, a former journalist who was co-chair of Columbia's board of trustees before stepping in as acting president, listened. It was a telling moment that helped produce the seismic events of Wednesday.

... According to a recent survey commissioned by Columbia, 62 percent of Jewish students last year said that they did not feel accepted for their religious identity at the university. There was also a broader problem of intolerance, some felt, with too many people choosing to shut out, rather than engage with, other points of view.

...The very tactic of withholding scientific research money to pressure Columbia over campus unrest was probably illegal, a Massachusetts judge had already found. But some on campus, particularly those concerned about the fate of scientific research, welcomed the deal, which they hoped would let Columbia regain its footing.

...[In March] Columbia's 21-member board of trustees, in consultation with the school's lawyers, decided to negotiate. Lawyers advised the board that suing would probably bring short-term wins, but that the government could still remove Columbia from consideration for future grants. That would be an extremely unstable situation, risking billions of dollars of important research funding. Under Katrina Armstrong, then the new interim president, the board landed on a compromise that it felt it could live with. The university modified each demand in a way that it believed would not compromise core values or academic independence.

Instead of a total mask ban, for example, masked demonstrators would be required to show identification when asked. Instead of putting a Middle Eastern Studies department under receivership, a step that would remove its independence, a new vice provost would review the department's work, along with that of other departments.

...It also became obvious internally at Columbia that the blow to its science enterprise was much bigger than the original \$400 million. Columbia now says that most of its \$1.3 billion in annual federal grant funding had been frozen or stopped. The university was also barred from competing for new grants. In May, about 180 people were laid off. Every day, scientists were getting other offers and were uncertain if Columbia was going to be a home for major research anymore.

...In the eyes of Columbia's negotiators, much of what they agreed to – pledges to follow civil rights laws and to not engage in illegal diversity practices – would have been necessary anyway under a Trump administration. Most of the internal reforms, such as centralizing control over student discipline and appointing at least 36 security officers with arrest powers, are changes they had already committed to.

Comments...

As a Columbia alumni I am appalled and ashamed that they capitulated

to this morally bankrupt extortioner.

That Columbia had or has an antisemitism problem is absurd. 20% of Columbia's students are Jewish, while the population of Jewish people in the United States is a mere 2.4%. Jewish Americans are over represented nearly 10 fold, while African Americans are under represented by half.

Columbia caved. The principles of free speech should be respected, it's a right of all of us. The decision to put research funding ahead of freedom of speech demonstrates that this is more important to the university than a constitutional right. Certain groups of students will be silenced. There will be government monitoring. Now, more than ever, constitutional rights must be prioritized. Science can wait. If I had a child at university here, they would not be continuing to attend.

It's terrible to watch people, most of whom would be considered elite, or at least privileged, collapse when challenged by a government that is acting illegally and irresponsibly.

This 'arrangement' would seem to have less to do with anti-Semitism than this administration's continuing assault on academic values and freedoms. Columbia has kissed the ring, showing that intimidation and blackmail will be rewarded. Science, knowledge and thought are the short and medium term casualties. In the long run the demise of the US as an intellectual leader and exemplar seems inevitable. But who needs intelligence, when you're holding the gun and you've corrupted and intimidated the congress and the courts?

Hi, I work at a 'New Ivy' institution in the Boston area. We have received signals from our senior leadership that we intend to keep our heads down but when the WH comes knocking, we will stand up for ourselves and fight. Not everyone will be Columbia, who we're so disappointed with. We've heard from neighboring colleges that they will also stand and fight, which gives us confidence that there will be strength in numbers. We'll be here long after this dark period ends, and to capitulate is to, as far as I'm concerned, condone what's happening. Shame on Columbia!

I try to imagine myself as an 18 yo freshman walking on campus past completely masked, shouting, taunting, drum banging men and women twice the size of me with menacing and threatening signs and later witnessing violent acts of breaking glass and doors, where half the protestors are not even students and many of my mid-east studies and "humanities" professors are shouting and waving fists. Welcome to college and free speech and "peaceful demonstration."

I laugh to think how Columbia will soon be sanctimoniously be asking 18 year olds to submit essays explaining their values, when they've

just shown the world they stand on none. This school is tarnished.

Harvard alum here who would rather see his Alma Mater resist death on its feet rather than die on its knees.

Already, the WSJ is reporting that Trump is seeking similar deals with a bunch of other universities – including a ruinous payoff (I refuse to call these “settlements”) from Harvard. This is extortion, pure and simple.

I do find it remarkable that the core of the agreement is Columbia conceded to ‘follow existing civil rights law and to not allow illegal diversity measures’. Columbia strayed from this and thankfully will revert to what they should have done all along.

I'm sure among the thousands of students there are some antisemitic people. But the university as a whole? Antisemitic? Puleeze.

It was activist hostility (and administrative indifference or even support for it) that got us here in the first place. I don't think the average American is siding with Columbia or pro-Palestinian activists. Would love it if the left took the lesson from this fiasco that immersing your politics with hate speech is an ineffective social movement tactic that they should abandon permanently. The American public is not with them.

Well, let's put it this way. Should we sympathize with people who assist a crime organization to commit crimes because they think they'll be treated better?

7/25/25: Van Scoyoc Associates
Subject: Washington Week in Science – July 25, 2025

NIH to limit AI use, cap P.I. grant applications at 6 per year

The National Institutes of Health is telling researchers to limit the number of applications they submit and restrict how much they use artificial intelligence in writing their proposals. The agency announced last week that it will accept no more than six “new, renewal, resubmission or revision applications” per principal investigator per calendar year. Read more: Inside Higher Ed

Trump administration asks the Supreme Court to let it move forward with NIH grant cuts The Trump administration asked the Supreme Court on Thursday to give it the green light to cancel hundreds of grants awarded by the National Institutes of Health because they were tied to issues like gender identity and diversity, equity and inclusion. Solicitor General D. John Sauer asked the high court to

halt a lower court decision that ordered the NIH to reinstate the grants and required the Trump administration to continue paying out roughly \$783 million in awards. Read more: CBS News

US fertility rate reached a new low in 2024, CDC data shows

The fertility rate in the U.S. dropped to an all-time low in 2024 with less than 1.6 kids per woman, new federal data released Thursday shows. The U.S. was once among only a few developed countries with a rate that ensured each generation had enough children to replace itself – about 2.1 kids per woman. But it has been sliding in America for close to two decades as more women are waiting longer to have children or never taking that step at all. Read more: ABC News

Microsoft stops relying on Chinese engineers for Pentagon cloud support

Microsoft on Friday revised its practices to ensure that engineers in China no longer provide technical support to U.S. defense clients using the company's cloud services. The company implemented the changes in an effort to reduce national security and cybersecurity risks stemming from its cloud work with a major customer. The announcement came days after ProPublica published an extensive report describing the Defense Department's dependence on Microsoft software engineers in China. Read more: CNBC

Senate appropriators fund dozens of threatened NASA science missions

A Senate spending bill would restore funding for dozens of NASA science missions threatened with cancellation in the administration's 2026 budget request, but is silent on one flagship program. The Senate Appropriations Committee released July 18 the report accompanying its commerce, justice and science (CJS) spending bill for fiscal year 2026 that the committee approved on a 19-10 vote a day earlier. That bill includes \$24.9 billion for NASA, slightly more than the \$24.838 billion that the agency received in 2025 and far more than the \$18.8 billion proposed by the White House in May. The bill includes \$7.3 billion for NASA science programs, approximately the same that the agency received in 2025. The White House proposal, by contrast, requested just \$3.9 billion for science programs. "The Committee rejects the mission terminations proposed in the fiscal year 2026 budget request for Earth Science, Planetary Science, Astrophysics, and Heliophysics," the report stated. "The Committee is concerned by the plan to end 55 missions across Science, which was driven by budget pressure rather than scientific value." Read more: Space News

[The missing "flagship" is apparently the Mars Sample Return

Mission, according to spacepolicyonline.com]

In scathing letter, NASA workers rebuke 'rapid and wasteful changes' at agency

A group of 287 scientists and current and former NASA employees has issued a declaration lambasting budget cuts, grant cancellations and a "culture of organizational silence" that they say could pose a risk to astronauts' safety. The document – titled "The Voyager Declaration" and dedicated to astronauts who lost their lives in tragic spaceflight incidents of the past – is addressed to acting NASA Administrator Sean Duffy, a staunch Trump loyalist who abruptly replaced Janet Petro, a longtime NASA employee, in the agency's top role on July 9. The letter has 156 anonymous signatories and 131 public signatures – including at least 55 current employees. Read more: CNN

NASA loses another senior official as tension about the agency's future grows

The director of NASA's Goddard Space Flight Center announced her resignation Monday, marking yet another high-profile departure as questions loom about the agency's budget and future. Makenzie Lystrup, who has served as director of the center in Maryland since April 2023, will leave the agency on Aug. 1, according to a NASA statement. Read more: NBC News

Senate approps bill would fully fund NSF, rejecting Trump's cuts

The Senate Appropriations Committee advanced legislation that would dodge the sharp cuts to the National Science Foundation that President Donald Trump suggested, and the House softened. The Senate's bill would provide the National Science Foundation with \$9 billion in "support for key research in quantum information science and artificial intelligence," among other areas. That's effectively on par with current agency funding levels. The House proposed the NSF get \$7 billion, while the administration had recommended \$3.9 billion for the NSF. Republicans on a party-line vote rejected an amendment by Sen. Tammy Baldwin (D-Wis.) to restore more than 1,500 NSF grants canceled by the Trump administration "except in cases of financial mismanagement, research fraud or malfeasance." Read more: Politico Pro

Congressional committees push back on Trump administration's proposed NOAA budget cuts

Lawmakers from both parties have so far rejected steep cuts to the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) proposed by the Trump administration and reiterated their support for a fully

staffed National Weather Service (NWS) during recent committee meetings, which included key appropriations markup sessions. For fiscal year 2026, the Trump administration proposed cutting NOAA's budget by roughly 25%, including the elimination of its research division, the Office of Oceanic and Atmospheric Research (OAR), and making major reductions to other key offices such as the National Centers for Environmental Information (NCEI), the world's largest provider of weather and climate data.

The House Appropriations Subcommittee on Commerce, Justice, Science and Related Agencies advanced a spending bill with bipartisan support last week that would fund NOAA at levels mostly in line with budgets of previous years. The fiscal year 2026 Commerce, Justice, Science appropriations bill provides roughly \$5.8 billion to NOAA in 2026, a 6% decrease from the previous year. However, it restores a majority of funding for NOAA's Operations, Research and Facilities (ORF) account, which includes OAR. The Senate's version of the bill allocates approximately \$6.14 billion to NOAA for fiscal year 2026, just below the \$6.18 billion approved for 2025. While this represents a modest overall decrease, the Senate Committee on Appropriations voted to boost spending for the agency's Operations, Research and Facilities (ORF) account, adding \$68.7 million. Read more: ABC News

7/28/25: NYT. The Bull Market for Economists Is Over. It's an Ominous Sign for the Economy. / Earning a Ph.D. in economics has long been a reliable path to affluence and prestige. Not anymore.

...For decades, earning a Ph.D. in economics has been a nearly foolproof path to a lucrative career. Even as bearers of advanced degrees in history, English or anthropology struggled to find gainful employment, the popularity of economics as an undergraduate major created plenty of tenure-track teaching positions, while government agencies snatched up Ph.D. economists in bulk. Those looking for even larger paychecks could turn to tech companies, Wall Street and consulting firms, which bid up the price of economists as if they were a bespoke cryptocurrency.

Last year, the average base salary for newly hired economics professors at major research universities was more than \$150,000, according to the American Economic Association, and their compensation swelled to about \$200,000 once bonuses and summer teaching were included. As recently as the 2023-24 academic year, the employment rate for Ph.D. economists within a few months of graduation was 100 percent... Job satisfaction topped 85 percent.

Those glory days seem to be ending. Universities and nonprofits have scaled back hiring amid declining state budgets and federal funding

cuts. At the same time, the Trump administration has laid off government economists and frozen hiring for new ones.

Tech companies also have grown stingier, and their need for high-level economists – once seemingly insatiable – has waned. Other firms have slowed hiring in response to the economic uncertainty introduced by President Trump's tariffs and the possibility that artificial intelligence will replace their workers, even if those workers have a doctoral degree.

"The advent of A.I. is also impacting the market for high-skilled labor," said Betsey Stevenson, a labor economist at the University of Michigan, in an email. "So the whole thing is kind of a mess."

Of course, if it were only some egghead economists scrambling to find work, that might be not be terribly consequential. But the same forces bedeviling economists are crimping employment for other highly trained scientists and social scientists, as well as for many recent college graduates, whose jobless rate has been unusually high for an otherwise strong economy.

The drop in government payrolls and federal funding for universities and nonprofits alone is a major problem, since they support two to three times as many jobs for college graduates as for those without degrees. In some cases, workers with Ph.D.s are displacing others with master's or bachelor's degrees.

Then there is the potential impact on the country's future. Marcia McNutt, a geophysicist who is president of the National Academy of Sciences, said a sharp drop in the number of research jobs in the hard sciences and social sciences would send Ph.D.s abroad. Their flight will deprive the government of the brainpower it needs to perform basic functions and leave U.S. firms less innovative and competitive.

"U.S. industry is incredibly dependent on the training that is done in colleges and universities," Dr. McNutt said. "When the top people go elsewhere, we'll be left with the B team in America."

...The University of California, Santa Barbara, typically produces 10 to 15 Ph.D. economists a year, and about one-third to half of them secure tenure-track academic jobs right away, said Daniel Martin, an economics professor and the graduate program's job placement officer. A few more typically land jobs at federal or international agencies...Just before the pandemic, essentially "all of those who wanted academic jobs would have gotten them," Dr. Katz said.

...Then in January, Mr. Trump took office and put the kibosh on federal hiring. Hundreds of prospective jobs vaporized overnight, including more than a dozen that Dr. Fullagar had applied for at agencies like the Treasury Department and the Census Bureau. "That

was a brutal moment," said Dr. Martin, the placement officer at Santa Barbara. "I contacted our department and said, 'Listen, I need to prepare you for the possibility that we may be graduating people without jobs" – something that hadn't happened in recent memory.

...[He said] he was still optimistic about the future of the economics profession, partly because the job recession was only a slowdown relative to the highly auspicious employment climate that reigned for decades. "Who has that?" he said. "Not even computer science has been able to place people just at will."

Comments...

Here we are in the midst of a real competition with China in math, science, engineering, and technology and Trump hobbles the United States STEM force with big funding cuts. If you wanted to allow China to take the lead, it would be hard to find a better way. Trump wants to have the US ahead of China in AI. How does that square with cutting off funding for the talent pipeline? Let's face it. It's not about making America great again. But it is all about giving more money to the very top earners (and himself). Someone after him will have to clean up the mess that the US will become,

One bright spot would be to replace congress with AI. It could not possibly do any worse.

"In some cases, the tenured ranks have become clogged by baby boomers putting off retirement." This is not unique to economics. They simply will not leave. There are plenty of faculty on my campus who are well into their 70s and a few in their 80s. They are showing no signs of leaving anytime soon.

Trump is bad for the economy
Trump is bad for middle and working class Americans
Trump is only good for Trump

Virtually all economists are wedded to the idea of exponential, unlimited growth. In a world of 8 billion souls and mass extinctions, we don't need more of these economists, we need economists who embrace a de-growth economy where housing is available and affordable and wages provide a decent standard of living. It is time we got rid of all of Wall Street's apologists.

Unfortunately, with the end of the defined benefit pension, many people, not just in universities, can't risk retiring because they depend on the whims of the market for their survival.

It's especially true in academia (a close friend is 84 and has no plans to retire) but it is true in lots of sectors. It is an especially bitter pill for Gen X.

America is already at B level by the damage done to its finest universities and DOGE slashes and destruction...The ongoing "brain drain" will be America's greatest loss , and other nations greatest gain in the decades to come.

Are you kidding? Try to get a tenure track job at a major university with a PhD in any field right now. Universities are terrified and NOT HIRING. The common wisdom is that STEM is the holy grail, but young STEM PhDs are being eaten alive by no jobs available. These young people have worked and studied for years and their careers are being ruined. Not everyone is sauntering over to Europe to be offered a big job. A generation of scientists is being destroyed.

As a lab tech at a university, I work with lots of doctoral students. In this most recent graduating class, most of them had to pivot at whiplash speed away from tenure track and civil service positions. A few have pursued post-docs. The rest are looking for positions outside of the USA. The tide which went a long way to sustaining American greatness has turned, and the brains that fueled our research and development gains are now washing into other nations. I asked what advice they would give incoming graduate students. Invariable, the answer was to become fluent in a second language.

[To an anti-liberal critic] Interesting that you point to health care as an area supposedly being dragged down by immigrants. In reality, our healthcare system would collapse without the thousands of immigrants working as nurses's aids and other support staff. Immigrants skew younger, and therefore have fewer needs for healthcare. And, many pay into Medicare without being eligible for the benefits.

On the other hand, there are and will be plenty more jobs as farm laborers.

If you want to know what the U.S. will look like in a generation just look closely at the Trump administration's hires for all the top positions. With very few exceptions not only are they not the A Team but most of them aren't even qualified to make the B Team.

[The "Duh" team]

A physicist, a chemist, and an economist are stranded on an island with nothing to eat. A can of soup washes ashore. The physicist says, "Let's smash the can open with a rock." The chemist says, "Let's build a fire and heat the can." The economist says, "Let's assume that we have a can opener."

The hard truth: If you are getting a PhD in Economics, make sure it is

from Chicago, Princeton, Stanford or MIT. Otherwise, be prepared to do gigs for Uber.

This is concerning and I have seen this across many fields. Many that once were set on getting their PhD are changing paths, I hear people say given it's such a difficult process to go through and question if it's worth it in this environment. I've seen it in online forums as well, from PhD's to MD's, and definitely in mstp (MD/PhD) programs. Many say why bother with research with the uncertainty of grant status and the job market... I don't think many people understand the long term implications, the readers here likely do but the average person has no clue how this can impact the US in the future. It will not be 'great' when we fall behind in every area of research.

Ignorance is bliss. The current government is collectively missing a highly functioning brain; and hence, cannot know what is being lost. There is ample research and anecdotal evidence that traces the American economic growth and technological prowess to the promotion of basic research and applied sciences since the Second World War, primarily supported by the federal government. It is the American ingenuity and entrepreneurship that took these seed corn of science and grew into the great harvest of commercial value and GDP growth. It is futile to argue with the current Luddites and high priests molded in the Taliban mindset regarding value of education, let alone research. If the world power is what the current government is after, it must know that missiles, rockets, deep penetrating bombs, lasers, satellites, modern digital communications do not grow on trees. Many basic and applied research from hard sciences and social sciences make them happen. By cutting off supply of scientific seed corn, the US is brainlessly and with spite and malice turning off the spigot to US prosperity.

Anyone who thinks you can hang on as a Professor at the University of California does not know what they are talking about. I sit on a committee that reviews the work of every faculty member every two to five years. You must be satisfactory in teaching/mentoring, in research, and service (either administratively to the school or externally to the scientific community). A deficiency in any of the three, and you will be given an unsatisfactory rating. At that point, you are given a remediation plan. If that fails, you are out, even if you have tenure. I am familiar with the dossier of practically every senior full Professor at my campus, and only four of them in the last year were unsatisfactory. Indeed, most of the 70 and 80-year-olds were doing a fantastic job. We are so lucky to have them. Note that most faculty retire in their late 60s, so the older ones are a special elite group. I should also note that most retirement benefits max out after 20 years of service, so staying longer does not increase those any further.

7/29/25:

From: Astronomy Department Chairs <Astro-Chairs@virginia.edu>
To: Faculty Department <astro-faculty@virginia.edu>
Subject: [astro-faculty] State of the Astronomy Workforce

Hello –

Chairs are being asked to report some information to the AAS about the effects of policy changes since January 2025 on astronomy departments. Information will be anonymized and aggregated.

To that end, could you please report to me (if you desire – this is voluntary):

1. Whether you have had any of your federally funded grants reduced or terminated since January 2025?
2. Whether you have expectations of federally funded grants being reduced or terminated in the next 6 months?
3. Do you have comments on any research or funding disruptions because of federal policy changes?
4. Did you curtail any student summer research programs due to funding or policy changes instituted at the federal level since January 2025?
5. Were you or any students unable to travel to a professional conference because of unexpected cuts to funding or policy changes instituted at the federal level since January 2025?
6. Did you have any trouble publishing an accepted paper due to a lack of funding or policy changes since January 2025?

Unfortunately, this request came with an “ASAP” request attached...so quick, short replies are better than essays that will take you a while to get back to me. So let’s just say that I would appreciate responses by midnight Wednesday night, July 30.

Thanks,
Steve

7/29/25: FYI. Hundreds of Science Agency Employees Criticize Changes Under Trump

Current and former employees at NSF, NASA, NIH, and the EPA have signed onto letters enumerating their concerns.

Hundreds of employees at the National Science Foundation and NASA signed onto letters issued last week that protest policy changes since the start of the Trump administration, including workforce reductions and grant terminations. The letters reveal major shifts inside the agencies, only some of which have previously been reported.

"As civil servants, NSF employees are bound by their oath to uphold the Constitution," the NSF letter reads. "That oath now compels us to call attention to actions that jeopardize NSF's mission, its independence, and the foundational laws that protect the federal workforce from politicization and abuse." NASA's letter similarly states that "we are compelled to speak up when our leadership prioritizes political momentum over human safety, scientific advancement, and efficient use of public resources."

The NSF letter says fear of retaliation, lack of job stability, and abrupt return-to-office orders pushed hundreds to retire early or resign. The letter also highlights the administration's plans to fire staff in the Division of Equity for Excellence in STEM through reductions in force. NSF has lost one-third of its staff since the start of the Trump administration, said Jesus Soriano, a program officer at NSF and president of the union that represents the agency, at a press conference with the top Democrat on the House Science Committee. The agency had around 1,700 employees in January.

The NASA letter states that thousands of the agency's civil servants have resigned, retired early, or been terminated, "taking with them highly specialized, irreplaceable knowledge." The agency said Saturday that nearly 4,000 employees, about 20% of NASA's workforce, are retiring early or resigning – fewer than 1,000 took the deferred resignation offer in the first round that ended in February, while 3,000 accepted the offer in the second round that ended last week.

Both letters accuse the administration of interfering with congressionally appropriated funding. The NSF letter states that the White House is withholding \$2.2 billion of the agency's funds for fiscal year 2025, while the NASA letter states that the agency is closing out missions even though they are funded in FY25, representing "a permanent loss in capability."

The NSF letter criticizes Trump's budget request for the coming fiscal year, saying it would "cripple American science." The request proposes a 56% cut to NSF's total budget and more than 70% cuts to biological sciences, engineering, and STEM education. If enacted, these cuts would eliminate funding for over 250,000 researchers and students, the letter adds.

The NSF letter also highlights the administration's "eviction" of the agency from its current headquarters "without any transparent

planning, cost-benefit justification, or identified destination," the extension of probationary periods from one year to two, and a secondary review process of NSF programs and proposals by "unqualified political appointees," which Soriano said is performed at high levels of NSF with input from the Trump administration.

The NASA letter further criticizes cuts to diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility programs and the proposed elimination of the Office of STEM Engagement. It accuses the administration of "abandoning" allies by canceling NASA participation in international missions, and protests changes to NASA's system of safety checks and balances.

The NSF signers include 149 current agency employees, some of whom chose to sign anonymously and others whose names were redacted in the public version of the document. The NASA signers include 363 current and former NASA employees from every NASA center and mission directorate, some named and some anonymous. The NSF letter asks the House Science Committee to "defend" NSF's civil service protections and mission, while the NASA dissent letter, like those signed by employees of the National Institutes of Health and the Environmental Protection Agency in the last two months, addresses concerns to the agency head. NIH employees were the first to issue their dissent letter, also known as the Bethesda Declaration, on June 9, and signers met with agency Director Jay Bhattacharya last week.

NSF employees sent the letter as an official whistleblower complaint to protect the signers from retaliation, according to a Democratic press release, after the publication of the EPA letter resulted in over 100 signers being placed on administrative leave.

The NASA letter references an agency policy directive on respecting "diverse views... with no suppression or retribution." The letter says it constitutes a formal dissent that "warrants a timely review and decision by higher-level management."

AUGUST

8/5/25: FYI

EPA, DOE QUESTION CLIMATE RISKS IN GHG REG ROLLBACK

The Environmental Protection Agency released a proposal [aip.us17.list-manage.com] last week to rescind its 2009 endangerment finding, which underpins the agency's authority to regulate greenhouse gas emissions. As part of the justification for the move, the Department of Energy released a report [aip.us17.list-manage.com] on the climate impacts of greenhouse gas emissions that concludes the

warming induced by carbon dioxide “appears to be less damaging economically than commonly believed, and that aggressive mitigation strategies may be misdirected.” DOE Secretary Chris Wright tapped five scientists known to be skeptical of climate change impact assessments to produce the report, which criticizes aspects of global climate models and notes some positive effects of elevated carbon dioxide concentrations.

The EPA will hold a virtual public hearing [aip.us17.list-manage.com] Aug. 19 and 20 to receive comment on the proposal, while DOE issued a request for comment [aip.us17.list-manage.com] on the report that closes Sept. 2. “Speaking from the perspective of individuals who have commented on the IPCC and NCA reports only to see our comments ignored, we plan to take a different approach,” wrote Judith Curry, one of the DOE report authors, in a blog post. [aip.us17.list-manage.com] “Rather than primarily seeking to defend our report, we regard the open comments as an opportunity for dialogue, learning, and clarification of areas of disagreement,” she added. Curry wrote that she hopes for the “redirection of climate science... away from alarmism and advocacy and towards better understanding of the fundamentals of climate dynamics.”

Various scientists whose work is cited in the report have said it uses their research in a misleading way. [aip.us17.list-manage.com] One such scientist, Zeke Hausfather, wrote [aip.us17.list-manage.com] that the report “cherry-picks figures and parts of studies to support a preconceived narrative that minimizes the risk of climate change.” Mainstream climate scientists are now mulling ways to offer a coordinated rebuttal [aip.us17.list-manage.com] to the report.

TURMOIL CONTINUES OVER UNIVERSITY GRANT CANCELLATIONS

The University of California, Los Angeles was cut off from funding from the National Science Foundation and the National Institutes of Health last week after the Justice Department concluded [aip.us17.list-manage.com] that the university had violated civil rights law in its “deliberately indifferent” response to students’ claims of antisemitism. UCLA Chancellor Julio Frenk protested the decision, stating [aip.us17.list-manage.com] the university has taken various actions against antisemitism and that “this far-reaching penalty of defunding life-saving research does nothing to address any alleged discrimination.”

Other universities hit with similar cuts have begun to strike deals with the White House to have research funding restored: Columbia University agreed [aip.us17.list-manage.com] to pay a \$200 million fine to the federal government over three years while Brown University agreed [aip.us17.list-manage.com] to pay \$50 million over ten years to workforce development organizations in Rhode Island. Both agreements

also include restrictions on diversity and inclusion initiatives, among other provisions. Meanwhile, other universities such as Harvard [aip.us17.list-manage.com] and Northwestern [aip.us17.list-manage.com] have announced layoffs that are related to the funding cuts and other financial pressures, and the Massachusetts governor is proposing [aip.us17.list-manage.com] to allocate \$400 million to offset cuts at universities in the state and at Boston hospitals.

The outlook for grant funding remains uncertain even for NIH grants that have already been judicially ordered to be restored. Some scientists whose grants were included on the list for reinstatements said [aip.us17.list-manage.com] they have not received the funding as of July. Meanwhile, five higher education associations asked [aip.us17.list-manage.com] NIH Director Jay Bhattacharya last week to restore not just the approximately 900 grants subject to the court rulings but all grants “terminated pursuant to the same directives, using the same process, and according to the same termination rationale,” which total more than 2,000.

8/7/25: FYI

For new faculty and others ordering big-ticket items, the import taxes can be a gut punch.

Since the start of the second Trump administration, the US science community has been confronted with the axing of jobs, the slashing of federal funding, attacks on diversity, and increased visa restrictions. Tariffs are an added twist. On 2 April—which Trump referred to as Liberation Day—new tariffs on many countries went into effect. A roller coaster followed, as rates were raised, lowered, and paused. The threats and negotiations have sowed uncertainty in the science community and beyond about the cost of goods.

Tenure-track experimentalists who are establishing their labs are in a particular bind.

New faculty members receive startup funds, uniquely flexible money that they use for equipment, students and postdocs, conferences, and their own summer salaries. Startup funds in the more expensive areas—notably atomic, molecular, and optical physics, condensed-matter physics, and biophysics—can be as high as \$5 million, although around \$1.5 million is typical.

Tariffs were not yet a concern for tenure-track faculty who negotiated their job terms in the past few years. But today, as they attempt to establish themselves in their new positions, ponying up tens of thousands of dollars more for big-ticket items can be a hardship—or a dealbreaker.

In early 2024, a tenure-track physicist at a midsize public university on the West Coast ordered laser equipment from China. It didn't arrive in the US until April 2025, at a time when the tariff rate exceeded 100%. The equipment was stuck in customs, accumulating storage fees, until the physicist could pay the nearly \$130 000 import tax. An internal university loan to the physics department saved the day, says the department chair.

The payload for a planned long-duration, high-altitude balloon mission to study cosmic star formation at terahertz frequencies was test-flown last year in New Mexico. Jeffrey Filippini, who leads the development of the cryogenic camera for the mission's upcoming Antarctic flight, was slapped with a \$10 000 tariff for an infrared filter from the UK. Joaquin Vieira, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

Dacen Waters started his tenure-track position at the University of Denver last fall. He studies how electrons behave in 2D materials, work that could eventually feed into quantum computing technologies. Last October, he ordered a dilution refrigerator for about \$750 000 from a Finnish company—one of three, all in Europe, where such instruments are available. He had been trying to figure out how to cover \$75 000 at a 10% tariff rate. But when Trump threatened a 30% tariff in July, he was panicking. At that rate, he says, he'd have to cancel the order, which per the contract would mean forfeiting \$200 000. At press time, the expected tariff had come down to 15%, which Waters says he can make work. "I just need to decide what I will give up to pay the tariffs," he says.

"The tariffs have thrown a nasty curveball into everybody's life," says Walter Silvesky, commercial managing director for the US arm of the German company PI (Physik Instrumente). "It's especially tough for those in the academic sector. Researchers have no mechanism for dealing with extra costs." In some cases, vendors refuse to prepare firm bids because of the uncertainties on their end due to tariffs and inflation. And university purchasing offices sometimes won't approve purchases without a fixed price.

8/07/25: IHE. How Trump Forced Cuts at Wealthy Universities / Frozen research funding, rising endowment taxes and other concerns have prompted some of the nation's wealthiest universities to shed jobs despite their multibillion-dollar endowments.

Six months into his second term, President Donald Trump has forced changes at many of the nation's wealthiest universities, some of which have shed hundreds of jobs amid federal funding issues and investigations.

While sector layoffs are so frequent that /Inside Higher Ed/ has

dedicated monthly coverage to rounding up such reductions, those actions are more common at small, cash-strapped colleges or state institutions reeling from budget cuts. But universities with multibillion-dollar endowments have been among those making the deepest cuts in the first half of 2025, often driven by freezes on federal funding that the Trump administration imposed with minimal notice.

Some universities have also cited the recently passed endowment tax increase as a factor in layoffs.

Altogether the layoffs show a sector bracing for a new reality where research funding can be suddenly yanked away with little to no explanation and international and graduate student enrollment, once considered a cash cow, is under threat—prompting institutions in even the highest financial stratosphere to cut costs as they navigate changing policies and a president sharply critical of the sector.

Here's a look at how the nation's wealthiest universities are adjusting staffing levels due to an uncertain federal policy environment, research funding issues and a flurry of legal actions from the Trump administration that have forced concessions from multiple well-resourced institutions.

Thousands Out at Johns Hopkins

The Trump administration's cuts to the U.S. Agency for International Development hit Johns Hopkins University with \$800 million in canceled funding prompting the Baltimore-based institution to shut down numerous international programs and lay off 2,222 employees earlier this year.

The 2,222 job cuts are the deepest announced at any institution this year.

The layoffs, announced in March span more than 40 countries. Of the jobs cut, 1,975 were located internationally, while another 247 were in the U.S., with the majority in Baltimore. JHU announced at the time that another 107 employees would be furloughed.

Johns Hopkins has an endowment recently valued at more than \$13 billion.

Hundreds of Buyouts at Duke

Duke University, which has an endowment recently valued at nearly \$12 billion, made some of the deepest cuts of the year so far when officials announced in July that 599 employees had accepted

buyouts. Another 250 faculty members are reportedly weighing buyout offers as well.

Following the first round of buyouts, university officials said layoffs will begin this month.

Duke officials announced the buyouts before the Trump administration froze \$108 million in federal grants and contracts and opened investigations into alleged racial discrimination, accusing the university of emphasizing diversity over merit in hiring, admissions and other practices.

Deep Cuts at Northwestern

Earlier this year, the Trump administration abruptly froze \$790 million in research funding for Northwestern University, reportedly with no explanation. That action occurred at about the same time that the federal government opened an investigation into alleged antisemitism on campus.

Northwestern, which has an endowment valued at more than \$14 billion, responded by eliminating 425 jobs last month in an effort to shave 5 percent off of its staff budget. The move was preceded by a hiring freeze and other cost-cutting measures announced earlier this year.

President Michael Schill and other administrators wrote in a message to campus that the cuts were “in response to more than just the federal research funding freeze.” They also pointed to “rapidly rising healthcare expenses, litigation, labor contracts, employee benefits, compliance requirements and a suite of federal changes” that may harm international student enrollment.

The Ax Falls at Stanford

Stanford University plans to cut 363 jobs beginning this fall as part of an effort to shave \$140 million off the general funds budget due to financial issues connected to federal policy changes.

Those cuts come after the university announced a hiring freeze in February.

Stanford has the fourth-largest endowment among U.S. universities, recently valued at \$37.6 billion. But despite its deep pockets, the private research university is feeling the squeeze from the Trump administration, with officials writing in a state regulatory filing that the university anticipates “reductions in federal research funding” and an increase in endowment taxes.

Additionally, the U.S. Department of Justice launched an investigation

into admissions practices at Stanford earlier this year, accusing the university of sidestepping a ban on affirmative action.

Nearly 180 Layoffs at Columbia

Few institutions have faced as much scrutiny from the federal government in recent years as Columbia University, which agreed to sweeping changes and yielded to demands from the Trump administration to overhaul admissions, disciplinary processes and academic programs. The university will also share admissions data and reduce the number of international students it accepts in an unprecedented agreement with the Trump administration that culminated in a \$221 million settlement over allegations of antisemitism tied to pro-Palestinian campus protests.

Although the Trump administration will release some frozen research funds as a condition of the settlement, choking off federal dollars has already prompted cuts. Columbia announced in May that the university had laid off nearly 180 researchers amid its standoff with the federal government.

Columbia's endowment was recently valued at \$14.7 billion.

'A Day of Loss' at Boston U

Boston University announced plans last month to lay off 120 workers and eliminate another 120 vacant jobs.

Officials wrote in a letter to campus that "recent and ongoing federal actions and funding cuts are affecting our research enterprise as well as day-to-day operations" and creating "uncertainty" as BU grapples with inflation, declining graduate enrollment and other challenges.

"This is a day of loss for all of us," officials wrote. "There is no way around this. We know our community may need time to adjust to these difficult changes. Yet, it is also a necessary step in ensuring our future."

BU's endowment is valued at more than \$3 billion.

Dozens Laid Off at USC

The University of Southern California cut 55 jobs last month, according to a state regulatory filing.

Officials announced in mid-July that layoffs were underway, though they did not specify the number of employees affected. USC also

implemented a hiring freeze, halted merit-based pay raises, ended some vendor contracts and pulled back on discretionary spending and travel.

Interim president Beong-Soo Kim called the layoffs “painful” in a message to campus. He cited various financial concerns, including “significant shifts in federal support for our research, hospitals, and student financial aid” as well as potential declines in international enrollment.

“The ultimate impact of these changes is difficult to predict, but for a university of our scale, the potential annual revenue loss in federally sponsored research funding alone could be \$300 million or more,” Kim wrote, adding these changes came on top of a pre-existing budget deficit.

USC’s endowment was recently valued at \$8.1 billion.

Unspecified Cuts at Harvard

Harvard University, which is currently locked in a legal battle with the Trump administration over alleged antisemitism and other accusations, has also laid off employees this year. /Harvard Magazine/ reports

<<https://www.harvardmagazine.com/2025/07/harvard-layoffs-across-university-schools>>

that multiple schools have reduced staff as a result of having federal research funds frozen.

However, Harvard has not released numbers and declined to provide an estimate to /Inside Higher Ed/. Union officials have said

<<https://www.thecrimson.com/article/2025/4/22/huctw-open-letter-funds/>>

that layoffs could add up to hundreds of workers.

Harvard is the nation’s wealthiest university, with an endowment valued at nearly \$52 billion.

Likely Layoffs at Brown

Following Columbia, Brown University struck a deal with the Trump administration last month, agreeing to certain changes in order to restore around \$510 million in frozen research funding.

The federal government closed investigations into alleged antisemitism as part of the settlement. Brown also agreed to put \$50 million over the course of a decade into workforce development in Rhode Island. Less than a week after the settlement, Brown officials announced that “some layoffs will be necessary” due to the “persisting

financial impact of federal actions.”

Brown also enacted a hiring freeze in March, and nearly 350 jobs remain unfilled.

University officials wrote that they expected a \$30 million hit to the 2026 fiscal year budget from the One Big Beautiful Bill Act, Trump’s far-reaching legislation that affected the sector in various ways, including increases to endowment taxes and limiting or eliminating some loan programs.

Brown’s endowment was recently valued at \$7.2 billion, the lowest among its Ivy League peers.

8/11/25: FYI

TRUMP GIVES GRANTMAKING AUTHORITY TO POLITICAL APPOINTEES

President Donald Trump signed an executive order [aip.us17.list-manage.com] last week to give political appointees power over grantmaking decisions, specifying that each agency must have one or more senior appointees or their designees review and approve funding opportunities and grants. Agencies may use peer review methods for grantmaking on an advisory basis, but these recommendations should not be “ministerially ratified, routinely deferred to, or otherwise treated as de facto binding,” the order adds. As part of the justification for increasing political oversight over grant review, the order claims the National Science Foundation has funded grants that “promoted Marxism, class warfare propaganda, and other anti-American ideologies,” alluding to a review of NSF grants published [aip.us17.list-manage.com] by Senate Commerce Committee Chair Ted Cruz (R-TX) in 2024.

The order requires all grant awards to “demonstrably advance the president’s policy priorities” where applicable and prohibits them from supporting “forms of racial discrimination by the grant recipient” including the use of race as a selection criterion for employment or program participation, “denial by the grant recipient of the sex binary in humans,” and other initiatives that “promote anti-American values.” The order also directs appointees to give preference to institutions with lower indirect cost rates and directs the Office of Management and Budget to limit the use of grant funds for indirect costs. It adds that appointees should give grants to “a broad range of recipients” instead of “repeat players,” and ensure grantee institutions comply with the earlier “gold standard science” [aip.us17.list-manage.com] executive order.

House Science Committee Ranking Member Zoe Lofgren (D-CA) derided [aip.us17.list-manage.com] the order, pointing out that political

appointees may have conflicts of interest. "This means someone who has made millions lobbying for chemical companies could block research into the dangers of pesticides, PFAS, microplastics – the list goes on," Lofgren stated. COGR, a consortium that represents research institutions, also criticized the order. COGR President Matt Owens said [aip.us17.list-manage.com] the peer review process, sheltered from political appointees, is "a key reason U.S. science and innovation are the envy of the world." Owens added that by seeking to further cap grant funds for indirect costs, "the administration refuses to acknowledge and pay for the true costs of research critical to the security of the nation and the health of its people."

GAO CONCLUDES NIH HAS ILLEGALLY SLOWED SPENDING

The National Institutes of Health's grant terminations and pause on grant reviews violate impoundment law, as they coincide with a decline in grantmaking from February to June with no indication that the funds are being used for another congressionally mandated purpose, according to a decision [aip.us17.list-manage.com] issued last week by the Government Accountability Office. Between February and June of 2025, NIH awarded \$8 billion less than in the same period last year, according to GAO. The Department of Health and Human Services has shown "no sufficient justification" for its earlier pause on grant review meeting notice submissions in the federal register, the GAO report states. It adds that if the administration pursues deferrals or rescissions of funds, it must send a message to Congress outlining the amounts in question and the reasons for the impoundment. In a press release [aip.us17.list-manage.com] about the report, Senate Appropriations Committee Ranking Member Patty Murray (D-WA) also noted that the administration initially cut off [aip.us17.list-manage.com] an additional \$15 billion in NIH funding last week before quickly reversing the decision. GAO's role is to support Congress and its decisions do not have any legal binding on their own.

Meanwhile, the Trump administration has asked the Supreme Court to overturn the lower court ruling that restored around 900 NIH grants. Higher education associations filed [aip.us17.list-manage.com] an amicus brief opposing the administration's efforts. The court's emergency docket decision could come at any time.

- * The Trump administration has proposed [aip.us17.list-manage.com] that UCLA pay a \$1 billion settlement to restore almost \$600 million [aip.us17.list-manage.com] in grant funding frozen by the administration. Meanwhile, a judge has ordered NSF to justify [aip.us17.list-manage.com] its freezing of 300 grants that were awarded to UCLA given that the move conflicts with a June court order [aip.us17.list-manage.com] that restored terminated grants to California faculty.

8/12/25: Price of oil: WTI is around \$62/bbl. Price is low enough to discourage production. Decline is partly related to lower demand because of higher US tariffs leading to reduced economic activity and fear of a recession. Oil companies have no interest in producing oil at low prices.

8/12/25: WP. Jay Bhattacharya: Why the NIH is pivoting away from mRNA vaccines / As a vaccine for broad public use, mRNA technology has failed to earn the public's trust.

...The mRNA platform is promising technology. I do not dispute its potential. In the future, it may yet deliver breakthroughs in treating diseases such as cancer, and HHS is continuing to invest in ongoing research on applications in oncology and other complex diseases. But as a vaccine intended for broad public use, especially during a public health emergency, the platform has failed a crucial test: earning public trust. No matter how elegant the science, a platform that lacks credibility among the people it seeks to protect cannot fulfill its public health mission...

...Unfortunately, the Biden administration did not manage public trust in the coronavirus vaccines, largely because it chose a strategy of mandates rather than a risk-based approach and did not properly acknowledge Americans' growing concerns regarding safety and effectiveness. ...The failure was thus not a communications problem. It is a trust problem due to the Biden administration's scientific overreach, public pressure and, frankly, arrogance.

...I am not here to litigate the past. I am here to chart a better path forward. That is why the NIH, under the leadership of HHS Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr., is investing in new vaccine technologies – based on whole-virus inactivated vaccines, which offer a broader immune response and have a longer track record of safety and public acceptance. We are continuing the Operation Warp Speed model of investing in technology with the most potential to help Americans.

Comments...

Orwellian double-speak that will kill Americans.

The conservative ideologues have taken over thanks to the rich oligarchs who don't want to be taxed or regulated ever again. They are anti-science and full to the brim with hatred, vitriol and vengeance toward the strawman liberal manufactured by right-wing mass media. Money and power corrupts without ethics or morals. This kind of ignorance leads to nowhere good very quickly.

He almost had me going, until he got to the part about blaming the Biden administration for the Republicans who criticized the vaccine, relying upon rhetoric, not science, to make scientific decisions. Is there anybody competent there?

This guy is blaming the public's lack of trust, when he should be blaming those who misinform the public. A deteriorating lack of general education and the proliferation of MISinformation ensure that trust in science-based information will be increasingly difficult to achieve. Add RFK to the brew and Americans will eventually lose access to vaccines we've relied on to keep us healthy. If "the public" chooses to listen only to news outlets peddling junk science and medical conspiracy...

Was a mandate necessary to break the pandemic? We don't know, but we certainly gave ourselves a better chance because more people got the initial vaccine. Those people who believe that was somehow an infringement of their rights to be an individual don't understand the basic principle of public health: We are all in this together and requiring certain basic health conditions has improved humanity's position. That certainly deserves some respect in the author's point of view.

Mandate or no mandate, you don't cancel research because a portion of the population has been hoodwinked by anti vaccination pundits raising money and their profiles off of misinformation.

The mRNA vaccine could have created unknown proteins or prions that could cause permanent damage to everyone that took the shot or it could have saved millions of lives. There is no way to know and forcing individuals into a trial is unethical.

Nonsense. Of course there is a way to know. It's called science. The underlying science that gave us mRNA vaccines didn't just come out of nowhere in 2020/21. They have been researched for years.

More MAGA propaganda. The use of the mRNA vehicle has been under development for over 30 years and it was under human trials for 12 years. No prions (which would be impossible to come from mRNA), and no harmful proteins were ever associated with the mRNA vaccines.

Individuals weren't "forced into a trial." All the Covid vaccines went through three-phase clinical trials before being released for use, just like any other drug or vaccine. Yes, there's a way to know – and it's not a bunch of clueless people telling each other lies about vaccines, it's scientific research.

Billions took it. The trial is long over, it works.

PhD biochemist here. Explain to me how the vaccine could create prions. You're using terms to scare people you don't understand them.

The goal of the NIH is to conduct and support medical research to improve health, lengthen life, and reduce illness and disability. Where in this article is this part of the conversation? Popular opinion about science is not part of the scientific method. If people choose to ignore medical advice, so be it. We've already seen what that does to measles. Keep going along this path and we will find ourselves 100 years behind the science. Oh, I miss the good old days of cholera and typhus. I haven't missed a COVID vaccination yet and am happy to report that I've never had it. (that I know of) . My grandchildren go to a school where vaccines are mandated. No sign of whooping cough there. So many reasons to be happy to be living in the 21st century. Let's pray that this administration doesn't send us further backwards in time.

Doctors and health agencies have long promoted vaccinations against deadly diseases without knowing the details of how they work. The mRNA vaccines are better understood than any of their predecessors were when they were first introduced. This type of vaccine doesn't require massive quantities of chicken eggs to make sufficient quantities of vaccine, and the components can easily be adjusted for new strains. This would make it ideal to replace the flu vaccine which needs to be planned and manufactured long before we are certain of the strains that will be circulating in North America during flu season. My friend who has a sensitivity to eggs can't have current flu vaccines without her entire arm swelling up with accompanying pain and days of disability. She's not alone. The actual data from rollout of the Covid mRNA vaccines conclusively demonstrates their effectiveness and safety. It's unconscionable for the US to end research funding for mRNA vaccines while saying that we don't have enough information on how they work. Political rhetoric should not trump scientific inquiry, but here we are. When there is another pandemic, traditional vaccines won't provide the fast turnaround needed to prevent huge mortality rates. Let's just pray that there's not a Republican administration in power when that happens, because they prefer to rely on hopes and prayers instead of actual prevention and scientific evidence.

The Trumpers, MAGA mavens, and Republicans in general, trashed the COVID vaccines relentlessly. Then they turn around and dismiss the technology that produced the vaccine by saying the vaccines failed to earn the trust of the public. What hypocrisy!! What rubbish! The problem is that their actions endanger all of us. Just wait until the next pandemic arrives, and we needlessly have to wait 4 to 5 years for effective vaccines to be developed.

Stream of unconsciousness from the current potus about internal bleach use began april 2020. They funded the moonshot to get the vaccines ready, but undermined public health from January 2020 on.

I'm an 81 year old man so am at high risk from a respiratory disease like COVID. I have kept up with the shots and boosters and have had no adverse effects from them. I tried for years to avoid catching COVID but finally got it last December. Turns out all I had was a mild cough and it went away in about a week presumably thanks to the vaccinations. Thank goodness M. Battacharya hasn't been running things. It makes me wonder what happens next, though.

The sad truth is that all the damage and loss we have sustained from these criminals will continue for many years, if not decades. Not only in the sciences, but in all areas of life. All sane people recognize that this debacle will be reversed eventually. I am sorry that my elderly parents will not live to see the course correction, nor will I most probably. I hope my children see the time when we return to some semblance of rationality, but even that is now questionable.

I review scientific studies as a chair of a large Institutional Review Board. During Covid, this included vigorous, double blinded studies involving vaccines, as well as ivermectin and hydroxychloroquine. The mRNA Covid vaccine was an objectively massive success, helping prevent deaths and suffering. The alternative medicines did not. The messaging certainly could have been better and trust was clearly undermined by the current administration. I do not understand why political talking points should dictate scientific research and policy.

Trust was eroded? Let's be clear – people who listened to conspiracy theorists and snake oil salesmen like RFK Jr may have their trust eroded. Not scientists, doctors, or anyone who reads credible news.

Bhattacharya has been a political hack and continues to be a political hack. It's the only reason he's heading the NIH now, because the majority of scientists and particularly physician-scientists think he's toxic, together with his allies Prasad, Atlas, etc. Just remember he's the one that wanted the virus to rip. He'll deny it, paint another picture, and claim he was always right & he wanted to protect the elderly.

[cont] The problem with his rebuttal, now and then, is he had no answer how to protect elderly living with younger people. He had talking points, but the fact was that there was little hope to adopt those kinds of preventions. Instead, he gave the go-ahead for the right-wingers and people shouting FREEDOM to ignore safety protocols.

[cont] The result was the USA had among the worst results of any major industrialized county. And if we had listened to

Bhattacharya and his self-righteous freedom fighters, it would have been A LOT WORSE since they were calling on limited restrictions well before the vaccine was available. I'm a physician-scientist and I think "Dr B" has a fan base similar to Trump. He's definitely not the worst of Prasad, Atlas, and those who pretend they got it right, but only under the anti-science Trump would he be head of NIH. When we vote Trump out, we'll get rid of him too.

[JB was a leader of the group that wrote the Great Barrington Declaration arguing that the best approach to the pandemic was to achieve herd immunity ASAP by letting it spread. Of course, herd immunity requires something like >80% exposure of the population to the disease or a vaccine. The argument shortchanged the well being of huge cross-sections of the populations -- especially elderly and those with pre-existing respiratory disease. At the time, there was no good evidence regarding the susceptibility of children and infants to COVID-19. It later emerged that they were less susceptible than adults...which has been used by vaccine skeptics as evidence of governmental overreach -- but caution was the correct approach at the time.]

A lot of people tried to explain vaccine efficacy and response, didn't have the background to do so, and provided their own misinformation as well, but the degree of damage they did was considerably less than Bhattacharya, et. al. Further, the efficacy rate for preventing infection did approach the mid-to-high 90% rate for the initial vaccine against the first two strains of virus we saw, and modeling I did at the time suggested that, with another 4-6 weeks of social isolation and vaccine rates >95%, we could well have reduced the incidence of COVID-19 disease in the US to background levels. But it wouldn't have lasted.

[cont] 1. Trump and his stooges undermined rapid vaccine uptake intentionally, Include Vinay Prasad, Bhattacharya, Atlas, Makary, and a host of others playing that game, and because of their credentials, provided cover to the false statements they were making.

[cont] 2. We lacked world-wide distribution, and the number of doses required, to vaccinate virtually the entire world in a timely manner. Thus we'd see viral evolutionary drift and another strain would sneak into the country and we'd have yet another novel coronavirus to deal with, That one, however, likely would have seen reduced morbidity and mortality because, had we hit that 95% mark for vaccinations, there would have been sufficient immune memory to see the invading virus and produce antibodies that were at least somewhat effective.

This Trump appointee heading up NIH is responsible for fueling the

misinformation he now criticizes. In 2020, early in the onslaught of coronavirus Jay penned an op-ed for the Wall Street Journal titled: "Is the Coronavirus as Deadly as They Say?.... the title alone stirs distrust and confusion. Yes Jay the virus is as deadly and subsequently killed over a million Americans. The cult of MAGA is responsible for mRNA vaccine distrust and thankfully MAGA doesn't come close to representing 50% of American thought. Continue on Jayyou and "Dr." Ladapo here in Florida are minority thinkers in the scientific community. Best not write any more op-eds and embarrass yourself and the highly qualified scientific community at NIH.

the same people who spread misinformation about it are now citing the confusion they created as a reason to block public access to mRNA vaccines rather than trying to correct the public's misperceptions.

Dr. Bhattacharya (who did not pursue residency training and does not clinically see patients) is off base. He is not referencing any of the data from when these vaccines rolled out late 2020/early 2021 in which there was drastic reduction in hospitalization and mortality associated with COVID. In reviewing his history, he has been on the wrong side of this issue from the beginning and his article reflects his own opinions, which are not founded on an evidence based approach. As a practicing internist/hospitalist, I am thankful for these vaccines, continue to recommend them to my high risk patients, continue to receive them for myself and family annually and am hopeful for mRNA technology during future pandemics. This article needs to be better fact checked and he should attempt to publish in a peer-reviewed journal.

There is a reason why this guy would never get an article published in a peer reviewed journal. I hesitate to call him doctor since his piece was so political. Trump good, Biden bad. Yeah, we get it.

Installing totally unqualified people is one of the hallmarks of authoritarian governments, according to a piece I read recently about Hannah Arendt's writing on the topic. We think it's a bug, but for maga it's a feature: those people will remain loyal no matter what because they only have their positions for that reason.

[JB got a BA and MA in economics; an MD in 1997; a PhD in economics in 2000. Evidently never practiced medicine; likely did not have an internship.]

This frightens me. I accept that some people for whatever reason don't want to have a vaccine, but I do. And I want a vaccine that will be effective and the mRNA vaccines have met that test. Why are you trying to deny the public effective therapies?

As an infectious disease physician, I cannot believe what I am

reading. Dr. Bhattacharya asserts that the vaccine "lost credibility," which is a completely non-scientific assertion. THE REASON IT LOST CREDIBILITY IS NOT DUE TO THE ACTUAL PERFORMANCE OF THE VACCINE ITSELF, WHICH IN MY OBSERVATION WAS EXEMPLARY, BUT PRIMARILY DUE TO A VIRULENT ATTACK CAMPAIGN BY RABID ANTI-VAXXERS AND POLITICAL EXTREMISTS WITH AN AGENDA. This is a revolutionary technology, and in my opinion the rapid rollout of the COVID vaccine was about the only worthy thing to come out of the Trump administration. The best way I can illustrate my point is the fact that I COULD PREDICT WITH A GREAT DEGREE OF ACCURACY WHETHER MY COVID PATIENTS WOULD LIVE OR DIE BASED ON THEIR VOTING HISTORY, AND CONSEQUENTLY WHETHER THEY TOOK THE VACCINE.

Why did I have to read this far to see someone make this point? You are exactly correct, sir. IT'S PURE NIHILISM TO SPREAD MISTRUST AND THEN ACT LIKE AN INNOCENT OBSERVER LATER ON.

If an opinion piece could be called malpractice this one is it.

This very newspaper, before it became Pravda for MAGA, published data weekly showing rates of hospitalization and death by vaccination rates state by state. Now it publishes disinformation under the guise of "opinion".

as a reputable public health scientist I'm sure you also know that vaccinating lower risk populations protects those at higher risk by decreasing the chance of exposure. I would posit that decreasing the risk to the elderly as well as younger people who for whatever reason are more susceptible is a desirable aim for a public health innovation.

mRNA vaccines are revolutionary period hard stop. THE EXPECTATION OF BEING TOTALLY PROTECTED WITH VACCINATION WAS FALSE AND IT WAS NOT COMMUNICATED. The deficiency and the horrible politics due mostly to the antivaxers and trumppers poisoned the well. Good science is just that, it is good science and communication of the data is lacking for this virus. Good communication has now been muzzled by this trump administration and kennedy jr. We, collectively will pay the price.

thanks in part to fringe conspiracy theorists like Dr. Bhattacharya and Mr. Kennedy himself, some people demanded to participate in the workplace unvaccinated despite an increased risk of contracting and passing on the virus to their coworkers and further straining overburdened hospitals. Now Dr. Bhattacharya uses that manufactured controversy to justify canceling the scientific work underlying the medical breakthrough that saved those lives and holds great promise for combating other emerging and existing diseases. What a tragic abdication of responsibility by those charged with safeguarding our health.

I respectfully disagree! The mRNA vaccine won the trust of a vast majority of well educated Americans.

He has earned the trust of uninformed Americans.

Why are people not getting the Covid vaccine in 2024? Perhaps because the vaccine was so successful that Covid now has a very low incidence. People may be making a rational decision about how to use their time that has nothing to do with vaccine hesitancy or communications in the Biden administration...IF ANYONE IS PROMOTING VACCINE HESITANCY IT IS THE DOCTOR, THE HHS SECRETARY AND THIS WHOLE ADMINISTRATION THAT SEEMS TO HAVE A VERY STRANGE RELATIONSHIP WITH FACTS, RATIONAL ANALYSIS AND THE TRUTH.

This really is NOT good enough for government work.

In an emergency we have to follow some orders even if we personally think another option is better. You don't argue with the firefighter getting you out of the burning building!

I am a scientist and actively work in clinical trials. Dr. Battacharya is very, very wrong, and has sullied his reputation beyond repair among those of us who are *REAL* scientists, with lab and clinical experience, not just armchair medical quarterbacks. First, do no harm seems to be way over his head, despite his previous appointment at Stanford.

If we doubted his qualifications to lead NIH before this ignorant opinion piece confirms it.

Your article is political & bunk: I studied the mRNA scientific research for weeks before I went to get the COVID. This was after I nearly died getting it in Dec of 2021, before it was known what it was. I almost died from a second bout before I could get the vaccine. I was getting the Long Haul symptoms, becoming more debilitated at 75 years old. But, as soon as I got the vaccine my health began to improve. I've had the updated version every 6 to 9 months since the first shot and my health is as good as it's ever been. The scientific breakthrough of the mRNA is astounding, one of the best scientific accomplishments in my lifetime. My long haul symptoms have reversed and I haven't gotten ill from RSV or any other bug. The choices you all are making in the current administration is setting us back, not moving us forward. Another sad choice in the issues of power.

Obviously, the goal should be to be effective. While it would be nice to earn public trust, that can't be a primary goal particularly when health issues become politicized.

Because a small segment of the population does not believe in science, the majority is barred from the benefits of basic research?

Very excited about the impact a non-practicing Doctor and an environmental lawyer are having on public health as we usher in a new Age of Enlightenment.

If one of the arguments is the lack of public trust because of poor messaging from the former administration then the current administration needs to do better in this area not cancel research.

This article is the old "we aren't sure about smoking and cancer" routine. You put a lot of misinformation out there, and then question whether there is trust.

This is a very misguided article in my view. The lack of trust was mainly due to the misinformation that was spreading on line -- faster than viral infection rates. Moreover, many politicians-- mostly from the Republican party, and amplified further by Fox News, cast serious doubt on the vaccines. The Biden administration-- from all I observed tried desperately hard to counter these aspersions. The author inadvertently, makes the case that the mRNA -- platform needs even more research -- and he is in a position to help build the public trust. This article shows his true bias. and that is very unfortunate. I see the USA marching backwards in all areas of science -- health, environmental, and energy transformation. It is sad to observe when we so badly need evidence based decision making.

Bhattacharya was never a practising MD. He has an MD degree, but graduate work was in economics and HIS EMPLOYMENT WAS AS A MEDICAL ECONOMIST AT THE CONSERVATIVE HOOVER THINK TANK housed at Stanford. During the pandemic HE OPINED THAT 20,000 TO 40,000 INDIVIDUALS WOULD DIE in the US from COVID. This was based on his own understanding of the disease from a seroprevalence study he did in Santa Clara County, CA. This study was strongly criticized at the time for its design flaws. He was very wrong about mortality from COVID and I am not aware that he has ever addressed his widely inaccurate estimate. We are now at 1,225,000 million deaths and counting. If we had followed his recommendations, this number would undoubtedly be much higher. This individual should have little role to play in making important and strategic decisions to protect the health of Americans, although he is clearly a wingman for RFK Jr.

The reason that mass media didn't report GBS [Giulian Barre syndrome] as a side effect of the RSV vaccine was because it wasn't anything special. GBS can occur at anytime after a viral infection and incidents of GBS after the RSV vaccine are 10 times lower than incidents of GBS after infection of the RSV virus itself. Incidents of GBS are very very rare after vaccination and are more likely to be less common and less severe than being infected by the virus

itself. Want to reduce your chances of severe GBS? Get vaccinated !

While serious and requiring immediate medical attention, most people with GBS recover fully or with minor residual effects. Unfortunately, the million people who died from the virus did not recover.

The facts: Operation Warp Speed did not produce the highly effective original COVID 19 mRNA vaccine in record time. Pfizer did., and they did it without accepting any money from the federal government for R&D. They gambled \$9 billion of their own resources. Had the original Phase III trial for their vaccine not proved at least 50% effective in protecting against serious illness, they would have received nothing from Operation Warp Speed. Also, even after the trial demonstrated an astonishing 95% efficacy, Trump's HHS only ordered 100 million doses, far short of the 200 million public health officials thought would be necessary. The US averted a severe shortage only because Pfizer figured out how to produce far more doses than originally planned. The current NIH Director would do well to read one of the best books on medical discovery ever...Dr. Albert Burla's "Moonshot" about how the vaccine was developed. The other thing about the NIH Director's Op Ed that is so disturbing is that he is arguing that NIH grants for mRNA research in vaccines should be curtailed (stopped?) because the public has lost confidence in the technology. Well, WHY IS THAT? They've lost confidence because of the gross misinformation being promulgated by...well, we all know who.

[One of the several errors in Bhattacharya's argument is the claim the anti-vaxxers object to the mRNA-developed vaccines. The overwhelming majority of those people don't know mRNA from a hot rock. They aren't suspicious of the technique used to produce the vaccine, they are suspicious because they think it was developed by the GOVERNMENT and then ostensibly foisted on the naive American people. Any other type of vaccine would have generated the same irrational anti-government backlash.]

8/13/25: IHE. Trump Order on Grants Puts Politics Above Peer Review, Researchers Say / The executive order says senior appointees must review grants, and it demands awards be easier to terminate. Research groups say it undermines science.

Since Inauguration Day, the Trump administration has repeatedly frozen and terminated research funding for seemingly political reasons. Federal agencies have ended grants for studies because they allegedly advanced diversity, equity and inclusion or "gender ideology," and they've cut off research dollars across the board for some universities to pressure them to crack down on pro-Palestine advocacy and bar transgender women from women's sports.

But, late last week, the president laid out new processes for how he wants “senior appointees” to take charge of awarding, or denying, new federal grants. He also ordered that they regularly review grants that have already been awarded—and consider terminating them.

The executive order, in one sense, puts into writing the administration’s ongoing efforts to assert greater control over who receives grants and for what kinds of research. But researchers and those who advocate for them and their institutions also say some aspects of the order escalate this campaign. Moreover, they say the political review threatens to further slow the flow of federal research funding over all.

“The [order] would add a new and unnecessary layer of bureaucracy that will diminish the role of quality and excellence in science while simultaneously adding delay to the process of evaluating and awarding grant proposals,” Barbara R. Snyder, president of the Association of American Universities, said in a statement Tuesday. She said it “will apparently replace the merit-based system of science-based decision-making for research grant funding in favor of decision-making by political appointees.”

Debbie Altenburg, vice president for research policy and advocacy at the Association of Public and Land-grant Universities, said, among the other provisions, “certainly, adding a term and condition to grants for cancellation for convenience is a significant change.”

President Trump’s executive order further prohibits federal officials from awarding discretionary grants that fund or “promote” specific purposes that conservatives have railed against: illegal immigration, racial preferences, “intentional proxies for race” and “the notion that sex is a chosen or mutable characteristic.” It criticized past federal funding of “drag shows in Ecuador,” “transgender-sexual-education programs” and critical race theory training, though the White House didn’t provide /Inside Higher Ed/ examples of this.

But the order doesn’t just aim at specific targets of the right. It uses broad language to ban funding for initiatives that “promote anti-American values,” without defining that. It further requires discretionary grants to “where applicable, demonstrably advance the President’s policy priorities,” without defining where that’s applicable.

This misguided order will slow progress for cures and treatments that patients and families across the country urgently need by delaying critical research with problematic political and bureaucratic hurdles.”

—Association of American Medical Colleges

And it threatens grant money that's already been awarded, by ordering the Office of Management and Budget to ensure future discretionary grants can be terminated "for convenience." It further directs other federal agencies to revise terms for existing grants "to permit immediate termination for convenience."

In multiple places, the order urges the senior appointees at grant-making agencies to question peer reviewers' assessment of who deserves funding.

"Senior appointees and their designees shall not ministerially ratify or routinely defer to the recommendations of others in reviewing funding opportunity announcements or discretionary awards, but shall instead use their independent judgment," the order says, adding later that peer-review recommendations must "remain advisory."

'Bottlenecks'

Backlash to the order was swift as the major research associations and some individual researchers spoke out against what they called a usurpation of merit-based review of grant applications. Ultimately, they said, the order prioritizes politics above peer review, adding that it will further slow research funding when federal grant making is already lagging.

The Association of American Medical Colleges said in a statement Friday that the order "will create significant bureaucratic bottlenecks in the grant review and approval process, slowing the pace of innovation and introducing political preferences as part of the approval process."

"This misguided order will slow progress for cures and treatments that patients and families across the country urgently need by delaying critical research with problematic political and bureaucratic hurdles," the association said.

Todd Wolfson, president of the American Association of University Professors, said in a statement, "This order further weakens our nation's ability to conduct and support scientific research across various fields by replacing experts with ideologically driven political stooges who have no expertise and no business making decisions on academic research."

Katie Lotterhos, an associate professor of marine and environmental sciences at Northeastern University, told /Inside Higher Ed/ that "political review of grants is definitely going to narrow the kinds of science that can be done."

"Now scientists not only have to get through that whole gantlet of peer review and panel review—there's going to be an additional gantlet of political review," Lotterhos said.

Lotterhos also said she thinks the order "just formalizes what we think is already being done behind the scenes."

Joanne Padrón Carney, chief government relations officer for the American Association for the Advancement of Science, told /Inside Higher Ed /the Trump administration already placed an "additional level of review" atop peer review in the form of the Department of Government Efficiency, which led grant-cancellation efforts.

Carney said one could argue that the executive order codifies "steps the administration has already undertaken" and could give officials some legal cover. Many of the higher ed-related lawsuits filed against the administration are challenges of grant cuts. But she said the order could also establish "a more formalized process that leaves in question how research proposals based on advancing scientific ideals will be measured against the administration's priorities."

Additionally, it's "critically important to emphasize that it also codifies a layer of red tape that is a bottleneck in the execution of great science and research awards," Carney said. She and others have raised concerns that the National Institutes of Health won't be able to spend all its allocated grant money before the fiscal year ends next month—meaning that money will return to the U.S. Treasury.

"It slows down the research process, and it introduces more uncertainty," Carney said.

Even for future grants that are awarded and aren't later officially rescinded, the order may still stymie researchers' access to funds. It says agency heads, to the extent legal and "practicable," must put terms into grant agreements banning "recipients from directly drawing down general grant funds for specific projects without the affirmative authorization of the agency" and requiring grantees to "provide written explanations or support, with specificity, for requests for each drawdown."

A key reason U.S. science and innovation are the envy of the world is our scientific peer-review process that bases funding decisions on scientific merit, not political preference and partisanship."

—Matt Owens, COGR president

Daniel Aldrich, the Dean's Professor of Resilience at Northeastern University, said, "No president has sought to the degree that Trump has to control what science looks like." Aldrich said the order replaces what's supposed to be an objective and knowledge-based

approach to deciding who gets grants with a partisan one.

"We want scientists to make those decisions," Aldrich said. "They know the field best—not a political appointee who is seeking to make the president look good."

'National Interest'

Trump's order directs federal agency heads to designate appointees who will then create new processes to review already awarded grants and new funding opportunities. The goal is to ensure consistency "with agency priorities and the national interest," the order says. National interest isn't defined.

These appointees or their designees must approve any announcements of new funding opportunities. And—before the discretionary grants are actually handed out—grant-review panels or program offices must discuss them with these appointees or their designees.

Once the money is out the door, the appointees' oversight responsibility still won't be over. Trump ordered the appointees to annually review discretionary awards "for consistency with agency priorities and substantial progress." The president said this "review shall include an accountability mechanism for officials responsible for selection and granting of the awards."

And, until this process is in place at an agency, the agency "shall not issue any new funding opportunity announcements without prior approval from the senior appointee designated ... except as required by law," the order says.

Lotterhos said "national interest" is "such a vague and subjective term." She said the order might result "in grants having to be written in such a way now that they can pass peer review as well as pass political review," like including in a National Science Foundation grant application a section on how the research would advance national interests.

An NSF spokesperson declined to comment for this story beyond sending a written statement, which said the agency "is currently reviewing our processes to ensure we are in compliance with the [order] while continuing to invest in innovating science and engineering research that drives American competitiveness."

Spokespeople for the NIH, the Health and Human Services Department, the Office of Management and Budget, and the White House didn't respond to requests for comment this week.

Matt Owens, president of COGR—an organization that now only goes by

its acronym and that advocates for researchers and universities on the federal level—said in a statement that the order “sidelines scientific merit in federal research grant decisions by putting political appointees and partisans in charge of determining which scientific research grants should be funded.”

“A key reason U.S. science and innovation are the envy of the world is our scientific peer-review process that bases funding decisions on scientific merit, not political preference and partisanship,” Owens said.

And—like the leaders of other research associations—Owens also criticized another part of the order: It contains another attempt by the Trump administration to target indirect research costs.

Scrutiny Again on Indirect Costs

For months, the administration has sought to curb how much money it spends on costs indirectly related to research, arguing that colleges are misusing the funds. Reimbursements for indirect costs are supposed to help universities shoulder expenses that can’t be attributed to any single research project, such as building maintenance, compliance with patient safety regulations and more.

Universities negotiate these rates with the federal government, and they vary. While some institutions have negotiated reimbursement rates higher than 50 percent, the average is 28 percent.

[Again, ambiguous. Believe this is the fraction of the TOTAL award devoted to ID costs, not the fraction of the DIRECT costs.]

Under Trump, the NIH, NSF and Departments of Defense and Energy have all moved to cap indirect costs at 15 percent, but courts have blocked them. Senate appropriators also rejected that cap in a recent spending bill. The new executive order doesn’t try again to set that or any maximum amount, but it does incentivize institutions to ask for lower rates in order to win grants.

“All else being equal, preference for discretionary awards should be given to institutions with lower indirect cost rates,” the order says.

Lotterhos said this seems to be one of a couple of good things in the order.

“I think a lot of us would like to see more transparency in indirect costs,” she said.

The order also calls for limiting “the use of discretionary grant funds for costs related to facilities and administration,” another

term for indirect costs. But multiple research associations—including some that have been working as part of the Joint Associations Group to come up with a new research funding model Congress and the administration will accept—have objected.

“The administration refuses to acknowledge and pay for the true costs of research critical to the security of the nation and the health of its people,” Owens, of COGR, said in the statement. “Facilities and administrative (or ‘indirect’) costs partially reimburse an institution’s costs associated with equipment, lab space, utilities, compliance activities, and other items that are essential to conducting research and meeting federal requirements. These costs have been capped since 1991, and this order aims to cap reimbursement for these costs further.”

The Association of American Medical Colleges said in its statement that the provision will “weaken the ability of institutions to maintain essential research infrastructure.”

Heather Pierce, senior director for science policy for the AAMC, noted that the executive order doesn’t create law. She said people should be on the lookout for what rules agencies promulgate to comply.

“The key will be what action the agencies take in response to this,” Pierce said.

8/18/25: FYI. UCLA Grants Restored, But Future Litigation Faces Obstacles

A federal judge has ordered [aip.us17.list-manage.com] the National Science Foundation to restore grants to UCLA for the second time this year. The judge ruled in June [aip.us17.list-manage.com] that NSF must restore grants to University of California institutions that were canceled “for researching blacklisted DEI topics” or “by form letter without any grant-specific explanation.” NSF restored those grants but then froze all its grants [aip.us17.list-manage.com] to UCLA in July, following the Justice Department’s finding that the university violated antidiscrimination statutes by “creating a hostile educational environment for Jewish and Israeli students.” The National Institutes of Health also froze nearly 500 grants to UCLA. The judge rejected NSF’s claim [aip.us17.list-manage.com] last week that the injunction did not apply to grant suspensions, only terminations.

Meanwhile, an appeals court ruled [aip.us17.list-manage.com] last week that under the Impoundment Control Act, only the Government Accountability Office can sue the administration over funding cuts, rather than people affected by the cuts. Multiple lawsuits from researchers and associations representing them, including the original

lawsuit to restore federal grants to UC schools, have argued that grant terminations violate the ICA. Plaintiffs in the case said they would appeal. GAO is an advisory body for Congress and so far has not sued over the Trump administration's funding cuts.

8/25/25: FYI. SUPREME COURT PERMITS TERMINATION OF NIH GRANTS

The Trump administration can re-terminate hundreds of National Institutes of Health grants following an order [aip.us17.list-manage.com] from the Supreme Court last week. The court found that challenges to grant terminations are outside the jurisdiction of the district court that originally overturned the terminations. The order is not a final ruling on the terminations, but requires researchers or their representative organizations to file suit in the Court of Federal Claims to seek a final decision. Earlier this month, a federal judge similarly ruled [aip.us17.list-manage.com] that a suit challenging grant terminations from the National Science Foundation must instead be brought before the Court of Federal Claims.

However, the Supreme Court did uphold the district court's decision to vacate NIH guidance documents that said the agency would no longer fund research "related to DEI objectives, gender identity, or COVID-19" nor "continue the practice of awarding grants to researchers based on race." Justice Amy Coney Barrett stated in her concurring opinion that "vacating the guidance does not necessarily void decisions made under it," referring to the terminations.

The court voted 5-4 on both decisions. "By today's order, an evenly divided court neuters judicial review of grant terminations by sending plaintiffs on a likely futile, multiveneue quest for complete relief," Justice Ketanji Brown Jackson wrote in her dissenting opinion.

The district court's decision in June ordered [aip.us17.list-manage.com] the restoration of grants for parties involved in the lawsuits, including individual researchers named in the suit, members of the American Public Health Association, the United Auto Workers union, and researchers at public institutions in the 16 states that sued NIH. Some of those researchers saw their funds restored [aip.us17.list-manage.com] while others did not; [aip.us17.list-manage.com] some never had their funding terminated [aip.us17.list-manage.com] despite being on the Department of Health and Human Service's list of cuts. [aip.us17.list-manage.com]

[Radio commentary (Bloomberg, I believe) states that this decision threatens to abrogate the traditional value of government contracts. Grant contracts were broken by Trump admin's actions. Casts doubt on desirability of any federal contracts (i.e. in the private sector as well as research institutions). The Federal

Claims court is normally used only for straightforward matters, not for something as complicated as this. AND, since the grant funds were already pulled from the grantees, the process has already almost guaranteed that the supported programs have been terminated, personnel laid off, and so forth. TERRIBLE.]

HOUSE SCIENCE COMMITTEE LEADER REITERATES SUPPORT FOR ARTEMIS

House Science Committee Chair Brian Babin (R-TX) emphasized his support for NASA's Artemis lunar program during a tour [aip.us17.list-manage.com] of Johnson Space Center last week. "Under President Trump's leadership, we are committed to Artemis – landing U.S. astronauts on the Moon during his term and building a sustained presence on the lunar surface and in low-Earth orbit," Babin said in a press release highlighting the tour. Transportation Secretary Sean Duffy, who is the acting head of NASA, and Senate Commerce Committee Chair Ted Cruz (R-TX) also attended the tour. Duffy has said [aip.us17.list-manage.com] he wants the agency to focus on human exploration of the Moon and Mars and ditch its other programs, especially those related to Earth and climate science.

The Trump administration's 2026 budget request [aip.us17.list-manage.com] proposes slashing NASA's overall budget by \$6 billion, roughly a quarter, but also proposes an 8% increase in funding for human exploration. The House proposal, which Babin led, proposes an even larger boost to human exploration of 26%, with lesser but still substantial cuts to other programs adding up to flat funding for the agency. The House and the administration recommend cutting NASA's Earth science programs by 40% and 53%, respectively. The equivalent Senate proposal, led by Cruz, recommends flat funding for most of NASA's programs, including human exploration and Earth science. Babin and Cruz have worked together on a number of NASA-related issues lately, including a push to relocate NASA's headquarters [aip.us17.list-manage.com] to their state.

8/25/25: WP. Harvard's research is shrinking amid the Trump administration's freeze / The university is at a crossroads as it navigates lawsuits and negotiations to try to mitigate the damage to research

...The weaponization of federal funding, cast as a necessary step to end discrimination and antisemitism, is threatening lifesaving research and forcing agonizing choices. It's an inflection point for Harvard, for higher education – and, many argue, for the country – as the generations-long partnership between the federal government and research universities totters under the Trump administration.

Harvard sued in federal court, calling the funding cuts unconstitutional. Both sides have asked for a ruling in the case

without a trial. Even if the specific grants frozen at Harvard were suddenly restored, there is deep-rooted uncertainty about the future of science in the United States. One central question for many researchers is whether the country's support for basic science is ending. For more than 75 years, the federal government has funded research at universities aimed purely at gaining knowledge – like the questions Adelman asks about cells.

Companies typically don't fund that kind of basic science, because there isn't an immediate application that would be profitable. But the discoveries can lead to dramatic advancements in medicine, and innovations such as cellphones, GPS and MRI machines.

Harvard provided an additional \$250 million as bridge funding for its researchers as its lawsuits challenging the Trump administration's actions and talks play out. That money has provided a stopgap.

...But the research enterprise is already shrinking under the Trump administration's cuts, and the signs are all over Harvard. Earlier this summer, a lab administrator's desk stood empty, leaving faculty members to take over those tasks. A taped-up sign in a hallway urged grad students to ask for help if told to leave their lab, graduate early or take reduced pay. A postdoc had given up on applying for jobs related to the expertise he'd just spent a decade earning because he had to find a way to pay rent.

In July, Harvard's president, Alan Garber, acknowledged painful layoffs, confirmed to the campus that a hiring freeze for faculty and staff would continue, and explained that federal actions could leave a hole of almost \$1 billion a year in the university's budget.

The government took action against Harvard after the school refused to agree to Trump's demands in April, including lodging numerous federal investigations and threats to block international scholars from campus. Nearly one thousand grants worth more than \$2 billion were terminated. Some canceled grants at universities across the country funded research that touched on political issues such as diversity, equity and inclusion. But at Harvard, the administration has announced it will not give any federal research funding, period – for any topic.

A spokesman for the White House, Kush Desai, said the United States is home to the largest publicly and privately funded ecosystem of gold-standard research in the world, and that Trump has pledged to “cement America's dominance in cutting-edge technologies like AI, crypto and space exploration while addressing our chronic disease epidemic.” Desai said the Trump administration “is strengthening this ecosystem by slashing waste, fraud and abuse in federal research funding – including on DEI projects that only support ideological activism” and by cracking down on antisemitism.

...The federal government is hardly the only contributor to research at Harvard; in 2024, the school funded more than \$525 million in research, and private foundations and industry contributed more than \$300 million. But it is the biggest, providing more than \$680 million in research funding in 2024, according to the university. About 1,800 faculty and staff members are partially or entirely paid by federal research funding, according to court documents, and about 1,500 graduate students and postdoctoral researchers get financial support such as stipends.

In a system that accelerated after World War II, researchers at universities like Harvard have competed for federal grants that reflect national priorities. Research powers the economy and national security.

Federal research funding is also used to train scientists at universities, said Michael Gordin, dean of the college at Princeton University and a historian of science, in a system that he called "magically effective" and the envy of the world. "It takes about a decade to make a chemist. That's done in universities," he said, even for those going to work for companies. But that formula requires smart people willing to bet their future on that career path – a bet that feels increasingly risky now. "I don't know where we go from here," Gordin said, "if we don't have that system."

...People working on research with a political aspect know that funding can ebb and flow. But there has always been strong bipartisan support for the kind of work Adelman does.

Until this year.

In May, while away at a scientific conference, she got an email informing her that her grants were terminated. A colleague from Harvard saw her face and asked, "'Did you just get the email, too?'" "We just stood there in the middle of this meeting and hugged and fought back the tears," she said.

...If the standoff between Harvard and the Trump administration continues, researchers will continue to leave. Labs will shut down. And scientists will scale back their aspirations.

Comments...

I work at Harvard Medical School in a leadership role for a center that supports and trains future medical researchers. We have been supporting these early-career professionals for years, struggling to convince them that the sacrifices they will need to make to embark on a research career (even part-time) are worth it. Private practice can pay quite a bit more than a research career, and there's a significant time investment needed to obtain grants, gain independence, secure

funding, and start a lab. There's no glory in this work; many researchers who have discovered groundbreaking medicines and devices are far removed from the limelight. In my many years at the medical school, I've met the kindest, most down-to-earth physicians and scientists who are committed to healthcare – and their aspirations to serve their communities. Now we face even greater impediments to launch this future workforce. Who will be the scientists who take the lead on treating and curing diseases we might all face in years to come?

I spent many years at NIH working with medical post-docs who sought the extraordinary clinical research training NIH provided, and I know so many who, bolstered by that experience, are now leaders in their fields. It is tragic that this extraordinary training, both at NIH and NIH-supported programs at top-notch universities, is being trashed by trump and rfk.

If more people understood the role that research conducted at universities across the country plays in health care and science, they would be aghast at what is happening to the funding. Anyone who has received health care of any kind has benefited from that research. Further, the economic harm that will flow from cutting off so much of this research is almost unfathomable. It isn't just about these scientists' jobs. It's about the money spent beyond the universities that support the local economies: the small businesses that will go under because they lose a double-digit percentage of their customers; the loss of home sales and rentals that will distort the local housing communities, the loss of tax dollars paid into the local governments, etc..

Do you have any evidence that backs up your claims? Harvard sits in very well off Cambridge, Ma. Harvard is by far the most effected University.

You are wrong. Every university is hit by this administration. Science is over in the USA sadly

The rational course of action is not just stopgap funding but salvaging the research by moving it overseas and finding new sponsors. ... Park funds away of the reach of an extortion autocrat? Yes, this is a nightmare scenario. There will be no quick reversal.

It sickens me to know babies will die because of trump, right here in America.

I'm all for federal funding – which is to say my tax dollars – goes to medical and scientific research. But in the face of the cancellation of such funding to Harvard, why would not some of its \$53 billion endowment (!!!) not go toward making up for the short gap? What am I missing here?

What you are missing is that much of the endowment is targeted to other activities, a lot for scholarships, buildings and infrastructure, specific research fields, etc. It is not like a bank account that you can withdraw \$\$ and use it as you like.

Government funding for research is used to support research that the government wants to see carried out. Why should any university use its endowment (invested to support the long term growth of the university), to do the government's work? The problem American universities face now is a federal government that cannot hold a steady course. They'll respond appropriately – just like American corporations – start doing this work overseas.

You are missing that the funding was given to Harvard by Congress to do basic research to help advance medical, physical and biological sciences. The return on investment is on the order of 200–300% on every dollar spent. Harvard (or any other university) can't fund a moonshot on their own.

WaPo needs to do a better job of explaining how endowment's work. The university doesn't have the legal right to use every endowment they receive, in any way that they see fit. Many endowments are restricted. They were given on the condition that they only be used for specific purposes, and if the endowment is intended to provide funding in perpetuity, the principle must always remain intact, and only interest or investment income can be spent. If the endowment was restricted to a specific field, program, research, scholarship, etc., it can't be used for anything besides that purpose. Harvard's hands are probably tied regarding most of that \$54– or \$54-billion endowment total.

When a gift is made to the endowment for a specific purpose, that principal isn't spent. It's invested, and the returns on that investment are dedicated to fund the specific purpose of the gift. Those investment returns remain restricted, and cannot be used for other purposes.

The federal government is not “giving” this money to Harvard or other universities. They are in essence investing it with the return being discoveries that benefit the country's citizens many time over what the government invests.

Truly amazing how many people were apparently unhappy we had smart people.

High level research requires a complex ecosystem. It requires ultra sophisticated equipment suppliers, colleagues in adjacent fields of research, a continuous supply of doctoral and post doctoral fellows, often even cleaners with carefully developed training. This takes many

decades to evolve. Once it begins to deteriorate it cannot simply be replaced. This is what is happening now in the US. In the meantime China is pouring millions of dollars into research. How is this of benefit to the US?

"Why should we subsidize intellectual curiosity?"— Ronald Reagan
---And he was dead wrong. Many scientific breakthroughs come about because an expert or experts in their field do research and say, "That's funny—I didn't expect that..." In other words, it is a process of structured serendipity as contrasted with trying to hit the bullseye on a preconceived target. An example is vulcanized rubber (used in car tires) where a chemist allegedly spilled sulfur in molten rubber. For a scientific ecosystem to be healthy, we need to give the *experts* what they need to perform the work they love that *might* have the potential to benefit society, but focus less on some specific financial "payback". MBAs and risk-analysis freaks don't understand this, and certainly President Trump knows *nothing* about anything, except to capitalize on some immediate short-sighted return in terms of dollars and cents.

The politization of the funding wasn't by Trump, it was the Democrats pushing diversity agendas into science funding and shutting down anyone who wanted to oppose it. As well as the political weaponization vaccines vs Trump for political points. This is the predictable counter reaction. Harvard chose a "side" and now it is losing.

Did that make sense to anyone?? "Diversity agendas"?!?

It's not just Harvard. Medical research is being trashed throughout the country. It's a complete disaster.

It's not just medical research, it's all scientific research. I'm an earth scientist (oceanographer) and the cuts in our field are devastating as well. Just look at NOAA and NASA, everything from NSF....huge cuts everywhere.

The USA, in more rational times, made up for its poor educational standards by attracting overseas talent, concurrently with high levels of funding for research. Pandering via culture wars to the parochial nature of Americans has abruptly dried up the former and the latter has wilted under pressure from redirection of funds to billionaires tax cuts, and also evangelical and MAGA distrust of science and education. Science will suffer in the short term but the rest of the world is sensing an opportunity, and is taking it.

The rigorously competitive NIH and NSF funding for research is the best hope for future progress. This shouldn't be political. But it is. All done for cheap points about elitism, coming from Musk/Trump/Heritage/etc. Please vote against this self-destructive foolishness in midterms 2026 and sooner here in VA this November.

Trump is knee-capping our country's ability to compete internationally and severely undermining national security by interfering with important research that could help our military.

Basic research is the lifeblood of our economy and our standard of living. The Trump administration's attack on research, research institutions, and researchers is demonstrably weakening America by the day. We are the process of losing our world leadership status in all important research areas. And at the same time ceding our leadership to China. All because a thin-skinned, wannabe dictator and his minions are intimidated by people who are actually a lot smarter than they are. The destruction being wrought today will take decades to overcome, even if it is possible to overcome. MAGA, you voted for the destruction of America!

I have been carrying a sign that says: "Nobody voted to defund cancer research".to multiple protests. A man in his 40's yelled at me during the last protest and said, I did! Shame on me for thinking nobody with half a brain would be against funding cancer research.

8/27/25: WP. White House fires CDC director who says RFK Jr. is 'weaponizing public health' / Susan Monarez was confirmed as the CDC's director in July. Three top agency officials announced resignations as the Trump administration moved to oust her.

The White House on Wednesday fired Susan Monarez as director of the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention after she refused to resign amid pressure to change vaccine policy, which sparked the resignation of other senior CDC officials and a showdown over whether she could be removed.

Hours after the Department of Health and Human Services announced early Wednesday evening that Monarez was no longer the director, her lawyers responded with a fiery statement saying she had not resigned or been fired. They accused HHS Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. of "weaponizing public health for political gain" and "putting millions of American lives at risk" by purging health officials from government.

"When CDC Director Susan Monarez refused to rubber-stamp unscientific, reckless directives and fire dedicated health experts, she chose protecting the public over serving a political agenda," the lawyers, Mark S. Zaid and Abbe Lowell, wrote in a statement. "For that reason, she has been targeted."

Soon after their statement, the White House formally fired Monarez.

...Wednesday's shake-ups – which include the resignation of the

agency's

chief medical officer, the director of its infectious-disease center and other key officials – add to the tumult at the nation's premier public health agency.

...Monarez, who was confirmed in late July, was pressed for days by Kennedy, administration lawyers and other officials over whether she would support rescinding certain approvals for coronavirus vaccines, according to two people with knowledge of those conversations. Kennedy, who has a long history of anti-vaccine advocacy, and other officials questioned Monarez on Monday on whether she was aligned with the administration's efforts to change vaccine policy, the people said.

Kennedy and one of his top advisers, Stefanie Spear, also pushed Monarez to fire her senior staff by the end of this week, according to an administration official and another person with direct knowledge of that conversation. Spear did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

Monarez, who was a longtime federal government scientist before President Donald Trump nominated her to lead the CDC, declined to commit to support changing coronavirus vaccine policy without consulting her advisers, two people said. That prompted Kennedy to urge her to resign for "not supporting President Trump's agenda," one of the people said.

...Demetre Daskalakis, the CDC's top respiratory illness and immunization official, posted his scathing resignation letter on X where he blasted Kennedy and his appointees for unraveling coronavirus vaccine recommendations, which he said "threaten the lives of the youngest Americans and pregnant people."

"I am not sure who the Secretary is listening to, but it is quite certainly not to us. Unvetted and conflicted outside organizations seem to be the sources HHS use over the gold standard science of CDC and other reputable sources," Daskalakis wrote. "At a hearing, Secretary Kennedy said that Americans should not take medical advice from him. To the contrary, an appropriately briefed and inquisitive Secretary should be a source of health information for the people he serves. As it stands now, I must agree with him, that he should not be considered a source of accurate information."

...Before becoming HHS secretary, Kennedy had falsely called the coronavirus vaccines the "deadliest vaccine ever made" and said they contained a "poison."

...The agency had been reeling from the gunman's Aug. 8 attack on its Atlanta headquarters, which forced hundreds of workers into lockdown and left a police officer dead. The shooter was frustrated by the

coronavirus vaccine and blamed it for his health problems, according to law enforcement officials, neighbors and his father. Trump has not publicly addressed the shooting.

Comments...

I want to believe that because we survived 45, we can survive 47, but there are days I'm not so sure. This is one of them.

My local public radio today had a segment today with national physician vaccination leaders discussing where people are to get vaccine recommendations going forward since THE CDC CAN NO LONGER BE TRUSTED. I am a physician and in my mind this is simply the new reality that any CDC/HHS pronouncement or decision on vaccines cannot be trusted full stop. They pointed to The American Academy of Pediatrics, The American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists, the Public Health Agency of Canada and the European Center for Disease Prevention and Control. But of course this is a tall task to require even high information citizens to seek out and parse through alternative recommendations and then further figure out if the vaccine will be made available to them and whether they have to pay out of pocket.

I'm still astounded and appalled that a lawyer who sues vaccine manufacturers for a living is now deciding who gets vaccines and who doesn't.

Last reports I heard out of DC insiders was that he's considering banning covid vaccines & mRNA tech process use all together – meaning they won't be available for purchase either. Incidentally that could negatively impact vaccine production and distribution beyond the US in conjunction with USAID dissolution. He'll be a mass murderer & should be held accountable

Thanks Susan for standing up for CDC employees and the agency after the shooting. Trump didn't even acknowledge the horror employees felt after the incident where a police officer died

8/28/25: WP. CDC leaders who resigned said RFK Jr. undermined vaccine science, risking lives / As the CDC reels from departures, the White House appoints Jim O'Neill as acting director.

As the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention reeled from the ousting of its director, three senior leaders who resigned in protest told The Washington Post they were asked to participate in an unscientific vaccine recommendation process that they believe could harm the health of Americans.

...Demetre Daskalakis, who resigned as the agency's top respiratory illness and immunization official, said the CDC had reached an "unfettered situation where undue influence and ideology would drive the science."

The criticism from departing CDC leaders prompted Sen. Bill Cassidy (R-Louisiana), who chairs the Senate's health committee and cast a pivotal vote to confirm Kennedy, to call for the delay of an upcoming meeting of Kennedy's vaccine advisers to review vaccine recommendations. "These decisions directly impact children's health and the meeting should not occur until significant oversight has been conducted," Cassidy said in a statement.

...As the founder of an anti-vaccine group, Kennedy has a history of falsely linking vaccines to autism and other unscientific claims. Kennedy has criticized the CDC often, calling it a "cesspool of corruption" and arguing it's in the pocket of the pharmaceutical industry.

Since taking the nation's top health job, Kennedy has continued to disparage those who work in public health, saying in an interview after a gunman who opposed coronavirus vaccines fired hundreds of rounds at the CDC's Atlanta headquarters this month that public health agencies "have not been honest." CDC employees grew angry at Kennedy's response to the shooting, arguing that he is responsible for misinformation that has turned citizens against public health workers. Hundreds of current and former HHS and CDC workers called for Kennedy to resign following the shooting.

...Monarez wrote an op-ed about the attack on the CDC buildings and how vaccine misinformation can be harmful and drive violent rhetoric, according to Houry. But when Monarez sent the op-ed to HHS for clearance, it was returned to her with "significant revisions" and Monarez no longer wanted to submit it "because it was no longer her voice," according to Houry, who said Monarez told her what happened.

Comments...

I remember as a young Elementary school student lining up to get the newly created and released vaccine. I had a few friends in iron lungs and was pretty positive it would interfere with my sports activities, but the fact that every kid's parents were there to see their child get vaccinated really impressed me. All of the mothers were crying with relief and many of the father's eyes were watery with tears. As a scientist in my later years, I am outraged that one of my adult children will not qualify for CDC guidelines and none of my grandchildren can receive it.

[cont] Our health decisions are being made by a lawyer who rather thinks he knows more than the Medical and Scientific experts, even

though he has absolutely no knowledge of experimental design or analysis of data. This is a lawyer who has fired anyone qualified to make vaccine safety decisions and replaced them with quacks, opportunistic influencers, and political ideologists. The few replacements for qualified scientists with medical degrees are not scientists or so far out in left field that any medical opinion they have on vaccines would fail to pass peer review.

RFK Jr. may be qualified to research legal cases, but he hasn't a clue on how to conduct or evaluate medical research. For the first time in my life, I can not trust anything the majority of Federal agencies say because the opinions or statements are coming from people who are totally incompetent in their fields or they have no actual experience or education on what they are regulating, just ideological political purity.

Every kid's parents were there? There were no parents, permission slips or debates when I received the first available Salk polio vaccine. The public health workers came to the school, grabbed us by class batches, willing or not, we were all vaccinated and the iron lung wards started to close in the state hospitals. That was a public health miracle, and couldn't happen today because everything seems to be a cause for debate or a matter of viewpoint, mostly ignorant, ill informed or malicious.

Actually clarkii, he cant even perform legal research properly because he can't differentiate between facts and opinions. This is the same failing as with vaccines, no matter the field.

The whole world is laughing at the stupidity of this administration and especially the extraordinary dumb decisions of the HHS Secretary Kennedy who was appointed to this post only because of his loyalty to the Dictator in Chief. Immediate firing of this incompetent can hopefully restore the proven scientific approach to the health of Americans before it's too late.

I remind readers that two parents whose unvaccinated child died of measles during the Texas outbreak said they didn't intend to have their other children vaccinated. That is the kind of intransigence we are up against.

Kennedy means so much to so many people. We should believe him because he has a name that doesn't just rhyme with that of a famous president, but is actually the same. As a former trial lawyer he is uniquely qualified to view evidence in a balanced manner without being partial because that's the opposite of what trial lawyers do. The fact that he got his job as a direct quid pro quo for a Trump endorsement is also reassuring. Who better to root out conflicts of interest than someone who received his job as a benefit for a political favor? I hope I've

reassured some of the naysayers. Everything is going to be fine. Please go back to your regularly scheduled political infotainment.

Several years ago I had lunch with two retired nurses who graduated with me from 8th grade in 1956. I mentioned that we had been a "tough" generation who got all the childhood diseases (measles, mumps, chicken pox) before vaccines were developed and we all survived. After a long silence, the nurses said that they spent their entire careers attending to people who suffered long term consequences from those diseases. And, I even learned that one of the nurses got polio as a child before the vaccine was developed. I felt like a fool.

8/29/25: Van Scoyoc Washington Week in Science

White House restores stalled CDC research funds

Tens of millions of dollars in funding for health programs run by the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) that had been blocked by the Trump administration is being released to grantees. According to several CDC employees, the White House Office of Management and Budget (OMB) approved the agency's spending plans for specific grants, which had been held up since at least the end of July. Read more: [The Hill](#)

RFK Jr cancels \$500m in funding for mRNA vaccines for diseases like Covid

The US Department of Health and Human Services (HHS) plans to cancel \$500m in funding for mRNA vaccines being developed to counter viruses that cause diseases such as the flu and Covid-19. That will impact 22 projects being led by major pharmaceutical companies, including Pfizer and Moderna, for vaccines against bird flu and other viruses, HHS said. Health Secretary Robert F Kennedy Jr, a vaccine sceptic, announced he was pulling the funding over claims that "mRNA technology poses more risks than benefits for these respiratory viruses". Read more: [BBC News](#)

Supreme Court allows NIH to axe millions of research funds related to DEI

The Supreme Court will allow the National Institutes of Health to cut millions of dollars allocated for research funds as the Trump administration continues its effort to bar federal funds from supporting diversity, equity and inclusion. The court ruled 5-4 on Thursday to allow the administration to cancel \$783 million in previously allocated grants, reversing a lower court's order blocking the cuts. However, the justices left in place a portion of the lower court's ruling that threw out the original guidance

documents outlining the policies, raising questions about whether the administration will be able to withhold research dollars for similar reasons moving forward. Read more: [Health Care Div](#)

GSA launches search for new Alexandria office space to house displaced National Science Foundation

The General Services Administration has launched an official search for office space [[vsadc.us4.list-manage.com](#)] in Alexandria to relocate the National Science Foundation after the agency was displaced from its Eisenhower Avenue headquarters [[vsadc.us4.list-manage.com](#)]. The search comes as the Trump administration announced [[vsadc.us4.list-manage.com](#)] that the Department of Housing and Urban Development would take over NSF's current headquarters at 2415 Eisenhower Ave., forcing the research funding agency to find new accommodations. HUD Secretary Scott Turner, Virginia Gov. Glenn Youngkin, and GSA Commissioner Michael Peters made the announcement at the NSF headquarters, emphasizing taxpayer savings and improved working conditions for HUD employees. Read more: [NSF](#)

NSF invests over \$74 million in 6 mathematical sciences research institutes

The U.S. National Science Foundation is investing over \$74 million in six research institutes focused on the mathematical sciences and their broad applications in all fields of science, technology and many industries. Reflecting the universal usefulness of the mathematical sciences, the institutes have partnered with and received support from a broad range of public and private organizations, including the U.S. Department of Energy's Argonne National Laboratory, the Air Force Research Laboratory, NASA Goddard Space Flight Center, Advanced Micro Devices, IBM, Microsoft, the Gates Foundation, the Simons Foundation and many others. Read more: [NSF](#)

SEPTEMBER

9/5/25: IHE. UC System Warns of Broader Risks in Federal Funding Fight

The University of California system is warning state lawmakers that federal funding cuts could extend well beyond UCLA as tensions between the Trump administration and American colleges continue to rise.

UC president James B. Milliken wrote a letter to dozens of local elected officials Tuesday explaining that "the stakes are high and the risks are very real." The system's 10 institutions could lose billions

of dollars in aid, forcing its leaders to make tough calls about staffing, the continuation of certain academic programs and more, he said.

PRESIDENT TRUMP HAS ALREADY FROZEN MORE THAN \$500 MILLION IN GRANTS AT UCLA, allegedly because the Justice Department accused the university of violating Jewish students' civil rights. THE PRESIDENT DEMANDED THE UNIVERSITY PAY A \$1.2 BILLION FINE TO UNLOCK THE FUNDS, and system officials are worried that more funding cuts are likely. California lawmakers have repeatedly urged the UC system not to capitulate. Most Popular

In an August letter, State Sen. Scott Wiener, a Democrat and chair of the Joint Legislative Budget Committee, and 33 other lawmakers told Milliken that Trump's actions were "an extortion attempt and a page out of the authoritarian playbook," the Los Angeles Times reported.

Milliken wrote in Tuesday's letter that a loss in funding would "devastate" the system and harm students, among other groups.

"Classes and student services would be reduced, patients would be turned away, tens of thousands of jobs would be lost, and we would see UC's world-renowned researchers leaving our state for other more seemingly stable opportunities in the US or abroad," he wrote.

If the UC system loses federal funding, it would need about \$4 to \$5 billion a year to make up the difference, Milliken added. "That is what fighting for the people of California will take."

9/5/24: FYI. House Joins Senate in Rejecting Drastic NIH Cuts Pushed by Trump / The House has proposed a nearly \$500 million cut to NIH, far short of the White House's request.

Congress is on track to reject the Trump administration's proposal to gut funding for the National Institutes of Health.

The House Appropriations Committee's Labor, Health and Human Services, Education and Related Agencies Subcommittee unveiled its fiscal year 2026 budget plans this week. Committee members voted 11-7 to advance the bill during a markup session on Tuesday, with Democrats opposing.

While the committee has yet to publish a full breakdown of its spending proposal, a Democrat press release says the bill will include a \$47.8 billion budget for NIH – a reduction of \$456 million, but far short of the \$19.4 billion cut proposed in President Donald Trump's budget request. The House proposal also appears to reject White House plans to restructure NIH's 27 institutes and centers.

The Senate has proposed increasing NIH's budget to \$48.7 billion for fiscal year 2026. Senators also rejected plans to reorganize NIH and included a reminder in their appropriations bill that 24 of the NIH's institutes and centers were established in statute, and that plans to restructure them should be communicated to the Senate and the House with ample notice.

House Appropriations Committee Chairman Tom Cole (R-OK) said in an online statement that the budget proposal directs taxpayer dollars "where they matter most" and "prioritizes cutting-edge biomedical research." At the markup hearing on Tuesday, Ranking Member Rosa DeLauro (D-CT) disagreed – urging her colleagues to block the bill.

"The bill cuts NIH research funding by \$500 million," DeLauro said. "This comes as Russ Vought [director of the Office of Management and Budget] has canceled previously awarded grants, throwing away potential life-saving cures or treatments and wasting millions of dollars in the process."

DeLauro added that the proposed NIH cuts are "sad" because for "eight straight years" she worked with Cole to provide annual increases for NIH research. "Biomedical research used to be a bipartisan priority in the Congress," DeLauro said. "Sadly, those days are gone."

While the House's proposed NIH budget does include a boost for some NIH institutes – such as an additional \$48 million for the National Cancer Institute, bringing its budget to nearly \$7.3 billion – it also includes a significant cut to the Advanced Research Projects Agency-Health. Under the House's proposal, ARPA-H's budget would fall by \$555 million to \$945 million. DeLauro and other Democrats on the committee also voiced concerns about proposed cuts to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. The House bill proposes a \$1.7 billion cut to the CDC, bringing its budget down to \$7.4 billion. The Senate has proposed a cut of \$70 million – a 0.8% reduction that contrasts sharply with the 19% cut proposed by the House.

The proposed CDC budget cuts come as the agency faces a leadership crisis following the ouster of former CDC Director Susan Monarez and pressure from Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. to change vaccine policies. Kennedy defended his actions in a Senate Finance Committee hearing on the administration's health care agenda this week.

Speaking at the subcommittee markup on Tuesday, Rep. Bonnie Watson Coleman (D-NJ) said there is a "clear crisis of confidence in this administration's management of the CDC."

"This bill signals to the men and women charged with keeping our country safe from disease that they are not valued, that this administration does not believe in their mission, that science must take a back seat to the ego and the arrogance of the health secretary

and the president," said Watson Coleman. "That's not going to make America healthy; it's going to make and keep us sick," she added.

Congress has less than a month to decide how to fund the federal government for fiscal year 2026, which begins Oct. 1, or face a partial government shutdown. Have a news tip for us? Contact the author on Signal at lindsaymck.24 or via email at lmckenzie@aip.org.

9/6/25: (Sat) A post on the Facebook "Astronomers" Group from Shane Davis (UVa):

It is my understanding that a significant number of researchers had their NASA supercomputing accounts first disabled and then terminated without warning in the last couple of days. Everyone I have heard about this happening to was a Chinese citizen in the US on a visa. I will be contacting my university's research office because this directly impacts my research, so I would appreciate if anyone who knows more about this could share information or point me to any media coverage of this (I do not see any at this time). My worry is that this affects a significant number of astronomers, but only a small number of people at any single institution, so that there will not be effective pushback.

[No add'l comments yet]

9/10/25: Nature editorial. Climate impacts are real & denying this is self-defeating / The US administration is attempting to undermine efforts to curb greenhouse-gas emissions. It will ultimately leave that country, and the world, worse off. [Captured full PDF version]

In July, the administration of US President Donald Trump announced formally that the US Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) would seek to overturn its 2009 ruling that greenhouse-gas emissions endanger public health and welfare. The move would negate the legal foundation for many climate regulations. The agency in charge of protecting the nation's environmental and public health is now arguing that climate researchers have overstated the perils of global warming.

The EPA's proposal defies the established findings of leading climate researchers and laboratories, not least those of the United States. That the world's largest greenhouse-gas emitter, as measured by cumulative emissions over time, is abandoning its nascent moves towards decarbonization -- and doing so on such spurious, unscientific grounds -- should be ringing alarm bells everywhere.

...In support of the EPA's deregulatory proposal, the Department of Energy (DOE) has published an unprecedented critique of mainstream

climate science (see go.nature.com/4mtwsm5). If implemented, the proposal would be the first time that a globally respected, science-based regulatory agency has so thoroughly departed from the scientific consensus on global warming, represented by the work of thousands of scientists under the auspices of the IPCC over several decades. That consensus is, for good reason, the basis of both international law on climate change and hundreds of national laws and concurrent actions to stop anthropogenic climate change.

Taking just one of many examples, the DOE report critiques IPCC findings describing how human-generated emissions are leading to extreme weather. This is despite the fact that, year after year, climate-attribution science is getting more accurate.

...The stakes could not be higher: the United States is the currently second-largest emitter of greenhouse gases, behind China. What the United States does on climate will affect billions of people. This is the threat posed by the Trump administration, which is promoting a dangerous fossil-fuel agenda, rolling back investments in clean-energy technologies and seeking to block the EPA's authority to regulate greenhouse-gas emissions, both now and into the future. Leading climate scientists have crafted a formal response (see go.nature.com/41j3fsa), arguing that the DOE's report makes a mockery of science by misrepresenting, cherry-picking or outright ignoring evidence compiled by scientists around the world over the past several decades. Ultimately the United States, and the world, will emerge the poorer for it.

9/11/25: From: FYI: Science Policy News from AIP

September 11, 2025

House Science Committee Advances Weather Research Bill

The reauthorization act received unanimous, bipartisan support, but a similar bill passed the House and stalled in the Senate last year.

A bipartisan bill for weather research advanced out of the House Science Committee on Wednesday by unanimous vote. The Weather Act Reauthorization reaffirms and updates NOAA research, forecasting, and emergency preparedness programs authorized in the 2017 Weather Research and Forecasting Innovation Act. The bill recommends between \$160 million and \$170 million each year through 2030 for NOAA's research office to carry out specified weather research programs, roughly steady with the program amounts for fiscal year 2024. "I've seen firsthand that accurate and reliable weather forecasting is crucial for the day-to-day lives of Americans nationwide," bill co-sponsor and former Committee Chair Frank Lucas (R-OK) said in a press release. "Protecting American citizens and industries stands at the heart of President Trump's America First agenda, so I look forward

to seeing this bill reach his desk to be signed into law," he added.

The House passed similar reauthorization legislation in April 2024, but the bill did not receive a committee vote in the Senate.

"By taking up this proven framework, we are establishing a clear and united House position heading into potential negotiations with the United States Senate," Committee Chair Brian Babin (R-TX) said in his opening statement, adding that he looks forward to working with Senate Commerce Committee Chair Ted Cruz (R-TX) on severe weather preparedness.

The implementation of the 2017 Weather Act has advanced hurricane tracking predictions by over 10% and improved tornado warning lead times by more than 10 minutes, Babin said. In July, the National Weather Service's warnings of flash floods in Texas had a 201-minute lead time, he added.

"Yet, despite that warning, many precious lives were tragically lost," Babin said. "This heartbreaking event underscores the urgent need to strengthen the connection between forecasts and the timely flow of information to the public." Babin also highlighted that the reauthorization bill directs NOAA to create a pilot program to enter into contracts with private companies providing observation services and data. If the program meets NOAA's standards, the bill directs the agency to use private observation services and data "when cost-effective and feasible," including during acquisition of any future satellite systems. The bill recommends \$100 million each year through 2030 for the commercial data program.

Ranking Member Zoe Lofgren (D-CA) said the bill will advance data assimilation, which she called "our most significant limitation in forecasting accuracy today." Data assimilation is a weather forecasting technique that combines real-world observations with a predictive model. The bill would create a program to test data assimilation methods, including using machine learning, as well as a university consortium to support research and draw students to the field. The bill also includes a provision to expedite hiring and onboarding of National Weather Service employees. Rep. Deborah Ross (D-NC), speaking in favor of the bill, criticized the administration's workforce cuts to NOAA earlier this year. "This bill makes clear that no matter our political differences, we all agree that safeguarding lives through accurate forecasting, sustained weather research funding, and timely alerts must remain a national priority," she said. "Unfortunately, the recent DOGE cuts threatened the very foundation of our weather infrastructure."

Other Democrats also spoke in support of the bill, noting that it incorporates several smaller bills co-sponsored with Republican colleagues. These include bills that aim to boost weather and climate

prediction using advanced computing, and to improve precipitation forecasts by replacing aging Next Generation Weather Radar (NEXRAD) infrastructure and supporting NOAA Earth system models. Committee members did not mention the administration's proposal to eliminate NOAA's research office. President Donald Trump's budget request for fiscal year 2026 preserves about a quarter of the office's funding, including for the weather programs prioritized in the reauthorization bill, by moving it to other NOAA offices. The Senate and House appropriations committees have both put forth proposals preserving the research office, but neither chamber has passed its bill.

The committee unanimously adopted many of the offered amendments from both Republicans and Democrats, while Republicans passed amendments along party lines to block NOAA from purchasing drones from Chinese-owned companies and to strike a mention of "communities of color, low-income communities, Indian Tribes or Indigenous communities, and rural communities." Democrats withdrew amendments to continue leveraging NASA's expertise in acquiring environmental satellites and to authorize the National Integrated Heat Health Information System, saying they would continue to work across the aisle on those topics.

9/11/25: From: American Astronomical Society <aas@aas.org>
Subject: Not All That Glitters Is Gold – Get Up, Stand Up

A message from AAS President Dara Norman, expressing her perspective on the OSTP's Agency Guidance for Gold Standard Science and urging our members to be steadfast in supporting the AAS's mission.

Not All That Glitters Is Gold – Get Up, Stand Up

Dear Colleagues,

Throughout my career, one of my goals has been to use my insider knowledge of how our field operates to work on making and supporting changes that better serve all scientists. For many years, I have been discussing our current scientific culture and how it has not been working well for all members of the astronomy community. I have been using my work and platform to promote workforce development and user support to ensure that a rising tide doesn't capsize the smallest boats, but that we all are able to pursue science goals as a collaborative armada.

This is why, when the OSTP sent out their "Agency Guidance for Implementing Gold Standard Science in the Conduct and Management of Scientific Activities," I chose to read it as if I were reading a dual anonymous proposal... what are the ideas put forth and not who is the messenger. That document described several activities and methods that the astronomy community has already adopted to ensure excellence in

selecting, implementing, and monitoring research and education programs and projects, including dual anonymous reviews of proposals. The OSTP document also addresses some areas where the scientific community (and industry) could do better, like with accessibility, openness, and transparency, as well as collaboration and interdisciplinary communication. The document even mentions "viewpoint diversity," which many of us have long pursued, since viewpoints come from a wide range of experiences.

The tenets of a 'Gold Standard' for science have been implemented for many years in the astronomical sciences. Peer review of proposals and projects allows for rigorous scrutiny to ensure high-quality research and worthwhile projects. As part of our culture, the community has been striving to continually implement good and improved practices for reviews and selection. Evidence of the success of current processes is seen in the achievement, benefit, and value of the science that is produced through this process, and the leadership role that the US occupies in the global science community. These are spectacularly manifested by the science coming from flagship facilities, like Rubin, DKIST, JWST, Juno, etc., and innovative partnerships between agencies (e.g., DESI, NEID) and internationally, like ALMA.

However, as I have argued previously, anonymous review cannot be the whole answer to improving access or inclusion because mission objectives require that we understand from where the information comes – its motivations and intentions. To give a fair assessment of what is being communicated, the whole message and its context must be understood. This is why I am concerned about the executive order (EO) issued on 7 August, entitled "Improving Oversight of Federal Grantmaking." This EO is, in many instances, at odds even with the Gold Standard Science activities laid out in the OSTP directive. In particular, this EO calls for advisory expertise to be replaced with cronyism, and scientific rigor to be seen as on par with misinformation when it comes to grant selection. Such assertions are not just bad for science; they are antithetical to scientific discovery.

In the astronomical sciences, we have a culture of review, questioning, experimentation, and decision-making based on credible evidence. However, we have taken for granted that scientists are the most qualified and best equipped to understand and critique science proposals and papers through peer review. The recent EO attempts to dismiss that history and rigor. As scientists, educators, and researchers, we need to step up our involvement in supporting and advocating for expert peer review processes, if we wish to retain our advisory and decision-making responsibility and privilege! We are seeing, in this new era, that if we don't explain and advocate for this privilege, there are those who stand ready to remove scientific review from the jurisdiction of scientists. This is not to say that our system has always been perfectly implemented, but it is better

than an alternative that looks to minimize the importance of expertise, data, and evidence in decision-making. The AAS is leading an effort across a wide range of science societies to alert Congress to the serious harm that could be done by this EO and urge Congress to provide needed oversight. However, we cannot do this without your support. It is critical that we maintain the groundswell of grassroots advocacy for science to bolster the efforts being carried out by science societies in DC.

As with all of my messages, I am calling on you to please stay engaged in the fight to keep science flourishing in the US, by advocating for its funding, the development of its workforce, and the need to keep scientific voices and expertise front and center in its implementation! We must continue to do this nationally and locally. We must speak to the public about our work and how it matters, inspires, and leads to further advancements. We also need to remind our colleagues that a diverse and supported workforce is key to driving innovation and advancing astronomical discovery. Science cannot continue without scientists. Only through these efforts can we recognize the AAS vision, "to create a world where all people value and benefit from a scientific understanding of our universe." At the AAS, we will continue to monitor, inform the community, and address concerns for the well-being of astronomical research and education, but it is up to the AAS membership to be steadfast in supporting our mission to enhance and share humanity's scientific understanding of the universe as a diverse and inclusive astronomical community.

See <https://aas.org/public-policy-updates> for more information on getting involved, and take a few minutes today to write to your members of Congress (even if you have done so before).

Don't give up the fight!

– Dara Norman, AAS President

Background image: A wide-field image of the Christmas Tree Cluster, also known as NGC2264. Credit: T.A. Rector (NRAO/AUI/NSF and NOIRLab/NSF/AURA) and B.A. Wolpa (NOIRLab/NSF/AURA)

9/12/25: FYI Subject: 'Nearly Unmanageable' Research Regulations Tackled by New Academies Report

'Nearly Unmanageable' Research Regulations Tackled by New Academies Report

A committee convened by the National Academies recently produced 53 proposals to reduce the red tape surrounding federally funded research without sacrificing its integrity, security, or value.

The recommendations published last week are the result of an expedited effort to inform the Trump administration's push to cut regulations and reduce federal funding for research.

"With federal research agencies facing billions of dollars in budget cuts and reductions in staffing, there is not only the opportunity but the necessity to optimize the nation's investment in academic research by allocating more time and money to conducting research and reducing the time and money spent on administrative tasks," the report states.

Science advocates, including leaders at the National Academies and groups such as COGR, an association of research institutions that advocates for research policy, have long called on Congress and the federal government to reduce the regulatory burden on researchers and research administrators by streamlining requirements across federal agencies, but the report finds that relatively little progress has been made and that regulations have continued to proliferate.

"This year, significant federal actions and policy changes, some of which have come quickly without sufficient implementation guidance and consideration of their effects on the scientific enterprise, have added administrative workloads and created uncertainty, especially for research universities," the report states.

"There is a tremendous amount of regulation and policies that overlay on the conduct of science, and there is great concern that the excessive, uncoordinated, and sometimes duplicative or inconsistent policies are hampering progress in science," Committee Chair Alan Leshner said during a report release webinar last week.

While the 120-page report recognizes the need for checks and balances to ensure federally funded research is conducted responsibly, Leshner noted in his introduction to the report that the growing list of federal requirements has created a "nearly unmanageable" workload for researchers, administrators, and research funders.

To reduce that workload, the report proposes several options that policymakers could pursue to centralize oversight of the research regulation landscape and increase coordination between agencies. The report cautions, however, that progress may be difficult to achieve given legislative barriers, a lack of trust between research agencies, and unwillingness by institutions to support change given the "the upset reform can cause."

"There's no way that what we are calling for can happen unless somebody is in charge, somebody makes it happen, and some individual or group provides the coordination among the over 20 agencies so that they are, in fact, working together," Leshner said during the webinar.

The report proposes changes to grant proposal and management processes, research misconduct investigations, conflict of interest disclosures, research security requirements, export controls, cybersecurity standards, and the regulation of research involving biological agents, humans, and animals. Each proposal in the report is accompanied by a list of pros and cons that highlight potential barriers to implementation.

9/12/25: Van Scoyoc Associates

House Appropriations Committee approves CDC funding cut

The House Appropriations Committee approved the FY2026 Labor-HHS-Education Appropriations bill Tuesday. The bill cuts funding for the Centers for Disease Control (CDC) by \$1.7 billion. CDC programs recommended for elimination include Domestic and Global HIV/AIDS Prevention and Research, Sexually Transmitted Diseases, Tuberculosis, Tobacco Prevention and Control, School Health, Prevention Research Centers, Community and Youth Violence Prevention, Climate and Health, the Preventative Health and Health Services Block Grant, and some Global Vaccination activities, among others. Read more: House FY2026 Labor-HHS-Education Appropriations, House FY2026 Labor-HHS-Education Appropriations -- Democrats

House Appropriations Committee rebuffs administration on NIH funding

The House FY2026 Labor-HHS-Education Appropriations bill approved on Tuesday includes a total of \$47.8 billion for NIH, a decrease of \$456 million below the 2025 level. The administration had requested an \$18 billion cut. The bill includes: \$7.3 billion for the National Cancer Institute (NCI), an increase of \$48 million above the 2025 level; \$2.3 billion for the National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases (NIDDK), an increase of \$20 million above the 2025 level; \$2.6 billion for the National Institute of Neurological Disorders and Stroke (NINDS), an increase of \$30 million above the 2025 level; \$6.6 billion for the National Institute of Allergy and Infectious Diseases (NIAID), an increase of \$20 million above the 2025 level; \$945 million for the Advanced Research Projects Agency for Health (ARPA-H), a decrease of \$555 million below the 2025 level. The bill and report does not approve the administration's proposal to streamline and eliminate NIH institutes, but noted the House Energy and Commerce Committee has jurisdiction over large-scale NIH restructuring. Read more: House FY2026 Labor-HHS-Education Appropriations, House FY2026 Labor-HHS-Education Appropriations -- Democrats

MAHA strategy released: Targets vaccines, chronic disease, childhood nutrition

The Trump administration released a new strategy report for how it plans to implement its efforts to "Make America Healthy Again" (MAHA), seeking to make changes to vaccines but sidestepping calls to regulate pesticides and toxic chemicals. The strategy report builds upon a previous report outlining what the administration sees as threats to public health, talking about how it will implement a vision largely driven by Health and Human Services (HHS) Secretary Robert. F. Kennedy Jr. In particular, it seeks policy action on vaccines, setting up a "vaccine framework" to be developed by the White House Domestic Policy Council and Kennedy's department. The report also calls for working to "reform the approval process" for chemicals and pesticides, but does not specify what those reforms will be other than to say the goal is to protect against pests and "increase the timely availability of more innovative growing solutions for farmers." Read more: The Hill

US death rate dropped back to pre-Covid levels in 2024,

CDC report says The death rate in the United States returned to pre-pandemic levels in 2024 as Covid-19 fell out of the top 10 leading causes of death, according to a report published Wednesday by the US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention. The overall US death rate has fallen about 18% since 2021, and last year's 4% drop brought the US death rate down to the lowest it's been since 2019. Read more: CNN

House appropriators offer support to threatened NASA missions

House appropriators offered support, but no specific funding, for several NASA missions slated for cancellation in the administration's 2026 budget proposal. The House Appropriations Committee approved a commerce, justice and science (CJS) spending bill on a 34-28 vote late Sept. 10, sending the measure to the full House. The bill includes \$24.838 billion for NASA, nearly the same as the \$24.875 billion the agency received in fiscal 2024 and 2025, and far above the \$18.8 billion the administration proposed for fiscal 2026 in May. The report includes language expressing support for several NASA missions targeted for cancellation, including the Chandra X-ray Observatory, the Juno mission at Jupiter and the New Horizons mission in the Kuiper Belt. Read more: Space News

NASA blocks Chinese nationals from working on its space programs

NASA has begun barring Chinese nationals with valid visas from joining its programs, underscoring the intensifying space race between the US and China. The policy shift was first reported by Bloomberg News and confirmed by the US government agency. "NASA has taken internal action pertaining to Chinese nationals, including restricting physical and cybersecurity access to our facilities, materials and network to ensure the security of our work," NASA press secretary Bethany Stevens

said on Wednesday. According to Bloomberg, Chinese nationals had previously been allowed to work as contractors or students contributing to research, although not as staff. Read more: [The Guardian](#)

House Appropriations Committee approves NSF funding cut

On Wednesday, the House Appropriations Committee approved the Commerce, Justice, Science (CJS) and Related Agencies Appropriations Act, which would provide an estimated \$76.8 billion for 2026, a 2.8% cut from the 2025 fiscal year, which ends Sept. 30. The bill would give \$7 billion to the National Science Foundation in 2026, a \$2 billion drop from 2025. Read more: [House Commerce-Justice-Science Appropriations](#)

Federal judge declines to restore \$1B in grants cut by NSF

A federal judge on Wednesday declined to restore more than \$1 billion in research grants cut by the National Science Foundation over research related to diversity, equity and inclusion while a lawsuit against the agency goes forward. In the ruling, U.S. District Judge Jia Cobb concluded that the court didn't have the jurisdiction to temporarily restore the grants and that plaintiffs failed to show they would experience "irreparable harm" from the agency's new anti-DEI policies while the case proceeds. Read more: [Higher Ed Dive](#)

House panel protects NOAA labs, research from Trump cuts

The House Appropriations Committee approved its fiscal 2026 Commerce-Justice-Science spending bill Wednesday, including an amendment prohibiting the Trump administration from closing NOAA laboratories and ending university-based cooperatives that provide fundamental research on extreme weather and climate disasters. The spending package, which passed 34-28 along party lines, also includes a manager's amendment requiring NOAA to advance research on early prediction and warning systems for flood disasters in rural areas, provide support for NOAA's Hurricane Hunter program and fund coral reef research institutes on the Atlantic and Pacific coasts. President Donald Trump has sought to shrink the nation's premier climate science agency but provisions in the House bill would restore full staffing and funding levels to agencies like the National Weather Service. The House bill would cut NOAA by nearly \$400 million for fiscal 2026, but the reductions would not be as deep as the president requested. Read more: [E&E News](#)

9/16/25: AAS action alert

From: American Astronomical Society <public.policy@aas.org>
Subject: Action Alert: Oppose Changes to Visas for International Students and Researchers

The federal government has proposed limiting the duration of F and J visas to a maximum of four years (see details below). This would add significant uncertainty and potential bureaucratic hurdles for many international students and researchers in the US. The American Astronomical Society has partnered with the American Physical Society to help our members easily submit comments on this proposed rule. Take a few minutes today to submit a comment:

Currently, F and J visas allow international students and researchers to remain in the US for the length of the program they were admitted for, known as "duration of status." However, under the administration's new proposal [rhpiczrab.cc.rs6.net], F and J visas would expire before graduation for many students. This means that international graduate students would have to apply and pay a fee for visa extensions to graduate, without any guarantees that delays or denials will not disrupt their research and lives.

A public comment period on this proposed rule is open until 29 September. The administration must respond to each unique comment submitted, so we encourage you to use the tool we linked here and submit your comment [rhpiczrab.cc.rs6.net]. This tool provides three easy prompts to walk you through writing and submitting your proposal in under 15 minutes. Upon submitting, your comment will be uploaded to Regulations.gov [rhpiczrab.cc.rs6.net].

9/17/25: FYI 'Gold Standard Science' Plans Emphasize Existing Agency Efforts

Agency plans to implement Trump's "gold standard science" order explain how long-standing initiatives align with its tenets.

Agency plans for implementing the "gold standard science" executive order by President Donald Trump largely commit to continuing or expanding long-standing policies relating to scientific integrity and public access, contrasting with the strong reform language presented in the original order.

The plans began to roll out last month, after a 60-day drafting deadline triggered by the release of guidance by the White House Office of Science and Technology Policy. NASA, the National Science Foundation, the National Institutes of Health, and the Department of Energy are among the agencies that have publicly released their plans.

The guidance directed agencies to describe how they are working to

ensure the science they support is reproducible, transparent, unbiased, and free of conflicts of interest, among other goals.

“For the entirety of these federal agencies’ existence, they’ve really been working to increase all of these things, and I think that’s really well reflected in the reports that came out of NIH, DOE and NSF,” said Maryam Zaringhalam, senior director of policy at the Center for Open Science and a former OSTP official during the Biden administration.

Cultural change

Agencies were also required to identify challenges to implementing the executive order’s goals.

NSF’s plan states that “cultural change” will be needed in the scientific community to achieve “broad adherence” with some of the order’s tenets, such as accepting null results as a positive outcome for research projects. NSF says it will work to develop “establish community-driven and community-accepted norms” for sharing of null or negative results.

Ian Banks, director for science policy at the Foundation for American Innovation, applauded the mention of cultural change in NSF’s plan, saying “in order to address the reproducibility crisis and to improve scientific integrity, we have to address the cultural problems.”

“Scientific cultures as we have them today are truly conservative in the sense they resist change, but we clearly need change, and the gold standard science is a path towards that change,” Banks added.

However, Zaringhalam believes the agencies’ implementation reports push back against the notion that sweeping changes are needed.

“The idea of restoring something that has somehow fallen away or crumbled in previous administrations, I think, is ... problematic,” Zaringhalam said. She also argued that the Trump administration has failed to live up to its own definition of gold standard science, stating, for instance, that DOE did not use a regular peer review process for the recent report it commissioned that concluded the effects of greenhouse gas emissions are less damaging than is widely accepted.

Jules Barbat-Dajches, an analyst for the Center for Science and Democracy at the Union of Concerned Scientists, said that the nature of the implementation plans also leaves room for undue political influence in science.

“The biggest reason that scientific integrity policies were created in the first place was to prevent inappropriate influence in scientific

processes ... mainly like political influence," Barbat-Dajches said. "And there was no emphasis of that in the OSTP guidance."

Concerns over political influence have been stoked by the Trump administration placing enforcement of the gold standard science principles in the hands of political appointees.

OSTP Director Michael Kratsios has defended the oversight model as consistent with democratic government. "It is the responsibility of those appointed to represent the people to help direct and coordinate the taxpayer-supported research enterprise in the national interest," he wrote in a June op-ed.

Academic freedom

Although the agency implementation plans generally build on existing initiatives, one notable shift from the status quo is that NIH's plan states the agency is placing a new focus on "academic freedom."

NIH's attention to the subject has been driven by NIH Director Jay Bhattacharya, who announced in April that the agency would be reviewing its Intramural Research Program to make sure NIH scientists can engage in "open, academic discourse without fear of official interference, professional disadvantage, or workplace retaliation."

NIH's plan states the agency is modifying its policies governing researcher interactions with the media and is "exploring plans to shift its process for scholarly works from approving scientific content or findings to reviewing exclusively for policy and regulatory compliance."

While many NIH scientists have applauded the focus on academic freedom, 484 staff signed a letter to Bhattacharya in June arguing the Trump administration has selectively applied the principle. The letter points to recently interrupted grants on subjects such as health disparities and COVID as examples of censorship.

Other agency plans do not use the academic freedom terminology but do address ways of fostering dissenting opinions. For instance, NSF plans to "expand the specific clauses on 'differences of scientific opinion' in the upcoming updated Scientific Integrity Policy."

9/19/25: Science. NSF held captive / Trump directives have undermined a 75-year history of independence and threaten agency's vaunted track record for excellence

Illustration of Trump steering a ship with the NSF logo on the wheel. He is in the middle of rapidly turning the wheel, causing

the ship to lean. Scientific paraphernalia such as beakers are in disarray and falling over, and a scientist is falling off the ship in the background. Stephan Schmitz/Folio Art

In April, the National Science Foundation (NSF) announced its latest class of graduate research fellows, a storied program dating from the agency's earliest days that has fueled the careers of 50 Nobel laureates and attracts more than 12,000 applications each year. To many scientists' dismay, NSF had chosen just 1000 fellows—half the usual number and 1200 fewer than it had originally promised to fund.

So the community applauded 2 months later, when NSF named 500 additional fellows. NSF officials never explained why the agency originally shrank the program and how it found the money to expand this year's cohort. But the answer soon emerged: NSF's leaders weren't calling the shots. The Trump administration was.

"We wouldn't have been able to do [the second round] without the direct intervention of Michael Kratsios [director of the White House Office of Science and Technology Policy]," Brian Stone, NSF's acting director, told NSF's presidentially appointed oversight body, the National Science Board (NSB), during its 23 July meeting. "I just wanted to express my appreciation for what OSTP was able to do."

The ups and downs of the fellowship program testify to the biggest transformation in the 75-year history of the agency, which prides itself on funding the best nonmedical academic research while staying out of the political fray. But NSF has lost much of its independence and been buffeted by politics in the 8 months since President Donald Trump took office.

The White House has ordered the \$9 billion agency to abandon long-running programs, terminate more than 2000 grants, and reverse decisions on what to fund next based on the administration's political agenda, which excludes diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) efforts and climate change research. NSF is also making radical changes in its daily operations, including sharply reducing its reliance on top academic scientists on loan from their institutions and realigning the agency's entire grantmaking apparatus to conform to Trump's priorities (see sidebar, below <#sidebar>).

Many science policy experts say those changes move NSF away from its founding principles, laid out in a 1945 report to then-President Harry Truman, to maintain U.S. leadership in science by funding the best ideas across all fields and training the next generation of researchers. That compares with the more targeted missions of most government agencies, such as advancing energy, health, or space exploration. But both of NSF's goals, as put forward by Vannevar Bush in his seminal report that led to NSF's creation in 1950, have lost

support under Trump.

"This administration doesn't buy the idea that the government's investment in basic research buys us anything useful," one former senior NSF official says. "And if they don't agree with Bush's assumption, then why bother to even have an NSF?"

Insiders describe a crisis of morale. In May, after only 11 months as head of NSF's computing directorate, Gregory Hager reluctantly concluded that NSF's loss of autonomy had made his job so unattractive that he resigned and returned to his faculty position at Johns Hopkins University. "My ability to carry out my vision and to be a voice for computing research are diminished to the point that I can have more impact outside NSF than within it," Hager wrote in a letter to the community, perhaps the first time a top-level NSF official has cited disagreement with agency policies as the reason for their departure.

NSF hasn't had a Senate-confirmed director since 24 April, when Sethuraman "Panch" Panchanathan resigned abruptly, declaring, "I have done all I can." Panchanathan left only 10 days after staffers from the so-called Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE) had set up shop at the agency's headquarters in Alexandria, Virginia. The grant terminations began the next week.

DOGE's intervention in NSF's gold-standard grantmaking process was also more than sociologist Alondra Nelson could stomach. Nelson, an NSB member and acting OSTP director under former President Joe Biden, resigned her board position on 13 May. She was only 7 months into her 6-year term.

The board, she wrote in a *Time* essay, has been reduced to a "ceremonial assemblage ... given the freedom to speak [without] the possibility of being heard." Instead, she wrote, DOGE has been granted the authority "to give thumbs-up or -down to grant applications which had been systematically vetted by layers of subject matter experts."

Keivan Stassun, who was named to NSB in January 2023, sees DOGE operating as the ultimate decision-maker at NSF, in tandem with the White House Office of Management and Budget. And OMB, he says, has discarded NSF's well-regarded system of choosing the most worthy proposals. "If OMB is using anything like NSF's merit review criteria," says Stassun, an astrophysicist at Vanderbilt University, "that has not been communicated and is certainly not apparent to me."

Taking orders from the White House has forced NSF staff to walk a tightrope, one NSF program manager says. "Yes, NSF has to carry out the priorities of the president," says the program manager, who requested anonymity to avoid repercussions. "But we're all trying to find a way to educate scientists on how to dance the new dance we've got to dance without violating our principles."

Even if I turn only a few degrees each time, after 10 or 15 times I'm going to be heading off in a different direction.

* *Gregory Hager*
* Johns Hopkins University

NSF hasn't stopped making new awards, many of them in areas the administration favors—such as artificial intelligence (AI), quantum information science, and advanced manufacturing—and other topics industry is also eager to support. But even there, clouds are gathering: If Congress agrees to Trump's request to reduce the agency's budget next year by more than half, all NSF programs would suffer.

NSF declined to make anyone available for comment, and NSB Chair Victor McCrary refused repeated requests to talk about the agency's new direction. But dozens of interviews with scientists from many disciplines, including current and former NSF employees who asked to remain anonymous for fear of retribution, reveal the extent of NSF's transformation.

Four high-profile programs highlight the changes. One was caught in the crossfire between the White House and universities over alleged antisemitism on campus. Another fell victim to the administration's push to end efforts to promote diversity, and two others illustrate how scientists and administrators now tailor their proposals to conform to White House priorities.

Collateral damage

For more than 4 decades, NSF has supported a network of institutes that bring together top mathematicians and rising stars for in-person workshops to explore a range of hot topics and spark new areas of research. "The math institutes are the crown jewels of our portfolio," says mathematician Juan Meza, former director of NSF's math division, which spends roughly 15% of its annual budget on the network. "They support the entire mathematical community."

The Institute for Pure and Applied Mathematics (IPAM) at the University of California Los Angeles (UCLA) has been part of that network since 2000 and is known for bridging the gap between academia and industry by working on problems that appeal to both theoretical and applied mathematicians. Early-career scientists especially benefit, notes IPAM's director, UCLA mathematician Dimitri Shlyakhtenko. "This is the place where you can go and talk to a person whose papers you read and pick up insights that can be career changing," he says.

On 27 July, NSF issued an embargoed press release announcing it would fund seven institutes in the network, including IPAM, which would get another \$17 million over the next 5 years. But when the news became public a week later, IPAM wasn't on the list.

The cause of the about-face was White House politics. On 29 July, the U.S. Department of Justice announced UCLA was guilty of antisemitism and violating the civil rights of its Jewish students. The next day, NSF cited that finding in a letter to UCLA Chancellor Julio Frenk saying the agency was suspending 300 research grants, including what was left of a \$25 million grant awarded to IPAM in 2020, and removing IPAM from the next round of winners.

"This is a lot bigger than IPAM," says Shlyakhtenko, whose own \$420,000 NSF grant was suspended, noting that the Trump administration has targeted several elite universities for alleged discrimination. "I think the people at NSF are trying to do the best they can. But they are operating under serious constraints."

On 12 August a federal judge in San Francisco ruled that the suspensions were illegal, and the next day NSF reinstated the grants. The ruling is part of a related, ongoing class action suit by UC faculty whose grants were terminated earlier this year by several federal agencies.

IPAM plans to support workshops scheduled for the fall with funds left from its 2020 grant and hopes to raise \$500,000 from private donors. But that's only a temporary solution, Shlyakhtenko acknowledges. "I'm hoping that, once the dust settles, NSF will agree that the things we're doing are sufficiently well aligned with its mission that we would be able to get some funding from them."

"Not aligned to NSF priorities"

U.S. minority populations have historically been severely underrepresented in the nation's pool of data scientists and coders. The Carpentries, a nonprofit group, has worked to fix that imbalance. Since 2012 it has recruited 5000 volunteer instructors to train more than 100,000 "novice learners."

So when CEO Kari Jordan and chief scientist Erin Becker learned last fall about an NSF program that supports organizations like theirs, they rushed to apply. After Trump took office they assumed their bid was hopeless. "We had seen the executive orders that had just come out [banning federal agencies from supporting DEI activities] and figured that meant we wouldn't be getting an award," Jordan says.

To their surprise, NSF told them in February they were in line for \$1.5 million over 2 years to do even more to diversify the coding

community. "We were shocked," Becker recalls.

But their elation was short-lived. "Your proposal has been flagged for DEI content," an NSF officer wrote to them on 15 May. "It contains activities for the retention of underrepresented students which has a limitation or preference in outreach, recruitment, participation that is not aligned to NSF priorities," the email continued. "Accordingly, NSF requires the project remove the planned activity."

Jordan and Becker thought about doing that. "But DEI programming is one of our core values. It's baked into everything we do," Becker says. "It's not just providing a diverse community of learners with the necessary technical skills," she adds. "It's also making sure they feel recognized, supported, and empowered." She and Jordan also worried that if they accepted the award and NSF later found new reasons to withdraw it, their small organization might not survive the blow. So 2 weeks later, The Carpentries withdrew its proposal.

Despite opting out, Jordan doesn't criticize other organizations that have agreed to accept NSF's conditions to remain eligible for funding. "That amount of funding can really lift up your organization or your research program," she says. "And we're all in a very difficult position because you're talking about people's livelihoods. So I understand their decision."

Conceptual illustration. Trump standing at a White House podium. A tightrope is stretched between the two microphones, and three scientists are attempting to balance on it.
Stephan Schmitz/Folio Art

A marriage of convenience

When a high-powered academic team asked NSF for funding to develop software for tapping the massive, open-source public databases that have become essential for doing cutting-edge science, the agency saw an opportunity to please the Trump administration. It tailored the proposal even more closely to White House priorities by playing the role of matchmaker between the applicant and a leading semiconductor company.

On 13 August, NSF made a 5-year, \$75 million award to the Allen Institute for Artificial Intelligence (Ai2) to extend its current open language model so it can be trained on graphics and images as well as data. Industry colossus Nvidia agreed to supplement the award with \$77 million worth of its advanced graphic processing unit chips and related software.

The grant comes from NSF's midscale infrastructure program, which provides up to \$100 million for user facilities that are too costly to

be part of an individual grant. It will allow the team to advance “the science of AI,” says project leader Noah Smith, a computer scientist at the University of Washington and head of Ai2’s natural language processing team. It will also give researchers access to tools to improve natural language processing models, a boon in a field where most models are proprietary.

The partnership with Nvidia reflects NSF’s long-standing effort to foster partnerships with industry and foundations, for which the agency carved out a new directorate—called Technology, Innovation, and Partnerships—in 2022. But bringing Nvidia into the project also gave NSF a chance to contribute to the much-touted AI initiative that the Trump administration rolled out earlier this year, says Hager, who left NSF before the award was announced.

“This project was very close to being funded, and it was in an area of interest to the administration,” Hager explains. “So I think that’s where the idea of reaching out to Nvidia came up. The project was essentially shovel-ready. But NSF could point to it and say, ‘Look, this is how we are supporting the administration.’”

Smith says he welcomes the additional resources. “Nvidia has been a champion of open-source AI, and open access to models,” he says. “They build their own ... and they make hardware that’s very important to these processes.”

He and his four co-principal investigators will receive \$18.3 million in the first year of the project. But funding for the remaining 4 years is contingent on NSF’s overall budget for 2026 and beyond, and the outlook is grim. If Trump has his way, funding for NSF’s midscale infrastructure program would drop by nearly 75%, from \$160 million in 2024 to \$43 million in 2026. NSF has already committed \$320 million to four other projects. It would have to break its promises to most, if not all, including Smith’s, if Congress accedes to Trump’s wishes.

Water and oil

Residents of New Mexico and the Navajo Nation suffer from the highest rate of water insecurity in the United States. It’s a problem that University of New Mexico biologist David Hanson hoped to address with funding from an NSF program, launched with much fanfare in 2022, to combine universities, industry, and nonprofits into a regional “innovation engine.” The Energized Watershed project he leads, whose goal is “to efficiently capture, recycle, treat and reuse water,” was not one of the 10 inaugural winners announced in January 2024. But in July it was named one of 29 semifinalists for a second round of engines to be funded in 2026. And this time Hanson thought his engine stood a better chance.

"Water solutions are also needed for oil and gas exploration," he says, referring to an energy sector Trump strongly supports. "There's also a growing recognition of the need for water for cooling and operation of the massive data centers" needed in AI, another priority for the Trump administration. The region's brackish water, he adds, is a promising source of minerals that are in demand commercially.

At the same time, Hanson assured NSF his engine wouldn't give preferential treatment to certain groups that are part of his team, in violation of another Trump directive.

"We are working closely with the Navajo, for example, because they are a sovereign nation in our region," he explains. "So we just need to be clear about that in whatever we say and not focus on [other] things that the administration isn't interested in."

However, even those tweaks weren't enough. On 18 September NSF winnowed the competition to 15 finalists—and Hanson's project isn't one of them.

Tighter control

As dismayed as they are by NSF's loss of autonomy, many staffers and outside scientists fear worse is to come. They worry an ongoing reorganization could reduce NSF's internal expertise and allow tighter political control.

The agency is eliminating some three-quarters of the roughly 350 "rotators," the academic scientists who stay from 1 to 4 years and work alongside federal employees. Simultaneously, it is reducing the number of supervisors, many of whom are rotators, in its eight research directorates and replacing them with outside political appointees or existing NSF staff.

Many current and former NSF officials worry the changes will reduce the flow of good ideas and, ultimately, lower the quality of the research NSF supports. "If you cut out the rotators, you stop getting new ideas," Meza says.

Having so few rotators will also make it easier for Trump to bend NSF to his will by replacing its 71 discipline-based divisions with a smaller number of clusters focused on White House priorities. Rotators now fill the top two management slots at many of those divisions; under the new alignment, most clusters would be led by government employees, either promoted from within or new hires. Some of those new supervisors may not be experts in the areas they are overseeing, and many NSF watchers worry those new managers will first need to pass a political litmus test.

Hager says he supports eliminating the traditional divisions if the new structure fosters more cross-disciplinary research. "Computing is an evolving discipline, and so that organizational flexibility could make it a little bit easier to keep up with where the community is going," he says. But having topic-based clusters, he cautions, could pose a problem for other directorates with divisions that correspond to traditional fields such as math, physics, chemistry, and astronomy. "Program directors aren't necessarily fungible in those fields," he says.

NSF is still working out the details of changes to its upper echelon. But according to several sources, the plan is to have two people at the top of each directorate, with the traditional leader, now called an assistant NSF director (AD), paired with another federal employee. The AD would serve in an advisory capacity, whereas the second person would ensure everything the directorate funds reflects the administration's priorities. One former senior NSF official compares the latter to political commissars in the former Soviet Union.

That arrangement could hamper NSF's ability to attract top scientists, says geochemist Alexandra Isern, who retired in December 2024 as head of NSF's geosciences directorate. "I'd worry about the caliber of candidates [applying for AD]," she says. "People come to NSF to have an impact on research in their field, and I'd be reluctant to take a job if I didn't have the authority to make decisions."

And sooner or later change will come to the top of the agency. "Once this reorganization stuff gets settled, someone will be appointed as the next NSF director," Hager says. "And I've got to believe it's going to be a friend of the administration."

He fears the eventual effect of many small changes. "Even if I turn only a few degrees ... after 10 or 15 times I'm going to be heading off in a different direction," Hager says.

How NSF ensures grants don't 'do DEI'

By Jeffrey Mervis

The National Science Foundation (NSF) has adopted a kind of honor system to make sure grantees don't violate President Donald Trump's ban on federal support for programs aimed at increasing diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI). Rather than dictating changes, it is asking researchers to strip objectionable elements from their projects and then certify they have done so.

First, an internal review searches pending or existing grants for

elements that might violate the anti-DEI directives. "Program directors have complete discretion on making that decision," one NSF program officer says. And they don't need to note specific violations.

The next step is to contact the offending scientist, who is expected to consult with their institution—the official recipient of the grant—and agree on a mitigation plan. "The PI [principal investigator] is then asked to send us an email saying that they [will] not conduct any outreach, recruitment, or participatory activities that show a preference to any protected group," the program officer explains.

NSF doesn't ask how the project has been altered. "It's up to the [scientist's] institution to tell us that the project is now in compliance," the staffer says, although some program officers give PIs a chance to ask about how mitigation should work.

At a group meeting with their program officer, "We all just agreed not to do DEI," one PI says. Then it's clear sailing, the officer says. "After documenting that we had a conversation, I basically would rubber stamp it and tell my division director, 'OK, this is ready to go forward.'"

9/22/25: IHE. Trump Proposes \$100K Fee for H-1B Visa

The Trump administration moved Friday to restrict access to the H-1B nonimmigrant visa program, which universities make use of, as do many other industries including technology and finance, The New York Times reported.

New applicants will have to pay \$100,000 in order to qualify for an H-1B visa, starting with the February 2026 lottery. The change took effect Sunday but is likely to face legal challenges. The presidential proclamation directs the Department of Homeland Security to "restrict decisions on petitions not accompanied by a \$100,000 payment." The White House clarified over the weekend that the change doesn't apply to current H-1B visa holders, Politico reported.

In the proclamation, Trump officials argued that the H-1B program "has been deliberately exploited to replace, rather than supplement, American workers with lower-paid, lower-skilled labor." This has led to "a disadvantageous labor market for American citizens."

Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick said Friday in the Oval Office that the goal was to "make sure the people coming in are the top, top people," according to the Times. He also said, per Politico, that the aim was to encourage big tech companies to hire Americans. "The whole idea is no more with these big tech companies or other big companies

training foreign workers," Lutnick said. "If you're going to train somebody, you're going to train one of the recent graduates from one of the great universities across our land. Train Americans, stop bringing in people that take our jobs."

Democrats in Congress and others argued that the change would make it difficult to recruit highly skilled foreign students and workers to this country.

The H-1B program is capped at 85,000 new visas a year, but colleges and universities and some other organizations aren't subject to that cap.

[Note the implication: would bring in only \$8.5 billion per year to the Treasury -- not much in the scope of things -- so the policy is mainly intended to discourage hiring foreign workers.]

Brendan Cantwell, a professor of higher, adult and lifelong education at Michigan State University, wrote in his Substack newsletter that "U.S. higher ed is chock-full of H-1B workers" and that institutions would struggle to operate without international talent. He expects that many colleges won't be able to afford the \$100,000 fee.

"Faculty, researchers, including some but not all postdocs, and staff are often initially hired into U.S. higher education using H-1B visas," he said. "Many, if not most, of these people eventually become permanent residents or U.S. citizens, but for a period of years are reliant on the H-1B system to live and work in the U.S. Simply put, without access to H-1B workers, U.S. colleges and universities will not be able to fill vital roles on campus, especially in science and engineering fields."

[The policy seems to be explicitly aimed at Big Tech companies -- Amazon, Microsoft, Meta, etc. The administration may not even know that research universities rely on H-1Bs as well. Glad you cozied up to Trump now, boys?]

[9/29/25: From IHE. "More than 16,700 employees at colleges and universities got H-1B visas approved in fiscal year 2025, but they are concentrated at 100 large research institutions."

--- That rate of hiring implies universities would be drained of an additional \$1.7B per year! Of course, they can't afford that and will instead hire many fewer H-1B people.]

9/22/25: FYI

NATIONAL LABS SEE LAYOFFS AND VOLUNTARY SEPARATIONS

Pacific Northwest National Lab saw involuntary layoffs last week, following offerings of voluntary separation to some staff, according to a lab spokesperson. The lab originally asked for 90 volunteers but said that the necessary number of volunteers was not achieved. The spokesperson did not address how many people were laid off or accepted voluntary separations. Staff at Fermi and Argonne Labs have also received voluntary separation offers in the last month, according to the Chicago PBS station WTTW. [aip.us17.list-manage.com] Argonne aimed to cap the accepted separation offers at 60. At Sandia Labs, layoffs of 400 people are planned to be completed by October, Source NM reported last month. [aip.us17.list-manage.com] Steeper job losses have been feared across the national lab system but apparently have not yet occurred. Back in July, [aip.us17.list-manage.com] California lawmakers expressed concerns about the prospect of mass layoffs at national labs.

9/23/25: Astronomy Magazine. Bipartisan reps urge House leaders to add NASA funding protection to stopgap bill / Fearing 'irreversible' cuts, lawmakers are pushing for a special provision, or 'anomaly,' to prevent the White House from cutting billions from the space agency's budget during the stopgap funding period.

Key Takeaways:

- * The White House proposed a 24% budget cut to NASA for fiscal year 2026, a significant departure from historical precedent, with a 47% reduction specifically targeting science programs.
- * Congress, through its House and Senate Appropriations Committees, opposes the proposed cuts and has advanced full-year funding bills rejecting the White House's reductions, maintaining funding near previous levels.
- * A short-term continuing resolution (CR) to avoid a government shutdown is under consideration. Concerns exist that this "clean" CR, lacking protective language, would enable the Office of Management and Budget (OMB) to unilaterally impose the proposed cuts.
- * A Democratic counterproposal to the CR includes specific language protecting ongoing NASA missions and development from the proposed cuts, highlighting a bipartisan effort to prevent the OMB from enacting the White House's budget reductions.

The months-long drama over NASA's fiscal year 2026 budget has entered a critical new phase, with a looming government shutdown forcing a high-stakes confrontation over the agency's future.

The central conflict pits the White House's proposed 24 percent cut to NASA against bipartisan congressional efforts to maintain funding. Now, with competing stopgap funding measures on the table, a growing chorus of lawmakers and advocates is pushing for a special provision to protect NASA, fearing the White House's Office of Management and Budget (OMB) will unilaterally impose the deep cuts – including a 47 percent reduction to the agency's science programs – on Oct. 1.

"Without inclusion of an anomaly providing guidance on the NASA budget," House of Representatives members wrote in a letter to House Appropriations Committee leaders, "OMB has pledged to apply its proposed FY 2026 cuts as soon as October 1st. That would result in an unprecedented, single-year cut to NASA, particularly NASA's space science activities, resulting in irreversible impacts on America's space leadership and capabilities that ignore congressional intent."

The path to conflict

The current standoff is the culmination of a lengthy annual budget process. It began months ago when NASA submitted its own budget proposal to the White House OMB, the agency responsible for implementing the president's policy agenda. Through a series of negotiations, the OMB adjusted NASA's request to align with the administration's priorities, resulting in the President's Budget Request (PBR) being sent to Congress.

This year's PBR proposed a historic 24 percent cut to the agency, a stark anomaly from decades of precedent. While the PBR is only a proposal, it has historically served as a strong indicator of NASA's final funding; according to an analysis by The Planetary Society, Congress has never cut NASA's budget by more than 11 percent or increased it by more than 9 percent relative to the PBR, except for the aftermath of the /Challenger/ disaster.

This historical alignment makes the FY26 proposal a significant departure from the norm. The ultimate constitutional power to fund the government rests with Congress, which signaled its strong disagreement with the administration's plan. The House and Senate Appropriations Committees – specifically their subcommittees on Commerce, Justice, and Science (CJS) – both advanced full-year funding bills that reject the White House's cuts. Their proposals maintain funding near the roughly \$24.9 billion level enacted in previous years and are now awaiting votes on the House and Senate floors.

A 'clean' stopgap creates a new crisis

With the Oct. 1 deadline to fund the government looming, Tom Cole

(R-OK), House Appropriations Committee Chairman, released a short-term solution: the Continuing Appropriations and Extensions Act, 2026. The bill, known as a continuing resolution (CR), is designed to keep the government open through Nov. 21, 2025, by continuing funding for federal agencies at the previous year's rate. Federal agencies are currently operating under a similar year-long CR, meaning they are still funded at fiscal 2024 levels.

Cole described the bill as a "clean, short-term funding extension" intended to prevent a shutdown. In this context, "clean" means the bill

is free of major policy changes or special funding provisions and is intended only to extend current funding levels. However, its "clean" nature is the source of the new crisis, as it lacks the explicit directive – or "anomaly" – that NASA's supporters say is necessary to prevent the OMB from imposing the PBR's deep cuts. During a briefing on

Wednesday, Jack Kiraly, director of government relations for The Planetary Society, stressed that the bill should be seen as just an initial proposal. "It is the opening salvo of what will be a very contentious two weeks, as we careen towards that Sept. 30 deadline for the fiscal year," Kiraly said.

Democrats counter with NASA protections

In a significant development, Democratic appropriators introduced a counterproposal to the CR on Wednesday. The bill, from Sen. Patty Murray (D-WA) and Rep. Rosa DeLauro (D-CT), includes the specific protective language that advocates have been requesting. Section 123 of the bill states that "any [NASA] mission in operation, including extended operations, or under development or formulation ... shall be continued in such operations, development, or formulation."

This provision would limit the OMB's ability to enact the proposed cancellations. While the bill is unlikely to pass as-is, its introduction formally places the protection of NASA science on the negotiating table. "This new bill includes a provision that ... would, in

effect, curtail OMB's ability to enact their cuts and mission cancellations during the CR," Kiraly said in an email update to attendees, including /Astronomy/, the day after the briefing. "The inclusion of this section shows that NASA Science is a priority for Congress."

The bipartisan push for an anomaly

The Democratic counterproposal builds on a bipartisan effort already underway. A group of lawmakers led by Reps. Judy Chu (D-CA) and Don Bacon (R-NE) has been pushing to amend any CR to protect the agency. They argue that allowing the OMB to implement cuts, even temporarily,

would be “devastating,” wasting billions in taxpayer investment by terminating almost 20 active space science missions and ultimately “surrender[ing] space leadership to China.”

Their call has been amplified by a coalition of 15 science, education, labor, and space advocacy organizations led by The Planetary Society. The group’s letter highlights the disproportionate impact the proposed budget would have on research, warning that without protection, the cuts to NASA’s Science Mission Directorate would lead to the elimination of more than 40 NASA science projects, including 19 active missions.

“Congress has already made its intent clear: It rejects these reckless cuts and supports continued investment in NASA science,” said Kiraly in a press release. But “without language in the CR, OMB could override that intent, shutting down missions mid-stream, wasting taxpayer dollars, and undermining U.S. leadership in space exploration. Congress must act now to prevent irreversible harm.”

Casey Dreier, The Planetary Society’s chief of space policy, emphasized that the request is about preservation, not new money. “This is simply a directive to prevent un-strategic and wasteful mission terminations rejected by Congress,” Dreier stated.

Three potential paths forward

In Wednesday’s briefing, The Planetary Society outlined three potential legislative paths that could determine NASA’s fate in the coming months. The first, and most immediate danger, is the passage of a “clean” CR like the one currently proposed. In this scenario, the temporary funding bill is approved without any protective language for NASA, allowing the OMB to begin implementing the PBR’s deep cuts and start the process of shutting down missions.

The danger, as Dreier explained, lies not in the top-line funding number but in how the OMB can control the rate of spending. “You have a potential situation where these dramatic cuts could potentially functionally be implied during a short-term stopgap period. Not because on paper ... you have the same amount of money, but because they are going to restrict again that flow of money,” Dreier said.

A second possibility is a full-year CR. If Congress remains deadlocked on full-year appropriations, it could opt to extend the current flat funding for the rest of the fiscal year. While this would avoid the immediate cuts of the PBR, The Planetary Society warned that without specific guardrails, it would create a prolonged state of uncertainty and leave NASA vulnerable to other administrative actions to withhold funds.

The final path is an "omnibus" spending bill. This would occur if, after one or more short-term CRs, congressional leaders reach a deal to combine all the annual spending bills into one large package. Kiraly described how this process would ultimately reflect the bipartisan consensus already established in the CJS bills. "Likely, an omnibus will ... use those proposals that are currently being considered by the House and Senate as the foundation on which they build a bipartisan consensus around an omnibus funding bill," he said, resulting, potentially, in "a final spending package that actually results in a stronger NASA that has clear stability and direction, provided by the Congress."

Human exploration gets a boost

An interesting aside to the annual budget drama reveals the Trump administration's apparent interest in human exploration over science. In July, President Trump signed the "One Big Beautiful Bill," a special reconciliation bill that operates outside the normal annual appropriations process. An amendment added by Sen. Ted Cruz (R-TX) provided nearly \$10 billion in supplementary, multiyear funding to secure the Artemis program, specifically ensuring the continuation of the Space Launch System (SLS) rocket and Orion spacecraft through 2032.

This apparent focus on human spaceflight at the expense of science has led observers to speculate about the origins of the administration's budget proposal. "The source of this is not the outcome of a considered policy process, but a factional and potentially even somewhat personal image for what NASA should or shouldn't be expressing itself," said Casey Dreier, chief of space policy for The Planetary Society, in Wednesday's briefing.

This move highlights a contrast in priorities. While the administration's own FY26 budget request calls for retiring SLS and Orion and slashing science, this supplementary funding legally mandates the continuation of the human exploration programs. The two potential outcomes are telling: If the OMB imposes the PBR cuts on Oct. 1, NASA would face a catastrophic 47 percent reduction to its science programs while its human exploration directorate receives a nearly \$10 billion boost. Conversely, if Congress passes a full-year budget that protects science, NASA would receive both its standard funding and this supplementary Artemis money, fully funding both directorates.

A high-stakes standoff

With the Oct. 1 deadline fast approaching, NASA finds itself at the center of a high-stakes budgetary battle. While lawmakers have shown clear support for the space agency, the immediate challenge is

ensuring that a temporary solution to keep the government open doesn't inadvertently trigger the deep, long-term cuts they have sought to avoid. With Democrats now having placed specific protections for NASA on the negotiating table, the fate of the agency's science and exploration portfolio rests on whether Congress can find a compromise before the clock runs out.

9/25/25: Science. 'Completely shattered.' / Changes to NSF's graduate student fellowship spur outcry The announcement comes months later than usual, leaving many would-be applicants stranded

After months of anticipation, the U.S. National Science Foundation (NSF) today released its instructions for the next round of applicants to its Graduate Research Fellowship Program (GRFP). To the dismay of many, the prestigious program, which funds more than 1000 promising STEM graduate students each year, will now exclude a key group of students, as second-year Ph.D. students are no longer eligible. The students who are still able to apply—undergraduates, bachelor's degree holders, those in joint bachelor's-master's programs, and first year Ph.D. students—aren't in the clear either, as some must decide whether to throw their hats in the ring with an unusually narrow timeframe to apply.

"I'm very upset and angry," says Eric Foreman, a second-year Ph.D. student in biomedical sciences at Augusta University. He and others note that for the past decade, NSF has only allowed students to apply once during graduate school, and many are given advice to wait until their second year, when their applications will be stronger.

Second-year students who had put in significant work on their applications prior to the solicitation release now feel abandoned. "I had already completed several drafts of my personal statement and research proposal," says University of Chicago molecular engineering Ph.D. student Ben Broekhuis. After receiving an honorable mention when he applied as an undergraduate, he opted to sit out the application process the first year of his Ph.D. after being advised to wait. "Now, seeing from the solicitation that I've been cut out of my opportunity to apply, I'm completely shattered."

There are no publicly available data on what proportion of GRFP applicants, who typically number more than 13,000 per year, are second-year Ph.D. students. But Susan Brennan, a former GRFP director who now works at Stony Brook University, says in her experience the bulk of applications come from people at that stage. "It's completely unconscionable that NSF is pulling the rug out from under these students." She adds that for students coming into graduate school from less well-resourced universities, having an extra year to get publications and other research experiences under the belt can be particularly important.

An NSF spokesperson told /Science/ the changes are meant to “restore the program's original emphasis on supporting students at the start of their research careers.”

Some researchers told /Science/ they aren't opposed to that shift in emphasis, but NSF should have given students a 1-year warning before changing the eligibility requirements. “We have a large cohort of incredibly competitive students ... who now can't apply” to one of the nation's premier graduate fellowship programs, says Cynthia Reinhart-King, chair of the department of bioengineering at Rice University who has served as a reviewer for the GRFP program and has mentored several fellowship winners. As one second-year Ph.D. student told /Science/ on the condition of anonymity, “It feels like we are being punished for following the conventional advice.”

The change in policy now also puts unexpected pressure on first-year Ph.D. students, many of whom were planning to wait until next year to submit their applications but now may feel compelled to apply, assuming the requirements won't change next year and this will be their last shot. “It forces many students to propose projects based on limited experience in a particular research domain, having only been in graduate school for a few months,” says Ryan Sochol, an associate professor of mechanical engineering at the University of Maryland. Some may not have even joined a lab yet, as some Ph.D. programs require students to complete lab rotations during their first year.

This year's prospective applicants don't have much time to make up their minds. Normally the program solicitation comes out in July, giving applicants at least 90 days to prepare their materials—a policy that's clearly stated on NSF's website <https://www.nsf.gov/funding/overview>. But this year's applicants will have just over 6 weeks—and that's only after earlier this week the agency extended the posted deadlines by about 2 weeks, from late October to early November, with no announcement or explanation. “This is a pretty tight timeline now for the students to prepare an application,” Reinhart-King says. (When asked by /Science/ whether NSF's 90-day policy has changed, a spokesperson wrote, “I'll look into that and get back to you.”)

The program faced criticism in the spring when this year's cohort of winners skewed in favor of the computer sciences—a field that's a stated priority of President Donald Trump's administration. The instructions released today say “fellowships will be supported in all NSF-eligible research areas.” But it adds that the agency “will continue to emphasize high priority research areas in alignment with Administration priorities.”

Jason Williams, assistant director of Cold Spring Harbor Laboratory's

DNA Learning Center, says he worries the program has “become liable to outside influences that are not necessarily really aligned with the mission of NSF and the mission of the country to create the best STEM talent.” He and others submitted an open letter to NSF in 2020 <<https://jasonjwilliamsny.github.io/grfp2020/>> expressing concern when, during the first Trump administration, the agency first began stating that artificial intelligence, quantum information science, and computationally intensive research would be considered high-priority research areas. Williams had a meeting scheduled today with colleagues, including Brennan, to decide how to proceed after they posted an open letter <<https://jasonjwilliamsny.github.io/grfp2025/>> yesterday about the delay in guidelines, which quickly garnered hundreds of comments.

They may find a partner in Daniel Bolnick, an evolutionary biology professor at the University of Connecticut who spoke out on the social media platform Bluesky after seeing that NSF was revoking eligibility for second-year Ph.D. students without any prior warning. “This is so deeply unfair that it warrants a formal protest from the scientific community.”

9/26/25: FYI

AI and Quantum Among Top White House R&D Priorities for FY2027

OSTP’s vision for federally funded research prioritizes emerging technologies, nuclear energy, biotechnology, national security, and space exploration.

The White House published a memo this week detailing its priorities for federally funded research in fiscal year 2027. The memo, published Tuesday, was authored by Office of Management and Budget Director Russell Vought and Office of Science and Technology Policy Director Michael Kratsios. It criticizes years of “unfocused federal investments weighed down by woke ideology and diversity, equity, and inclusion initiatives” and aims to realign the federal R&D portfolio to “serve its core purposes: driving economic growth and high-wage employment for all Americans, promoting high quality of life, and ensuring U.S. leadership in critical sectors of the economy.”

Congress, not the White House, ultimately sets budgets for federal R&D, but the memo signals the Trump administration’s funding priorities. These priorities include:

- * Ensuring American leadership in critical and emerging technologies through R&D related to artificial intelligence, quantum science, semiconductors, advanced communications networks, future computing technologies, and advanced manufacturing.

- * Unleashing American “energy dominance” by encouraging agencies to prioritize “affordable, reliable and secure energy technologies.”
- * Strengthening American national and economic security by, for example, advancing U.S. military capabilities, investing in cybersecurity capabilities, and implementing President Donald Trump’s vision for a “Golden Dome” missile defense shield.
- * Safeguarding American health and biotechnology through, for example, R&D focused on pressing health challenges, boosting biosafety, and building domestic biomanufacturing capabilities.
- * Assuring continued American leadership in space through, for example, crewed missions to the Moon and Mars, and basic and applied R&D into areas such as novel sensing modalities and radiation belt remediation.

The memo appears to reflect the Trump administration’s hard turn against certain STEM education programs and diversity initiatives. An earlier memo published during Trump’s first term overtly called for agencies to prioritize “activities that advance innovation in STEM education and increase diversity, equity, and inclusion in STEM.” This objective is ridiculed in the latest memo, and the Trump administration has pursued an aggressive campaign to eliminate grants, programs, and policies that have even passing connections to DEI. General principles, such as growing the American science and technology workforce, encouraging partnerships with industry, and strengthening national security, remain.

As part of its critical and emerging technology goals, the memo encourages federal investment in “novel AI paradigms and computing architectures” to realize AI applications such as accelerated scientific discovery, nuclear fission and fusion, quantum energy science, advanced space analytics, and remote sensing and navigation. The memo also emphasizes enhancing methodologies for AI evaluation and creating structured scientific datasets for AI model training. On quantum science, the memo recommends agencies develop consortia to support R&D efforts, invest in testbeds and other critical infrastructure, and boost efforts to manufacture next-generation quantum devices, adding that “funding for related basic and applied materials research and mathematical and physical sciences should also be prioritized.”

Achieving American “energy dominance” has been a key talking point of the Trump administration, with OSTP encouraging federal agencies to prioritize R&D investments related to fossil fuels, advanced nuclear fission and fusion, geothermal and hydropower energy, as well as support the development of advanced reactors, small modular reactors, fusion energy demonstrators, and processes for nuclear fuel recycling

and reprocessing.

"Federally funded energy R&D should reflect an increased reliance on the private sector to fund later-stage R&D and commercialization of energy production, storage, and consumption technologies, while also supporting user facilities that can improve multisector collaboration," the OSTP memo says.

Though the Trump administration has cut federal support for climate research by, for example, terminating National Science Foundation grants, the OSTP memo highlights the importance of research focused on polar regions, urging agencies to "prioritize research and associated research infrastructure investments that enhance America's ability to observe, understand, and predict the physical, biological, geologic, and socioeconomic processes and interacting systems of the Arctic to protect and advance American interests and ensure prosperity of America's Arctic residents." The memo also urges agencies to "maintain, and where feasible, strengthen Antarctic research infrastructure" – a goal that seems to be at odds with the Trump administration's decision to defund the National Science Foundation's construction budget earlier this year.

9/28/25: WP. White House considers funding advantage for colleges that align with Trump policies / The proposal could transform the government's vast research funding operation, which has long awarded university grants based on scientific merit.

"COLLEGE COMPACTS"

The White House is developing a plan that could change how universities are awarded research grants, giving a competitive advantage to schools that pledge to adhere to the values and policies of the Trump

The new system, described by two White House officials, would represent a shift away from the unprecedented wave of investigations and punishments being delivered**to individual**schools and toward an effort to bring large swaths of colleges into compliance with Trump priorities all at once.

"Now it's time to effect change nationwide, not on a one-off basis," said**a senior White House official, who like the other official described the plan on the condition of anonymity because it is still being developed.

"Suddenly, to get a grant, you need to not demonstrate merit, but ideological fealty to a particular set of political viewpoints. That's not merit," he said. "I can't imagine a university in America that would be supportive of this."

Since President Donald Trump returned to office in January, his**administration has launched investigations of and pulled research funding from universities including Columbia, Harvard and UCLA, and then worked to extract concessions in exchange for restoring the money. Officials say the punishments are an effort to enforce federal laws that bar funding for schools that discriminate on the basis of sex, race or national origin.

The White House has faced setbacks in court – including a big loss this month in its high-profile fight with Harvard and another setback last week in California – and has not reached as many settlement agreements as Trump officials had hoped for.

The senior White House official described the new system as an opportunity for schools to show they are in compliance, as interpreted by the administration. Those that do so, the official said, would be rewarded with a “competitive advantage” in applying for federal grants.

“I think there will be an opportunity for universities to be forward-looking and ... state their positions out loud: What are the things that you believe? What are your values? How are you providing value to students?” the official said. “And that will be something that not only is important to the administration ... but it’ll be super impactful for students, too.”

The official said the administration also would continue to launch investigations of individual universities that it believes are in violation of civil rights laws.

Erwin Chemerinsky, dean of the University of California at Berkeley’s law school, said “no one will object” if the White House simply requires universities to pledge compliance with existing law.

But Chemerinsky, one of the attorneys representing UC researchers in a lawsuit challenging terminated federal research funding, also said the administration’s view of what the law requires//could be at odds with other interpretations: “It all depends on what the conditions are, and whether those conditions are constitutional.”

“It’ll be a whole range of what it means to be a really excellent institution of higher education,” the official said.

Part of the plan would include asking universities to affirm that they are not considering race in admissions, which the Supreme Court has ruled unconstitutional. Universities maintain that they are no longer doing so, but the Trump administration suspects many schools are using proxies for race to, in its view, illegally cling to their diversity

goals.

Some selective universities have tried to build racially diverse classes by admitting more lower-income students or by targeting recruitment in high schools with high concentrations of Black and Hispanic students.

Brown University said it would pay \$50 million over the next decade to workforce development organizations in Rhode Island, along with other concessions, while denying any fault or violation of federal law.

Talks are ongoing with others, including the University of California system.

While critics complain that the administration is trying to bully schools into adopting Trump policies, some allies of the White House have suggested the schools are not having to change much at all. Earlier this month, conservative activist Christopher Rufo urged the White House to draw a tougher line.

"Sources are telling me the deal terms are degrading and the WH is at risk of getting rolled by the university presidents," he wrote on X. "Time for a return to principle: President Trump has all of the leverage and should insist on significant reforms."

The second White House official rejected any suggestion that the new approach was motivated by disappointment in the strategies to date. The current approach has been "very effective" in pushing positive changes on campus, the official said, pointing to the agreements with Columbia, Brown and Penn.

"These schools are now embracing common-sense policies, restoring merit-based admissions, protecting their students and fostering safe learning environments," the official said. "This new approach allows more schools to make positive changes quicker."

Comments...

AI summary: The comments on the article express strong opposition to the Trump administration's plan to give funding preference to universities that align with its policies on admissions and hiring. Many commenters argue that this approach undermines scientific merit and academic freedom, turning research funding into a political loyalty test. They warn that such a policy could damage the U.S.'s global standing in science and technology, discourage talented researchers from working in the U.S., and lead to a decline in innovation. Some comments also highlight concerns about authoritarianism and the erosion of democratic principles.

Funding based on Trump's policies vs scientific merit? Clorox vs

vaccines. Tylenol vs autism. Magnets vs water. How much more quickly do they want American excellence to unravel?

More bribery from trump, at a huge cost to the public. Public money not going to the most qualified, but to those who kiss up to trump. Could there be anything more wasteful and corrupt? We are deep into lunacy with this guy, and it's way past time for the public, and I mean all the public, not just 60% who are already there, but all the public to recognize trump for what he is, and demand his resignation.

"and that college costs are not out of line with the value students receive." It's not the value that students RECEIVE, it's the value that students are OFFERED. At the same university one student might attend class, engage with professors, study hard and get a tremendous education; another student might do the minimum, party a lot, and do the minimum to pass. Both will have the same diploma, but one received a more valuable education because of his or her desire and effort. I could buy a high end AI laptop or a cheap one. If I'm only browsing is the manufacturer of the high end laptop to blame that I'm not getting the value?

The best solution to [overpriced or low-value degrees] would be to close hundreds of nonsense-teaching, low-quality, fourth-tier (or unranked), superstition-driven colleges operated by and for conservatives seeking dogmatic intolerance, sacred ignorance, and backwardness.

Universities are complex entities with a multitude of educational and scientific programs. I agree fully with Dean Chemerinsky, if all that will be required is that universities comply with the law, there should be no problem. One aspect of the proposal is troublesome to me – eliminating useless programs that don't prepare a graduate for employment. Is the government to decide what is useless? To follow this line of thought down the proverbial rabbit hole, it leads to a more fundamental questions – what is the purpose of higher education? Is it to prepare a graduate for employment? Is it to round out the individual's talent and to stimulate intellectual curiosity? Is the government going to answers questions such as these – I hope not. I am not saying that higher education needs to eliminate or reduce some academic programs, but knowledge is never "useless."

Ivy league schools get a disproportionate amount of science funding. The total undergraduate population of all the ivies is the size of a large state university. Im all for funding science, but the selection process for grants should consider how the institution benefits educating students. We should have a bias towards public universities. Private schools like Harvard have the ability to self fund.

The research aspect of a university has nothing to do with the

undergraduate students. The graduate students and certain professors do the research.

Research in the sciences (physics, chemistry, biology,...) is done largely (let's say, 95%) at the level of the GRADUATE programs, and POSTDOCTORAL programs. That is the difference between a "college" and a "university." It's rather apparent that the current White House, and colleagues, have no idea what they are talking about. Researchers doing science don't spend their time attending demonstrations. Their political views are discussed outside their professional activities. Get it, Steven Miller?

We shouldn't have a bias towards any university. Selection should be based on the university's ability to carry out the research based on scientific evidence. Period.

Once again government by historic norms would be abused. Federal procurement is protected by laws that demand open competition and merit-based awards, but research funding rests mostly on tradition and agency practice. That makes it dangerously vulnerable to political capture. If a White House can tie grants to ideology, the foundation of peer-reviewed science crumbles. Just as we codified rules to prevent defense contracts from becoming political patronage, we now need clear legal safeguards for research. Science should be judged by merit, not McCarthy era loyalty oaths. Codifying this principle is the only way to keep politics from distorting discovery.

There is already an unequal treatment of universities and research funding. For instance, West Virginia and South Dakota faculty who submit research proposals get extra points for being from those states. Note that they are both red States. I think if you would look at Alabama Mississippi and many other red states they would fall into the same category. Some might call this balancing the scale others would call it what the administration wants to do and put a finger on the scale.

University California Santa Cruz offers undergraduate degrees such as Critical Race and Ethnic Studies and Feminist Studies. There were often "marches" from the university into the town of Santa Cruz. During the Black Lives Matter era, the marchers vandalized along the way, including cutting down the Mission Bell at Mission Park. There's now a City of Santa Cruz sanctioned kiosk at the spot to explain that the Spanish Mission that began the town was cruel to native first people. (Yet most other California cities including Monterey, Santa Clara, Santa Barbara, Los Angeles still have Mission Bells at their historic Missions.)

Why is it that the same people who obsess over academic merit in college admissions and hiring feel free to ignore it when deciding on awards of research grants?

On each and every issue, the loyalty test is what matters and not the merits of the case. Final decisions are all made based on the loyalty only. This will cause irreparable loss to our country.

Trump and his administration care little about expertise as evidenced by his appointments most recently of Ms. Halligan. He also cares little about science or even the scientific method as evidenced by his appointment of RFKJr to lead HHS. Thus it is not surprising that he is willing to dismantle the spectacular US public scientific research industry. I have served as a Program Officer at NSF. Grant applications reviewed at my panels were judged on two criteria, scientific merit and broader impacts, with the former being paramount. Peer reviewers and panelists were very rigorous in evaluating scientific merit. I was pleasantly surprised when I saw that sloppy proposals from big labs were not ranked as highly as a tight proposal from a younger investigator. The broader impacts criterion was twofold: educating the lay public about the value of the research and training the next generation of scientists. Proposals that had a poor description of their broader impacts did not fare as well. We were often faced with proposals that scored 4 excellent reviews or 3 excellent and 1 very good. With a limited budget, they could not all be funded. Thus, the broader impacts often separated those that got an award from those that did not. However, a strong broader impacts portion of a proposal never saved a proposal that was weak on merit. It now sounds like Trump wants to devalue merit in favor of loyalty to his view of white Christian exceptionalism. Just watch as China, South Korea, Japan, Germany and other countries pass us by in scientific achievement.

This plan is an excellent way to drive the most talented researchers to foreign universities. Very few brilliant scientists will choose to have their research proposals accepted or denied based on political ideology when they could go elsewhere and have them evaluated based on scientific merit and promise. China has already surpassed the US in some areas of science. This will accelerate their advance and our decline.

Seems like many in the comments didn't read the article. Universities should be required to not consider race in admissions or hiring, and universities should also be held to account for pushing out students with few job prospects and too much debt.

Call it a smoke screen. Call it gas lighting. Call it anything you want except what this administration calls it which is DEI or antisemitism. It's not either. What Trump wants is for universities to fall in line which he is attempting to do as in every sphere including the federal government and civil society. If successful the country will end up being an empty shell of itself and a pariah state in the world.

It's seems as though you aren't comprehending events. Trump and his minions are all in on government viewpoint discrimination. This is another shot at bringing to heel what they consider to be "liberal" institutions.

Funny..I am not aware of any US university that requires students to have a particular major. Students choose their own majors in the US academic system. IF A STUDENT ENDS UP WITH A MAJOR THAT HAS LOWER JOB PROSPECTS, THE STUDENT MADE THAT CHOICE, NOT THE UNIVERSITY.

Students come to the University to learn what they want to learn, "I would found an institution where any student can find instruction in any subject." Ezra Cornell. Our job is to teach and let the graduates do with it as they will.

Something had to be done. For many decades, colleges and universities have been bastions of left wing, secular, anti-religious thought and curriculum. William F. Buckley wrote of this problem in 1951, "God and Man at Yale". It's gotten much worse since then. Also there should not be DEI or racial quotas in hiring or admissions. The nation is going in a new, more conservative direction now.

what Trump does is not at all conservative. it is radical and authoritarian. Conservatives opposed gigantic power grabs by the executive. Calling Trump conservative is a joke.

Funny how knowledge makes one more critical and enlightened. That's considered liberal.

Hmmmm...maybe a greater knowledge of the world gained through education just makes you realize the limitations and hypocrisies of "conservatism."

Yes, there is a clear bias at universities in favor of facts, science, and basic human rights. And there should be. Universities are not churches.

Sure the Trump admin has a hammer, but this won't nail the "woke humanities" -- it will smash the extraordinary U.S. scientific research enterprise. A university is a collection of different colleges, which is a collection of departments and programs, each with their own graduate admission and faculty recruiting policies. Universities are also middle men for federally sponsored research grants -- they have research money the way an accountant or bank has money. Of course all practices must be consistent with the law! But beyond that, there is a huge amount of heterogeneity and none of this is really coupled together. For instance, my biophysics research grant might be less competitive because of legal actions by

our English department that the Trump administration just doesn't like. I have no control over the English department, the English department won't see the funding, and none of the graduate students being funded by the grant will have any interaction with the English department. So nothing will change except that STEM funding will become more random and less meritocratic.

NIH, DOD and other federal research grants have long had non scientific conditions that "increase priority." To say otherwise is uninformed at best, and intentionally deceptive at worst. This proposal allegedly moves the responsibility for these nonscientific elements to the schools rather than research teams, which is a positive change. I agree with the Berkeley professor in that this could be much ado about nothing if it's just a reassertion that the institution is following the law. The reported criteria would fall into that category. More broadly, the variability in nonscientific requirements in grants puts up a significant barrier to new research groups' attempts to establish themselves. It fosters the creation of dynasties that are well resourced enough to accommodate the shifting requirements, reducing the importance of novel ideas and scientific merit through the use of process mandates.

Although this comment shows some insight into the grant award process, it misses the big picture. The Trump administration is not interested in improving the grant process to include a more deserving group of grantees. Instead it is actually trying to shrink the pool of grantees to include only those who adhere to the MAGA conservative mindset. Academic freedom be damned. Societal interest be damned. Just look at other areas where this administration is aggressively reigning in support for, or aggressively opposing those it doesn't agree with.

So much of what is happening is very reminiscent of Chairman Mao and his Great Leap Forward, an ambitious and ultimately disastrous economic campaign in China from 1958 to 1962 He also reorder China's education system in the 60's. In a nutshell he stopped all education for approximately 10 years and sent professors to reeducation camps and moved the peasant class into training to take over the science, medicine and tech areas of education. He ordered musical instruments confiscated and when the music began again it was state controlled. He ordered the production of his official portraits, He had ongoing influence on contemporary art and Chinese politics during this period. As a result in the colleges lessons that were not approved were taught in secret and a brain drain began as the intellectuals left the country. Many coming to the US to teach at acupuncture colleges springing up in the 80s and 90's These TCM doctors had a medical degree in western medicine as well in China but not recognized in the US. Many went on to get that degree here by going US medical schools. I know this because I was an apprentice to one of these doctors. This is not a road we want to go down. It leads to financial

ruin for those that live through it.

I am sure that this new policy will bring about a culture of excellence at our universities similar to what we are seeing in the current administration.

Not only is this plan discriminatory, it is shortsighted: imagine a reversal of ideological favor when Democrats are in power. They would not pursue such a plan, but questions of precedent and unintended consequences are always important to consider. Of course, if you have no interest in formulating responsible public policy conducive to the common good and care nothing for posterity or the judgment of history, then such a plan would seem perfectly sensible--which explains the Trump administration's concoction of it.

The purpose of a college education should be to get an education, NOT To get a job. There is no area of study that is not worthy. There is no such thing " Frivolous" Degree. Choosing any major and achieving a degree, is in the control of the student.

So the Trump administration is going to dump the system that has piloted the US to a top source of scientific merit in the world?

The uncomfortable truth is that many of America's brightest undergraduates don't choose careers in science because they're chasing economic stability in medicine, law, or finance. To keep our labs thriving, we've relied on drawing the best and most ambitious students from across the globe. Simply look at the faculty of any STEM department at a major University. But what happens if they stop coming? If top-tier students from India, China, Europe, or Africa decide the U.S. is no longer a welcoming or stable environment, our pipeline collapses. Universities will struggle to recruit. Companies will be stuck with a narrower talent pool, forced to either relocate their research overseas or pass the costs of diminished innovation onto consumers. And the most accomplished professors and researchers—who can work anywhere—will think long and hard about whether staying in the U.S. is worth it when opportunities abroad are expanding. This is the risk Trump is playing with. By undermining academic freedom and turning research funding into a political loyalty test, he's not just waging a cultural war—he's mortgaging our future in science, technology, and economic leadership. If we cripple the very system that has made the U.S. the world's innovation hub, we won't just lose prestige. We'll lose the industries, the jobs, and the breakthroughs that secure our global standing. And once that edge is gone, it's not easily won back.

The autocratic playbook continues apace. Trump and his minions are acting with the surety there will not be any free and fair elections going forward. Their actions destroying free speech, controlling the unfettered discussion of ideas in our universities, establishing a

military presence on our cities under false pretenses, using trumped up charges against political enemies and condoning corruption and self enrichment, are not actions taken to bolster our democracy. They are concerted actions that consolidate power over Americans in perpetuity. The time to make a stand is now, before this monster declares martial law and removes our freedoms. Because, dear folks, that is Trump's end game.

OCTOBER

10/3/25: Van Scoyoc newsletter.

NIH research grinds to a halt as government shuts down

As the U.S. government shuts down due Congress' failure to pass a spending bill, the National Institutes of Health (NIH) is implementing a contingency staffing plan that will again roil a research apparatus that has already been heavily disrupted during the second Trump administration. The NIH will retain 4,477, or 24.5%, of its staff during the shutdown, primarily to maintain operations at the NIH Clinical Center, which is a hospital run by the agency, according to the plan. Other employees will stick around to care for lab animals or perform upkeep for infrastructure and facilities. In total, 32,460 employees across the Department of Health and Human Services (HHS) will be furloughed during the shutdown, according to an HHS contingency plan. Read more: [Fierce Biotech](#)

After months in limbo, four NIH institute directors fired

Four institute directors at the National Institutes of Health (NIH) and another top agency official who have been in professional limbo since being placed on administrative leave in the spring have now been fired, ScienceInsider has learned. They are Jeanne Marrazzo, director of the National Institute of Allergy and Infectious Diseases (NIAID), who in a recently filed federal whistleblower complaint says her removal was for political reasons; Diana Bianchi, director of the National Institute of Child Health and Human Development; Eliseo Pérez-Stable, who directed the National Institute on Minority Health and Health Disparities; Shannon Zenk, director of the National Institute of Nursing Research; and NIH Deputy Director for Program Coordination, Planning, and Strategic Initiatives Tara Schwetz. All received letters from NIH or the Department of Health and Human Services (HHS), its parent agency, in the past few days informing them that their appointments had expired or were being terminated. Read more: [Science Magazine](#)

DOE cancels \$7.6 billion in funding meant for projects

The U.S. Department of Energy on Wednesday said it planned to cancel \$7.56 billion in financing for hundreds of energy projects that it said would not provide sufficient returns to taxpayers. In a statement issued late on Wednesday, the DOE said it would cancel 321 financial awards supporting 223 projects. According to a list of all 321 terminated awards obtained by Latitude Media, EVERY SINGLE CANCELED AWARD WAS FOR A PROJECT LED BY A COMPANY BASED IN A DEMOCRAT-LED STATE. The canceled funding ranges from several hundred million dollars for projects focused on reducing methane emissions from oil and gas operators to a \$50 million grant for National Grid to add distributed energy resources to the Massachusetts electric grid. Read more: Reuters, Latitude Media

Energy Dept. tells employees not to use words including 'climate change' and 'green'

The Department of Energy has told employees to avoid using certain words, including "climate change," "green" and "sustainable," according to an internal email sent to staff and obtained by NPR. The details of the email were first reported by Politico. It was sent to employees of the Energy Department's Office of Energy Efficiency and Renewable Energy, which is the largest federal funder of clean energy technology. Read more: NPR

DOE announces \$625 million for 'beautiful, clean coal' and gas

The U.S. Department of Energy on Monday announced \$625 million in funding aimed at retrofitting and recommissioning coal plants. "Beautiful, clean coal will be essential to powering America's reindustrialization and winning the AI race," Energy Secretary Chris Wright said in a statement. The agency did not immediately respond to questions about the funding mechanism, including whether it would be made available as loans or grants. Read more: Utility Drive

NASA closes doors to 15,000 employees as US government shutdown begins

More than 15,000 NASA civil servants have been furloughed as the U.S. federal government enters a shutdown. The grinding halt forces NASA and other agencies to scale back nearly all of their day-to-day operations after lawmakers in Washington D.C. failed to pass a government funding bill by the deadline. Only a fraction of NASA's workforce remains on duty, assigned to missions that cannot be paused without risking astronaut safety, critical hardware, or the Trump administration's highest priorities. With most science programs and public-facing activities frozen, the shutdown leaves NASA in a holding pattern until Congress approves new funding. Read more: Space.com

Report argues NASA is illegally using President's Budget Request to circumvent Congress

A new report from the Democratic staff of the U.S. Senate Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation (CST) argues that NASA has been “illegally” implementing President Donald Trump’s proposed budget request (PBR) and ignoring the funding levels previously approved by Congress. Read more: [Spaceflight Now](#)

10/3/25: FYI Subject: Democrats Accuse Administration of Cutting Spending at NASA and NOAA

Senate Democrats this week accused the Trump administration of illegally restricting spending at NASA and the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration.

A report published on Monday by Democrats on the Senate Commerce, Science and Transportation Committee claims that White House Office of Management and Budget Director Russell Vought directed NASA in early summer to begin implementing spending levels outlined in President Donald Trump’s fiscal year 2026 budget request – a claim which NASA leadership denies.

President Trump’s budget request proposed approximately \$18.8 billion for NASA, a sharp drop from the fiscal year 2025 enacted level of \$24.8 billion. Whistleblowers quoted in the Democrats’ report said they were told to “get in line with the presidential budget request or lose their job or position.” They also raised safety concerns in relation to reduced spending. One whistleblower said they were “very concerned that we’re going to see an astronaut death within a few years” because of the Trump administration’s “chainsaw approach” to the agency. Another whistleblower quoted in the report said there is “no efficiency and no strategy” to the budget cuts, stating: “it’s a dart board in a dark room where darts are being thrown at random and hitting people.”

“The report is false,” NASA Associate Administrator Amit Kshatriya said in a statement shared with FYI. “NASA has communicated openly and transparently with Congress that we continue to execute our available appropriated funding in accordance with established fiscal policies which respect congressional authorities,” Kshatriya said. “NASA will never compromise on safety. The president’s budget request stands with Congress at this point, and NASA will enact the budget appropriated to us,” he added. The committee report focused on NASA, but it also asserts that there is “no doubt the Trump administration is trying to execute similar plans at agencies across the federal government.”

Senate Democrats also raised concerns about spending at NOAA this week, with Sens. Chris Van Hollen (D-MD) and Adam Schiff (D-CA) sharing a letter they wrote to Vought demanding answers on agency spending in recent months. The senators asked why NOAA’s fiscal year

2025 spending plan, reportedly approved by OMB in August, was \$246 million less than what Congress directed. Much like at NASA, these cuts put spending at NOAA roughly in line with the funding cuts President Donald Trump proposed in his fiscal year 2026 budget request for the agency.

NOAA did not respond to a request for comment on the letter, but staffing is currently reduced due to the government shutdown. Van Hollen and Schiff's letter suggests budget cuts at NOAA have affected research labs, competitive research grants, cooperative institutes, and fisheries management programs – actions that “will lead to environmental damage, economic loss, and social harm across the nation,” the senators wrote. It remains unclear exactly how much money President Trump has delayed, withheld, canceled, or clawed back from federal agencies and programs over the course of his second term, but Democrats on the House Appropriations Committee estimate that the figure exceeds \$410 billion.

An analysis published by the Center on Budget and Policy Priorities, a think tank that studies state and federal budgets, found that, as of July 31, the Trump administration had delayed or blocked the distribution of approximately \$26 billion in funds approved in the fiscal year 2025 stopgap funding bill, which Congress approved in March.

These funding freezes, known as impoundments, targeted agencies and programs that did not align with Trump administration priorities, the CBPP report says. The accounts with the largest delays include health-focused agencies, such as the National Institutes of Health and the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention; agencies that the Trump administration has targeted for elimination, such as the Institute of Museum and Library Services; and foreign assistance programs.

While the deadline for federal agencies to spend or commit funding for fiscal year 2025 passed on Sept. 30, reporting by Nature suggests NIH was able to overcome delays and obligate most of its fiscal year 2025 funding before the deadline, assuaging fears that the agency would have to return billions of dollars in unspent funds.

10/6/25: FYI

TRUMP THREATENS FURTHER AGENCY CUTS AS SHUTDOWN CONTINUES

The government shutdown continues this week, with Republicans and Democrats still at an impasse over healthcare spending. The Senate is expected to vote again at 5:30 pm today on the continuing resolution agreement that the House passed in September. Senate Republicans need 60 votes to pass the CR and will need the support of at least eight

Democrats or independents, but only a few have indicated a willingness to support the CR in prior votes. The Senate will continue to meet this week, but the House is not scheduled to resume meetings until after Columbus Day.

The Trump administration has warned it may use the shutdown to make cuts to federal agencies and implement widespread federal layoffs. President Donald Trump met with White House Budget Director Russell Vought last week to “determine which of the many Democrat Agencies, most of which are a potential SCAM, he recommends to be cut, and whether or not those cuts will be temporary or permanent,” Trump wrote on Truth Social last Thursday. That same day, the Department of Energy announced the termination of more than 300 grants totaling more than \$7 billion. Many of the projects focused on clean and renewable energy, with cancellations impacting two major hydrogen hub projects, per reporting by E&E News.

Vought tweeted a list of states – all of which voted Democratic in the last presidential election – where projects have been cancelled. Democratic leaders have described the cuts as illegal and politically motivated. “This administration has had plans in the works for months to cancel critical energy projects, and now, they are illegally taking action to kill jobs and raise people’s energy bills,” said Sen. Patty Murray (D-WA), the top Democrat on the Senate Appropriations Committee, in a statement. (This May, Energy Secretary Chris Wright began a large-scale review of DOE-funded projects to identify candidates for cancellation.)

Just prior to the shutdown, the Office of Management and Budget directed federal agencies to consider reductions in force, in addition to standard furloughs, as part of their shutdown plans. Intramural research at science agencies has been largely paused, but whether the shutdown has triggered new staff RIFs remains unclear.

TRUMP OFFERS FUNDING ADVANTAGE DEAL TO SMALL GROUP OF UNIVERSITIES

The Trump administration sent a proposal to nine universities last week asking them to adopt certain conservative priorities in exchange for priority access to federal grants, looser restraints on overhead costs, invitations to White House events, and conversations with administration officials.

Signatories to the 10-page “compact” would commit to maintaining “institutional neutrality” at all levels, ensuring university employees abstain from political speech, and recognizing that “academic freedom is not absolute.” The compact also requires signatories to conduct surveys of “viewpoints among faculty, students, and staff at all levels” and publicly publish the results.

Signatories would be required to cap international enrollment at 15%

for undergraduates, with no more than 5% from a single country. They would also freeze tuition for five years, with free tuition awarded to students in "hard science" programs at institutions with endowments exceeding \$2 million per undergraduate student. The compact prohibits signatories from considering gender, race, or political ideology in admissions. It also requires institutions to provide single-sex spaces for women and strictly define sex and gender according to "reproductive function and biological processes."

The compact has drawn criticism from Democrats, with California Gov. Gavin Newsom threatening to pull state funding from any California institution that signs the agreement. In a statement, Newsom said that California will not "BANKROLL SCHOOLS THAT SELL OUT THEIR STUDENTS, PROFESSORS, RESEARCHERS, AND SURRENDER ACADEMIC FREEDOM."

Most of the universities that received the proposal have not publicly shared a response, but Kevin Eltife, chairman of the University of Texas System Board of Regents, reportedly said he was honored the system's flagship school was selected for potential funding advantages.

10/7/25: FYI

Shutdown May Prolong Grant Lawsuits and Reinstatements

The government shutdown is slowing some court proceedings over research grant terminations. Justice Department attorneys moved to delay various court deadlines related to restoring grants to Harvard University and the University of California because government attorneys are generally prohibited from working during the shutdown. The judges have so far granted short-term extensions for those deadlines, which DOJ attorneys still may not be able to meet if the shutdown continues beyond this week.

Proceedings also appear to have stalled in several other cases related to grant terminations and indirect cost caps. For some, no appeal has been filed, while others await hearings.

In the Harvard case, the judge directed the Trump administration to reverse more than \$2.6 billion in federal funding cuts in early September but left it to Harvard and the administration to jointly establish "implementation details" before issuing the final judgment. Following the shutdown, the judge extended the deadline for a status report to Oct. 10.

President Donald Trump said the administration would "immediately appeal" the decision against it in the Harvard case.

In the UC case, university researchers won a temporary restoration of grant funding, including two separate rounds of grant reinstatements from the National Science Foundation – one in June and one in August – and another ongoing tranche of reinstatements from the National Institutes of Health and the Department of Defense. The appellate court granted a stay in the administration's appeal to overturn the temporary restoration of funds, while the district court extended the deadlines to restore all grants to Oct. 10 for NIH and to Oct. 17 for DOD. On top of the furloughed attorneys, the ability of federal agencies to service grants – including restoring funds to those that courts have ordered reinstated – appears to be hampered. Agencies including NIH and NSF say in their shutdown plans that researchers may continue work on current awards but the agencies will not award any new grants. Like DOJ staff, most employees at science agencies are furloughed during a government shutdown and are not permitted to work, even voluntarily.

NIH and NSF's plans both indicate that staff may not be available to provide oversight or administrative support, even of existing grants, and one court filing from DOJ specifies that NIH's grant office staff are furloughed. A Harvard spokesperson said on Sept. 19 that the Department of Health and Human Services had returned \$46 million in research funding to the university. This amounts to less than 2% of the total funding to be restored. FYI has reached out to Harvard for an update.

For the UC system, NIH had already restored 52 grants to researchers before the shutdown and planned to review nine remaining grants for potential reinstatement by Oct. 3, while DOD planned to reinstate all grants by Oct. 10.

10/7/25: NPR/Marketplace

For the first time since the beginning of the industrial revolution, coal is not the leading source of electricity in the world. It's been overtaken by RENEWABLE ENERGY.

The latest auction of federal land (SE Montana) for coal mining had only one bidder (the Navajos), and the bid was 1000 times smaller (in dollars per ton) than those of 10 years ago.
[Should call this "dirt cheap."]

The price of oil has come down about \$10/Bl since a year ago, but the average price of gasoline in the US (\$3.13/gallon) is about the same, mainly because of the sanctions on Russian oil and pressure on refineries. OPEC has recently approved larger production, which should lower gasoline prices but simultaneously hurt US oil producers.

BBC: Renewables overtake coal as world's biggest source of electricity

RENEWABLE ENERGY OVERTOOK COAL AS THE WORLD'S LEADING SOURCE OF ELECTRICITY in the first half of this year – a historic first, according to new data from the global energy think tank Ember.

Electricity demand is growing around the world but the GROWTH IN SOLAR AND WIND WAS SO STRONG IT MET 100% OF THE EXTRA ELECTRICITY DEMAND, even helping drive a slight decline in coal and gas use.

However, Ember says the headlines mask a mixed global picture. Developing countries, especially China, led the clean energy charge but richer nations including the US and EU relied more than before on planet-warming fossil fuels for electricity generation.

10/10/25: IHE. MIT Rejects Proposed Federal Compact / MIT is the first institution to reject a proposal by the Trump administration that would trade preferential treatment on federal funding for far-reaching changes.

The Massachusetts Institute of Technology has rejected the Trump administration's proposal to sign on to the "Compact for Academic Excellence in Higher Education," which would mandate sweeping changes across campus in exchange for preferential treatment on federal funding.

MIT is the first of the nine universities invited to join the compact to publicly reject the proposal, which has ignited fierce pushback from other higher ed leaders, faculty and experts who see the document as a way to strip institutions of their autonomy. The Trump administration also asked Brown University, Dartmouth College, the University of Arizona, the University of Pennsylvania, the University of Southern California, the University of Texas at Austin, the University of Virginia and Vanderbilt University to sign. Most have provided vague statements saying that they are reviewing the compact, though Texas officials have expressed some enthusiasm about the offer.

MIT president Sally Kornbluth announced the move in a Friday morning letter <<https://orgchart.mit.edu/letters/regarding-compact>> to the campus community, which included a copy of her response to Education Secretary Linda McMahon.

Kornbluth highlighted a number of areas the White House had emphasized in the compact, such as focusing on merit, keeping costs low for students and protecting free expression.

"These values and other MIT practices meet or exceed many standards outlined in the document you sent. We freely choose these values because they're right, and we live by them because they support our

mission—work of immense value to the prosperity, competitiveness, health and security of the United States. And of course, MIT abides by the law,” Kornbluth wrote.

She also noted that MIT disagreed with a number of the demands in the letter, arguing that it “would restrict freedom of expression and our independence as an institution” and that “the premise of the document is inconsistent” with MIT’s belief that funding should be based on merit.

“In our view, America’s leadership in science and innovation depends on independent thinking and open competition for excellence,” Kornbluth wrote. “In that free marketplace of ideas, the people of MIT gladly compete with the very best, without preferences. Therefore, with respect, we cannot support the proposed approach to addressing the issues facing higher education.”

Neither the White House nor the Department of Education responded to requests for comment.

Kornbluth has weathered searing criticism in recent years, both by Republican lawmakers and the broader public, after a disastrous congressional hearing in late 2023 over how universities handled pro-Palestinian protests and concerns about antisemitism.

She was one of three presidents, including former leaders of Harvard University and Penn, who offered equivocating answers when asked about hypothetical calls for the genocide of Jews and whether that would violate institutional policies. Kornbluth, who is Jewish, was somewhat more direct with her answers and the only one of the three to keep her job following the hearing.

Where Do Others Stand?

While MIT is the first institution to outright reject the compact, others have indicated they may be leaning that way.

Dartmouth president Sian Leah Beilock, for example, issued a statement last week saying she was “deeply committed to Dartmouth’s academic mission and values and will always defend our fierce independence.” The university “will never compromise our academic freedom and our ability to govern ourselves,” she wrote. While some observers have read Beilock’s statement as a rejection of the compact, Dartmouth spokesperson Jana Barnello rebutted that notion.

Barnello told /Inside Higher Ed/ by email that deliberations continue as administrators are “engaging with faculty across the university through Dartmouth’s shared governance framework and working closely with the Board of Trustees.”

Officials in Texas — where concerns about academic freedom and political interference in the classroom are surging — have publicly welcomed the idea. UT system Board of Regents chairman Kevin P. Eltife, a former Republican lawmaker, wrote in an Oct. 2 statement that the university was “honored” to be among the nine institutions “selected by the Trump Administration for potential funding advantages” and the board looked forward to “reviewing the compact immediately.”

Some state government officials are aiming to make the university’s decision for them by threatening financial consequences if they sign onto the proposed compact. California governor Gavin Newsom was the first to do so warning that any institution in the state that signs the agreement will lose funding, including access to scholarship funds known as Cal Grants.

Virginia Democrats made a similar threat to scale back state funding in a letter to UVA, to which the University of Virginia Board of Visitors offered a vague and noncommittal response. A working group at UVA is studying the proposal even as officials have expressed concerns. Pennsylvania lawmakers have also spoken out against the compact.

Boards for both the UT system and UVA are heavily stocked with GOP donors and figures.

Reactions Pour In

The same day MIT rejected the compact, the Association of American Universities (which all nine institutions are members of) voiced concerns about the proposal.

While AAU president Barbara Snyder noted in a statement there are some principles in the compact that the organization agrees with, such as making higher education more affordable and accessible and fostering “a vibrant marketplace of ideas,” other points were concerning. Specifically, Snyder pointed to concerns that the proposal “could damage, compromise, or depart from our nation’s competitive, merit-based system of research grant funding” that has been in place for more than a half century.

“While we cannot compromise the foundational principles that have made—and will continue to make—American higher education the envy of the world, we would welcome the opportunity to work with the administration to reimagine the important partnership between the federal government and research universities,” Snyder wrote in Friday’s statement.

MIT's rejection of the compact prompted celebration in academic circles.

"I am proud to say that MIT has rejected Trump's poison compact," American Association of University Professors president Todd Wolfson wrote on Bluesky shortly after the news broke.

And some scholars suggested that MIT had established a precedent that others may look to. Brendan Cantwell, a higher education professor at Michigan State University, questioned in a post on Bluesky whether MIT's action changes "the calculus" for the other eight universities.

"The language MIT uses does put the onus on all universities that accept to explain how they are not surrendering academic freedom and institutional independence," Cantwell wrote.

Some lawmakers also applauded MIT for rejecting the compact.

"This is what courage in the face of authoritarianism looks like. No university should take Trump's bribe & surrender their integrity—bending the knee to a bully only feeds the beast & puts ALL our rights at risk," Sen. Chris Van Hollen, a Maryland Democrat, wrote in a post on X. He encouraged others to follow MIT's example in rejecting the administration's demands.

But some Trumpworld figures hinted that there may be retaliation ahead for MIT. "It's time for MIT to be held accountable for their noncompliance. We have a pending lawsuit," Kenneth L. Marcus, a former Department of Education official in the first Trump administration, wrote in a post, tagging Harmeet Dhillon, the assistant attorney general for civil rights at the Department of Justice, who is playing a growing role in the pressure campaign against universities.

Comments from NYT article on MIT rejection...

--- Overwhelmingly approve of MIT's rejection of the compact.
Some threaten to stop contributing to U Texas.

...I am not surprised to learn that MIT has flatly refused to bow to extortionate, anti-intellectual demands. I plead with every other institution of higher learning in the U.S. to join them in saying no to such Stalinist tactics, and am deeply grateful MIT for its leadership in this terrifying time.

...For those of us who remember history, Europe was effectively lost because of appeasement.

I don't know how anyone who claims to be "conservative" can read this list of demands with anything but revulsion. The government telling institutions how to run themselves, how to run their finances, what to

teach, and to police free speech are 100% repugnant. They are NOT American values. They are authoritarian or fascist. Take your pick. Even worse, it has been shown that these attacks are bullying tactics, and like every bullying tactic, if you actually give in to the bully, they will just be back to bully you again.

So the guy who had to pay a \$20 million dollar judgement for running a fake university wants institutions such as MIT to do what he wants.

Conservative ideas belittle themselves. Loudly. Constantly. I am a 70 year old white women and cannot think of any conservative idea that has benefitted me. Even their tough on crime campaign slogan failed to prevent me being attacked by a man released early due to overcrowded prisons (GOP failed to fund prisons, trying to create for profit prisons for their investors instead)

Conservative here. Good for M.I.T. they made a wise choice. I dislike a whole bunch about these Universities but signing a Stalin-like thought control manifesto is not how America works. Trump is no Conservative. He is a freakish alien to Conservatism and supporting him means you have lost your Conservative Soul. End of story.

Let's start with the fact that the architect of this "agreement" is a hedge fund guy MARC ROWAN (see guest essay Oct.10, 2025 -- copy captured). Taking advice on education from wall street elites is laughable. Wealth does not imbue wisdom or integrity, just look at Elon Musk. Second, I guess the Republicans are no longer for free enterprise (extorting equity stakes from corporations Intel and Nippon Steel), science based health care (the destruction of the department of HHS), destruction of strategic relationships with our global allies, the co-opting of our justice system and last but not least free speech and the unencumbered pursuit of knowledge. Trump, Rowan, Bessent, Lutnick, Kennedy...its a long list, are playing tennis on someone else's court. They are like the drunk at the end of the bar who has an uneducated opinion about everything and doesn't mind shouting them in a loud voice. Culture wars as a means of diverting attention from a debauched Republican party, devoid of any principles or policy ideas is a sad movie. Unfortunately my kids have to stick around for the ending.

[MARC ROWAN, according to "Republic Report": "Billionaire Behind Trump Pressure Campaign on Colleges Owns Predatory University of Phoenix... a school with a record of deceiving, over-charging, and under-educating students, leaving graduates and drop-outs alike with overwhelming debt....The University of Phoenix has received tens of billions from federal taxpayers for student grants and loans, at times more than \$2 billion in a single year. It reported \$950 million in income last year – 88 percent of that from federal taxpayers. But the school has posted abysmal graduation rates – currently listed by the U.S. Department of Education as just 25

percent and for many years, and many programs, far worse than that. According to the education department, only 10 percent of former Phoenix students have paid off their student loans or are even making progress in doing so."]

10/13/25: NASA Watch. JPL Announce 550 Layoffs

Keith's note: In a "A message from JPL Director Dave Gallagher" a JPL layoff of 500 people has been announced that is "not related to the current government shutdown". Full memo below:

"In order to best position JPL going forward, we are taking steps to restructure and establish an appropriate size to ensure future success. As part of this effort, JPL is undergoing a realignment of its workforce, including a reduction in staff. This reduction – part of a reorganization that began in July and not related to the current government shutdown – will affect approximately 550 of our colleagues across technical, business, and support areas. Employees will be notified of their status on Tuesday, Oct. 14. Over the past few months, we have communicated openly with employees about the challenges and hard choices ahead. This week's action, while not easy, is essential to securing JPL's future by creating a leaner infrastructure, focusing on our core technical capabilities, maintaining fiscal discipline, and positioning us to compete in the evolving space ecosystem – all while continuing to deliver on our vital work for NASA and the nation. We are grateful for the contributions of our departing colleagues, whose work has advanced exploration and innovation in ways that benefit us all."

Full memo:

Colleagues,

For the past few months, I have communicated openly about our need to create a streamlined infrastructure that enables us to operate more efficiently, make decisions more quietly, and remain competitive in our rapidly changing environment. We continue to take thoughtful but necessary steps now to shape the Lab for the future.

As part of this organizational realignment, we are taking steps to restructure and establish an appropriate size to ensure future success. I'm sharing the difficult news that JPL will be conducting a workforce action tomorrow, Oct, 14, resulting in a layoff of approximately 550 colleagues, or 11% of our workforce. This reduction is part of a reorganization that began in July and not related to the current government shutdown. Unless otherwise notified, all personnel are required to work remotely tomorrow.

Following the workforce action, those continuing with JPL will be notified of their role in the new Lab structure, which will become effective Wednesday, Oct. 15.

Please watch this short video from me (see here) with a message about these changes and the path ahead. Within the same link, you will find more information, including resources and frequently asked questions. At 8:30 a.m. tomorrow, we will host a short, virtual Lab-wide meeting to share what to expect related to the layoff. A calendar invitation will be sent later today.

I recognize this is a tremendous amount of change in a short period of time and will be challenging for our entire community in the coming weeks. While not easy, I believe taking these actions now will help the Lab transform at the scale and pace necessary to help achieve humanity's boldest ambitions in space.

To our colleagues who will be leaving JPL, thank you for your many contributions to the Lab, our community, NASA, and the nation. We are truly grateful for your service, advancing exploration and innovation in ways that benefit us all.

To everyone, I encourage you to take advantage of the resources available through the Human Resources site, including our Employee Assistance Program and more.

Please take care in the days ahead and continue to show the kindness, respect, and support that define this community.

10/14/25: Eos. JPL Workforce Decimated

Today, NASA's Jet Propulsion Laboratory (JPL) in Pasadena, Calif., laid off 550 people, a roughly 11% reduction of its workforce.

...Gallagher said that this workforce reduction is part of a reorganization that began in July and is not related to the current government shutdown that began on 1 October. A 10 October court filing by the White House Office of Management and Budget did not include NASA among the agencies targeted for layoffs by the Trump administration during the ongoing shutdown, reported Space News.

JPL is a research and development laboratory federally funded by NASA. While the current government shutdown continues, NASA has been directed to operate and plan as if the appropriations bill passed by the House of Representative is in effect, which would fund NASA (and most JPL projects) at nearly the same level as the current fiscal year.

Federal whistleblowers, however, have come forward with evidence that

NASA leadership has been operating as if the President's Budget Request (PBR)—not the appropriations bill—is in effect, directing mission wind-down operations and staff reductions under the assumption of a 20% overall budget cut. Some of that lost spending would affect JPL's ability to plan, build, and operate Earth science missions and space exploration spacecraft.

Despite vocal support from the Trump administration and NASA leadership about putting humans on the Moon again and eventually on Mars, the PBR would also cancel the Mars Sample Return program, which would pick up and return to Earth sample capsules collected and deposited by the Perseverance rover. Analysis of those samples would provide critical support to any future human exploration mission to Mars.

Kevin Hicks, a systems engineer who formerly operated rovers at JPL, said that Perseverance's budget is being reduced by two-thirds, "just enough to technically keep it going and not get the full PR backlash of canceling a working rover," he wrote.

This is the fourth round of layoffs at JPL since the beginning of 2024, including an 8% reduction in staff that affected mostly engineering-related positions. The mood among current and former JPL employees is grim. Several people commented on a JPL Reddit forum that they expect more layoffs in the future. "Today was very somber on lab. It felt like everyone [was] grieving," one Redditor wrote on 13 October. Several other posters echoed that sentiment. "We tried to keep a positive, but realistic attitude and we even took a final group photo in front of the JPL concrete logo. However, there's no whitewashing the 'doomsday-eve' feeling that's looming over all our heads."

10/16/25: IHE. Colleges Push Back Against Trump's Effort to Collect More Admissions Data / Institutions and advocates took issue with the proposal's vague language and lack of privacy safeguards as well as the vast time and effort needed to collect the required data.

Institutions of higher education and their advocates are sounding the alarm about the Trump administration's plan to require colleges to submit new data about their admissions decisions.

They argued in public comments that the new requirements for admissions data collection are too vague, request data institutions do not collect and could violate students' privacy. Several institutions said they broadly support transparency and the federal data collection but that the department needs to rethink the proposal to lessen the administrative burden on colleges and universities—especially smaller

institutions with limited institutional research capacity.

Under the Department of Education's proposed Admissions and Consumer Transparency Supplement, institutions would have to submit applied, admitted and enrolled student data broken down by test score quintiles, grade point average quintiles, income ranges, Pell Grant eligibility and parental education levels, as well as data regarding aid and student outcomes. Institutions would also be required to send historical data going back to 2020.

President Donald Trump first called for this data to be collected in an executive order, part of an ongoing crusade to stamp out racial preference in admissions that experts say is going well beyond Supreme Court's 2023 ban on affirmative action. The announcement prompted outcry from admissions professionals, who worried about whether their institutions had the capacity to collect the required data and about how the government planned to use the data.

The public comment period for the rule closed Tuesday, and the department has to review and respond to the comments before finalizing the changes. That process will likely be delayed because of the government shutdown. The department has said it wants to put the requirement in place starting with institutions' annual submission of enrollment data for the 2025-26 application cycle.

Once the rule is finalized, institutions would have just 120 days to submit that data—a deadline that colleges said in comments would prove difficult to meet. The Association for Institutional Research called the proposed data survey "the single largest expansion in [Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System] history, adding more the 100 new questions and roughly 10,000 data fields." AIR said in its comment that in a survey of 580 institutional research and other data professionals, 91 percent of respondents said they would be unable to provide the data by the given deadline and 88 percent of members said that providing retrospective data would be "untenable" due to only holding applicant data for a handful of years.

...Among the comments in opposition to the rule was a joint comment from 18 Democratic attorneys general, who stressed that the data collection went beyond the scope of the Supreme Court's affirmative action ban in *Students for Fair Admissions v. Harvard* and would not help reduce discrimination in the admissions process. "SFFA does not prohibit schools from pursuing diversity by lawful means. Nothing in the Supreme Court's decision restricts IHEs from embracing diversity as an objective; indeed, the Court held that '[u]niversities may define their missions as they see fit,'" they wrote. "Diversity is not a symptom of discrimination; data showing that campuses maintained diverse student populations after SFFA does not indicate a likelihood of unlawful admissions practices."

Nearly 90 percent of the more than 3,400 comments posted supported the proposed rule, ALL USING NEAR-IDENTICAL LANGUAGE that reads, "As a concerned citizen, I am worried about the appearance of continued racial discrimination in college admissions. Universities that receive our tax dollars have been repeatedly told that using race for admissions decisions is illegal, yet it is unclear whether colleges have gotten the message." It's unclear what the source of this comment is, but it cites data from the right-wing nonprofit Defending Education.

...Institutions also questioned the inclusion of several metrics that would likely be difficult to standardize. In a comment, University of Rochester provost Nicole Sampson wrote that high school GPA, for example, is calculated differently at different high schools—some using a weighted 5.0 scale, others only using an unweighted 4.0 scale—and has never previously been collected by IPEDS. Similarly, some institutions have test-optional or even test-free admissions policies, meaning they do not collect their applicants' scores.

...Similarly, some comments noted that graduate admissions are decentralized, often spread across professional schools and health centers, and those different schools or departments may collect different information.

A comment from the Association of American Universities also drew attention to a slew of issues the department may face in interpreting the data it has requested from universities, including the fact that the majority of institutions consider many factors outside of GPA and test scores when making an admissions decision.

...The association also noted that local priorities may shape admissions decisions; in North Carolina, for example, no more than 18 percent of an incoming class may be out-of-state students, which may result in lower test scores and GPAs from in-state students.

...Several commenters also suggested the department outline how it will safeguard students' privacy and proposed that the government allocate funds to support institutions in their data collection—especially as cuts to IPEDS staff have already made it more difficult for colleges to complete their mandated data collection.

10/21/25: FYI

Subject: COMMERCE MOVES TO TAKE CUT OF RESEARCH PATENTS / The agency has opened the possibility in a recent funding announcement and threatened to take control of Harvard's patents.

Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick says he is looking to take a cut from university patents that result from federally funded research,

going against the Bayh-Dole Act, a 1980 law that allows universities full ownership of such patents.

In a September interview with Axios, Lutnick argued that taxpayers should receive half the profit from university patents, comparing it to fully funding a private business.

Once the government starts taking that 50% cut, Lutnick said, "our social security system will be paid for and we won't be a broke country running \$2 trillion deficits, because we're the richest country in the world, we're just dopey," adding, "We give away between \$200 and \$300 billion a year in grants." Lutnick said every U.S. university should be subject to such profit-sharing, with "a few universities to start and then a master deal." Lutnick sent a letter to Harvard University in August regarding its patents and said he planned to send another to the University of California system.

The administration has so far struck deals with Columbia University and Brown University to restore federal funding and has been pursuing other university deals, the latest being the "Compact for Academic Excellence in Higher Education" offered first to nine higher ed institutions and now open to all. However, none of these mention patents.

The Commerce Department began implementing new patent-related policies soon after Lutnick's interview, with the National Institute of Standards and Technology issuing a broad funding solicitation for which awardees may be required to issue royalties or otherwise share revenue with the Commerce Department "to ensure a return on investment to the government." In response to Lutnick's remarks, the Bayh-Dole Coalition, which advocates for protecting the legislation, said taxpayers "already benefit greatly under the current system," adding that the law has enabled nearly \$2 trillion in economic output, supported 6.5 million jobs, and helped launch more than 19,000 startups since 1996.

The coalition added that lawmakers considered including a similar profit-sharing model in early versions of the Bayh-Dole Act, but abandoned it after federal agencies "correctly concluded" that it would deter licensing and commercialization.

Stephen Ezell from the Information Technology and Innovation Foundation think tank wrote in response to Lutnick's remarks that the federal government receives 20 times more in tax revenues from university research parks than it would by taking half of university royalty revenues. The government also benefits from the "extensive innovations" produced and the tax revenue from "trillions in industrial output and millions of jobs created as a result of university tech transfer," Ezell wrote.

However, some scholars have argued that the Bayh-Dole framework is ineffective, causing universities to prioritize profits rather than commercialization potential and even discouraging innovation overall. A 2018 article from *Issues in Science and Technology* theorizes that Bayh-Dole stifles biomedical innovation because the resulting exclusive licensing agreements prevent other university and industry scientists from using new basic knowledge. "More effective innovation policies would provide incentives for universities to make their commercializable discoveries freely available and to disseminate them widely," the article states.

More recently, witnesses testifying before the House Science Committee have suggested that the Bayh-Dole framework needs improvement. "I actually think that some of the federal laws with respect to intellectual property need to change," said Heather Wilson, president of the University of Texas at El Paso, at a hearing in February. "From my perspective, the value of the research as a university is in the research and the development of the PhDs through doing research. We do a lousy job of getting that IP out into companies. So things like Bayh-Dole may actually limit the amount of research that can be transferred out," she added.

MARCH-IN ON HARVARD

The Bayh-Dole Coalition wrote a letter to President Donald Trump in March asking him to reverse actions from the Biden administration that infringe upon Bayh-Dole. Among these was a draft guidance from NIST that would permit agencies to exercise their "march-in rights" if a company's product does not have a "reasonable" price. March-in rights, which are established in the Bayh-Dole Act, allow the funding agency to compel the patent owner or an exclusive licensee to grant a license to third parties in specific circumstances.

The Trump administration has not rescinded the NIST guidance. Moreover, Lutnick moved to exercise the Commerce Department's march-in rights in his August letter to Harvard, potentially taking ownership of Harvard's patents or granting licenses to third parties. The letter asserts that Harvard has failed to comply with regulations regarding timely disclosure and election of title, preferencing U.S. industry, and taking "effective steps to achieve practical applications of subject inventions."

"If Harvard won't honor the Bayh-Dole Act, then we will find someone who will," Lutnick wrote on X. Harvard has not issued a response. The Council for Innovation Promotion, a coalition focused on IP rights, criticized the move, adding that no administration has exercised its march-in rights before. "Just as no one would build a house on land they might lose, innovators and entrepreneurs will not invest in discoveries if their patent rights can be revoked at will," C4IP Executive Director Frank Cullen said in a statement.

Lutnick's letter is just one element of the Trump administration's attacks on Harvard this year, which so far have included terminating all of the university's federal grants – which have since been restored by court order– and considering debarment, which would prevent the university from receiving any federal funding or contracts.

Separately, other high-level members of the Trump administration have floated ideas for using march-in rights for other purposes. In an op-ed last year, Paul Dabbar and Ted Garrish, who now respectively serve as deputy secretary of commerce and assistant secretary for nuclear energy, suggested starting a China IP Initiative that would use march-in rights to prevent Chinese entities from illegally appropriating U.S. federally funded discoveries.

10/22/25: IHE. 'Because I Said So': Universities Double Down on Unwritten Policies / A growing number of institutions are censoring faculty speech and instruction through murky verbal directives that sow fear and confusion. Can they be enforced?

In front of a few dozen faculty members at a town hall-style meeting on Oct. 10, Angelo State University president Ronnie Hawkins said, repeatedly, that new university policies prohibiting discussion of transgender identity in class would not be written down.

"We have not put out any written guidance on that, but it's tied to that executive order that the president put out, and then also the directive of the governor, and so that's what makes it law for us to have to follow here at Angelo State University," Hawkins said, referencing orders by President Donald Trump and Gov. Greg Abbott that recognize only two genders—male and female. "But there's no other written types of documentation that we plan to be putting out that's tied to that."

Angelo State, one of five institutions in the Texas Tech University system, has been in the news for weeks over murky new directives, passed down telephone-style from university leaders to deans to faculty members, that prohibit faculty from acknowledging more than two gender identities. The rules have confusing and widespread implications; for example, faculty are unsure whether they can display a pride flag in their own office, field student questions about transgender identity or teach health-care students how to care for someone who has had gender-confirmation surgery. The Oct. 10 town hall didn't clear anything up.

"Our general counsel has told us that at the system level, there's no gray area" in the law, Hawkins said at the town hall, according to a

recording Inside Higher Ed obtained. But none of the laws or orders Hawkins referenced limit what faculty can legally teach about gender. Texas House Bill 229, which Hawkins also cited during the town hall, directs state institutions to use only male and female gender options in state data collection, but it does not apply to academic instruction. The president's and governor's executive orders are not law. When asked by a faculty member whether the spoken directive violates the university's core values of "diversity and inclusion," Hawkins said it does not, because designing the core values "had nothing to do with race. It had nothing to do with gender. It had everything to do with us being a diverse university." Regarding whether or not to follow the directive, Hawkins told faculty members, "If you don't agree with that, you have a choice to make yourself."

...other institutions have issued similar spoken rules. So has the University of North Florida, where university leaders verbally instructed the College of Education dean to remove the words "diversity, equity and inclusion" and "culture" from course descriptions and learning objectives, and to bypass typical institutional processes for changing course content.

..."All the [education] college deans are just scratching their heads about this. It is not written anywhere, and it's very clear in Florida statute ... that all laws and administrative rules be written and published in order to be valid and enforceable," Beasley said.

he new rule is likely a response to two Florida laws, faculty say. The first, Florida House Bill 7, is currently blocked by a court order, but if enforced it would significantly curtail how faculty members can teach and speak about sex and gender. The law prohibits any instruction or training that "espouses, promotes, advances, inculcates, or compels a student or employee to believe" certain "concepts" relating to race, color, national origin or sex. For example, a lesson about structural sexism or racism would be prohibited under the law. The second law, Florida House Bill 875, which took effect in May, says that teacher-preparation courses "may not distort significant historical events or include curriculum or instruction that teaches identity politics, violates or is based on theories that systemic racism, sexism, oppression, and privilege are inherent in the institutions of the United States and were created to maintain social, political, and economic inequities."

Neither law specifically bans the terms "diversity, equity and inclusion" or "culture" from course content, descriptions or syllabi. Spokespeople for the Florida Board of Governors did not respond to Inside Higher Ed's request for comment.

..."Faculty are losing control over the curriculum," Trapani said. "Textbooks are just disappearing in the night. Assignments are being changed, words are being changed, and we have no idea what's

happening at any of our sister institutions. As we speak, there could be some intransigence happening at University of Florida, and I have no idea about what's going on there, nor, probably, do the faculty at large, because it happens in such small corridors with so few officials involved."

John White, an English professor...is pushing back hard on the new directive. He filed a grievance with the faculty union, arguing that "my academic freedom has been infringed by the university making me change course materials via some kind of mandate from above that no one can show me," White said. Administrators changed course descriptions and learning objectives over the summer without faculty input, according to White. When faculty returned in the fall, they were told to remove the terms from their syllabi as well, he added, or else their course might not be approved by the department.

"I told the dean I would not change my syllabus, because I said, 'I want to actually read the administrative rule or the law that mandates this ... otherwise, we're just going on hearsay, and I refuse to give up my rights based upon hearsay,'" White said. "And they insisted that I would be in trouble if I didn't change it."

10/23/25: FYI: Science Policy News from AIP

Union Lawsuit Challenges NASA National Security Rebrand
Lindsay McKenzie

The International Federation of Professional and Technical Engineers is suing the Trump administration over its attempt to end union representation at NASA and rebrand the agency as an intelligence and national security organization. The IFPTE lawsuit, filed earlier this month, challenges the White House's assertion that national security is NASA's "primary function," adding that NASA has been collectively bargaining with IFPTE local unions for over 60 years and "at no time has such bargaining ever been questioned as inconsistent with national security." It argues that President Donald Trump's actions exceed his authority and unfairly target the union, which has publicly protested the administration's cuts at the agency. IFPTE represents approximately 6,000 employees at NASA.

The lawsuit follows an August executive order that bars some agencies – including NASA and parts of the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration – from engaging in collective bargaining on the grounds that negotiating union contracts could hinder agencies' ability to operate effectively and quickly, creating a national security risk.

Trump's order describes "intelligence, counterintelligence, investigative, or national security work" as "a primary function" of NASA and other agencies. An accompanying fact sheet states that NASA

“develops and operates advanced air and space technologies, like satellite, communications, and propulsion systems, that are critical for U.S. national security.”

Trump issued a related executive order in March directing most federal agencies – including the National Science Foundation, most of the Department of Energy, and parts of the Department of Health and Human Services – to terminate their union contracts, citing a narrow legal provision that allows the president to suspend collective bargaining in the interest of national security.

Trump’s March order prompted swift legal challenges from multiple unions representing federal workers, including IFPTE, which filed a lawsuit on behalf of employees at the Department of Defense in July. On Sept. 30, a federal judge issued a preliminary injunction blocking the Trump administration from terminating the collective bargaining rights of DOD workers represented by IFPTE, saying the president had overstepped his authority. Some agencies not covered by the injunction have reportedly terminated union contracts in line with President Trump’s orders.

Other lawsuits filed in response to the August executive order are ongoing, including one representing around 4,000 employees at NOAA’s National Weather Service and the Office of Satellite Products and Operations in the National Environmental Satellite, Data, and Information Service.

The Trump administration’s framing of NASA as an intelligence and national security agency has drawn criticism from space policy experts, including Casey Dreier, chief of space policy at The Planetary Society, who told Politico that the public’s relationship with NASA will be “fundamentally changed for the worse if NASA is seen as an extension of the national security apparatus, rather than a projection of peaceful exploration and shared values.”

NASA was created by a 1958 law that designated it as a civilian agency and specified that “activities peculiar to or primarily associated with the development of weapons systems, military operations, or the defense of the United States (including the research and development necessary to make effective provision for the defense of the United States) shall be the responsibility of, and shall be directed by, the Department of Defense.” The law further states that U.S. space activities “should be devoted to peaceful purposes for the benefit of mankind.”

The creation of the Space Force in 2019 as a military branch responsible for protecting U.S. interests in space also prompted discussion about NASA’s role as a civilian agency for science and exploration – a distinction that is reiterated on the Space Force website. Some security experts argue, however, that NASA’s mission is

central to U.S. national security interests. Peter Garretson, a senior fellow in defense studies at the American Foreign Policy Council, wrote in a journal article last year that "NASA is a national security organization whose duties include ensuring the pre-eminence of the United States. Its job is not to build weapons or engage in conflict—but to pursue American strategic objectives below the threshold of armed conflict."

NASA's ties to the Department of Defense have separately drawn criticism from Rep. Zoe Lofgren (D-CA), the top Democrat on the House Science Committee. In a letter to acting NASA Administrator Sean Duffy last month, Lofgren wrote that she has "serious concerns about NASA's developing relationship with the U.S. Air Force that will need to be addressed."

"NASA must remain focused on its mission as a civil space agency and a scientific agency," wrote Lofgren. "It cannot permit unrelated priorities to distract it from its mission or impair its ability to achieve its ambitious objectives in space for the benefit of humanity here on Earth."

10/31/25: Halloween developments...Talk about scary!

Van Scoyoc newsletter

Trump's surgeon general pick goes into labor before confirmation hearing

President Donald Trump's controversial pick for surgeon general, Casey Means, had to postpone her Senate confirmation hearing after going into labor with her first child, a spokesperson said. Dr Means, nominated to be the "nation's top doctor", was scheduled to appear before the Senate committee virtually because of her advanced pregnancy. Unlike past surgeon generals, the 38-year-old Stanford-trained doctor and wellness entrepreneur DOES NOT HAVE AN ACTIVE MEDICAL LICENSE. She is known for her SKEPTICISM OF CONVENTIONAL MEDICINE AND PROMOTION OF WELLNESS PRODUCTS instead. Read more: [BBC \[vsadc.us4.list-manage.com\]](https://www.bbc.com/news/health-67444444)

Head of RFK Jr.'s vaccine panel: SCHOOL MANDATES 'NOT NECESSARY'

Martin Kulldorff, chair of the Advisory Committee on Immunization Practices (ACIP) at the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), said in an interview Thursday he believes vaccine mandates for schools are "not necessary." In an interview with Politico, the ACIP's influence on school vaccine policy was noted and Kulldorff was asked how he wanted the committee to approach the issue. Last month, Florida moved to ban all school vaccine mandates in the state. The decision drew pushback from some Republicans in

Congress, with Sen. Thom Tillis (N.C.) calling it a “horrible idea.” Read more: The Hill [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

Threat to US vaccines as CDC staff supporting key advisory panel laid off

The staff supporting the Advisory Committee on Immunization Practices (ACIP) WERE LET GO EARLIER THIS MONTH in a sweeping round of layoffs that GUTTED ENTIRE DEPARTMENTS of the US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC). Most of the committee’s working groups, which pore over data and help set the agendas, haven’t met for months, and there was little communication from the staff even before they received reduction in force (RIF) notices during the US government shutdown. Read more: The Guardian [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

Kennedy directs CDC to study alleged harms of offshore wind farms, Bloomberg News reports

U.S. Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. ordered the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention staff to probe the potential harms of offshore wind farms, Bloomberg News reported on Tuesday, citing people familiar with the matter. The move is part of a broader push by the Trump administration to SCRUTINIZE OFFSHORE WIND DEVELOPMENT, which Trump himself has repeatedly criticized. The report added that the office of the U.S. surgeon general has also been involved in the initiative, which the HHS, prior to the ongoing government shutdown, aimed to have completed within a couple of months. Read more: Reuters [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

Navy REPLACES ADMIRAL LEADING NAVAL RESEARCH WITH FORMER DOGE STAFFER

The U.S. Navy has replaced the admiral in charge of the Office of Naval Research with a civilian who has reportedly worked as a Department of Government Efficiency staffer, according to the service. Rear Adm. Kurt. Rothenhaus, who has served as chief of naval research since June 2023, has been reassigned and replaced by Rachel Riley, who most recently acted as a senior adviser for the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, a Navy public affairs official confirmed in an emailed statement Thursday. Read more: Navy Times [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

GSFC UNDER ATTACK

10/31/25: Space.com. Josh Dinner.

NASA is sinking its flagship science center during the government shutdown – and may be breaking the law in the process, critics say

"There is just a general acknowledgement that a lot of what is happening is illegal..."

NASA's flagship center for space science is under attack from within, and some of the biggest losses appear to be happening behind the curtain of the government shutdown.

Throughout the summer of 2025, Space.com interviewed nearly a dozen current and former NASA workers and reviewed several internal agency communications in an investigation into allegations of unlawful activity by NASA leadership – allegations supported in a recent report by the U.S. Senate Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation. The conclusion: NASA has been prematurely and illegally implementing the President's 2026 budget request before Congress finalizes funding.

The workforce at NASA's Goddard Space Flight Center (GSFC) in Greenbelt, Maryland, say this has put groundbreaking missions at risk, and is degrading roadblocks designed to safeguard human lives. Now, under the cloak of a closed U.S. government, nearly half the GSFC campus – the hub of NASA science – is marked for abandonment.

Goddard has a target on its back

Goddard has worked on some of NASA's most iconic space science missions, including the James Webb Space Telescope and the Hubble Space Telescope, which continue to provide groundbreaking astronomical discoveries, and OSIRIS-REx, NASA's first asteroid sample-return mission. It's also where NASA is tackling ambitious new missions like the Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope, the Laser Interferometer Space Antenna (LISA) to detect gravitational waves and measure ripples in space-time, and the Venus atmospheric probe DAVINCI.

GSFC hosts the largest single concentration of researchers in the NASA workforce, encompassing the agency's Science Mission Directorate (SMD) and Engineering and Technology Directorate (ETD). Nearly 10,000 scientists and engineers work at Goddard in total, around 7,000 of whom are employed through NASA contractors. Center staff said they felt what they perceived as the new administration's vitriol for science early on.

"The atmosphere, from my perspective, at least, has been incredibly dark and depressing," Goddard astrophysicist Casey McGrath told Space.com <http://space.com/>, clarifying that he was not speaking on behalf of NASA or his agency contract employer. "I feel like the people I work with, myself included, have just been demoralized, exhausted, terrified, frustrated and angry, for months and months on end with no pause whatsoever."

The internal cultures of NASA centers across the country have evolved to align, at least in part, with the political leanings of their respective locales. With Goddard based in a Democratic state under a Republican administration, many there feel as though the space center is being singled out.

Casey Dreier, chief of space policy at the space science and exploration advocacy nonprofit The Planetary Society, explained the divide_during a Sept. 18 livestream_ <<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uwUhLmM4UdQ>> about NASA's ongoing budget saga.

"There's been a really notable divergence and concentration within NASA, almost purely by a historical accident of its major internal directorates and responsibilities, where human spaceflight NASA centers have become very solidly Republican represented, at least at the state level, and NASA science centers have become very Democratic represented at the state level," Dreier said.

"My title is Research Physical Scientist ... even though I'm actually a climate scientist. Apparently the c-word just sets some people off." – Claire

It's a perception shared by many Goddard employees. "Claire," who asked that her real name remain anonymous for fear of retribution, is a climate scientist at the Goddard Institute for Space Studies (GISS) – a branch of the Maryland campus that, until earlier this year, occupied a building on the Columbia University campus in New York City. While her primary focus is on climate science, Claire's official title is Research Physical Scientist. She referred to "climate" as the "c-word,"**and a term she and her colleagues constantly felt the need to talk around, rather than say outright.

"It does feel like there is an overlap between the political party in charge of your NASA center and how your NASA center is faring right now," Claire said. "Goddard is a science-based center with a lot of engineers, and a lot of their missions are canceled out (in the President's budget request). It's taking a huge hit to the civil service workforce. It does feel like Goddard is now being singled out."

In January 2025, former NASA Administrator Bill Nelson stepped down from the position ahead of Trump's inauguration, making way for the appointment of_Kennedy Space Center_ Director_Janet Petro_ as the agency's acting administrator. Petro was_tasked with steering NASA's early transition_ period.

At Goddard, Segrid Harris was appointed ETD director in January and began enforcing rigid expectations that many staff saw as a cultural break from NASA norms.

After that, "the mood started changing almost immediately," Rose Ferreira, a former Goddard spaceflight analyst who was abruptly laid off during SpaceX CEO Elon Musk's early DOGE (Department of Government Efficiency) sweep through the federal workforce, told Space.com. "The language that was being used in some of our internal emails was so aggressive. I've never seen anything like this from NASA," Ferreira said at the time.

"I think they know that what they're doing shouldn't be put in writing." – Wendy

"[Harris] was brought in from the Air Force, and she is very strict on the chain of command, and basically is implementing what center management is telling her to do," said "Wendy," a Goddard spacecraft engineer who also spoke on the condition of anonymity for fear of retribution, in an interview.

"When we had DOGE coming on site, we had some supervisors saying that if DOGE asks you for access to your laptop, you should give it to them. Basically, just hand over the keys," Wendy said. "That direction was implied to come from Engineering management, but not put in writing."

"It's really hard for us to get anything in writing from Engineering management, because I think they know that what they're doing shouldn't be put in writing," she added.

Another GSFC civil servant who asked to remain anonymous, "Peter," said that's by design. "Goddard management is very good at obfuscating its intentions directly, either through refusal to put any directives in writing or by working through chain of command, such that decisions don't necessarily reflect back on the individual who ultimately made them." Peter spoke with Space.com about ongoing building closures taking place at Goddard's Greenbelt campus, but months before, GISS was identified as the first in a chain of dominos to be knocked down.

GISS: The first to fall

By March, NASA was implementing workforce reductions and closing offices (such as the Office of the Chief Scientist and the Office of Technology, Policy & Strategy). Internal speculation about NASA's future painted a bleak picture for Goddard and its programs. Meanwhile, the vulnerability of NASA's climate science programs was being underscored nationally, as former agency leadership raised the alarm.

"The first person that was fired at NASA ... was the Chief Scientist and Chief Climate Officer," Nelson said during an event in Washington,

D.C. in April. "I think we need to be concerned about that."

That concern, it seems, was warranted. Later that month, GISS employees were ordered to vacate their Columbia University building (which many may recognize as the one with the corner diner in the show /Seinfeld/). Since then, they've been forced to work remotely – at a time when the government was doling out return-to-office mandates – preventing access to labs and crippling the center's mission of embedding NASA climate scientists within international academia. Though the closure came as a shock, the reasoning behind it seemed obvious to those on the ground.

"We have one of the original models for climate simulation," Claire explained. GISS develops and maintains research on atmospheric composition and long-term climate change, and manages NASA's global surface temperature record – one of the world's key climate datasets.

"We have the ignoble distinction now of being the second NASA center ever closed down," Claire said. NASA's Electronics Research Center in Cambridge, Massachusetts, was the first, shuttered in 1970 due to budget cuts during the restructuring of the Apollo program.

Jim Green, a former NASA Chief Scientist who retired in 2022 after 42 years at the agency, told Space.com that stewardship of that climate research requires a significant undertaking.

"The huge Earth science workforce at Goddard analyzes an enormous amount of Earth science data that comes in ... That requires quite a cadre of very knowledgeable people," Green said. "Not only the project scientists and the scientists analyzing the data coming from those missions, but also the scientists that are managing multi-mission analysis. That's particularly true in Earth science."

Green said climate and Earth science have a big footprint at NASA. "Earth science in particular has a huge, huge infrastructure analyzing our Earth satellites. So I think they, of course, have been hit disproportionately because of the approach the administration is taking," he said.

The move out of the GISS building was chaotic. Equipment for one NASA mission, PACE (Plankton, Aerosol, Cloud, ocean Ecosystem) – a satellite launched in February 2024 that measures the health of Earth's oceans – had to be hurriedly moved between agency sites to avoid program setbacks.

"There was about, I don't know, a million dollars worth of [PACE] equipment," Claire estimated. "They told us to get out of the building... So the PI (principal investigator) rented a car, and he put all of the stuff in the car and drove through the night to put it on another NASA facility so that it'd be safe."

GISS's position on a university campus allowed for a unique relationship between the facility and academia. Only about a third of the people who work at GISS are federal employees or federal contractors. The other two-thirds work for Columbia and other universities. "They are those soft-money scientists who are totally supported by those federal research grants," Claire said.

"They didn't fire us, but they didn't have to fire us," Claire said. "All they have to do is stop putting money into federal research grants, and it will have the same impact without any of the stop measures that you have for the federal civil service. Those do not exist in the academic community for the federal research grants."

While they still have work to do, their ability to do it is being siloed. "When it comes to doing cutting-edge science, having a little bit of face time goes a really long way," Claire explained. "The cross talk, the back-and-forth that you cannot have during Zoom meetings – during face-to-face meetings, you can. You actually make a lot of progress," she said. "That's all gone. And so this piece of our mission, which was to be integrated into the academic community – we've been cut off at our knees."

Claire used Climate Week NYC, an event celebrated at the end of September, as an example of opportunities missed as a result of the new constraints. "There are people coming to New York City from across the world," she said at the time. "If we still had our facility and that was happening, we would have dozens of meetings leveraging our conference centers on site, so that we could be true to our mission ... Now, we're scrambling just to find a space."

Closing GISS may have also violated NASA's agreement with Claire's employee union. Claire is a member of GESTA, the Goddard Engineers, Scientists and Technicians Association. GESTA operates under the umbrella of IFPTE, the International Federation of Professional and Technical Engineers, and advocates for NASA employees' rights, working conditions and policies.

"As a civil servant, I had a collective bargaining agreement that said certain things had to happen before there could be a change in working conditions," Claire said. "My collective bargaining agreement was totally ignored when they kicked us out of our building with just a month's notice."

Today, the GISS building presumably still sits empty, with NASA apparently continuing to foot the bill.

"The super has told us the building is not rented out," Claire

said. "He thinks it's still being paid for. They're not showing it off to anyone else."

In retrospect, Claire wondered if GISS was a test case for closures at Goddard that came months later, and are happening now.

"They are closing down a significant part of the Goddard campus, and so I think that we [at GISS] were singled out to be the first one to get poked," she said. "In general, Goddard is not a favorite amongst the NASA centers."

NASA's budget eviscerated

Days after GISS employees were given notice to vacate their building, the White House released the FY26 Presidential Budget Request (PBR). It proposed a historic 24% cut to overall NASA funding and slashed the money for space agency science programs by 47%.

Experts called the cuts catastrophic, saying they waste billions in federal investments and gut groundbreaking missions.

"Three words that we've been using to describe this: unprecedented, unstrategic and wasteful – wasteful of the taxpayers' investment," Jack Kiraly, director of government relations at the Planetary Society, said during the Sept. 18 livestream. The Planetary Society has lobbied to restore NASA's budget in Congress's appropriations bill since the budget request's publication, which cancels 41 planned or already active science missions, including functioning spacecraft operating in Earth orbit and beyond.

Dreier called it an "extinction-level event."

"This isn't just poor policy – it's fundamentally wasteful and inefficient, exactly what this Administration is saying it does not want," Dreier told Space.com in June. "When you abruptly terminate projects that are already in development, or well-functioning projects operating for pennies on the proverbial dollar, you're essentially throwing away all the previous investment while gaining nothing in return."

"The operating missions cancellations alone represent over \$12 billion of invested taxpayer value. And once they're gone, they're gone. It would take years and many millions more to replace them," he added.

Another casualty of the FY26 budget request was NASA's Office of STEM Engagement (OSTEM), which was completely eliminated from the space agency's portfolio. OSTEM was responsible for NASA's educational outreach and student involvement in science, technology, engineering and mathematics programs.

"That not only has an effect on what we do at NASA in terms of workforce development, but also kids across the entire country," said Julie, an agency employee who did not wish to give her last name, told Space.com during a worker-organized demonstration to protest agency science cuts_ in July. She was not authorized to speak on behalf of NASA.

Julie listed programs like grad school scholarships and teacher training initiatives that will be lost in OSTEM's absence. "If that's something that goes away completely, it's going to impact the entire next generation of students," she said.

"We're not talking about delays in scientific exploration. We're talking about the end of it." – Bill Nye, Planetary Society CEO

Since the FY26 budget request's release, pushback has been sharp. Employees at Goddard under the banner NASA Needs Help_ <<https://sites.google.com/view/nasaneedshelp/home>> organized three public protests over the summer, and have joined organizations like the Planetary Society and lawmakers to call on Congress to restore NASA's funding.

At an Oct. 5_day of action on Capitol Hill_ hosted by the Planetary Society, CEO Bill Nye outlined the stakes. "Fully functioning spacecraft summarily turned off, development work on virtually every future science mission summarily halted. We're not talking about delays in scientific exploration. We're talking about the end of it," he said.

To his relief and others,_Congress is pushing back_ <<https://www.space.com/space-exploration/senators-push-back-on-trumps-proposal-to-cut-nasa-science-funding-by-47-percent>>__on the proposed cuts.

The Senate Appropriations Committee advanced a measure to fund NASA at a level comparable to fiscal year 2025, and there is_bipartisan support_ for maintaining the space agency's science programs. But many who_protested over the summer_ worry that irreparable damage has already occurred, and is being accelerated by the government shutdown.

Part of that fear is due to the perception that whatever Congress signs into law won't matter. Employees assume the Office of Management and Budget (OMB) will illegally impound funds anyway. Some think it's already happening. "People expect that to continue," said Wendy, the Goddard engineer. "So they don't trust that Congress's budget will actually be implemented even after it's passed."

Lawmakers, too, have voiced skepticism about OMB's actions. In

an_op-ed published Aug. 5_, Republican Representative Brian Babin, of Texas's 36th district, wrote, "Although Congress is working to ensure NASA has what it needs, the Office of Management and Budget's proposed budget doesn't align with Mr. Trump's directives. To be blunt: OMB needs to start rowing in the same direction. We don't have time for budget games."

Kiraly, with the Planetary Society, thinks there's a deeper motivation behind OMB fighting the tide: OMB Director Russell Vought.

"This is not the President's budget. This is not Congress's budget. This isn't even secretary Sean Duffy's, who's serving as the acting Administrator of NASA (_since replacing Petro in July_). This is Russ Vought's budget," Kiraly said during the Planetary Society livestream.

Vought, Kiraly said, has it out for NASA. "He is somebody that historically has not seen a lot of value in space science ... who does not believe that the government should be investing in space exploration or space science," he said. "And we know that because just a couple years ago, he very much_wrote this exact thing_. He wants to propose a 50% reduction to NASA Science."

Dreier agreed. "The problem with the OMB," he said, "is not just that they can control the flow of money. They control the rate of spending in addition to preparing these budget requests. So even if you provide them the money, they can throw in a decent number of internal bureaucratic hurdles or slow-walk the pace at which this goes out."

Early enforcement

The debate over the budget and implementation legalities is still taking place months later. Very quickly after the FY26 budget request's release, however, NASA leadership started sending messages to staff about reshaping the agency in that image. They announced organization restructurings, impending reductions in force (RIFs) and encouraged space agency employees to take advantage of Deferred Resignation Programs (DRPs).

In a June 9 email obtained by Space.com, Petro instructed staff to start implementing changes to reflect "the Administration's priorities."

"While it is moving through the legislative process, the proposed funding requires action now," the email states. In bold, Petro listed three different programs available to employees who wanted to do their part in thinning NASA's workforce: the agency's DRP, Voluntary Early Retirement (VERA) and a Voluntary Separation Incentive Program (VSIP).

"We're already seeing the agency is moving to put in motion things that are laid out in the President's budget request, even though Congress hasn't weighed in yet, because they think it's clear that that is the direction we're ultimately going to be heading in," McGrath said in July.

That observation was shared by others at Goddard. "The reason a lot of management says that we have to plan for the President's budget request, as opposed to Congress's budget, is because they believe that the President will impound the funds even if Congress passes a budget," Wendy said.

U.S. Senator Maria Cantwell (D-Wash.), Ranking Member of the Senate Committee on Commerce, Science and Transportation, said what's happening at NASA is illegal. A Democratic staff report released by Cantwell and the Committee on Sept. 29, titled "The Destruction of NASA's Mission," says NASA's preemptive compliance with the PBR is an "unconstitutional plot to gut the agency" and circumvents Congress's authority.

"The President's proposed budget...carries no force of law, cannot override existing spending laws, and has no legal impact on funding appropriated by Congress," the report says.

"Losing hundreds of NASA scientists and experts with irreplaceable experience – especially at Goddard – as well as permanently shuttering labs, one-of-a-kind equipment and entire buildings, causes irreversible disruptions to core scientific research that will last far into the future and undermine the United States' global leadership position," Cantwell told Space.com in a statement.

"We will not win the space race in the long run without fully funding NASA's science mission," she added.

Duffy named Amit Kshatriya as NASA associate administrator Sept. 3. After the report's release, Kshatriya unequivocally denied its claims.

"This report is false," Kshatriya said in a statement to Space.com. "NASA has communicated openly and transparently with Congress that we continue to execute our available appropriated funding in accordance with established fiscal policies which respect congressional authorities."

"NASA will never compromise on safety. The President's budget request stands with Congress at this point, and NASA will enact the budget appropriated to us," Kshatriya added.

NASA Press Secretary Bethany Stevens said that the publication of the Senate report was strategic, and politically motivated.

"The intentionally timed release of this inflammatory, false report is nothing more than a distraction tactic from Senate Democrats. As Democrats push to shut our government down, they're attempting to divert attention," she told Space.com in a statement.

The Senate's report supports Space.com's findings, stating, "as early as June 2025, NASA began 'implementing immediately' certain 'institutional changes' to align with the President's proposed budget," and asserts that NASA Chief of Staff Brian Hughes is conspiring with OMB to "actively implement the President's FY26 budget request."

In an internal NASA email obtained for the report, space agency leadership was told, "PBR is the direction. Discretionary funds can be impounded per the Impoundment Act of 1974. If there is a CR (continuing resolution), impoundment is likely going to get on the table as a mechanism to get to the PBR."

One of the report's key findings concluded that "OMB Director Russell Vought's budgetary end game is to use impoundment to illegally implement the President's proposed budget at NASA, while ignoring congressional funding levels."

Over the past several months at Goddard, this has been an open secret. "There is just a general acknowledgement that a lot of what is happening is illegal," Wendy said, "but people have been told to do it, and so they feel like they have to do it. That's especially true for management, because they're getting directives from people above them, and if they don't comply, they will lose their jobs."

Reduction in force

Through June and July, leadership continued to push DRPs and signaled looming RIFs. Morale at Goddard sank as losses mounted, and the future of different missions hung in limbo.

"We are seeing more and more people taking [the DRP] now while the window is still open. I think that's kind of because we don't know what will happen after that window closes, and it might be a worse scenario than the current one," McGrath said earlier this summer.

Employees in programs that lost their funding in the budget request are preparing to shut off functioning spacecraft. Some of those active missions marked for termination include the Chandra X-ray Observatory, which studies high-energy X-ray sources like black holes, the MAVEN (Mars Atmosphere and Volatile Evolution) orbiter studying the Martian atmosphere, the Juno probe orbiting Jupiter, which has at least another three years of life in it, and New

Horizons_, which became the first spacecraft to fly by Pluto in 2015 and is now exploring the Kuiper Belt beyond.

"Mission leads are being told to plan for their missions to be shut down if they were zeroed out in the President's budget request, and this includes missions that are already in space and sending back data and have very minimal upkeep. They just want to turn them off," Wendy said. Meanwhile, NASA leadership tightened their embrace of the budget request.

"The President's FY 2026 Budget Request for NASA is NASA's budget request," Petro wrote in a June 27 email to employees obtained by Space.com. She acknowledges an ultimate budget has yet to be finalized by Congress, but that NASA needs "to begin preparing to align our workforce and resources now to meet the mission priorities [the budget request] outlines."

The directive was again echoed down the chain of command in a July 9 email to Goddard engineers obtained by Space.com, which says ETD reorganization plans in development prior to Trump's second term would be shifted to fit "the vision put forward within the President's Budget Request for NASA."

McGrath's work in astrophysics supports one of the missions zeroed out in the FY26 budget request. After its release, his contract employer wrote to inform him they were unable to guarantee his job past the end of the fiscal year, which ended Sept. 30.

"I received an email from my direct employer just acknowledging that elephant in the room," McGrath said earlier this year. "My NASA sponsor told them I am in a high-risk position right now, and they can't guarantee anything beyond September 30."

Before that date passed, McGrath's contractor was able to extend his position through the end of 2025. Now, the government shutdown has put him and thousands of other contract employees in the awkward position of having to sign on remotely for work, but without many of their coworkers and resources needed to do their jobs.

"I can't really communicate with my civil servant colleagues and bosses since they are all furloughed," McGrath said in October. "My weekly meetings are canceled or underattended." It has continued this way for McGrath and many other contract employees since the_shutdown began on Oct. 1_.

As some contract employers attempted to be as transparent as possible, NASA's communication efforts with its own workforce shrank over the course of the year.

A July 17 email obtained by Space.com, sent from one lab chief in a

"First Line Supervisor" position, explained that division town halls would be canceled indefinitely and to expect department-wide group chat channels to be disabled. The lab chief said that these changes were made in an effort to funnel information to employees through First Line Supervisors, but was unable to say definitively since official reasoning had not been communicated to that level of management, according to the email.

"In normal times, all agency GSFC [department] town halls were officially recorded, but that was discontinued some months ago, and later most such meetings were stopped entirely," Marshall Finch, a contract systems administrator at Goddard, told Space.com. He was not authorized to speak on behalf of NASA or his direct employer.

At the same time, word about the uneasiness within the United States' scientific community had spread worldwide, and many Goddard scientists and engineers began receiving recruitment emails from European research institutions.

Before GSFC town halls ended in the spring, Lystrup mentioned the notion of scientists being recruited for positions overseas to employees on at least one occasion. "With grants drying up, there is going to be less soft money for people to survive on as well," she said in a June 16 town hall, adding, suggestively, according to Wendy, "I know that there are a number of countries that are actively recruiting US scientists and putting money behind recruiting US scientists to go abroad."

Speculation circulated that the reason town halls stopped had to do with something Lystrup said that NASA higher-ups didn't like. Lystrup ended up resigning as GSFC director on July 22.

One group was told they were not allowed to talk to HR or any higher levels of management without first contacting their supervisor. Another email obtained by Space.com reads, in part, "We must do this because: 1) management is directing us to communicate this way."

Finch said the changes in communication have been "chilling."

"I have spoken to people afraid to put comments and directives in writing. I know people afraid to dissent, or afraid to do so in writing," Finch said. "Some people feel more vulnerable than others, so we lose their voices as they silence themselves. The result is lost safety and lost productivity."

As the window to volunteer for a deferred resignation neared its end, NASA employees were forced to make hard decisions about their future. "Because our management is telling us that we have to align to the President's budget request, people are using it to predict whether or

not they will have a job in the next year, and deciding to leave based on that," Wendy said.

The deadline for NASA employees to opt into the agency's DRP was July 25. By that time, more than 4,000 people at the space agency had signed up to leave, reducing NASA's employee pool by over 20%. At Goddard, GESTA reported that 447 people chose the DRP route, equating to roughly one in six GSFC civil servants – about 17% of the center's workforce, totaling more than 11% of NASA's voluntary departures across its 10 major facilities nationwide – the largest of any agency center.

No one Wendy spoke with who took the DRP actually wanted to leave NASA. "Prior to this year, they really enjoyed their jobs," she said.

Loss of science and safety

Unpredictable losses from voluntary departures left many Goddard programs with holes in their expertise, growing safety concerns and, in some cases, fractured mission teams that may lack the resources to continue regardless of what final budget is passed.

"Because of our own management reassigning people to other projects, we won't have enough people on the projects to keep them going, regardless of the funding," Wendy said.

Former NASA astronaut Terry Virts joined the space agency in 2000. He has flown to space twice, served as commander of the International Space Station and spent a cumulative 213 days in orbit. He retired in 2016 but still maintains a residence in Houston, near NASA's Johnson Space Center, where he keeps in close contact with his past NASA community. Virts is currently running as a Democrat for a U.S. Senate seat in Texas.

"Once the hardware is canceled, once the scientists are gone, you can't just start [those missions] up again," Virts told Space.com in an interview. "Solar system probes require engineers to understand very technical things to work for years on a program. Once you let someone go, you're not just going to get them back."

"Anytime you're doing something as complicated as launching rockets and operating spacecraft in space, you don't want turmoil and angst and people quitting on the ground," Virts said. "The things that are happening are safety issues for NASA, but they're also safety issues for the other 330 million Americans."

Virts said that implementing these kinds of cuts to science at NASA and other federal agencies has "absolutely" already cost human lives. He pointed to the July 4 Hill Country floods in Texas, when

more than 130 people died from the catastrophically rapid rise of the Guadalupe River, which overtook entire communities.

"The one person who was supposed to warn everybody was gone, thanks to this administration's disastrous cuts," Virts asserted. Some reports have speculated that the National Weather Service office in Austin_lacked a warning coordination meteorologist_ due to an early retirement tied to federal cuts, and that the person in that position could have potentially activated an earlier alert system for affected residents.

On June 24, just before the Hill Country floods became the latest example of the effects of climate change and natural disasters, scientists at the National Snow and Ice Data Center (NSIDC) at the University of Colorado received word they would_no longer have access to data_ provided by satellites that form the US Air Force Defense Meteorological Satellite Program. The NSIDC has long used this critical information to measure sea ice in real time to inform the_sea-ice index_, which monitors the amount of ice coverage around Earth's poles.

The Department of Defense uses those measurements for planning things like ship deployment, but it has long been integrated into NASA's own Earth science programs, with_algorithms developed at Goddard_ forming the backbone of the sea-ice concentration datasets. GSFC scientists routinely processed the data to monitor polar climate trends. When access to those feeds was suspended, it didn't just cut off NSIDC, it also_cut off Goddard's ability_ to update the global datasets it maintains for NASA's climate missions, effectively blinding parts of the agency's environmental monitoring network.

By then, workers at NASA saw the writing on the wall and began to organize. "A lot of people are starting to realize that the risk to the whole agency is getting greater and greater," McGrath said in June. "Time is running out. If we don't say something now, then there's not going to be much opportunity left going forward."

In addition to the NASA Needs Help_demonstrations over the summer_ nearly 300 current and former NASA employees signed the "_Voyager Declaration_ which they_published_ on July 21. Its signatories included astronauts, scientists and engineers protesting the preemptive funding cuts and employee losses, which, they said, "threaten to waste public resources, compromise human safety, weaken national security, and undermine the core NASA mission."

The letter invoked "Technical Authority," an_established process_ put in place following investigations into the_Columbia_ and_Challenger space shuttle_ accidents, which establishes employee protections if they speak out against something they view as unsafe.

"I can see another Challenger, another Columbia happening down the road as a result of this..." – Julie

Goddard's arm of NASA's Office of Safety and Mission Assurance was hit particularly hard by position losses, according to employees. The department is responsible for ensuring safety protocols are followed through every stage of spacecraft development and testing, and when scientists and engineers interface with potential hazards like high-pressure procedures, vacuum chambers, radioactive materials and heavyweight hardware.

Julie, who attended a July 20 NASA Needs Help_"Moon Day"_
<<https://www.space.com/space-exploration/nasa-workers-plan-moon-day-protest-on-july-20-to-oppose-mass-layoffs-budget-cuts-this-year-has-been-an-utter-nightmare-that-has-not-stopped>>
demonstration, worried about the effects on NASA's Office of the Chief Knowledge Officer. "That was set up after Columbia and Challenger to make sure that we were passing any lessons learned on to the entire community," she said. "I can see another Challenger, another Columbia happening down the road as a result of this, and it will ultimately be blamed back on us."

"We build very specific things," George, a NASA employee who did not wish to provide his last name, told Space.com at the protest. He feared the deterioration of critical expertise and the consequences that could come with it. "If we lose that, we lose that, it's gone. Where are we going to learn how to do that again? Are we going to have to have another Challenger moment to learn how to do that again? Maybe."

Employees fear that long-standing safety guardrails are being eroded. "It feels like a lot of the leadership at NASA is undoing a lot of good progress that we've made over the past years and decades," McGrath said. "We're getting real close, I think, to that moment where it might be too late to undo some of the changes that could happen."

Duffy briefly touched on these concerns during a Sept. 4 all-agency_town hall livestream_. He acknowledged employee feedback about insufficient personnel, but downplayed fears over science losses and safety. "We have Congressionally mandated science, which we're going to do," he said, "but we also have a lot of science that is going to drive human exploration, that's going to drive our mission to the moon. We are going to lean into that science as well."

"Do we have the human resources available? ... As of right now, I think we do," he said, adding that he was open to reevaluating if an assessment was needed.

"We are safety driven, and we should be safety driven," Duffy

said. "But sometimes we can't let safety be the enemy of making progress. We have to be able to take some leaps. We have to be able to jump forward in our innovation and drive this mission. And there's always a balance to that."

For all the cuts in the FY26 budget request, the Trump administration is doing all it can to bolster human spaceflight programs like_Artemis_, NASA's effort to return astronauts to_the moon_. But without a robust scientific portfolio, some at NASA wonder how astronauts will occupy their time during such missions.

"It turns us away from those quests that give our astronauts something to do when they're doing the exploration, and keeps them safe while they're doing it. Science enables exploration," Barbara Cohen, a NASA planetary scientist, said to attendees of a_Sept. 15 protest_ outside the agency's Washington, D.C. headquarters. "We need science to drive the innovation."

NASA seems to be driving in the opposite direction.

Campus closures begin

Over the last few months, notices have trickled down through supervisors to inform employees at Goddard of several facility closures. A July 1 email to managers, obtained by Space.com, announced the impending closures of the staff fitness facility on the main GSFC campus – marked for Nov. 30 – and the health facilities at both the Greenbelt campus and at NASA's_Wallops Flight Facility_ in Virginia, which operates under Goddard's umbrella.

Goddard's health services are in place to address injuries specific to the types of hazards NASA scientists and engineers may face, like exposure to radiation or hypergolic fuels. They also provide physicals and medical assessments required by people's jobs at the center. "Anticipated budget reductions in Fiscal Year 2026," was the reason given for the closures in the email. Both health units were scheduled to close Oct. 31.

On Aug. 4, in another internal email obtained by Space.com, managers were notified of more closures – a list that includes buildings, services and employee socialization hubs across Goddard and Wallops. Effective Oct. 1, both centers were set to close their employee cafeteria and motor pool services, as well as vending services and the recreation center at the Greenbelt campus.

Like the face-to-face collaboration benefits lost at GISS, employees fear shutting down Goddard's cafeteria will be stifling. "Being able to meet with colleagues and build relationships over lunch has a big impact," Wendy said. "That will be a hit to our ability to do our

jobs."

NASA officials say maintaining the cafeteria has been a strain on the center's budget. To compensate, Goddard administration arranged for food trucks on campus as an alternative option for employees.

Most alarming on the email's list were both facilities' visitor centers. Closing the visitor centers at Goddard and Wallops would cut off the only public-facing arms of NASA in their areas and eliminate the communities' primary way of interacting with the space agency.

Union fights back

Amid the turmoil over facilities closures, the union representing Goddard workers took action. A GESTA_press release_ on Aug. 15 opposed the decisions, and speculated that the closures might be targeted.

"There is growing concern that the closure may be more than a budgetary decision ... GESTA has yet to receive any indications of other NASA Centers closing their Visitor Centers," the release said, adding that the decisions were being "perceived by some employees as purposefully punitive, seemingly designed to inflict maximum institutional pain on remaining employees who chose not to voluntarily separate or resign during recent agency downsizing and restructuring."

"It does feel to me, and to a lot of people that I've talked to, that this is all part of making life miserable so that people leave," Wendy said at the time.

Goddard leadership declined Space.com's request for an interview. In an email sent Sept. 16 in response to that request, Goddard News Chief Rob Garner said the GSFC officials were "reviewing functions and capabilities as the center works to close out Fiscal Year 2025 and look ahead." He added that Goddard officials were "exploring a number of actions, including some that may involve closure of facilities," and that "no decisions have been made."

Beyond the view of the public, more closures were taking place. Employees received instructions to relocate from several buildings on Goddard's campus over the summer. They were moved from workspaces, like labs with specialized spacecraft testing equipment and infrastructure, to "windowless cubicle farms," Wendy said. One group was moved into a new building that lacked adequate lab space, another into a lab that lacked a functional climate control system. GESTA quickly stepped into negotiations about the change in working conditions.

The union filed bargaining proposals over the office and lab relocations, citing Federal Labor Relations Authority (FLRA)

precedent, and several moves were paused._In an email_ to union members, GESTA identified ETD Deputy Director for Planning and Business Management Matt Ritsko as the one who orchestrated the reassignments, "in concert with [top level] Management" to create a cost-savings option for center leadership. This was "driven," the email said, by "anticipated reductions in the upcoming fiscal year."

Ritsko serves just under Harris_at the top of the Engineering department_, which reports directly to Goddard's Office of the Director and, since Lystrup's resignation, acting Goddard Director Cynthia Simmons.

Unions eliminated

As negotiations between GESTA and Goddard management continued, the union had the proverbial rug pulled out from under it. In late August, an_executive order by Trump_ reclassified NASA as one of the federal agencies excluded from the requirement to offer employees the right to collective bargaining under_Chapter 71 of Title 5_ of the FLRA Management Relations Statute, banning unions at the space agency on the grounds of "national security."

"...the immediate harm suffered could be insurmountable for many of the employees." – Mark Gaston Pearce

A man stands outside holding a microphone in front of a NASA sign.

IFPTE President Matthew Biggs addresses protesters during a Sept. 15 demonstration outside NASA headquarters in Washington, D.C. (Image credit: NASA Needs Help)

"That's supposed to make us work more efficiently? That's just going to make all of us less safe," Monica Gorman, a GESTA area VP, said to protesters outside NASA's D.C. headquarters**on Sept. 15. "It's going to put NASA's missions at risk, and it's going to put NASA's people at risk."

At that same demonstration, representatives from GESTA's parent body came to show their support._IFPTE_ President Matthew Biggs told those gathered that the union was already in the process of_challenging the order_ in court. "It's a lot easier to do RIFs if there's no labor unions there to challenge them," he said. "So we are going to challenge it in the courts, and we're challenging it on Capitol Hill, and we're going nowhere."

Even if the unions have a case, the system is built against them, said Mark Gaston Pearce, who served as chairman of the National Labor Relations Board in the Obama administration from 2011 to 2017, and is the former executive director of, and currently a senior advisor at,

Georgetown University's Workers' Rights Institute.

"There will probably be causes of actions that can be pursued, but the practical nature of these circumstances is such that these employees will need to continue to keep working," Pearce said. "Funding these lawsuits are not a simple matter, and even if that is achievable, the time that would be taken for all of this to take place will be so, so long in the future that the immediate harm suffered could be insurmountable for many of the employees."

Negotiations end, cuts accelerate

"The Engineering and Technology Directorate in particular, seemed like it was ignoring that guidance..." – Peter

Trump's executive order freed Goddard leadership of their obligation to debate with GESTA about facility closures and anything else. The union was given 48 hours' notice to clear their resources from the conference room previously dedicated for their use, and employees were barred from congregating there during off hours.

Negotiations with GESTA stopped, and center leadership kicked their reorganization efforts into overdrive.

Despite media reports_ indicating that Acting Administrator Duffy directed NASA to begin working toward the budget outlined in the House Appropriations Committee's bill for the coming fiscal year, which restored much of the science programs initially cut in the PBR, that direction was not one communicated through Goddard's management levels to employees.

"There was certainly no widespread communication broadly disseminated to the workforce informing them that we would now be following the House budget request instead of the President's budget request at Goddard," said Peter, the GSFC civil servant. "That is unlike activities that I have seen through other centers."

NASA officials maintain they provided appropriate guidance to agency centers and mission directorates, instructing each to spend according to anticipated budget appropriations in alignment with presidential priorities, and that the agency remains in full compliance with Section 505 Appropriations reporting requirements_. Duffy and other agency leadership have repeatedly assured critics they intend to follow the law, and adhere to whatever Congress ultimately passes. He even said as much directly to lawmakers at the House Committee on Transportation and Infrastructure's hearing on July 17, promising to "follow the will of Congress."

"The Engineering and Technology Directorate, in particular, seemed

like it was ignoring that guidance from headquarters and instead continuing to plan to the Presidential budget request," Peter said. This would stand in direct contradiction to guidance passed down from NASA's top leadership, Space.com has learned.

The "cost savings" closures initiated by Ritsko to align with Trump's budget proposal expanded to include Goddard's 20-year Master Plan_ a vision for the center that began in 2017 and outlines upgrades, renovations and other changes to GSFC's 1,270-acre (514-hectare) campus, including the demolition of older facilities and the construction of new buildings through 2037. It includes reducing the campus's footprint by nearly 50%.

On Sept. 22, as worries over a looming government shutdown mounted in the face of deadlocked negotiations in Washington, Goddard Associate Center Director Raymond Rubilotta announced a rapid acceleration of the Master Plan from 20 years to six months.

"Beginning Wednesday, Sept. 24, we will initiate a series of moves at both campuses that will reduce our footprint into fewer buildings," Rubilotta said in an email to Goddard employees, obtained by Space.com. "All planned moves will take place over the next several months and will be completed by March of 2026."

A document with redactions and highlights.

<<https://cdn.mos.cms.futurecdn.net/6JZPKNRMkyeh4FosPn2dHP.jpg>>

An email on Sept. 22 announces the acceleration of Goddard's 20-year Master Plan. (Image credit: obtained by Space.com)

Over the week that followed, employees described hectic disorganization. "People are being told to relocate offices on short notice, often chaotically with little planning. They are being told to highly prioritize the moves," Wendy said.

There were instances of employees being assigned workspaces already occupied by others and unable to return to their original offices, buildings being emptied of personnel with no current plan to recover or relocate potentially millions of dollars of equipment left behind, employees told Space.com. "It's crazy," said Finch, the systems admin.

The long-term plans_ for Goddard's main campus included the construction of nine new facilities, the renovation of 10 facilities and "divestment or partial divestment of 12 facilities, and the demolition of 61 facilities." In this case, "facilities"_encompasses everything_ from land, utilities, buildings and really any structure on NASA's property.

While there is no current work underway to begin construction on any of the new facilities shown in the plans, almost half of the largest buildings marked for future divestment or demolition have been listed

for abandonment by the March deadline – nearly everything west of Goddard Road (the red line), on this map provided to Space.com.

The slides below highlight which of the buildings planned for demolition by 2037 have been accelerated to the March 2026 timeline, and where planned constructions overlap.

Image 1 of 3

a map with highlighted buildings and a red line down the left-center. Buildings marked for divestment or demolition in Goddard's 20-year Master plan. According to employees, nearly everything west (right) of Goddard Road (the red line) is on an expedited track to be closed by March 2026.(Image credit: obtained by Space.com)

Expedited closures

A map of planned closures taking place at Goddard through March 2026.

a map with highlighted buildings and a red line down the left-center. This map from Goddard's 20-year Master plan shows planned demolitions to take place by 2037, many of which have been accelerated to just a few months.(Image credit: NASA)

Planned demolitions

A map from Goddard's 20-year Master plan showing planned demolitions to take place by 2037.

a map with highlighted buildings and a red line down the left-center. This map from Goddard's 20-year Master plan shows planned constructions to take place by 2037, none of which have been completed or broken ground on during the accelerated closure of many buildings on the GSFC campus.(Image credit: NASA)

Planned construction

A map from Goddard's 20-year Master plan showing planned constructions to take place by 2037.

For NASA, the staffing decrease as result of the DRP was one of the motivations behind ramping up building consolidations, which the agency assured are being methodically carried out in order to preserve the science and resources needed across projects. The buildings being vacated were apparently already 40% unoccupied, and a burdensome cost on center resources.

According to Wendy, if GSFC leadership is using the smaller workforce

to justify the downsizing, the numbers don't add up. "They basically want to move everybody out of half of the buildings on campus. Half of the physical footprint of Goddard. But we only lost about a third of our employees to DRP and attrition," she said.

More than just a logistical challenge of physical space, the moves themselves seem to ignore the impact of what's being left behind. "They're being implemented in inept ways that do not properly account for how unique the technical work that has been done at Goddard truly is," Peter said. "It seems that there is a lack of understanding in Goddard management in general as to what technical capabilities we have, and what's actually important to retain them."

a map transitions to show building demolition plans.

Maps**show Goddard's 20-year Master Plan, with nearly half of the Greenbelt campus now marked for abandonment – a visual "hollowing out" of NASA's flagship science hub. (Image credit: obtained by Space.com)

Government shutdown

Days after Rubilotta's Master Plan notice, OMB issued a memo, first reported by Politico directing agencies to consider reduction in force notices during a shutdown for programs not aligned with the "President's priorities."

On Sept. 29, NASA updated the agency's shutdown guidance to add a similar "presidential priorities" phrase, heightening employee fears that the administration would use the government shutdown as an excuse for further layoffs and project cuts.

Goddard's leadership did not provide employees any center-specific shutdown instructions, according to employees. "They didn't hold a single town hall – other [NASA] centers did – and didn't send any guidance on what to do during a shutdown," Wendy said. What they did send was "a big new re-organization email," which came at 5 p.m. on the evening before the shutdown began.

"We are shutting down center capabilities with no plan to replace them..." – Peter

Some groups received instructions to pack their work and equipment – in some cases, massive testing hardware – and were told to stand by for a notice with a 48-hour window to relocate.

"Active research and mission development has been greatly disrupted as some labs have been told to leave their buildings immediately," McGrath said. "A very hard task to do when you have extremely sensitive equipment that isn't just meant to be moved on a whim. So we

are shutting down center capabilities with no plan to replace them in other lab facilities."

While the government was closing its doors for business, Goddard's management laid the groundwork to make sure theirs were deadbolted. "Raymond Rubilotta (Associate Center Director) and Segrid Harris (Director for the Engineering and Technology Directorate) are continuing to push the disassembly of Goddard Center at a rapid pace, even while the government is shut down," McGrath said.

On Oct. 1, the first day of the shutdown, some staff were still being told to come pack their offices as part of their "orderly shutdown procedure," according to an email sent that morning, obtained by Space.com, and that movers would relocate the contents if and when new workspaces were assigned. "Normally, the orderly shutdown activities are limited to things like getting your work into a safe state, setting automatic replies on your emails, and clearing out your fridge," Wendy said.

"It's being done essentially in secret, on compressed timelines, and it seems to be that the justification for doing so is under false pretenses." – Peter

As the shutdown continued into multiple weeks, Goddard leadership began designating select employees with part-time excepted status, deeming the consolidation of "technical work and employees" as a priority, and reinstating their furlough once their offices are packed.

For federal workers during the government shutdown, an "exemption" differs from an "exception." Contracted movers paid from pre-obligated funds, for example, could be considered exempt, but federal civil servants would not. An exception, by contrast, allows employees to continue certain unfunded activities because they are necessary to protect life or property.

Only two exceptions have been approved for facility relocations during the shutdown so far at Goddard, Space.com has learned, and no office spaces were submitted as part of those requests. In fact, over 100 office space moves were put on hold specifically because of the government shutdown. However, employees needing to relocate their workspaces as a result of their laboratory spaces being moved did fall into the excepted category.

"It's unclear what activity is really taking place under any officially approved status from headquarters at this point," Peter said.

"It's being done essentially in secret, on compressed timelines," he added, "and it seems to be that the justification for doing so is

under false pretenses, and the activities themselves may also be illegal due to Anti Deficiency Act_ violations of recalling civil servants from furlough."

"The expectation will be to report onsite no later than Thursday October 16th to conduct packing of your office materials and any lab preparations," reads an Oct. 14 email to employees, obtained by Space.com. Employees were given three business days to do so, according to the email, and informed that, once packed, their offices' contents would be moved to "offices and labs as they are ready."

"I think one of the intents of the master plan was to move people out of buildings that were falling apart, but we have not built new buildings to move those people into, and we don't have lab spaces available," Wendy said.

Employees on some teams were told that if they were unable to complete evaluations of their lab equipment, whatever wasn't designated give-away or keep would be thrown out. "All items not marked in labs by COB Monday 10/20 will be excessed," an Oct. 16 email, obtained by Space.com, said.

"There's equipment that is being planned to just be abandoned in place," Wendy said.

All that hardware adds up. Peter said losses will include "tens of millions of dollars and decades' worth of investment in these facilities that historically have been considered core to Goddard's capabilities."

Take, for instance, Building 19, which houses the Goddard_Electro-Magnetic Anechoic Chamber_ for testing antennas and other microwave devices used on spacecraft, communications laboratories, hardware assembly rooms and the avionics laboratory, among others.

Of Building 19's infrastructure, at least eight laboratories have been completely divested without replacement, with some still needed to support critical functions for ongoing or upcoming missions, according to Peter.

So far, at least four sites on Goddard's campus have already been impacted, including Buildings 20, 30 and 32, as well as Building 19, which, as of Oct. 24, was "emptied of all government and personal property and is being locked and made inaccessible," Peter said. There is speculation about which will be next, he added.

The cost of moving

Many scientists and engineers track their time and workload according to the projects that work is associated with, including missions based out of other NASA centers. This allows NASA to track costs across multiple missions, funding sources and facilities nationwide. Employee hours are tracked under a different "charge code" during a government shutdown, however.

For employees packing up and moving their offices during the shutdown, though, "they're being told to charge their projects," Wendy said. According to her, this could lead to a situation where a mission based out of Johnson Space Center, for example, is paying for part of Goddard's employee relocation efforts, making the actual cost of work being done during the shutdown harder to track.

"If there's ever a cost-benefit analysis of how much money we're saving, versus how much money we're spending and losing by throwing stuff out, that won't be tracked accurately," Wendy said.

Marking those hours under certain mission costs like this will hit some harder than others.

"Some of these are independent research projects that people have worked really hard to propose funding for," Wendy said. "It's a very limited pot of money that they have ... and they're being asked to spend that money on moving their lab."

An uncertain future

The feeling that Goddard is being targeted has been hard to shake for those working within its walls. "Seems like Goddard is giving up on its future, whether that is being forced by headquarters, OMB and the White House, versus management not doing a good job protecting it. Some people are speculating that NASA is using Goddard as a sacrifice to preserve the rest of the agency," Wendy said.

Green, who worked at NASA through several administrations before becoming Chief Scientist, says the space agency has weathered turbulent times before. "NASA has gone through, in my 42 years as a civil servant, huge changes. We've had many buyouts. We've had huge hiring freezes. We have had RIFs," Green said, and offered advice to the NASA employees currently riding out the storm:

"Stay the course. Keep doing what you're doing. Don't anticipate you won't be doing it tomorrow, until you're told you won't be doing it tomorrow, but then also be flexible ... If you're not taking that knowledge and connecting it to something else that you can go to, that's a problem."

That course may now be much more difficult to navigate as employees

steer the murky waters of a management hierarchy they feel doesn't support them. And, whatever Congress ultimately passes may indeed no longer matter. The damage at Goddard is already being felt in lost expertise, dismantled facilities and the quiet unraveling of the center's safety infrastructure.

With projects bracing for termination, mission teams broken apart and safety protocols weakened, the guardrails that once kept NASA from repeating its worst tragedies are being stripped away in real time. Labs are being shuttered faster than they can be reestablished, institutional knowledge is walking out the door faster than it can be replaced and the foundation that once made Goddard the center of NASA's scientific excellence may never regain the depth of comprehension and capability it once held.

As Goddard is hollowed from within, center scientists and engineers like Wendy and Peter can't help but feel deflated.

"Regardless of how priorities may shift at Goddard in terms of what kinds of work we support, what is an absolute certainty at this point is that we as a center will be incapable of supporting as many types of work as we have historically," Peter said.

Wendy sees implications beyond just Goddard and NASA.

"I think it just kind of speaks to the atmosphere of the agency and the nation," she said, "where people are like, 'Well, laws don't matter for the people at the top anymore.'"

All Comments

1.

Comment by Ross Warren.

RW

Ross Warren

1 hr ago

Excerpt from the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine 2024 report: NASA at a Crossroads.

"NASA's budget is often incompatible with the scope, complexity, and difficulty of its mission work. The long-term impacts of this mismatch include erosion of capabilities in workforce, critical infrastructure, and advanced technology development. The current relative allocations of funding to mission work as compared to that allocated to institutional (i.e. underutilized NASA centers), has degraded NASA's capabilities to the point where agency

sustainability is in question."

NASA simply can't afford to keep all the current centers left over from the Apollo days, strewn across the nation, running. Some of them need to be closed and missions consolidated to save money. Perhaps it will be Goddard that bears the storm of closure in order to save NASA. Back when NASA was getting 3% of the federal budget such considerations weren't necessary, but NASA has been stuck at 0.5% (half a penny out of each bloated Federal dollar spent) since the Nixon and Carter years. Something has to give. NASA isn't supposed to be a jobs program, but rather a program that delivers for the American people.

Reply by descender.

de
descender
34 min ago

Reply to Ross Warren

Conservatives defunding a government program until it can't function properly and then declaring "it doesn't work and should be privatized" has been going on for almost 100 years.

Comment by bluedresses.

bl

bluedresses
3 hrs ago

Thank you for your detailed reporting on this. My husband is an engineer at Goddard and the past year has been agonizing for our family. The uncertainty, the fear, the outright lies and contradictions from GSFC leadership... I am stunned every single day by the ways in which GSFC continues to undermine and intimidate its own employees, and undermine with them the missions and projects already authorized by Congress.

Comment by Simon DelMonte.

SD
Simon DelMonte

3 hrs ago

About time you started running articles like this.

Sadly, we have the perfect storm of people who think the only

things the government should fund are the military and police, people who think science is bunk, jingoists who are only interested in "beating China to the Moon," and out and out tyrants. We can protest all we want, but the conjunction of Trump, Vought, Duffy, and the rest, abusing power left and right, makes it unlikely anything we say or do will matter.

--- ENDD GSFC UNDER ATTACK ---

NOVEMBER

11/4/25: NYT Trump Again Names Jared Isaacman to Lead NASA After Pulling His Nomination / The nomination of the billionaire entrepreneur, private astronaut and Elon Musk ally was before the floor of the Senate when the president abruptly withdrew it in June.

Five months after President Trump abruptly yanked the nomination of the person he had chosen to lead NASA he finally put forth a new nomination on Tuesday – of the same person.

Jared Isaacman, 42, a billionaire entrepreneur who led two private missions to orbit on SpaceX rockets, is again in line to become the next NASA administrator.

"Jared's passion for Space, astronaut experience, and dedication to pushing the boundaries of exploration, unlocking the mysteries of the universe, and advancing the new Space economy, make him ideally suited to lead NASA into a bold new Era," the president wrote in a post on Truth Social.

He did not acknowledge that he had earlier named Mr. Isaacman to the post, nor that he had angrily withdrawn the nomination.

In his own post on the website X, Mr. Isaacman thanked the president. "It will be an honor to serve my country under your leadership," he said.

Should Mr. Isaacman's second nomination be confirmed, he will assume leadership of a NASA with a thinner budget and a reduced work force that could be recovering from the effects of a prolonged government shutdown.

When Mr. Trump originally nominated Mr. Isaacman in December, it seemed in part to be related to the entrepreneur's close association with Elon Musk, the founder and chief executive of SpaceX. But by late May, Mr. Musk, then leading the Department of Government Efficiency, had a falling out with the president over a domestic policy bill that

rancorously spilled over to social media.

On May 31, the day after Mr. Musk left his government role, and just days before the Senate was scheduled to vote on Mr. Isaacman, Mr. Trump announced that he would withdraw the nomination. Mr. Trump was upset that Mr. Isaacman had contributed to the campaigns of some Democrats, including former Senator Bob Casey of Pennsylvania.

Despite the sacrifices that Mr. Isaacman made to avoid conflicts of interest as NASA administrator -- stepping down as chief executive of the payment processing company Shift4, canceling contracts with SpaceX for future space missions and selling off his aerospace investments -- he has remained publicly cordial and deferential toward Mr. Trump.

"I am incredibly grateful to President Trump @POTUS, the Senate and all those who supported me throughout this journey," he wrote on X the day that Mr. Trump made his U-turn.

In September, Mr. Isaacman, filling in for Mr. Musk, attended a dinner of Silicon Valley executives that Mr. Trump hosted at the White House.

Mr. Isaacman has also chimed in to support Mr. Trump on issues unrelated to space, including military attacks on boats of suspected drug smugglers, which many experts regard as illegal.

"I really support this," Mr. Isaacman wrote on X last month.

NASA has been without a permanent leader for more than 10 months. As is typical, Bill Nelson, the space agency's administrator under the Biden administration, stepped down when Mr. Trump was sworn in.

Janet Petro, the director of the Kennedy Space Center in Florida, filled in as acting administrator until July. Then President Trump decided that Sean Duffy, the secretary of transportation, would temporarily lead NASA.

Like many federal agencies, NASA has been unsettled by the Trump administration's shifts in policy. The president and his advisers are seeking to pivot the agency's priorities in space, proposing deep cuts to Earth science and robotic missions to other worlds while placing a greater emphasis on sending astronauts to the moon and maybe Mars.

In recent weeks, Mr. Duffy and Mr. Musk have tussled over the Artemis III mission. Currently scheduled for mid-2027, it is to land NASA astronauts on the lunar surface in the south polar region.

SpaceX has a contract to adapt its Starship spacecraft to serve as a moon lander. But it is looking increasingly likely that Starship, with its immense size and complexity, will not be ready for quite a few years. Instead, an astronaut from China, which is aiming for its first

moon landing by 2030, could be the next person to set foot there.

Mr. Duffy, who has vowed that the United States will win this 21st-century space race, announced he would reopen the Artemis III lander contract to seek a simpler, faster solution.

Mr. Musk then mocked Mr. Duffy. "Sean Dummy is trying to kill NASA!" he wrote in one post on X. "The person responsible for America's space program can't have a 2 digit IQ," he wrote in another.

How Mr. Isaacman will handle the Artemis III lander will almost certainly be a topic of questioning when he again faces the senators of the Commerce Committee. Although he is considered an ally of Mr. Musk's, Mr. Duffy has also been supportive of other aerospace companies, including Blue Origin, the rocket company started by Jeff Bezos.

Blue Origin has proposed to NASA a lander design that it says could be built more quickly for Artemis III.

Behind the scenes, Mr. Duffy and Mr. Isaacman have been jockeying to gain lasting control of NASA.

After The Wall Street Journal reported that Mr. Duffy would like to become the agency's permanent administrator, a NASA spokeswoman said Mr. Duffy had only been suggesting that NASA become part of the Department of Transportation. She said that it might benefit from being part of a cabinet-level organization.

Even some of Mr. Duffy's Republican supporters were leery of shifting NASA under the transportation department, noting that NASA's mandates were broader than sending people to space.

Over the past month, Republicans including Senator Tim Sheehy of Montana and Laura Loomer, a far-right influencer, have been calling for Mr. Trump to reverse course again and nominate Mr. Isaacman a second time.

Mr. Trump also praised Mr. Duffy on Tuesday for filling in at NASA. "Sean Duffy has done an incredible job as interim administrator of the National Aeronautics and Space Administration," Mr. Trump wrote.

Mr. Duffy, in turn, thanked Mr. Trump and congratulated Mr. Isaacman. "I wish him all the success and will ensure the transition is seamless," Mr. Duffy wrote on X.

11/6/25: From fyi@aipcomm.org Thu Nov 6 17:03:23 2025

Subject: Leaked NASA Manifesto Hints at Isaacman's Vision for Science
FYI: Science Policy News from AIP

Leaked NASA Manifesto Hints at Isaacman's Vision for Science
Lindsay McKenzie

Jared Isaacman has been renominated to lead NASA, and a document outlining his vision for the agency has been leaked to the press.

Commercial astronaut and billionaire Jared Isaacman is again in the running to lead NASA following his renomination by President Donald Trump on Tuesday. Trump selected Isaacman to lead NASA back in December, but pulled his nomination in June "after a thorough review of prior associations," which may have referred to Isaacman's donations to Democrat politicians, or his close ties to Elon Musk and SpaceX. Transportation Secretary Sean Duffy has served as NASA's acting administrator since July.

Shortly before the announcement of Isaacman's renomination, Ars Technica and Politico reported that they had obtained a 62-page document outlining Isaacman's vision for NASA, which he prepared while his first nomination was pending in the Senate.

The full text of Isaacman's NASA manifesto, known as Project Athena, has not been shared publicly, but snippets shared by media outlets and Isaacman hint at his vision for NASA science and the future of the agency. In a statement on X, Isaacman verified the plan was his but declined to share it publicly, saying, "I just don't think the space community needs to debate line-by-line while NASA and the rest of the government are going through a shutdown."

Isaacman's plan for NASA is organized around five main ideas: reorganizing the agency to reduce bureaucracy, putting more American astronauts in space, figuring out how to "extract more value from space than we put in," using NASA as a "force multiplier for science," and investing in technology and resources for the future.

Isaacman wrote on X that his plans for science include leveraging NASA's resources to "increase the frequency of missions, reduce costs, and empower academic institutions to contribute to real discovery missions." He added, "The idea is to get some of that \$1 trillion in university endowments into the fight, alongside NASA, to further science and discovery."

[Sounds like he wants university COST-SHARING ON ACTUAL MISSION IMPLEMENTATION!]

NASA's Commercial Lunar Payload Services (CLPS) program, through which

NASA hires companies to send small robotic landers and rovers to the Moon, could be used as a model for all of planetary science to “accelerate discovery and reduce time-to-science,” Isaacman wrote, adding that it would be “better to have 10 x \$100 million missions and a few fail than a single overdue and costly \$1B+ mission.” He echoed this sentiment in the All-In Podcast earlier this year, saying, “Why do we accept things taking 10 years when they could be a year? Even the decadal process of prioritizing scientific missions over a 10-year span is kind of insane.”

Isaacman’s plan also embraces PURCHASING EARTH SCIENCE DATA FROM COMMERCIAL PROVIDERS. “I know the ‘science-as-a-service’ concept got people fired up, but that was specifically called out in the plan for Earth observation, from companies that already have constellations like Planet, BlackSky, etc,” Isaacman said on X. “Why build bespoke satellites at greater cost and delay when you could pay for the data as needed from existing providers and repurpose the funds for more planetary science missions (as an example)?”

Isaacman’s plan also recommends that NASA TERMINATE ITS SPACE LAUNCH SYSTEM and the Gateway lunar space station after the planned Artemis II and Artemis III missions, eventually incorporating elements of the programs into a nuclear propulsion program. During the All-In Podcast, Isaacman also CRITICIZED THE ROBOTIC MARS SAMPLE RETURN MISSION, suggesting that NASA should redirect those resources toward private companies that can support a crewed Mars mission.

On the Jet Propulsion Laboratory, Isaacman’s post said he would like to look at overlaps between the work of the lab and its contractors, and denied ever suggesting that the U.S. could do without JPL, adding, “I have publicly defended programs like the Chandra X-ray Observatory, offered to fund a Hubble reboost mission, and anything suggesting I am anti-science or want to outsource that responsibility is simply untrue.”

Rumors that the so-called Project Athena document was leaked to the press to hinder Isaacman’s nomination and keep Duffy in control of NASA were framed as an unfortunate “distraction” by Isaacman in his X post. He also added context on his relationship with Duffy in the post, stating that “if there is any friction, I suspect it is more political operators causing the controversy.”

How long it will take for Isaacman to secure Senate confirmation to lead NASA is unclear. The White House has yet to formally submit his nomination to the Senate, where he may face another nomination hearing and fresh questions about his NASA plans.

NASA IN TURMOIL

11/6/25: WP. NASA has lost thousands of workers. Here's what that means for science. / Staffers told The Post about months of turmoil and sweeping changes that, if fully implemented, could transform NASA and American science beyond the Trump years.

URL:<https://www.washingtonpost.com/technology/2025/11/06/nasa-cuts-departures-isaacman/>

By Kasha Patel <<https://www.washingtonpost.com/people/kasha-patel/>> and
Hannah Natanson <<https://www.washingtonpost.com/people/hannah-natanson/>>

For 13 consecutive years, NASA has been named the "Best Place to Work in the Federal Government" among large agencies. But since the Trump administration took over and proposed deep budget cuts, there has been an exodus from the agency – with many of those who remain feeling demoralized and unsure about the future of their work.

The low morale may be an unanticipated challenge for billionaire entrepreneur Jared Isaacman, should he be confirmed as NASA administrator. President Donald Trump nominated Isaacman – again – on Tuesday, five months after abruptly withdrawing his nomination. A lot has shifted in that time.

A dozen current and former employees, who spoke on the condition of anonymity for fear of retribution, described months of turmoil and sweeping changes that, if fully implemented, could transform NASA and American science beyond the Trump years.

"You have people questioning their future with the agency, with their contractor, with their company," said Jack Kiraly, director of government relations at the Planetary Society, a nonprofit.

Kiraly also expressed concern for the tens of thousands of students who may turn away from scientific fields and be discouraged "over the sort of the upheaval that's happened at NASA and other science agencies."

More than 360 former and current employees have signed an open letter <<https://www.standupforscience.net/nasa-voyager-declaration>> voicing concern that the cuts and mass departures are increasing safety risks for space missions.

"I think NASA has always been an exceptional agency, filled with exceptional people doing exceptional things. And yet we are just getting decimated," one NASA employee said. "What was so fundamentally broken that we needed to get to this point?"

NASA spokesperson Bethany Stevens said that the changes and cuts at the agency have been mischaracterized and that no one is deprioritizing safety.

"NASA remains committed to our mission as we work within a more prioritized budget," she said in a statement.

Trump speaks at the Kennedy Space Center after a successful SpaceX launch on May 30, 2020. (Saul Martinez/Getty Images)

In May, Trump proposed a budget of \$18.8 billion for NASA, a 25 percent decrease from the previous year – and the smallest NASA budget since the start of human spaceflight in 1961, according to the Planetary Society.

Trump's budget proposed cutting NASA's science funding by about half and reducing its staff to one-third of its workforce.

Although no budget has been approved by Congress, and the Senate and House versions don't make such drastic cuts to the broadly popular agency, many former and current employees say NASA's leadership has appeared to be operating as if the president's proposal were**in effect.

That has meant a hyperfocus on work for getting astronauts back to the moon, the employees said. Meanwhile, the president's budget puts more than 40 current and planned space missions – largely related to climate and Earth science work – on the chopping block.

"Basically, anything that supports human life on Earth is deprioritized,"**one worker said.

NASA officials rebutted the idea that the president's budget proposal has been enacted before authorization.

"NASA's leadership has been clear that depending on the action taken by Congress, the agency should prepare for different scenarios, including a continuing resolution," Stevens said, adding that there has been "no guidance stating that the [president's budget request] will become the operating plan for NASA prior to Congressional authorization of a budget."

Amid shifting priorities and uncertain funding, NASA reported at the end of July that at least 4,000 civil servants – about a fifth of the civil staff – were leaving. More people have left since then,**and the numbers are even higher if counting departures of contractors, who make up a large portion of the NASA workforce.

The agency hasn't seen such a small civilian staff since 1960,

according to the Planetary Society.

Some of the departures have been in response to separation and early retirement offers. While the packages were “voluntary,” employees were told they may be reassigned, transferred involuntarily or denied severance benefits if they didn’t take the package, according to an anonymous memo submitted to several inspector general offices.

Workers have left from nearly every corner of NASA – scientists with missions related to the moon, Mars, astrobiology and Earth sciences, as well as in engineering, finance and communications. Many departed workers were very senior, staffers said, holding important institutional knowledge.

“No one feels confident that anything planned further than a few months will be executed; no one feels confident that more job cuts aren’t coming; no one feels confident that today’s priorities and next year’s or even next week’s will align,” an employee said.

Prioritizing the moon

Like across much of the federal government, the mood at NASA started to change when tech entrepreneur Elon Musk launched the U.S. DOGE Service and sent representatives to the agency early this year.

Some directives were unusual. On one floor at NASA headquarters, workers were told to remove symbols or flags that weren’t American flags – it was verbally made clear that this applied to rainbow symbols and flags.

Other actions affected the agency’s**core work. A handful of employees had to reevaluate about 5,000 science grants that were already awarded, said David Grinspoon, who was NASA’s senior scientist for astrobiology strategy. In a matter of days, he and his colleagues had to provide a justification for how the grants served the public.

The change in environment and tone was unsettling, said Grinspoon, who was no longer employed at the agency at the end of September. He said it was unclear where the directives were coming from or whether leaders were having their arms twisted.

“One thing I’ve always loved about NASA is this sense of teamwork and people being mission-focused ... and along with that, there was a lot of trust between leadership,” he said. “A lot of that trust started to get eroded.”

More dramatic changes followed the president’s budget proposal in the spring.

"As early as June 2025, NASA began 'implementing immediately' certain 'institutional changes' to align with the President's proposed budget – which carries no force of law," a Senate Democratic staff report concluded in late September.

The report, the NASA spokesperson said, is unsubstantiated, and the authors did not reach out to fact-check the report with the agency ahead of releasing it.

The Trump administration has been transparent about prioritizing one area: making sure America gets back to the moon before China, with a longer-term goal of building a permanent base there.

What's known as the Artemis program has continued to receive funding and largely been spared staffing cuts, said one employee associated with the program. Political appointees have urged those involved to move faster.

Unlike some other agency missions, work on Artemis has continued during the government shutdown.

The support will continue if Isaacman becomes the head of NASA. In a post on X this week, he endorsed "the energy and focus on the Moon" while acknowledging the near-term difficulties for NASA and talked up the role commercial providers and private capital are playing.

Overall, an employee said, the Trump administration has been good for human spaceflight – "which I struggle with," he said. "Because what that means is everything that is not putting humans on the moon is falling by the wayside."

The impact of NASA cuts

Among the initiatives that have lost support and significantly slowed, one NASA worker noted, are programs that help respond to floods, track fires and forecast what will happen long-term to the world's oceans, ecosystems and crops as the planet warms. The NASA Goddard Institute for Space Studies, which does climate-focused work, lost the lease <https://www.cnn.com/2025/04/24/climate/nasa-lease-canceled-columbia> for its New York City building.

In the aeronautics division, a project designed to test and develop a new generation of hybrid electric-powered aircraft is being phased out, according to staff members. Other aeronautical projects have been reduced in scope.

Astrophysics, planetary science and solar sciences are also in limbo although some projects that were told in July to prepare "contingency closeout" plans – such as the Osiris-Apex mission studying an asteroid

passing close to Earth in 2029 – have secured funding for the immediate future.

The cuts have hit NASA headquarters hard. The Office of the Chief Scientist; the Office of Technology, Policy and Strategy; and the diversity, equity, inclusion and accessibility branch in the Office of Diversity and Equal Opportunity have been shuttered.

Beyond Washington, NASA's Jet Propulsion Laboratory in California, home to much Mars and Earth science research, laid off 550 people in October as part of the agency reorganization. Its director stepped down in June.

Perhaps the largest cuts have occurred at NASA Goddard in Maryland, home to "the nation's largest organization of scientists, engineers, and technologists," according to its website. If the president's budget is followed completely, the center could lose about half of its civil workers.

Goddard's director, who was previously at Ball Aerospace, left abruptly on Aug. 1 without a clear explanation.

Morale among employees is the lowest anyone can remember, staff said. One Goddard employee expressed feeling a sort of survivor's guilt for colleagues in Earth sciences and other affected areas.

Goddard's physical campus is expected to contract by March to save money, closing numerous engineering labs, a key science building that houses solar research, maintenance shops, the only full cafeteria and an on-site child development center for employees.

Stevens, the NASA spokesperson, said that 40 percent of office space at Goddard was vacant after people took the voluntary separation programs, but that the agency was still paying to maintain the space. She said a plan to consolidate the center's buildings was also approved years ago.

But employees say the building moves are happening on a hastier timeline – months instead of years – and putting flight hardware and labs at risk.

"We heard a story about someone who had to go dumpster diving and only got back some of their stuff because others took it upon themselves to frantically get rid of everything," said a memo written by and circulated among employees.

The changes at NASA are coming at a time when the entire space industry is changing. Commercial spaceflight and satellites have boomed in recent years, raising questions about how NASA might redefine its role, said Scott Pace, a space policy expert at George

Washington University's Elliott School of International Affairs.

"A lot of the skills we've had in the past [at NASA], that's not what we need now," Pace said. "We do need other skills to integrate, oversee, manage and architect commercial and international and government partners to do exploration and science./."

But NASA staff, he said, need clearer direction, informed by realistic expectations about what work can reasonably be picked up by the private sector or academia.

The newly renominated Isaacman has proposed sending astronauts into space more frequently, adding more science missions in more cost-effective ways and partnering with commercial vendors, for instance. He wrote on X on Tuesday that his plan "never favored any one vendor, never recommended closing centers, or directed the cancellation of programs before objectives were achieved."

"The plan valued human exploration as much as scientific discovery," he said.

130*Comments*

AI summary: The comments express significant concern and criticism regarding the Trump administration's impact on NASA, particularly its science programs. Many commenters highlight the administration's perceived disdain for science, leading to budget cuts and a loss of institutional knowledge, which they fear will set back American leadership in space and science. There is also a sentiment that these actions benefit private companies like SpaceX and Blue Origin, while potentially ceding space leadership to countries like China. Some comments suggest that the administration's focus on returning to the moon is misguided compared to the value of Earth science missions

As lots of institutional knowledge is escorted out the door, America loses as our leadership in science is gutted. In pilot lingo, it is "controlled flight into terrain" which means flying perfectly good airplane into the ground. It endangers flight safety of our astronauts, and these Russel Vought sponsored cutbacks will lead to a new dark age in space sciences. The cancellation of Earth and Planetary Science programs demonstrates the ineptitude of this Administration. How can you study other worlds if you can't understand the processes on and about the Earth? The entire effort of the partisans is an unforced error by people who know not what they do. The contempt toward science shown by the Project 2025 crowd will set this country back for years. The USA will have another Sputnik Moment when we look hopelessly inept having intentionally fumbled the ball and given up the lead. There was a time not too long ago where

science was largely nonpartisan. Maybe the billionaires should fund science as philanthropy and a stopgap. Billionaires funded large observatories in the early 1900s. The do nothing Congress must step in and save NASA and its science budget (along with NOAA and other science based agencies) before it is too late. China is investing in the future, and the USA is living in the past on borrowed time.

"Basically, anything that supports human life on earth is deprioritized," There's your Republican motto right there.

My husband is a contractor at NASA. He comes home every day with news of the mass exodus of senior people who were near retirement age and just decided it was not worth fight anymore. He is currently in the process (being considered an essential worker) of taking two labs his project formerly had and consolidating them into a smaller overall space. It makes me angry and sad to see what is happening there. Science in this country is in a terrible decline and I mourn for the future.

I am one of those senior engineers, a contractor with 42 years at Goddard that got the axe due to budget cuts. The loss of experienced people is very real there and I can attest to the destruction of a once incredible morale.

Absolutely tragic. NASA makes / made America exceptional. The Earth programs alone, with their contributions to weather forecasting, agriculture, forest fire science, ocean research, famine and disease prediction, and climate are worth the entire budget

Trust me, that is the #1 place where Trump-republicans WANT to cut funding. They don't want us pesky scientists showing them piece after piece of evidence showing that climate change is real. And since even those of us earth scientists who aren't directly studying climate change are impacted by it, there's no way around it. Ie: I'm doing a study now on the drift of the Earth's pole (the pole it spins around) over time. This is impacted by any change in the Earth's mass/density structure. When water or solid land moves from one spot to another, it impacts the spinning pole of the Earth. Now, I'm not studying climate change per se, but when I look at the impact on polar wander due to mass motion in Greenland and Antarctica... well, let's just say it's really hard to explain if you don't discuss climate change. This is not what Trump wants to hear.

The Space Shuttle Challenger exploded in mid air because of a design flaw from a decade earlier. I fear that this gutting of NASA will have consequences for years to come.

Bullcrap. There's "no guidance" on this because leaders at Goddard have been forcing employees to adopt the president's budget request WITHOUT PUTTING IT IN WRITING because they know anything written can

be challenged in court. Hide the receipts, and you can verbally force your employees to make drastic, illegal cuts without any legal pushback, as long as you do the damage quickly enough like they have with the building closures.

It's not just at Goddard. It's been the strategy at at least 4 other centers as well. I can understand the approach – the center directors can see the hostility to their mission as well as anyone and they'd rather prepare for the worst. Unfortunately, that helped send their most experienced engineers to the exit. At least some of the engineers are hoping to come back if the budget picture improves.

I took the buyout, not retirement age but seeing the end game. Wasting days nay weeks writing justifications for continuing to fund highly competitively-awarded, peer-reviewed investigations was just a low point in 8 months of the morale-destroying gutting of NASA's science mission. Industry doesn't do this stuff, and boosting a 30+ year old mission that is way past its prime does nothing for the future of US science and technology leadership. RIP Science at NASA.

I have done work for NASA. Ironically, many of their employees are die hard Republicans so I have to laugh at the irony. Trump destroys everything and now maybe they will finally open their eyes.

My brother is a long time NASA employee. As a die hard MAGA his eyes are still firmly closed. Out of six siblings he's the only MAGA. We don't know what to make of him.

The situation at NASA is another example of the braindrain happening in America , especially science. America is not becoming great again, but rather dragged downward. Look for other nations, perhaps not allies, to be the leaders of our new century.

The story of Trump's devastation of the American scientific enterprise should be at the top of the fold every day everywhere. It's very possible this will be his most lasting and ruinous gift to a country that until his inauguration towered over the rest of the world in scientific discovery and development. Why anyone on any side of the aisle would think we should degrade, for generations to come, the most advanced and productive research endeavor in history – the thing the rest of the world most admired and envied about us – is beyond me. It's so painful to watch – unless you're China.

As reported in this article, what has happened to Goddard Space Flight Center in Greenbelt, MD is shocking. I remember my first job out of college was working at GSFC in Building 3, Room 137. Some things you just don't forget. The engineering, technical, and scientific expertise built up over the last 50+ years has been torn down in 10 months. They say elections have consequences. Who voted for this one?

There's another story behind this one that involves the contractors (many of whom are small businesses) who showed up every day to work with their government counterparts. Someone needs to tell their story.

When you put nihilistic vandals in charge, things get wrecked.

I worked for two decades in the NASA Office of Diversity and Equal Opportunity. We sought not only to help create the best and most talented workforce from across the country, but to create more and more efficient avenues for reporting sexual and other forms of harassment, and to better ensure that NASA-funded STEM programs at universities were affording equal opportunities regardless of race or sex. Now all of the work of equal opportunity and civil rights has been destroyed, not just at NASA but across the federal government. Whole offices and agencies that sought to ensure EO for people with disabilities, or older workers, and yes, women and racial/ethnic minorities, have been shuttered and why? So that that most oppressed of minorities, the straight, white, Christian, male, can no longer be discriminated against as he has been historically in America? "Of all the things at risk, the loss of an objective reality is perhaps the most dangerous."

--- ENDD NASA IN TURMOIL ---

11/7/25: Van Scoyoc newsletter.

Health

Appeals court judges seem skeptical of Trump administration's defense of capping NIH overhead Federal appeals court judges' questions and comments during a hearing Wednesday suggested they may be skeptical of some of the Trump administration's central arguments in a lawsuit challenging its proposed changes to research overhead payments. The case revolves around a multibillion dollar question: Did the National Institutes of Health, the nation's premier funder of biomedical research, violate federal law in an announced plan to slash support for research overhead? Read more: STAT News

FDA's top drug regulator resigns after federal officials probe 'serious concerns' about his conduct The head of the Food and Drug Administration's drug center abruptly resigned Sunday after federal officials began reviewing "serious concerns about his personal conduct," according to a government spokesperson. Dr. George Tidmarsh, who was named to the FDA post in July, was placed on leave Friday after officials in the Department of Health and Human Services' Office of General Counsel were notified of the issues. The departure came the same day that a drugmaker connected to one of Tidmarsh's

former business associates filed a lawsuit alleging that he made “false and defamatory statements,” during his time at the FDA. Read more: AP News

Energy

Energy Department announces \$625M for quantum research centers The Department of Energy announced \$625 million in funding Tuesday to renew five quantum research centers. Each research center is set to receive \$125 million in funding over the next five years, as they study different facets of quantum science and technology, which rely on the principles of quantum mechanics. Quantum research received a boost during President Trump’s first term with the passage of the National Quantum Initiative Act in 2018, allocating \$1.2 billion to the newly created research centers and other quantum efforts. Read more: The Hill

Dept. of Energy directs \$100 million to modernize declining coal plants The U.S. Department of Energy has announced up to \$100 million in federal funding for projects modernizing the nation’s remaining coal plants, nearly half of which were slated to close by 2030. Last Friday, U.S. Secretary of Energy Chris Wright issued the Notice of Funding Opportunity, calling for applications to design, implement, or test refurbishments and retrofit systems that allow coal plants to “operate more efficiently, reliably, and affordably.” Read more: Inside Climate News

Space

Trump renominates Musk ally Jared Isaacman to run NASA months after withdrawal President Donald Trump has renominated Jared Isaacman to run NASA after pulling his prior nomination months ago due to what the president called a “thorough review of prior associations.” Isaacman, who is friends with Tesla CEO Elon Musk, was originally picked to lead NASA in December, before Trump had even taken office. Isaacman is a billionaire who founded payments company Shift4 and has led two private spaceflights. But Trump pulled the nomination in late May after a spat between the president and Musk. Read more: CNBC US slams ‘discriminatory’ draft EU space law as imperiling NATO cooperation The US has come out swinging against a draft law by the European Union that Washington claims would establish restrictive market barriers, impose costly environmental protection requirements, and create regulatory hurdles for US commercial firms – thus undermining bilateral, as well as NATO-wide, cooperation. The US “expresses deep concern regarding measures in the proposed Act that would impose unacceptable regulatory burdens on U.S. providers of space services to European customers,” the State Department charges in a document submitted to the EU on Tuesday. Read more: Breaking Defense

Fundamental Science and Engineering

Top Democrat challenges US budget chief over science cuts as Beijing boosts research Cuts to federal research would weaken America's scientific edge against Beijing, said Raja Krishnamoorthi, the top Democrat on the US House committee focused on China, who is pressing budget chief Russ Vought on whether his office has assessed their impact. "While the United States is dismantling the very foundations that have sustained our STEM and innovation leadership for generations, Beijing has announced its plans to continue accelerating its investments in science, technology, and innovation," Krishnamoorthi wrote to the Office of Management and Budget (OMB) director on Tuesday, according to a letter seen by the South China Morning Post. Read more: South China Morning Post

All government shutdowns disrupt science – in 2025, the consequences extend far beyond a lapse in funding This shutdown arrives at a time of massive upheaval to American science and innovation driven by President Donald Trump's ongoing attempts to extend executive power and assert political control of scientific institutions, according to Kenneth Evans of Rice University. With the shutdown entering its fifth week, and with no end in sight, the Trump administration's rapid and contentious changes to federal research policy are rewriting the social contract between the U.S. government and research universities – where the government provides funding and autonomy in exchange for the promise of downstream public benefits. In the context of broader policy reforms to federal grantmaking, student and high-skilled immigration, and scientific integrity, this shutdown has both known and unknown consequences for the future of U.S. science. Read more: Yahoo News

Oceans and Atmosphere

NOAA cancels funding for data collection crucial to tsunami warning systems The National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration is halting a contract that makes it possible for the federal agency to accurately monitor for potential tsunamis in Alaska – and quickly warn at-risk communities. In late September, the federal agency advised the Alaska Earthquake Center that it does not have funding available for that work. "We are anticipating direct data feeds to stop in mid-November," said Mike West, the Alaska state seismologist and director of the Alaska Earthquake Center, which is part of the University of Alaska Fairbanks' Geophysical Institute. Read more: Anchorage Daily News

11/13/25: IHE. Texas A&M Requires Approval for Courses That

'Advocate' Certain Ideologies / Many faculty members decried the new restrictions on race- and gender-related courses as an assault on academic freedom. Meanwhile, the board also discussed a once-per-semester systemwide course review process.

Courses that "advocate race or gender ideology, sexual orientation, or gender identity" now require presidential approval at Texas A&M system campuses, the system Board of Regents decided Thursday.

Faculty members and external advocacy groups say the new rules violate academic freedom, and for many professors, questions remain about how the policies will be implemented and enforced. Approved in a unanimous vote after a lengthy public comment period, the policy changes fit a pattern of censorship at Texas A&M that escalated after a video of a student challenging an instructor about a lesson on gender identity went viral, leading to the instructor's firing and the resignation of then-president Mark Welsh.

... It will also define "gender ideology" as "a concept of self-assessed gender identity replacing, and disconnected from, the biological category of sex." Similarly, "race ideology" is defined as "a concept that attempts to shame a particular race or ethnicity, accuse them of being oppressors in a racial hierarchy or conspiracy, ascribe to them less value as contributors to society and public discourse because of their race or ethnicity, or assign them intrinsic guilt based on the actions of their presumed ancestors or relatives in other areas of the world. This also includes course content that promotes activism on issues related to race or ethnicity, rather than academic instruction."

A previous version of the revision proposed that no system academic course will "teach" race or gender ideology, but the verb was changed to "advocate" before the policies were presented formally to the full board. It's unclear how the system will differentiate between advocacy and regular instruction on these topics.

...A second policy on "Academic Freedom, Responsibility and Tenure" previously stated that "each faculty member is entitled to full freedom in the classroom in discussing the subject that the faculty member teaches, but a faculty member should not introduce a controversial matter that has no relation to the classroom subject." The approved amendment adds that faculty members may not "teach material that is inconsistent with the approved syllabus for the course."

..."This is not university-level education, it is cruelty and political indoctrination in wolf's clothing," said Leonard Bright, a professor of government and public service and president of the Texas A&M College Station AAUP chapter. "I would need to tell my students that 'What you came here to learn, I'm unable to tell you, because I'm

restricted to tell you that information, even though such knowledge is available at every major university in this world.'"

...Two faculty members—finance professor Adam Kolasinski and biomedical engineering professor John Criscione—spoke in favor of the policy changes. "I don't think somebody should be able to say that Germans born two generations after the Holocaust somehow bear guilt for the Holocaust, because that's really what's being prohibited here," Kolasinski said. "My colleagues seem to think that the policy says something it doesn't." Kolasinski also suggested the board change the language back from "advocate" to "teach."

AAUP president Todd Wolfson urged the board to reject the proposed policy changes in a statement Tuesday. So did Brian Evans, president of the Texas Conference of the AAUP, which includes faculty at Texas A&M campuses. "By considering these policy changes, the Texas A&M University System Board of Regents is telling faculty, 'Shut up and teach—and we'll tell you what to teach,'" Evans said in the statement. "This language and the censorship it imposes will cause irreparable harm to the reputation of the university, and impede faculty and students from their main mission on campus: to teach, learn, think critically, and create and share new knowledge."

In a Monday statement, FIRE officials wrote, "Hiring professors with PhDs is meaningless if administrators are the ones deciding what gets taught ... Faculty would need permission to teach students about not just modern controversies, but also civil rights, the Civil War, or even ancient Greek comedies. This is not just bad policy. It invites unlawful censorship, chills academic freedom, and undermines the core purpose of a university. Faculty will start asking not 'Is this accurate?' but 'Will this get me in trouble?' That's not education, it's risk management."

11/12/25: FYI. NASA Goddard Building Closures Draw Scrutiny

Sudden moves to shutter multiple buildings at the Greenbelt campus have alarmed the top Democrat on the House Science Committee.

House Science Committee Ranking Member Zoe Lofgren (D-CA) is demanding that NASA immediately halt the closure of multiple buildings on the agency's Goddard campus. "In recent days, my staff has received disturbing reports that NASA is directing the imminent closure of laboratories and facilities hosting mission-critical capabilities at the Greenbelt, Maryland, campus of the Goddard Space Flight Center," Lofgren said in a letter to acting NASA Administrator Sean Duffy. The closures underway at Goddard "put essential hardware and capabilities at great risk," Lofgren wrote, adding that the facilities facing closure support many NASA flight missions, and include laboratories essential to the completion of the Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope.

"NASA must halt any and all laboratory, facility, and building closure and relocation activities at Goddard as well as the relocation, disposal, excessing, or repurposing of any specialized equipment or mission-related capabilities, hardware, and systems, and it must do so now," wrote Lofgren. In the letter, dated Nov. 10, Lofgren demanded that NASA respond in writing within 24 hours to confirm its compliance. Science Committee Democratic staff said they had not received a response as of Monday afternoon. The NASA press office did not respond to a request for comment. Lofgren also demanded that NASA provide a "full accounting of the damage inflicted on Goddard thus far" within seven days, and shared her intent to request an investigation by the NASA Office of Inspector General.

LONG-TERM PLANS FOR MODERNIZATION

NASA's leadership has, across multiple presidential administrations, pursued a long-running plan to modernize the Greenbelt campus and reduce its footprint through building demolition, remodelling, and new construction. The agency has reportedly justified its recent actions as part of carrying out that plan. But those plans spanned 20 years, and Lofgren claims the agency's "sudden rush" to close buildings is out of line with what was originally proposed. She cited reporting by Space.com on a September email from Goddard management to employees that said: "Unlike previous large-scale Center reconfigurations, which occurred over a number of years, all planned moves will take place over the next several months and will be completed by March of 2026."

Earlier this month, the Goddard Engineers, Scientists and Technicians Association, a union representing NASA workers, published an update stating the agency was in the process of closing 13 buildings on the Goddard campus, including around 100 laboratories, with "extreme haste and no transparent strategy. Tens or hundreds of millions of dollars of taxpayer-funded NASA property and laboratories are at risk of either being discarded, mishandled, or out-of-commission for significant time periods. Unique and critical US and NASA capabilities are being abandoned without consultation with NASA employees (e.g., mission leads, subject-matter experts), NASA agency leads, Congress, or the public," the GESTA statement reads. The building closures on the Goddard campus will hinder high-profile missions such as Roman and Dragonfly, GESTA said.

Additionally, the union reports that NASA employees are being pressured to move with minimal notice and "discard valuable equipment and flight hardware they have dedicated years to. Goddard management had previously agreed during union bargaining to halt moves until adequate laboratory space had been identified but they are renegeing on those agreements," the union said, adding that conducting the closures during the government shutdown might be illegal under the Antideficiency Act, which defines what

activities federal agencies may carry out during a lapse in appropriations.

GESTA said NASA is justifying the Goddard closures as cost-saving, but that "no details are being provided and any short-term savings are unlikely to offset a full account of moving costs and the reduced ability to complete NASA missions." The union noted that the agency was still paying rent on the Goddard Institute for Space Studies in New York, which had its lease terminated in May. The agency also closed the Goddard Visitor Center in Greenbelt in October. Goddard's Greenbelt campus hosts the largest concentration of NASA scientists in the agency. The campus houses the agency's Science Mission Directorate, as well as the Engineering and Technology Directorate, and has a large Earth and climate science footprint.

FUTURE OUTLOOK FOR GODDARD

Congress has yet to determine NASA's budget for fiscal year 2026. In April, the White House Office of Management and Budget proposed a 47% cut to NASA science that would disrupt many projects underway at Goddard, including the Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope. At the time, Sen. Chris Van Hollen (D-MD), the leading Democrat on the Commerce, Justice, Science appropriations subcommittee, said the plans would "gut" NASA Goddard and the Science Mission Directorate. In October, Democrats on the Senate Commerce, Science, and Transportation Committee accused the Trump administration of illegally reducing spending at NASA in line with the White House budget request. President Donald Trump's nominee to lead NASA, Jared Isaacman, wrote in a leaked manifesto for the agency seen by FYI, that many field sites under the Goddard banner, including GISS in New York and the Katherine Johnson Independent Verification and Validation facility in Fairmont, West Virginia, represent "opportunities for deletion, consolidation or at a minimum standardization for efficiency." In a section about Goddard, Isaacman also said he wished to "evaluate dispersion of mission control centers vs Jet Propulsion Laboratory, Johnson Space Center, Marshall Space Flight Center with the aim to consolidate at JSC." In a statement on X, Isaacman said parts of his leaked plan had been misinterpreted by the media, and stressed he never recommended closing centers, or directed the cancellation of programs before objectives were achieved.

11/14/25: FYI. Science Agencies Face Backlogs Following Record-long Shutdown /The shutdown had wide-ranging effects on research funding and the federal science workforce.

President Donald Trump signed a bill to reopen the government Wednesday night, ending the longest federal shutdown in history. Federal agencies are set to reopen, allowing intramural research activities and extramural research awards to resume. The

funding bill keeps the government open through the end of January, at which point another shutdown is possible.

Krystal Toups, the director for contracts and grants administration at COGR, said the organization is “hopeful that the reopening will largely mark a return to business as usual,” but that it anticipates agencies will take some time to clear backlogs of proposal reviews and grant-related requests.

The 44-day shutdown had notable effects on research funds at agencies and universities and on the federal science workforce. Science agencies furloughed most of their staff, halting additional disbursements of grant funding to universities and many internal research activities. Brian Stone, acting director of the National Science Foundation, issued a memo to staff on Thursday saying the agency would prioritize “restoring our capacity to make awards” over the next several days and anticipated taking “a few weeks” to resume reviews of pending solicitations, panels, and travel.

“We cannot recover the time missed during the lapse, which means we cannot conduct all the programs and activities that we had originally planned for FY 2026,” the memo adds.

The National Nuclear Security Administration furloughed staff for the first time in the agency’s history. Meanwhile, the Trump administration used more than \$9 billion in research funds from the Department of Defense to continue paying military personnel through the shutdown.

The administration tried to permanently reduce the federal workforce during the shutdown, issuing hundreds of reduction-in-force notices to staff at the Department of Energy, U.S. Geological Survey, and other agencies. The notices were blocked in court, and the funding bill that ended the shutdown also nullified any notices issued since the beginning of the shutdown and blocked any RIFs through the end of January.

The Department of Justice requested stays in multiple court cases related to university grant reinstatements, though it appears that most grants to Harvard University and the University of California system were restored before or during the shutdown.

Some universities, including Georgia Tech, the University of Georgia, and North Carolina State University, told researchers a few weeks into the shutdown to limit nonessential spending, including travel and supplies. Georgia Tech told its faculty on Thursday that the school will lift its cost-saving measures starting Monday.

Before the shutdown ended, one researcher at NCSU, who requested anonymity because he feared retribution, said the university

implemented the measures to ensure it could continue paying researchers and staff. Many graduate students and postdoctoral researchers receive their paychecks through federal funds, and the university was drawing on its cash reserves to pay them through the shutdown, he said.

The researcher added that federal reimbursements for research at his institution were “down to a fraction” because agencies were generally unable to release funds. NSF, a major funder of university research, said work could continue during the shutdown on any awards that still had funds available and did not need intervention from federal staff. However, most

The funding situation is complicated further for some grantees whose current allocation ended at the end of the fiscal year and was expected to be renewed on or after Oct. 1. “We don’t know if we have authorization to spend the money we had budgeted for the upcoming fiscal year,” said Luke Oeding, a researcher at Auburn University. “There are some limited options at the university to spend funds in anticipation of the new money coming in, however, that is a risky move if we don’t know what will happen with the grants after the government reopens, and we could end up spending money that we can’t get reimbursed.”

That uncertainty left the researchers in a “holding pattern” throughout the shutdown, Oeding added, unable to commit to things like providing graduate students with stipends during the summer term in 2026. The uncertainty has also held back his team’s progress, he said, because they are unsure if their current project will eventually receive funding or if they should be planning to work on something different.

The shutdown also prevented Oeding’s team from getting academic articles publicly released because they are pending review from the Air Force Research Lab, which is funding the work.

Even though the shutdown has ended, the NCSU researcher said, “it’s not like we’re done and back to normal, because grant reviews have not happened, new batches of funding have not been sent. The longer you wait, the bigger those cumulative effects get, and the harder they are to come back from.” Have a news tip for us? Contact the author on Signal at clarezhang.54 or via email at czhang@aip.org.

More From AIP

NASA Goddard Building Closures Draw Scrutiny

NOV 12, 2025

Sudden moves to shutter multiple buildings at the Greenbelt campus

have alarmed the top Democrat on the House Science Committee. The A.D. White Reading Room in Uris Library at Cornell University.

The Week of November 10, 2025

NOV 10, 2025

- Cornell makes deal for funding
- Government shutdown may end
- DOE renews quantum research centers

President Trump speaks in front of a posterboard that reads "Golden Dome for America."

Lawmakers Seek Next Steps on Golden Dome

NOV 07, 2025

Republicans are appropriating billions for the project despite skepticism from Democrats.

11/17/25: FYI. NSF moving to USPTO campus / OSTP and NOAA nominees face vote / Academies to discuss nuclear space travel

A satellite map showing the plan to move NSF from its current headquarters to a building on the USPTO campus.

NSF RELOCATING TO USPTO CAMPUS

The National Science Foundation is moving from its dedicated 19-story headquarters in Alexandria, Virginia, to a smaller office building on the U.S. Patent and Trademark Office campus a few blocks away, the General Services Administration announced Friday.

The Trump administration announced back in June that the Department of Housing and Urban Development would take over the NSF headquarters, but gave no indication of where NSF might end up, prompting concern that the agency and its staff could be forced out of Virginia.

News that the agency will stay in Alexandria has been welcomed by local politicians and NSF chief of staff Brian Stone, the top official at the agency since its director resigned in April.

"This relocation enables the U.S. National Science Foundation to remain in Alexandria while making responsible use of federal facilities and supporting the needs of our workforce and the research community," Stone said in a press release. "Co-location with the U.S. Patent and Trademark Office will also strengthen both of our abilities to translate discoveries to innovation," he added.

An NSF employee who asked to remain anonymous out of fear of retaliation told FYI that NSF staff are “outraged by the move.”

“It is not justified by any logic or savings,” the employee said. “The costs of moving are large, the building is smaller, and not equipped to meet our needs. In addition, we have lost a lot of staff this year, and we have just emerged from a record-long shutdown. Catching up and returning to normal will take a long time – time now additionally perturbed by the move.”

NSF moved to its current headquarters in 2017. The building was custom-built for NSF, with approximately 690,000 square feet of office space. The Randolph Building at 401 Dulany Street, where NSF is moving, has about 380,000 square feet of office space. USPTO vacated the building as a result of efforts to downsize the agency’s footprint that began in 2022.

NATIONAL ACADEMIES BOARDS TO HOLD MEETING ON SPACE

The Space Studies Board and the Board on Physics and Astronomy will hold a joint meeting this week to discuss science philanthropy, public-private partnerships, and AI for science, among other topics. Argonne Associate Director for Computing, Environment and Life Sciences Rick Stevens and NASA Chief Science Data Officer Kevin Murphy will present at the panel on AI for science. The meeting will also cover a report funded by Idaho National Lab on flying a fission reactor in space by 2030, outlining one option to demonstrate nuclear electric propulsion by 2030 and two other lower-risk options. Jared Isaacman, President Donald Trump’s nominee to lead NASA, has expressed a desire to make nuclear electric propulsion a top priority for the agency.

11/21/25: Van Scoyoc Newsletter

NIH grant cuts have disrupted hundreds of clinical trials, study finds

The second Trump administration has been defined by widespread cuts to federal spending, including at the National Institutes of Health (NIH). A new analysis reveals that the termination of NIH grants has disrupted at least 383 clinical trials, which collectively include more than 74,000 patients. The study, published on Nov. 17 in JAMA Internal Medicine, is a stark example of the real-world repercussions of Trump’s health cuts. Read more: Fierce Biotech

CDC says claims that vaccines do not cause autism are not evidence-based

The U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention updated its website on Wednesday to say that claims about vaccines not causing autism are not "evidence-based." Vaccine skeptic and U.S. Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. as well as U.S. President Donald Trump have promoted the theory – contrary to scientific evidence – that childhood vaccines are a cause of autism. But the CDC's website previously said "studies have shown there is no link between receiving vaccines and developing autism spectrum disorder." Read more: Reuters

Energy Department cuts two major clean-energy offices

The Energy Department is eliminating two of its biggest offices that channeled billions of dollars into clean-energy projects, another step in President Trump's efforts to put a chokehold on federal funds for technologies designed to reduce greenhouse-gas emissions. The DOE is cutting the Office of Clean Energy Demonstrations and the Office of Energy Efficiency and Renewable Energy, according to an organizational chart the DOE unveiled Thursday as the Trump administration moves to further unwind Biden-era climate policies and advance fossil-fuel projects. Read more: WSJ

Totaling about \$3 billion in unspent funds, the cuts by the Trump administration reshaped science

In 2025, more than 3,800 research grants from the National Institutes of Health and the National Science Foundation were terminated or frozen as part of the Trump administration's effort to realign funding priorities. As of November 2025, NIH has seen about \$2.3 billion in unspent funds across nearly 2,500 grants frozen or terminated. At NSF, over 1,300 grants had about \$700 million in unspent funds cut. While this doesn't capture the full extent of government cuts – science-focused agencies such as NASA, NOAA and the EPA aren't included – it does highlight the breadth of the reductions and the ripple effects likely to be felt throughout the scientific community for years to come. Bottom of Form The cuts – totaling about \$3 billion in remaining funds – targeted initiatives related to diversity, equity and inclusion; environmental protection; vaccine hesitancy; public health and more. Read more: Science News

11/26/25: FYI Trump Administration Overhauls CHIPS R&D Plans / The Commerce Department is taking a "venture-capital approach" to funds for the National Semiconductor Technology Center after shuttering Natcast.

In late August, Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick announced he was “clawing back” \$7.4 billion from Natcast, a nonprofit created in 2023 to operate the National Semiconductor Technology Center, a public-private consortium intended to support the U.S. semiconductor industry. The administration has offered new details on its NSTC overhaul, emphasizing its intent to use a single solicitation to rapidly allocate billions of dollars.

In his publicly posted letter to then-CEO of Natcast Deirdre Hanford, Lutnick argued that the Biden administration had broken the law by giving agency authority to an outside body and criticized Natcast as a “slush fund that did nothing but line the pockets of Biden loyalists.”

The National Institute of Standards and Technology has since issued a broad solicitation for semiconductor research, which Deputy Secretary of Commerce Paul Dabbar said will be “the primary mechanism” for the department to make awards for the NSTC and other CHIPS R&D programs. He added that the department will be “fully utilizing the dollars appropriated” to CHIPS R&D and that “this process is intended to be nimble and capable of moving on a business-like timeline.” The solicitation states that awardees may be required to issue royalties or otherwise share revenue with the Commerce Department. NIST staff said in the webinar that the agency “will mirror a more venture capital-style approach” and “strongly recommended” that every applicant “suggest an approach to a financial return on investment to the American taxpayer” in their proposals. Proposals should seek at least \$10 million and will be accepted on a rolling basis through Sept. 30, 2029, NIST staff said.

FYI spoke to five people who served on Natcast’s board of trustees or oversaw Natcast while employed by federal agencies. All were granted anonymity because they feared retaliation for criticizing the Trump administration. Two former Commerce officials said they believe Lutnick will use the solicitation to accelerate product development at private semiconductor companies in exchange for equity, instead of focusing on high-risk, exploratory research. In August, the White House took a stake in Intel and made a deal with Nvidia and AMD to collect 15% of their revenue from chip sales to China. Lutnick has also proposed taking a cut of university patents that result from federally funded research.

Sources said major delays to Natcast’s work began from the start of the Trump administration. A complete lack of approvals from Commerce Department leadership prevented Natcast from moving forward with finalizing their research agenda, new research awards, investment fund plan, and plans for three flagship R&D facilities, one source said.

The funding for the three R&D facilities has been canceled, and Lutnick now plans to use the Natcast funds for projects that will have short-term achievements before the end of the Trump administration,

instead of continuing to establish an entity focused on long-term issues for the industry, as Natcast's creators envisioned, sources said.

"I don't know that there's a right or wrong. It just depends," one former Commerce Department official said. "Would you like to just spend the money and be done with it, and then the industry picks it up? Or do you want this to become an enduring institution for many decades?"

The former Commerce official said "almost everyone" at the Commerce Department who oversaw the NSTC left this year, even before Lutnick's announcement cancelling Natcast. They said the department appears to be consolidating staff to oversee a broader group of semiconductor-related programs at NIST, such as the NSTC and the National Advanced Packaging Manufacturing Program. The department also disbanded the Industrial Advisory Committee, which advised the department on long-term issues for Natcast, a former IAC member said. Natcast has laid off most of its staff, keeping a few employees needed to finish winding down the organization's activities. Even if NIST wanted to follow Natcast's plans, they would need 200 to 300 people, many with technical expertise, another former Commerce official said.

The Commerce Department and NIST did not respond to requests for comment.

R&D FACILITIES CANCELED

The NSTC's three R&D facilities were intended to fill the gap between small-scale experiments in university labs and R&D in a company's manufacturing line, one former Commerce Department official said.

One selected facility, the Albany Nanotech Complex in New York, has existed since 1997. The Commerce Department and Natcast said they would initially spend up to \$825 million to stand up the Extreme Ultraviolet Accelerator facility in the complex, which would provide access to EUV technology with standard numerical aperture capabilities by 2025 and higher ones by 2026. Higher NA allows for more intricate printing on a transistor so that more transistors can fit on one chip wafer, giving each chip greater processing power. The other two facilities, a Design and Collaboration Facility in California and an Advanced Packaging Piloting Facility in Arizona, will not be built. Natcast had already funded a large team to design the Arizona facility and will likely face a penalty for canceling prematurely on the California site, one source closely associated with Natcast said.

The three facility grantees did not respond to requests for comment. Politico reported that a spokesperson for NY Creates, which owns the Albany Nanotech Complex, noted that New York state had also

committed \$1 billion to expand the complex but did not answer further questions about how replacement funding would be secured. A spokesperson for Arizona State University, which would have housed the Arizona site, told Politico that “the planned facility reflects a commitment on the scale of a new national laboratory” and “achieving that national vision depends on federal support.”

THE ORIGINAL VISION FOR NATCAST

The Biden administration envisioned Natcast as a public-private consortium built to last for multiple decades and pursue long-term programs to support the U.S. semiconductor industry. The plan for the NSTC, as codified in the CHIPS and Science Act, includes research, workforce training programs, and an investment fund to help startup companies commercialize new technologies.

Some cited imec, a Belgium-based semiconductor and nanotech research hub, as an inspiration for Natcast. Imec is a nonprofit with semiconductor facilities, thousands of employees, and a billion-dollar annual budget. It began in 1984 as fully government-funded, but as of 2024, it received 75% of its budget from industry.

The CHIPS and Science Act’s mandate for a five-year program with \$7 billion would not be enough on its own to establish U.S. semiconductor leadership, sources said.

“There was the recognition that, over time, it had to generate enough value that it would be self-sustaining without government funding,” said a former member of the Industrial Advisory Committee.

Part of the idea behind creating Natcast as an independent body, they added, was to maintain focus on longer-term research agendas and keep the organization “separated from the vagaries of annual government funding.” One former Commerce official said the U.S. is missing its opportunity to create its version of imec.

“Pretty much every major silicon network company participates in the imec consortium... because that’s where that sort of pre-competitive research gets done, which is wonderful, except it’s not in the U.S.,” they said. “There’s been pockets of it, if you look here and there... but there’s not that sort of scale for open, collaborative research in this country.”

They also expressed doubt about whether the current plan for the NSTC would align with the CHIPS and Science Act.

“I think people in government will have to take a look at that, in terms of, is what’s going on now consistent with the statute,” the former official said. “I don’t think anyone really knows what’s going

to happen.”

DISPUTING NATCAST’S LEGALITY

In his clawback announcement, Lutnick pointed to the Department of Justice’s published opinion that Natcast’s creation violates federal law. The opinion, written in response to a request from the Department of Commerce, concludes that the creation of Natcast violated the Government Corporation Control Act by establishing a corporation to “act as an agency” without being specifically empowered to do so by a law. The opinion acknowledges that DOJ “suggested informally” to the Biden administration that the plan for Natcast was in compliance with the GCCA, but says the legal reasoning behind that advice was flawed.

Because Natcast’s creation violated the GCCA, Lutnick wrote, the funding agreement between Natcast and the administration “has no legal force or effect” and “the department will not abide by its terms.”

In particular, Lutnick criticized Natcast’s board of trustees and the committee that selected the board because some members had previously held positions within the Biden administration, including in the Commerce Department or as a member of an independent advisory committee for the department.

Lutnick also said the funding agreement between the Commerce Department and Natcast would “tie future administrations’ hands” by requiring the department to issue payments annually and whenever Natcast meets certain milestones, and by limiting the department’s authority to terminate the agreement.

Since Natcast’s founding, members of both the Biden and Trump administrations had argued that the department did not have enough control over the nonprofit, one source said. But others overseeing Natcast believed the department had too much control. One former member of the board pointed to the Commerce Department having veto authority over all of Natcast’s programs as an example of excessive oversight that would have hampered the nonprofit.

“I think people would still be okay with administering the program differently, with a lighter touch or more direct government involvement. But what’s happened now is, everyone in industry invested multiple years of engagement, only to have it go away,” a former Commerce official said. “So starting from scratch and saying, ‘We’re going to do something completely different,’ I think a lot of people are just going to decide not to engage.”

DECEMBER

12/17/25: NYT. Trump Administration Plans to Break Up Premier Weather and Climate Research Center / Russell Vought, the White House budget director, called the laboratory a source of "climate alarmism."

DISMANTLING NCAR

The Trump administration said it will be dismantling the National Center for Atmospheric Research in Colorado, one of the world's leading Earth science research institutions.

The center, founded in 1960, is responsible for many of the biggest scientific advances in humanity's understanding of weather and climate. Its research aircraft and sophisticated computer models of the Earth's atmosphere and oceans are widely used in forecasting weather events and disasters around the country, and its scientists study a broad range of topics, including air pollution, ocean currents and global warming.

But in a social media post announcing the move, Russell Vought, the director of the Office of Management and Budget, called the center "one of the largest sources of climate alarmism in the country" and said that the federal government would be "breaking up" the institution.

Mr. Vought wrote that a "comprehensive review is underway" and that "any vital activities such as weather research will be moved to another entity or location."

USA Today first reported on the White House plans.

Scientists, meteorologists and lawmakers said the move was an attack on critical scientific research and would harm the United States.

The National Center for Atmospheric Research was originally founded to provide scientists studying Earth's atmosphere with cutting-edge resources, such as supercomputers, that individual universities could not afford on their own. It is now widely considered a global leader in both weather and climate change research, with programs aimed at tracking severe weather events, modeling floods and understanding how solar activity affects the Earth's atmosphere.

For decades, the center has operated with the freedom to develop outside-the-box ideas that have advanced weather forecasting. Its researchers identified atmospheric patterns that meteorologists rely on today to predict the weather.

In the 1970s, the NCAR scientists Roland Madden and Paul Julian discovered a "pulse" of clouds and rain that circles the Equator every 30 to 90 days. This phenomenon, now known as the Madden-Julian oscillation fundamentally changed the field, helping forecasters

predict weather patterns weeks to months in advance.

NCAR scientists also developed GPS dropsondes, instruments that are dropped from aircraft to gather crucial data about a cyclone's strength and center. This data became pivotal for the computer models used to predict hurricane paths today.

The center's research has often proved useful in unexpected places, such as when its studies of downdrafts in the lower atmosphere in the 1970s and 1980s led to development of wind shear detection systems around airports that helped address the cause of hundreds of aviation accidents during that era. Those systems still protect airplanes today.

The lab is operated by the University Corporation for Atmospheric Research, a nonprofit consortium of more than 100 universities, but the vast majority of its funding comes from the federal government, including through hundreds of millions of dollars in grants from the National Science Foundation.

Scientists said dismantling the center's climate research would do irreparable damage to cutting-edge meteorology and advances in weather forecasting.

"It's the beating heart of our field," Kim Cobb, a climate scientist and the director of the Institute at Brown for Environment and Society, wrote in a post on Bluesky "Generations of scientists have trained there, and almost everyone I know relies on deep collaborations with NCAR scientists."

Katharine Hayhoe, a climate scientist at Texas Tech University, wrote on X that the institution is "quite literally our global mother ship." She said nearly everyone who researches climate and weather around the world has worked at or with NCAR.

It "supports the scientists who fly into hurricanes, the meteorologists who develop new radar technology, the physicists who envision and code new weather models, and yes – the largest community climate model in the world," she wrote, adding, "Dismantling NCAR is like taking a sledgehammer to the keystone holding up our scientific understanding of the planet."

Mr. Trump routinely mocks climate change as a hoax and his administration has labeled virtually all efforts to study climate change, reduce the level of dangerous greenhouse gases in the atmosphere or protect communities from the impacts of global warming as "alarmism."

The administration said the center had supported what it called frivolous and ideological issues, such as research on how to protect

wind turbines from hurricanes and a project to incorporate Indigenous knowledge into studies of how climate change would affect coastal communities.

Yet experts said much of the center's activities focused on basic atmospheric science that had little to do with political debates over climate change.

"If you asked me where you'd find the most politicized elements of climate research, NCAR would be way down that list," said Roger Pielke Jr., a political scientist at the conservative American Enterprise Institute who has often criticized climate researchers elsewhere for engaging in activism.

"A lot of what NCAR does is atmospheric science beyond climate change, like improving short-term weather forecasts," added Dr. Pielke, who worked at the center early in his career. "Destroying it makes no sense."

Putting the facility on the chopping block would also be an economic blow to Colorado. President Trump has feuded with Gov. Jared Polis, a Democrat, in recent days, calling him a "weak and pathetic man" and accusing the governor with no evidence of being "run" by Venezuelan gang members.

The dispute stems from the case of a former state election official in Colorado, Tina Peters, who was convicted of multiple felonies after she gave Mr. Trump's supporters unauthorized access to voting machines after the 2020 presidential election. Mr. Trump has pardoned Ms. Peters, but Colorado officials have countered that presidential pardons do not apply to state crimes.

A senior White House official, who declined to be identified, said in response to the announcement that Colorado constituents would be better served if Governor Polis wanted to work with the president.

Governor Polis said in a statement that the federal government had yet to inform the state of its plans. "If true, public safety is at risk and science is being attacked," he said.

"Climate change is real, but the work of NCAR goes far beyond climate science," the governor said. "NCAR delivers data around severe weather events like fires and floods that help our country save lives and property, and prevent devastation for families. If these cuts move forward, we will lose our competitive advantage against foreign powers and adversaries in the pursuit of scientific discovery."

On Wednesday afternoon, the facility's headquarters on a mesa above Boulder were locked and empty, closed because of a ferocious windstorm that had created critical wildfire danger after weeks of near-record

high temperatures and almost no snow.

"This hits so close to home, and on a day when we have summer clothes on when we should have snow," Christine Cowles, 61, said as she and a few friends hiked through the brittle grass leading up to the facility's entrance sign and made plans to protest the White House's proposal.

To Ms. Cowles, the fact that Boulder was bracing for a potential wildfire on a 66-degree December day demonstrated the importance of NCAR's research on climate change in a hotter, drier West. In December 2021, she watched the Marshall fire sweep through a suburban neighborhood near her home, destroying 1,000 structures and killing two people. She said the danger would only get worse if the administration gutted efforts to track and understand climate change.

Others visitors hiking up to the trailhead that sits beside the facility's pink headquarters, designed by I.M. Pei, called the closure announcement a political attack against a Democratic state that briefly kicked Mr. Trump off the ballot, has opposed his immigration crackdown and refused to free one of his high-profile political allies from prison.

"It's a blatant attack," Jennifer Roos, 57, a retired software engineer, said. "They're going after blue states."

Mayor Aaron Brockett of Boulder called the facility an economic and scientific cornerstone in the university town. He said that dismantling it would erase hundreds of good-paying jobs and could also hurt research firms and other businesses that are based in Boulder to be close to scientific agencies like NCAR.

"The ripple effects would be significant," he said. "You'd have those iconic buildings empty. It would have a very strong negative impact on the Boulder community."

In New Orleans, where many of the world's top Earth science researchers are gathered for an annual meeting, Antonio Busalacchi, president of the University Corporation for Atmospheric Research, which operates the center, said, "What we are seeing is the administration canceling the freedom of scientific thought and inquiry."

Comments...

The Republican Party, not just Trump but the Republican Party as a whole, are imposing upon America a version of Mao's cultural revolution. The party and its elite are all that matters. Science and knowledge that conflicts with their current agenda is

suppressed. Ignorance that aligns with it is supported. They are dragging America, and Americans, backwards and downwards. China must be thanking its lucky stars that the Republicans are in control of their primary opponent on the world stage.

I find it impossible to understand why our government is destroying the country.

Ah yes...another one of our "best in class" U.S. institutions to be destroyed by 45-47. The country is going to look like west L.A. after the Palisades Fire when DJT is finished with us.

Somewhere in the bowels of Congress is the authorization for NSF funding of this and other programs. If only Congress were protecting its prerogative to control how taxpayer funds are spent.

As someone who studied this field in college and is passionate about weather/climate science, this is incredibly sad to see. I certainly hope it does not come to pass, but after the moves this administration has made, I am not hopeful. Another move in a string of short-sighted decisions that will set us back for decades.

Why am I paying taxes? Oh that's right, they will cut my taxes so I can pay a private equity firm an exorbitant fee for a weather report. Can you imagine running any kind of business that relies on consistent weather reports? What a nightmare

This is what authoritarian regimes do...eliminate all information, facts, and resistance to their agenda. When will America stop sleep walking and take action to fix the crony capitalism corruption stealing from us all and especially our future?

At some point the several states will have to start funding vital scientific research without the help of the Federal Government It's clear that facts and the truth do not matter to this administration if facts and the truth do not line up with the official rhetoric. Of course once funding for scientific research, healthcare, education etc. is assumed by the states it begs the question Why are we sending any money to Washington in the first place? Maybe it's time to defund the government.

I hate everything that is happening in our country. It is going to take decades to come out from this heinousness.

OMB Director Vought went on to say "Climate Change was not an issue during the Stone Age so that's where we're heading."

@Dan Dan, I will help you. This is all about Trump taking money from the fossil fuel industry. If there is no data about climate change, then there is no concern about it. He said this during COVID - if

there is no testing, then no one has COVID. He has been bought and paid for by ExxonMobil, Chevron, and ConocoPhillips. I wouldn't doubt that Gazprom in Russia is also paying Trump, which probably in part explains his closeness to Putin. Follow the money.

This ideologically driven attack on reason and scientific inquiry should have been the lead story today. The Trump administration is creating irreparable harm with actions such as this. We are in very dark times.

There is a bizarre irony in that today in Boulder, Colorado, where NCAR (The National Center for Atmospheric Research) perches above our beautiful valley keeping us preparation ready for dangerous weather events, is experiencing cyclone level winds—schools closed, electricity shut down, community asked not to drive— the news comes out this premiere weather and climate scientific service will be dismantled. NO!

This administration (mainly under the instigation of Russell Vought) is in the process of dismantling all of the meteorological institutions in this country that have made the US a leader in this field until now. Tellingly, this was one of the main goals in Project 2025 (architect: Russell Vought) aimed at boosting climate denial and supporting fossil fuel use (and the associated corporations). They have defunded NOAA, etc. These actions will likely lead to catastrophic harm in the farming industry and the population at large. Where is Congress (the Republican Party!!) in these insane decisions?

The Trump administration's move to dismantle the National Center for Atmospheric Research is not an isolated budget cut; it is part of a broader war on science that harms everyone. NCAR's work underpins weather forecasting, disaster preparedness, agriculture, aviation, and public-health planning. Weakening it does not enhance security – it leaves the country blind. This attack on evidence comes as the administration opens the Arctic to expanded oil and gas drilling, dismantles clean energy, and rolls back environmental and public-health protections. You cannot discard climate science while claiming to manage climate risk.

[cont] Climate models are not abstract. They inform hospital surge planning by predicting when and where extreme heat, wildfire smoke, floods, and storms will occur – the conditions that drive spikes in ER visits, respiratory failure, cardiac events, trauma, and infectious disease. Health systems use these projections to plan staffing, bed capacity, cooling and power backup, supply chains, and evacuation protocols. Without them, hospitals are forced into reactive crisis care. At the same time, the administration is defunding university research and installing RFK Jr. to dismantle public-health institutions from within. Calling

this "national security" does not make it so. Real security comes from evidence, foresight, and preparedness – not from erasing inconvenient facts and hollowing out the institutions that save lives.

So I read years ago (I don't know where) about how there was a movement to privatize the national weather service and forecasting. Also doing a quick google search on it comes up with results on project 2025 stating just that. This certainly looks like a step in that direction. It seems the people will still be paying taxes, but getting a lot less out of it.

Additional context for this article: I believe the administration has also tried to zero out two other federally-funded Earth modeling centers at NOAA in Princeton and at DOE. Not sure what the status of those efforts is.

Direct from Project 2025 the plan the Trump and his Administration swore they were not going to implement. "Downsize the Office of Oceanic and Atmospheric Research. OAR provides theoretical science, as opposed to the applied science of the National Hurricane Center. OAR is, however, the source of much of NOAA's climate alarmism. The preponderance of its climate-change research should be disbanded.". Historians will comment on the stupidity of this Administration after lives are lost, property destroyed and scientific progress is set back for generations. When will this country and Congress wake up!

I'm sorry– who elected this bureaucrat, Russell Vought? What he is doing, ignoring Congressional funding appropriations, is illegal. He needs to be in prison, not destroying our ability to monitor and respond to climate change.

Putin will never stop laughing about how easy it was to get Americans to destroy themselves from the inside.

If we survive this presidency, one lesson I hope people carry away from this experience is just how fragile our government and its institutions really are. One man, with the help of a number of groups like the Heritage Foundation have levied an assault on this country and the damage done may never be reversed.

There is no end to what the mentally ill sociopath and his enablers will do to further enrich billionaires and big fossil companies. The embodiment of ignorance. I'm retired, but have degrees in geology and applied physics. I can assure the 94% of US citizens who have no traditional science degree that global warming and climate change is real. As backed by decades of research and data. And we've barely begun to see the negative impacts: more frequent and intense storms, heat waves, forest fires, coastal erosion and flooding, rising sea level, fresh water and agricultural impacts. ecosystem destruction,

etc. etc. The fact trump calls it all a hoax and most republicans agree and do nothing tells educated, rational people all you need to know about their ignorance and arrogance, and greed at any cost. And of course we and airlines all need accurate weather forecasting for our safety and survival. How half the voting country can just shrug at this destruction of our science and research infrastructure and believe the ignorant lies of trump and republicans just defies comprehension. Trump is the biggest threat to our nation and world we've seen in our lifetimes. Hope we can impeach him and vote all his supporters out. We have to try.

Dogma over science. One giant leap back to Middle Age mentality. This administration is single handedly setting the US excellence in science back by decades. China moves ahead as we move backwards in science, technology, innovation and research. Darwin wept.

Russell Vought and Steven Miller are so driven by what to my mind is an unfathomable ideology, that to call it conservative or even right wing would be to describe it in a way that might lend it credibility. That it is destructive, cruel and void of anything other than a callous disregard for US Citizens let alone the rest of the world is the only thing that can be said about it. If they sleep at night – and they probably sleep soundly – they certainly keep others up wondering what calamitous stupidity they will get up to next.

This is so grotesque a denial of science, truth, respect for excellence and expertise. respect for decency, respect for our Re[public that it's beyond the pale. Oh, wait, so sorry. I wrote this same comment about something that Trump did yesterday. Oops, I also wrote it about something that happened w Trump the day before yesterday. I apologize. I'm losing it. I think I wrote this same comment about something that happened w Trump three days ago...and four days ago as well...and I'm sure I've written it, or thought it, since he was inaugurated. Is there a way to just put this comment from me on daily repeat?

The research, models, data, and everything else needs to quickly backed up someplace that is beyond the reach of the Trump administration before they start destroying it. At some point sanity will reappear but it could be years away. I'd suggest a university outside the US would be the safest repository, along with key staff if possible.

"Russell Vought, the director of the Office of Management and Budget, called the center "one of the largest sources of climate alarmism in the country" and said that the federal government would be "breaking up" the institution. When Trump and his acolytes an enablers are history we need to find Vought and make him stand before the American people to answer for the radical, reactionary and vengeful policies of this Administration. He's the wellhead of ideas that have ruined

thousands of lives and will leave American climate technology eating the dust of China and other countries with rational governments. Vought is a vengeful little man on a mission to re-make America into a bizarre notion of "greatness"

Trump can dismantle agencies forever but it won't change the facts of climate change. During this administration we are starting to fall behind other countries in research and sciences to the detriment of our society and economy. Time to wake up America.

When do they start to raid the universities and toss the professors from the windows like 1936 Germany.

The hiring surge by the next democratic administration is going to be one of the biggest job booms in history.

Trump's Chief of Staff referred to Russell Vought as a "right wing zealot" in the interviews she did with Vanity Fair. And you know if that is her description of Vought, he is much worse than that. I've read a lot of articles about Vought. He is a hard right wing white Christian Nationalist, and a member of the Heritage Society, a group that is certainly NOT your average conservative. This is a group of hard right zealots who are obsessed with anti-government sentiment and nihilist views. Vought was one of the co-authors of Project 2025: a fringe, hard right, autocratic manifesto (and I'm being polite about my description.).

[cont] Vought along with his main lawyer Mark Paoletta are responsible for all the illegal claw backs and withholding of prior appropriated funds authorized by Congress. Vought worked closely with DOGE/Musk to unjustly and frankly often stupidly fire so many experienced federal workers. Vought helped to dismantle the U.S. State Dept., it's diplomatic core and U.S. AID, a critical tool for U.S. international relations. Vought is an ignorant hard core climate change denier. He has zero respect for peer reviewed, ethical science. During a time of increasing severity & numbers of super storms, flooding, wildfires would you decimate the U.S. Weather & Climate Change Research Center? Weather prediction saves lives. Vought is a zealot who is doubling down on stupid & he must be stopped.

This is what happens when ignorant and uneducated men run the country. Xi Jinping is a chemical engineer. Is it any wonder that China is miles ahead of us in renewable energy powering Chinese AI good and cheap enough to be used by Airbnb? Science deniers lose in the 21st century.

Russell Vought of course is one of the chief threats to this country, not NOAA. This is more blue state warfare and denial of an existential threat that human societies have caused, and idiot savants like Vought

will make worse to pursue his 'far-right zealotry' (Susie Wiles' words, not mine).

Every day another horrifying report of the follies of Trump, actually of Vought, who seems to be a strange, obsessive personality, consumed by resentments. When the Times interviewed him, he claimed to have been influenced by seeing the terrible burden of taxation on his parents that prevented them from accomplishing great things. The reality was that his mother was a public school teacher, thus a government employee, and as a widow with two children presumably received Social Security payments. His father was a union electrician, probably well paid, and a veteran, thus eligible for various government benefits, including a VA mortgage. When they combined his four sons with her two daughters and had Russell, they created a burden of seven children who were also tax deductions, so the nature of the government tax burden is not at all clear. At some point the parents became religious zealots and sent Russell to the religious and very conservative Wheaton College, which probably encouraged his disdain for science, and now Trump has turned him loose to destroy much of the government funded research that would be a source of pride to a normal president.

How does a nation of 341 million people—with instant access to the world's knowledge—allow a middling, extremist right-wing bureaucrat and a handful of unqualified loyalists to dismantle eight decades of the post-war order and begin erasing a century of American leadership in science, medicine, and technology? This is not just political failure but institutional collapse. Systems built over generations—public health, biomedical research, climate science, universities, and alliances—are being hollowed out by people who neither understand how they work nor respect evidence. Expertise is dismissed as elitism, data as ideology, and uncertainty as fraud. History is clear: nations that abandon evidence-based governance dismantle the foundations of their own prosperity and security. We have 3 more years to go. We will not survive this.

It's a very dry 66 degrees in late December [in Denver], with projected 60–80 MPH winds. For those not accustomed to these conditions, it's terrifying. Firefighters can do nothing to stop a fire in this situation. The same agency warning us about these events is under threat from a mob boss wannabe president. Home insurance has skyrocketed due to weather events. Just another financial pain point the incompetent and corrupt Trump administration will make drastically worse.

Everything is upside down and backwards in this administration. I am afraid that we can't survive another three years of this attack on our environment, our democracy and the rule of law. Another day, another piece of bad news from the far right.

First the NIH, the CDC, NREL, now NCAR..... Our national scientific enterprise – built over decades and with tens of billions of dollars of taxpayer investment – is being completely dismantled. Why? Because science and facts that conflict with Republicanism is "inconvenient." When your party is composed of either the ignorant, or those who can profit from the ignorance of others, this is the natural course of events.

NCAR has been around since 1960. Fifty-five years of excellence. It is a stellar scientific institution. So of course Trump and his henchman Vought want to dismantle it. Are there really that many stupid people in this country, who still support this imposter of a president? Meanwhile, here in the Rockies, we continue to experience record drought and warming temperatures. It's December 17, and it hit 70 degrees today, it is forecast to remain unseasonably warm, with not a drop of rain or flake of snow in sight. Insanity.

They are destroying the very things that make our country great – the institutions that represent pinnacles of human understanding – because with understanding comes awareness of the fact that they are stealing this country from its electorate. The MO is Fascist through-and-through. The Vought-Miller gang is as sinister as it is smart.

"If you asked me where you'd find the most politicized elements of climate research, NCAR would be way down that list," said Roger Pielke Jr., a political scientist at the conservative American Enterprise Institute ... " As someone who has collaborated with numerous NCAR scientists over the years, this statement rings true. NCAR has done more to establish the scientific basis of climate and environmental science than any other institution on the planet. This is exactly why the Trump administration and its backers want to destroy it. This is a truly devastating day for science and our society. Without NCAR, we will be flying blind as we try to navigate our rapidly changing environment. Rather than confront the truth, our government has chosen to kill the messenger.

Mother Nature doesn't care. The climate crisis will proceed apace.

This administration (mainly under the instigation of Russell Vought) is in the process of dismantling all of the meteorological institutions in this country that have made the US a leader in this field until now. Tellingly, this was one of the main goals in Project 2025 (architect: Russell Vought) aimed at boosting climate denial and supporting fossil fuel use (and the associated corporations). They have defunded NOAA, etc. These actions will likely lead to catastrophic harm in the farming industry and the population at large. Where is Congress (the Republican Party!!) in these insane decisions?

12/19/25: NYT. A Somber Mood at Science Meeting as Trump Budget Cuts Continue / News of the breakup of a leading science institution [NCAR] rippled through an annual gathering of Earth, ocean and space scientists. Many say American science is suffering under the Trump administration.

American science is wobbling right now. After cuts to federal funding and the firing or early retirement of thousands of government scientists this year, another blow to scientific research landed this week. The Trump administration on Tuesday night announced a plan to dismantle the National Center for Atmospheric Research in Boulder, Colo., one of the world's premier climate and weather science institutions.

News of the planned closure rippled through the annual gathering of the American Geophysical Union, an organization of Earth and space scientists, being held this week in New Orleans.

"You could feel the energy in the room, and it was very sad," said Mohammed Shehzaib Ali, a graduate student at North Carolina State University who uses NCAR's supercomputer to run programs to understand how weather patterns affect air pollution from wildfires. "Atmospheric science is built on collaboration, and NCAR is the pathway through which we collaborate," Mr. Shehzaib Ali said.

The center's 830 employees conduct research on weather, climate and energy systems, and operate supercomputers that are used by thousands of scientists across the globe. In his announcement, Russell Vought, the director of the Office of Management and Budget, called NCAR "one of the largest sources of climate alarmism in the country."

Antonio Busalacchi Jr., president of the University Corporation for Atmospheric Research, which manages NCAR, told reporters on Thursday that the center's research had led to technological advances in aviation, hurricane prediction and space weather. It has also collaborated with the insurance industry to better predict risk from extreme weather.

"We are talking about a significant impact on the scientific enterprise in this country," Dr. Busalacchi said. Closing the center would be "setting back science in this country by decades."

...The NCAR announcement was the latest cut to science from the Trump administration. President Trump routinely mocks climate change as a hoax, and his administration has labeled virtually all efforts to study climate change, reduce the level of dangerous greenhouse gases in the atmosphere or protect communities from the impacts of global warming as "alarmism."

Brandon Jones, the president of the American Geophysical Union, said the Trump administration had removed data from federal websites, frozen or canceled grants for climate research and weakened regulations designed to protect public health and the environment.

"What we've experienced this past year is not an abstract policy disagreement," Dr. Jones said. "It's a fundamental disruption of the systems that allow science in this country to function."

This year's event was smaller than in previous years. Conference attendance was down by one third to 20,000 from 30,000 last year. Federal science agencies and universities sent fewer recruiters for both jobs and academic positions. Those who did attend said they were struggling to keep their research projects running and money flowing to support graduate students who represented the future of American science.

We've tried to use as much money as we can before it got taken away," said Robert Pockalny, associate dean for academic affairs at the University of Rhode Island Graduate School of Oceanography. The school has admitted 22 graduate students each of the past three years. That number dropped to 10 students this year, mostly because of uncertainty about federal funding for ocean science.

"What we tell our students is, the writing was on the wall about these jobs, but the skills you're learning are transferable," Dr. Pockalny said. Even if they are no longer studying the ocean, he said, the things that they are learning "can be applied to business, industry, banking and all sorts of data analysis."

To maintain federal grants, some universities are switching from researching how to slow climate change to studying how to limit its effects... "There's an increasing appetite for adaptation as opposed to mitigation."

But for midcareer researchers, technicians and scientists working in the middle of ambitious projects, switching gears isn't an option.

In 2009, the National Science Foundation allocated \$386 million to build the Ocean Observatories Initiative, strings of stationary buoys and moored instruments in four locations around the United States....The observatories were completed in 2016, but the Trump administration has slashed the \$40 million each year needed to keep the 900 scientific instruments running, according to James Edson, a leader of the project and a senior scientist at the Woods Hole Oceanographic Institution.

"Things are starting to break," Dr. Edson said about some of the devices.

--- ENDD NCAR DISMANTLE ---

12/19/25: Inside Higher Education. The Year That Changed Research / A year of mass federal grant terminations and sweeping policy changes to the nation's research enterprise broke many scientists' trust in the government. And those changes offer insight into what may come next year.

Ask just about any federally funded researcher to describe 2025, and they use words like chaotic, demoralizing, confusing, destabilizing and transformational.

"It's been a very destabilizing year [that's made] people question the nation's commitment to research," Heather Pierce, senior director for science policy at the Association of American Medical Colleges, told /Inside Higher Ed/.

She expects 2026 to be a year of rebuilding and standard setting.

Speaking of the National Institutes of Health, which calls itself the world's largest public biomedical research funder, Pierce said the research community is expecting more major regulation and written policy changes in 2026, which will shed more light on how grants will be funded, how much the federal government will invest in the research enterprise and what priorities will emerge from this administration.

If the administration's attacks on federally funded research in 2025 are any indication, the federal government of 2026 will likely be just as willing to advance its conservative ideological agenda by controlling universities through the nation's research enterprise. And while the administration may not let up in the new year, courts stymied some of its most sweeping changes in 2025 and may continue to be an obstacle in the new year.

Soon after President Donald Trump started his second term in January, the National Institutes of Health, National Science Foundation, Department of Education and numerous other federal agencies that collectively send billions in research dollars to universities, began freezing and terminating hundreds of grants. Many of the targeted grants—including projects focused on vaccines, climate change, and health and education disparities among women, LGBTQ+ and minority communities—were caught in the crossfire of Trump's war against diversity, equity and inclusion initiatives and so-called woke gender ideology.

Not only would the terminations lead to the loss of jobs, staff and income, a lawsuit filed by a group of NIH-funded researchers in April

predicted that “scientific advancement will be delayed, treatments will go undiscovered, human health will be compromised, and lives will be lost.”

The true damage comes from the betrayal, the sense of uncertainty and the loss of trust researchers have—or had—vis-à-vis with the federal government. That’s really hard to quantify.”

Scott Delaney, cofounder of Grant Witness

Terminated federal grants encompassed a wide range of research projects. Some of the casualties included funding to study the erosion of democracy, the effectiveness of work study, dementia, COVID-19, cancer and misinformation. Others supported teacher-training programs and initiatives designed to attract more underrepresented students into STEM fields.

“The premise of this award is incompatible with agency priorities,” read a letter the NIH sent to numerous researchers back in March, terminating their active grants. “[R]esearch programs based primarily on artificial and nonscientific categories, including amorphous equity objectives, are antithetical to the scientific inquiry, do nothing to expand our knowledge of living systems, provide low returns on investment, and ultimately do not enhance health, lengthen life, or reduce illness.”

But it didn’t stop there.

The Trump administration also temporarily froze billions more dollars in federal research grants at a handful of the nation’s wealthiest, most selective institutions, including Harvard University, Columbia University and the University of California at Los Angeles, for allegedly failing to address antisemitism on campus and ignoring the Supreme Court’s ban on affirmative action, among other allegations. (Most of the universities got their money back after cutting deals with the administration or via court orders.)

And because the NIH, NSF, ED and several other federal agencies also laid off thousands of workers, researchers with questions had far fewer resources to help them navigate changes to application and award processes.

By some estimates, the government disrupted upward of \$17 billion in NIH grants alone this year, according to Scott Delaney, a former lawyer and Harvard University epidemiologist who the university laid off as a result of grant terminations.

Earlier this year, he cofounded Grant Witness, a website that has been tracking grant cancellations at the NIH, NSF and the Environmental Protection Agency. While both the NIH and NSF have since restored

thousands of grants, Delaney said those and other restorations won't be enough to repair the now-fractured relationship between faculty and federal funding agencies.

"The true damage comes from the betrayal, the sense of uncertainty and the loss of trust researchers have—or had—vis-à-vis with the federal government. That's really hard to quantify," he told /Inside Higher Ed/ this month. "In the years ahead, there will be folks who don't want to plan long-term research projects because they don't know if their funds are going to get summarily yanked out from underneath them; folks who don't want to continue their careers in academic research or train in academic research; trainees who would have had training grant support who don't now and go do something else. And some researchers will just leave the country."

In addition, some of the Trump administration's research funding proposals have stoked worry this year about the long-term sustainability of the nation's academic research enterprise.

Numerous agencies—including NIH, NSF and Department of Energy—have attempted to cut university reimbursement rates for indirect research costs. Higher education and science advocates characterized such policies as "shortsighted and dangerous," and said it would hamper university budgets, hurt the economy and stymie scientific progress. Although federal courts have since blocked the rate caps, the mere anticipation of such policy changes led some universities—including the Massachusetts Institute of Technology and Northwestern University—to freeze hiring and, in some cases, graduate admissions.

But by September, the NIH said it was on track to spend its full \$47 billion budget by the end of the fiscal year that month.

However, the NIH awarded 3,500 fewer competitive grants this year with the biggest declines at the Institutes of minority health, nursing, human genome, alcohol abuse and alcoholism and mental health, according to /The New York Times/. Those changes are part of the White House's plan to streamline scientific funding by eliminating wasteful spending and cutting "woke programs" that "poison the minds of Americans."

As 2025 fades into 2026, the federal research funding picture isn't looking as bleak—at least not on the surface.

A flurry of litigation from universities, individual researchers, trade associations and labor unions prompted several federal agencies to reinstate some research grants.

All things considered, 2025 "could have been worse, but it was still awful," Delaney said, noting that there are still thousands of grants

in limbo at the NSF, DOE and numerous other agencies beyond the NIH.

“So many people fought so hard—some of them sacrificed their jobs inside these federal agencies—and they succeeded in many ways. To tell a story that doesn’t include both their sacrifice and their success discredits what was a Herculean and heroic effort for scientists, many who have never spoken up in a political way before this year,” he added. “But it’s also important to emphasize that this fight isn’t over, and we need to keep fighting. It can get worse.”

‘Not Insulated From Politics’

Katie Edwards, a social work professor at the University of Michigan, is one of the researchers who sued the NIH. In March, the agency canceled six grants she was using to research mental health and violence prevention among marginalized young people, including Indigenous and LGBTQ+ youth. Valued at \$10 million, the grants supported roughly 50 staff, community collaborators and trainees and put them all at risk of losing their jobs.

“For many trainees—especially those who are LGBTQ+ or people of color—the message they internalized was painful: that research on their communities is ‘ideological’ or expendable,” Edwards wrote in an email to /Inside Higher Ed/. “The emotional toll of fighting for and protecting staff, reassuring community partners, and trying to navigate a constantly shifting federal landscape has been immense.”

Fighting for Public Health Research

April: A group of NIH researchers, a public health advocacy organization and a union representing more than 120,000 higher education workers sued the NIH for terminating more than \$2.4 billion in grants.

June: A federal judge ordered the agency to reinstate the grants immediately and said the government’s actions amounted to a policy of “racial discrimination” guided by “homogeneity, inequity and exclusion.”

August: The U.S. Supreme Court ruled by a vote of 5 to 4 that any legal challenges to the grant terminations should be litigated in the Court of Federal Claims, not the federal district court system they’ve been moving through for months.

Although her grants have since been reinstated—albeit some with reduced dollar amounts, administrative delays and anti-DEI language in the notice of award—and her team has resumed their work, this year has

forever changed her perspective on research.

"This year made clear that science is not insulated from politics—and that researchers must be prepared to defend not only their projects, but the people those projects exist to serve," Edwards said. "Federally funded research with marginalized communities requires constant vigilance, strong partnerships, and collective resistance. We cannot simply adjust our science to political winds when real communities rely on this work."

But not every researcher who appealed a grant termination got their money back.

In March, the Education Department informed Judith Scott-Clayton, a professor of economics and education at Teachers College, Columbia University, that it was cancelling her six-year grant to examine the impact of receiving federal work-study funding on enrollment and persistence among low-income students four and a half years into the grant.

Teachers College appealed the decision in April, but the government rejected it in September, stating that Education Department grants were specifically excluded from Columbia University's settlement with the Trump administration. Support from a private foundation allowed Scott-Clayton and her team to resume their research this November, but she told */Inside Higher Ed/* that the disruptions to research have been "extremely unsettling and demoralizing."

And she's not certain that 2026 will be any better.

"Even though I believe in the value of what I do, self-doubt can flare up when an authority as significant as the federal government formally declares your work to be a waste of resources," she said. "I am not sure what the future of our field looks like if our federal government no longer values research evidence. And I am not sure what our society looks like if the federal government can make decisions so arbitrarily without any consequences or constraints."

New Year, Old Concerns

This year is ending with unresolved questions about what the Trump administration's research policies will ultimately be, and how much the federal government will fund research. Pierce at the Association of American Medical Colleges said she expects next year will provide answers.

Joanne Padrón Carney, chief government relations officer for the American Association for the Advancement of Science (AAAS), said "I think the [the Energy Department's] Genesis mission and the

prioritization of artificial intelligence and emerging technologies is going to be a key driver in – I guess you could say – filling in the cracks of the foundation of the research enterprise that has been kind of hit by this earthquake in the past year.”

The continuing resolution that ended the historically long federal government shutdown in November expires Jan. 30, and Congress is leaving town for the holidays without passing funding bills for some major science funding agencies, including the NIH, NSF and Energy.

Trump proposed slashing about \$5.2 billion from the NSF. But House appropriators have suggested cutting \$2.1 billion, while senators only put forth axing \$60 million, according to an appropriations debate tracker from the AAAS. And while the president proposed cutting nearly 40 percent from the NIH—\$18.1 billion—the House and Senate have instead suggested increasing its funding by roughly \$1 billion, the tracker shows. That pushback from Congress is promising, advocates say.

And colleges and universities are still waiting for federal research funding agencies to set indirect cost reimbursement caps, after litigation blocked their plans to set the limit at 15 percent. The forthcoming OMB guidance setting those caps is also supposed to help agencies implement Trump’s controversial August executive order directing “senior appointees” to take charge of awarding, denying, reviewing and terminating new and already awarded grants. Among other changes, that order also said grants can’t “promote” racial preferences or “the notion that sex is a chosen or mutable characteristic,” and that they “should be given to a broad range of recipients rather than to a select group of repeat players.”

Further, the NIH is eyeing ways to reduce how much of its grant dollars researchers can use to pay scientific journals to publish their work. The proposed options ranged from limiting how much could be spent per publication or capping the percentage of a grant that can go toward publishing fees overall, to no longer funding publication costs whatsoever. The NIH said in the summer that it planned to make whatever policy it chose effective early next year, but it only recently released the public comments, and an agency spokesperson said he couldn’t provide a definitive implementation timeline.

Just this week, /Science /published a memo showing that NSF is scaling back its reviews of grant proposals, citing its “significantly reduced” workforce and a need to expedite approvals and denials to address a “significant backlog of unreviewed proposals and canceled review panels” from the government shutdown. The memo also said NSF program officers are “expected to maximize their use of available automated merit review tools, especially tools that identify proposals that should be returned without review.”

And the NIH ordered staff last Friday to start using a “computational text analysis tool” to scan current and new grants for words and phrases that may mean they’re misaligned with NIH priorities. Staff were told to look out for terms such as “health equity” and “structural racism.” How this and the NSF policy changes will work in practice remains to be seen.

The educational improvement research field also awaits word on the future of the congressionally required Institute of Education Sciences (IES), which the administration gutted early this year amid its ongoing push to dismantle the larger Education Department. IES is the federal government’s central education data collection and research funding agency. Education secretary Linda McMahon hired a special adviser to “re-envision it, but the plan hasn’t been released.

Overall, Pierce said 2026 “will continue to be a challenging year, especially for those researchers, institutions and trainees that have seen their grants terminated.” But she noted medical research is marked by passion for improving the nation’s health.

“It’s an incredibly resilient field,” she said.

12/24/25: From: American Astronomical Society <aas@aas.org>
Subject: 2025: An Amazing Year

A message from AAS CEO Kevin Marvel highlighting key moments of 2025 and wishing members a happy holiday season.

2025: An Amazing and Tumultuous Year for the Society

2025 will go down in history as one of the most successful yet stressful years for the Society, including substantial changes coming in the near future. It has been a truly incredible year, and I want to thank our volunteer leaders, our members, our authors, and especially the AAS staff for achieving great things in challenging times. Your dedication to the AAS is what has kept me engaged and working to achieve the goals set by our Board of Trustees.

To start off, AAS 245 at the Gaylord National Harbor hotel and conference center was the largest gathering of astronomers in history. More than 3,693 attendees enjoyed 1,085 sessions, 17 invited and prize talks, and a wide range of affiliated content. It was a burst of energy for our field... and little did we know how much we would need that energy in the coming months.

January, February, and March brought a flurry of public policy actions, executive orders, and draft budget proposals that knocked

much of the scientific community back on its heels. Proposals to cut the National Science Foundation (NSF) in half, decimate NASA astrophysics, and negatively impact science across the board were truly gut-wrenching. At the AAS, we undertook scenario planning to prepare for whatever might come our way. This process was tremendously valuable and, when things began to not turn out as bad as they were proposed (we are not out of the woods yet!), we were ready to adjust as needed.

Although many grants that were undertaking useful and valuable work to enhance participation in science were canceled, most research grants were left untouched. The House and Senate have rejected the president's proposed draconian cuts to NSF and NASA, and we await passage of the final funding package. We, the AAS, and the entire scientific enterprise, are still concerned with what may transpire in the coming months, but we are ready and engaged. We are undertaking policy actions we have not previously considered, such as joining other organizations to file amicus briefs to inform lawsuits against the administration, significantly increasing our advocacy efforts by our members and with our professional staff, and partnering with a wider range of organizations in advocacy than we ever have before.

Summer saw us meeting in Alaska, and although the meeting was quite a bit smaller than our January meeting, it performed well, and the consensus among attendees was that the meeting was valuable to them personally.

Throughout the year, the number of submissions to our journals has been running roughly 20% higher than last year. We are on track to exceed 9,200 submissions to our journals for 2025. For comparison, the years 2018–2023 saw us grow from roughly 6,000 submissions to 6,700 submissions. Clearly, we are doing something right with our journals, as even with this substantial growth, the quality of the manuscripts has not declined, and our acceptance rate remains where it has been for years.

Our long-serving AAS Journals Editor in Chief, Ethan Vishniac, announced his retirement as of August 2027, and a search committee is working to take the pulse of the publishing landscape, define the position clearly, and recruit his replacement.

We had a useful gathering of our Division leadership this fall, where they shared their successes and challenges with each other and with AAS leadership. New ideas and partnerships resulted, and we look forward to seeing how these come to fruition, like the Laboratory Astrophysics Division's intention to meet with Divisions over time to demonstrate the fundamental value of laboratory astrophysics to all our sub-disciplines.

Finally, although we budgeted for a very small AAS 247, fearing the

worst, the meeting will be close to a normal-sized January AAS meeting, with all the vibrant content and sessions we have come to expect. As of this writing, we have more than 2,700 registrants. I look forward to seeing some of you in Phoenix for what will be a great conference!

Other accomplishments and details will appear in the 2025 annual report, so let me again thank the AAS leadership, members, authors, and staff who have accomplished so much in 2025 and will do so in 2026 and beyond. The AAS continues to outperform as we strive to fulfill our mission to enhance and share humanity's knowledge of the universe!

As 2025 comes to an end, I want to thank you for being part of the AAS community during a year of both challenge and achievement, and wish you a happy holiday season!

– Kevin Marvel, CEO

2026

JANUARY

1/4/26: From: David J. Toscano from Fights of Our Lives
<deltoscano@substack.com>

HIGHER EDUCATION UNDER ATTACK: Federal Firestorms and Statehouse Power Plays

The battle for the future of U.S. higher education is on. President Donald Trump frequently asserts that “our colleges [are] dominated by Marxist Maniacs and lunatics.” Vice President Vance argues that conservatives should “aggressively attack the universities in this country.” The Heritage Foundation proclaimed that “too many schools have lost their way” and proposed, in Project 2025, that the Justice Department’s Civil Rights Division serve as the “vanguard” in investigating and prosecuting institutions of higher education over diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) initiatives. They have made their intentions clear—to change the country, transform higher education.

2025 brought a new level of attack. Almost every institution—public and private—felt the heat. Trump suspended grant funding to force universities to adopt policies to his liking. The administration made it increasingly difficult for international students to enroll and continue their studies in this country, undermining a major source of revenue for our universities and an important source of research

talent.[1] And DOJ has embraced the challenge of Project 2025; it is now leading these attacks. In this year, 120 investigations have been opened at 60 institutions in over 40 states. University leaders anxiously wonder whether their school will be next to receive a letter from DOJ announcing an investigation.

Never underestimate the turmoil caused by DOJ targeting. Simply look at the University of Virginia, where DOJ was able to use threats, a compliant state government, and a cowardly governing board to force the resignation of a popular and effective President. You can read more here and here, including my op-ed in the Richmond Times Dispatch about how our new governor, Abigail Spanberger, should respond. While most of Trump's fury and federal intervention has been directed at the "elite privates" like Harvard, Yale, and Columbia, state institutions like UVA and UCLA are increasingly being targeted, not only by DOJ but by conservative governors and state legislatures.

States Are the Laboratories

While federal actions attract headlines, changes at the state level may prove more consequential over the long term. State colleges and universities educate the largest share of American students and generate the bulk of undergraduate degrees. Today, we see many examples where governors with national ambitions join with conservative state legislatures to promote their agenda.

Florida is the textbook case. The state passed the "Stop WOKE Act" in 2022, a measure to prohibit DEI programs in colleges and universities. In 2023, Gov. Ron Desantis's appointments to the governing board of the New College of Florida led to sweeping changes at the school. In January 2025, the Florida Board of Governors overhauled curricula across the state's public institutions, removing courses that explored issues of race and gender. These measures have been described as among the most sweeping state attempts to regulate college curricula in recent memory. But the changes have not helped the institutions; more than two years after the conservative takeover of New College of Florida, its rankings have plummeted and costs have exploded.

Other states – including Texas, Indiana, Ohio, Alabama, Utah, and Iowa – have adopted laws and board policies to curtail diversity programs and place new limits on professors. In May, the University of North Carolina System's board of governors forced the elimination of DEI programs and positions at 17 campuses.

Conservatives have also engineered leadership changes. The President of Texas A&M was fired after a controversy involving the release of a secretly-made video showing a classroom dispute between a student and an instructor about the appropriateness of exploring issues of gender identity. Northwestern's President resigned several months after

conservative state lawmakers opened an investigation into the school's handling of pro-Palestinian protests on its campus.

Not every state has taken this path. Those with Democratic leadership – such as California, Illinois, and New York – have resisted federal pressure to curtail academic freedom and unwind their efforts for DEI.

Is Public Support for Higher Education Slipping? It's Complicated.

Americans' views on higher education are complex and evolving. For the last century, Americans viewed the U.S. system of higher education as the envy of the world, and a source of economic growth and technological innovation. A college education was the way to “get ahead”, studies consistently showing that college graduates do better economically than those with a high school degree.

A graph of money and dollar AI-generated content may be incorrect.

Recent polls, however, show overall public confidence in higher education has declined in the last decade, reaching multi-year lows in recent years. Gallup polling reported that in 2015, nearly 60% of Americans surveyed expressed strong confidence in colleges; by 2024, this had fallen substantially. Similarly, a October 2025 survey by the Pew Research Center reported that seven in ten Americans say the U.S. higher education system is headed in the wrong direction.

A graph with green lines and black text AI-generated content may be incorrect.

In mid-2025, Gallup reported the first noticeable uptick after a decade of decline, finding that 42% of Americans now say they have “a great deal” or “quite a lot” of confidence in higher education, up from around 36% in previous years, but the general trend has been downward. Democrats are significantly more likely to express confidence than Republicans.

The constant refrain of the conservative spin machine that higher education is nothing more than liberal indoctrination explains some of these numbers, especially among Republicans, many of whom were counted as strong advocates for these institutions only a decade ago. But criticism of higher education is not limited to perceptions of political bias.

Tuition and costs continue to rise at many institutions, and the public struggles to understand why more schools invest in elaborate facilities that seemingly have little to do with education. Citizens also do not understand—nor do many universities adequately explain—why the overhead costs of research are so high. Increasing layers of bureaucracy and the hiring of non-academic staff are questioned. Finally, there is growing concern that academic standards

are not sufficient to prepare students for what is needed to be successful in a challenging economy.

Reasons for Optimism

Despite this swirl of negativity, some studies provide reason for optimism. Large majorities of Americans oppose cutting federal or state funding for science, health, or education by margins of roughly four or five to one. Nearly half of Americans say they favor more investment in scientific research, and 57 percent want more medical research funding.

And surveys show that Americans have more confidence in public colleges and universities than in private ones. In a 2025 survey, nearly half of respondents (46 percent) reported “a great deal” or “quite a lot” of confidence in public institutions, while only 30 percent felt the same about their private counterparts. Among traditional Republicans, the gap between assessments of private and public universities is even larger. For example, over 40 percent of traditional Republicans have confidence in public universities, but that number drops to just 16 percent for private institutions.

These data are significant, if only because public institutions award between 60 and 70 percent of undergraduate degrees. In Virginia, the number is approximately 67%.

State-specific surveys often reveal higher levels of trust in state universities than found in national polls. A recent poll in Virginia found confidence rates substantially above national figures. Only 18% expressed “very little” confidence in our colleges and universities, well below the 32% nationally. And the gaps between Republicans and Democrats are also smaller in Virginia. This is one reason why the twenty-two appointments that new Governor Spanberger will make to various Virginia college boards when she takes office this month are so critical; she can calm the rhetoric and set an example for the next four years.

Key Role of State Governing Boards

State colleges and universities are typically overseen by Boards of Trustees or, in the case of Virginia, Boards of Visitors. Historically, these boards largely deferred to academic leadership and focused on institutional goals rather than politics. Today, however, as appointments have become increasingly political, some board members are taking a more aggressive posture.

In 42 states, board members are appointed by the governor, and most are then subject to final approval by state legislatures.[2] Historically, legislatures have let governors have their choices. But as partisanship has intensified, appointments have become increasingly

contested, especially in states where governors and the legislature are from different parties. In Wisconsin, for example, Democratic Gov. Tony Evers was unable to stop the Republican legislature from removing board members he supported, an action rarely seen in the recent past. And in Virginia, the Democratic Senate stopped approving Gov. Youngkin's nominees once it was clear that he was pursuing an agenda not shared by the legislature.

In sharp contrast to previous governors, Youngkin argued that board members owed their primary duty to the state and not the institution. Many appointees embraced the governor's attack on everything "DEI." In May 2024, despite several years of work, plans by George Mason University and Virginia Commonwealth University to incorporate race- and diversity-related subjects into the general education curricula were blocked by boards whose majorities had been appointed by Youngkin. In early 2025, VMI's Board voted against renewing the contract of the school's first Black superintendent, Major General Cedric T. Wins, after he led efforts to expand diversity at the institution. Concerns arose about plans to replace the African American President of George Mason University for his DEI support. The UVAs Board involvement in Jim Ryan's forced resignation may have received the most publicity, but it is only part of a national pattern of Boards pushing a political agenda.

Headlines Focus on Washington – But the Real Action Is in the States

Will 2025 be remembered as a turning point for American higher education, as institutions capitulate to federal and state pressures aimed at reshaping their governance and curricula? Or will educators, policymakers, and business leaders succeed in reaffirming higher education's traditional role as a source of innovation and democratic vitality?

One constant stands out: while federal interventions draw most headlines, many of the most consequential decisions will be made at the state level. The actions of governors, legislatures, and governing boards will be critical in determining the future of U.S. higher education.

[1] According to the Association of International Educators (NAFSA), a drop in fall 2025 international student enrollment generated a revenue loss of \$1.1 billion to the institutions and cost nearly 23,000 Jobs. Virginia alone received \$893.5 million in the 2024–25 academic year from more than 23,000 international students at its colleges and universities.

[2] In eight states, the Governor plays no role in the appointment process. Minnesota, North Carolina, South Carolina, Pennsylvania, and

Vermont have boards directly appointed by the legislature or already-seated board members. In Colorado, Nebraska, Nevada, and Michigan, some or all board members are chosen in statewide elections.

1/5/26: From FYI

Subject: This Week: Minibus funding deal rejects big science cuts / NIH reviewing shelved grant applications / H-1B to ditch lottery system

FYI: Science Policy News from AIP

FUNDING DEAL REJECTS TRUMP'S PUSH FOR MAJOR SCIENCE CUTS

Congressional appropriators released a "minibus" of three bipartisan spending bills today that would pare back the budgets of some science agencies but largely reject Trump's request for steep cuts. The minibus consists of the Commerce-Justice-Science, Energy and Water Development, and Interior-Environment bills, which cover a substantial portion of federal research funding for fiscal year 2026.

The package includes:

- * \$24.4 billion for NASA, a 1.6% cut (including \$7.25 billion for NASA Science, a 1.1% cut);
- * \$8.75 billion for the National Science Foundation, a 3.4% cut;
- * \$8.4 billion for the Department of Energy's Office of Science, a 1.9% increase;
- * \$6.17 billion for the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, roughly flat funding;
- * \$1.42 billion for the U.S. Geological Survey, a 2.0% cut; and
- * \$1.18 billion to the National Institute of Standards and Technology, a 2.3% increase (NIST's topline is technically \$1.85 billion, but that amount includes roughly \$660 million in earmarks that would fund external projects.)

Within DOE, the topline budget of some agencies is supplemented by unspent money originally allocated by the Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act. For example, DOE's Office of Science would get \$150 million repurposed from the infrastructure act in addition to its base budget of \$8.25 billion. DOE's Office of Energy Efficiency and Renewable Energy would get \$1.15 billion repurposed from the infrastructure act to bring its total budget up to \$3.1 billion – a

10% cut overall, but far from the 74% cut requested by Trump.

Sen. Patty Murray (D-WA), the top Democrat on the Senate Appropriations Committee, praised the minibus in a statement, saying it “rejects President Trump’s push to let our competitors do laps around us by slashing federal funding for scientific research by upwards of 50% and killing thousands of good jobs in the process.” Senate Appropriations Committee Chair Susan Collins (R-ME) identified science funding as a priority in a statement on the minibus, saying it is “a fiscally responsible package that restrains spending while providing essential federal investments that will improve water infrastructure in our country, enhance our nation’s energy and national security, and spur scientific research necessary to maintain U.S. competitiveness.”

House Speaker Mike Johnson (R-LA) said on X that the House will vote on the package this week. The House previously proposed cuts that were less severe than the president’s, but in many cases still far larger than those in the minibus. Congress is laboring under a deadline to pass spending legislation or stop gaps before funding for many federal programs expires on Jan. 30.

NIH GRANT APPLICATIONS IN RE-REVIEW, HHS RULEMAKING POLICY UNDER SENATE SCRUTINY

In two case settlements announced in late December, the National Institutes of Health agreed to deliver “good faith” decisions on certain grant applications that it denied or did not decide on last year. In both cases, NIH did not concede any legal violations in refusing to consider or “unreasonably delaying” review of and decisions on grant applications. Inside Higher Ed reported that the Dec. 29 agreements have already led to at least 634 grant approvals out of 674 re-reviewed applications. The agreement in the case led by state attorneys general covers more than 5,000 grants, while the agreement in the case led by the American Public Health Association covers around 400 grants. The agreements require NIH to complete further rounds of review throughout the first half of 2026.

Also last month, senators led by Angus King (I-ME) sought to overturn a policy at the Department of Health and Human Services established early last year that allows the department to finalize rulemaking without a period of public comment. King’s resolution narrowly failed in a 50–50 vote. The White House issued a statement rejecting the resolution, saying the change in policy allows agencies to implement regulatory changes “flexibly and efficiently.”

H-1B TO DITCH LOTTERY SYSTEM

The Department of Homeland Security announced in late December that it

will replace the lottery system used to award H-1B work visas with a system that prioritizes high-skilled workers, effective Feb. 27. In a press release, DHS said the change aims to incentivize employers to use the program primarily for "higher-paid, higher-skilled workers," while the previous lottery system allowed employers to "flood" the selection pool with applications for low-skilled workers. The release added that the new policy is in line with other changes the administration has made to the H-1B program, including its imposition of a \$100,000 per visa fee. On Dec. 23, a federal judge ruled in favor of the administration in a lawsuit challenging the fee. The plaintiffs in that case, which include the U.S. Chamber of Commerce and the Association of American Universities, have appealed the ruling. Other lawsuits challenging the fee are ongoing.

1/8/26: ArsTechnica. Eric Berger. Telescope philanthropy is back / Former Google CEO plans to singlehandedly fund a Hubble telescope replacement

Prior to World War II the vast majority of telescopes built around the world were funded by wealthy people with an interest in the heavens above.

However, after the war, two significant developments in the mid-20th century caused the burden of funding large astronomical instruments to largely shift to the government and academic institutions. First, as mirrors became larger and larger to see deeper into the universe, their costs grew exponentially. And then, with the advent of spaceflight, the expense of space-based telescopes expanded even further.

But now the tide may be turning again.

On Wednesday evening, former Google CEO Eric Schmidt and his wife, Wendy, announced a major investment in not just one telescope project, but four. Each of these new telescopes brings a novel capability online; however, the most intriguing new instrument is a space-based telescope named Lazuli. This spacecraft, if successfully launched and deployed, would offer astronomers a more capable and modern version of the Hubble Space Telescope, which is now three decades old.

A billionaire with a keen interest in science and technology, Schmidt and his wife did not disclose the size of his investment in the four telescopes, which collectively will be known as the Schmidt Observatory System. However, it likely is worth half a billion dollars, at a minimum.

"For 20 years, Eric and I have pursued philanthropy to seek new frontiers, whether in the deep sea or in the profound connections that link people and our planet, committing our resources to novel research

that reaches beyond what might be funded by governments or the private sector," Wendy Schmidt said in a statement to Ars. "With the Schmidt Observatory System, we're enabling multiple approaches to understanding the vast universe where we find ourselves stewards of a living planet."

Essentially the Schmidts have taken innovative telescope concepts that scientists have proposed for government funding and will provide the money needed to build them. Their gift has enormous potential to advance the study of astronomy and astrophysics.

Deep blue

Named for the deep sky blue of the rock Lapis lazuli, Lazuli is an optical space telescope with a mirror diameter of 3.1 meters (by comparison, the primary mirror of the Hubble Space Telescope is 2.4 meters). It is intended to launch as early as late 2028 and begin scientific operations in 2029.

There are some notable differences between Hubble and Lazuli, starting with the orbit. Lazuli will be located much farther from Earth, in an elliptical orbit with an apogee of 275,000 km and a perigee of 77,000 km, the latter distance about twice as high as geostationary orbit. This will afford the telescope a much clearer view than Hubble, located about 500 km above Earth and increasingly affected by the passage of Starlink and other communications satellites in its observations. At this higher altitude the Lazuli team believes it can maintain control of the telescope at all times and have a rapid data downlink.

"We sit on decades of technological developments since Hubble," said Arpita Roy, lead of the Astrophysics & Space Institute at Schmidt Sciences, in an interview. "Lazuli is a very modern take on Hubble, with a larger mirror, swifter response, and different instruments."

The instruments are a wide-field camera, a spectrograph, and notably, a coronagraph to blot out the light from stars to reveal the atmospheres and other details of exoplanets orbiting them.

<https://cdn.arstechnica.net/wp-content/uploads/2026/01/lazuli.jpg>
Some specs on the Lazuli space telescope. Credit: Schmidt Observatory System
Some specs on the Lazuli space telescope. Credit: Schmidt Observatory System

Schmidt Sciences will act as the overall integrator and manager of the Lazuli project. The president of the philanthropic organization, Stuart Feldman, said he was not ready to disclose the telescope's primary contractors yet. But he said a key goal of this telescope, and the other three projects, is to move quickly. Moving from a telescope

concept to launching hardware in less than five years would be rapid indeed.

Feldman said in an interview that the major space telescopes planned, built, and launched by NASA have tended toward 25-year gestation periods. It is common today for an astronomer to design instruments on observatories that will only be used by their graduate students upon nearing retirement. Moving expeditiously should also better control costs.

Feldman said he had "moderate-high confidence" that deploying and operating Lazuli would be a success. "We are taking far more risks than NASA would be willing to do," he acknowledged. "But we are doing things rigorously, and aiming for a very high probability of success."

No privately funded observatory remotely close to Lazuli's scope has ever been launched into space. If successful, it would be, in many ways, historic.

On the ground

The other three telescopes that will be funded by the Schmidts will be based on the ground, in the southern and western United States, but they are no less innovative than Lazuli. All three of the proposed telescopes are modular and take advantage of recent advances in computing power, storage, and AI processing and analyzing data.

They are:

- * ***Argus Array***: This is an array of 1,200 telescopes with 11-inch mirrors, likely located in Texas, to mimic the effect of an 8-meter optical telescope. It will image the entire Northern Hemisphere sky. Managed by the University of North Carolina, with a company called Observable Space building the telescopes, the Argus Array will be co-funded by the Schmidts and a Russian-born British financial trader named Alex Gerko. It will produce an image every second and capture objects as faint as the 18th or 19th magnitude, Feldman said. Enticingly, it will essentially be able to generate movies of the night sky, allowing astronomers who observe a supernova or other interesting object to rewind 30 minutes, or two hours, to see what happened leading up to the explosion.
- * ***DSA radio telescope***: This will be an array of 1,600 radio dishes, each with an antenna of about 6 meters, located in a valley in Nevada. It is far less expensive to fill a valley with these smaller antennas than to build a single Arecibo-size radio telescope. This project will be managed by the California Institute of Technology and fully funded by the Schmidts. The

radio dishes will feed an enormous amount of data and require processing faster than Netflix's global data stream currently does to map over a billion radio sources in the universe. It will aim to produce a picture of the sky every 15 minutes.

- * *LFAST*: This instrument will conduct scalable, large-aperture spectroscopy. Likely based in Arizona, a prototype could be deployed by mid-2026. It will contain 20 80cm mirrors in a single rack to provide the equivalent observational power of a 3-meter telescope. Among its capabilities will be to search for biosignatures on other worlds, and it is designed to be expandable over time. It will be led by the University of Arizona and fully funded by the Schmidts.

Modular and affordable

The design of each telescope selected for the Schmidt Observatory System feels very modern. Their designs are enabled by recent developments in the miniaturization of electrical components, more powerful computers, artificial intelligence, lower-cost launch, and other trends.

These telescopes could probably not have been built even five years ago. Feldman said the storage for some of the ground telescopes requires petabytes. AI will be crucial to poring over all of this data to uncover new and novel observations. And prior to the current class of commercial heavy-lift rockets, a telescope had to scrimp on mass and power; but now, with cheaper and brawnier launch, it's easier just to throw more solar cells on an instrument.

The plan is to freely and openly share data from the telescopes. The Schmidts have emphasized that this is not a commercial project in any way. They will not be selling time on the telescopes. Rather, there will be an open competition for the best scientific ideas and observations to make.

"We are basically providing a gift to the global astronomical community," Feldman said. "We wish the data to be openly available for all of the instruments."

The Schmidts' approach also includes tapping into emerging commercial space companies, such as Observable Space, which is building the Argus Array telescopes.

"The Argus Array's commitment to open data and open science represents a new model for how astronomical discovery should happen," Dan Roelker, CEO of Observable Space, said. "We're excited to partner with the University of North Carolina and Schmidt Sciences to build the more than 1,200 telescopes designed not just for today's questions,

but for discoveries we haven't imagined yet."

The Schmidts have been reticent to speak about costs, but Feldman acknowledged that building and launching a space telescope will easily cost in the "hundreds of millions of dollars." And that's just one of the four telescopes.

"Putting up a whole valley filled with 20-foot antennas is not child's play either," he said. "This is a very significant contribution to astronomy."

Comments...

As mentioned, the Schmidts have been funding great work in deep sea oceanography. The Schmidt Ocean Institute runs its own ship, the R/V Falkor (too). It's a larger successor to their R/V Falkor, which they donated to Italy. It has a remotely operated submersible, the ROV SuBastian, which can get down to 4500 m. Oceanography is not as glamorous as astronomy, although it's of more day-to-day importance, so their contribution there is very welcome. They also funded the Keeling Curve when national funding was cut off in 2014. This is the lab on Mauna Loa that has been measuring CO2 concentrations since the 1950s. It's by far the longest continuous record of CO2, and has been crucial in identifying the calamity of climate change. It's nuts that this has to be privately funded.

If we have to have billionaires without progressive taxation for them, then this is better than the sophomoric political activism of some others in their cohort.

Unfortunately, for every billionaire like Schmidt and MacKenzie Scott, there are a hundred like Elmo and Bezos. Thanks to the few who use their immense fortunes to benefit humanity rather than themselves.

This is what the new gilded era will look like. We're not going to fund public works as much with public money, but rather let them be led by prominent individuals. It's a lot more like Renaissance Venice than our prior model. I'm not convinced it can compete well with China, any more than Venice could really compete with say the Ottomans. There are obvious limits to historical analogy, don't get carried away.

Ah, welcome back to the middle ages, where scientific advancement is based on the whims of the lords and barons who might take a particular fancy to a subject.

Historically, States had very little if any money of their own. Pre-19th century European "government" consisted largely of wealthy people and their whims – wars, for example, used to be fought with private fortunes, not "state funds". The transition to enormous

bureaucratic states with deep deep pockets as we know them today was gradual, and the ability of the state to fund these sorts of massive projects is pretty recent.

Other interesting billionaire science founders are Jim Simons (ran one of the first and most profitable hedge funds, and since then the best ground-based studies of the cosmic microwave background; his money also backs Quanta magazine which is what Scientific American used to be) and D E Shaw whose investment company has a surprising sideline in highly optimised custom molecular dynamics hardware

1/9/26: Van Scoyoc newsletter

Trump proposes massive increase in 2027 defense spending to \$1.5T

President Donald Trump on Wednesday proposed setting U.S. military spending at \$1.5 trillion in 2027, citing "troubled and dangerous times." Trump called for the massive surge in spending days after he ordered a U.S. military operation to capture Venezuelan leader Nicolás Maduro and spirit him out of the country to face drug trafficking charges in the United States. U.S. forces continue to mass in the Caribbean Sea. The 2026 military budget is set at \$901 billion. Trump in recent days has also called for taking over the Danish territory of Greenland for national security reasons and has suggested he's open to carrying out military operations in Colombia. Read more: [Military Times](#)

[Almost certainly implying that the extra \$500B will have to come out of the other parts of the federal budget, undoubtedly including science and higher-ed.]

Trump threatens to nix Raytheon's defense contracts

President Trump threatened to kneecap a division of RTX, the world's second-largest defense contractor, if it did not step up and invest in "plants and equipment." This was the most specific in a series of warnings Trump sent out to American defense firms on Wednesday, ordering them to cap executive pay, halt all dividends and stock buybacks, and speed up production. Such interventions from the commander-in-chief are highly unusual. It was also unclear how Trump could enforce such dictates on private companies, though his subsequent threat to Raytheon suggested he may cut federal contracts to firms he sees as out of compliance. Read more: [Axios](#)
[vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

House, Senate lawmakers ignore requested Trump cuts at key science agencies

A three-bill minibus appropriations bill that includes funds for Energy and Water development, including \$25.4 billion to the National Nuclear Security Administration (NNSA), passed the House floor 397–28 Thursday. The Department of Energy would avoid a requested Trump cut with a funding level of about \$50 billion, though totals in summaries again differed slightly. That would keep funding for the agency that houses the national labs and the nation's nuclear stockpile funded at roughly the same amount. That includes an increase for DOE's Office of Science, which would get a \$160 million uptick to \$8.4 billion under the bill rather than a \$1.1 billion decrease proposed by the Trump administration. It also exceeded the administration's request for the Office of Cybersecurity, Energy Security, and Emergency Response – which secures energy infrastructure – funding the office at \$190 million rather than the \$150 million requested. Read more: FedScoop [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com], FY2026 Energy and Water Development Appropriations Conference Report – Summary

Congress rejects President Trump's deep NASA budget cuts

The FY2026 Commerce–Justice–Science Appropriations Conference Bill and Report passed by the U.S. House of Representatives Thursday would give NASA \$24.4 billion in fiscal year 2026, which started on Oct. 1. Much of the restored funding would go to NASA science programs. The bill rejects the administration's devastating proposal to cut NASA Science by 47% and terminate 55 operating and planned missions. It instead provides \$7.25 billion. The bill provides \$1.6 billion for Astrophysics, including \$300 million to complete the Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope to investigate dark energy and the formation of galaxies and stars, and \$150 million to ramp up development of the Habitable Worlds Observatory. The bill also provides \$7.78 billion for Exploration, which is \$117 million above fiscal year 2025. The bill supports progress on the Artemis Campaign, including sufficient funding for NASA to meet the ambitious goal of returning humans to the Moon by 2028. Aeronautics is supported at \$935 million, equal to fiscal year 2025. Read more: Space.com [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com], FY2026 Commerce–Justice–Science Appropriations Conference Report – Summary

Congress rejects proposed cuts to NSF

The FY2026 Commerce–Justice–Science Appropriations Conference Bill and Report passed Thursday by the U.S. House of Representatives funds NSF at \$8.75 billion, rejecting President Trump's proposal to investment in NSF by 57%. The bill invests \$7.18 billion for NSF's research and related activities, level with fiscal year 2025, to help drive U.S. economic competitiveness, including investments in artificial intelligence and quantum information science, and the Directorate for Technology, Innovation, and Partnerships. NSF's

education and training programs to build tomorrow's innovation workforce are funded at \$938 million. According to the Committee summary, this funding level for NSF should support nearly 10,000 new competitive awards and more than 250,000 scientists, technicians, teachers, and students. Read more: FY2026 Commerce-Justice-Science Appropriations Conference Report – Summary

1/10/26: WP. Here are the agencies that were cut the most by Trump, new data shows / About 335,000 federal workers left government from January to November 2025, with a vast majority of those people quitting or retiring.

More than a third of the Agriculture Department's food inspectors left government last year. Over a quarter of Social Security's IT management is gone. The Treasury Department is down about 4,000 tax examiners, or about 26 percent.

In total, about 335,000 federal workers left government from January to November 2025, with a vast majority of those people quitting or retiring, according to data released Thursday by the federal government's human resources arm. While Trump officials and billionaire Elon Musk had vowed to fire many federal employees – accusing the workforce of being bloated and inefficient – [only] a small fraction of workers, approximately 11,000, were laid off.

... the biggest overhaul to the federal workforce since the 1990s. [Although the article doesn't mention this, it was Al Gore who led the contraction of the workforce ca. 96–97 -- all done without significant damage to government operations or betraying the loyalty of its workers.]

...nearly all of the U.S. Agency for International Development's workforce was wiped out, largely through layoffs, after the administration moved to formally abolish the agency. The Education Department, which Trump has promised to eliminate, lost about 40 percent of its staff, including nearly 700 employees who were laid off. More than 4,000 people were laid off at the Department of Health and Human Services, while the number of voluntary departures was more than three times that number.

A far greater number of federal employees took buyout offers that Musk and agencies offered last year to reduce workforces, The Washington Post previously reported. While the database doesn't say specifically how many workers took buyouts, those employees were counted among those who quit, which totaled about 154,000, or about half of those who left. More than 100,000 others took various forms of retirement offers, leading to a backlog in processing the departures.

...Many federal workers described feeling beaten down and exhausted by the Trump administration, which encouraged people across the board to leave,

...At the same time, the administration launched a hiring campaign to recruit Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents for its efforts to deport undocumented immigrants, gaining more than 6,000 ICE employees in 11 months. In total, the agency said on Jan. 3 that it has hired about 12,000 ICE officers and agents. There were also more hires within the Secret Service and the Federal Law Enforcement Training Centers.

Comments...

Quit is something of a misnomer since many who quit were actually driven out by threats and harassment. Even the WaPo reported that was the case when it was going on, but the report now makes it look like they voluntarily left. Seems to legitimize the actions of the administration when they were anything but legitimate and it is a big question if they were even legal.

Oh yes, they were harassed, asked to report 5 things they did during the week. [Part of the Musk lunacy -- millions of make-work reports that nobody ever read.]

To briefly quote Joni Mitchell, from big Yellow Taxi... "You don't know what you got til it's gone...." Think about it next time you buy ground beef (because the new food guidelines advise us to eat more meat) and wonder whether it's safe to eat because there aren't any food inspectors.

The marvelous advances most of us Americans enjoyed in nutrition, health care, education, job opportunities, and consumer electronic technology will begin to quickly erode once we have allowed Trump's agency-paralyzing obsessions to acquire the force of law, further corrupting our government. Many of the physicians, engineers, and medical research scientists who recently left ('resigned'? driven away? threatened with firing?) HHS cited that an important consideration of their decision to leave was the sudden (beginning Inauguration Day 2025) ascendance within their departments of under-trained 'leadership' who preferred partisan loyalties and even outright propaganda to well-established scientific findings.

[cont] A prime example of this was Trump's appointment of famous fruitbat RFK Jr. who sounds like he never passed a collegiate science class, to preside over HHS and overrule sound scientific judgment from within the technical ranks of the agency in favor of personal prejudices and unscientific bias. Abusing government power in order to publicly discredit valid scientific research and medical technology is a ticket to some new kind of Dark Age.

Someday, in the not distant future, everybody will say they were against this. They created the myth of a "deep state", destroyed the CDC, NASA, EPA, NIH, FDA, HHS, USAID with the excuse that this were "non-elected bureaucracies", as if you can run elections to staff a federal agencies. No invading army would have destroyed the foundation of America like this government, the consequences will be felt long after Trump is gone.

Seems we are building a secret police state while gutting departments that serve the public.

It's a country with armed thugs on the state payroll who can legally hide behind masks as they terrorize and murder citizens.

Taking a buy out is being fired because if you don't take it you will be fired. Same for early retirement. If I am going to get fired I won't be building up any further retirement. So I retire early get some money flowing and find job somewhere else. So the article is disingenuous about only a few were actually fired. Only upper management of huge corporations who have done mass layoffs would try to spin firing people like this article does.

I lost a corporate job during the recession. When you are in your 50's, graduate degree or not, you may not ever go back to the same level or full time job. You lose hundreds of thousands over time with low pay, less investment and less SS

[The article] points out in the beginning that the cuts followed Trump's priorities, as does everything he does. So it is telling that veterans took the biggest hit.

As someone fired on April 1 from HHS I feel forgotten about. Even in this article the fact that HHS had more RIFs than any other department isn't even mentioned. No one talks about us at all anymore, despite our health agencies being absolutely gutted to the point of devastation. Feels like my 16 years of service were all for nothing.

For our government to basically brag about how decimated the agencies have become, with personal damage to thousands of employees, just says volumes about the inhumanity of DOGE and the leaders in OMB. Sad.

A letter from a neighbor follows:

"Dear neighbors, it's with a mixture of emotions that I retired from NIH on December 31. This is earlier than I had planned but the job became intolerable under the "leadership" of RFK Jr., Jayanta Bhattacharyya, and Matthew Memoli. They are systematically dismantling the world's foremost scientific funding agency, seriously disrupting the medical research establishment in the

USA, destroying careers (especially for early stage researchers), and spreading harmful misinformation that is undermining public health. Funding decisions have become non-transparent and based on "alignment with administration priorities" rather than on scientific merit. I concluded that I could not, in good conscience, continue to play a role in this farce."

Trump cut all of USAID and closed programs for food to refugee camps and medicine, including vaccines. Over 100,000 have reportedly died as a result so far and millions will likely die. Under Obama, quick assistance stopped the worldwide spread of the Ebola virus. Abandoning Africa (and ignorant verbal and military attacks against individual countries) will cause problems that will eventually include damage to the US. As China takes some of the world leadership the US has abandoned, US prosperity will eventually suffer. US products, services, political system, universities and position in the world used to be admired worldwide. Now it is feared and despised worldwide. US prosperity will suffer as a result.

From Fareed Zacharia editorial in the Post yesterday:

"This strategic capital built over decades is now being squandered. And in the long run, an America that behaves like an utterly self-interested predator on the world stage will not grow stronger; it will grow lonelier. Allies will hedge. Partners will search for options. Neutrals will inch away. And the balancing that history predicted all along may finally arrive – not because America became weak, but because it forgot the real source of its strength."

Interesting that the military lost so many personnel. Guess even they don't want to work for a madman.

Last week Noem announced she's cutting FEMA staffing by half. 15 mos after Helene flooded NC there are still roads and bridges that are impassable.

Even though I've always known the US Republican party was authoritarian, I'm staggered by the brazenness of these giant Trump posters I keep seeing in photos of Washington DC. They're just so overtly Stalinist, North Korean, Big Brother Orwellian. The personality cult is so in-your-face. It can't be an accident, they're actually trying to look as much as possible like an authoritarian regime.

You're really being disingenuous here by making it sound like everyone just either happily retired or rage quit, when the fact is that the "buyouts" you glossed over were really a threat.

This is only a piece of the picture. What about those individuals who work for private sector contractors that are paid by our Federal Government for providing routine, non-specialized services? What are the reduction numbers associated with them? Although outsourced, these jobs are executed on behalf of the Federal Government even though it has not been including their numbers over the decades in order to trumpet a smaller Federal workforce number. Could it be, in fact, that contractor employment increased as Federal employment decreased? Surely an investigation is warranted to present a more honest depiction of what is happening with the workforce that provides services on behalf of our Federal Government.

How can the reader judge whether the reduction is significant – the article presents no data from previous years? Where is the analysis?

...and then there are thousands more, dedicated public servants still receiving salary, but made professionally impotent and incapable of doing their valuable professional work on behalf of the country, due to restrictions on contracts, supplies, and other support services, or simple lack of direction and support by incompetent or outrightly hostile partisan hack management. Condemned to busy work, with one hand tied behind their back.

And has our deficit gone down??

1/11/26: Draft statement by the "Concerned Faculty" at UVa regarding the appointment of new President Scott Beardsley in December 2025.

ince our last statement in December, the conduct of the Board of Visitors has gone from bad to worse, confirming our worst fears. Against virtually every publicly-expressed opinion by students, faculty, staff, alumni, as well as Virginia's elected representatives, senators, and the Governor-elect herself, the Board chose to appoint a president in a rushed process that seemed designed to accomplish one thing: to install a new president before the new Governor's inauguration on January 17, 2026.

The Board took these steps after the University was closed for winter break, when they knew students, faculty, and staff would be unable to respond meaningfully. This confirms the Board's indifference to good procedure, long-established academic norms, stakeholder judgment, and any regard for the good opinion of all participants in the process. By acting in bad faith, the Board has flouted its fiduciary duties to the University and has violated its own bylaws calling on it to protect the University from outside interference. It has done so while vital questions of its own composition and statutory compliance remain open.

Recent revelations only strengthen the impression that the appointment

of Scott Beardsley as 10th President of the University is illegitimate and deserves no benefit of the doubt. Texts released through a FOIA request show that Governor Youngkin has been improperly involved in the Board's activities. They demonstrate that Board members abused their authority, failed to act transparently, and willfully subverted process at nearly every step of the way—from the dismissal of President James Ryan, to the appointment of Paul Mahoney as an Interim President, to behind-closed doors "negotiations" with the DOJ, to the launching of a presidential search, and to the hurried conclusion of that search in the face of nearly universal opposition from every major stakeholder group that has spoken publicly. At every step the Board has said "trust us, we know what you don't"; but now we know what they said to each other when no one else was listening, and it turns out they knew their assurances were duplicitous.

New revelations indicate that the Board failed in its most basic duty in searching for a new president. At a minimum, the Board is responsible for thoroughly vetting candidates to ensure their candidacy meets the norms and standards commensurate with a university of UVA's caliber. There is reason to believe this may not have been done in this case. No less troublingly, there is concern that the firm (Isaacson, Miller) hired to coordinate the search, and its directing partner, may have lacked independence vis-à-vis Mr. Beardsley's candidacy in a politically fraught process. This raises questions about the independence of the firm's judgment. More worryingly, it may suggest a conflict of interest. Regardless of how these questions might have been or might ultimately be answered, the point is this: they should have been asked and answered, by the Board, as part of the search process.

Text messages among Board members suggest a troubling level of interaction for people bound by Virginia's Open Meetings Act, as well as inappropriate communication with the Governor's office, which the Board has previously denied. As to Mr. Beardsley, he certainly knew of the concerns that had been raised about the process from its onset in August. He had a chance to take a principled stand and ask that the process be slowed down until questions regarding the Board's authority were resolved, as did nine of his fellow deans in an open letter. Had he done so, and had the Board agreed, he would have been able continue as a candidate, knowing that he had done right by the institution he aspired to serve as president and confident that a decision to appoint him to that position would be legitimate.

Considering this, we believe that the Board's decision to appoint Mr. Beardsley cannot be allowed to stand. Any claim that it is better to accept what has happened and move on can only be self-serving on the part of those who created this crisis. Doing so would only make a mockery of the idea that the appointment of a president is supposed to reflect UVA's values. Are we willing to say to the world that this is what we stand for? Board members must abide by their obligations to

the institution they profess to love and serve. After the disruptive events of the past year, we must return the University to the path of excellence and honor that have guided it since its founding.

Therefore, because the appointment of a president is so consequential an act and because the Board's actions are so lacking in legitimacy, we believe that the only sensible remedy is: (1) for the current Board, as a body, to be held accountable for its dereliction, through investigation by the Legislature and through litigation if need be; (2) for the incoming Governor and Attorney General, and the Legislature to take all necessary steps to hold individual members of the Board accountable and ensure nothing like this ever happen again; and (3) for the presidential search to be reset, by rescinding the appointment of Mr. Beardsley and launching a new presidential search, once underlying issues of process have been addressed.

1/15/26: NASA Watch. Keith Cowing.

Diving Catch To Save U.S. Science

Keith's note: According to a press release /"*U.S. Science Leadership Survives Existential Threat From Trump Budget as Cantwell Rallies Colleagues to Reject Gutting NASA, NSF, & NIST*" / from Senator Maria Cantwell: "America's leading science agencies have survived an existential threat thanks to bipartisan rejection of massive budget cuts proposed by the Trump Administration, U.S. Senator Maria Cantwell (D-WA), ranking member of the Senate Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation, and senior member of the Finance Committee, announced today." *(Full text below)*

Today, the Senate passed a bipartisan second FY 2026 minibus appropriations bill that stabilized funding for the National Aeronautics and Space Administration (NASA) and National Science Foundation (NSF), and boosted funding for the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST). All three agencies are overseen by the Senate Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation. The bill now goes to the White House for President Trump's signature.

/"Our science and technology enterprise is the envy of the world and the growth engine of our innovation economy. The President's budget would have slashed a quarter of NASA's funding and half of the National Science Foundation's funding, jeopardizing our economic competitiveness and national security. Instead, Congress held the line, protecting America's ability to do big things, like establishing a permanent outpost on the Moon, developing space technology that monitors extreme weather and protects our citizens from natural disasters, and inventing the microelectronics of the future that power information systems and lifesaving medical devices. Our world-class

researchers and technologists will have the resources they need to expand the boundaries of knowledge that have long enabled us to invent our future,” /Sen. Cantwell said.

Agency	*FY2024/25 Enacted*		*FY2026 Legislation*	*Trump Budget Request Cuts*	*Final Increase/Decrease*
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NASA	\$24.9B	-23.8%	\$24.4B	-1.6%	
NSF	\$9.1B	-57.1%	\$8.75B	-3.85%	
NIST	\$1.46B	-43.2%	\$1.85B	+21.0%	

National Aeronautics and Space Administration

NASAstunned the world and inspired generations on the day Americans first set foot on the moon. Since then, NASA has:

- * Pioneered breakthroughs and discoveries that superpowered America’s innovation economy;
- * Helped the U.S. achieve global leadership in space technology;
- * Pushed the boundaries of knowledge about the origins of our universe with stunning images collected by space-based telescopes, and;
- * Leveraged earth sciences to protect the American public from natural disasters.

President Trump’s FY2026 budget would have cut over \$6 billion from NASA’s budget. Under the minibus appropriations bill passed today, the agency will receive \$24.44 billion, only slightly less than last year’s budget of \$24.88 billion.

NASA’s budget includes funding for:

- * Human Landing System (HLS): The bill provides \$2.005 billion for the crewed lunar lander that will return American astronauts to the surface of the moon. This is a \$586 million increase (29%) from FY24/FY25 enacted levels, enough funding to meet all contractual obligations for both HLS providers in this fiscal year.
- * Science: The bill provides \$7.25 billion for NASA science, a \$50 million decrease from FY24/FY25 enacted levels – but a \$3.34 billion increase from President Trump’s budget.
- * Space Technology: The appropriation for space technology programs is \$920.5 million, which is a \$180 million decrease over FY25 enacted levels, but a significant increase over President Trump’s proposal of \$569 million.

- * Aeronautics: The bill provides \$935 million for aeronautics, the same as FY24/FY25 and a \$346 million increase from President Trump's budget.
- * Office of STEM Engagement: President Trump's budget eliminated this program completely. The bill provides \$143 million for STEM Engagement, the same amount as the FY24/FY25 enacted levels.

Sen. Cantwell's Commerce Committee alerted Senators and their staffs to the danger facing NASA with a September 2025 report "The Destruction of NASA's Mission": Whistleblowers reveal OMB's Unconstitutional Plot to Gut the Agency./ The report revealed that OMB Director Russell Vought had been directing NASA—since early summer 2025—to begin implementing the devastating cuts in President Trump's Fiscal Year 2026 Budget Request (PBR), without regard for the destructive impacts to NASA's missions, safety, and workforce.

Earlier that month, at a Commerce Committee hearing, Sen. Cantwell forcefully explained why the U.S. must stay ahead of China in the space race.* */"The strategic value of maintaining our position to live and work in space is critical," said Sen. Cantwell. "It's critical to our future economic and national security. All you have to do is look back to the 1960s and look at the development of technologies that created an ecosystem within the United States of America that led to discoveries and innovations that we're still now counting on today."/

In December, Sen. Cantwell supported the nomination of Jared Isaacman for NASA administrator – only after securing assurances that he would defend the agency's science mission and role in developing America's next generation of science leaders. Earlier in the year, Sen. Cantwell had pressed Isaacman on his commitment to protect critical NASA programs from DOGE cuts and support the Artemis mission.

Sen. Cantwell has been a champion for our nation's space industry and its aerospace workforce, and currently oversees NASA and the space industry as Ranking Member of the Commerce Committee. In March 2025, Sen. Cantwell and Sen. Ted Cruz (R-TX) introduced the bipartisan NASA Transition Authorization Act to set near-term priorities for NASA programs, advance American leadership, and prevent the United States from falling behind in the space race with China and our strategic competitors.

National Science Foundation

NSF supports fundamental science research and innovation in all 50 states. Some of the products that would not exist without NSF research include Medtronic pacemakers or insulin pumps, ChatGPT, Nvidia GPU chips that power ChatGPT; Alexa; MRIs for medical imaging; Teslas,

cruise control; Da Vinci robotic surgical systems; quantum computers – even Fortnite, according to Dr. Dean Chang, Chief Innovation Officer and Associate Vice President for Innovation & Entrepreneurship & Economic Development at the University of Maryland, who joined Sen. Cantwell in speaking out against proposed NSF cuts.

The president wanted to only provide \$3.9 billion for the NSF. The bill provides \$8.75 billion, more than double Trump's requested amount. It's a 4.0% decrease from FY24/FY25 appropriation of \$9.1 billion.

NSF's budget includes funding for:

- * Research: The bill provides \$7.177 billion for research, a \$4.189 billion increase over the FY26 PBR levels and no change over FY24/FY25 enacted levels.
- * Regional Innovation Engines: The bill provides \$200 million in funding for Regional Innovation Engines.
- * STEM Education: The bill provides \$938 million for STEM Education, a tripling of the FY26 PBR level of \$288 million and a 20% (\$234 million) decrease from FY24/FY25 enacted levels.

National Science Foundation cuts were the subject of a May 2025 press conference held by Sen. Cantwell. She was joined by Sen. Chris Van Hollen (D-MD) and a panel of prestigious scientists including Dr. Chang.

/"We are in an Information Age. We are in an age where there are several areas of U.S. competitiveness that depend on continued science innovation, aerospace being one of those, certainly AI being another, quantum being a third,"/ Sen. Cantwell said at the time. /"And all of this is being put into jeopardy by this cut."/

*NIST *is the gold standard in measurement and standards that allow technology to work. Among the many products that rely on NIST's work are the smart electric power grid, electronic health records, atomic clocks, advanced nanomaterials, and computer chips.

The president's budget also proposed just \$830 million in funding for NIST. This bill provides \$1.847 billion, more than double the amount requested – a 21% increase from FY24/FY25 enacted levels.

NIST's budget includes funding for:

- * Research: The bill provides \$1.249 billion for NIST research, a 44% (\$550 million) increase from FY26 PBR levels and a 14% (\$169 million) increase from FY24/FY25 enacted levels.

- * Manufacturing Extension Partnership: The bill provides \$175 million for the Hollings Manufacturing Extension Partnership Program, which is the same amount as FY24/FY25 enacted levels. The FY26 PBR would have zeroed out this program.
- * Manufacturing USA: The bill provides \$37 million for the Manufacturing USA Program, the same amount as FY24/FY25 enacted levels and FY26 PBR.
- * U.S. Center for AI Standards and Innovation (CAISI): The bill makes available \$10 million for CAISI, formerly known as the AI Safety Institute, which is equivalent to the FY24/FY25 enacted levels. It also includes a further \$45 million for NIST AI-research and measurement science efforts.

Sen. Cantwell was a main architect and key negotiator of the 2022 CHIPS & Science Act. In her position as Chair of the Commerce, Science, and Transportation Committee, she was instrumental in securing the science R&D funding authorizations in the 11th hour of negotiations. The new law authorized a new mission at the NSF focusing on translational science in key areas – including artificial intelligence, quantum technology, advanced manufacturing, composites, energy, and biotech – with an authorization of \$20 billion over five years.

1/16/26: From the AAS

Subject: Policy Update: Congress Passes Funding Bills for Science Agencies

Yesterday, the Senate passed three spending bills for Fiscal Year 2026, following their passage by the House last week. This package includes the bills that fund the National Science Foundation, NASA, and the Department of Energy Office of Science. In these bills, Congress showed strong support for the sciences, largely rejecting the cuts proposed in the President's Budget Request and putting a number of guardrails in place to protect the work being carried out by our science agencies. You can read more about the provisions of the bills in our blog post [rhpiczrab.cc.rs6.net].

This rejection of the devastating proposed cuts to science agencies was made

possible by the advocacy of the scientific community. We must continue to remind Congress of the importance of federal support for science, so that this support continues in future years. Please take a few minutes today to thank your members of Congress for their rejection of the proposed cuts, and urge them to continue to provide robust and sustained support in the future. Note that our action alert will only work if your members of Congress voted to pass these bills.

Send a Thank You Message to Congress [rhpiczrab.cc.rs6.net]

If you are interested in meeting with your congressional offices this spring in Washington, DC and in learning more about how scientists can interface with the government, we encourage you to apply to our Congressional Visits Day program, a fully-funded three-day opportunity to experience science policy in DC. The deadline for applications is 1 February 2026.

Apply to Congressional Visits Day [rhpiczrab.cc.rs6.net]

Thank you again for your engagement in advocacy over the past year! We hope that we can count on you to continue to speak up for science moving forward.

More from the AAS Blog:

On 15 January 2026, the US Senate passed a “minibus” of Fiscal Year 2026 spending bills, following its passage by the House of Representatives on 8 January. This minibus includes the Commerce, Justice, and Science (CJS) bill (which funds NASA, NSF, NIST, and NOAA, among other agencies), the Energy and Water Development bill (which funds agencies including the Department of Energy), and Interior and Environment bill (which funds the EPA and other agencies). In this blog post, we break down the provisions of this bill that are relevant to the astronomical sciences, covering NSF, NASA, NIST, and the DOE Office of Science. Note that as of 15 January 2026, the bills have been sent to the President to sign into law, but we are awaiting that final signature....

[Captured PDF of the article and a separate snap of the budget

table.]

1/22/26: First hour of "1A" on NPR: heavy expert criticism of
RFK Jr's changes at HHS and scandalous politicization of
vaccine and other health advice. Doesn't mince words.
Explains devastating effects on sponsored scientific programs.

1/23/26: Van Scoyoc Newsletter

House and Senate appropriators endorse NIH budget increase, reject
Trump's proposed cuts

Congressional appropriations committees offered a near-total rebuke of
President Trump's proposed downsizing and reshaping of the National
Institutes of Health in their spending bill for the 2026 fiscal
year. In a compromise bill released Tuesday, Congress set NIH's budget
at \$48.7 billion, a \$415 million increase over the 2025 fiscal year,
and retained language meant to prevent the Trump administration from
slashing support for research overhead. But the measure included a
win for the White House, allowing it to continue using a new funding
strategy for multiyear grants that resulted in several thousand fewer
awards for scientists in 2025. Read more: STAT News
[vsadc.us4.list-manage.com], House Labor-HHS-Education Appropriations
Subcommittee -- Democrats [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com] House and
Senate appropriators reject proposed CDC cuts

The FY2026 Labor-HHS-Education Appropriations Conference Bill and
Report includes \$9.2 billion for the Centers for Disease Control and
Prevention (CDC) – rejecting President Trump's request to cut funding
by 50%. The bill funds a number of programs that had been eliminated
in the House bill, including: \$1.1 billion for domestic and global
HIV/AIDS activities; \$12.5 million for Firearm Injury and Mortality
Prevention Research; \$247 million for Tobacco Prevention and Control;
and \$160 million for the Preventive Health and Health Services Block
Grant. Read more: House Labor-HHS-Education Appropriations
Subcommittee -- Democrats [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

NIH says it will stop funding research using human fetal tissue

The National Institutes of Health, the largest public funder of
biomedical research in the world, announced Thursday that it would no
longer support research that utilizes fetal tissue donated to science
after elective abortions. The policy move was celebrated by
antiabortion advocates but criticized by scientists who said it would
set back efforts to understand crucial questions about human
development and the search for treatments. The announcement was not a
surprise – the first Trump administration established restrictions on
fetal tissue research that were later reversed by the Biden

administration. Read more: Washington Post
[vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

US officially exits World Health Organization

The U.S. has officially completed its withdrawal from the World Health Organization (WHO), the Trump administration announced on Thursday. It comes exactly one year after President Donald Trump signed an executive order to begin the process of withdrawal. Read more: ABC News [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

US cutting or revising nearly \$84 billion in energy loans

The Trump administration said on Thursday it is restructuring or eliminating nearly \$84 billion in clean energy projects funded during the administration of former President Joe Biden. The move was the latest by President Donald Trump's administration to favor fossil fuels and nuclear energy while eliminating subsidies for alternative energy like wind and solar. The changes by the Office of Energy Dominance Financing, or EDF, come after a review of \$104 billion in loans made during the Biden administration with the majority of that coming after the 2024 presidential election. Read more: WKZO [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

NASA quietly ends financial support for planetary science groups

NASA is quietly ending financial support for independent planetary science advisory groups, according to a letter posted to the agency's website on January 16. The affected groups have historically offered feedback to the space agency on science efforts ranging from the exploration of Mars and ocean worlds to the storage of extraterrestrial samples, and more. Read more: Scientific American [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

1/30/26: Van Scoyoc Newsletter

HHS appoints 21 new members to federal autism advisory committee

The Department of Health and Human Services on Wednesday announced the appointment of 21 new members to a federal committee that advises health secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. on autism. Many of the new members of the Interagency Autism Coordinating Committee share a common trait: They have publicly expressed or belong to groups that have publicly expressed a belief in the debunked claim that vaccines can cause autism. Read more: STAT News

Dozens of CDC databases aren't being updated – most related to vaccines, study finds

Nearly half of the databases that the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention used to update regularly – surveillance systems that tracked public health information like Covid vaccination rates and hospitalizations for respiratory syncytial virus – have been paused without explanation, according to new research. The findings, published Monday in the journal *Annals of Internal Medicine*, indicate that at the start of 2025, the CDC maintained 82 databases that were updated at least monthly. But by the end of October, the study found 38 had gone stale, with 34 showing no new entries at all in the previous six months. Read more: [NBC News](#)

Chair of CDC's vaccine advisory committee questions polio shot recommendation

The head of the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention's vaccine advisory committee questioned whether broad recommendations are necessary for vaccines that protect against polio and other infectious diseases. Dr. Kirk Milhoan, a pediatric cardiologist who was appointed chair of the CDC's Advisory Committee on Immunization Practices (ACIP) by Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. last month, said decisions on whether to receive a vaccine should be made by patients and doctors, not by mandate. Read more: [ABC News](#)

Key NIH review panels due to lose all members by the end of 2026

Membership at many of the high-level advisory councils for the US National Institutes of Health is dwindling – a decline that could trigger a freeze in issuance of some grants. Crucial grant-review panels for more than half of the institutes that make up the US National Institutes of Health (NIH) are on track to lose all their voting members within the year. Federal law requires these panels to review applications for all but the smallest grants before funding can be awarded, meaning that the ability of those institutes to issue new grants could soon be frozen. Read more: [Nature](#)

National Science Foundation signals plan to break up NCAR

The National Science Foundation signaled plans to dismantle the National Center for Atmospheric Research in a letter that also opened the door to a private operation taking over. The letter marks the first official step toward dismantling the Boulder-based research center, advancing a Trump administration push that critics, such as Rep. Joe Neguse, say could put public safety at risk by privatizing weather forecasting. The science foundation's letter, published Friday, doubled down on the administration's intent to "restructure" NCAR and sought "input from agency partners and the research community

on the scope of work currently performed" there. It also asked for input from possible operators on opening ownership of the NCAR's Mesa Lab building for "private use." Read more: [Axios](#)

FEBRUARY

2/3/26: Hedge Hog Review. When Power No Longer Needs Reasons.

What makes the present moment dangerous is not that hypocrisy has been exposed, but that it may no longer be needed. The abandonment of justification is defended as honest realism—rules dismissed as naïve, law as theater, explanation as weakness. But this is not realism; it is political exhaustion. Authority has always depended on a shared expectation that power will explain itself. Fragile and often abused, that expectation nonetheless distinguishes politics from domination.

What emerges instead resembles what the Nazi jurist Carl Schmitt described in *Political Theology*: sovereignty revealed in the power to decide, even when justification is reduced to the bare assertion of necessity. In such a world, authority no longer argues; it declares. The exception becomes permanent, and explanation gives way to command.

Trump did not invent this erosion, but his presidency, particularly in his second term, has made it explicit. Authority is increasingly announced rather than argued—through fiat, spectacle, and appeals to strength. The message is not that rules permit such actions, but that rules no longer matter. When power stops explaining itself, critique loses its footing: there is no claim to interrogate, no contradiction to expose.

Hypocrisy, for all its ugliness, once preserved a space between word and deed. That space is closing. The postwar order rested on the expectation that power would justify itself, however dishonestly. If that expectation collapses, what disappears is not merely rules or institutions but politics itself—leaving only force to endure.

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2/5/26: FYI

Date: Thu, 5 Feb 2026 14:16:02

From: FYI <fyi@aipcomm.org>

Subject: A Look Back at Project 2025's Plans for Science

FYI: Science Policy News from AIP
BULLETIN

February 5, 2026

A Look Back at Project 2025's Plans for Science

Clare Zhang

Where the Trump administration has and has not stuck to the conservative policy blueprint.

President Trump holds a cabinet meeting in January 2026. The White House The Heritage Foundation's Project 2025, released in 2023, was widely considered a policy blueprint for President Donald Trump's second term, though Trump frequently denied that the document would play a role in his decisions. Looking back on the first year of the second Trump administration, the White House has pursued some of the science policy ideas presented in Project 2025, such as overhauling climate and energy programs and cutting science budgets. In some cases, the administration has gone several steps beyond the report's recommendations; in others, it has directly contradicted them.

Mirroring the blueprint

National Climate Assessment: Project 2025 proposes to "reshape" the U.S. Global Change and Research Program; the administration completely cut federal funding for the program in April. USGCRP coordinates climate change research across agencies and produces the National Climate Assessment. The administration also dismissed the authors of the sixth NCA, which was in progress last year. The administration has interviewed candidates for USGCRP and has asked four scientists and one economist, all of whom have expressed skepticism about leading climate change impact assessments, to serve as authors of the next NCA, E&E News reported in December. That group earlier authored a report for DOE that argued that warming induced by carbon dioxide "might be less damaging economically than commonly believed, and that excessively aggressive mitigation strategies could prove more detrimental than beneficial."

Department of Energy: Project 2025 proposes eliminating many of the Department of Energy's offices focused on energy technology development and programs focused on climate change. Of the five offices that the document calls to eliminate or reform, four have seen changes under DOE's reorganization announced in November. These include the Office of Clean Energy Demonstrations, which will "be wound down" but transfer some elements to the new Office of Critical Minerals and Energy Innovation, according to an internal DOE email obtained by E&E News. The Advanced Research Projects Agency-Energy, which Project 2025 proposes eliminating, appears unchanged in the reorganization chart. OCED and the Grid Deployment Office, which has also been wound down and partially transferred to the new Critical Minerals and Energy Innovation office, saw billions in grant cancellations last year. In the announcements, Energy Secretary Chris Wright said the canceled projects "did not adequately advance the

nation's energy needs, were not economically viable, and would not provide a positive return on investment of taxpayer dollars."

Visas: Project 2025 proposes "transforming" the H-1B visa program into "an elite mechanism exclusively to bring in the 'best and brightest' at the highest wages." It does not specify how that transformation should be achieved. The administration imposed a \$100,000 fee on new petitions for H-1B visas, saying the higher costs will discourage companies from replacing, rather than supplementing the domestic workforce "with lower-paid, lower-skilled labor." The fee is currently being contested in court, though a lower court upheld it. **Return on investment:** Both Project 2025 and the administration have advocated for increasing the "return on investment" of science funding, but through different means. Project 2025 proposes reviving an initiative at the National Institute of Standards and Technology that aimed to "dramatically increase returns from the more than \$150 billion per year of U.S. federal investment in research and development."

The current administration has not moved on that initiative, but NIST issued a broad funding solicitation in September for awards related to various CHIPS R&D programs that states that awardees may be required to issue royalties or otherwise share revenue with the Commerce Department. Over the past year, Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick has expressed a desire to increase taxpayers' return on investment from federally funded research, including by having the U.S. government take as much as half the profit from university patents.

Missile defense: Project 2025 recommends that the Department of Defense develop advanced missile defense technologies, including space-based systems. Trump issued an executive order soon after taking office that pushes for the creation of a missile defense shield capable of protecting the U.S. against "any foreign aerial attack," now known as Golden Dome. Congressional appropriators have repeatedly requested details on Golden Dome from the Department of Defense, writing in the appropriations bill report for DOD that the department has not provided complete budgetary details and justification as directed in the reconciliation megabill that passed in July and appropriated nearly \$25 billion for the initiative.

Congress pushing back

Budget cuts: The president's budget request for fiscal year 2026 mirrored Project 2025 proposals to cut research on climate change and renewable technologies at DOE and the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration. The budget request proposed cutting biological and environmental research within DOE's Office of Science by more than 50% and pulling funding for most programs within the Office of Oceanic and Atmospheric Research, which is NOAA's research arm. Congress approved the transfer of some OAR programs to the National Weather Service but continued to fund its remaining programs.

Indirect costs: In line with Project 2025, the administration moved to reduce indirect cost rates for university research grants to be comparable to the rates offered by private organizations. Indirect costs cover research-adjacent expenses such as equipment and facilities maintenance, IT services, and administrative support. The administration's caps were swiftly blocked in court, and congressional appropriators have since rejected the proposed budget cuts and changes to the current indirect cost rate system. In reaction to those provisions becoming law, DOE announced that it would withdraw its caps.

NOAA: Project 2025 calls NOAA "one of the main drivers of the climate change alarm industry" and refers to OAR as "the source of much of NOAA's climate alarmism." It adds that NOAA should be dismantled and "many of its functions eliminated, sent to other agencies, privatized, or placed under the control of states and territories." The administration does not appear to have pursued such dramatic changes at NOAA, though the agency suffered staffing shortages last summer due to layoffs and early retirements, with a subsequent push to re-hire around 20% of the lost employees.

In contrast, the administration has announced its intent to dismantle the National Center for Atmospheric Research, an R&D center in Colorado funded by the National Science Foundation. The announcement calls NCAR "one of the largest sources of climate alarmism in the country," mirroring the language about NOAA in Project 2025. NSF has since issued a request for input from public and private entities to take over NCAR programs and infrastructure. Congress declined to add language to its 2026 funding bills to continue funding and operating NCAR.

Going further

The Trump administration's widespread cancellation of grants at the National Institutes of Health and the National Science Foundation, as well as those targeting specific universities, were not explicitly proposed in Project 2025, but the roots of the cancellations are present in the blueprint.

Project 2025 expresses strong opposition to the term "diversity, equity, and inclusion" and related federal initiatives. It proposes "deleting" terms including DEI, gender, and reproductive health "out of every federal rule, agency regulation, contract, grant, regulation, and piece of legislation that exists." An executive order, issued immediately after Trump took office, targets DEI-related initiatives across the government. The White House followed up with a directive to temporarily freeze and review federal grant spending. The administration later canceled nearly 6,000 grants at NIH and nearly 2,000 at NSF.

For the Environmental Protection Agency specifically, Project 2025 proposes putting a political appointee in charge of determining the distribution of grants. The Trump administration applied similar policies both formally and informally at additional science agencies. Staff at NIH and NSF have reported that staff from the Department of Government Efficiency, created by Trump and led by Elon Musk, were overseeing grant reviews and cancellations, and Trump later formalized such reviews through an executive order in August that directs agencies to give political appointees ultimate decision-making power over grants.

Trump also froze billions in federal research funding to Harvard and other large research universities, an idea that is not explicit in Project 2025 but echoes its proposal for USAID to eliminate funding for partners that “promote discriminatory DEI practices” and to consider debarment in “egregious cases.” The Department of Health and Human Services has referred Harvard to its office responsible for debarment.

Although Project 2025 calls for a freeze on hiring for certain federal positions, the blueprint cautions against large-scale reductions-in-force, warning that they can be more expensive than they are worth. “Cutting functions, levels, funds, and grants is much more important than setting simple employment size,” Project 2025 states. “Simply reducing numbers can actually increase costs,” the document adds, pointing to costly buyout programs in the first Trump administration and the Clinton administration. In contrast, the administration pursued widespread workforce reductions last year, including through an estimated 150,000 federal employee buyouts.

Pending or rejected ideas

Research security: Project 2025 proposes to “eliminate or significantly reduce the number of visas issued to foreign students from enemy nations” with particular emphasis on reducing visas for Chinese students and researchers. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said in May the U.S. would “aggressively revoke” visas held by Chinese students, but the White House later decided to issue 600,000 Chinese student visas over the next two years, in line with numbers issued in previous years.

Project 2025 proposes several other ideas related to research security. Some of these ideas have been floated by the president’s allies in Congress, but the White House has not pursued them directly. These include relaunching the Justice Department’s China Initiative; withholding federal funds from universities that take money from the Chinese government; and prohibiting “all Communist Chinese investment” in U.S. high-technology industries.

NIST: Project 2025 proposes combining NIST with the U.S. Patent and Trademark Office and the National Technical Information Service, creating a new Office of Patents, Trademarks, and Standards with all non-mission-critical research functions eliminated or moved to other federal agencies. The Trump administration has not done this.

SBIR: Project 2025 looks to direct more R&D funding toward small businesses through the Small Business Innovation Research and Small Business Technology Transfer programs. The report encourages the administration to push Congress to increase the percentage of spending by federal research agencies that is set aside for small business R&D. This percentage has not changed, and the congressional authorization for the program lapsed in October.

NIH: Project 2025 suggests that Congress consider converting NIH's grants budget into block grants provided to state governments and proposes instituting term limits for top leaders at NIH. The administration has not pursued either idea, but more than a dozen directors of NIH institutes and centers have left the agency since January 2025. Six of these directors were fired in mass layoffs.

2/5/26: Reader comment on a Washington Post article on DEI hiring in research universities:

What we are witnessing has nothing to do with "efficiency," "accountability," or improving science. It is naked revenge. Trump is dismantling American research because universities refused to submit to him politically – and because he genuinely believes his instincts outweigh the judgment of scientists, professors, and peer review. That level of hubris would be comic if it weren't so destructive. The economic damage will be severe. U.S. federal R&D has historically delivered extraordinary returns – driving productivity, new industries, and long-term growth.

Gutting funding, politicizing grants, and intimidating institutions doesn't save money; it erodes the very engine that made the U.S. economy dominant. Innovation ecosystems take decades to build and only a few years to wreck. Once talent leaves, it does not magically return on command. Internationally, this matters. On the Academic Freedom Index, the U.S. no longer sits at the top. Countries like Germany, the Netherlands, Sweden, Denmark, and Finland rank higher – and they are now actively absorbing the researchers America is pushing away. Canada, France, and parts of Asia are doing the same. This is not theory; it is already happening. History offers a grim parallel. In Stalin's Soviet Union, ideology replaced evidence, loyalty trumped competence, and science became an instrument of power rather than truth. The result was stagnation, fear, and decades of lost progress. No, the U.S. is not the USSR – but the logic is disturbingly familiar.

You can bully researchers. You can starve institutions. What you cannot do is command discovery by decree.

What I'm writing about has nothing to do with undergraduate admissions or the 2023 Harvard/UNC Supreme Court case. That ruling dealt narrowly with how race may be considered in student admissions. It did not authorize the DOJ to freeze or weaponize federal research funding, override peer review, or punish universities for resisting political demands. Pretending otherwise is either ignorance or bad faith.

What we are witnessing now is something entirely different: a political power play, where one man uses the federal purse to bend independent institutions to his will. That is not "enforcing meritocracy." It is a blunt demonstration of power by a leader with obvious cognitive and temperamental deficiencies, who genuinely seems to believe he knows better than entire scientific communities how research should be judged.

Even more surreal is the assumption that the rest of the world should simply fall in line. Newsflash: Europeans do not dance to Washington's tune by default anymore not when that tune is played by someone who mistakes vengeance for governance. The uncomfortable truth is that this "gubbfan" is actively gambling away America's scientific credibility, soft power, and longterm economic strength. Undermining the research ecosystem that took generations to build doesn't just hurt universities it weakens the U.S. position in the global balance of power. That affects all of us.

2/13/26: Van Scoyoc newsletter

FDA refuses to review Moderna's application for mRNA flu vaccine, company says

The US Food and Drug Administration has refused to accept an application from Moderna to review its first mRNA seasonal flu vaccine, the company said Tuesday, in another setback for the technology that's been a target of some Trump administration health officials. The agency told Moderna that its application didn't contain an "adequate and well-controlled" trial because the control arm didn't reflect the "best-available standard of care in the United States at the time of the study," according to a letter dated February 3 that Moderna posted online. Read more: [CNN \[vsadc.us4.list-manage.com\]](https://www.cnn.com/2026/02/03/health/fda-moderna-flu-vaccine/index.html)

Prasad overruled FDA staff to reject Moderna's flu vaccine application

Top Food and Drug Administration official Vinay Prasad overruled the agency's reviewers when he refused to accept Moderna's application for

a new influenza vaccine, STAT has learned. Three agency officials familiar with the matter told STAT that the team of career scientists was ready to review Moderna's application, and that David Kaslow, the head of the vaccine office, wrote a detailed memo explaining why the FDA should embark on the review. Read more: STAT News [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

2/13/26: FYI

Shrinking the federal workforce

According to newly released OPM data, [aip.us17.list-manage.com] the size of the federal workforce fell by 242,260 employees in 2025 – a mixture of resignations, retirements, and firings. A recent analysis [aip.us17.list-manage.com] by Science found that more than 10,000 STEM PhDs left the federal workforce last year, but suggests relatively few scientists actually left their positions because of RIFs. The number of scientists who received RIF notices, however, may be much higher than the number of scientists who were laid off because of them. Some workers at science agencies such as the National Nuclear Security Administration [aip.us17.list-manage.com] and the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention [aip.us17.list-manage.com] were issued termination notices that were later reversed by the Trump administration. Federal courts also blocked or reversed RIF notices at many agencies, including an attempt to lay off over 4,000 workers [aip.us17.list-manage.com] during the government shutdown last year.

2/13/26: WP Editorial. Another government sop to an ailing industry / An executive order requiring the military to purchase coal puts politics over the free market.

There is perhaps no greater sign of the coal industry's decline than the Trump administration's demand this week that the Pentagon purchase more energy generated by the fossil fuel. If powering military bases with coal-fired plants was the best option, no edict from the government would be necessary.

President Donald Trump justified his executive order on Wednesday by invoking the nation's "Energy Emergency." He also announced that the federal government would use taxpayer dollars from a \$525 million fund at the Energy Department to upgrade four aging coal plants to "to keep them online and keep those plants open."

This is part of a broader strategy by the administration to prop up the ailing industry with taxpayer dollars. Washington has already forced multiple coal plants to remain open beyond their scheduled retirements, trampling local control over energy projects and driving up electricity prices. Last year, it added coal to the Interior

Department's critical mineral list, granting it priority treatment in federal investments and permitting decisions. The administration even created a cartoon mascot named "Coalie" to promote the industry.

These are feeble and costly attempts to halt the market forces driving a transition to cleaner energy. A little more than two decades ago, coal generated most of the country's electricity. Today it contributes 15 percent. Competition from cheaper sources of energy, especially natural gas, made that happen – not government. Non-carbon energy sources such as solar and wind, which together already eclipse coal's output, have also cut into the business.

The country needs more energy to sustain growth, but that only underscores the need for the government to get out of the way. It is telling that despite these economic forces, no new coal plants have been under development for more than a decade. And it's because investors understand that other technologies are becoming cheaper and come with far fewer health and environmental consequences.

The political calculus here is also off. In 2024, the entire coal mining industry employed fewer than 43,000 people in a country with a 172 million person labor force. Is subsidizing those jobs worth the danger that Americans will feel as their utility bills tick upward?

[Article doesn't mention two key facts:

- 1 – RENEWABLE ENERGY SOURCES OVERTOOK COAL AS THE LEADING SOURCE OF ELECTRICAL ENERGY IN THE WORLD last year. See 10/7/25 articles on this landmark.
- 2 – Many more people are employed in the renewable energy sector than in coal.]

Comments...

AI summary: Participants in this discussion express strong criticism of the Trump administration's decision to mandate the Pentagon to purchase more coal power. Many comments highlight the outdated nature of coal as an energy source, pointing out its environmental and health drawbacks, such as pollution and black lung disease. Commenters argue that coal is a declining industry, with significantly fewer jobs compared to renewable energy sectors like wind and solar. They suggest that the administration's move is politically motivated, aimed at appeasing fossil fuel executives and campaign donors rather than addressing energy needs or market demands. Some comments also draw parallels between this decision and historical examples of government intervention in failing industries, labeling it as a form of socialism or crony capitalism. Overall, the conversation reflects a consensus that the focus should be on transitioning to cleaner, more sustainable

energy sources rather than propping up coal.

Put it simply, Trump impose socialism to keep coal mines and the coal mining industry going. And, doing so at taxpayer expense. Yes, MAGA, you elected a socialist backed by the coal industry.

Third try on commenting, must use sarcasm. This idea is so intelligent and thoughtful that I cannot really imagine the words to describe it.

Coal is not merely an 'ailing industry.' It has been stagnant to declining for decades. Total U.S. coal mining employment has been around 50,000 since the early 2000s... a fraction of the employment in wind, solar and electric storage. Amazon employs as many people in the Seattle area alone as the entire U.S. coal industry. Disability payments for miners suffering from black lung and other workplace injuries and the cost to remedy environmental damage from coal mining operations runs into many billions a year. Coal isn't merely 'ailing.' It's an albatross around our necks. Spending gobs of money to perpetuate the industry is like building a funeral pyre with greenbacks.

It's great to be breathing in more toxins, and our tax dollars will be supplementing it. Even before Trump's BBB, renewables received only one tenth of what the US fossil fuel industry receives per year in terms of subsidies. This is criminal on multiple levels.

What's wrong here is that people who want to do away with coal and oil don't realize that we cannot do away with fossil fuels now – because if we do away with fossil fuels overnight people will freeze in the winter and sweat in the summer. It takes time – and Democrats think it's like flipping a switch...and that just ain't so!

[Right, of course, but it's obvious we can start with shutting down coal on a 10-year time scale w/o harm.]

Comical to hear the Republicans, for years, decades even, complain about the failure of state and government managed economies and see them completely silent now. NEVER, utter the words free market again, you've lost all credibility.

So in Trump's sick mind, government subsidies for coal, which is the very dirtiest energy source that most states no longer want or use, are good, but subsidizing electric cars, which Americans DO want if they were more affordable, is bad. Welcome to Trumpland.

You're looking at this the wrong way, rather than a rational energy policy for the country, think in terms of a purse snatcher. Grab what you can get in the short run, however you can get it, and then get out of town.

** [from DecoratedVeteranOfficer] Under 50,000 are employed in the coal industry. Over 150,000 are employed in the wind energy production industry. 280,000+ are employed in solar energy production industry. The numbers should speak loudly to Trump, but his knowledge is poor and he thinks he has friends and supporters in the coal industry. What is the trend? Trend is away from coal. It is more expensive than all other forms of energy production. As of April 30, 2024, there were 54 commercially operating nuclear power plants with 94 nuclear power reactors in 28 states. In 2024, wind and solar together generated more electricity than coal for the first time in the US, while solar rose more than gas to meet increased demand growth.

[cont] The United States' shift towards clean electricity continued in 2024, as wind and solar together rose to 17% of total electricity generation, surpassing coal, which dropped to an all-time low of 15%. After nearly 14 years of stagnation, electricity demand is now firmly rising. It increased by 3%, marking the fifth-highest rise this century, partly as a rebound to a milder summer in 2023, when electricity demand fell by 1.3%. Rising demand drove an increase in gas generation, which grew three times more than the decline in coal, increasing power sector CO2 emissions.

[cont] However, solar generation met more of the rise in electricity demand and fall in coal than gas did. Solar (+64 TWh) added more generation than gas (+59 TWh) and together with wind (+32 TWh), contributed to the continued decline of coal (-22 TWh) and meeting high electricity demand growth (+128 TWh). It remained the fastest-growing source of electricity, with its generation rising by 27% in 2024, surpassing hydro generation for the time.

If I see the phrase "free markets" again in an editorial I'm going to regurgitate my lunch!

Especially when it's wrongly applied to industries significantly subsidized by the federal government, such as coal, and every single company that has made Elon Musk a billionaire.

I grew up in a coal town. Up til about the late 60s, many had coal fueled stokers for heat, and coal delivery trucks were a common sight. By the end of the 70s, the coal trucks were gone. Everyone, as soon as they could afford, had switched to cleaner, more convenient oil or gas. Folks in coal country know better than anyone it is dirty stuff. We didn't have white winters, we had gray ones, and the stream that ran through town was a sickly green. Trump can make all the pronouncements he wants, but the world is moving away from coal, and he cannot stop that. He may just as well try to revive a horse mounted cavalry.

China and our other competitors are looking forward. While they still use fossil fuels, they are moving heavily into the use of alternate energy sources. The volume of their research and support of science and manufacturing makes us look almost idiotic by comparison.

Why would anyone think Trump is in favor of free markets? His entire history shows he operates as a mob boss and crony capitalist, yet it's comical how so many people still think of him as a protector of free enterprise.

Quote from an article in the Australian newspaper (owned by Rupert Murdoch) of Saturday Feb. 14: '...last year China achieved a genuine milestone: for the first time in its history, wind and solar absorbed all growth in electricity demand. The nation consumed more power than ever before without burning a single extra lump of coal.' Sorry to say it but Trump is leading the US back to the past. Communist China will replace the US as the global hegemon by mid-century and the yuan will replace the US dollar in world trade.

2/17/26: FYI

NASA RESTRICTS SPENDING FOR 17 PROGRAMS

NASA is pausing [aip.us17.list-manage.com] new fiscal year 2026 spending on 17 science initiatives in anticipation of guidance from the White House Office of Management and Budget. The affected projects include major missions recommended by the latest decadal surveys for astrophysics, heliophysics, and planetary science. Some of the missions are ongoing, such as the Chandra X-Ray Observatory and GRACE Follow-On, while others are currently in development. NASA announced [aip.us17.list-manage.com] just two weeks ago that missions under the Earth System Explorers program were moving forward; that program is now one of the 17 affected by the pause.

The Trump administration proposed deep cuts to or zeroing out funding for almost all of these projects in the presidential budget request for fiscal year 2026, largely providing little explanation other than "to achieve cost savings." NASA's letter to its centers announcing the pause indicates that the White House may attempt to use OMB's apportionment [aip.us17.list-manage.com] process to prevent the agency from spending further fiscal year 2026 funds on these projects. Jack Kiraly, director of government relations at the Planetary Society, said the pauses are "a new attempt to implement the PBR (presidential budget request) after it's been rejected." He also noted that some of the projects affected by the pause will not meet their prime mission until after the current administration.

Kiraly added that there is “a pretty significant response in Congress opposing this move.” Sen. Chris Van Hollen (D-MD), the ranking member on the Commerce, Justice and Science Appropriations Subcommittee, said the appropriations passed by Congress make it “crystal-clear that the Administration must continue efforts at Goddard and other centers that drive American space exploration. In choosing to ignore this, Russ Vought is breaking the law.” Rep. Zoe Lofgren (D-CA), the ranking member on the House Science Committee, said she is “very concerned” and hopes that NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman takes action to “prevent OMB from unlawfully cutting appropriated science programs.” Senate Democrats issued a report in September accusing [aip.us17.list-manage.com] the Trump administration of illegally restricting spending at NASA since early summer.

NEW LAYOFFS AT THE NATIONAL LABORATORY OF THE ROCKIES

At least 100 employees were laid off last week at the National Laboratory of the Rockies, previously known as the National Renewable Energy Laboratory. The fired staff worked in research and operations roles, according to local news reports. [aip.us17.list-manage.com] The layoffs followed a 10% budget cut to the Department of Energy’s Office of Energy Efficiency and Renewable Energy, which is a primary source of funding for the lab. A further 114 employees were laid off [aip.us17.list-manage.com] from the lab in May last year. The lab’s website says it employs nearly 4,000 people, though it is unclear if that number accounts for recent rounds of layoffs. Several Democratic members of Congress representing Colorado have spoken out [aip.us17.list-manage.com] against the layoffs.

2/19/26: WP. After leaving WHO, Trump officials propose a more expensive replacement to duplicate it / HHS proposes spending \$2 billion a year to re-create systems the U.S. accessed through the World Health Organization at a fraction of the cost, according to officials briefed on the matter.

2/26/26: FYI

FEDERAL SCIENCE WORKFORCE DECLINES SHARPLY UNDER TRUMP Clare Zhang [aip.us17.list-manage.com]

The last year was marked by turmoil at science agencies and the administration’s stated desire to shrink the federal workforce.

The White House with an American flag in front on the right side The South Lawn of the White House in June 2025. Molly Riley/White House
Federal science agencies shed more jobs in the past year than they did over the last two decades of steady decline, data

[aip.us17.list-manage.com] published by the White House Office of Personnel Management reveals. The number of federal employees in the physical sciences fell 12% from 2024 to 2025, compared to an 8% decline from 1998 to 2024.

In the first full year of the second Trump administration, the White House pushed for cuts to the federal workforce by incentivizing staff to leave through the deferred resignation program, directly cutting probationary staff, asking agencies to submit plans for significant reductions-in-force, and issuing RIF notices. OPM's most recent data release provides insight into the effects of these efforts at the agency level.

Agencies overseeing science have seen significant job losses since Trump took office, including over 30% at the National Science Foundation and around 20% at the U.S. Geological Survey, the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration, and the National Institutes of Health. The Department of Energy and the National Institute of Standards and Technology shrank by 17% and 15% respectively, while NASA lost 12% of its staff. In comparison, the total federal civilian workforce has fallen about 10% since January 2025.

These science agencies saw the greatest losses in administration and program management and analysis. They also collectively lost thousands of employees across engineering, health science, and physical science.

Changes to scientific staff at the Department of Defense are less clear, but DOD as a whole shed about 75,000 positions over the past year, including in research offices. The Office of Naval Research, for example, shrank by more than 400 people, about 14%.

DEFERRED RESIGNATIONS

Over 15,000 employees at science agencies left the federal workforce last year. Around 5,000 of those staff accepted offers from the deferred resignation program [aip.us17.list-manage.com] (DRP), in which the administration offered to continue paying full salaries to employees who resigned until Sept. 30, or until Dec. 31 if retirement-eligible.

The DRP affected science agencies unevenly. At NASA, 63% of the agency's total departures last year were through the program. For DOE, NSF, and USGS, the DRP also accounted for more than 50% of separations last year. In comparison, the federal workforce overall dropped 10% in 2025, about half of which was through the DRP.

At NOAA, NIST, and NIH, the DRP accounted for less than 20% of separations last year. For instance, only about 80 of the more than 700 people who left NIST used the program. NOAA saw many non-DRP voluntary retirements, while many separations at NIH were due to

non-DRP departures or reductions-in-force.

Some agencies offered multiple rounds of deferred resignations, and the current OPM data may not yet account for all employees who accepted the deferred resignation offer last year.

A bar chart showing science agency workforce separations, including deferred resignation program separations and other separations, from Jan. 2025 to Dec. 2025.

At federal science agencies, job losses in 2025 ranged from around 12% to 30%. AIP

PROBATIONARY FIRINGS

Early last year, the administration carried out mass firings [aip.us17.list-manage.com] of employees who had not completed their probation period – typically of one year – and were easier to fire than longer-term employees. A court eventually ruled that the firings were illegal but did not mandate reinstatement for many of the fired individuals. Some employees went through multiple rounds of being fired and reinstated. [aip.us17.list-manage.com] Others were put on leave following reinstatement and did not return to work until months later, some as recently as December. [aip.us17.list-manage.com]

The number of probationary federal employees in the physical sciences in 2025 remains unclear due to redactions in the OPM data. Based on the unredacted data, the number of probationary federal employees in the physical sciences appears to fall sharply from 2024 to 2025. For instance, the Department of Energy had 116 physical sciences employees with less than one year of service in 2024, compared to just 12 such employees in 2025. However, the length of service of more than 200 DOE employees in 2025 is redacted, so the number with less than one year of service could be much higher than 12.

REDUCTIONS-IN-FORCE

OPM's data reveals no completed reductions-in-force at most agencies overseeing science. NIH was a notable exception with 807 employees lost due to RIFs, including 340 across contracting and program management, 71 in general health science, 62 in writing and editing positions, and 50 in public affairs. NASA lost [aip.us17.list-manage.com] 13 employees as part of RIFs across program management, engineering, and physical science. NSF lost four employees as part of RIFs across program management and other administrative functions. The OPM data shows no separations due to RIFs at DOE, NOAA, NIST, or USGS.

Last year, the administration directed [aip.us17.list-manage.com] agencies to produce plans for “large-scale” RIFs by March, then again

asked [aip.us17.list-manage.com] for similar plans in advance of the government shutdown in October. The Energy, Commerce, and Health and Human Services departments collectively issued [aip.us17.list-manage.com] around 1,300 RIF notices during the shutdown, which were temporarily blocked in court and later by the stopgap funding law until Feb. 13.

WORKFORCE ADDITIONS

Both the high number of separations and the low number of new hires contributed to the federal workforce drop in 2025. The employees added at agencies overseeing science constituted no more than 2% of the total workforce of those agencies, while separation rates ranged from 7% to 30% at those same agencies. The administration froze federal hiring beginning in January last year, and the freeze is now ongoing indefinitely.

A bar chart showing science agency separation rates and accession rates Jan. to Dec. 2025.

Federal science agencies saw much higher rates of employees exiting the workforce than entering in 2025. AIP

MARCH

3/2/26: WP. Why MAGA suddenly loves solar power / The Trump-led attack on solar eases as the right reckons with its crucial role in powering AI and keeping utility bills in check.

...But recently that Make America Great Again fire hose has also contained posts that seem off-brand for the former GOP official, whose spouse is Trump's domestic policy chief Stephen Miller.

"Solar energy is the energy of the future," Katie Miller posted recently. "Giant fusion reactor up there in the sky – we must rapidly expand solar to compete with China." Another of her posts suggested solar is more vital to the U.S. than coal power, contradicting White House messaging and policy.

Trump has been blunt about his distaste for solar panels, calling them a "blight" on the landscape, "very inefficient, and very ugly too" and – along with wind turbines – "THE SCAM OF THE CENTURY." His administration has blocked hundreds of projects from final approval as it prioritizes fossil fuels.

A growing number of prominent Trump allies – including former House speaker Newt Gingrich, veteran strategist Kellyanne Conway and GOP pollster Tony Fabrizio – are promoting solar as electricity demand surges and energy affordability climbs the list of voter concerns.

Their clean energy advocacy may be having an impact, as the White House signals it is reconsidering power from the sun. The tone of Trump himself has even changed....

...Solar is one of the few options for bringing new electricity generation online quickly – projects can often be planned and connected to the grid in a fraction of the time required for new fossil and nuclear energy sources.

TOGETHER WITH BATTERY STORAGE, SOLAR WILL ACCOUNT FOR 79 PERCENT OF THE NEW CAPACITY ADDED TO THE U.S. POWER GRID THIS YEAR, according to the federal Energy Information Administration. Most of it is destined for Republican states, with 40 percent going to Texas alone.

Comments...

Hillary Clinton was pushing hard for solar dominance of the US in 2015. She wanted the US to be the leader. Fools went for Trump and squashed our solar hopes. Biden brought them back. Trump squashed them again. NOW they want to compete with China? A little late I think.

Indeed, that included canceling the tax incentives for our citizens to install residential solar. They went out of their way to destroy a program that was already on the books.

All over Texas there are wind turbines generating power.
Money (sometimes) talks.

Yet American-made solar panels remain rare. Top solar-panel manufacturing nations are, in order:

China.
Vietnam.
Malaysia.
India.

Together those nations produce about 89% of solar panels globally. China's share is 77.8% of global production.

Solar is the cheapest manner of creating energy and when trump stupidly shut down Biden's green bill, they just made power more expensive.

As the article points out, solar and storage are now among the fastest and cheapest electricity sources to deploy. The learning/experience curves of both of these technologies is about an 18% to 20% reduction in cost for every doubling of global manufacturing. Nothing will stop solar and storage from dominating. And while the Administration will very likely continue to hate wind power, it is also among the cheapest and fastest sources today. GLOBALLY, AND EVEN IN THE US, WE ARE SEEING

RENEWABLES (INCREASINGLY PAIRED WITH STORAGE) REPRESENTING ABOUT 90% OF NEW CAPACITY ADDITIONS.

3/13/26: NYT. Trump Administration Readies Plans to Dismantle Renowned Science Lab / Proposals include transferring a supercomputer to the University of Wyoming and shifting a space weather lab to a private company.

The Trump administration is reviewing proposals to break up one of the world's leading climate and weather laboratories, transfer its work to universities and private companies, take away its aircraft, and sell its property in Boulder, Colo.

The laboratory, the National Center for Atmospheric Research, has been targeted for months by the Trump administration. In a social media post in December, Russell Vought, the White House budget director, called the Colorado center "one of the largest sources of climate alarmism in the country."

The center, founded in 1960, is responsible for many of the biggest scientific advances in understanding of weather and climate. Its research aircraft and sophisticated computer models of the Earth's atmosphere and oceans are widely used in forecasting weather events and disasters.

Scientists say the move to dismantle the center would weaken research that is crucial to understanding the atmosphere, space and oceans, air pollution and climate change. It would leave emergency officials and planners less prepared for extreme weather events, critics said.

The center's staff includes about 830 employees working under the University Corporation for Atmospheric Research, a nonprofit consortium of colleges and universities that oversees the center for the federal government. The center also operates a massive supercomputer, known as Derecho, in Cheyenne, Wyo., that scientists use to predict the behavior of wildfires, space weather, hurricanes and other complex weather patterns.

..."Breaking up the institution would have detrimental impacts," Gov. Polis said in a statement on Thursday. "People evacuate more quickly and safely from fires because of NCAR."

The center's data, Mr. Polis said, "improve forecasting of severe weather events like fires and floods, support safer aviation and transportation, and help businesses and communities make informed decisions."

In a letter to the N.S.F.'s acting director, Brian Stone,

Representatives Joe Neguse, a Democrat, and Jeff Hurd, a Republican, wrote that dismantling the center would increase costs and “erode critical research capacity, disrupt longstanding partnerships, and diminish our ability to understand, anticipate and respond to extreme weather-related risks.”

Mr. Neguse said that the proposals and comments should be made public, and that he intended to press N.S.F. should it refrain from doing so. He has asked the N.S.F. inspector general to review allegations from a whistle-blower that Trump administration officials began negotiating the transfer of the center’s space weather program to a private company in January, before the review had been completed.

According to Mr. Neguse’s letter to the inspector general, the whistle-blower confirmed the report with an employee of an unnamed for-profit company during a January meeting of the American Meteorological Society in Houston.

...Scott Rayder, the chief executive of Lynker, a firm in Leesburg, Va., that provides space weather forecasts for the U.S. military and other federal agencies, said that he was submitting a proposal to the N.S.F. to take over management of the center’s High Altitude Observatory, whose scientists study solar flares, space radiation and other atmospheric phenomena.

...The University of Oklahoma is making a proposal to the N.S.F. “on how the nation can best preserve that legacy and organize our atmospheric science capabilities to meet current and future needs,” said Matthew Wade Hulver, the university’s vice president for research and partnerships.

The University of Wyoming has begun negotiations with N.S.F. officials about taking over management of the Derecho supercomputer, according to Chad Baldwin, a university spokesman.

Mr. Baldwin said it was too early to know who would set the research priorities for the supercomputer. But some scientists say the university’s goals may not match the priorities of the larger U.S. scientific research community.

...Also unclear is the fate of the center’s Mesa Laboratory, which was founded in 1960, designed by the famed architect I.M. Pei, and used as the setting for the 1973 Woody Allen sci-fi comedy film “Sleeper.”

In a January letter, the N.S.F. said that it wanted proposals to sell the buildings and transfer the center’s two high-flying research

aircraft to another federal agency.

Comments 388

Will we ever be able to repair the terrible damage Trump is doing to our best institutions?

The unelected "White House budget director" doesn't seem to say that the institution is too expensive or that there is no room for it in the government budget. He just says it produces information that is unwelcome. Not that it's inaccurate or fraudulent; only that it isn't favored in this administration. What next?

What an outrageous and tragic disgrace! Fifty years ago, I staffed the first Congressional hearings on climate research, regarding a bill that would help fund NCAR. At the time, none of us was aware of any particular threat of global warming. We called in expert scientists from around the world, including NCAR, to testify. Witness after witness testified that more research was needed, but if their theories were correct, the earth would experience accelerating global warming due to the buildup of CO2 from industrial pollution. They also predicted that the first noticeable effects would probably be in 15 years or so. Congress funded more research, and 15 years later, around 1990, that is exactly what transpired. Since then, global temperatures have risen in accord with their predictions. The dismantling of NCAR is a perfect example of the king killing the messenger for bad news. That won't stop it from happening, but it's a setback for U.S. scientific leadership worldwide.

The Trump war on science continues. This is insanity.

Sickening. China laughs while America just keeps getting stupider and further behind. Our grandchildren will never be able to understand how we could have been so filled with grievance that we let the greatest liberal democracy on Earth crumble into ruins. The embarrassment and shame will live much longer than we will.

Despite what the misinformers would have people believe, science works. Your smartphone is built from sand, oil and rocks. Sand for glass and chips, oil for the plastic and the right shiny rocks for rare earth minerals and palladium. It has Einstein in it, without special and general relativity the nice lady who tells you where to go will get you lost. It has quantum physics built into it. Science and some engineering, technology, marketing and design. And still you have people pulling out their smartphones and sending out tweets and posting on internet threads that scientists don't know what they are talking about. Try giving a bunch of congressmen some sand, oil and rocks and ask them to make a smartphone and monkeys would type Shakespeare before you got the phone.

You can say you don't believe in gravity but the apple will still hit you on the head. You can say you don't believe in climate change but that's not going to stop it getting hotter. I think we are headed to a future with considerably greater warming than 2 °C. What that means is a lot of people will suffer, a lot of people will die. No matter what republican lawmakers, government appointees and fossil fuel executives proclaim.

Here in Cheyenne we've experienced devastating winds, trees uprooted, roofs blown off houses, semi trucks blown over on I80 & I25 and various kinds of damage all over town. We know wind in Wyoming, but this is off the charts and climate change has a lot to do with it. The dismantling of NCAR and its pieces parceled out or sold off is unconscionable and dangerous. Climate change is real and it doesn't matter what Trump wants to believe or any of my most ardent maga neighbors think. Nature is reacting to what we humans have done and what have refused to admit and act on to reverse course and be better stewards of our environment. Mother Nature always has the last word and if her lessons go unheeded, her retribution is harsh.

Why is a budget director in charge of cancelling a well-established scientific research center with the rational in his social media post in December? As your article states "Russell Vought, the White House budget director, called the Colorado center "one of the largest sources of climate alarmism in the country." Why is a budget director going way out of his job description to close something he knows nothing about, especially his logic being that somehow the NCAR causes "climate alarmism"? Can we please see his scientific credentials and research to make such a statement? I would rather say that Mr. Vought is the alarmist. Mr. Vought should stay in his lane, be a budget director, and not promote his alarmistic fantasies into the world of science.

Russell Vought (of Project 2025 fame) said this lab is "one of the largest sources of climate alarmism in the country." Substitute "vital climate information" for "climate alarmism" for the actual truth. This un-elected man (unfortunately nominated by Trump and confirmed by GOP Senators) has caused massive harm to our country by illegally stealing Congressionally-approved funding for agencies and projects that are vital for the well-being of the US and our people. I hope when this regime falls, he will be one of the first, along with Trump, Stephen Miller, Kash Patel, and Pete Hegseth, to be prosecuted.

Another example, alas, of ideology undercutting science. Back, back, we go, into a new Dark Ages. And now there's double whammy: we can't predict the occurrence and course of natural disasters, and we can't aid in recovery from them, thanks to the dismemberment of FEMA (as of March 2026, western North Carolina continues to struggle with Hurricane Helene recovery, with over 75% of the estimated billion in total needs remaining unfunded). "We're finally on our own," as the

1971 song Ohio says.

"Climate alarmism"? Ask the insurance companies if climate change is real. This amounts to unilateral disarmament in the face of a major threat to our economy and well-being.

Scientific research is antithetical to closed minds and limited imaginations and profit grubbing charlatans that inhabit the Trump Administration. With them as well as their supporters and donors, ignorance is bliss so long as it makes them money.

The race to the bottom just accelerated. The Crown Jewels of our scientific research so carefully constructed for decades are being destroyed in the blink of an eye. The drain of scientific genius is going to haunt us for generations. We are on the cusp of devolving in to a backward, ignorant dark age. At some point can we not all agree enough is enough???

Through decades, NCAR has been in the forefront on R&D for countless scientific advances -- including many new technologies to enable planes to fly in an ever more turbulent atmosphere. NCAR has been a cornerstone of US science, and its destruction for petty purposes is the essence of barbarism. The NCAR dismantling is driven by anti-science motives but also by a vendetta against Colorado. Recently, the Trump crowd got caught trying to sell portions of the magnificent complex to private interests. This is top-value land and architecture, right down the hill from me.

As government attorney, I used to draft regulations for federal agencies. I am now retired. Agencies are required to present drafts of regulations (Notice of Proposed Rulemaking) to the public for comment. NPRM's are published in the Federal Register. Agencies review comments and, in fact, actually revise draft regulations based on comments. The rulemaking process is usually very detailed, cites pertinent legal and nonlegal sources, requires careful legal scrutiny, and presents justifications for the proposed rule. The NSF is an independent federal government agency, just like the EPA -- which subject to rulemaking requirements. So, my question is: how can the NSF legally keep these proposals and received comments private? Shouldn't the NSF's noncompliance, if it occurs, be appealed to a Federal District Court?

This makes me ill, plain and simple. This, and the DOGE inquiries is revealing that (as we suspected) there is no 'there there'. No ideas, no thought, no consideration that there may be other people with expertise they may not possess themselves. No humility at all. I suspected this would be the case, and I am steeling myself to the reality that we will find out, again and again, that this is true. It's a government of people who know nothing, and don't care. Proven again and again and again.

This decision, made by scientific know-nothings and haters, to close a world class scientific center because its scientific conclusions are unpalatable to the right-wing MAGA base, exemplifies the vicious stupidity at the heart of this movement. It will destroy the country. Everyone needs to stand up against it, each in his own way, but there is no compromising if the country is to survive.

You remember during covid trump asked the testing to be reduced because he didn't like the numbers? Guy at the end of our road is a climate change denier, he was ranting at me today about how electric cars are a scam because "they don't run on electricity, they run on batteries and all electric car owners have to pay huge amounts for the batteries." I tried to explain that I'd owned my electric Nissan for 9 years now, it was second hand when I got it, and so far I have not paid for a single battery, and haven't paid for a single charge because the panels on my garage fill it enough even in a British winter, to do every journey. He just didn't believe it, telling me I'd been lied to... lied to by my own hands when they only ever had to plug it in to the investor in my garage, lied to by my own mind when I wired up the solar panels and breakers, was I being lied to by my wife because she was sneaking out at night to buy some mystical giant Duracells and wedging them in the car? He simply couldn't accept it, so brainwashed was he. When science, measurements, the observations of rational people are abandoned, a country cannot possibly move forward.

Weather data (and weather data in the aggregate = climate) is among the most valuable info societies can have— day to day function, charting and anticipating global unrest, disasters and disaster response, supporting military capabilities, longevity of infrastructure, shipping and trade, agriculture, planning, everything about the planetary water cycle including where and when we will be without water for communities and ecosystems— a push to privatize is big money for monied interests that can sell data everyone needs back to the public— and a grab of taxpayer funded tools and infrastructure for private gain without public accountability. The costs of this are staggering.

Trump (and MAGA's) war on science is despicable, unethical and immoral. Let's add "deranged" to the list of descriptors. Is it also insane? I would have to agree, inasmuch as it is designed to suppress and eliminate objective, evidence-based investigations of natural science and gaining an understanding of underlying principles that may not "align" with this administration's political, social and cultural agenda. The administration and the MAGA movement are invested in an effort to mold and shape the world to reflect their fantasies...as if reality were malleable. That is a chimeric belief. But in pursuit of this illusory goal, they are destroying so many important institutions, it is almost unbearable.

3/16/26: FYI

PLANS TO BREAK UP NCAR TAKE SHAPE

The deadline for proposals to take over part of the National Center for Atmospheric Research closed last week, and Trump administration officials are now weighing how to carve up one of the world's leading climate and weather labs.

The National Science Foundation announced its intent to restructure NCAR in December, shortly after White House Budget Director Russel Vought tweeted that NCAR was "one of the largest sources of climate alarmism in the country" and would be broken up, with "vital activities such as weather research" moved to another entity or location. NCAR is currently operated by a consortium of universities called the University Corporation for Atmospheric Research on behalf of the federal government.

As plans to dismantle NCAR's facilities, assets, and research portfolio take shape, one of the biggest questions is what will happen to NCAR's Mesa Laboratory in Boulder, Colorado, where most of the center's approximately 750 staff work. The future of NCAR's flagship supercomputer, Derecho, located in Cheyenne, Wyoming, is also undecided. The supercomputer is used to predict complex weather patterns, including the behavior of wildfires and hurricanes.

While proposals to take over the lab have not been made public, and an NSF spokesperson told FYI there are currently no plans to release them, Science and the New York Times reported details last week of some expected proposals, including from the University of Oklahoma and NOAA contractor Lynker, a firm that hopes to take over management of NCAR's High Altitude Observatory. The University of Wyoming is reportedly in talks with NSF to take over the Derecho supercomputer, and NSF is expected to transfer two NCAR-operated research aircraft to either NASA or the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration.

Politicians, scientists, and research advocates have expressed concerns about the plans to break up NCAR. Rep. Joe Neguse (D-CO) wrote a letter last week to NSF's Office of Inspector General asking it to look into whistleblower allegations that Trump administration officials began discussing the transfer of NCAR's space weather program to a private company in January – before NSF had formally reviewed any proposals. Also last week, the Senate Commerce Committee advanced the Weather Act, which includes an amendment that would require federal agencies to notify Congress several months before transferring atmospheric research infrastructure, like NCAR, to a private entity.

BUDGETARY DELAYS SLOW SPENDING AT NIH

The White House Office of Management and Budget has been slow to authorize the release of fiscal year 2026 funds to the National Institutes of Health, according to reporting by Nature. In previous years, federal agencies such as NIH had been able to start spending a portion of their appropriations while waiting for OMB authorization, but OMB changed the policy last year to restrict spending to essential expenses such as salaries. The delay means that NIH has been slower to award new funding grants this year, as it can only spend leftover funding from the stopgap bill Congress signed in November, and may face a time crunch to spend its new funding before the end of the fiscal year once it secures OMB approval. OMB did not respond to a request for comment. NIH Director Jay Bhattacharya will appear before the House Appropriations Committee on Tuesday for an oversight hearing.

3/23/26: FYI.

NCAR OPERATOR SUES NSF AND WHITE HOUSE OVER DISMANTLING PLANS

The National Science Foundation has already made plans to transfer operations and maintenance of the National Center for Atmospheric Research's Wyoming Supercomputing Center to the University of Wyoming or another "third party managing entity," according to a lawsuit filed last week by the University Consortium for Atmospheric Research, NCAR's operator. NSF notified NCAR's director of the plans in February, weeks before the period to submit proposals for transfer plans ended and responses could be considered. NSF does not plan to transfer the R&D activities that depend on the supercomputing center, according to the February letter from NSF.

The lawsuit also references a whistleblower complaint to Rep. Joe Neguse's (D-CO) office alleging that Trump administration officials began discussing the transfer of NCAR's space weather program to a private company in January, before NSF had formally reviewed any proposals. Additionally, the lawsuit states that the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration terminated a multi-million-dollar agreement with NCAR's operator under the Climate Adaptation and Mitigation Program following the White House's announcement that it would "break up" NCAR. UCAR alleges that federal agencies have also unconstitutionally restricted its employees' speech by forbidding them from publicly discussing any restructuring.

The lawsuit says the White House's plans to dismantle NCAR are part of "a series of punishments targeted at Colorado," where NCAR is headquartered. The lawsuit adds that the agencies lack "any legitimate programmatic rationale for the actions" because they have not

identified any performance deficiency with UCAR. Furthermore, the plans undermine the agencies' and the administration's broader priorities, the lawsuit states. It says Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick's "commitment to weather forecasting modernization and 'innovation'... will be adversely impacted by any action that disrupts supercomputing functions or divests authority from the organization most knowledgeable and capable of overseeing the supercomputing center – namely, NCAR." The lawsuit also alleges that NSF lacks the authority to transfer stewardship of NCAR under its current agreement with UCAR, which ends on Sept. 30, 2028.

3/26/26: FYI, Subject: White House Announces PCAST Members

White House Announces PCAST Members /The roster is heavy with tech company leaders, and university scientists are nearly absent.

President Donald Trump announced yesterday the first 13 members of the President's Council of Advisors on Science and Technology, almost all of whom are current or former CEOs from major tech companies.

PCAST convenes eminent volunteer experts from outside the federal government to advise the White House on matters relating to science and technology policy. Previous PCAST cohorts included a mix of university researchers and experts from major companies. The experts drawn from private industry were usually high-ranking technical or scientific leaders within those companies, such as chief technology officers and heads of research divisions, rather than CEOs.

For example, in the first Trump administration, eight of the 15 people who served on PCAST were university scientists. The remaining members all came from private industry, but only two of them were CEOs. The other five were heads of research or chief technology officers.

A similar dynamic was consistent across the Clinton, Bush, Obama, and Biden administrations.

The latest membership appears to mark a striking departure, although the White House announcement noted that PCAST can have up to 24 members and that more members will be appointed "in the near future."

At present, the council includes only one university scientist, UC Santa Barbara physicist John Martinis. The rest of the members are:

- * Marc Andreessen, general partner at Andreessen Horowitz, a venture capital company
- * Mark Zuckerberg, CEO of Meta, a social media company
- * Sergey Brin, former president of Alphabet, the parent company of Google

- * Safra Catz, vice chair and former CEO of Oracle, a technology company
- * Larry Ellison, executive chairman of Oracle and a major backer of his son David Ellison's media conglomerate
- * Michael Dell, CEO of Dell Technologies, a computer technology company
- * Jensen Huang, CEO of Nvidia, a semiconductor company
- * Lisa Su, CEO of AMD, a semiconductor company
- * Jacob DeWitte, CEO of Oklo, an advanced nuclear power company
- * Bob Mumgaard, CEO of Commonwealth Fusion Systems, a fusion energy start-up
- * David Friedberg, former CEO of The Climate Corporation, an agri-tech company that is now part of Monsanto
- * Fred Ehrsam, co-founder of the cryptocurrency exchange Coinbase and CEO of a neurotechnology start-up

The only returning members of PCAST are Su and Dell, who served in the council during the Biden and Bush administrations, respectively.

The announcement also confirmed that White House AI and Crypto Czar David Sacks and Office of Science and Technology Policy Michael Kratsios will be the co-chairs of PCAST, roles that were previewed in Trump's order restarting the council early last year.

In a post highlighting the new members, Kratsios said, "PCAST will focus on the opportunities and challenges that emerging technologies present to the American worker and how to best ensure the U.S. continues to lead in the Golden Age of Innovation."

In his own post, Sacks emphasized that the council will "make policy recommendations to ensure that America leads—and wins—in artificial intelligence and other cutting-edge technologies."

At present, the latest cohort of PCAST members appears to be more narrowly focused on technology development than in previous years. In comparison, the Biden White House's announcement of its PCAST membership in 2021 emphasized its members' expertise in "astrophysics and agriculture, biochemistry and computer engineering, ecology and entrepreneurship, immunology and nanotechnology, neuroscience and national security, social science and cybersecurity."

APRIL

4/3/26:

From: American Astronomical Society <public.policy@aas.org>
Subject: The President's Budget Request for Fiscal Year 2027
Date: April 3, 2026 at 12:03:42 PM EDT

Earlier today, the President's Budget Request for Fiscal Year 2027 was released, once again proposing substantial cuts to our science agencies. These include a 55% cut to the National Science Foundation, a 47% cut to NASA's Science Mission Directorate, the elimination of the NASA Office of STEM Engagement, and a 13% cut to the Department of Energy Office of Science. If enacted, these cuts will result in the abdication of US leadership in discovery science, with long-lasting impacts on our national STEM workforce.

Currently, we only have high-level information about the budget request. We are expecting more details from each of these agencies, including proposed funding levels for specific programs, in the coming weeks, and the AAS policy team will be sending out more information as it becomes available.

You will recall that last year, the President's Budget Request pushed a similar agenda to drastically cut funding for the astronomical and astrophysical sciences. I am writing to remind you that the President's Budget Request is a proposal from the President to the Congress. Congress is ultimately responsible for deciding annual funding levels through its appropriations process. That process is simply initiated by the President's proposal.

Our congressional leaders are tasked with representing our interests, and we all have a responsibility, as constituents, to voice our priorities in this budgeting process. Last year, our scientific community spoke up and engaged in strong advocacy in record numbers. It was this groundswell of engagement that led to Congress rejecting such drastic cuts in the budget request and keeping funding for our science agencies relatively flat. This year, we must continue to consistently and forcefully speak out, to remind Congress that leadership in the scientific enterprise cannot be sustained on year-to-year flat budgets. However, it is up to each of us to make those critical arguments to our representatives in Congress

The AAS provides action alerts as an easy way for you to call and email your members of Congress. I encourage you to both send an email and make a phone call today, and also to share this link with colleagues, friends, and family, encouraging them to express the importance of science and the need for robust support.

There are also currently "Dear Colleague" letters circulating for signatures in the Senate requesting robust funding for various science agencies. You can use our action alerts to encourage your Senators to support Fiscal Year 2027 budgets of \$9.9B for the National Science Foundation and \$9B for NASA Science.

While the action alert takes only a few minutes, I encourage you to continue to advocate in other ways. For example, members of Congress are currently back in their home districts until 13 April. Please consider using this opportunity to set up a meeting at your local district office, or to attend any town halls that they are hosting. While I have not been able to meet directly with my House representative, I was able to make an appointment with his district director simply by calling the local district office. The conversation was productive, with the staffer giving me insight into what arguments about the importance of science would resonate with his boss. By engaging with members of Congress in local contexts, we can remind them why investments in science matter not just at a national level, but at a local level – to people in their district.

Finally, though what counts as normal public discourse seems to be growing more belligerent in these times, please be respectful in all your communications with elected representatives. It should go without saying that cordial discourse is the best way to make oneself heard. However, last year, the AAS policy team heard from Congressional staffers that they were sometimes yelled at by scientists. This is not productive, and it tarnishes the reputation of our profession in lasting ways. Similarly, staff at the federal agencies are NOT our enemies in the process, and they have no control over the funding levels that they are expected to plan to. Please remember this in your interactions with them. Let's continue to be professional as we make our points about the need for science funding.

The AAS policy team will be in touch as we receive more details regarding agency budget requests, and we will also share information soon on how you can engage in advocacy for the sciences through a Week of Action (April 13–17) and beyond.

Thank you for being an advocate!

–Dara Norman, AAS President

4/6/26: FYI

TRUMP AGAIN PROPOSES DEEP CUTS TO SCIENCE AGENCIES

The Trump administration has proposed significant cuts to many science agencies in its budget request for fiscal year 2027, including:

- * An 84% cut to the National Institute of Standards and Technology;
- * A 54% cut to the National Science Foundation;

- * A 47% cut to NASA's Science Mission Directorate, as well as a 23% cut to NASA's overall budget;
- * A 13% cut to the Department of Energy's Office of Science, despite a 2% increase to DOE's overall budget;
- * A 10% cut to the National Institutes of Health;
- * No funding for the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration's research arm; and
- * Cuts to basic research at the Department of Defense and the U.S. Geological Survey.

In contrast, the administration proposed a 12% increase to the National Nuclear Security Administration's budget (over total fiscal year 2026 funding, which includes funds from the reconciliation bill [aip.us17.list-manage.com] enacted in July) to maintain and expand nuclear capabilities. The "skinny" budget documents released last week include many topline funding amounts as well as specific proposals that the administration seeks to call attention to, but they do not include comprehensive program-level numbers, which will be released at a later date. In several cases, the cuts are similar to those the administration proposed last year, which Congress largely rejected [aip.us17.list-manage.com] in its final budget for fiscal year 2026. Last year's request similarly proposed deep cuts across NSF directorates, dozens of NASA Science mission cancellations, and eliminating funding for NOAA's Office of Atmospheric Research.

The request reiterates AI and quantum as administration priorities, proposing using \$1.2 billion from the Biden-era Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act for DOE's recently created [aip.us17.list-manage.com] Office of AI and Quantum, which the request states will coordinate all DOE AI and quantum information science activities, including those related to the Genesis Mission. [aip.us17.list-manage.com] The request also specifies that the funds would go to supercomputers [aip.us17.list-manage.com] at Argonne and Oak Ridge National Labs. However, the request does not include funding for the American Science Cloud, which DOE calls [aip.us17.list-manage.com] the "cornerstone of the Genesis Mission's platform infrastructure."

The proposed 80% cut to NIST is significantly larger than the 28% cut proposed last year. The request says it aims to eliminate awards for "the development of curricula that advance a radical climate agenda." The request proposes reorganizing NIST lab programs and standards coordination programs into several more specific funding lines mainly vcentered around measurement and standards, as well as advanced manufacturing R&D, resilience and fire research, and neutron research.

Across the federal government, the request proposes eliminating funds and programs dedicated to minority-serving institutions and prohibiting funds for “expensive subscriptions to academic journals and prohibitively high publishing costs,” unless required by statute or with prior agency approval.

NSF, NIH LAGGING IN AWARDING GRANTS

The National Science Foundation has awarded just 613 grants [aip.us17.list-manage.com] this fiscal year, at about 20% the level at this time in the year in each of fiscal years 2021 through 2024, according to the group Grant Witness. The amount of funding awarded is at similarly low levels, about one-third that of previous years. The trend is visible across each of NSF’s directorates. New and competitive award renewals, which undergo full peer review, are particularly low compared to previous years. The National Institutes of Health has seen a similar trend regarding its number of awards, having given out about 10,000 awards this year compared to around 18,000 at this time in previous years; total award funding is also down by a similar amount. NSF and NIH are even lagging behind fiscal year 2025, during which thousands of grants were canceled and fewer grants were awarded than in previous years.

4/9/26: FYI.

TRUMP PROPOSES DEEP RESEARCH CUTS, NEW ICEBREAKER FOR NSF

The president’s budget request, released last week, recommends major cuts to research funding at the National Science Foundation across all its directorates. Accordingly, the administration would expect a significant reduction in the number of awards given in fiscal year 2027 and in the number of people directly involved in NSF activities. At the same time, the request proposes several major construction projects and a new office focused on “metascience” initiatives at the agency.

The request proposes \$4 billion for NSF, a 54% cut from the fiscal year 2026 enacted level. The amount echoes last year’s proposal of \$3.9 billion, which Congress soundly rejected, funding the agency at \$8.75 billion. The request also recommends an additional \$900 million for a new research icebreaker, but those funds are separate from the rest of the agency’s budget.

NSF would plan to fund just 2,900 competitive awards in fiscal year 2027, compared to 7,400 in fiscal year 2025, according to the request. (Competitive awards include research grants as well as cooperative agreements, fellowships, and other grants.)

For research grants, NSF would award 2,100 in fiscal year 2027, compared to 5,800 in fiscal year 2025. However, the agency would increase the size of each award by 14%, on average. NSF also estimates that the number of people directly involved in NSF programs and activities, including researchers and K-12 students and teachers, would fall by 69%.

Each research directorate would receive deep cuts under the request, including a 75% cut to the Engineering Directorate, a 72% cut to Biological Sciences, a 67% cut to Mathematical and Physical Sciences, a 63% cut to Computer and Information Science and Engineering, and a 43% cut to Technology, Innovation, and Partnerships. (Directorate-level spending totals for fiscal year 2026 are not yet available, so the request compares to the figures released for 2025.) The request proposes multiple reorganizations within the Research and Related Activities account, including moving the Office of Polar Programs out of the Geosciences Directorate. OPP would be cut by 13%, down to \$497 million, while the remainder of the Geosciences Directorate would be cut by 58%, to \$426 million.

The request would eliminate the Social, Behavioral, and Economic Sciences Directorate, though it would preserve the National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics as a separate program and cut its budget by 41%. The request says continuing grants that “align with administration priorities, such as in behavioral and cognitive science,” would be transferred to other parts of the agency, as would all impacted employees.

The proposal again seeks to fold the account that funds the STEM Education Directorate into the Research and Related Activities account, which Congress rejected in the final fiscal year 2026 funding law. The request would fund STEM Education at \$428 million, a 54% cut from 2026.

The request proposes deep cuts to several fellowship and scholarship programs within STEM Education, including a 43% cut to the Graduate Research Fellowship Program, which already saw a steep drop in the number of fellowships awarded last year. The request notes that NSF will seek co-funding from industry stakeholders in exchange for having students perform sponsored research apprenticeships. In contrast, the request proposes level funding for the EPSCoR Graduate Fellowship Program. EPSCoR provides funds to institutions in U.S. states and territories that have historically struggled to secure NSF grants. Even AI and quantum information science, which NSF designated in fiscal year 2026 as “Frontier Initiatives” that represent “the highest strategic importance to the nation,” would see cuts of 32% and 37%, respectively. The additional “innovation focal points” – advanced manufacturing and materials and biotechnology – would also receive cuts of 70% and 40%, respectively. The request also proposes cutting the Office of International Science and Engineering by 94% and the

Office of Research Security Strategy and Policy by 26%.

NEW ICEBREAKER AND MAJOR CONSTRUCTION PROJECTS

The request proposes \$900 million beyond the \$4 billion topline figure to support the development of a new Antarctic research vessel for NSF. The agency terminated its lease on the RV Nathaniel B. Palmer icebreaker last year. For the rest of the major construction projects, the request proposes a 31% cut. It recommends \$81.45 million for the Leadership-Class Computing Facility in Texas, \$60 million for Antarctic infrastructure upgrades, and \$30 million for mid-scale infrastructure projects.

The request notes that NSF selected just one of the two Extremely Large Telescopes, the Giant Magellan Telescope, to move forward to the final design stage, as the administration requested last year. The GMT will be completed without further funds from NSF, the request says. However, Congress directed the agency to also advance the Thirty Meter Telescope in its explanatory report for the fiscal year 2026 funding bill. A report from December 2024, commissioned by NSF and written by external experts, said pursuing either telescope could dominate the agency's limited facilities budget and damage other research areas absent a significant and sustained budget increase from Congress.

The request proposes \$18 million to support the design of two "potential" construction projects. The Summit Modernization and Recapitalization project would rebuild the Summit research station in Antarctica to be "safer, more efficient, and more flexible," the request says. The Next Generation Very Large Array project, a radio telescope array, would replace the Very Large Array and the Very Long Baseline Array.

NEW INITIATIVES

The request proposes \$100 million for a joint initiative on energy-water security between NSF and the Department of Energy. DOE would provide an additional \$75 million. The initiative would work to "reduce vulnerabilities where water-related issues threaten reliable energy production."

The request also proposes funding a new office dedicated to "metascience," which refers to the scientific study of scientific research. This office would explore novel methods for improving the effectiveness of the U.S. R&D enterprise and collaborative research teams, including non-traditional R&D funding mechanisms. The request raises "flexible fast grants alongside longer-duration grants" and "golden tickets," which would allow a grant reviewer to fund an application regardless of objections from the other reviewers, as examples of ideas the office would pursue.

4/9/26:

From: American Astronomical Society
Subject: President's Budget Request Details and a Call to Action
Date: April 9, 2026 at 10:17:05 AM EDT

Last week, the President's Budget Request for Fiscal Year 2027 was released, proposing devastating cuts to the US scientific enterprise, including a 47% cut to NASA Science, a 55% cut to the National Science Foundation (NSF), and a 13% cut to the Department of Energy (DOE) Office of Science. The AAS Policy Team is following up on President Dara Norman's message from Friday with additional information about what these cuts would entail and how you can advocate to Congress against these cuts.

Details of NASA, NSF, and DOE Budget Requests

The AAS policy team has published a blog post breaking down the detailed budget requests from the NASA Science Mission Directorate, NSF, and the DOE Office of Science. You can read it at the link above; please reach out to us at public.policy@aas.org if you have any questions.

Participate in the Week of Action

Next week, two dozen members of AAS and the American Association of Physics Teachers will be in Washington, DC, to advocate for funding for the astronomical sciences and STEM education. You can help amplify their efforts by being an advocate for science from home. We are calling on AAS members to take one advocacy action per day from April 13 to 17. Learn more by using the link above.

Take Action Today

In addition to participating in the Week of Action, we encourage you to take a few minutes today to urge your members of Congress to reject the cuts proposed in the President's Budget Request. Due to the broad interest in the Artemis II space launch and the inspiring images that have recently been returned, now is an especially ideal time to advocate for funding for the astronomical sciences. Please consider reminding your representatives that successes in our understanding of the Earth-Moon system and the cosmos only advance through funding of research and workforce development for science. You can use our action alert form, linked above, to quickly send an email to or call your congressional offices.

Learn More at a Webinar on Friday

The AAS policy team will be hosting a webinar at 12 pm ET on Friday, 10 April, to share details regarding the President's Budget Request and to help you set up a meeting with your local district office, which is a highly impactful way to advocate for science. Register using the link above.

We hope that you will continue to engage in advocacy with us. It was your advocacy that led to Congress rejecting these proposed cuts last year, and we must sustain (and hopefully grow) that engagement to secure robust funding for our field and for science more broadly. Thank you for being an advocate!

– The AAS Public Policy Team

4/10/26: Van Scoyoc Newsletter

Trump administration drops court fight to cap NIH payments for research overhead costs

The Trump administration will not be asking the Supreme Court to take up its fight to slash federal support for funding that the nation's science enterprise relies on for basic operating costs. The deadline to do so came and went this week without a petition from Trump's Department of Justice, effectively ending the 14-month standoff over a controversial policy to drastically reduce the rate of reimbursement for "indirect costs" on federal grants. Read more: STAT News [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

Trump administration seeks more funding cuts for NIH

A budget proposal released last week by the Trump administration seeks to cut \$5 billion from the National Institutes of Health (NIH). The cuts listed in President Donald Trump's Fiscal Year 2027 Budget are part of a \$15.8 billion overall reduction the administration is seeking for the Department of Health and Human Services, which oversees NIH. The document from the Office of Management and Budget (OMB) says the budget reductions will be achieved through reforms and elimination of several NIH centers, including the National Center on Minority Health and Health Disparities. Read more: CIDRAP [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com], NIH FY2027 Budget Request [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

White House unveils \$1.5 trillion defense budget.

What comes next? President Donald Trump's administration is seeking a record-breaking \$1.5 trillion defense budget for fiscal 2027—and projecting a \$1.28 trillion topline in 2028. Among the top priorities the White House highlighted in its FY27 budget rollout is the Golden Dome missile defense shield, which an Office of Management and Budget official told Air & Space Forces Magazine is funded for \$17.5 billion in the coming year. OMB unveiled the first details on the FY27 budget request April 3, with a fact sheet laying out the topline funding level and key priorities for the Pentagon with few specifics. Read more: Air and Space Forces Magazine [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com], DoW FY2027 Budget Request [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

Budget would cut Pentagon research by one-third. Can industry compensate?

Pentagon R&D spending would drop by about one-third under the White House's 2027 defense-spending proposal—but the impact of that \$4.5 billion reduction might be cushioned by the tech industry's willingness to fund its own research. The proposed drop, which echoes a similar cut in the first Trump administration's 2020 proposal, was outlined in Friday's record-breaking \$1.5 trillion defense-spending request. Basic research spending would fall \$3.7 billion from this year's appropriated amount. Most of that—\$2.6 billion—would be borne by the Space Force, but reductions would also hit the Army (\$173 million), Navy (\$529 million), Air Force (\$150 million), and the Defense Department-wide account (\$202 million). Read more: Defense One [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

Deja vu: Trump proposes cutting NASA science funding by 47% again

A proposed fiscal year 2027 budget for NASA would cut the agency's overall funding by 23% and slash its science programs by nearly half, prompting strong opposition from the space community. The Planetary Society, the world's largest independent space interest organization, issued a statement in response to the release of the FY 2027 top-line budget request for NASA, which would reduce the space agency's Science Mission Directorate from \$7.25 billion to \$3.9 billion — a 47% drop that advocates say would be the largest single-year cut to science funding in the agency's history, according to the statement. Read more: Space.com [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

Massive budget cuts for US science proposed again by Trump administration

For the second year in a row, US President Donald Trump has proposed significant cuts to the budgets of the most prominent US science agencies. The administration's plan for federal spending next

year, released on 3 April, also includes a ban on using federal funds to pay subscription and publishing fees for some academic journals. Some of the steepest cuts would be made to the National Science Foundation (NSF) and the Environmental Protection Agency. The budgets of both would fall by more than 50% in 2027 compared with their current levels. A budget document released by the White House says that the proposal would maintain funding for research on quantum information and artificial intelligence "to ensure the United States remains on the cutting edge" in those areas. But quantum and AI research funding at the NSF, for example, would be cut by 37% and 32%, respectively, from their levels in 2025. Read more: Nature [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com], NSF FY2027 Budget Request [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

Trump's proposed 2027 budget slashes NOAA by \$1.6B despite maritime investment

President Trump's proposed fiscal year 2027 budget delivers massive cuts to NOAA, reducing Operations, Research, and Grants programs by \$1.6 billion while providing a comparatively modest \$135 million increase for shipbuilding and unmanned systems. The budget represents a net reduction of approximately \$1.465 billion to NOAA, with the administration targeting what it calls "Green New Scam programs" while attempting to refocus the agency on core fisheries management and maritime infrastructure. The \$1.6 billion in cuts eliminates educational grants, climate adaptation programs, and research initiatives. Read more: Seafood News [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com], NOAA FY2027 Budget Request [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

Trump's budget proposes massive cuts for climate and environmental programs

President Trump's annual budget request to Congress continues his administration's defunding of climate change programs, environmental protection and renewable energy, slashing the budgets of the Environmental Protection Agency, the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration and the Federal Emergency Management Agency. EPA spending would be cut in half under Trump's proposal, released last Friday, and grants from the agency would be slashed by \$1 billion. Congress rejected a similar budget request from the president last year. An Inside Climate News analysis of federal workforce data released by the Office of Personnel Management shows that EPA lost more than 4,000 employees in the first year of Trump's second term, reducing its workforce to 12,849, its lowest level since the 1980s. Read more: Inside Climate News [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com], EPA FY2027 Budget Request [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

4/13/26: FYI

SCIENCE GROUPS PUSH BACK AGAINST PROPOSED BUDGET CUTS

Science advocacy groups are urging Congress to reject President Donald Trump's proposed cuts to research funding in fiscal year 2027. The Association of American Universities condemned the Trump administration's proposed cuts to the National Institutes of Health, the National Science Foundation, NASA, and research offices at the Department of Energy in a press release, highlighting reports that China's investments in scientific research and development "are now outpacing our own." The Trump administration's proposal to cut NSF's budget by 54% and eliminate the agency's Social, Behavioral, and Economic Sciences Directorate has drawn criticism from groups such as the Federation of Associations in Behavioral and Brain Sciences.

The administration's proposal to cut NASA Science by nearly 50% has also raised alarm, with Rep. Judy Chu (D-CA) and Rep. Don Bacon (R-NE), the co-chairs of the Congressional Planetary Science Caucus, releasing a joint statement that such cuts would "create enormous chaos and uncertainty for critical missions, the scientific workforce, and long-term research planning." Last month, Chu and Bacon co-authored a letter, signed by more than 100 House Representatives, requesting \$9 billion for NASA Science in the upcoming budget. A similar letter, led by the American Astronomical Society and Sen. Mark Kelly (D-AZ), is circulating among senators. The request seeks \$3.9 billion for NASA Science. (AAS is an AIP Member Society.)

While some university groups, such as the American Council on Education and the Association of Public and Land-grant Universities, applauded the Trump administration's proposal to increase funding for the Pell Grant program, which helps undergraduate students from low-income families pay for their education, they expressed alarm over wider cuts to student aid, institutional support, and research funding. The American Physical Society, alongside other scientific organizations, has launched a campaign urging people to write to their representatives in support of increased science funding. The Planetary Society has also launched a letter-writing campaign and is planning a day of action on April 20. (APS is an AIP Member Society.)

TRUMP ADMINISTRATION SKIPS DEADLINE TO APPEAL NIH INDIRECT COST RULING

The deadline for the Trump administration to appeal a court decision on indirect costs at the National Institutes of Health passed last week, leaving in place a ruling blocking the 15% cap on such costs that the White House sought to implement last year for university grantees of several agencies. NIH's budget request for fiscal year

2027 says that the agency “will continue the policy to cap indirect cost rates at 15 percent.” FYI has reached out to NIH for comment on whether that statement is still accurate.

Indirect costs are the portion of a grant that covers expenses such as equipment and facilities maintenance, IT services, and administrative support, often expressed as a percentage of direct research costs. The administration attempted to institute 15% caps at NIH, the Department of Energy, the National Science Foundation, and the Department of Defense, which were each blocked in court. Typical cost reimbursements are between 30% and 70%. DOE, NSF, and DOD withdrew their own cap policies following the litigation, and appropriations laws blocked changes to the current indirect costs system in fiscal year 2026.

A group of higher education associations proposed the Financial Accountability in Research (FAIR) model last year as an alternative indirect costs model, and a spokesperson said the group will work with Congress to implement the model as part of the fiscal year 2027 appropriations process.

4/17/26: FYI

HEARING HIGHLIGHTS OPPOSITION TO TRUMP PUBLISHING FEE PLANS

The Trump administration’s latest budget request proposes canceling federal subscriptions to academic journals and banning the use of federal funds to cover publishing costs. sykes science committee.jpg

Investigations and Oversight Subcommittee Ranking Member Emilia Sykes (D-OH) delivers her opening statement at the hearing on April 15, 2026. House Science Committee

Speakers at a House Science Committee hearing on Wednesday criticized the Trump administration’s plans to implement a government-wide ban on paying to access or publish academic research.

The Trump administration’s fiscal year 2027 budget request, published earlier this month, calls for a “government-wide prohibition on publishing and subscription fees,” adding that the use of federal funds for “expensive subscriptions to academic journals and prohibitively high publishing costs” will only be covered if required by federal statute or approved in advance by a federal agency. The administration justifies the ban by saying that “research funded by taxpayers should be publicly accessible; yet many publications charge the Government to both publish and to access the same research study.” In her opening statement at the hearing, Investigations and Oversight Subcommittee Ranking Member Emilia Sykes (D-OH) described the Trump administration’s decree for the federal government to stop paying

subscription and publishing fees as a “sledgehammer,” when this is “an issue in need of a scalpel.”

“Cutting federal funds for publishing costs is only going to put a further strain on our universities and researchers who are already under attack from this administration,” Sykes said. She argued that “pulling the rug from under the publishing industry carelessly will be a disaster for research integrity,” adding that publishing fees support high publishing standards. Sykes noted, however, that she has doubts over whether the publishing fees that journals charge are fair, praising the work of universities in her state that have negotiated money-saving open access publishing agreements with big academic publishers.

Republicans on the committee did not weigh in on Trump’s prohibition on subscription and publishing fees, but did express dissatisfaction with how the scholarly publishing industry operates. In his opening statement, Investigations and Oversight Subcommittee Chair Rich McCormick (R-GA) said that “what was once a straightforward process of peer review and dissemination has become a complex, commercialized marketplace with misaligned incentives and bad actors willing to exploit them.” McCormick and others speaking at the hearing criticized the “publish or perish” culture of academia, saying it rewards quantity over quality.

Asked by Sykes to comment on the Trump administration’s proposal to stop paying for subscriptions, Carl Maxwell, senior vice president for public policy at the Association of American Publishers, said preventing federally employed scientists from accessing the latest science is “self-defeating.” “I’m not sure what good it does to tell a NASA scientist or an Oak Ridge scientist, go find it on a public repository, you can’t have a login to Science magazine or Nature magazine,” Maxwell said. Several media outlets reported last year that federal agencies had canceled their subscriptions to some academic journals, including from high-profile publishers such as Springer Nature.

Maxwell also criticized the Trump administration’s proposal to stop paying publishing fees, noting that researchers who perform government-funded research are required to submit the final, post-peer review version of their research publications to the agency that funded them, which typically requires the payment of an article processing charge to the publisher. These charges can run into thousands of dollars for high-profile journals.

“If in the end the author pays a fee to publish, and then has to give the article to the agency, and is not able to pay for that publication out of their grant, it’s like a political science 101 definition of an unfunded mandate,” Maxwell said.

The National Institutes of Health announced last year that it intends to cap the amount it will contribute toward publishing costs for NIH-funded research. FYI has reached out for comment on when the agency plans to announce its new policy. The Trump administration's budget request for NIH includes \$100 million "to elevate replication and reproducibility as a transformative scientific priority through a coordinated, cross-institute approach." The budget also says NIH will create new platforms for publishing negative results in the National Library of Medicine and "establish benchmarks that define and reward true scientific impact." The agency will also "restore credibility" to NIH science by implementing "updated public access and limiting allowable publication cost policies."

Jason Owen-Smith, executive director at the Institute for Research on Innovation and Science at the University of Michigan, said at the hearing that the Trump administration's proposal would be better if it required transparency in the setting of subscription fees instead of banning them entirely. Concerns over the rise of AI-generated content, paper mills, China's mining of published research data, reproducibility, and research misconduct were discussed at length during the hearing. Kate Travis, managing editor of the blog Retraction Watch, told the committee that her publication had tracked a rise in retractions, but that the increase is not necessarily a bad thing. "It means the scientific literature is being cleaned up," she said. Travis noted, however, that it can be difficult to investigate potential misconduct due to limited access to research data sets, adding that the National Science Foundation has recently lost key personnel charged with conducting investigations into suspected research misconduct. "We need more investigations and more transparency around them," Travis said.

4/25/26: WashPost. Trump ousts National Science Board members / Members of the independent board that guides the National Science Foundation said they received a notice from the White House that their positions were being terminated.

Multiple scientists who serve on an independent board established to guide the nation's nearly \$9 billion basic science funding agency were terminated from their positions Friday by President Donald Trump.

Members of the National Science Board, which helps govern the National Science Foundation, were dismissed in a message from the Presidential Personnel Office thanking them for their service, according to screenshots shared with The Washington Post: "On behalf of President Donald J. Trump, I'm writing to inform you that your position as a member of the National Science Board is terminated, effective immediately."

The National Science Board was established**in 1950 to guide the

governance of the National Science Foundation, in an unusual structure within the federal government that echoes the setup of a company board in the private sector. It helps guide an agency that operates Antarctic research stations, telescopes, a fleet of research vessels and supports basic science research in laboratories across the United States.

...The board's members are scientists**and engineers from universities and industry and are appointed by the president, but they serve six-year terms, ensuring overlap between different administrations. There are typically 25 members, but some slots are empty – including the NSF director, which has been vacant since the former director who was appointed during the first Trump administration, Sethuraman Panchanathan abruptly resigned a year ago.

...Keivan Stassun, a physicist and astronomer at Vanderbilt University, who has been a board member since 2022 said he had personally received confirmation from a third of the board members that they had been terminated by the boilerplate emails, which provided no reason.

...He noted that without a director over the last year, the board has played a major role in advising Congress of the agency's role in the nation's investment in science. In the president's budget request last year, there was a proposed 55 percent cut to NSF's budget. Congress rejected those cuts.

The president's budget request for fiscal year 2027 also proposes a deep cut to NSF, and Stassun questioned whether the timing of the cuts were connected to the work the board does in advising Congress of the agency's importance, even as the president has aimed to cut it.

... "This is the latest stupid move made by a president who continues to harm science and American innovation," said Rep. Zoe Lofgren (California), the ranking Democrat on the House Science, Space and Technology Committee. "The NSB is apolitical. It advises the president on the future of NSF. It unfortunately is no surprise a president who has attacked NSF from day one would seek to destroy the board that helps guide the foundation."

Related: From FYI

The board is required by statute and has existed since the 1950s. It plays a major role in establishing NSF policy and advises Congress and the president on scientific issues. The 24 committee members are scientific experts who are selected by the president and serve 6-year terms in a part-time capacity. NSB Chair Victor McCrary and Vice Chair Aaron Dominguez were elected to lead the board last August after former NSB Chair Darío Gil left to lead the

Department of Energy's Office of Science. The board was scheduled to meet on April 16 to discuss its next election, but canceled that meeting and never rescheduled it. The firings will likely add to the tumult at NSF. The foundation has been without a confirmed director since April 2025, has shed roughly a third of its staff since the start of 2025, and is currently transferring its operations from a custom-built office to a building a few blocks away. The White House proposed halving the agency's budget last year and has made a similar proposal for the next budget cycle. The proposed cut would also reduce NSB's budget from \$5 million to \$3 million.

...Association of American Universities President Barbara Snyder said the firings leave NSF "rudderless," and the American Association for the Advancement of Science issued a statement calling the move "destabilizing." The Association of Public Land-Grant Universities said it was "dismayed" by the firings. Union of Concerned Scientists CEO Gretchen Goldman criticized the firings as an "unseemly political maneuver" aimed at limiting independent science.

Related: From Inside Higher Ed

The White House didn't initially tell board members or the public why it gutted the board, but in an email Monday to /Inside Higher Ed/, the White House pointed to a 2021 Supreme Court decision. The court's reasoning in *U.S. v. Arthrex* "raised constitutional questions about whether non-Senate confirmed appointees can exercise the authorities that Congress gave the National Science Board." The board's members—it has 25 at full capacity, and 22 were listed online at the time of the terminations—are appointed by the president, but not confirmed by the Senate.

... The Trump administration had already upended NSF. After the inauguration, it quickly moved to cancel a slew of NSF and National Institutes of Health grants including on transgender individuals' health care, vaccine hesitancy, misinformation and diversity, equity and inclusion — but also on non-politically contentious topics, such as cancer research. In August, through executive order, the president ordered "senior appointees" to take charge of awarding, or denying, new federal grants.

In February, NSF's chief management officer said the agency's staff was down about 35 percent from the same time last year, and the agency was planning to "consolidate" solicitations for grant awards to half, or fewer, of the usual number of these funding opportunities.

...NSF, which has a nearly \$9 billion budget, now lacks board

members, a permanent director and a deputy director. While the White House said in its email that the agency's "work continues uninterrupted," the Grant Witness research funding tracking site says NSF is significantly behind on grant making compared to previous years.

...Stassun also speculated that the board terminations might have something to do with Congress's rejection of Trump's proposal to halve NSF's funding for this fiscal year—after board members advocated for preserving funding. Trump has again proposed cutting more than half of NSF's budget next fiscal year.

"It was clear that we were getting ready to once again offer that guidance to Congress, which in the past budget cycle they clearly listened to," Stassun said. "So, perhaps the administration didn't want us offering that statutorily mandated advice to Congress."

Science does not operate on four-year cycles. The work of understanding our universe, solving complex problems and building the knowledge base for the technologies of tomorrow requires patient, sustained investment guided by rigorous scientific judgment—not political preference."

— Willie May, a former NSF board member and vice president of research and economic development at Morgan State University.

Related: FYI

ADMINISTRATION EXPLAINS NATIONAL SCIENCE BOARD FIRING AS CRITICISM GROWS

The White House says the firing of the entire National Science Board on April 24 was driven by "constitutional questions" raised by a 2021 Supreme Court ruling. The White House did not publicly announce the firings, which were first reported by science news outlets, nor did it initially provide a rationale for them. The move appeared to catch both the board and the National Science Foundation by surprise, with NSF initially declining to comment on the firings and directing all questions to the White House.

The court ruling in question, *U.S. v. Arthrex*, sets certain limits on the powers of executive branch officials who are not Senate-confirmed. The White House contends that the statute that created the NSB in the 1950s now runs afoul of that ruling. "We look forward to working with the Hill to update the statute and ensure the NSB can perform its duties as Congress intended," a spokesperson for the White House said.

The White House has not clarified how it wants to update the statute. The Arthrex ruling determined that the authority of "inferior offices" must be reviewable by a superior officer who is confirmed by the Senate. In that particular case, the court ordered that the decisions made by patent judges, who are not confirmed by the Senate, must be reviewable by the director of the U.S. Patent and Trademark Office, a Senate-confirmed position.

Julia Phillips, one of the board members who was fired from the NSB, said the board had been aware of the Arthrex decision and took steps to ensure that its activities did not run counter to the ruling. Specifically, she said the board emphasized in its reports and meetings that its positions were recommendations for NSF, not approvals or orders. (Phillips is also a member of the AIP Foundation board)

...Democrats in Congress have criticized the firings and questioned the White House's rationale. "The issue of constitutionality seems dubious since it's not at all clear that would apply to the NSB," House Science Committee Ranking Member Zoe Lofgren (D-CA) said. "If there was a legitimate concern on the part of the Trump Administration on a legal issue, the path forward is not to fire the entire NSB – one third of whom he appointed in the first place – but to work with Congress," she added. Senate Commerce, Science and Transportation Committee Ranking Member Maria Cantwell (D-WA) called the firings "a dangerous attack on the institutions and expertise that drive American innovation and discovery."

MAY

5/15/26 WP. MIT president blames federal policy shifts for big drop in research on campus / Funding cuts and restrictive immigration policies are throttling scientific work as other nations are investing heavily, education experts say.

MIT is doing less research and enrolling fewer graduate students as a result of federal actions, the university president warned Thursday. Federally funded research on campus is down more than 20 percent compared to this time last year, MIT's president, Sally Kornbluth, told the campus community in a video message, and the number of new federal research awards is also down more than 20 percent.

"That is a striking loss for one of the most influential and productive research communities in the world," Kornbluth said.

Graduate student enrollment will also decline significantly in the coming academic year, she said; outside of two programs that are still in the midst of admissions, the number of grad students will be 20 percent less than it was in 2024 – about 500 fewer students.

MIT's loss is emblematic of the shrinking of American science caused by Trump administration actions that are affecting labs across the country. Ted Mitchell, president of the American Council on Education, said he expects to hear similar assessments coming from other leading research universities. "This is the first of many of these kinds of alarms that will be ringing," he said.

But at MIT, the reduction in research funding is exacerbated by the impact of a sharply increased tax on its endowment returns. Most colleges and universities are exempt from taxes because of their nonprofit status and educational mission. MIT expects to pay about \$240 million a year for that tax, which was increased to 8 percent this year by Congress and applied to only a handful of elite schools.

...MIT is one of the leading scientific institutions in the world, said Brendan Cantwell, a professor of higher education at Michigan State University, so if it is scaling back how it does research, that means universities across the country should be thinking about scaling back and adjusting. That's happening at the same time that China continues to invest in research, particularly in the sort of research that MIT is good at, he said.

A lot of the attention to changes in higher education has focused on cultural issues, he said, such as debates over free speech. "But there's also a real economic and geopolitical dimension to what's happening, in terms of the shifting away from the scientific enterprise and the leading global role that the United States has played for decades."

Federal funding isn't flowing to MIT as it typically has, Kornbluth said. Some federal agencies are talking about taking geography – not just scientific merit – into account when allocating money, distributing funding to more parts of the country. Some grants are not getting renewed as expected. And fewer new grant proposals are getting funded.

The decline in research dollars has affected scientists at every stage of their careers, not just the youngest scientists trying to establish their labs. Senior faculty members with long track records of winning significant grants are having to cut graduate students, post-doctoral fellows and entire lines of research. Graduate student enrollment is dropping because of the funding uncertainty. But there are also signs, Kornbluth said, that policy changes affecting international students and scholars are discouraging talented people from applying.

...MIT was able to find other sources of funding for some labs, and is working to tap into others, especially in industry and philanthropy. But overall, taking into account both federal and non-federal funding, research on campus is down 10 percent. "The fact is that we're looking at a real drop in research being done by the people of MIT," Kornbluth said. "When you shrink the pipeline of basic discovery research, you choke off the flow of future solutions, innovations, and cures – and you shrink the supply of future scientists."

Comments...

"Some federal agencies are talking about taking geography – not just scientific merit – into account when allocating money, distributing funding to more parts of the country." -- Translation: grants will be pulled from "blue" states and transferred to "red" states.

The greatness of the US economy has always been significantly dependent on science and research in the pipeline. Trump has cut the pipeline. Our economy will suffer enormously in about 5 years. Meanwhile other nations are picking up and even hiring our scientists. The future is elsewhere. The US economy is moving to one of extraction and taking; what will be left after they have sold off everything?

Yes, MIT has a large endowment. What many people don't know is that money from the endowment isn't simply sitting there making MIT rich(er), unlike how wealthy individuals tend to hoard cash for their own benefit. One notable example: it's being used to pay the tuition of students from families making under \$200K/year, and to pay tuition/housing/dining/fees of students from families making under \$100K. Attending and graduating from a premier school like MIT is a path to upward mobility. My own spouse came from a poor family, earned a degree from MIT, and earns a 6-figure salary as an engineer. He's not an outlier in this regard. Taking huge chunks of money away from schools with large endowments might seem reasonable, but all it's actually doing is forcing layoffs, cuts in resources and programming, and hampering the ability to attract top talent. It's cutting off their nose to spite America's face. If you took that money away from a multibillionaire, what's the worst that would happen? They buy one or two fewer mansions and megayachts? Please. It's not the same thing.

FYI the MIT endowment is 27.4 billion with a B. The funding cut back is a few million. They don't need tax dollars to continue this guys research. They could fund it themselves for the next 200 years.

80% of MIT's endowment is restricted -- its use is already set -- and income from the additional 20% pays for a wide variety of costs. You seem to think that the endowment is a big cash bank

account, but it is not, and the income is already allocated. Shifting any of it to pay for research that has been funded by external grants would mean shortages in other areas.

Most endowment funds are restricted to uses specified by the original donors. Unrestricted funds are already committed to various purposes (some of which is research). What would you have them cut to spend more on research? Student financial aid? If you read the article it says that MIT has been able to find some other sources of research funding to replace about half what the federal government is cutting. Of course, MIT is also getting hits with a brand new wealth tax on its endowment fund that will cost over \$200 million/year.

There is a cost to unbridled stupidity. It is the degradation of society. This is exactly how great civilizations decline.

When did universities and colleges become federally funded R&D labs instead of schools. For most of our country's history R&D was funded by private enterprise. It shows that once you open the flood gates to tax dollars there is an entitlement mindset. We often see many comments asking to cutoff corporate welfare. Aren't shifting R&D costs from private entities to the taxpayers just another form of corporate welfare?

Not all research is the same. Private enterprise very rarely does research that does not have a clear potential commercial application. There used to be a few places like Bell Labs that did, but they were supported by the profits from monopolies. Given the changes in the economy since the 1970s, that is becoming more and more rare. Now the government funds basic research – research driven more by curiosity and the desire to resolve inconsistencies in our current knowledge or fill in the gaps than any particular end use. Some of that leads to spinoffs (pharmaceutical drugs, the internet, etc.) but much of it does not or if it does it is only decades later. We can argue over the amount of the budgets for agencies like NIH and NSF since it is impossible to put a value on the research results in advance, but it is not "just another form of corporate welfare."

When did the federal government not use the gains from university and college labs to improve things like the military, health and human services, and various other government departments?

Where do you think those Private Enterprise r&DDDDD labs go to find workers? Someone has to train them, with more than just book learning.

A prospective 21 year old new science graduate who wants to do medical research as an MD/PhD is looking at a very long and perilous path: 4

years MD, 4 years (at least) PhD, 4 years clinical residency and fellowship and at least 3 years of post-doctoral research. Now you are 37 at least, and going on the job market, and have never had a well-paying job. Married? Children? Home? Probably not, but you may have significant debts.

[cont] If things go well, you get a job that pays pretty well but requires you to raise your own salary from grants while you do research, and pay all the salary and benefits of people who work in your lab, and pay off your educational debts. Your odds of getting your first grant from the NIH today? About 15% (that includes the special rate the NIH gives to new investigators---for everyone else, it is about 4 to 8% this year). You will almost certainly be at least 40 before you get your first NIH grant to keep you going for the next 5 years.

[cont] Are you married? If you are a woman, are you still fertile? Do you have children yet? Do you even know what a child is? Do you own a home? Little time for that because the odds that you will be able to renew that first grant are about 25% so you had better get busy and put your nose to the grindstone immediately. Let's say you are successful and get tenure! You are 48. If you are a woman you are not fertile. Oh and BTW, you will have to renew those NIH grants continuously every 5 years for the next 30 years or you lose your lab and are for practical purposes fired. At 4-8% for 30 years is that even possible? No.

[cont] I have been there and done that but during years when funding was possible. But at 4-8% grant funding rates today, that is no longer possible. Today, only a lunatic would sign up for this life.

This is a 5 alarm crisis, look at any top science journal, half the papers are now coming from Chinese scientists . All while Russel Vought implements insane funding policies at the NIH to effectively cut the level of funding up 80%. So many new grants are not being funded. America is so rapidly losing its innovative edge, it's an absolute tragedy.

Retired Canadian prof. here: Whatever you guys are doing down there, keep doing it. It has kicked our Pennywise government into an all-out spending spree to drain your top, fed-up academic talent--offering each scooped academic \$4-8 million to set up their research program at a Canadian university. It's called the Canada Global Impact+ Research Talent Initiative. I have met a few of the first wave of Americans fleeing to a country whose government still takes science seriously. It's terrible for you guys, obviously. But all it's costing us taxpayers to fund this talent grab is the equivalent of retrofitting one Saudi gift airplane and doing one White House ballroom/bunker reno.

Oops. This headline should read:

"MIT president correctly points out that Trump's completely spite-based funding cuts are destroying the worldwide scientific and technological preeminence that the US has held since WWII, and decimating America's absolute powerhouse of a scientific infrastructure that has been built up since the Cold War -- all to 'own the libs.'"

I can share that at an institution across the river, the much reviled Harvard Medical School, the drop in research activity is at least as severe and the cuts are certain to deepen. The faculty's research programs - in Alzheimer's disease, cancer, AI - have always drawn their primary support from Federal grants not some internal fund. They strive, perhaps with a few "bad apple" exceptions, to advance the public good, improve healthcare, and bring new companies into existence (emulating MIT in all of these areas). My estimate is that our research programs have shrunk by ~15% on average (mine by ~20%) and we have now exhausted rainy day funds. Another substantial shrinkage is yet to come this year. Letting Russell Vought run the Federal research program in defiance of Congress is causing deepening damage. Congress must wake up - there will not be much to revive once this administration is through.

I think MIT and other higher education institutions need to shift from public funding for research (federal grants) and get even more funding from private institutions such as Intel, Apple, and NVIDIA if they seriously need more funding. These corporations are doing well for themselves enough to make it happen to the next level, especially with the AI Revolution at play. MIT should invest in energy efficiency and energy storage solutions for data centers due to their immediate impact on our national power grid. Sure, public funding and other public endorsement is still needed for national recognition.

The reason companies you mentioned are doing well, is bc they sit on the backbone of basic research. You need a balance of basic vs applied research. For profit companies only want applied research that leads to profit. We must invest in basic research too, where real breakthroughs and serendipitous moments/ discoveries occur.

And the traditional way to have these wealthy companies to pay for basic research that will benefit everyone, not just those companies, used to be to tax them. Now you want those companies to do it voluntarily and with whatever strings they want to attach? Do you see why that's a bad idea?

This is one of the greatest self-inflicted wounds of the Trump era.

Oh, I'm sure the academic powerhouses of Liberty University and

Hillsboro College will pick up the slack./s

Stealing money from the futures of America's. Best and brightest to pay for corruption, gold statues, and war. this is the new American legacy.

5/15/26: Van Scoyoc newsletter:

House Appropriators advance key NASA funding bill

The House budget bill that includes NASA funding just cleared a key hurdle, advancing out of the Appropriations Committee. This is the first funding bill for FY 2027 to be released and reach this stage, establishing congressional intent and rejecting the worst of the Office of Management and Budget's proposed cuts to NASA. The bill keeps NASA funding flat with the currently enacted budget, but reprioritizes funding levels across the agency, including a 17% cut to Science to offset increases elsewhere. A number of science missions proposed for cancellation by the OMB see their funding protected by this bill, including OSIRIS-APEX, New Horizons, and the Chandra X-Ray Observatory. New programs initiated by Administrator Isaacman that were absent from the OMB proposal, like Space Reactor-1 Freedom, also see their first dedicated mention in the proposal. Read more: The Planetary Society [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com], House FY2027 Commerce-Justice-Science Appropriations [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

NASA provides some details about Artemis III, but hard decisions remain

NASA announced Wednesday it will fly the Artemis III mission in low-Earth orbit and that it continues to target 2027 for this stepping-stone flight that will help land humans on the Moon. The space agency chose the orbit close to Earth—as opposed to a higher orbit—because it would preserve the final remaining Interim Cryogenic Propulsion Stage for launching the Artemis IV landing mission later this decade. Instead, NASA will use a “spacer” to simulate the mass and overall dimensions of an upper stage but without propulsive capabilities. Read more: ARS Technica [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

Trump's man takes over NASA launches

The return of Brian Hughes, a Florida political operative who served as NASA chief of staff last year, has raised concerns on Capitol Hill about his qualifications to take on a new role at the space agency. But while some lawmakers may be worried, industry is hoping the reorganization will speed up rocket launches. NASA announced last week that Hughes will oversee launch operations at Kennedy Space

Center in Florida and Wallops Flight Facility in Virginia. Wallops has long been managed by Goddard Space Flight Center in Maryland. Read more: Politico Pro [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]

House Appropriations Committee eliminates funding for NSF STEM Education

The House Appropriations Committee approved its FY2027 Commerce–Justice–Science Appropriations Bill and Report Thursday. The bill cuts NSF funding by \$1.75 billion (20%). Research and Related Activities is cut by \$736 million. The bill provides no funding for STEM Education, which received \$938 million in FY2026. The report includes language encouraging NSF to partner with commercialization organizations, private-sector accelerators, and regional innovation ecosystems that support researchers and early-stage companies in moving NSF-funded technologies toward deployment. Read more: House FY2027 Commerce–Justice–Science Appropriations [vsadc.us4.list-manage.com]